Noir – A Dystopian Roleplaying Game

By Marco Behrmann and Petter Nallo

A dystopian roleplaying game by Marco Behrmann and Petter Nallo

Producer

Marco Behrmann Original idea & concept **Marco Behrmann Petter Nallo Lead Writers Marco Behrmann Petter Nallo Guest Writer Jonas Karlsson Illustrators Michael Gullbrandson** Patrik Hultén **Alf Svensson Editor Victoria Eriksson Designer Rikard Jespersen Cover Illustrator Michael Gullbrandson Text Contributors Martin Fröjdh** Patrik Hultén **Alf Svensson** Quality assurance & playtesting **Martin Fröjdh Sarah Geijer Johan Linder Roger Lindström Magnus Lindström Andreas Nordlund Johan Rising Mattias Svendsen Anton Wahnström Thanks to** Sarah Geijer, for your love, understanding and tolerance of my obsession Kim Vässmar, for understanding the vision and sharing the enthusiasm The very vocal forum at www.rollspel.nu and its interested and critical participants, for both praise and criticism. Noir is a violent and dystopian roleplaying game that deals with humanity's dark sides in a tangible way. Noir is not recommended for sensitive individuals or children under 15 years of age. Noir is a registered trademark, Noir Copyright © 2006 Marco Behrmann Regnskugga Förlag, Göteborg 2006, Product number 10-1001, ISBN: 91-976556-0-0 www.noir.nu

Chapter 1 – Introduction

- Introduction
- What roleplaying is
- What Noir is
- Mood & setup
- Sandukar
- The Empire
- An evening with Noir
- Rules
- Online

Chapter 2 – The protagonist

- The protagonist
- Creating a protagonist
- Who the protagonists are
- How a protagonist is created, step by step
- Depth
- Background & psychological profile
- Personality & traits
- Creating a protagonist
- New protagonist
- Archetypes & background packages
- Archetype description

- Lawyer
- Businessman
- Academic
- Worker
- Performer
- Athlete
- Confidence Artist
- Criminal
- Bureaucrat
- Lone Wolf
- Femme Fatale
- Fixer
- Freelancer
- Street Urchin
- Tactical Officer
- Artist
- Police Officer
- Prostitute
- Priest
- Reporter
- Brawler
- Soldier
- Technician
- Hitman
- Investigator
- Caretaker
- Background packages
- Expertises
- Expertise areas
- Resolve
- Listing of all expertises
- Charm
- Empathy
- Dexterity
- Vehicles
- Humanities
- Intuition
- Throwing
- Stamina
- Construction
- Leadership
- Medicine
- Resist
- Natural Science
- Melee
- Reflexes

- Resistance
- Mobility
- Sense
- Create
- Firearms
- Deduction
- Strength
- Tolerance
- Awareness
- Worldliness
- Persuasion
- Sports
- Limitations
- Description of limitations
- Traits
- Description of traits

Chapter 3 – Belongings

- Belongings
- Possessions
- Cash
- Carrying objects
- Buying things
- Selling used items
- Condition & quality
- Breakdown & reliability
- Equipment
- Clothing & accessories
- Fashion
- Women's fashion
- Men's fashion
- Formal & festive
- Cultural differences
- Weapons & combat equipment
- Acquiring weapons
- Weapon information
- Melee weapons
- Throwing weapons
- Automatic pistols
- Revolvers
- Submachine guns
- Rifles
- Shotguns
- Machine guns
- Heavy weapons
- Ammunition & weapon accessories

- Holsters
- Body armor

Chapter 4 – The empire

- The capital
- Sandukar – The heart of the Empire
- City districts
- The Icon
- Groups in the Icon
- The Fallen City
- Groups in the Fallen City
- The state & the Empire
- Society
- The state
- The Empire
- The peoples of the Empire
- Darost
- Iskarian
- Kovan
- Madrostav
- Presvedonia
- Sadovia
- Vadaja
- Languages of the Empire
- The seven Houses
- The Houses
- Arkady
- Guiskard
- Kriger
- Mengal
- Orlok
- Todescu
- Zovrin
- The justice system
- Justice
- The police
- Forensics
- Court & legal proceedings
- The Church of the One
- The Church's role
- History
- Religious branches

Chapter 5 – Influence

- Influence

- Rules
- Dice
- Dice rolls
- Bonus & penalty
- Cooperation
- Actions
- Social interaction, notoriety & relationships
- Social interaction
- Social conflict
- Notoriety
- Relationships & Contacts
- Impression
- Relationship
- Influence
- The protagonist's anatomy
- Attributes
- Abilities
- Skill
- Description of attributes
- Description of abilities
- Description of stats
- Experience
- Experience & Life experience
- Learning
- How a protagonist gains experience
- Improving a protagonist
- Training & study
- Character traits
- Character traits
- Using character traits
- Expression
- Stronger influence
- Motivations
- Motivations
- Suggested motivations
- A motivation's birth
- Fulfillment
- Conviction & frustration
- Finding strength
- Fate
- Fate
- What Fate does
- Well-being
- Well-being
- Physical exhaustion
- Mental exhaustion

- Standard of living
- Standard of living
- Concepts
- Loans & debts

Chapter 6 – Combat

- Bullets & brawls
- Combat
- Succeeding in combat
- Combat breakdown
- Initiative
- Combat actions
- Initiative actions
- Defensive actions
- Injuries & death
- Injuries
- Recovery
- Other ways to be harmed Drugs, poisoning & defenseless victims 268
- Using drugs
- Drugs & poisons
- Defenseless victims
- Examples of combat & injuries
- Examples
- Combat
- Initiative actions
- Defensive actions
- Injuries & drugs

Chapter 7 – The taint

- The Taint
- The Taint
- Tainted places
- Tainted objects
- Myths & occultism
- Secret societies
- The nature of the Taint
- The state commissars
- Creatures of the Taint
- Being tainted
- Being tainted
- Attributes & Abilities
- Becoming infected during a story
- Psychological effects
- Visualization
- The Darkening

- Manifestations
- Manifestations
- Magnitudes
- Activating manifestations
- Character traits
- Focus & limitation
- Physical manifestations
- Mental manifestations
- Environmental manifestations
- Creating a tainted
- New tainted protagonist

Chapter 8 – The experience

- The experience
- The Noir roleplaying game
- The narrator
- The player
- The story
- Example story structures
- Narrative methods
- Narrative style
- Genre elements
- Story names
- Technology & anachronisms
- Narrator characters & locations
- Narrator characters
- Central narrator characters
- Common narrator characters
- Combat & injuries
- Fate
- Antagonists
- Experience & values
- Example narrator characters
- Locations
- Maps
- Story: Deadlock
- The story
- Who are the protagonists?
- Where does the story begin?
- Characters
- Locations
- Bombs
- What happens next?

The archive

- Afterword
- Character sheet
- Inspiration

Table of Contents

Illustration Index

Michael Gullbrandson: 8, 67, 72, 93, 118, 133, 147, 162, 165, 168, 179–180, 184, 187, 190, 194, 206, 208, 219, 249, 254, 265, 282, 286, 288, 295, 297, 302, 307, 319, 328. Patrik Hultén: 104–117. Alf Svensson: 12, 14, 24, 33, 86, 88, 98–101, 122, 130, 138–139, 144–145, 150–151, 156, 172–173, 196, 250, 278, 312, 346.

"This must be the place I've always wanted to leave." —Talia Navarre

I died a few minutes ago. Or at least, that was the plan. As usual in this city, nothing went according to plan. But I'm getting ahead of myself. Let me start from the beginning, about twelve hours ago.

I was eating a late lunch at the Golden Salon down in Ikonen. A meal consisting of eggs, pork, sausage and bacon, made for a hard-working man. With a Redovs Fat I washed away the greasy fat taste from my palate. I had no clients in the afternoon and was planning to visit a lady acquaintance for some relaxation for body and soul. It was already here my luck left me, but I didn't realize it then.

Behind me came a two-meter refrigerator lumbering. A strained breath hit my neck and a coarse, hairy hand was placed heavily on my left shoulder.

"Jandaran..." said a hoarse voice, which broke the calm like a pistol shot at midnight.

I knew who was standing next to me. Donner. The man without a first name. One from the old guard, an ox who had survived everything from lead poisoning to being found hanged from the Klemenko Bridge. You have to respect such a man. The hand remained on my shoulder. I slowly turned my head.

"Gabriel Jandaran, the gumshoe?"

The hoarse voice said it more as a statement than as a question. The breath smelled of cheap booze and cheap whores.

"Yes, that's me. Who's asking?"

I scrutinized Donner. He wore an older, rough suit that didn't fit particularly well, it strained across his frame. The shirt collar had small, barely visible, traces of dried blood. The knuckles on the hand on my shoulder had fresh bruises and a cut. Donner's face, as if chiseled by an epileptic stonecutter, glared at me. Hell, he was huge.

"The boss wants to talk to you, outside, now."

The face was completely expressionless when the words came. If I was correctly informed, Donner was employed by one of the city's bigwigs, Klarence Gieger, a magnate in metal and industry, and with contacts within both the clans and the State. A man it would be foolish to irritate.

I nodded briefly, reached for my hat, laid a twenty on the counter and let myself be escorted out.

On the street I was led to a gigantic Concran, extended, probably bulletproof. It stood on the other side of the street, all windows were tinted. I saw my reflection in the shiny, black lacquer when the back door was opened by a pale hand. Donner gave me what he surely considered a careful push forward to show that I should get into the car.

The effect was rather that I tumbled in and landed on the floor. Behind me the door slammed shut and the noise from the street abruptly fell silent. I rose as dignified as I could, smiled an awkward smile and sat down on the seat opposite the older, well-dressed man who quietly observed me.

"May I offer you something?" he asked with a cold, strained voice.

"Yes please, a whisky."

A chilly smile flashed across his face. He opened the bar section in the car and took out a bottle, a good brand.

"How do you take it?"

"In a glass."

The professional smile again. The eyes didn't smile. With slightly trembling movements he poured a double for me. He took nothing himself.

"Mr. Jandaran, I am Klarence Gieger. I got your name from a mutual acquaintance, Dr. Yannik Reasescu. You helped him a while ago and he said you were quick and discreet."

The gray eyes didn't let go of me with their gaze. He expertly lit a brown cigarette and contentedly blew out the smoke in the cabin. I took a deep swig of the warming liquid. In the corner of my eye I noted how Donner remained standing outside the door. There was a chauffeur in the car. The door on the opposite side was locked and the handle was removed. I was trapped in here.

"I remember the case."

It was an old case, one of the easy ones. Find a family member gone astray and return the person to the family. A specialty of mine. I was lucky that time, picked up the right trail and followed it to the end, to the treasure and the reward. Good money.

"I find myself in a similar situation, Mr. Jandaran."

Gieger leaned forward and lowered his voice. I met him. Felt mint and smoke in the exhaled air. His mouth was small with narrow dried lips, yellow teeth and an almost black tongue. Under the eyes the skin was stiff and almost grayish-black—like on a smoked corpse. The clothes were of the latest cut, elegant and of high quality. He wore a wedding ring and at least two order rings I couldn't place.

"My daughter is missing. I want you to find her. She is fourteen, turning fifteen this year."

Gieger stubbed out the cigarette and handed over a photograph of a young woman in school uniform. Bored expression, well-developed for her age, light hair, beautiful, defiant face. She looked older than fourteen, but the city has that effect. If she was even his daughter, if she was even fourteen. It's hard to determine if a man is telling the truth when you yourself would probably lie if the roles were reversed. But it didn't matter. I didn't care about the motives as long as I got paid in the final act.

"Her name is Derya. I got a call this morning that she hadn't shown up for lessons at Todos."

Todos, one of the Inner City's most prestigious private schools, with boarding school and the whole package. Sure, thanks. Here there was money to be milked.

"According to her bodyguard, a bungler who doesn't work for me anymore, she disappeared without a trace during the night. If she's been kidnapped I'm willing to pay whatever it takes to get her back."

He lit a new cigarette while the gray eyes locked onto mine. I swallowed and nodded briefly.

"There are many in Sandukar who wish me harm, and going through Derya is one way to strike at my heart."

Reality seemed bad enough, I decided to believe the story for now.

"You'll get two thousand zovrins per day, plus a bonus of five thousand if you solve the case within 48 hours. I don't want this to leak out to the press or the police. Understood?"

I nodded again. He seemed somewhat relieved and drew the smoke into his lungs.

"Keep the photo, on the back is a phone number you can call when you've solved this or need something. I need to get her back."

The constant problem with wanting something. You always risk failing. Desire makes one unfocused and weak. But I would do my best. That a wealthy man's daughter gets kidnapped is a cliché in this city. But the situation is never a cliché when it strikes you yourself.

The rest of the afternoon went like clockwork. Already then I should have suspected trouble. Nothing goes that smoothly. The gatekeeper at Todos got his memory back when his wallet was filled and he confirmed my suspicion. Derya

Gieger left the school voluntarily shortly before midnight the night before, got into a car and left the place. No coercion, no gasp, no violence. I cashed in a favor at the archives and traced the car's registration number to an address in Askan, toward the harbor. The State's control over citizens is frighteningly accurate in most cases. The owner of the car, a guy by the name of Janos Kostin, worked as a croupier at a popular nightclub called Chacha Club. A notorious place where more have entered than have come out. The watering hole was also known for its private rooms on the second floor, something that made my stomach knot up. Chacha Club is by no means a place for a fourteen-year-old schoolgirl.

After maneuvering my way through the subway in rush hour traffic I emerged a block from the club. I found myself in a run-down part of the district, with containers, condemned warehouse premises and worn apartment buildings for bums, fugitives and criminals. It was almost deserted but the music from the club could be heard from far away and several cars, most of older models, stood outside. Suddenly I felt watched. I quickened my pace and entered a doorway and waited. Nothing was heard. I looked out, backward, but it was empty. Probably it was my own nerves playing tricks.

A light snowfall wrapped the wet streets. I saw my own breath in front of me. Chacha Club was not a place I wanted to return to. A number of my enemies could very well be there—unfaithful husbands, abusive swine, ex-cons who had served their sentences—all could be someone I put away earlier.

In the darkness of a broken street lamp I stopped and checked that the revolver was loaded. I returned it to the ankle holster. My automatic pistols were at the office. Five bullets were what I had if the situation went

sour.

The club was housed in a two-story brick building in red. The windows were barred. The building had previously been a police station, so it was freestanding, with parking and alleys all around. A few years ago apparently the police had moved after a scandal when a clan son was found beaten to death and raped in one of the cells. Who was behind the deed never came to light, but according to a source the duty officer, as well as the constables who picked up the son, are in the canal somewhere, in concrete and chains. If you mess with the wrong people in Sandukar it's often the last thing you do.

Light from a couple of spotlights cut through the snowflakes and passed me. I couldn't help but let out a low whistle when I recognized the registration number—Kostin's car. The same car that barely a day earlier had picked up young Miss Gieger. I considered running after the car and meeting it when it parked but decided to take it easy. Observe and act based on what happened. Think first and not do anything rash.

The car stopped right outside the club and a slim man in coat and cap got out. From the passenger side emerged a short, neat figure in a cloak. In the glow from a street lamp her light hair was visible. She walked around the car, the man put his hand around her waist and the two quickly made their way through the snowfall and in through the door to Chacha Club.

There wasn't a chance I would succeed in getting in without drawing attention. Such miracles don't happen in this city. Opposite the club was a solitary phone booth. I jogged across the empty street and discovered that luck was with me—the phone worked.

I had memorized the phone number and my stiff fingers dialed to reach Mr. Gieger. Two trembling signals, a crackling click and a hoarse voice that answered.

"Yes, Mr. Jandaran?"

I was surprised but collected myself quickly.

"Donner, Miss Gieger is at Chacha Club in Askan. Are you familiar with it?"

"Yes."

"So where do I pick up the money?"

There was silence for a few moments.

"You'll get a bonus if you fetch her right now. Twenty thousand zovrins."

The hoarse voice was completely without emotion. Immovable as a wrecked diesel locomotive. Greed flared up within me. Although the voice of reason in my mind warned against this, the sum made me feel desire. Desire makes one unfocused and weak. Greed killed the voice of reason in just a second.

"Of course. I'll get her. Have the money ready." "Yes." There was a click on the line and it went silent as the grave. The snowfall had intensified. I turned up my coat collar and walked toward my doom. Under cover of snow and the absence of streetlights, I circled the building and saw the kitchen entrance among overflowing garbage cans and a rusty dumpster. The snow cover crunched softly as I made my way forward as quietly as I could. The door I reached was metal but proved to be unlocked. The heat and stench of fried food hit me. Quickly I slipped in, closed the door and listened. I found myself in a shabby corridor with bare concrete walls and cardboard boxes along the floor. A few meters down to the left came the clatter of kitchen utensils.

Beyond the kitchen a door was visible, from which the harsh music could be heard more clearly. Two bare light bulbs spread their yellowish-white glow over the corridor as I quickly made my way past the kitchen without being discovered. The door to the establishment had a foggy, round window that I peered out through. It was packed in there. Rough men drank beer, played billiards, made pathetic attempts with harbor whores to get a quickie for free, but neither Kostin nor Miss Gieger were visible anywhere. The staircase up lay a few steps from the door. Quickly I got the door open without a sound. Luck continued to smile my way when with a few quick strides I conquered the solid wooden staircase and came up into a dimly lit corridor with a worn red carpet with burn marks from cigarettes and stains from both one thing and another. From closed rooms along the corridor came grunting and giggling. At one of the doors furthest away stood Kostin. He looked toward me. "Desire for twenty thousand has made you stupid in the head." **The voice in the back of my head got air but** I stifled it. Now it mattered. Show that you can handle this. Take a vacation with the money. Leave the city for a while. Without staring down the thin man I advanced as nonchalantly as I could. No one else was within sight. Sweat pressed forth on my forehead, the hat fortunately covered my eyes. Otherwise Kostin would surely have seen in them that he was in trouble. My right hand moved down into my pants pocket and closed around a roll of coins. The roll lay perfectly in my hand. The fist clenched. Kostin reacted to me by turning and meeting up. He raised his hand and was just about to say something when my fist struck his nose bone. He blacked out before he hit the floor. I would get a serious bruise over my knuckles, but that was a later problem. The coin roll returned down into my pocket and I got out my lockpicks. Still the corridor was empty. The music rang from downstairs together with indistinct voices and cheerful calls. A quick glance through the keyhole confirmed that the room inside was occupied. The lock only took a couple of seconds to open, I stood up and quietly drew my revolver, grabbed the door handle, breathed in, saw a bag of money in my mind's eye and threw open the door. Suddenly I realized that all luck was gone with the wind. I felt like a wild dog the second before being hit by an express train. The room was dim. The bare walls, with their mold stains and their flea market art stared at me. At one wall stood a brass bed. Around the bedposts sat rusty chains with handcuffs. But it was not this that made the air go out of me like a puncture. Two people stood in the middle of the room. Miss Gieger was naked except for a corset and was just in the process of buttoning the shirt of a large, fat, unshaven, slovenly man with a cigarette in the corner of his mouth. Not really a problem if it weren't for the fact that the man was Sergy Rulov, Sandukar's perhaps most famous and brutal gangster boss. No one was ignorant of his power, connections and ruthless methods. Suddenly twenty thousand felt like two cents. I went cold in my soul. The situation was beyond bad. "Who the hell are you, you bastard!?" roared Rulov and surprisingly quickly pulled out a chrome automatic pistol, a Calder M2245. I stood there like a fool. Of all the millions of people in all of Sandukar, why Sergy Rulov? Hell! He's the guy who knocks out your teeth and then kicks you in the stomach because you mumble. "Well?! You have two seconds to answer before you die." He raised the pistol. Derya Gieger pulled closer to him and tried to cover herself. Her eyes looked hatefully at me. "I am Gabriel Jandaran." The voice was unexpectedly firm. "I am here to bring home Miss Gieger. She is sought by her father." Rulov's eyes narrowed. He cast a glance at the young woman and lowered the pistol slightly. She looked wide-eyed up at him. "What the fuck are you saying? Gieger? The industrialist?" He pushed away the girl. "You didn't say your old man sat on the council, you little whore! Are you stupid, what the fuck are you doing here?"

She looked defiantly at Rulov. A look I myself would not have given in that situation. Blood and composure began to return to my thick skull. "Papa says he has power and influence." She clenched her fists. Every muscle in her perfect body tensed, the legs, the back, the buttocks. "But I wanted to show him who has power! He is weak, he feels strong with me. I hate him. I love you Sergy!" She opened her arms in a disarming gesture. "For fuck's sake, you stupid fucking idiot. I don't want anything to do with you, you're poisoned. If you're connected to me I'll get all the shit in this whole city on me. I've stayed away from messing with people like Gieger for a reason. Don't you understand that, you ugly whore?" "But I want to get away from him, his

disgusting nibbling teeth, his disgusting dry lips, how disgusting he feels inside me!" She almost screamed. The hatred took over. Her breasts heaved. The tears were not far away. "You're the only one who can stop him, I'm yours forever if you help me kill him, Sergy, you get me!" She moved toward him, with open arms, reached toward the man, displaying her young, firm, voluptuous body. "You, little girl, I can get whoever the fuck I want. I take who I want. You're too dangerous!" Rulov spat out the cigarette and turned toward the young woman. "But Sergy, please, save me f..." She got no further before Rulov shot. The sharp bang echoed in the room. The fragile girl's body tumbled over like a rag doll when the lead shattered her chest. Her outstretched hand fell still after her like a farewell. The rage came like a tap being opened. I reacted an eternity too late, but took aim with my revolver right at the large body mass. Then I only saw stars. My neck bent from the pressure of the baseball bat that struck the back of my head. I don't remember falling. Just that the pain took over. Somewhere in my mind's eye I saw a bag of money being pulled away from my struggling hands. It went black and cold. I woke to being wet and shivering. I lay on my back. My skull felt heavy and dull. Multitudes of small cold spear points hit my face. I lifted my hand and shielded my eyes. It was snowing heavily and the alley I lay in was covered by a centimeter-thick layer of snow. The kitchen entrance to the Chacha club was visible further down in the alley. I rolled laboriously around and saw the silhouette of a thin man a few meters away. Kostin. He had a revolver in one hand and a baseball bat in the other. He grinned, a wide grin, the kind you have when you're a lousy player but have all the aces in hand. I put a hand down in the snow, took strained support and got up on my knees. My head screamed like a badly tuned brass orchestra. My heart beat as if it would get out of my chest. I looked toward Kostin. His broken nose had almost stopped bleeding. "The girl...?" "The broad is stone dead, Rulov got on her while she bled out. It's not the first time. Too bad you shot her." I blinked, unable to comprehend. Then I felt a weight in my coat pocket. I moved my hand down, grabbed something and pulled out Rulov's chrome Calder. My fingerprints on the weapon that murdered Klarence Gieger's fourteen-year-old daughter. "I haven't heard the boss laugh so much in a long time. What luck that I caught the killer when he tried to flee..." Kostin's cackling echoed distantly in my skull, despite him standing next to me. Death would free me from the hell that had just become my life. He fired, cold as the snow he stood in. The pain that burned in my stomach was enormous. My balance disappeared completely and my body crashed backward, down into the white, pure, innocent snow. This was truly a night when the wolves were silent and the moon howled. Another shot went off somewhere, someone screamed shrilly but it turned into a quiet rattling. I don't know how long I lay there in the alley before I was dragged away by my coat collar. In a haze, a world of dream and reality together, I was shoved into the back seat of a car. My belly screamed and leaked, I screamed even more when cheap liquor was poured over the wound. Large, hairy hands began expertly bandaging it. I started shaking. Then the slide was opened. The unmistakable sound of the loading mechanism from a pump-action shotgun rang out. While I lay there I heard Donner's voice briefly say that I should lie still, he would go in and get Miss Gieger. I obeyed the hoarse command and saw the tall figure disappear into the snowstorm, while I welcomed the darkness that began to envelop me.

Chapter 1 – Introduction

Marx Begel was on his way up again. He felt it in his whole body. Sure, he had been at the bottom for a while, no damn it, below the bottom. As far down as you can get without actually giving up. It had started with Sayah Bonn, his biggest find so far. She had had everything, charisma, grace and that perfect combination of innocence and sexuality that later made her one of the Imperium's biggest stars. And it was he who had found her. He should have gotten a life of luxury, and she a brilliant career. If only it hadn't been for Joachim Lechkov. That bastard had waltzed in and swept away Sayah to Glitterdalen, lured her with a seemingly better contract and some quick steps up the career ladder. Marx had not, however, passively let Lechkov take over his star. With some money in the right pockets and some more or less clean lawyers he had let Lechkov understand that it wouldn't go so easily. Then came the fall. It was obvious that Lechkov had staged the whole

thing, from beginning to end. Accusations from women Marx had never met, and contracts with them that he had never written. Naturally all the evidence was in the office, neatly archived and signed by him himself. Marx hadn't had a chance. And when his reputation was completely sunk the gorillas had come, dragged him out into the night and without a word poured acid in his left eye. They hadn't needed greetings from Lechkov. But that was then. That was history. When he was at his lowest he had one day lifted his gaze from the liquor glass and found her. Morgana Caravaldi would help him up again. With his help she would become an even bigger star than Sayah. And this time he had learned his lesson, he would be prepared. The revolver he constantly carried was only part of his insurance. He knew that the entertainment industry was as rotten as the underworld, with the big difference that within show business there was no honor whatsoever. He had learned from a master. And if anyone would try to take Morgana from him they would have to pay. Dearly.

Introduction

Imagine a cocktail party in the penthouse of a black sky-scraper covered in gothic statues and vaults, to the sounds of a raging rain that frenetically drums against the tall window panes. All present are dressed from top to toe, smiling, conversing. Deals are formed and fortunes lost during the course of a few spoken words or a few sips from frosted drink glasses. The people conceal something ominous, something feverish, within themselves, which makes them uneasy and on edge, it drives them to extremes and misfortune. Welcome to Noir. **What roleplaying is** Roleplaying in the Noir vein is to build a story in a group that all group members participate in with immersion. The story is created together and takes participants to another place than our own world, where they act based on the roles they have in the story. This new world contains elements from our own, but much is also different – the sky is darker, people are more nervous and the rain is colder. In roleplaying everyone wins if the game is exciting, interesting and fun and if the protagonists handle the challenges they face in a good way. The goal is to cooperate and together build up an engaging atmosphere and story. One of the participants is the narrator and functions as rules arbiter and director in one, the others are players and each have a protagonist that the game is about. The narrator portrays other characters and speaks for them in the story. The narrator is not the players' enemy, even though he/she sometimes portrays narrator characters who are hostile toward the protagonists. The narrator prepares building blocks that the players during the game session help to build together into the story itself. The building blocks consist of narrator characters, with background stories and mutual relationships, places and special events that the protagonists can be faced with. When the protagonists begin to act the narrator characters will react and vice versa, and the story is built up by the events that arise. The goal is for the story after one or several game sessions to conclude – often through the protagonists defeating the villain, freeing the prisoner, finding the missing object or avenging a wrong. The absolutely most important thing about roleplaying is that it should be fun. It's good to talk outside the game about what is and is not fun, and if something goes wrong during the game's course one must see to doing something about it so it doesn't happen again.

> **Character Sheet** — *This section contains a fillable print character sheet. See the original PDF for the form layout.*

What Noir Is

Noir is a dystopian roleplaying game of darkness, violence, and death. The dystopia consists of a worldview that resembles our own during the early 20th century but which is nevertheless not the same. The world is darker and more dangerous—something we recoil from, something we don't want to experience for real. Noir is a French word meaning simply "black" and it's a fitting name as it encompasses darkness and light as well as the grayscale between them. The game's setting and mood is dark, bleak and hopeless—where individuals are secondary before the primary state apparatus, where bureaucrats and clans fight for power in the

countless corridors of the authorities, where the State's police without cause bring in citizens for interrogation and where insane madmen, strange forces and hidden mysticism lurk in the fog-veiled alleys. In Noir's world, human life has little value and free will is far from self-evident. Nature is plundered of its wealth and ravaged in a reckless hunt for profit and resources. Vast wars rage against a nameless enemy and many of the Imperium's men perish in the meat grinders of war. All occurs in the State's presence and at its command. Orders shall be obeyed, not questioned. Many who live in the world fight a daily struggle for survival in the vast machinery. If you try to break societal patterns you must be prepared to fight for your cause and for your views. It's a cold and harsh world where many meet grim fates. The rich have enormous fortunes and the poor are left without any social safety nets whatsoever.

Mood & Setup

The goal with Noir is to create a setting and mood where exciting, dramatic and entertaining stories can be born and driven forward by players and narrator together. What follows is a number of highly stylistic and general thoughts on how Noir can be played, even though it naturally supports other types of stories as well. The below should be seen as a very generalizing description, where multitudes of exceptions from common conventions exist side by side. The idea is that Noir shall contain elements to create precisely that game world that both players and narrator want to experience adventures in. A melancholic world where fate guides dark doubting heroes in a hopeless struggle against a condescending authority, widespread corruption and brutal criminality—and not least a struggle against themselves, where destructive emotions like violence, vengeance, lust and desire brood beneath the surface. The players create their protagonists who are often anti-heroes with traumatic experiences in their past. They have weaknesses and fears like everyone else and no one is perfect, but they nevertheless possess the ability to perform small or great wonders in the dystopian world in which they live. Their innate morality is usually questionable but is rarely either completely black or completely white, but lands in a gray zone where egoism and survival instincts decide. Their motivations vary—perhaps someone wants to achieve forgiveness for past sins, another wants to find their childhood sweetheart and finally confess their love while a third wants to avenge the corrupt prosecutor who made him or her lose family, home and honor. Common phenomena in Noir's world are corruption, violence, cynicism, pessimism, alienation, guilt, desperation and paranoia. The individuals who move in the stories are often hardboiled private eyes, charming sociopaths, corrupt cops, zealous bureaucrats, cunning intelligence agents, brutal gangsters, pathetic petty criminals, chain-smoking war veterans and cold-hearted killers. Common traits in these are obsession, crude cynicism, resignation, guilt, brooding, inner insecurity and a sordid past, full of dark secrets, tragedies and broken promises. Often they are morally dubious losers who fight from the underdog position and who struggle to even survive in the harsh and unforgiving world they find themselves in. Not infrequently they fail. Betrayal, murder, vengeance and guilt are very common ingredients in the stories. The women in the stories are often strongly polarized —either it's about the maternal, safe, loving and dutiful woman, or about the deadly woman—femme fatale—strong women who by various means control and manipulate their surroundings, especially men. They use charm, sexuality and charisma to seduce, turn the heads of and control their victims, and are often perceived as being mysterious, enigmatic, beautiful, sophisticated, lustful, irresponsible, tough, quick-tongued and/or desperate. Their motives are many times hidden and they use duplicity, flattery and lies to mislead those who seek the truth. Many times the woman wants to get some person, usually a man, to perform a task. Often it's about something that is illegal and/or life-threatening to carry out, but the woman's enticements with rewards on multiple levels get even the most stubborn of men to give in, regardless of risks or consequences.

Surroundings and environments are characterized by darkness, shadows, rain and bleakness. Rain-wet asphalt, cracked facades in dark alleys and dirty back streets sparsely illuminated by bare light bulbs or weathered

neon signs, are classic scenes in a typical Noir story. This shapes the people who live there, many are morally broken, sadistic and selfish, and love, peace and care are as rare as an honest police constable. The individuals are broken, with weaknesses, bad experiences and wounded psyches, and cannot find the way out of their own hell but only repeat their bad patterns time and again in hope of reaching something better, of succeeding with something, even if it's only surviving until morning. **Sandukar** The world's center, the world's light, the world's darkness: Sandukar —the eternal city. Here the dead skyscrapers stretch high up toward the firmament. The streets are shadowed by massive zeppelins that navigate between the air harbors and everywhere can be heard the constant pounding from the machines. Sure, the smoke from the chimneys lies like a sick fog over the city and sure the acid rain falls often, but in the middle of the despotic world's center lies beauty and freedom. Some seek it in the one god, others in spirits. I myself prefer the whores' warm bodies and their soft words in my ear, while they empty my wallet. So I hope you will enjoy it here; oppressed, sullied and forgotten. —Vautiren Markov, street philosopher, entertainer and agitator wanted by the State Sandukar is the city. The city where things happen, where raw materials are shipped on endless railways, where the poor journey to find fortune. Sandukar is the city that never sleeps, that is never calm or quiet. Around this tangle of people, iron, stone, concrete and glass are massive industries that spew their sick black smoke over the city's inhabitants, making them live in a gray haze which the sun rarely manages to break through. As if it were time's hub, everything seems to revolve around Sandukar, by some called the eternal city. Even before the ancient frost had faded and the mighty wind stilled, the industries' smoke rose anew from the city's foundations. The city devours life, the city devours death, the city devours violence, torment and horror. Sandukar is built on the western coast, by the Oil Sea, and has millions of registered inhabitants. It is also the capital of the Imperium, a collection of realms which are ruled by the State and its officials from tradition-bound and ancient clans. In Sandukar everything can be found, from basic goods to luxury, from the harmless to the vulgar, from the moderate to the perverse. The city is a breeding ground for human darkness, selfishness and degradation. Many of the inhabitants are passivized and spend their spare time in their sordid apartments to later journey to dirty and heavy industrial jobs where they spend twelve hours per day. In families they gather around the radio sets in the evenings or they read aloud from books or newspapers. Despite the harsh world, most have learned to live with the State's oppression and no longer think about it. They uncritically absorb the news the State grants them through censored newspapers and newsreels. Critical thinking

has nearly vanished and people would rather spend time reading about the latest movie stars, their relationships and scandals. Similarly, they read about the brave soldiers who fight at the fronts and about the terrible enemies that threaten the realm. They choose not to see reality in order to cope with living. For even in this harsh world there is hope, love and pleasure. In their free time people enjoy sports, theater, cinema visits or visits to museums and art galleries. Some prefer a cup of coffee at a café, others have a few beers at their favorite tavern. They go with the flow and stay away from trouble.

For others, who have made something of themselves, there are pleasures to partake in such as exquisite food, magnificent operas, exclusive balls and secret order meetings. A third group lives in hiding and makes their living by smuggling in or out contraband, refugees, slaves, weapons, drugs or stolen goods.

The city's architectural appearance fascinates many. The high-rises are built in stone, with lead-framed windows and grinning stone gargoyles. Marble, copper and steel are also evident. Several architectural styles are mixed but the Gothic spires and arched vaults as well as the Art Nouveau movement's beautiful forms are dominant. In addition to the majestic high-rises there are the overcrowded workers' districts where the hard-toiling laborers live in soot-blackened brick houses. The industries themselves are massive constructions of

brick, steel and cogwheels. From their tall chimneys constantly billows a sickly stinking smoke whose ashes like a shroud of mourning settle over the surroundings.

Above the houses the zeppelins glide forward in silence to the airship harbors in the city's center. Sandukar is surrounded by a high wall of black basalt and at its countless gates thorough inspections are conducted by state troops. The circular shape, the canals' unusual construction and the massive towers that reach toward the clouds, higher than any other buildings, reinforce the city's surrealistic feeling. One can find massive monuments, ancient constructions and decorated halls where the lineages are said to take their pleasure.

Nowhere in the Empire is corruption as widespread as in its stronghold. The bureaucrats, civil servants, authority personnel and police force are all severely afflicted, which causes ordinary citizens to harbor great contempt for all forms of authority. At the same time they know they must have cash on hand to escape the greedy inspectors' wrath and be punished for some obscure crime that the inhuman law book is full of, while the tribunals' lawyers eagerly lick their lips. One must be careful so that no one reports one's anti-state thoughts or expressions. Members of the secret state police, Stapo, move among the people and monitor, eavesdrop and note what happens. Should one receive a visit from the black-coated Stapo collectors one evening, one knows it is probably the last time one sees one's loved ones.

Within the city's sectors the individual's movement is often restricted and to be able to go to another sector requires passes and correct identification papers. Subway and canal boats are commonly used, but for longer journeys trains are required. To get in or out of the city one must take one of the bridge gates, which are guarded by state inspectors and city guard. The queues at exit and entry are usually long and patience-trying.

Sandukar is both the dream and the nightmare in one—a place where one can succeed in reaching the ultimate achievement, but where one just as easily can die a slow and agonizing death.

The Empire

The Empire is the gigantic state where the stories in Noir take place. It is said that once upon a time war raged in the Empire. The peoples fought against each other in an unending spiral of violence. Times of peace were short and there was always some realm that fought to conquer its opponents. When everything fell under the State's shadow the realms became provinces under the lineages' rule. Some of the provinces are very rich and have multiple cities, others are wastelands that are plundered for their natural resources but otherwise left alone.

The Empire covers thousands of miles and is connected by poorly maintained roads, canals and airship harbors for the zeppelins. If one wants to travel through the realms one does so most safely by train. The railway tracks stretch like a spider's web across the Empire and stop at all major stations. This way of traveling is cheap and fast, moreover the State has good control over the passengers and exactly where they travel. The rich use the airships to travel and most places have an airship harbor with at least one ship's capacity.

Beyond a few larger cities, where the capital Sandukar shines brightest, the realm is fairly barren, meager and desolate. Few people in the cities see much of the wilderness, the pine forests or the majestic mountains. In the wilderness there are many hidden things. It is said to be a place for rebels and outlaws. Likewise many areas stand under direct control of the lineages, who dwell there in their massive estates and castles. Here ordinary people are not given access and what transpires behind the walls is kept secret.

Despite the world outside the cities being ill-regarded, here one finds the resources that drive the realms. From the mountains the iron ore and coal are retrieved, from the forests the timber, from the fields the grain

and livestock. Here and there rise massive industries where the workers are slaves under the companies. Usually one only sees the smoke from these in the distance.

Every area within the realm is ruled by a family or clan from one of the great lineages. Intrigue-making, double-dealing and machinations are daily fare among the lineages, as they wish to reach as great success as possible when it comes to riches, power and prestige. It may well happen at the expense of another lineage or in the worst case another family within one's own clan.

In the north the war rages against the enemy. The war has been going on for decades and devours manpower and materiel at a furious pace, all to reach the next trench and conquer another bomb-torn ruined city. But the most important thing is to ensure that the enemy does not succeed in breaking through and destroying the good lifestyle and standard that the State has provided its subjects with in the Empire.

In the east the war rages against a province that broke free from the realm. The province is surrounded but its strong armament and ability for self-sufficiency make it a very difficult target. Nevertheless it is considered only a matter of time before it is reconquered.

The Lineages

There are a number of lineage houses which under the State's authority watch over the Empire and its people. The lineages follow their own laws and have masses of money, influence and power at their disposal. In recent times it has become increasingly common for lineages to socialize with the rich and powerful from the ordinary population. The older and more conservative lineages, however, prefer to see the people as servants with whom one has no social interaction.

Between the lineages numerous conflicts occur in secret. This rarely reaches the ordinary people's ears. Assassinations, bribes, threats, intrigues and disputes can escalate into major conflicts where many innocent members of the people are used as pawns in the power game.

The Bureaucrats

The administrative chaos that drives the Empire seems as ingenious as it is incomprehensible. For an outside observer it is impossible to grasp, and even for those who work within the administration, all parts outside one's own specific area are shrouded in mystery.

Despite its complicated and sometimes seemingly illogical function, the bureaucracy works and maintains the Empire. If one has great influence or money one can take shortcuts within the bureaucracy—but most ordinary mortals must endure its incomprehensible web.

An Evening with Noir

Here follows an example of a typical roleplaying session in Noir. Petter is the narrator while Marco, Sarah and Rikard are players. Marco portrays Gabriel, a socially smooth private detective who can handle a pistol. Sarah's role is the efficient criminal inspector Anya Malov, who frantically ensures that the law is followed. Anya and Gabriel have a certain romantic tension between them but Anya has difficulty with Gabriel being, as she sees it, overprotective. Rikard plays Mordekai, an indifferent, large-built ox of a man, with brawling in his blood and masses of dark secrets in his past.

The scene is a rainy Sandukar, the capital of the Empire. It is night and the sky is covered by heavy rain clouds which pour their contents toward the ground below. In the city district Ikonen the three protagonists struggle

to get open a back door to a darkened mechanical workshop. Anya is there because she suspects there should be information about human smuggling among the company's ledgers. Gabriel is there because his client's missing brother was last seen entering the building. Since the workshop is located in one of the really bad quarters Gabriel contacted an acquaintance—Mordekai—to get support if it should be needed.

In the example certain rule terms will be used, which may seem strange if one doesn't know Noir's rules. Feel no frustration over this but read on—and read the example again later when the rules have also been read through, for increased understanding.

Everything the protagonists say in the scene is written within quotation marks, as opposed to what the players say the protagonists do. All rules and die rolls are written within brackets.

Petter (Narrator): The rain pours down over the city and threatens to flood the deserted and dark back alley where you stand. The clock approaches midnight this Monday evening. At the door stands Gabriel on his knees, determinedly focused on opening the lock in the rusty metal door into the workshop. What are the rest of you doing?

Sarah (Anya): I keep watch backward so we don't get visitors. Also I flip up my coat collar and adjust my hat so I get as little wet as possible.

Rikard (Mordekai): I don't give a shit about the rain and tiredly light another smoke.

Petter (Narrator): Okay. Gabriel, check how it goes with the lock. Roll a difficulty roll with Dexterity, don't forget the expertise you have in lockpicking.

Marco (Gabriel): Yes, I roll. I have skill twelve. [Marco rolls two ten-sided dice]. Yes, it's well over 20, probably 26, 27 something, do you need to know exactly?

Petter (Narrator): Is the roll exceptional?

Marco (Gabriel): No.

Petter (Narrator): It's okay, as long as it's successful. You reach the lock's challenge level. With a click you feel how the lock opens to your sensitive fingers.

Marco (Gabriel): I whisper and wave to the others and put away the picks.

Rikard (Mordekai): I walk forward.

Sarah (Anya): I follow, but keep watch backward.

Petter (Narrator): You see nothing and hear nothing either. It's dead as the grave here.

The Church

Like a dog cowed by fear, the church of the one god cowers in the shadow of the State. As time passes it grows ever weaker. Still there are those who pray to the one god, but the oppression of those who visit the church grows ever harsher. Many keep their prayers to themselves and rarely bear the symbol of the cross openly. Yet the church has the power to defy the State, for according to an ancient decree it has the right to spread its teachings. In the church one can find piety and benevolence, but many evildoers hide behind the holy facade, and here it is greed and dark lusts that rule.

Many within the church believe that they now live in the end times. That purgatory will soon sweep across the world. Others believe this has already happened. That the darkness and suffering that surrounds them can only mean that humanity is doomed, and that only through submission before the one god can one be guided to the kingdom of heaven.

Since the uprising in the kingdom of Presvedonia and the church's newfound power there, though the holy scripture is proclaimed in a different interpretation, the State's agents monitor budding revolts within the church's ranks. It would not take much for the State to find justification to crush the church completely.

The Contagion

The State's apparatus of power knows what exists and what does not exist. To claim anything other than what the State has proclaimed is punishable by death. Sometimes, however, events and mysteries break through the State's control. People see and hear things they shouldn't, and some things cannot be hidden. In Sandukar, a rumor spreads of a soul plague, reaching more and more ears.

The plague is a destructive force that destroys and perverts everything it touches. Within the church, one can hear priests tell their confidants about it and warn them of the afflicted. In the poor quarters, street thugs whisper of strange things living in the city's shadows. The afflicted are driven to madness before the contagion finally extinguishes their life flame. But some of them are said to return from death as something far more malevolent and terrible. The State claims that all this is the enemy's tactic to create chaos, and those who spread this message do best to do so in secret.

The Military

The Empire has a mighty military force. The infantry is the main unit, and the massive battles raging in trenches, ruined cities, and during violent offensives consume many lives. Simpler types of armored vehicles have begun to appear on the battlefields. These, however, have trouble advancing in difficult terrain and require constant service. The artillery available is powerful but not particularly precise, and often bombs detonate within friendly territory. Even though aircraft are effective as bombers and fighters, they play a withdrawn role, as most generals believe that battle should be fought on the ground and not in the air.

Recently, all soldiers have been equipped with gas masks, as the eastern enemy commonly uses various types of poison gas in their attacks. At first, it was considered that the loss of soldiers in gas attacks was less severe than the cost of having to manufacture gas masks for the army.

The gas masks, however, do not always provide adequate protection, as the enemy constantly introduces new biological weapons. Soldiers who have spent long periods on the eastern front often suffer from constant nausea, temporary hallucinations, and tremors, as a result of being exposed to poison gas countless times.

Only men are allowed to fight in the Empire's army. Most come from poor circumstances and see a chance for a better future by letting themselves be recruited. Those who survive 20 years within the army receive a pension and can advance as officers. In addition to soldiers who volunteer, there are special army units with former prisoners. These have been pardoned in exchange for spending time in the army to atone for their crimes. These units have worse

Summary – Roleplaying • Everyone participating in playing Noir is called a player, except one who is called the narrator. • Each player has a main character in the game, a hero of the story, and decides for themselves what the main character will do. • The game proceeds as a told story between the players and the narrator and

takes place in each participant's imagination. Neither game pieces nor boards are used. • The players usually cooperate to achieve the story's goal. • The narrator is the game's leader – he/she acts as director, screenwriter, cameraman, and judge, and portrays all supporting roles in the story. • Each main character in a story is described with game values in a form called the character file. The values are used when the main character's skills in different areas are assessed or need to be checked. • Game rules exist to represent the game world, create dramatic conditions, and handle the unpredictability that dice rolls bring.

Marco (Gabriel): I try to get the door open as quietly as possible.

Petter (Narrator): It's stiff and some creaking is impossible to avoid, but you do your best.

Marco (Gabriel): I slip inside quietly.

Rikard (Mordekai): I follow his example.

Sarah (Anya): Me too.

Petter (Narrator): Okay, can you all make a resistance roll with Agility to see how quietly you move, as it's quite poorly lit in here, or do you want to turn on the light? [All three players shake their heads and roll the dice]

Sarah (Anya): I get a sum of 24.

Marco (Gabriel): And I get 15.

Rikard (Mordekai): Yippee, I got a total of 12, exceptional too, with double twos. So that's bound to fail... [The narrator makes a hidden roll]

Petter (Narrator): You slowly enter the premises, among machines and tables with tools. It smells acrid of solvents and oil. The rain drums against the roof. Suddenly Mordekai bumps into a pile of tools whose handles stick out beyond the table edge. The tools fall onto the concrete floor with a terrible racket.

Marco (Gabriel): I stop, crouch down, and try to take cover behind the nearest machine.

Sarah (Anya): I sigh and draw my pistol.

Rikard (Mordekai): And I curse like hell: "Fucking goddamn cursed shit-bastard, you shall die, for Satan's sake!" Then I kick, in frustration, a wrench away so it slams into the far wall.

Sarah (Anya): "But quiet, for fuck's sake!"

Rikard (Mordekai): I give her the look. The look that says more than words.

Sarah (Anya): I raise my left hand, disarmingly like that, it's calm, you know.

Petter (Narrator): Gabriel, make a difficulty roll.

Marco (Gabriel): Really? For what?

Petter (Narrator): You don't know.

Marco (Gabriel): Okay. [Rolls the dice] The result is 15, an eight and a seven.

Petter (Narrator): [Checks Gabriel's skill in Intuition that the narrator has written down and sees that the roll succeeded] Gabriel, even through all the racket and commotion you sense that you're not alone in here.

Marco (Gabriel): Oh, I scan the premises and slowly draw my submachine gun with one hand. With the other hand I try to gesture to the others that something is up.

Petter (Narrator): You others perceive that Gabriel seems to want something.

Rikard (Mordekai): Really?

Sarah (Anya): I look at him questioningly.

Petter (Narrator): Suddenly the light comes on, the heavy fixtures are awakened with a hum to life over the course of a few seconds. Up on a platform, behind and above you, you see a grated floor with a spiral staircase up to an office behind glass panels. Now you also see how a work lamp seems to have been lit up there. On the grated floor stand three people: a man with a leather jacket and a cigarette in his mouth, another in a suit and glasses, and a third – a giant bruiser

equipment and are usually assigned the most dangerous missions, such as storming machine gun nests, advancing through minefields, or leading mass assaults against the trenches.

The women who wish to fight for freedom must settle for staff positions, maintenance, and hospital service, as the war leadership doesn't want to mix the two sexes unnecessarily. They would be considered harmful to morale and esprit de corps, diverting focus among individual soldiers. However, one can find female officers within the military. They often come from the families and command just as well as their male counterparts.

Soldiers in the field have few pleasures. After brief leaves, they are forced to return to the war and witness which of their comrades have fallen to the enemy. Alcohol and drugs are used to cope, and the female lifers who are forced into the field are heavily used and usually become breeding grounds for various lice and diseases. Everything contributes to making the soldiers inhuman and cold-hearted. But there are those who find comradeship and those who burn with their struggle to protect the Empire. Then there are always those who begin to enjoy the horrors of battle. They cannot adapt to a normal world but remain in the war because it is only in the bloody clashes that they belong.

The Enemy

The Empire has two major enemies. These diabolical adversaries threaten constantly, and only through the State's forceful intervention are they kept at bay. There is no communication with the enemy that the soldiers notice. The enemy must only be killed. Prisoners may only be taken on orders from superiors. To communicate with the enemy in any way is seen as treason and carries the death penalty. The State's propaganda fuels the hatred soldiers feel toward their enemies – only through their extermination can peace be achieved.

The northern enemy: In the north, beyond the Arkady Mountains lies a wilderness of ruined cities, burned forests, bomb craters, swamps, and mile-long trenches. Time and again the Empire's armies have clashed with the northern enemy in this hellish place. Millions of corpses lie sunk in the muddy ground along with rusty vehicles and mines. The war has been going on for nearly a century – sometimes in the form of a static trench war, sometimes as bloody offensives.

The eastern enemy: The Todescu family in the eastern province of Presvedonia unexpectedly turned against the State. The province, which is very rich in raw materials and industries, mobilized its troops and crushed the

loyal army units that remained. During the years the war has lasted, several cities have been destroyed, and the eastern enemy seems to constantly receive new powerful weapons on their side. The State's forces now have the upper hand and have slowly begun to close the noose around the eastern enemy's territory. Every meter is costly in terms of lives and capital. The enemy's massive artillery pieces bombard the State's forces day and night, and they have control over the airspace. A further problem is enemy agents who have infiltrated the army and bureaucracy. The eastern enemy, despite being at a disadvantage, is very strong.

The Church has gained great power in the rebellious province, and soldiers fight fanatically in accordance with the word of the one god in a new interpretation of the doctrine. On soot-scorched battlefields rise crosses where prisoners have been crucified to appease the one god. In the provincial capital Marcinko, which is the enemy's stronghold, the Silver Cathedral has become the seat of the enemy's leadership. From here are proclaimed the commandments of war's cleansing fire that must sweep across the Empire. The people hunger and lack many of the pleasures found in the other cities of the Empire, but in their hearts burns a supernatural faith. A hope for a better world after purgatory.

Rules

Rules in roleplaying are primarily used to create a fair balance in those moments where action and result need to be determined during the course of the story. They are used to simulate

with bulging muscles under a dirty undershirt. The man in the suit speaks. "You have no business here, you're trespassing on private land and property. Who are you?"

Sarah (Anya): I stand up and keep the pistol hidden behind my back. "We're from the police. We have suspicions of criminal activity here."

Petter (Narrator): "Oh, the police. So, where is your search warrant?"

Sarah (Anya): Damn, I knew we should have waited. "It's on its way, sir...?"

Rikard (Mordekai): I look for something big and heavy that I could throw at them.

Petter (Narrator): Okay, you see a pipe wrench on a bench nearby, just a few steps away. "Young lady, on its way, you say? So you don't actually have it? So right now you're just simple burglars, which means I have full right to defend myself? Good." You see him turn around and nod at the other two, who immediately draw weapons. The muscle guy has a shotgun while the man in the leather jacket has two revolvers. Roll initiative. No one is considered surprised. [Everyone involved rolls for Initiative.]

Marco (Gabriel): Successful roll, 16.

Rikard (Mordekai): The dice hate me tonight, I get seven.

Sarah (Anya): I know how it feels, I got nine...

Petter (Narrator): The guy with the revolvers is first at 22, he aims at you, Anya.

Sarah (Anya): I try to shoot back first. No, my initiative is too low for that. I defend myself.

Petter (Narrator): Make a resistance roll – Defense ranged combat.

Sarah (Anya): And I don't have any Fate either. [Rolls the dice] Let's see, sum 14, no 15.

Petter (Narrator): [Also rolls] Higher. He empties both revolvers into you. [Rolls again]. You take 21 in Shock, I suspect that's also a Wound?

Sarah (Anya): Damn, yes it is. I make the roll for Will to Live. [Rolls] But, it can't be true! I'm mortally wounded!

Petter (Narrator): What's the result of both dice?

Sarah (Anya): Eight.

Petter (Narrator): Then you die in eight rounds... Do you lose consciousness?

Sarah (Anya): [Rolls dice] No.

Petter (Narrator): You others see how Anya reads the situation too late. The guy with the revolvers laughs mockingly while he squeezes the triggers again and again. The bullets whine around Anya, many ricochet off the machines around her, but several shots hit her in the body and arms. You see her fall backward in a fine mist of blood.

Marco (Gabriel): "Nooooo!!" I awaken a drive: Save Anya's life, level Burning, okay?

Petter (Narrator): That feels reasonable given what just happened. Gabriel, it's your turn.

Marco (Gabriel): I want to run crouched toward Anya, while I fire snap shots up at the platform and the revolver guy. I spend two Fate points and roll two extra dice, because I must succeed. I add my character trait Loving too, since I want to protect and

different events in the world in a consistent and somewhat predictable way. Even the interaction between parts of the world and its inhabitants is governed by rules for the same reason.

The rules in Noir follow a simple basic concept where consistency and simplicity are guidelines. All dice rolls to determine results are made with two ten-sided dice, to which a fixed value is added. If the result is higher than either an opponent's value or a fixed difficulty level, the roll is successful. If not, it counts as failed. This is the rules in brief—more information about dice rolls can be found on page 199.

The philosophy behind the rules

The rules in Noir are designed to be easy to understand and consistent to use. They are built on two key words—plausibility and credibility. This means that the purpose of the rules, beyond directly governing interaction with the game world and simulating it, is to emphasize the feeling and atmosphere that Noir is meant to convey. This is done by considering what is plausible and credible based on the conditions in the game world and the story—not based on what is plausible and credible in our own world. It is important to remember this since Noir's world is different compared to our own. In Noir there are forces that affect ordinary people that do not exist in our world.

The players take on the roles of protagonists in a dramatic story where dark heroic deeds, agonizing self-sacrifices and brutal violence are a very tangible part, something most of us are thankfully spared from. Therefore, one cannot base assumptions about plausibility and credibility on our world—instead one must try to consider whether it is plausible and credible in Noir's world and in the story that is ongoing. This may sound difficult, but one quickly realizes at what level one should be for it to feel right.

A very important philosophy is that the rules should inspire the narrator and the players. The rules exist as tools for acting in a fantastic and different world. Therefore, it is crucial that the rules also facilitate and provide ideas for creating new adventures, and that they increase tension without bringing either frustration or pace-killing stops.

Realism

A very important point is that plausibility and credibility are not the same as realism. Noir is not meant to be a realistic game but one where melancholy heroic deeds, epic showdowns, dramatic twists, action-filled battles and exciting escapes occur without entailing such great risks that the protagonists are more or less guaranteed to die as a result. The goal of any role-playing game is to have fun when participating, and it is easier to achieve this goal when the game allows bolder and more fantastic actions and there is a reasonable chance of succeeding with them. Realism often goes against this goal, since a hit with a firearm usually immediately puts a person out of combat condition and forces them into long hospital stays—and how fun is that, really?

At the same time, it should be mentioned that even though Noir is meant to be an action-filled game where cool maneuvers can be performed, it is not a superhero game where the protagonists can fly, run at a hundred kilometers per hour or throw fireballs at the enemy. Such things are neither plausible nor credible.

Online

Noir also exists on the Internet, where news, information, background material, tools and similar things are available for viewing and download. The vision is that Noir should be a living game where participants can engage and create a community together. Links to discussion forums and also a constantly updated interactive reference work, a so-called wiki, can be found there.

The address to Noir's home on the Internet is: www.noir.nu

save Anya. [Rolls the dice] I get 23 total with the two best dice results, after deduction for recoil.

Petter (The Narrator): Good use of the character trait. [Rolls dice] You get higher than what the opponent gets on their chance defense, so it's you who describes the sequence.

Marco (Gabriel): The pistol is emptied anyway—eight shots are used. [Rolls the dice] Damage effect is a bit over 20 so I suspect he's incapacitated, and I don't have to come up with the exact sum?

Petter (The Narrator): Correct, so what happens in the scene?

Marco (Gabriel): Okay. I desperately lunge toward Anya, with my gaze focused on her bloody body that just reaches the floor, and the blonde hair that flutters. At the same time I shoot as fast as I can with the pistol up at the landing, without really looking in that direction. Most of the bullets go astray, one shatters the glass window, but one hits the revolver man right in the head so the laughter abruptly falls silent. The body slowly slides over the railing and lands with a crash in a wooden crate full of scrap. Since my magazine is empty, I let the pistol fall to the floor and I take Anya's head in my hands, with tears in my eyes.

Petter (The Narrator): Nice. Mordekai?

Rikard (Mordekai): Easy, I throw the pipe bomb at the guy with the shotgun. [Rolls dice] Yeah well, I get 33, I suspect I get the highest?

Petter (The Narrator): [Rolls dice] True. He fails exceptionally too, so he's not in on this.

Rikard (Mordekai): [Rolls dice] Damage effect is, wow, that was high, maxed dice, a full 31, stunning admittedly but still.

- Petter (The Narrator): He's incapacitated so you get to tell what happens.

Rikard (Mordekai): Okay, the pipe bomb leaves my rough hands, rotates around its own center point in a circular motion and hits the surprised guy in the throat. The force of the impact breaks his neck and he stumbles backward, into the office, gurgling.

Petter (The Narrator): Lovely. A door slams somewhere. The glasses guy seems to have removed himself and you hear a car engine roaring to life outside, what do you do?

Sarah (Anya): "Help... me... Gabriel..." I cough and spit blood. I seek dimly for contact with Gabriel's gaze.

Marco (Gabriel): I stroke Anya soothingly over the bloody hair and at the same time try to find something I can use as a bandage for Anya, rags or an apron or something. I also shout to Mordekai. "Catch that bastard, I'll take care of Anya, get the hell out!"

Rikard (Mordekai): I nod to Gabriel, draw my heavy revolver smiling and rush howling with excitement toward the motor sound.

Petter (The Narrator): When you wrench open the door you are met by the rain and you see that...

And there we leave the three protagonists to their fates.

Chapter 2 – The protagonist

Even when he called me that evening I heard that he was onto something big. There was no mistaking the excitement in his voice when he said that name I have carried with me ever since, that name I have on my lips when I wake from my darkest nightmares.

We set a meeting at our regular place, a small beer café a couple of blocks from the canal where he would deliver the evidence, what I needed to finish my article. But he didn't come.

Finally I gave up my wait and left the premises. Listlessly I looked around, lit a cigarette and began to walk down toward the stinking water that runs through our city like a disease-ridden vein. That's where I caught sight of him. He lay next to his car, pierced by several bullets. His chest heaved laboriously and it was a miracle that he was still alive. I threw myself down beside him and when I lifted his head into my lap he briefly focused his gaze and coughed.

"It's bigger... than we thought..."

I could say nothing. The thoughts raced in my head. It was my fault that he was here, it was I who had given him the assignment. I suddenly felt a heavy pressure over my chest and couldn't breathe. The heart. It wasn't the first time. The city's sounds disappeared around me and I was only aware of my own heart's irregular pounding. He said something more, but I couldn't hear what. The heart sounds drowned out everything else.

The attack passed as quickly as it had begun, and the sounds of the surroundings came back. He rattled, coughed up more blood and then the spark in his eyes went out. It took me a few seconds to understand that my brother had just died in my arms. I stared out into the night, and my mind immediately found a thought to

focus on. A name he had said when he called. The man who was behind it all. And while the body grew cold in my lap I swore that I would not give up until the Engineer lay dead at my feet.

The game's heroes, those the spotlight greedily craves to capture, are the protagonists. Each player enters the role-playing game through their own protagonist and takes him/her through the story created by the participants, on a journey where no one knows where it ends.

Creating a protagonist

The people that the players portray in Noir are called protagonists. The rules in this chapter are used to create interesting, deep and multi-layered protagonists who are anchored in the world they operate in.

It may be appropriate to point out that these rules are not intended to simulate all the individuals that exist in the world, but are for creating protagonists specifically, as these are often special people who experience exciting and amazing events.

Who the protagonists are

Each player has their own protagonist through which they act with and against the game world. The protagonists in Noir's dark, bleak and harsh world are often antiheroes with tragic backgrounds, troubled relationships, destructive behaviors and weaknesses such as guilt, vengefulness, desire, wrath and obsession. Not infrequently they harbor a hunger for justice, an opportunity to set things right, or to get a new chance after life has repeatedly kicked the shit out of them.

That the protagonists are not flawless, good, shining hero types makes them interesting to role-play, as their various dark sides make them encounter the story in unpredictable and exciting ways.

But the protagonists are, despite their human flaws and heavy emotional baggage, the game's heroes and they are the lead role holders in the story that unfolds. This is the reason why this chapter is fairly extensive as it allows a player to find their protagonist and create them as he/she wishes.

Many of the parts covered in this chapter, for example attributes and abilities, are described in depth in the section called "The protagonist's anatomy", on page 212.

The Protagonist

How a protagonist is created, step by step Here follows a step-by-step description of how a protagonist is created. By following it in order, all the parts needed to produce a complete protagonist will be covered. Each step is described in more detail below.

1. Get a character sheet, a pen, and an eraser. The character sheet is available for copying on page 354.
2. Choose an archetype, see page 40, or go directly to step 4.
3. Choose a background package, see page 54, go to step 13.
4. Come up with a concept, an idea about who you want to portray. The concept is described according to the format "Nature + Occupation", see below.
5. Assign attribute values, see page 28.
6. Increase the ability values as desired, see page 28.
7. Calculate the protagonist's skills, see page 28.
8. Assign expertises where applicable, see page 28.
9. Determine the protagonist's limitations, see page 28.

10. Determine the protagonist's traits, see page 28.
11. Define the protagonist's character traits. These are described on page 28.
12. Determine the protagonist's relationships. This is described on page 29.
13. Calculate attributes and attribute values, see page 29.
14. Deepen the protagonist if desired. See page 30.
15. Decide the person's name.
16. Determine the protagonist's liquid funds and acquire equipment, see page 94.

Step 1: The Character Sheet The protagonist's mechanical values, personal information, background, equipment and the like are recorded on a character sheet. The character sheet is a standardized form that has pre-printed headings which facilitate use during the course of the story. A copyable character sheet can be found on page 354.

The protagonist can also be written down on regular paper, but it requires more work and can become cluttered.

Step 2: Archetypes A player who has no clear picture of their protagonist's personality and background can choose to use an archetype. The archetype is a typical example and summarizes a protagonist's life before he/she becomes an active part of the story. It concerns both experiences, events, career choices, lessons, upbringing and interests. The archetype also provides the protagonist's current situation, which is stated in the concept.

If this feels like good support in creating the protagonist, continue to page 40 to see the archetypes that are presented. When the archetype is chosen, proceed to Skills on page 28. You can also choose to create the protagonist entirely from your own imagination, and skip the help that an archetype can provide—then go directly to Attributes on page 28.

Step 3: Background Packages Background packages summarize a protagonist's concept, limitations and traits, as well as character traits and relationships. The idea is that a player who doesn't want to micromanage their protagonist's background should quickly be able to find and use a ready-made package that fits, or at least is close to, the player's idea for the protagonist. Background packages can also be used as a base in which parts can be swapped out if desired.

Step 4: Concept All protagonists fit into a concept. The concept is a very brief summary of the protagonist's character. The purpose of the concept is to help the player form an internal image of how the protagonist acts and functions and what place he/she takes in the story. The choice of concept has no mechanical impact but is only intended as support.

The concept is always written in the form Nature + Occupation. Nature refers to a summary of the protagonist's current prominent character, temperament and mood. Occupation is what the protagonist primarily does right now—job, assignment or engagement. Each archetype, if one has been chosen, shows a selection of suitable concept constellations. Otherwise, there are suggestions for both nature and occupations on page 28. The concept is noted on the character sheet.

Examples of concepts are hardboiled private eye, war-damaged veteran, constantly intoxicated brawler, cynical whore, determined and rule-breaking cop or curious reporter who stands on the side of the weak.

When developing the concept, the protagonist's general occupation, gender and age should also be considered. Mechanically this doesn't matter, but it provides support to the player during the creative creation process.

If a player has no idea for a concept, this step can be skipped and filled in later, when the protagonist has taken shape.

A concept can very well change as a protagonist gains new experience and experiences new events. Then it's just a matter of updating the concept.

Better from the start

Characters created with the presented system all become roughly equal. If a player's new character joins an existing group of experienced protagonists, it can be boring to be much less experienced. Then a narrator can choose to give the newly created character experience directly after the character is created. It may be appropriate to give the character approximately half the life experience that the character with the highest value in the group has, even though this is only a recommendation.

More information about experience can be found on page 220. The narrator must decide for themselves whether this feels like a good solution for their particular group of players—sometimes it may simply fit well that there is a large difference in the characters' experience levels, such as when a beginner joins an older mentor.

If experience is given from the start, this improvement occurs after the protagonist has completed the last step in the creation process—acquiring equipment.

Example of how a protagonist is created

On page 34 there is an example of how the entire creation process of a protagonist works. If anything feels unclear, please look at the example to gain clarity.

Suggestions for nature

• Irresponsible • Relaxed • Bitter • Blasé • Charming • Cynical • Depressed • Desperate • Bold • Selfish • Mean • Single-minded • Enthusiastic • False • Cowardly • Cheerful • Reckless • Idealistic • Cold-blooded • Cocky • Broken • Stupid • Manipulative • Condescending • Nervous • Incompetent • Passionate • Talkative • Disturbed • Self-loathing • Sharp • Withdrawn • Dry • Doubtful • Pompous • Burned out • Friendly • Ambitious • Adventurous

Suggestions for occupations

• Lawyer • Worker • Athlete • Bartender • Boxer • Financier • Fugitive • Photographer • Freelance reporter • Forger • Writer • Gangster • Fence • Burglar • Engineer • Inspector • Artist • Criminal detective • Courier • Bodyguard • Fortune seeker • Doctor • Mechanic • Model • Musician • Broker • Pawnbroker • Police constable • Bounty hunter • Private detective • Priest • Actor • Petty criminal • Socialite • Con artist • Taxi driver • Clerk • Investigator • Vagabond

Step 5: Attributes The attributes are the protagonist's basic prerequisites. There are nine attributes that must each receive an attribute value. Each protagonist gets one attribute value of 6, one of 5, three of 4, three of 3 and one of 2. Table 1:1 summarizes this.

More about what the attributes mean can be found on page 214.

Number Attribute Value Capacity

1 6 Good 1 5 Good 3 4 Average 3 3 Average 1 2 Poor

Table 1:1

Step 6: Abilities The abilities are the protagonist's general areas of competence. Each attribute's attribute value is doubled and gives the number of points the player has to allocate to the three abilities that fall under each respective attribute.

Increasing an ability value by one step costs one point. The ability value shows the person's general competence in the ability. The different competence levels are shown in Table 1:2

Ability Value Competence Level

0 Nonexistent 1–3 Amateur 4–6 Competent 7–9 Professional 10–12 Expert

Table 1:2

Step 7: Skills When all attribute values and ability values are filled in on the character sheet, they are summed for each ability, in the Skill column. This shows the person's final proficiency in the ability. More about skill can be found on page 213

Step 8: Expertises Expertise areas are narrower fields within the abilities, which give the protagonist specialized competence. More detailed information about expertise areas can be found on page 58.

In the abilities where the person has ability value four to six (4–6), he/she gets one expertise area. Should the person have ability value seven or higher (7+), he/she may choose two expertise areas within the ability. This is summarized by Table 1:3. Naturally, the requirements for the chosen expertise area must be met.

Ability Value Number of expertises from start

0–3 0 4–6 1 7+ 2

Table 1:3

Step 9: Limitations Protagonists in Noir all suffer from various forms of limitations that mean they have a harder time acting independently. This is in line with the idea that the protagonists are dark heroes who not only struggle against the story, but also with themselves and the flaws and inadequacies they possess in soul and heart.

Each protagonist gets 10 points to spend to give themselves limitations. The limitations are listed on page 80 and onward.

Step 10: Traits All protagonists have traits—characteristics that show who they are. These traits can be both negative and positive. Everything from physical appearance, personality, events during upbringing, genetic advantages or tragic handicaps have shaped the person into who he or she is upon entry into the story.

Each protagonist gets 10 points to use to give themselves traits. The traits are listed on page 84 and onward.

Step 11: Character Traits Character traits show a person's personality and behavior. They are in themselves neither positive nor negative, but can influence the person's reasoning and actions in different situations—for example, a greedy person has difficulty resisting a bribe.

It is appropriate for a person to have between one and three character traits, although more can be chosen if it fits the concept. See page 225.

The Character Traits

• Aggressive • Arrogant • Cautious • Greedy • Honorable • Vengeful • Loving • Indifferent • Lustful • Suspicious • Treacherous • Risk-prone • Convinced

Limitations and traits

It is important that players and narrator together analyze and think through the choices made, so that it both fits into the story as a whole and into the person's life. Most of the choices are general and can be interpreted in several different ways to fit. It can be interesting to know when in a person's life things happen or have happened—having poor vision is probably a genetic condition the person was born with, while having a family can affect the person in very different ways depending on whether he acquired it recently or if it happened long ago in his/her life.

It may very well be that a player has a concept that requires more choices than he/she has points for. Then the player and narrator should discuss this and see if it's okay to change the sum of points so the concept fits. The important thing is to ensure that the person doesn't become completely unplayable or parodic. In the end, it's still about playing with a protagonist you enjoy and who fits into the story to be told.

Greater character trait impact

The character traits can be made more pronounced and then take an even larger place in the person's life and personality. By giving a character trait the prefix very or extremely, one amplifies its degree of impact. For example, a person instead of being honorable and aggressive can become very honorable and extremely aggressive.

A person should not have more than two character traits with the prefix "very" or more than one with the prefix "extremely", unless exceptionally good reasons exist.

Bear in mind that character traits that are extreme have very great impact on how the person acts, so they should be used sparingly and with consideration. People with several extreme character traits tend to be difficult to play and exaggerated, and this can easily ruin the story.

The narrator must approve all character traits that have prefixes.

Expression

When a trait is chosen, its expression must also be determined. The expression a trait takes provides increased depth and an extra dimension to the character and makes it easy to immerse yourself in him/her as it shows how and/or in which situations the trait manifests. All chosen traits shall have at least one expression. A trait can have several expressions, but usually the number is between one and three. For examples and information regarding expressions, see page 228.

Step 12: Relationships A protagonist knows three narrator characters from the start. The player should work together with the narrator to create these characters so they fit into upcoming stories and into the protagonist's concept. The narrator gets to assess the reasonability of the proposed narrator characters.

A narrator character may not have any blood ties to the protagonist or be his/her spouse, as this is reserved for the limitation family (see page 81).

The three narrator characters are noted in the protagonist's character sheet. Their respective name, profession, and concept are determined freely while Influence and Relationship are set to "Minor" and "Hostile" respectively. The player then gets 10 level points. Each level point can improve either Influence or Relationship by one level, see tables 1:4 and 1:5. More about narrator characters, relationships, and influence can be found on page 204.

Suggestions for suitable relationships

• Ex-partner • Former employer • Former business partner • Friend/acquaintance • Childhood friend • Lover • Assistant/henchman • Rival • Mentor • Professional contact

Level Points Value Corresponds to

0 6 Minor influence 1 9 Moderate influence 2 12 Influential 3 15 Significant influence 4 18 Very great influence Table 1:4

Level Points Relationship

0 Hostile 1 Disapproving 2 Neutral 3 Favorable 4 Friendly Table 1:5

Step 13: Attributes & attribute values Attributes are a kind of secondary information about the character that is used during gameplay. Some of the attributes are used for rolls, while others are used as references for other circumstances - also for calculating other attribute values. For more detailed information about attributes, see page 218.

Attribute values

Each attribute has an attribute value that is determined in different ways, usually by adding together the skill in different abilities, according to table 1:6. All attribute values are rounded down to the nearest whole number. A recommendation is to determine Size first as it is used in other formulas.

Every time a skill that is part of a formula changes, the attribute values governed by the formula must also be recalculated.

If an attribute value is affected by any additional factor, for example a trait or an area of expertise, this change is always applied after the possible formula, or base value, has been determined.

Attribute Attribute Value

Defense (Intuition + Reactions + Awareness)/3 Learning (Determination + Reasoning + Worldliness)/3 Impression (Charm or Leadership + Sense + Worldliness)/3 Standard of Living Usually 4, see page 86 Life Will (Determination + Constitution + Sense)/3 + 5 Notoriety Usually Unknown (5), see page 86 Damage Bonus (Size + Strength)/10 Size Usually Medium (15), see page 87 Combat Movement (Determination + Constitution + Mobility)/3 Wound Threshold (Constitution + Size + Strength)/3 Luck Usually 0, see page 87 Endurance (Resistance + Size + Strength)/3 + 5 Appearance Usually Ordinary (±0), see page 87 Well-being Usually 10 out of maximum 10, see page 80 Fate Usually 10, see page 87 Overview (Reactions + Sense + Awareness)/3 Table 1:6

Step 14: Deepening The deepening is for further exploring the protagonist's emotional life, upbringing, experiences, and personality. It can take quite a bit of time and is not necessary for character creation - but it gives the protagonist a multifaceted background and a complex depth.

Step 15: Name Determine what the protagonist shall be called. The name says a lot about the person in question and if it becomes the "wrong" name, this can disturb the experience. Avoid inappropriate, silly, famous, or historical names.

Step 16: Money & equipment The protagonist receives a sum of cash based on his/her standard of living, usually 5,000 zovriner. The character also gets a starting set of items that illustrates that he/she has lived a life before the story starts. He/she can also acquire additional possessions. More about possessions can be found on page 88 and onward.

Variants regarding relationships

A narrator can choose that each protagonist has more or fewer than three relationships from the start. The narrator can also assign narrator characters to a protagonist, for example if the narrator wants to tie in a narrator character he/she knows will appear in a future story and thus get a stronger connection to the protagonist.

Attraction & Passion A player who wants his/her protagonist to have an emotionally turbulent relationship from the start can give the relationship an attraction and/or a passion, according to page 208. This costs one level point for an attraction and an additional level point for a passion.

Successor

An interesting variant that can be used regarding relationships is that the player determines a successor to his/her protagonist. This means that one of the relationships is set in advance as a possible successor (that is, a new protagonist) if the current protagonist should disappear from a story, for example via death, kidnapping, retirement, flight, madness, or serious injury.

The advantage of this is that the classic stylistic elements revenge, searching, and mystery get a natural entry into the story. Often it can be difficult to introduce new protagonists into an ongoing story in a non-forced way.

If a successor is already designated among the protagonist's relationships, the connection becomes credible and falls naturally into the story.

A narrator can also let all protagonists get an extra relationship from the start, provided that it is precisely the successor. Otherwise, the successor has no special rules but functions exactly like an ordinary relationship to the protagonist.

Name suggestions

On page 158 there is information about naming cultures in Imperiet.

The deepening is for further exploring the protagonist's emotional life, upbringing, experiences, and personality. It can take quite a bit of time and is not necessary for character creation - but it gives the protagonist a multifaceted background and a complex depth.

History & psychological profile To give even more flesh on the bones, here follows a number of questions that the character reasonably should be able to answer. There are no right or wrong answers to the questions, but they are meant to help the player and narrator think in the right direction and to give the character the depth he/she deserves.

What does the protagonist's family, relatives & similar relationships look like? Does the protagonist have a large family or is he/she perhaps alone in the world? How does the family interact? Which holidays, festivities, and gatherings are celebrated? Do family members help each other or is there bad blood between different parts of the family? Are there other close ones who don't share blood ties with the protagonist but who still figure in his/her vicinity - like perhaps the shop owner on the corner or "uncle" Tatarin?

What were the protagonist's upbringing conditions like? Where was the young protagonist born and raised? Was it a protected, safe, and secure life or was it unsafe, with violence, shame, and anxiety? Was there fighting in his/her vicinity, were there bitter quarrels, divorces, disputes, alcoholism, abuse, violence, or assaults involved? How were the economic conditions - even in well-off homes emotional coldness and contempt are born?

What are the most important/most significant events in the protagonist's life? It is often individual events that make the protagonist choose certain paths in life - identifying some such events is of great importance when the character is developed. What has happened in the protagonist's life? Are there any events that played a major role during upbringing? **Perhaps a childhood friend's death or the adoption** of a pet? Or is there some other occurrence that has made a great impact - perhaps the first kiss, a brutal assault, the first car theft, or killing in self-defense?

Perhaps a role model died suddenly, perhaps the protagonist was betrayed by a comrade, or perhaps a love turned out to be an unfaithful bastard?

What does the protagonist value most highly? Is there something that is the absolutely most important thing in the protagonist's life? It can be anything from a photo of a lost love to spending time together with near and dear ones. Perhaps it is material status that is held highest, or a career with title, authority, and power. An ideal and a motto - to always protect the weak or to never strike women? To never fall into the detestable patterns one has experienced during one's upbringing and pass these on to one's own children? An object - a vintage car, a family heirloom, or maintaining the family's good name and reputation? The more valuable something is, the more the protagonist will fight for it.

What traits/characteristics does the protagonist dislike in others? All people like something about others. What is often called personal chemistry governs whom the protagonist prefers to associate with. Some people simply cannot get along. Mention some peculiarities, personality traits, or behaviors that the protagonist simply has very difficulty handling, accepting, or going along with. It can be a dissolute lifestyle, contemptuous attitudes and prejudices, boastful loudmouths, flirtatious slime, ingratiating toadies, lazy coworkers, or perhaps larger groups like women, men, bosses, or anything - but something is always there that disturbs the protagonist to the extreme.

What dark secrets or guilty conscience does the protagonist have?

Does the protagonist have a bad conscience about something he/she did in the past? Or perhaps about something he/she didn't do? An anxiety that sometimes scratches superficially and sometimes tears paralyzing wounds in the soul? A dark secret just waiting to leak out? Has the character hurt someone,

betrayed a friend for fleeting sex or dirty money, missed an important family dinner, looked the other way when a terrible crime was committed, or perhaps embezzled money from the poor and needy?

Perhaps the protagonist didn't take the chance to ask out the one he/she had yearned for for several years before it was too late? Perhaps the protagonist worked overtime one evening instead of going home to the family, and therefore couldn't protect them from the murderer who extinguished their lives? Or is the protagonist tormented by the memory of that evening, after the wild party, when he/she ran over a homeless girl and fled the scene? Or is it perhaps something shameful that hides beneath the surface - like that a brother and sister have a secret love affair or that the character is in debt and caught in the hands of an unscrupulous loan shark?

Personality & traits The player and narrator should figure out some characterizing traits that fit the protagonist's personality. Most people prefer certain things while they dislike others, or they dress or behave in a certain way.

Here follows a number of suggestions for different distinguishing traits a character can possess. These should be seen as help for bringing out the character in the story and for providing support in creating an image of the character, both for the player, the narrator, and fellow players. There are no rules governing these personality traits and a character can have none, one, or several, depending on what the image of the character is.

Appearance/clothing The character has a characteristic appearance or a preference for a special type of clothing. Overall, the character's appearance and presentation are important for being able to create an image of him/her. Here follows a number of suggestions for distinctive appearance and/or clothing, but it is of course free to come up with your own.

• Always wears blood-red lipstick • Always wears expensive clothes • Always wears a skirt • Always wears sexually provocative clothes • Always wears a white shirt • Always wears gloves • Always wears a scarf • Always wears a hat • Prefers clothes in a certain color • Always has a carnation in the lapel • Always wears expensive jewelry • Always has stubble • Always has visible wounds for some reason • Has bad/perfect complexion • Has a mustache or beard (or both) • Has no hair at all (anywhere?) • Has a clean-shaven face • Has wild and uncombed hair • Has a special hairstyle (slicked, curly, permed, ponytail, braids, etc.) • Never leaves his/her worn long coat • Never seen without a pair of sunglasses • Refuses to wear shoes other than stiletto heels • Is always meticulously made up • Is a fashion icon - only the latest may be worn • Is visibly scarred

Drives

Drives are the personal goals a character has. Usually the character develops drives during the course of the story in response to the events that occur. But if the character has a well-developed and thought-through background, it can very well be appropriate to give the character one or more drives from the start. See page 230 for more information about drives.

Behaviors

The person carries one or more distinctive behaviors and mannerisms. Here follows a number of suggestions for prominent behaviors, but you are of course free to come up with your own. • Easily becomes obsessed (with sex, a person, an object, a goal, et cetera) • Single-minded in thought—once you've decided, you've decided • Cries when tension releases, for example after a confrontation • Always rocks on their chair • Goes nowhere without being armed • Has a cigar in the corner of their mouth, usually unlit • Chain-smokes

constantly • Easily feels guilt (as soon as they might be the cause of something bad) • Sensitive about something, for example height, weight, size of nose, hair color, et cetera • Always puts their feet up on the table • Principled—even if it causes problems • Always flips a coin at every opportunity • Sits with their back to the wall when out at a bar • Throws around special recurring phrases, like "By Jestan!" or "That's hot!" • Curses in every sentence • Almost always angry/happy/gloomy/grumpy/et cetera • Constantly seeks confirmation from others for self-esteem • Comfort eats • Constantly chews on a toothpick • Chews gum • Creature of habit (must read the morning paper at breakfast, and/or always goes to the same barber at the same regular time) • Protective of something, for example children/women/ the vulnerable/homeless/elderly/et cetera • Eats the same food day in and day out • Only eats specific food **Irritating quirks** The person possesses one or more quirks that their surroundings may find disturbing and irritating. Here follows a number of suggestions for such traits, but you are of course free to come up with your own. • Bites their nails • Always flirts, even when it absolutely doesn't suit the situation, or when there's a rush. • Makes pessimistic comments about everything and everyone, is never satisfied or positive • Has dirty nails, regardless of whether they wash their hands • Likes to crack their knuckles • Cracks their jaw • Cracks their neck now and then • Picks their nose • Burps and passes gas • Calculates odds on all activities and actions. • Must always compete as soon as there's a chance—first to finish eating, first to the door, et cetera Despises/admires The person carries prejudices and despises phenomena or people. In the same way, the person can harbor great admiration and respect for phenomena and individuals. Here follows a number of suggestions for people, groups, organizations or phenomena a person can admire or despise. You are of course free to come up with your own. • Specific person/group/organization • The unemployed • Children in general • Criminals/gangsters • Animals • Drugs • Refugees/foreigners • Women in general • The Church/priests • The law • Men in general • Money • The police/police officers • Prostitutes • Racists • Sex • Hospitals/doctors • The state/authorities/bureaucrats • Beggars • Entertainers • Charity Likes/dislikes An individual always has something they like or dislike. It can be anything under the sun. Often the person has no problem interacting with things or people they don't like—it's just a general dislike and no deep fear. Here follows a number of suggestions for things one can like or dislike, but you are of course free to come up with your own. • Alcohol • Going to bars and meeting people • Reading books • Banks • Children • Cars • Dogs • Journalists • Cats • Knives • Artworks • The war • Opera • Rats • Sex • Hospitals • Firearms • Makeup • Gambling and betting • Sports • Water

Creating a protagonist To clarify the creation process, here follows a detailed example that takes into account both game mechanics and rules as well as the player's thoughts about creating a personality and emotional life for their protagonist. **New protagonist** Marco is going to play Noir and his narrator Petter has informed him that the intended stories lie close to classic film noir, with certain supernatural elements. After talking for a while, the two arrive at the conclusion that Marco's protagonist should be a shady figure, with one foot on the side of the law and the other in the underworld. Some form of consultant who takes jobs but isn't under anyone's yoke. Petter says that all protagonists at the start of the chronicle will begin with Life experience 0, see page 220. Step 1: Preparations (p. 27) Petter gives Marco an empty character sheet while Marco takes out a pencil and an eraser. Step 2 & 3: Archetype/background package (p. 27) In Noir, you're given the option to choose an archetype that becomes a framework for creation. Marco, however, wants to choose completely freely without the help that archetypes provide, which is perfectly fine. Thus Marco also skips step 3, the background packages. Step 4: Concept (p. 27) The protagonist needs to be summarized through a concept. After some pondering, Marco gives his protagonist the concept "Sharp consultant/detective". The protagonist is considered well-versed in the world he lives in (that the protagonist is male has emerged during the initial conversations), hence the sharp nature. The choice of consultant/detective as occupation provides dynamism in what kind of person the protagonist is—one who takes jobs for payment in various fields. Step 5: Attributes & attribute values (p. 28) Now the protagonist's basic data should be set up through definition of attributes

and attribute values. The nine values available to distribute are 6, 5, 4, 4, 4, 3, 3, 3 and 2. Marco sees the protagonist as a competent shooter, a guy who can handle himself socially and who isn't completely clueless. No particular weakness presents itself spontaneously.

The two highest values, 6 and 5, are placed on Motorics and Charisma respectively, to create prerequisites for a shooter who can talk to people. The three 4s are set on Build, Perception and Insight. The motivation behind this is that Marco sees the protagonist as well-trained and in good shape. Additionally, the protagonist is attentive to what happens around him and has a developed gut feeling. Insight provides the ability to resist social influence and have a grip on the situation so it feels right to put a relatively high value on that attribute. Three 3s and one 2 remain now. A 3 is put on Coordination so that the protagonist can manage if smooth movements or brawls are required. The next 3 is put on Creativity to give him imagination and resourcefulness. The last 3 is placed, after much deliberation, on Education, as Marco sees the protagonist as a reasonably well-read person, with schooling and general education in his background. This means that the 2 is placed on Will. At first it doesn't feel so good, but after some pondering and discussions with Petter, Marco arrives at the conclusion that it becomes a good hook for the protagonist, a twist in the personality. A doubting soul behind a harder exterior. Marco also takes the opportunity to update the protagonist's concept to "Sharp but doubting consultant/detective". Step 6: Skills & skill values (p. 28) By doubling an attribute's attribute value you get how many points you receive to increase the attribute's associated skills. In Marco's case it looks as follows: Coordination (3); gives 6 points. Build (4); gives 8 points. Motorics (6); gives 12 points. Education (3); gives 6 points. Creativity (3); gives 6 points. Will (2); gives 4 points. Insight (4); gives 8 points. Perception (4); gives 8 points. Charisma (5); gives 10 points. Marco looks at table 1:2 on page 28 and notes that a skill value of 4–6 corresponds to "Competent" and a skill value of 7–9 corresponds to "Professional". This gives an indication of what the levels represent. He begins with the attribute Motorics, where he has 12 points. The three skills under Motorics are Manual dexterity, Throwing weapons and Firearms. For seven points the skill value in Firearms is raised to 7. Five points remain. Four of these go to raising Manual dexterity to 4 and the last point raises Throwing weapons to 1. After Marco has gone through the rest of the attributes and skills, the point distribution looks as follows:

Coordination (3): Melee (4), Reactions (1), Mobility (1)

Build (4): Endurance (4), Strength (4), Tolerance (0)

Motorics (6): Manual dexterity (4), Throwing weapons (1), Firearms (7)

Education (3): Humanities (2), Medicine (2), Natural science (2)

Creativity (3): Construction (1), Create (1), Deduction (4)

Will (2): Determination (0), Resistance (1), Sense (3)

Insight (4): Empathy (1), Oppose (3), Streetwise (4)

Perception (4): Intuition (4), Vehicles (0), Awareness (4)

Charisma (5): Charm (1), Leadership (4), Persuade (5) That the skill values under Education are distributed evenly indicates a broad general basic knowledge. That Tolerance has 0 in skill value means that the protagonist's body isn't particularly resistant to diseases, poisons or drugs—probably the protagonist has been quite spared from such things since the value isn't higher. Since Persuade and Leadership are prioritized over Charm, the protagonist is quite direct in his approach and doesn't engage much in diplomatic maneuvering. A thought was born when the skill value in Leadership was determined, namely that the

protagonist has previously been in the army, for example as an officer, and that it was there that physique, shooting and leadership ability were formed. But due to low skill values in Resistance and Determination he didn't cope very well with this career, he had trouble giving orders in pressing situations and couldn't bear the horrors of war. Step 7: Proficiencies (p. 28) Proficiencies are obtained by summing the respective skill value with the governing attribute's attribute value. The protagonist's proficiencies in Marco's case are shown in table 1:7. **Attribute value** Skill Proficiency + Skill value

Attribute/Skill	Attribute Value	Proficiency
Determination	2	2+0
Charm	6	5+1
Empathy	5	4+1
Manual dexterity	10	6+4
Vehicles	4	4+0
Humanities	5	3+2
Intuition	8	4+4
Throwing weapons	7	6+1
Endurance	8	4+4
Construction	4	3+1
Leadership	9	5+4
Medicine	5	3+2

The table continues on the next page

Attribute/Skill	Attribute Value	Proficiency
Oppose	7	4+3
Natural science	5	3+2
Melee	7	3+4
Reactions	4	3+1
Resistance	3	2+1
Mobility	4	3+1
Sense	5	2+3
Create	4	3+1
Firearms	13	6+7
Deduction	7	3+4
Strength	8	4+4

Attribute/Skill	Attribute Value	Proficiency
Tolerance	4	4+0
Awareness	8	4+4
Streetwise	8	4+4
Persuade	10	5+5

Table 1:7 Step 8: Expertises (p. 28) Expertise is specialized competence or specialization within a skill. All skills that have a skill value between 4–6 get one expertise, and those with skill value 7+ get two expertises. In Marco's case this means that the protagonist gets expertises in the skills indicated in table 1:8. The table also shows the chosen expertises.

Skill	Skill Value	Expertises
Manual dexterity	4	1—Lock picking: Door locks (p. 63)
Intuition	4	1—Instinct (p. 64)
Endurance	4	1—Good shape (p. 66)
Leadership	4	1—Rhetoric: The army (p. 68)
Melee	4	1—Amateur boxing (p. 69)
Firearms	7	2—Battle-tested (p. 75), Weapon handling: Pistol (p. 75)
Deduction	4	1—Clear-minded: Tactics/strategy (p. 75)
Strength	4	1—Well-trained (p. 77)
Awareness	4	1—Observant: Notice discrepancies/details (p. 78)
Streetwise	4	1—Knows the score (p. 78)
Persuade	5	1—Persuasive: Convince/plead (p. 79)

Table 1:8 The expertises were chosen based on the image of the protagonist; a former officer in the army (Rhetoric: The army, Weapon handling: Pistol, Battle-tested, Clear-minded: Tactics/strategy), a guy who keeps his body in shape (Well-trained, Good shape, Amateur boxing) and who can handle himself socially and be aware of things (Persuasive: Convince/plead, Knows the score). Also the thoughts about the protagonist being involved in the action and having gut feeling are present (Observant: Notice discrepancies/details, Instinct). An expertise that hasn't been touched upon earlier during creation is Lock picking, something that came as a new experience for the protagonist in this step. The expertises help to shape the protagonist and show in a much clearer way than attribute values, skill values and proficiencies where his competencies lie. Step 9: Limitations (p. 28) Marco receives ten points that must be spent on limitations. After some reading he chooses the following: • Noticeable weakness: Women (Beautiful women): 2 points. The protagonist likes women, is drawn to them and spellbound by them, especially beautiful women. This is a sure source of trouble. • Tangible fear: Thick fog/smoke/gas: 3 points • Nightmares: 2 points The fear and nightmares stem from the war, Marco decides that when the protagonist finds himself in a situation where visibility is severely limited by fog, smoke or gas clouds he risks the fear taking over—a side effect from the countless gas attacks at the front. The nightmares the protagonist has are about the horrors he has seen and experienced on the battlefields. •

Indebted (Completely): 2 points Indebtedness means that the protagonist is in debt to a person, a company or an organization. The debt doesn't need to be further defined at this stage. However, it is a good hook to build personal stories on. • Basic code of honor Not harm women or children: 1 point The protagonist has a basic moral compass, a personal goal to never harm women or children. With this the ten points have been used. Step 10: Traits (p. 28) Also for traits Marco receives ten points that must be spent. On suggestion from the narrator Marco focuses on determining Size, Appearance and Standard of living first. • Tall (Size 21), height approximately 190 cm, weight approximately 90 kg: 2 points • Standard of living 6: 2 points • Attractive appearance: 1 point The protagonist is tall (Size 21). The height and weight are freely determined based on concept and background. The protagonist lives relatively well (Standard of living 6) with his own apartment and decent belongings. He looks relatively good (Attractive) which can provide advantages in social situations where appearance matters. Five points remain. • Flaw 1 extra point Among Flaws & Handicaps Marco sees that one can get more points. "Maximum five extra" Petter informs him. Marco chooses that the protagonist has a Flaw. The flaw concerns the skill Sense and comes from the protagonist's traumatic background. This gives an extra point, total six points. • Charming: 2 points • Hardy: 2 points For four points the protagonist gets two Talents & Gifts. Charming improves the first impression he makes on others, Hardy shows a physical ability to endure beatings and blows better than most. Two points remain.

"That night she used my body as a bandage." —Gabriel Jandaran

• Reputation: Noted (6): Underworld: 2 points Marco wants the protagonist to be known in the underworld as a reliable and dependable guy, a man you can trust when it counts. This consumes the last points. More points can be acquired through certain other features that give bonus points, but Marco thinks it feels good and sensible as it is.

Step 11: Character Traits (p. 28) Marco reads through the list of character traits. Three of them, with their respective expressions (p. 224), feel right. • Arrogant (Vain) • Very Greedy (Hungers for money) • Loving (Understanding, Accommodating)

The arrogance comes from a measure of vanity. Marco decides that the protagonist is a bit of a clothes snob and takes care of his appearance—always clean-shaven, clean nails, properly dressed in quality clothes from respectable brands, polished shoes, etc. "If you radiate class, you get classy jobs," as the saying goes.

The lust for money is a dominant character trait and therefore gets the prefix "Very." Money governs many of the protagonist's choices in life and he has difficulty saying no when money is offered for services or jobs.

Loving is perhaps a slightly unexpected character trait but it feels right—the protagonist gives a professional, interested impression, he has a smooth manner and an understanding of the client's needs and wishes.

Step 12: Relationships (p. 29) Three relationships shall be established, with name, trade, and concept. If the protagonist had had a family from Step 9: Limitations, members from this would have been added in this step. Each shall have a Relationship to the protagonist and a measure of their ability to perform actions, called Influence. Ten level points Marco shall use to increase these two values among the relationships.

Domenik "Manik" Jaeger, boastful but reliable smuggler/dealer. Relationship: Favorable (3 level points), Influence: 12 (2 level points) Manik is the protagonist's fence, a person who deals in most things and who has contacts on the street. The relationship has developed and is relatively personal—Manik sometimes gives the protagonist information or tips for free, something very rare in Sandukar. The two help each other when things get critical.

Doctor Yannik Reasescu, former client, private physician with his own clinic, has access to drugs. Relationship: Neutral (2 level points), Influence: 9 (1 level point) Doctor Reasescu was one of the protagonist's early cases, a client in a matter concerning finding a missing person. The case proceeded positively and the good doctor considers the protagonist to be a solid person, so he'll help out if medical care is needed outside the normal channels.

Talia Navarre, scorned and wounded ex-fiancée, manipulative and driven. Relationship: Hostile (0 level points), Influence: 9 (1 level point), Attraction (1 level point) Talia is the woman the protagonist abandoned at the altar. She is from a fine family with connections within House Guiskard and she didn't take the incident particularly well. She and the protagonist still have heated feelings for each other. But since wounded feelings are always close to the surface, the result is often fighting and quarreling.

Step 13: Attributes & Attribute Values (p. 29) Attributes and attribute values provide various information about the protagonist. Most are based on the protagonist's Skills. The formulas for calculation are given on page 29. In Marco's case it looks according to table 1:9.

Attribute Attribute Value

Defense 4 (sum 6, −2 from Sturdy Size) Learning 5 Impression 9 (sum 7, +2 from Charming) Standard of Living 6 (From Feature: Standard of Living) Life Will 10 Reputation Noted (6) (From Feature: Reputation) Damage Increase 3 Size Sturdy (22) (21 from Feature: Size, +1 from Well-Trained) Combat Movement 4 Wound Threshold 12 Luck 0 Endurance 20 (sum 16, +1 from Good Shape, +1 from Amateur Boxing, +2 from Tough) Appearance Attractive (±1) (From Feature: Appearance) Well-Being Relaxed (10) Fate 10 Overview 6 (sum 5, +1 from Combat Experienced)

Table 1:9

The attribute value for Defense is also noted at Ranged and Melee respectively—these are the values used during combat. The expertise in Amateur Boxing gives +1 to Defense in Melee so the numbers become: Defense Ranged: 4 and Defense Melee: 5.

Step 14: Deepening (p. 29) Parts of what is included in the Deepening step have already been addressed in other parts of the creation process but are also covered here so nothing is missed.

In this step, motivations are chosen among other things. Marco wants his protagonist to have an established motivation (p. 230) from the start. • Achieve goal: Become debt-free (Burning)

It fits well into the background and provides reasonable hooks for dramatic stories.

Regarding the protagonist's psychological profile, several of the questions are summarized in one long answer. The protagonist grew up in a middle-class home in the capital. His mother was a housewife and his father worked as a foreman at a factory in the city. The protagonist's only sibling, a younger sister, ran away nearly 15 years ago and has been missing since.

The upbringing was fairly secure and the protagonist did acceptably in school. After a few years of wavering in higher education he dropped out, to his father's dismay and his mother's horror, as he wanted to do his patriotic duty and enlist, eagerly encouraged by the Ministry of Truth's posters and information films at the cinemas. During basic training a major took him under his wing and gave him the chance to train directly as an officer, which he completed.

As a newly minted lieutenant he traveled to the northern front for a couple years of hell—comrades were killed or maimed, insane orders and equally insane attacks were carried out, and during the years he led thousands of young boys into the jaws of death, not many meters of land were conquered.

After a successful storming of an enemy bunker the protagonist was promoted to captain. But during the assault several of his closest friends died and psychosis became a reality. He increasingly sought solace and relief in liquor and whores, something that only added to the anguish. After a complete breakdown during an offensive in pouring rain and thick mud, the protagonist was furloughed home and ended up at a sanatorium in Sandukar. The protagonist doesn't know who arranged this, but suspects the old major from before.

It took him over a year to become human again. He rejected the idea of returning to the front and instead moved into the city's soul in search of housing and livelihood. He hustled jobs through postings at pubs and beer cafés, sold himself cheap to build up a reputation as a stable and reliable resource. Some jobs involved danger, others were simple, some led him into darkness, others to light and warmth.

Through the years his contact network was built up, more and more money and prestige came the protagonist's way, but also memories from before. Some jobs he never took, like going after women or children. Parts of the old destructive behaviors returned, like the hunt for female beauty and drowning the memories in liquor. Still,

Gabriel Dimitri Jandaran

Arrogant (Vain) Very Greedy (Hungers for money) Loving (Understanding, accommodating) Seasoned but doubting consultant/detective Become debt-free (Burning)

> **Character Sheet (stats)** — *Attribute and skill values extracted from the printed character sheet; see the original PDF for the complete stat block.*

Lockpicking: Door locks (+2 Dexterity) Instinct (+2 Intuition) Good Shape (Endurance +1) Rhetoric: Army (+2 Leadership) Amateur Boxing (Defense: Melee +1, Endurance +1) Weapon Handling: Pistol (+2 Firearms) Combat Experienced (Overview +1) Clear-Thinking: Tactics/strategy (+2 Reasoning) Well-Trained (Size +1) Observant: Notice deviations/details (+2 Awareness) Situational Awareness (+2 Worldly) Persuasive: Convince/beseech (+2 Persuade)

Notable weakness: Women (Beautiful women): Penalty (−2) (Sense) when activated Significant fear: Dense fog/smoke/gas: Penalty (−5) (Resistance) when activated Nightmares: Penalty (−5) (Sense) during Well-Being recovery

Indebted (Completely): 100% of Credit Rating utilized Basic code of honor (Not harm women or children): If broken, Shocking experience Sturdy (Size 21), height approx. 190 cm, weight approx. 90 kg Standard of Living 6: 25,000 cash, Credit 250,000 Attractive appearance: Penalty/bonus (1) in social situations

Hindrance (Sense): Double experience cost when increasing Charming: Impression +2 Tough: Endurance +2 Reputation: Noted (6): Underworld: Penalty/bonus (1) when used

In these abilities Gabriel is considered to have no competence (see page 213).

What limitations and features Gabriel has, and their effects, are described briefly.

Expertises that give bonuses to abilities are written with the bonus first. Where expertises give increased attribute values, the number is instead written after the attribute, for greater clarity.

After each ability, any learning marks are indicated (see page 221).

Gabriel's Hindrance is marked with a ring around the box for learning marks.

> **Character Sheet (form fields)** — *This section contains the fillable equipment, relationship and combat stats form. See the original PDF for the form layout.*

in the evenings, several times a week, he trains at the gym and boxes, partly to stay in shape, partly to process the assign-ments he's forced to carry out. He's left several broken hearts in his wake. A man in his line of work rarely gets truly close friends and he pre-fers to keep to himself when given the chance. During his time as a freelancer he's seen much that's abhorrent and participated in both this and that — but it's part of the job. Soon the big assignment will come, the one that brings the big money, the one that means he can retire, move to a different, better part of the city. Any day now... Step 15: Name (p. 29) Marco decides to give his protagonist the name Gabriel Dimitri Jandaran, where Dimitri is rarely used. Gabriel Jandaran holds the rank of captain in the army. He is 34 years old. Step 16: Cash & belongings (p. 29) Since Gabriel's standard of living is (6) he receives 25,000 zovrins in cash. These can be used for purchasing be-longings if desired. Marco has Gabriel buy two Calder pistols, two shoulder holsters, a snub-nosed revolver and an ankle holster, ten extra magazines and 200 rounds for the pistols, 100 rounds for the revolver, a pump-action shotgun with 24 shotgun shells placed in a duffel bag, licenses for the weapons, a lockpick set and spare picks sewn into his "official" tie, and finally a tape recorder, notepad, flashlight and a camera. This leaves him with just over 16,000 zovrins burning a hole in his wallet. **Complete** Now Gabriel Jandaran is ready to step into the exciting stories that Petter has planned for him and the other protagonists. **Gabriel's family** Note that in the background section it's stated that Gabriel has a father and a mother. But since they didn't crystallize during the selection of Limitations (Family), it means they're irrelevant for the stories Marco wants to experience with Gabriel. The point of relationships in general and blood and family relationships in particular is that they can be used as hooks for exciting stories. It's quite possible that Gabriel's parents later become relationships during a story through use of Fate (see Knows a contact on page 240). +1 (Battle-hardened)6 4 −2 (Lanky) 3 4 4 5 +1 (Amateur boxing) 5 0 10 12 24 48 20 10 +1 (Good shape)+1 (Amateur boxing)+2 (Tough) Domenik "Manik" Jaeger Smuggler **Dr Yannik Reasescu Private Doctor Talia Navarre Society Woman** Calder M2245 16 15 2D+1 10–50m +2 4E +4 1 8+1 Calder M2245 16 15 2D+1 10–50m +2 4E +4 1 8+1 R&S .38 Snub 12 13 2D−1 5–20m +1 3E +12 1 5r Rais H100 Pump. — 13 S5D−4(S2D−1) 10–30m +4 4E −7 1 5i 7 B1D+3 Weapons as above. 2x Shoulder Holsters (Draw +1, Conceal +1) 1x Ankle Holster (Draw −1, Conceal +5). 10x magazines for Calder, (2x in pistols, 4x spare on person, 4x in car). 120 loose .45 Auto rounds at office. 5 rounds .38 S in revolver, 95 rounds at office. Shotgun + 24 shotgun shells in a duffel bag in car trunk. Wallet with cash and genuine licenses for all weapons, authentic citizen passport, lockpick set in coat pocket plus a set sewn into a tie. Small briefcase with tape recorder, notepad + pens, flashlight and a camera. From standard of living: Personal car, 6x clothes, own apartment, furniture. Cash: 16,000z Credit: 250,000z, Debt: 250,000z, interest per month: 50,000z The value here comes from the current Skill, its expertises (in this case Weapon Handling: Pistols) and from the holster the weapon is usually carried in (see page 119). Note that the pump-action shotgun Rais H100 lacks Draw since Marco considers it highly unlikely it will ever be drawn in mechanical terms. If Gabriel uses the weapon, he has it in hand, and not concealed on his person. **The value here comes from the current** Skill and any expertises (in this case Weapon Handling: Pistols). Here the Damage Increase is already added for faster handling. The value here comes from the weapon and its holster, if there is one, or alternatively how the weapon is carried. Malfunction indicates which numbers the dice must show in an exceptional failure for the weapon to malfunction. All of Gabriel's weapons are of normal quality/condition which means the normal outcome is required — doubles.

Archetypes & background packages An archetype is a general description of a person and their personality, typical knowledge and background. Choose an archetype that seems interesting, exciting, challenging or perhaps easy to portray. **Archetype description** Each archetype is described with ideas, possibilities and selections for use and portrayal. The sections for nature and occupation provide more substance and the player can advantageously choose a concept (see page 27) from these. A suggestion for how the attribute values for the arche-type might look is presented here below. Note that the player is free to swap between different attribute values, and that the given values are only recom-mendations that suit the chosen archetype. If the attribute values are changed, this also affects the ability values. The archetype description also gives suggestions for which abilities are suitable for the archetype. The player is of course free to follow or ignore these recommen-dations, but the narrator should ensure no strange results occur, such as if a devoted commando soldier couldn't handle weapons. If the player chooses a different set of abilities, or wishes to change the presented ability values in the archetype description, just follow the rules on page 28 for how ability values are acquired. Under "Expertises" are shown suggestions for expertise areas that suit the archetype — but the player is of course free to change these. The expertise areas are based on the ability values given in the archetype de-scription. Note that if the player swaps out or changes ability values, perhaps certain expertises can no longer be chosen. See page 58 for more information about expertises. **List of archetypes Archetype Page Archetype Page Archetype Page** Lawyer 41 Businessman 41 Academic 42 Laborer 42 Performer 43 Athlete 43 Con Artist 44 Criminal 44 Bureaucrat 45 Loner 45 Femme fatale 46 Fixer 46 Freelancer 47 Street Urchin 47 Tactical Police 48 Artist 48 Cop 49 Prostitute 49 Priest 50 Reporter 50 Brawler 51 Soldier 51 Technician 52 Enforcer 52 Investigator 53 Caregiver 53

Lawyer

"You misunderstand. I don't need to know whether you are a murderer or not, Mr. Timaran. All I need to know is what happened, who knows something about it, and that you can pay my fee." A lawyer is a specialized type of bureaucrat whose task is to interpret the State's complicated legal system and use it to defend or prosecute individuals. Depending on the lawyer's connections, knowledge and influence, their price varies greatly. The very cheapest lawyers, who are appointed to those who have no money to pay with, are seldom capable. But not even the most skilled lawyer can influence a legal case where the State or one of the families accuses a person, as they can modify the law to suit themselves, and the State's special police, the commissars, have the right to pass sentence on the spot without any legal review whatsoever. Despite this, lawyers constitute an important professional group within which the skilled can twist the law to their advantage in most legal cases. A lawyer has good insight into the state bureaucracy and its legal code—something that gives the lawyer great advantages in most bureaucratically difficult situations and makes them respected and feared. It is not uncommon for lawyers to take bribes to forget parts of the evidence or plant false evidence. Despite their advantageous position, the lawyer runs great risk of ending up in dangerous situations if they become involved in criminal cases where the accused are powerful and dangerous individuals who don't shy away from threats and violence. Likely nature:

- Corrupt
- honorable
- cunning
- driven
- knowledgeable
- incompetent
- bold
- arrogant

- insane
- cowardly
- dull
- colorful
- cynical
- bitter
- committed. Likely occupation:
- Prosecutor
- defense attorney
- judge
- civil lawyer
- state lawyer
- military lawyer
- advisor or schnapps lawyer.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (3); Close Combat (0), Reactions (3), Mobility (3) Constitution (3); Endurance (2), Strength (1), Tolerance (3) Motor Skills (2); Dexterity (4), Throwing Weapons (0), Firearms (0) Education (4); Humanities (7), Medicine (0), Natural Sciences (1) Creativity (3); Construction (1), Creation (1), Deduction (4) Will (6); Determination (8), Resistance (0), Sense (4) Insight (4); Empathy (1), Oppose (5), Worldliness (2) Perception (4); Intuition (4), Vehicles (1), Awareness (3) Charisma (5); Charm (0), Leadership (4), Persuade (6) **Expertises** Stubborn (Determination) Quick Learner (Determination) Tricks: Distraction (Dexterity) Academic Focus: Law/Political Science (Humanities) Academic Specialist: Law/Political Science (Humanities) Fingertip Sensitivity (Intuition) Rhetoric: The Legal System (Leadership) Perceptive: Interrogation Techniques (Oppose) Aura of Calm (Sense) Clear-Minded: Investigate/See Connections (Deduction) Convincing: Interrogate/Interview (Persuade) **Businessman** "A first edition of Hellenov's 'Children of the Macabre Dance'? Indeed, if you wait a moment, sir, I shall retrieve it from the safe. I'll just close up the shop first and fetch my son, so he can keep watch. It is a valuable item, as you surely already know." A sharp mind, cold nerves and a strong will are required to survive as a businessman in Sandukar's world. Businessmen and -women constantly work to manage their operations, negotiate with suppliers and improve their selection and try to reach and retain customers. It's also necessary to know who must be bribed, who must not be offended and who to hire to handle problems. If one is skilled, one can go far, but the more power and money one gets, the more hungry, envious eyes begin to watch. Some are content to keep their business at one and the same level while others strive to rise in society, with bold ventures and forceful expansion. The higher up one comes, the more versed one must be in the bureaucratic system that governs society, for the latter can at any time turn against you and crush you if you don't follow the paragraphs and ordinances that have been declared. Likely nature:

- Driven
- greedy
- efficient
- accommodating
- visionary
- ruthless
- exploiter
- superficial
- talkative
- grandiose
- cunning

- shrewd
- competent
- corrupt
- fair
- considerate
- vain. Likely occupation:
- Shop owner (tool shop
- bookstore
- antique dealer
- specialty shop
- retailer
- butcher
- pawnbroker
- tailor
- newsstand
- etc.)
- entrepreneur
- manufacturer
- factory owner
- merchant
- restaurateur
- broker
- magnate
- tycoon
- banker
- consultant
- salesperson
- director
- financier
- socialite
- importer
- exporter
- transporter
- black market shark
- fence or gangster.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (2); Close Combat (0), Reactions (2), Mobility (2) Constitution (3); Endurance (2), Strength (2), Tolerance (2) Motor Skills (3); Dexterity (3), Throwing Weapons (2), Firearms (1) Education (4); Humanities (7), Medicine (0), Natural Sciences (1) Creativity (6); Construction (4), Creation (4), Deduction (4) Will (4); Determination (4), Resistance (0), Sense (4) Insight (4); Empathy (1), Oppose (5), Worldliness (2) Perception (3); Intuition (1), Vehicles (1), Awareness (4) Charisma (5); Charm (1), Leadership (2), Persuade (7) **Expertises** Focus (Determination) Academic Focus: Economics/Accounting (Humanities) Academic Focus: Administration/Organization (Humanities) Technical Focus: (something suitable for the profession) (Construction) Perceptive: Persuasion (Oppose) Aura of Calm (Sense) Creator: (something suitable for the profession) (Creation) Clear-Minded: Remember Things/Places/Phenomena (Deduction) Observant: Never Forgets a Face (Awareness) Convincing: Negotiate/Bargain (Persuade) Convincing: Persuade/Plead (Persuade)

Academic

"Doctor Villsayan, sir! Doctor! Come quickly, I have found the key! It was hidden between the sheets in the second bundle. It was chance that I discovered that the roughness of the paper was opposite when I ran my hand over it, and against the light. There I saw that the instructions were hidden! Do you understand? We have found the key!" Among dusty tomes, old writings and contemporary discoveries, the academic tries to expand their knowledge. Those who don't accept the State's description of the world or history but try to create their own picture of reality walk very dangerous paths. To defy the State's censorship and search for a different truth than the one given means risking arrest and execution for espionage and terrorism. Research often requires experimentation, which makes the need for laboratories present. Sometimes horrible experiments are carried out to achieve new knowledge, often with suffering and injury as a result. Horrific experiments occur in soundproofed rooms with steel gurneys and in attic rooms expeditions to forbidden ruined cities and lonely valleys are planned. In many academics the thirst for knowledge burns so strongly that they are prepared to sacrifice everything and defy all rules to find what they consider to be the truth. Many academics choose, however, to follow the State's worldview and often support themselves as teachers, librarians, researchers or similar. Likely nature:

- Shy
- manic
- intrusive
- ruthless
- insane
- curious
- boring
- interested
- dry
- knowledge-thirsty
- cowardly
- arrogant. Likely occupation:
- Student
- librarian
- teacher
- instructor
- researcher
- scientist
- doctoral candidate
- museum curator
- psychologist
- profiler
- civil servant or bureaucrat.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (3); Close Combat (0), Reactions (3), Mobility (3) Constitution (2); Endurance (1), Strength (0), Tolerance (3) Motor Skills (3); Dexterity (6), Throwing Weapons (0), Firearms (0) Education (6); Humanities (10), Medicine (0), Natural Sciences (2) Creativity (5); Construction (2), Creation (1), Deduction (7) Will (4); Determination (5), Resistance (0), Sense (3) Insight (3); Empathy (4), Oppose (1), Worldliness (1) Perception (4); Intuition (3), Vehicles (0), Awareness (5) Charisma (4); Charm (1), Leadership (4), Persuade (3) **Expertises** Quick Learner (Determination) Understanding (Empathy) Tricks: Steady Hand (Dexterity) Academic

Focus: (something suitable for the profession) (Humanities) Academic Specialist: (same as Academic Focus) (Humanities) Rhetoric: The Academic World (Leadership) Clear-Minded: Investigate/See Connections (Deduction) Clear-Minded: Remember Things/Places/Phenomena (Deduction) Observant: Notice Deviations/Details (Awareness) **Worker** "Wanna come grab a beer after the shift? The others were thinking of heading to Vaskarov's to listen to the match. The waitresses there aren't so uptight and the beer prices are affordable, damn, it's gonna get wild there. Tonight 'The Anvil' will show who's boss in the ring!" Sandukar rests on the backs of workers. In long lines they toil in dangerous workplaces to produce what is needed for the city and empire to continue being driven forward. They are parts in a machinery of flesh, gristle and bone. Union control, workplace safety and rules about working conditions and hours barely exist in Sandukar. Wages are low and many have difficulty managing. However, there are those who have the luck to be employed by people who care about their staff and these can sometimes find contentment in their work and companionship with their coworkers. For it is the community that binds the workers together. The hard toil they share with their brothers and sisters. The shit-talking about the bosses and the low wages. The talk about dreams that will never be able to be fulfilled. For freedom is found only in one's fantasies, in simple pleasures and in family life. When the whistle sounds, the workers either head home to their families or stop by a smoky tavern to have a beer or two after the day's grind. Those who are born in worker families most often end up following in their parents' footsteps and sometimes entire families work at the same factory and drive the eternal machinery onward. Likely nature:

- Bored
- resigned
- engaged
- lazy
- professional
- talkative
- stupid
- helpful
- crude
- villainous
- corrupt. Likely occupation:
- Builder
- industrial worker
- transporter
- plumber
- electrician
- welder
- mechanic
- craftsman
- laborer
- airship pilot
- taxi driver or guard.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (4); Close Combat (4), Reactions (2), Mobility (2) Constitution (6); Endurance (3), Strength (5), Tolerance (4) Motor Skills (3); Dexterity (3), Throwing Weapons (2), Firearms (1) Education (2); Humanities (2), Medicine (0), Natural Sciences (2) Creativity (5); Construction (7), Creation (0), Deduction (3) Will (3); Determination (0), Resistance (5), Sense (1) Insight (4); Empathy (2), Oppose (2), Worldliness (4) Perception (4); Intuition (2), Vehicles (4), Awareness (2) Charisma (3); Charm (3), Leadership (0), Persuade (3)

Expertises Driver: Car (Vehicles) Technical Focus: (something suitable for the profession) (Construction) Technical Specialist: (same as Technical Focus) (Construction) Brawling (Close Combat) Jaded: Endure Degradation/Abuse (Resistance) Lift/Drag (Strength) Hardy: Heat/Cold (Tolerance) Local Knowledge: (the neighborhood) (Worldliness)

Artist

"She's pretty beautiful, isn't she? And what a voice she has! And her body... The dress she's wearing, it's anything but discreet! Oh yes, many men and women surely lust after her and the facade she's created around herself. But deep down she's surely just as rotten as the rest of us." By offering themselves, stepping into a role and exploiting their talents, the entertainer makes a living by evoking emotions in their audience. It could be anything from strong emotions like tragedy and fate-laden sorrow in theatrical epics to swinging song numbers at smoky nightclubs—a skilled enter-tainer should be able to produce both laughter and tears. With their presence on the silver screen, the stage or at the street corner, the entertainer tries to make the viewer forget, for a moment, the grey everyday reality, dream away and allow themselves to be seduced by his/her presence. The big, popular names attract a loyal audience, big money and many privileges. However, the profession is difficult. Only the truly talented, those with good connections or those willing to do anything to achieve success have the opportunity to go far; others must struggle along with jobs on the side, and for them the competition is fierce. Many turn to drugs to cope with the pressure and some become completely con-sumed by their roles and burn out at a young age. Likely nature:

- Passionate
- serious
- depressed
- manic
- insane
- easygoing
- superficial
- vain
- exhibitionistic
- profound
- flamboyant
- withdrawn
- open-hearted
- stupid
- brilliant
- manipu-lative
- intense
- gloomy
- irresponsible
- arrogant
- burned out. Likely occupation:
- Theater actor
- film actor
- musician
- singer
- comedian

- club entertainer
- varie-ty artist
- magician
- dancer
- poet
- model or mannequin.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (4); Close Combat (1), Reactions (2), Mobility (5) Build (4); Stamina (4), Strength (1), Tolerance (3) Motor Skills (3); Dexterity (4), Thrown Weapons (2), Firearms (0) Education (3); Humanities (3), Medicine (0), Natural Science (3) Creativity (5); Construction (1), Create (7), Deduction (2) Willpower (3); Determination (4), Resistance (0), Sense (2) Insight (4); Empathy (2), Withstand (2), Worldliness (4) Perception (2); Intuition (2), Vehicles (1), Awareness (1) Charisma (6); Charm (8), Leadership (1), Persuade (3)

Expertises: Focus (Determination) Charismatic: (something appropriate for the profession) (Charm) Very charismatic: (same as for Charismatic) (Charm) Tricks: Card tricks/coin tricks (Dexterity) Good shape (Stamina) Agile: Modeling/posing (Mobility) Creator: (something appropriate for the profession) (Create) Outstanding creator: (same as for Creator) (Create) Well-dressed (Worldliness) **Athlete** "296... 297... Come on now! 298. Two more. Then the punching bag, followed by the speed bag. 299. Don't be such a weakling! You've got another sit-up in you. Yes, come on. That's it. That's it! Yes, 300! Well done, kid. One day it's you Mr. Rasparan will be interviewing on radio, before loads of listeners. One day, kid..." The athlete chooses to specialize in one or several disci-plines, everything from fencing to track racing. Popular activities are track racing, boxing, running competitions, tennis, golf, rugby, basketball and rowing. High society favors polo or horse racing. The main thing is that the practitioner has devoted a large part of their time and dedication to a particular area to become as skilled as possible at it. Skilled athletes can achieve star sta-tus but most must struggle along and often have jobs on the side. When success comes, shady promoters, managers and agents emerge from the shadows wanting to sign contracts, where they promise money, power, luxury life, wine, women and song—the only thing the athlete must do is win the next competition, and the next, and the next... There's always someone younger, more skilled, faster, more enduring or more daring waiting for the athlete to mess up, so they can take over. Some choose to improve their results through drugs, bribes or cheating, but if discovered it can cost them dearly. Likely nature:

- Goal-oriented
- driven
- focused
- lazy
- aggressive
- corrupt
- dumb
- vain
- angry
- friendly
- generous
- greedy
- mean
- has-been
- newcomer
- washed up

- star
- prodigy
- shy
- burned out. Likely occupation:
- Various disciplines (racing
- running
- swimming
- boxing
- fencing
- gymnastics
- football
- basketball
- rugby
- etcetera).

Attributes & Skills Coordination (5); Close Combat (1), Reactions (2), Mobility (7) Build (6); Stamina (7), Strength (5), Tolerance (0) Motor Skills (3); Dexterity (3), Thrown Weapons (3), Firearms (0) Education (3); Humanities (3), Medicine (1), Natural Science (2) Creativity (2); Construction (1), Create (1), Deduction (2) Willpower (4); Determination (4), Resistance (3), Sense (1) Insight (3); Empathy (2), Withstand (2), Worldliness (2) Perception (4); Intuition (3), Vehicles (3), Awareness (2) Charisma (4); Charm (3), Leadership (3), Persuade (2) **Expertises** Focus (Determination) Good shape (Stamina)* Very good shape (Stamina)* Agile: (something appropriate for the occupation) (Mobility)* Nimble: (same as for Agile) (Mobility)* Well-trained (Strength)*

- At least one of the above expertises should be replaced with an appropriate sports expertise, see page 79.

Con Artist

"Of course I can help you Miss Adescu—I know the finest doctors when it comes to performing abortions painlessly and in secret. However, I must demand a favor in return but it's nothing big or dangerous we're talking about. Here, there now, take my handkerchief, dry your tears and then tell me where your father keeps his notebook." Through cunning, manipulation and blackmail the con artist gets what he/she desires. That lives are ruined and families torn apart along the way is met with little sympathy—it's the punishment the victims get for allowing themselves to be deceived. Finding gullible victims' weaknesses and passions and then exploiting them to the fullest is the natural approach for a con artist. As well as finding the right individual for the con. It's precisely the ability to read individuals and the cold-bloodedness to treat them as objects that makes a con artist success-ful. Many become lost in the game with human emotions and find the hunt for control and humiliation as strong as the lust for wealth. There are con artists who have entire net-works of people under them, people they have leverage on, or who are completely captivated by them. Likely nature:

- Ice-cold
- smart
- calculating
- charismatic
- sadistic
- charming
- accommodating

- understanding
- appreciative
- flattering
- curious
- bold
- daring
- manipulative
- quick-witted. Likely occupation:
- Charlatan
- snake-oil salesman
- swindler
- hustler
- fortune hunter
- opportunist
- womanizer
- seductress
- cult leader
- quack or blackmailer.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (3); Close Combat (1), Reactions (2), Mobility (3) Build (3); Stamina (3), Strength (1), Tolerance (2) Motor Skills (2); Dexterity (3), Thrown Weapons (0), Firearms (1) Education (3); Humanities (5), Medicine (0), Natural Science (1) Creativity (4); Construction (1), Create (2), Deduction (5) Willpower (4); Determination (4), Resistance (0), Sense (4) Insight (5); Empathy (0), Withstand (4), Worldliness (6) Perception (4); Intuition (4), Vehicles (0), Awareness (4) Charisma (6); Charm (7), Leadership (1), Persuade (4) **Expertises** Focus (Determination) Academic focus: (something appropriate for the occupation) (Humanities) Charismatic: Deceive/manipulate (Charm) Charismatic: Flatter/fawn (Charm) Instinct (Intuition) Perceptive: Persuasion (Withstand) Self-discipline (Sense) Clear-headed: Remember things/places/phenomena (Deduction) Observant: Notice person in crowd (Aware-ness) Know the score (Worldliness) Convincing: Persuade/implore (Persuade) **Criminal** "Since those bastards from the Hexagon came to the nest, nothing's the same anymore. They check up on everything and those who try to fool them turn up in the canal with a bullet lodged in their skull. Thanks, I remember the good old days when gangs were run by strong leaders who settled things with fists, knives or pistols—not like now when everything's run by corruption and double-crossing. Soon you can't bloody trust anyone anymore." In a harsh existence controlled by the State and by a brutal and corrupt police force, crime often seems to many to be the only way up out of misery. People toil day and night at factories and still can't support their families. Selfish-ness takes over then and you let other people suffer so your own needs can be fulfilled. Maybe you engage in something as simple as pickpocketing, burglary and robbery or you deal with a type of criminal activity that has branches in many parts of the city. Criminals form groups that can gain great influence. Some such groups grow into power factors and sometimes have great control in parts of the city. The sense of community born from sharing a common livelihood can become very strong. However, you must be careful not to anger the wrong people, regardless of which side of the law. But with bribes, threats and deals you can go far as long as you respect those above you. Likely nature:

- Hardened
- desperate
- aggressive
- psycho-tic

- nervous
- calculating
- manipulative
- power-hungry
- greedy
- sadistic
- cocky
- selfish
- paranoid
- suspicious
- bold
- kind-hearted
- soft
- cowardly. Likely occupation:
- Burglar
- thief
- robber
- dealer
- smuggler
- snitch
- gangster
- gang member
- petty crimi-nal
- murderer
- fugitive
- collector
- enforcer
- infiltrator
- loan shark
- leg-breaker
- boss
- underboss
- black market shark
- fence or henchman.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (5); Close Combat (4), Reactions (4), Mobility (2) Build (4); Stamina (2), Strength (4), Tolerance (2) Motor Skills (4); Dexterity (3), Thrown Weapons (1), Firearms (4) Education (2); Humanities (2), Medicine (0), Natural Science (2) Creativity (3); Construction (3), Create (1), Deduction (2) Willpower (3); Determination (1), Resistance (4), Sense (1) Insight (4); Empathy (0), Withstand (2), Worldliness (6) Perception (6); Intuition (2), Vehicles (4), Awareness (6) Charisma (3); Charm (1), Leadership (1), Persuade (4) **Expertises** Driver: Car (Vehicles) Combat ready (Close Combat) Quick on your feet (Reactions) Fearless (Resistance) Weapon handling: Revolver (Firearms) Well-trained (Strength) Observant: Notice concealed weapons on person/frisk (Aware-ness) Local knowledge (Worldliness) Convincing: Threaten/intimidate/harass (Persuade)

Bureaucrat

"So you wish to use our archives for the purpose of, what did you call it… Ahh yes, that's right, research for personal satisfaction. You must be aware, madam, that this is a violation of nearly every legal statute I as a state official follow. But… for a tidy sum of 25,000 zovrins I can arrange a temporary permit for you and your associates."

Sandukar's vast machinery requires its cogs and wheels. These hard-working individuals are the bureaucrats. They struggle with administration and upholding the laws and ordinances upon which the State rests. In massive buildings with lonely corridors and endless rows of filing cabinets, the bureaucrat toils to preserve an idea of a society he/she cannot understand or overview. The hierarchy is draconian and only through working obediently and faithfully for one's superiors can one hope to advance in importance and recognition.

There are, however, some who try to take shortcuts by keeping on good terms with people within the clans or smearing their colleagues—but these play a dangerous game. Actions that can lead them to influential positions in society can just as easily plunge them into ruin if their schemes are revealed. Thus most bureaucrats choose to go the legal and bureaucratic route but bend the rules just enough to make it as advantageous as possible for them.

Likely nature:

- Meticulous
- formal
- helpful
- smug
- pragmatic
- strict
- obedient
- dry
- orderly
- cowed
- bored
- vindictive
- scheming
- suspicious.

Likely occupation:

- Bureaucrat
- archivist
- clerk
- courier
- inspector
- controller
- auditor
- examiner
- coordinator or planner.

Attributes & Abilities

- Coordination (3); Close Combat (0), Reactions (3), Mobility (3)

- Build (3); Stamina (2), Strength (1), Tolerance (3)
- Motor Skills (2); Manual Dexterity (3), Throwing (1), Firearms (0)
- Education (5); Humanities (5), Medicine (1), Natural Science (4)
- Creativity (4); Construction (0), Create (0), Deduction (8)
- Will (6); Determination (7), Resistance (2), Sense (3)
- Insight (3); Empathy (1), Oppose (4), Worldliness (1)
- Perception (4); Intuition (1), Vehicles (1), Awareness (6)
- Charisma (4); Charm (2), Leadership (2), Persuasion (4)

Expertises

Studious (Determination) Stubborn (Determination) Academic focus: Administration/organization (Humanities) Discerning: Persuasion (Oppose) Natural science focus: (appropriate subject, e.g. mathematics) (Natural Science) Clear-minded: Investigate/see connections (Deduction) Smart: Investigate/see connections (Deduction) Observant: Notice deviations/details (Awareness) Convincing: Negotiate/haggle (Persuasion)

Lone Wolf

"I've never felt comfortable among people, they're like vermin, stinking and infinite in number. Believe me, people are better off when I'm not in their vicinity. Ask those who now lie in the sewers overrun by rats—though on the other hand, one could say I merely returned them to their equals."

Among Sandukar's millions of people it's easy to be overlooked and abandoned. Many live in total isolation, don't know their neighbors or the people they work with, and no longer have contact with their families. Some seek this isolation and choose solitude over company. Perhaps they choose it because they enjoy their own thoughts and their own company. Perhaps they're afraid of hurting someone, or of the outside world gaining insight into their secrets.

Lone wolves usually support themselves through odd jobs, criminal activities, or by begging for money on the street. There are also those who have become scrap collectors—they take things people have thrown away, repair them, and sell them onward. Life on the street is very hard, nights are spent in abandoned houses, shabby apartments, or in seedy hotel rooms. As a lone wolf one is neither wanted nor missed, and the life one leads provides no good prospects for reaching old age.

It's not uncommon for the lone wolf to be a wanderer who moves through the city and stays only a short time in any one place.

Likely nature:

- Bitter
- cynical
- hopeful
- dejected
- sarcastic
- taciturn
- evasive
- restless
- insane
- aggressive

- self-destructive
- manic
- distrustful
- desperate.

Likely occupation:

- Vagabond
- outcast
- fugitive
- criminal
- unemployed
- hunter
- survival expert
- odd-jobber
- murderer
- mentally ill
- avenger or crime fighter.

Attributes & Abilities

- Coordination (4); Close Combat (4), Reactions (1), Mobility (3)
- Build (4); Stamina (2), Strength (1), Tolerance (5)
- Motor Skills (3); Manual Dexterity (4), Throwing (2), Firearms (0)
- Education (3); Humanities (3), Medicine (1), Natural Science (2)
- Creativity (5); Construction (4), Create (3), Deduction (3)
- Will (6); Determination (5), Resistance (7), Sense (0)
- Insight (4); Empathy (1), Oppose (4), Worldliness (3)
- Perception (3); Intuition (2), Vehicles (1), Awareness (3)
- Charisma (2); Charm (1), Leadership (0), Persuasion (3)

Expertises

Focus (Determination) Lockpicking: Door locks (Manual Dexterity) Technical focus: Mechanical objects (Construction) Discerning: Persuasion (Oppose) Self-defense (Close Combat) Hardened: Withstand terror/horror (Resistance) Hardened: Endure degradation/abuse (Resistance) Tolerant: Alcohol (Tolerance)

Femme Fatale

"Ah, my beloved, you came after all. Yes, I've packed and a car is already waiting down on the street. That we'll finally get to flee and start our own lives—together. You got hold of the family jewels, didn't you? Because without money we won't survive. Ah, you have them in the suitcase, excellent! Why I have a pistol in my hand? See it as a symbol that you are too gullible. There now, don't spill any tears, I'm not spilling any for you."

She knows what she wants and stops at nothing to get it. Manipulating, nagging, and begging are not beneath her. A femme fatale is a woman who has a goal and intends to achieve it at any cost. She does this through lies, threats, enticements, and sex—because these are paths that reach into the frozen heart of the men, or women, she manipulates into doing what she wants. It might involve getting rid of a competitor, murdering a spouse for inheritance and wealth, escaping a pursuer, or pulling off the perfect heist.

Some femmes fatales use manipulation to survive, others deceive and betray merely for their own pleasure. On the street and in criminal organizations women have learned the art of seduction to be able to work their way up, but must always be vigilant and cautious as it's a dangerous game they play. Among the clans, seduction is an art form and there it's more about cruel games. A woman who has learned to twist her victims around her fingers has a powerful tool at her disposal, and many times her manipulative charm can be just as deadly as a lead bullet as it often strikes the heart.

Likely nature:

- Ice-cold
- smart
- ensnaring
- calculating
- sadistic
- masochistic
- charming
- understanding
- appreciative
- flattering
- curious
- bold
- vulnerable
- manipulative
- quick-witted
- passionate
- sexy
- irresponsible.

Likely occupation:

- Housewife
- seductress
- thief
- fugitive
- model
- upper-class dame
- heist planner
- avenger
- crime victim
- madame or mistress.

Attributes & Abilities

- Coordination (3); Close Combat (1), Reactions (2), Mobility (3)
- Build (3); Stamina (3), Strength (1), Tolerance (2)
- Motor Skills (2); Manual Dexterity (3), Throwing (0), Firearms (1)
- Education (3); Humanities (4), Medicine (1), Natural Science (1)
- Creativity (4); Construction (1), Create (2), Deduction (5)

- Will (4); Determination (4), Resistance (0), Sense (4)
- Insight (5); Empathy (1), Oppose (4), Worldliness (5)
- Perception (4); Intuition (5), Vehicles (0), Awareness (3)
- Charisma (6); Charm (7), Leadership (0), Persuasion (5)

Expertises

Focus (Determination) Charismatic: Seduce/captivate (Charm) Charismatic: Dupe/manipulate (Charm) Academic focus: (appropriate subject) (Humanities) Fingertip sensitivity (Intuition) Discerning: Seduction (Oppose) Clear-minded: Remember things/places/phenomena (Deduction) Courteous (Worldliness) Convincing: Persuade/implore (Persuasion)

Fixer

"So what does my lord desire? Here with us no lusts are forbidden and no wishes too strange. Yes, I understand if your wish is something beyond the normal, otherwise you wouldn't be here, would you? So tell me, do you want a woman, a man, a child? Or is it perhaps drugs or weapons you crave? With us you can get everything—the question is only how much you're willing to pay."

Through contacts and colleagues the fixer can procure most things. He/she knows people in most agencies in society and knows where to go and whom to pump for information, equipment, or to have a particular type of service performed. An untraceable revolver, a police report obtained through back channels, information about who the film star slept with the night before, or smuggling someone out of the city are things the fixer can handle.

Many specialize in a specific area such as weapons, drugs, slaves, transport, information, or specific services. The fixer must be cautious, however, not to cross the wrong people, and bribing law enforcement is required for the fixer's operation to be left in peace.

Many fixers begin with time to see the entire social world as a collection of services and favors. If an acquaintance becomes too demanding these disillusioned individuals don't hesitate to terminate it or to sell their former friends to someone who offers some form of payment.

Likely nature:

- Suspicious
- superficial
- talkative
- pushy
- curious
- secretive
- personal
- ice-cold
- boastful
- slimy
- ingratiating
- surly
- manic
- nervous

- greedy
- spacey.

Likely occupation:

- Fence
- small business owner
- consultant
- forger
- odd-jobber
- dealer
- pawnbroker
- smuggler
- bartender
- bookmaker
- snitch
- informant
- procurer or slaver.

Attributes & Abilities

- Coordination (3); Close Combat (1), Reactions (3), Mobility (2)
- Build (4); Stamina (3), Strength (3), Tolerance (2)
- Motor Skills (2); Manual Dexterity (1), Throwing (0), Firearms (3)
- Education (3); Humanities (3), Medicine (1), Natural Science (2)
- Creativity (3); Construction (1), Create (0), Deduction (5)
- Will (4); Determination (5), Resistance (2), Sense (1)
- Insight (6); Empathy (1), Oppose (2), Worldliness (9)
- Perception (4); Intuition (4), Vehicles (0), Awareness (4)
- Charisma (5); Charm (4), Leadership (0), Persuasion (6)

Expertises

Focus (Determination) Charismatic: Flatter/fawn (Charm) Eyes in the back of one's head (Intuition) Clear-minded: Remember things/places/phenomena (Deduction) Observant: Never forgets a face (Awareness) Knows the score (Worldliness) Fixer (Worldliness) Convincing: Negotiate/haggle (Persuasion)

Freelancer

"Okay, let me repeat the whole thing to make sure I understand you correctly. You want me to get to manufacturer Janis, execute him and his family in a way that makes your enemies not dare stand up against you again? Don't think it'll be a problem, but I'll demand half the payment upfront. When it comes to macabre assignments like this, I want to make sure I don't get cheated. After payment is complete, we'll never see each other again."

The freelancer is a person who goes their own way or lets themselves be hired for services or substantial sums of money. However, they want to be their own and avoid becoming too closely tied to a particular organization. Many times the freelancer is hired to carry out distasteful, illegal and brutal assignments only to disappear afterward. One can find freelancers in many parts of society. It could be anything from private

detectives who don't hesitate to take morally questionable assignments to professional killers in the underworld who have made killing their art. Violence and death seem to seek out freelancers and many become notorious and feared. But life is hard and as if it weren't enough that the degenerate experiences risk tearing their minds apart, freelancers can at any moment be subjected to assassination attempts from former antagonists or employers.

Likely nature:

- Honorable
- moody
- cold
- selfish
- efficient
- compassionate
- diligent
- detached
- secretive
- curious
- superficial
- bold
- brave
- idealistic
- dishonest
- liar
- braggart
- meticulous
- principled
- cocky
- suspicious
- cynical.

Likely occupation:

- Debt collector
- bounty hunter
- bodyguard
- professional killer
- odd-jobber
- enforcer
- guard
- private detective
- protector
- courier
- adventurer
- daredevil
- bouncer or problem-solver.

Attributes & Abilities

- Coordination (6); Close Combat (5), Reactions (4), Mobility (3)
- Physique (4); Stamina (3), Strength (4), Tolerance (1)
- Motor Skills (5); Dexterity (1), Throwing Weapons (2), Firearms (7)
- Education (3); Humanities (2), Medicine (1), Natural Science (3)
- Creativity (3); Construction (1), Create (1), Deduction (4)
- Willpower (4); Determination (3), Resistance (4), Sense (1)
- Insight (3); Empathy (0), Withstand (2), Worldly (4)
- Perception (4); Intuition (2), Vehicles (1), Awareness (5)
- Charisma (2); Charm (0), Leadership (0), Persuade (4)

Expertises

Martial Arts Trained (Close Combat) Quick Reactions (Reactions) Fearless (Resistance) Weapon Handling: Autopistols (Firearms) Weapon Expert: Calder M2245 (Firearms) Clear-minded: Remember things/places/phenomena (Deduction) Well-trained (Strength) Observant: Shadow/follow (Awareness) Versed: Criminals (Worldly) Persuasive: Interrogate/interview (Persuade)

Street Vagrant

"Nadja doesn't live anymore, she went into the fallen tower to search for valuables and something attacked her. I heard her screams and rushed there but found only parts of her. So now one is alone again. Fortunately the bottle doesn't abandon one — it makes one endure another day in this hell!"

The street vagrant lives outside the system. They support themselves by begging, stealing and/or scavenging for food. Some perform simple services to scrape together enough money to get by. Most people don't even notice the pale and hollow-eyed figures sleeping in stairwells and alleys and wandering around like sleepwalkers. As a street vagrant you have no rights, no one will defend you or search for your killer if something goes wrong. However, the homeless see things more clearly than many others and among them are many hidden knowledges about Sandukar's forbidden areas, underground passages and modern myths.

The street vagrants live in many ways in their own world, in the shadow of humanity and the eternal city. There they wait, watch and fight for their survival. Among them one can find fallen prophets, mad leaders, visionaries and lunatics. They fight among themselves over food scraps from dumpsters and hide from the police's searchlights to avoid beatings or execution. Hunger, alienation and cheap liquor cause their psyche to break down and they have difficulty distinguishing dream from reality. Many die after only a few years on the street, frozen to death during winter nights or beaten to death in the search for something to eat.

Likely nature:

- Manic
- depressed
- insane
- taciturn
- submissive
- aggressive
- intrusive
- evasive
- unpleasant
- sarcastic

- ruthless
- curious
- hopeful
- bitter
- cynical.

Likely occupation:

- Homeless
- vagrant
- bum
- addict
- unemployed
- petty criminal
- snitch
- fence
- beggar
- drifter
- street musician
- odd-jobber
- street child
- mentally ill
- runaway or refugee.

Attributes & Abilities

- Coordination (5); Close Combat (4), Reactions (2), Mobility (4)
- Physique (4); Stamina (1), Strength (2), Tolerance (5)
- Motor Skills (3); Dexterity (6), Throwing Weapons (0), Firearms (0)
- Education (3); Humanities (3), Medicine (1), Natural Science (2)
- Creativity (4); Construction (3), Create (3), Deduction (2)
- Willpower (2); Determination (1), Resistance (3), Sense (0)
- Insight (4); Empathy (0), Withstand (3), Worldly (5)
- Perception (6); Intuition (5), Vehicles (0), Awareness (7)
- Charisma (3); Charm (0), Leadership (0), Persuade (6)

Expertises

Pickpocket: Steal from purses/pockets (Dexterity) Instinct (Intuition) Brawling (Close Combat) Agile: Sneak (Mobility) Resilient: Heat/cold (Tolerance) Observant: Orient in darkness (Awareness) Observant: Hide (Awareness) Versed: The street (Worldly) Persuasive: Persuade/implore (Persuade)

Tactical Officer

"Now it's time to clean up here, let no one escape, show no mercy. Those who live here in the house are all society's scum, men, women, children and elderly. Like a cancer tumor they have grown and now threaten the realm's survival. We are the scalpel that cuts away the tumor and brings order! So men, ready your weapons, this morning traitor blood shall be spilled."

Tactical officers are cold-blooded and combat-ready individuals deployed when the police force expects heavy resistance or needs to clean up dangerous areas. They can almost be likened to a military force within the police. They are often considered lacking in finesse and have the mentality of shoot first and ask questions later, but in their profession this is usually a requirement to survive. Some are driven entirely by aggression and adrenaline during missions, others by a sense of bringing justice, but all are marked in one way or another by the violence. Constantly encountering desperate people seconds before they behold death wears on the peace of mind and many seek destructive paths to relax and release the pressure.

Likely nature:

- Efficient
- hardened
- bitter
- cynical
- judgmental
- narrow-minded
- categorical
- aggressive
- tired
- authoritarian
- contemplative
- principled
- convinced
- corrupt
- sadistic
- lone wolf
- driven
- burned out.

Likely occupation:

- Tactical officer
- riot police
- sewer hound
- security troops
- state protection unit or escort force.

Attributes & Abilities

- Coordination (5); Close Combat (4), Reactions (4), Mobility (2)
- Physique (4); Stamina (4), Strength (4), Tolerance (0)
- Motor Skills (6); Dexterity (1), Throwing Weapons (2), Firearms (9)
- Education (3); Humanities (1), Natural Science (1), Medicine (4)
- Creativity (4); Construction (3), Create (2), Deduction (3)
- Willpower (4); Determination (3), Resistance (4), Sense (1)
- Insight (3); Empathy (0), Withstand (5), Worldly (1)
- Perception (3); Intuition (2), Vehicles (0), Awareness (4)
- Charisma (2); Charm (0), Leadership (4), Persuade (0)

Expertises

Good Shape (Stamina) Rhetoric: Criminals (Leadership) Medical Specialization: First aid (Medicine) Perceptive: Threats (Withstand) Martial Arts Trained (Close Combat) Dodge (Reactions) Endure Violence/war (Resistance) Weapon Handling: Shotguns or submachine guns (Firearms) Battle-hardened (Firearms) Well-trained (Strength) Observant: Notice concealed weapons on person/frisk (Awareness)

Artist

"Good, insert the needle a bit deeper into her chest, I want to capture her suffering. Yes like that. Now, put the noose around her neck and pull tight. Don't worry, she's been my model many times before so I know what she can handle. Now you can let her get some air, I need to change the film in the camera."

The world is observed, filtered and recreated through the artist. Impressions are gathered through studies of human behavior, nature's hidden language and culture's strange choices. Some artists resort to drugs to gain greater insight and inspiration, others sink into suffering and depression in the hunt for something greater. Art becomes an interpretation of the present and the artist absorbs the essence their surroundings give off. It's mixed with their thoughts, fantasies and experiences and shaped into paintings, music and literary works.

These creative people rarely fit the societal mold and many have difficulty supporting themselves. State censorship also complicates free thinking and many let their creation happen in secret and expose themselves only to a smaller audience. Some artists specialize in the generally accepted and popular and can succeed in living off their profession even if the creative side isn't satisfied. Others let the works take macabre forms, difficult for many to understand, but somewhere in the incomprehensible truth and insight can reveal themselves.

Likely nature:

- Manic
- depressed
- melancholic
- trying
- engaged
- shy
- pompous
- arrogant
- interested
- curious
- secretive
- spacey
- difficult
- talkative
- strange.

Likely occupation:

- Author
- painter
- artist

- composer
- writer
- sculptor
- photographer or poet.

Attributes & Abilities

- Coordination (3); Close Combat (0), Reactions (3), Mobility (3)
- Physique (4); Stamina (3), Strength (2), Tolerance (3)
- Motor Skills (2); Dexterity (3), Throwing Weapons (1), Firearms (0)
- Education (4); Humanities (5), Medicine (1), Natural Science (2)
- Creativity (6); Construction (2), Create (9), Deduction (1)
- Willpower (5); Determination (5), Resistance (1), Sense (4)
- Insight (3); Empathy (4), Withstand (1), Worldly (1)
- Perception (4); Intuition (4), Vehicles (1), Awareness (3)
- Charisma (3); Charm (4), Leadership (0), Persuade (2)

Expertises

Focus (Determination) Charismatic: Seduce/enthrall (Charm) Reading (Empathy) Academic Specialization: (suitable subject, for example Art History) (Humanities) Instinct (Intuition) Self-discipline (Sense) Creator: (something suitable for the profession) (Create) Outstanding Creator: (same as for Creator) (Create)

Cop

"So, are you going to tell me what you know? I know you're having trouble talking but trust me, it can get worse. A few knocked-out teeth are nothing compared to what I can do to you if I get really angry. So tell me now, who were your accomplices in the heist at the Golden Salon? You don't seem to understand who you're messing with, punk. I AM the law and the law doesn't care about scum like you."

As a cop you get to experience the violence, misery, terror, and the most unspeakable of perversions only to then return to your normal life, with family and colleagues who tackle the same terrible experiences. Not many manage this balancing act without being dragged down into depression and the feeling of helplessness. Many become desensitized and emotionally cold, others try to suppress the experiences through substance abuse. Being forced to experience the worst in all people can crush the strongest. However, there are those who keep their spirits up, don't let themselves be corrupted and actually see that their efforts make a difference, that they succeed in saving lives, helping fellow human beings and putting scoundrels behind bars. Yet it's hard to stay on the right side of the law, even for its guardians, especially when the criminals often have better resources, more money and contacts all the way up to the cabinet, the courts and the ministries.

Likely nature:

- Efficient
- enthusiastic
- jaded
- bitter
- cynical
- judgmental
- narrow-minded

- hateful
- aggressive
- understanding
- tired
- authoritarian
- insightful
- wise
- principled
- convinced
- corrupt
- sadistic
- lone wolf
- rule-breaker
- scared
- cowardly
- resigned
- helpful
- driven
- burned out.

Likely occupation:

- Radio car cop
- patrolling police constable
- guard
- crime fighter or citizen guardsman.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (4); Close Combat (4), Reactions (2), Mobility (2) Physique (4); Endurance (4), Strength (3), Tolerance (1) Motor Skills (3); Dexterity (1), Thrown Weapons (0), Firearms (5) Education (2); Humanities (2), Medicine (1), Natural Science (1) Creativity (3); Construction (2), Create (1), Deduction (3) Will (4); Determination (3), Resistance (2), Sense (3) Insight (6); Empathy (1), Withstand (5), Worldliness (6) Perception (5); Intuition (4), Vehicles (2), Awareness (4) Presence (3); Charm (0), Leadership (4), Persuade (2)

Expertise

Instinct (Intuition) Sprint (Endurance) Presence (Leadership) Read Through: Threats (Withstand) Self-Defense (Close Combat) Weapon Handling: Revolver (Firearms) Observant: Notice hidden weapons on person/frisk (Awareness) Local Knowledge: (local area) (Worldliness)

Prostitute

"If the gentleman wants to tie me up, spit on me and take me everywhere it costs two hundred. Expensive? I'm young, doll-like and good at what I do, unlike the other worn-out scabby whores down here. I know what I'm worth... and for you, here and now, that's two hundred."

The prostituted women and men, the girls and boys, live in harsh conditions with dirty brothels, dark alleys, dilapidated apartments and car front seats as their workplaces. Even though there are those who work their way up to higher levels with richer clients, the prostitutes' existence is based on being exploited for payment.

Many use drugs to numb the experiences and most are subordinated to pimps who take the greater part of their money and keep them in a firm grip.

Self-destructiveness and ever-expanding boundaries for which services are performed for payment lead to few prostitutes succeeding in leaving their profession. However, there are those who manage to establish a somewhat tolerable existence together with their sisters or brothers as family. A small clique that has been blessed with looks and aptitude may come to reach positions as kept mistresses for rich and/or famous individuals, and maintain their own apartment and pocket money.

Likely nature:

- Resigned
- kind-hearted
- cynical
- bitter
- suicidal
- sadistic
- masochist
- self-loathing
- passive
- action-oriented
- proud
- rough
- sarcastic
- crude
- distrustful.

Likely occupation:

- Stripper
- street whore
- brothel trash
- escort
- callgirl
- luxury prostitute
- porn star
- mistress
- kept woman or arm candy.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (4); Close Combat (2), Reactions (2), Mobility (4) Physique (3); Endurance (2), Strength (0), Tolerance (4) Motor Skills (4); Dexterity (6), Thrown Weapons (1), Firearms (1) Education (2); Humanities (1), Medicine (2), Natural Science (1) Creativity (3); Construction (0), Create (3), Deduction (3) Will (3); Determination (0), Resistance (6), Sense (0) Insight (6); Empathy (1), Withstand (2), Worldliness (9) Perception (4); Intuition (5), Vehicles (0), Awareness (3) Presence (5); Charm (8), Leadership (0), Persuade (2)

Expertise

Charismatic: Seduce/enchant (Charm) Charismatic: Dupe/manipulate (Charm) Pickpocket: Steal from purses/pockets (Dexterity) Eyes in the Back of Your Head (Intuition) Desensitized: Endure degradation/abuse

(Resistance) Agile: Model/pose (Mobility) Resilient: Diseases (Tolerance) Got the Situation (Worldliness) Fixer (Worldliness)

Priest

"In this world of total darkness you do right in coming to me, my child. There is much cruelty and horror and if one is not careful it drags one down into its perdition. Open your heart and tell of the deeds you have committed and for which sins you should be punished. Believe me I have heard most things and the One forgives all."

In times of darkness and despair the church is an important point for the faithful. To spread the word of the One is a great responsibility that often weighs on the priest's mind. For how does one know that the words one spreads are the One's and not one's own? How does one avoid falling for sin oneself in a world that seems lost? The State has in many ways made it more difficult for the church and made people afraid to seek comfort and support, but despite that the priest is an important individual who is respected in many parts of society.

The priests represent the ancient, a different perspective and the dream that somewhere beyond the human there is something greater. Beyond the cold and hard world there is joy and salvation for those who strive to work hard and do good. This very fact, that something would be greater and more powerful than the State, is in itself provocative for many. But people want to have something to believe in. They want hope.

Likely nature:

- Kind-hearted
- false
- believing
- fanatic
- doubting
- insane
- taciturn
- weak-willed
- helping
- narrow-minded
- bitter
- self-sacrificing
- idealist.

Likely occupation:

- Priest
- exorcist
- preacher
- benefactor
- doomsday prophet
- bishop
- cardinal
- clerk
- volunteer worker

- truth-seeker
- researcher
- witch hunter or savior.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (3); Close Combat (0), Reactions (3), Mobility (3) Physique (3); Endurance (2), Strength (2), Tolerance (2) Motor Skills (2); Dexterity (3), Thrown Weapons (1), Firearms (0) Education (6); Humanities (7), Medicine (4), Natural Science (1) Creativity (4); Construction (1), Create (2), Deduction (5) Will (5); Determination (4), Resistance (2), Sense (4) Insight (4); Empathy (7), Withstand (0), Worldliness (1) Perception (3); Intuition (4), Vehicles (0), Awareness (2) Presence (4); Charm (0), Leadership (4), Persuade (4)

Expertise

Teachable (Determination) Understanding (Empathy) Comfort & Calm (Empathy) Academic Focus: Religion/occultism (Humanities) Academic Specialist: Religion/occultism (Humanities) Fingertip Feeling (Intuition) Presence (Leadership) Medical Focus: First aid (Medicine) Aura of Calm (Sense) Clear-Headed: Remember things/places/phenomena (Deduction) Convincing: Negotiate/bargain (Persuade)

Reporter

"The article about how the top bosses at the Svakov factory ritually executed the workers who stood up against them caused me more trouble than benefit. Likewise the zeppelin scandal and the security at the mismanaged air harbor. I have been threatened countless times, but someone has to get the truth out to the people. My editor has a thick letter with pictures and copied documents that he will open if I disappear or have an accident. So far the letter's existence has saved me from horrors, but the latest scoop is so big that I suspect the insurance won't be enough."

In a society where all news is under strict censorship, where complaints against the State can mean the death penalty, and where biased reporting constitutes the norm, the reporter fills an important function. Even if the news becomes biased, they give a view of the world that constitutes reality for Sandukar's millions of inhabitants. However, there are reporters who strive to get the truth out and who in secret radio broadcasts and underground newspapers fight to get their messages across. They risk torture and the death penalty if they are captured, as they are regarded as terrorists and insurrectionists.

A reporter has good insight into the part of the city he/ she is located in, and plenty of contacts and sources. Moreover, he/she has access to masses of archive material at the editorial office and stumbles now and then upon unpleasant conspiracies and strange events.

Likely nature:

- Curious
- bitter
- cynical
- inquisitive
- dreamer
- idealist
- angry
- driving
- engaged
- tired

- daring
- rule-breaker
- compassionate
- principled
- honest
- corrupt
- burned out.

Likely occupation:

- Newspaperman
- correspondent
- photographer
- editor
- searcher
- freelance reporter
- documenter or investigative journalist.

Attributes & Skills Coordination (3); Close Combat (1), Reactions (4), Mobility (1) Physique (3); Endurance (2), Strength (1), Tolerance (3) Motor Skills (2); Dexterity (3), Thrown Weapons (0), Firearms (1) Education (4); Humanities (5), Medicine (1), Natural Science (2) Creativity (4); Create (7), Construction (0), Deduction (1) Will (3); Determination (3), Resistance (1), Sense (2) Insight (4); Empathy (1), Withstand (2), Worldliness (5) Perception (6); Intuition (4), Vehicles (2), Awareness (6) Presence (5); Charm (4), Leadership (1), Persuade (5)

Expertise

Charismatic: Mingle/converse (Charm) Academic Focus: (something suitable for the profession) (Humanities) Instinct (Intuition) Quick-Footed (Reactions) Creator: (something suitable for the profession, for example Write journalistic texts) (Create) Outstanding Creator: (same as for Creator) (Create) Observant: Notice deviations/details (Awareness) Got the Situation (Worldliness) Convincing: Convince/implore (Persuade)

Brawler

"You might not get it, but you're not getting in here! Not now, not ever. Are you completely fucking stupid in the head? You pulling a knife on me? Dumb bastard!" The Brawler makes a living fighting for various reasons. Being constantly in brawls or messy situations is his/her life. It could be a way to make ends meet, for example through illegal boxing matches or death fights. Or it's just that the language of fists comes naturally to the person, perhaps due to long-term bullying during upbringing, chaotic conditions, petty crime, or other factors that created a need for the ability to defend oneself. The Brawler's life is often marked by injuries and scars from fights, and he/she frequently suffers permanent damage, memory problems, or a smashed-in face. To numb the pain, many choose to turn to painkillers or alcohol. Few brawlers manage to live a normal life. Some try to settle down, find honest work, and perhaps even start a family, but the violence in their past has left its mark and it's hard not to fall back into it. Enemies from before who suddenly appear, frustrating situations, and mockery from bosses or colleagues can be very difficult to ignore when the fists are so eager to speak. The Brawler wages a constant battle against himself, his animalistic side, and his own aggression. Violence seems to have taken root forever, and many brawlers eventually give themselves over to it completely. Likely nature:

- Taciturn

- survivor
- bully
- aggressive
- single-minded
- stupid
- emotionally disturbed
- self-assertive
- sadistic
- brutal
- bitter
- burnt out
- disturbed
- driven. Likely occupation:
- Boxer
- bouncer
- odd-jobs worker
- petty criminal
- laborer
- bodyguard
- enforcer
- unemployed
- or martial artist. Attributes & Abilities
- Coordination (6); Close Combat (7), Reactions (4), Mobility (1)
- Build (5); Endurance (3), Strength (7), Tolerance (0)
- Motor Skills (3); Manual Dexterity (2), Throwing (2), Firearms (2)
- Education (2); Humanities (1), Medicine (2), Natural Science (1)
- Creativity (4); Construction (3), Create (3), Deduction (2)
- Will (4); Determination (2), Resistance (4), Sense (2)

- Insight (3); Empathy (1), Oppose (1), Streetwise (4)
- Perception (4); Intuition (2), Vehicles (2), Awareness (4)
- Presence (3); Charm (1), Leadership (2), Persuade (3) **Expertises** Amateur Boxing (Close Combat) Professional Boxing (Close Combat) Quick Reflexes (Reactions) Well-Trained (Strength) Lead Fists (Strength) Observant: Notice concealed weapons on person/frisk (Awareness) Local Knowledge: (local area) (Streetwise) Hardened: Withstand pain/torture (Resistance) **Soldier** "The meal is served—a watery gruel with a piece of black bread. A luxury meal worthy of a minister. I shall make my way over to the dugout in the trench, so the rain doesn't water down the soup any more. The rifle is so heavy and cumbersome. Soon it's leave. I long for it so. Almost there. The fog seems to be lifting out over the mud field. Damn it, an incoming grenade attack. You learn to recognize that whistling sound in your sleep. If you sleep at all. There it detonated. Cursed enemy, I hate you! Well great, just what I needed—mud splatter in my food. Oh well, there's an assault planned tonight so who needs to eat..." The State needs fodder for war's meat grinders, and it's the soldiers who are devoured. As a soldier, you get lousy compensation for defending your country, your way of life, and your ideals against the enemy. Usually the circumstances are terrible. Death stinks in the trenches while machine guns roar, gas grenades detonate, and orders are screamed. If the enemy's bullets don't finish off the soldier, the environment does its best, with starvation, diseases, infections, and madness. As a soldier, you've seen most of the worst that's hidden in man's interior. Virtually no one who joins the army returns home without being changed. Some suffer from physical and psychological damage. Others are hardened and cold, and some long to return to the trenches where life is mapped out and simple when you just follow orders. Fellowship with people who haven't experienced war's horrors is difficult to maintain as you live in different worlds. Something in soldiers dies among barbed wire and minefields. Virtue is lost forever. Likely nature:
- Idealist
- cynical
- sentimental
- war-damaged
- fearful
- slovenly
- heroic
- cold-blooded
- insane
- violent
- brutal
- calm
- broken

- patriotic. Likely occupation:
- Private
- officer
- staff member
- intelligence agent
- courier
- specialist
- commando
- engineer
- strategist
- interrogator
- or pilot. Attributes & Abilities
- Coordination (4); Close Combat (4), Reactions (3), Mobility (1)
- Build (5); Endurance (4), Strength (2), Tolerance (4)
- Motor Skills (6); Manual Dexterity (1), Throwing (4), Firearms (7)
- Education (3); Humanities (2), Medicine (2), Natural Science (2)
- Creativity (3); Construction (3), Create (1), Deduction (2)
- Will (4); Determination (1), Resistance (7), Sense (0)
- Insight (2); Empathy (1), Oppose (2), Streetwise (1)
- Perception (4); Intuition (3), Vehicles (1), Awareness (4)
- Presence (3); Charm (1), Leadership (2), Persuade (3) **Expertises** Throwing Technique: Hand Grenades (Throwing) March (Endurance) Close Combat Weapon: Bayonet (Close Combat) Hardened: Endure pain/torture (Resistance) Hardened: Endure violence/war (Resistance) Combat Veteran (Firearms) Weapon Handling: Rifle (Firearms) Tough: Diseases (Tolerance) Observant: Orient in darkness (Awareness)

Technician

"This electric clockwork should work perfectly, but for some reason it always runs slow toward morning when night withdraws. It's strange, somehow the water in the canals and the reservoir system seems to affect this mechanical construction..." In Noir's industrialized society, maintenance is needed. It's handled by technicians who must ensure that machines work, that technology is available, and that everyone is satisfied. The factories' machines are adjusted to function with utmost perfection. Reservoir dams in the canals are regulated and radio transmitters are installed. Cogwheels, levers, transformers, and generators are tools that

keep society alive. Without maintenance and the technicians' brains, Sandukar would be a silent and dead city where everything of steel and cables would stand still. By using their hands and their minds, the technician can create fantastic mechanical inventions that can result in everything from brutal war machines to precise clockworks. However, one must follow state laws and there are a handful of areas within technical research that must not be entered. Crossing these boundaries means being counted as a terrorist and thus risking execution. Exactly why these areas are forbidden is not explained, but most people value their lives and follow the templates the State has provided for how technological innovations should look. Likely nature:

- Fanatical
- goal-oriented
- gruff
- shy
- manic
- efficient
- perfectionist
- cheerful
- clumsy
- clever
- focused
- cowardly
- curious. Likely occupation:
- Inventor
- constructor
- engineer
- repairman
- mechanic
- or locksmith. Attributes & Abilities
- Coordination (3); Close Combat (0), Reactions (3), Mobility (3)
- Build (4); Endurance (3), Strength (3), Tolerance (2)
- Motor Skills (3); Manual Dexterity (3), Throwing (3), Firearms (0)
- Education (5); Humanities (2), Medicine (0), Natural Science (8)
- Creativity (6); Construction (8), Create (0), Deduction (4)

- Will (4); Determination (5), Resistance (0), Sense (3)
- Insight (2); Empathy (0), Oppose (4), Streetwise (0)
- Perception (4); Intuition (1), Vehicles (3), Awareness (4)
- Presence (3); Charm (2), Leadership (0), Persuade (4) **Expertises** Quick Study (Determination) Technical Focus: (choose an appropriate field) (Construction) Technical Specialist: (same field as Technical Focus) (Construction) Perceptive: Bribery Attempts (Oppose) Scientific Focus: (choose an appropriate field) (Natural Science) Scientific Specialist: (same field as Scientific Focus) (Natural Science) Clear-Minded: Experiment/invent (Deduction) Observant: Notice anomalies/details (Awareness) Persuasive: Negotiate/haggle (Persuade) **Enforcer** "You don't understand who you're messing with, you bastard! Do I have to break more of your ribs before you cough up the money? You're the one who gambled it away, you're the one who spits it back up! Don't give me that old story again, wife and kids, bah! Next time it's your wife I'll kick the shit out of, so you better pay up before the week's over. Then it'll be your kids. Rulov's generosity has limits, and you passed them long ago. So now you're crying, you weak bastard!" When someone needs to be threatened, beaten, or killed, the enforcer is called in. This cold-hearted individual makes a living by destroying lives and collecting debts for payment. The enforcer usually has a criminal past and has usually grown up in a world of violence and lies. This has hardened him/her to the degree that he/she now no longer hesitates to perform the most distasteful acts for a sum of money. Often the enforcer works for an organization in the underworld, but he/she can also function as a freelancer who is contacted when needed. Many enforcers are alcoholic brutes who've been forced into the only work they're capable of performing. They tell themselves they are without guilt as they only follow orders, but deep down many suffer. But there are also those who see killing as an art, who find pleasure in breaking ribs and squeezing people for money. These dangerous individuals have already stared down into the abyss and no longer fear its darkness. Likely nature:
- Taciturn
- aggressive
- efficient
- talkative
- loyal
- corrupt
- reliable
- dutiful
- polite
- goal-oriented
- attentive
- resourceful
- patient

- perfectionist
- sadistic
- ingratiating
- blunt
- honest
- dishonest. Likely occupation:
- Enforcer
- collector
- thug
- bodyguard
- hired muscle
- debt collector
- killer
- bone-breaker
- arsonist
- or assassin. Attributes & Abilities
- Coordination (5); Close Combat (7), Reactions (2), Mobility (1)
- Build (4); Endurance (1), Strength (7), Tolerance (0)
- Motor Skills (6); Manual Dexterity (4), Throwing (1), Firearms (7)
- Education (2); Humanities (2), Medicine (1), Natural Science (1)
- Creativity (3); Construction (2), Create (1), Deduction (3)
- Will (4); Determination (2), Resistance (4), Sense (2)
- Insight (3); Empathy (0), Oppose (2), Streetwise (4)
- Perception (4); Intuition (3), Vehicles (2), Awareness (3)
- Presence (3); Charm (0), Leadership (2), Persuade (4) **Expertises** Lock Picking: Door Locks (Manual Dexterity) Brawling (Close Combat) Close Combat Weapon: Knife (Close Combat) Hardened: Endure violence/war (Resistance) Combat Veteran (Firearms) Weapon Handling: Machine Pistol (Firearms) Well-Trained (Strength) Beefy (Strength) Know the Score (Streetwise) Persuasive: Threaten/intimidate/harass (Persuade)

Investigator

"When my flashlight illuminated the bloody symbols on the tiled wall, I realized I had found a new clue. Here, in this insane pattern, were the traces that would lead me to the murderer. He's luring me in and I'm now too deep in to resist, even though the investigation has officially been shut down. He's trying to tell me something, something I've missed. But I'll have to turn over every stone again and go through evidence and testimony one more time. I'll get you, you bastard!" An investigator is a person who spends their time interpreting clues, solving problems and searching for answers and people. Exactly what profession the investigator has can vary, he/she can be a police captain, hired consultant, problem-solver or private detective. Many investigators work for private individuals or companies. A corrupt police force that doesn't have the time or resources to conduct proper investigations, along with the need to have certain more illegal assignments carried out, means that the investigator fills an important function. Many assignments are simple and time-consuming, for example finding missing persons, finding evidence of infidelity and the like. However, it happens that the investigator stumbles into truly dangerous situations when trails turn out to lead to conspira-cies and high-level conflicts. Many investigators have a past in the police force (if they're not still there) and have contacts on the street. Likely nature:

- Efficient
- enthusiastic
- jaded
- bitter
- cynical
- judgmental
- narrow-minded
- aggressive
- understanding
- tired
- insightful
- wise
- principled
- convinced
- corrupt
- sadistic
- lone wolf
- rule-breaker
- afraid
- cowardly

- resigned
- helpful
- dri-ven
- burned out
- committed
- personal
- relaxed. Likely occupation:
- Criminal police
- security police
- crime scene technician
- interrogation leader
- negotiator
- profiler
- infiltrator
- surveillance officer
- private investigator
- government investigator
- insurance investigator
- private detective. Attributes & Abilities
- Coordination (2); Close Combat (2), Reactions (1), Mobility (1)
- Physique (3); Endurance (3), Strength (2), Tolerance (1)
- Motor Skills (3); Dexterity (2), Throwing (0), Firearms (4)
- Learning (4); Humanities (4), Medicine (2), Natural Science (2)
- Creativity (4); Construction (0), Create (1), Deduction (7)
- Willpower (3); Determination (2), Resistance (2), Sense (2)
- Insight (5); Empathy (2), Withstand (4), Worldliness (4)
- Perception (6); Intuition (5), Vehicles (2), Awareness (5)
- Presence (4); Charm (1), Leadership (3), Persuade (4) **Expertises** Studious (Determination) Instinct (Intuition) Perceptive: Threats (Withstand) Weapon Handling: Revolver (Firearms) Clear-minded: Crime

scene investigation/forensics (Deduction) Clear-minded: Investigate/see connections (Deduction) Observant: Notice deviations/details (Awareness) Versed: Criminals (Worldliness) Persuasive: Interrogate/interview (Persuade) **Caretaker** "Rarely have I met such a twisted and dangerous person as Maryla. The first time she managed to trick me into releasing her and then attacked me with a scalpel — it was sheer luck that I survived. The second time she killed a caretaker and escaped, but now I keep her drugged so that she's compliant. The conversations we have give me a unique insight into her morbid world and I cannot stop being fascinated by her thoughts." Illness, madness and human suffering have always exis-ted and in Sandukar's society it exists in abundance. There are however those who have chosen to focus on helping the sick and vulnerable. As a caretaker one encounters many individuals some of whom carry permanent injuries to both body and soul. But despite the horrors caretakers encounter, there are many who feel satisfaction from seeing the fruit of their labor, the souls they've saved, the epidemics they've stopped. Others have given up in the face of the cruel world that constantly strikes the innocent, that takes the lives of young people needlessly, or where meaninglessly random violence strikes against the good. Caretakers exist in all parts of society, among the families one finds skilled private physicians who run luxurious clinics and in the slums there are doctors who struggle to cure those in need or who squeeze money out of those who ask for help. Many have realized the importance of having contact with skilled caretakers, as this can mean life and death for those who have been seriously injured or ill. Likely nature:

- Doubter
- committed
- detached
- numbed
- skilled
- devoted
- considerate
- burned out
- corrupt
- friendly
- cold
- efficient
- accommodating
- superior
- disintere-sted
- principled
- idealistic

- braggart
- talkative
- incompetent. Likely occupation:
- Doctor
- paramedic
- mili-tary doctor
- surgeon
- researcher
- medical examiner
- psychologist
- counselor
- therapist
- psychiatric nurse
- nurse
- pharmacologist. Attributes & Abilities
- Coordination (3); Close Combat (1), Reactions (3), Mobility (2)
- Physique (3); Endurance (1), Strength (1), Tolerance (4)
- Motor Skills (3); Dexterity (5), Throwing (1), Firearms (0)
- Learning (6); Humanities (1), Medicine (10), Natural Science (1)
- Creativity (4); Construction (0), Create (1), Deduction (7)
- Willpower (5); Determination (4), Resistance (2), Sense (4)
- Insight (4); Empathy (5), Withstand (2), Worldliness (1)
- Perception (2); Intuition (1), Vehicles (1), Awareness (2)
- Presence (4); Charm (1), Leadership (4), Persuade (3) **Expertises** Studious (Determination) Understanding (Empathy) Tricks: Distraction (Dexterity) Presence (Leadership) Medical specialization: (choose an appropriate field) (Medicine) Medical specialist: (same field as for Medical specialization) (Medicine) Self-discipline (Sense) Clear-minded: Investigate/see connections (Deduction) Clear-minded: Remember things/places/phenomena (Deduction) Patient: Diseases (Tolerance)

Background Packages

The background packages exist to offer the player a way to give their protagonist a complete profile with minimal time investment. Here a number of ready-made packages are presented in the form of various concepts. In each package there are limitations and characteristics, as well as charac-ter traits and relationships. The idea is that a player who doesn't want to micromanage the protagonist's background can quickly find and use a ready-made package that fits, or is close to, the intended concept. In the packages below the point costs are included so the player can easily swap out parts of the package if a choice doesn't fit into his/her vision of the protagonist. All limitations and charac-teristics are described in detail on pages 80–87. In addi-tion there are suggestions for character traits (see page 224) and relationships (see page 209) that fit into the package. In those packages where the limitation Family is included, the family has been included among the relationships. The names of the background packages are chosen to give an idea of what type of protagonist they would be suitable for. However, there are no problems whatsoever in modifying the packages or using them for other types of protagonists. **Irresponsible Hedonist**

Limitations

Wanted: Minor crimes [1 point]

- Family: Two narrator characters [3 points]
- Fear (noticeable): Condemning mother [2 points]
- Vice (overwhelming): Gambling (various types of card games) [4 points] **Characteristics**
- Fatalist [3 points]
- Size: Small [1 extra point]
- Lucky: Luck 6 [6 points]
- Fate's Favorite [2 points] **Character Traits** Loving (passionate) Indifferent (uninterested)

Relationships

Mother; Influence 18, Disapproving relationship, Blood tie Son/daughter; Influence 6, Benevolent relationship, Blood tie Doorman; Influence 9, Hostile relationship Fixer; Influence 12, Disapproving relationship Nightclub owner; Influence 15, Neutral relationship, Att-raction **Cynical Detective**

Limitations

- Family: One narrator character [2 points]
- Vice (noticeable): Alcohol (whiskey) [2 points]
- Vice (significant): Opposite sex (dangerous men/women) [3 points]
- Code of honor (basic): Always complete started cases [1 point]
- Ailment (mild): Stomach ulcer [2 points] **Characteristics**
- Appearance: Attractive [1 point]
- Hardboiled [2 points]
- Quick-thinking [2 points]

- Talented: Deduction [4 points]
- Fate's Favorite [1 point] **Character Traits** Suspicious (questioning) Risk-taking (snooping)

Relationships

Ex-husband/ex-wife; Influence 12, Disapproving relationship, Attraction, Blood tie Detective; Influence 12, Neutral relationship Snitch; Influence 12, Disapproving relationship Bartender; Influence 6, Benevolent relationship **Dedicated Detective**

Limitations

- Family: One narrator character [2 points]
- Nightmares [2 points]
- Fear (noticeable): Dogs [2 points]
- Vice (noticeable): Children (vulnerable children) [2 points]
- Vice (noticeable): Opposite sex (appropriate superficial inclination) [2 points] **Characteristics**
- Flaw: Resistance [1 extra point]
- Standard of living: 5 [1 point]
- Reputation: Renowned (6) within the police [2 points]
- Talented: Intuition [4 points]
- Talented: Deduction [4 points] **Character Traits** Very honest (principled) Convinced (determined)

Relationships

Sister/brother; Influence 9, Benevolent relationship, Blood tie Crime victim; Influence 6, Neutral relationship, Attraction Psychologist; Influence 12, Neutral relationship Medical examiner; Influence 12, Disapproving relationship **Daring Enforcer**

Limitations

- Wanted: Minor crimes [1 point]
- Family: Three narrator characters [4 points]
- Fear (noticeable): Fear of heights [2 points]
- Vice (significant): Alcohol (hard liquor) [3 points] **Characteristics**
- Hardboiled [2 points]
- Standard of living: 3 [1 extra point]
- Natural Warrior [3 points]
- Size: Large [3 points]

- Resilient [2 points]
- Fate's Favorite [3 points]
- Eye injury [2 extra points] **Character Traits** Aggressive (cruel, brutal) Vengeful (resentful)

Relationships

Husband/wife; Influence 12, Neutral relationship, Blood tie Son/daughter; Influence 6, Friendly relationship, Blood tie Brother; Influence 15, Disapproving relationship, Blood tie Childhood friend; Influence 9, Benevolent relationship Corrupt cop; Influence 9, Neutral relationship Liquor store owner; Influence 9, Neutral relationship **Fanatical Agitator**

Limitations

- Wanted: Enemy of the State [4 points]
- Code of honor (fanatical): Never help/facilitate for the State [3 points]
- Minority [1 point]
- Vice (noticeable): Propagate one's cause before audiences (crowds in venues) [2 points] **Characteristics**
- Fatalist [3 points]
- Ex-convict [1 point]
- Charming [2 points]
- Standard of living: 2 [2 extra points]
- Reputation: Renowned (6) among the poor [2 points]
- Resilient [2 points]
- Lucky: Luck 2 [2 points]
- Appearance: Attractive [1 point]
- Fate's Favorite [1 point]
- Eye injury [2 extra points] **Character Traits** Honest (noble) Risk-taking (fearless) Extremely convinced (unwavering)

Relationships

Follower; Influence 9, Benevolent relationship, Attraction Informant; Influence 9, Disapproving relationship State police agent; Influence 15, Hostile relationship **Greedy Fraudster**

Limitations

- Impaired vision: Poor [1 point]
- Code of honor (fanatical): Never lose self-control in public [3 points]

- Vice (significant): Objects (expensive art) [3 points]
- Vice (significant): Events (gatherings/parties/ events) [3 points] **Characteristics**
- Charming [2 points]
- Gifted [4 points]
- Appearance: Handsome/beautiful [2 points]
- Standard of living: 6 [2 points]
- Pain-sensitive [2 extra points]
- Flaw: Close Combat [1 extra point]
- Flaw: Strength [1 extra point]
- Talented: Persuade [4 points] **Character Traits** Greedy (covetous) Very deceitful (fraudulent)

Relationships

Lawyer; Influence 15, Neutral relationship Thug; Influence 12, Neutral relationship Ruined businessman; Influence 9, Hostile relationship

Kindhearted Doctor

Limitations

- Drug Addict: Sedative drugs [1 point]
- Family: Two narrator characters [3 points]
- Code of Honor (fanatical): Always treat the sick and injured [3 points]
- Code of Honor (basic): Never reveal patient in-formation to outsiders [1 point]
- Nightmares [2 points] **Traits**
- Gifted [4 points]
- Hardboiled [2 points]
- Flaw: Close Combat [1 extra point]
- Flaw: Firearms [1 extra point]
- Standard of Living: 6 [2 points]
- Talented: Medicine [4 points] **Characteristics**

Cautious (prudent) Honorable (integrity)

Relationships

Spouse; Influence 12, Neutral relationship, Attraction, **Blood Ties** Father; Influence 12, Dislike relationship, Blood Ties Bureaucrat; Influence 12, Favorable relationship Widow of deceased socialite; Influence 15, **Hostile relationship** Rival at the hospital/clinic; Influence 9, Dislike relationship **Investigative Reporter**

Limitations

- Family: One narrator character [1 point]
- Code of Honor (fanatical): Never reveal or betray a source [3 points]
- Code of Honor (basic): Always report scoops to the public [1 point]
- Fear (noticeable): Confined spaces (elevators) [2 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Snooping (for scoops) [2 points] **Traits**
- Reputation: Renowned (6) within the press [2 points]
- Quick-Thinking [2 points]
- Talented: Create [4 points]
- Lucky: Luck 2 [2 points] **Characteristics**

Suspicious (skeptical) Very risk-prone (curious)

Relationships

Spouse; Influence 6, Favorable relationship, Blood Ties Businessman; Influence 12, Hostile relationship Freelance photographer; Influence 9, Friendly relationship Petty criminal; Influence 9, Favorable relationship **Heroic Veteran**

Limitations

- Depression: Maximum Wellbeing 7 [3 points]
- Family: One narrator character [2 points]
- Code of Honor (fanatical): Never leave a wounded comrade in the field [3 points]
- Nightmares [2 points] **Traits**
- Natural Warrior [3 points]
- Reserved [2 extra points]
- Reputation: Renowned (6) within the army [2 points]
- Stone Hard [3 points]
- Size: Tall [2 points]
- Battle Ready [2 points] **Characteristics**

Honorable (upright) Risk-prone (confident)

Relationships

Spouse; Influence 12, Dislike relationship, Attrac-tion, Blood Ties Army buddy; Influence 9, Favorable relationship Officer; Influence 15, Dislike relationship Taxi driver; Influence 6, Neutral relationship **Devoted Researcher**

Limitations

- Code of Honor (basic): Science is the supreme path [1 point]
- Impaired Hearing: Poor [1 point]
- Ailment (minor): High blood pressure [2 points]
- Debt: Heavily indebted [1 point]
- Weakness (sadism): Torture (experimentation) [2 points]
- Impaired Vision: Terrible [3 points] **Traits**
- Gifted [4 points]
- Flaw: Charm [1 extra point]
- Standard of Living: 6 [2 points]
- Damaged Hand [2 extra points]
- Talented: Natural Science [4 points]
- Lucky: Luck 5 [5 points]
- Appearance: Ugly [2 extra points] **Characteristics**

Aggressive (sadistic) Arrogant (self-righteous) Lustful (perverse)

Relationships

Bureaucrat; Influence 12, Favorable relationship Research competitor; Influence 12, Hostile relationship Dealer in strange things; Influence 9, Neutral relationship **Ruthless Seducer**

Limitations

- Depression: Maximum Wellbeing 9 [1 point]
- Code of Honor (basic): Never fall in love [1 point]
- Fear (significant): Insanity [3 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Sex (new conquests) [2 points]
- Weakness (significant): Sadism (dominate/seduce/de-grade/exploit) [3 points] **Traits**
- Charming: [2 points]
- Flaw: Vehicles [1 extra point]

- Flaw: Construction [1 extra point]
- Standard of Living: 6 [2 points]
- Weak Grip [3 extra points]
- Talented: Charm [4 points]
- Appearance: Perfect [6 points]
- Fate's Favorite [1 point] **Characteristics**

Greedy (power-hungry) Very deceitful (cunning, manipulative)

Relationships

Heartbroken man/woman; Influence 6, Hostile rela-tionship, Attraction Hotel manager; Influence 9, Neutral relationship Gangster boss; Influence 12, Neutral relationship, Attrac-tion/Passion **Cold-Blooded Professional Killer**

Limitations

- Depression: Maximum Wellbeing 7 [3 points]
- Wanted: Serious crime [2 points]
- Weakness (significant): Sadism (torture) [3 points]
- Fear (noticeable): Closeness/intimacy [2 points] **Traits**
- Hardboiled [2 points]
- Build: Thin [1 extra point]
- Flaw: Empathy [1 extra point]
- Reserved [2 extra points]
- Reputation: Infamous (4) within the underworld [2 points]
- Size: Tall [2 points]
- Battle Ready [2 points]
- Resilient [2 points]
- Talent: Firearms [4 points] **Characteristics**

Indifferent (ruthless)

Relationships

Avenger; Influence 9, Hostile relationship Gangster boss; Influence 15, Neutral relationship Arms dealer; Influence 12, Neutral relationship **Cold-Hearted Avenger**

Limitations

- Depression: Maximum Wellbeing 6 [4 points]
- Wanted: Serious crime [2 points]
- Code of Honor (fanatical): Never give up [3 points]
- Code of Honor (basic): Never harm innocent people [1 point] **Traits**
- Fatalist [3 points]
- Ex-Con [1 point]
- Natural Warrior [3 points]
- Reserved [2 extra points]
- Reputation: Infamous (4) on the street [2 points]
- Size: Well-built [1 point]
- Battle Ready [2 points]
- Slow Learner [3 extra points]
- Fate's Favorite [3 points] **Characteristics**

Aggressive (bloodthirsty) Very vengeful (obsessed) Very convinced (right to punish)

Relationships

Former friend; Influence 9, Dislike relationship Nemesis; Influence 18, Hostile relationship Reporter; Influence 12, Neutral relationship

Corrupt Official

Limitations

- Family: Three narrator characters [4 points]
- Code of Honor (basic): Always review all matters thoroughly [1 point]
- Fear (noticeable): Being exposed by superiors [2 points]
- Weakness (significant): Money (bribes) [3 points] **Traits**
- Build: Thin [1 extra point]
- Standard of Living: 6 [2 points]
- Quick-Thinking [2 points]
- Talented: Resolve [4 points]
- Talented: Humanities [4 points]
- Anxious [1 extra point] **Characteristics**

Arrogant (emotionally cold) Greedy (stingy)

Relationships

Spouse; Influence 9, Favorable relationship, Attraction, **Blood Ties** Mother; Influence 9, Neutral relationship, Blood Ties Sister; Influence 12, Neutral relationship, Blood Ties Gangster; Influence 12, Dislike relationship Accountant; Influence 9, Neutral relationship Clan member; Influence 15, Neutral relationship **War-Wounded Soldier**

Limitations

- Impaired Hearing: Poor [1 point]
- Ailment (severe): Chemical-burned lungs [3 points]
- Nightmares [2 points]
- Fear (noticeable): Fires [2 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Alcohol (liquor) [2 points] **Traits**
- Limp [2 extra points]
- Hardboiled [2 points]
- Strong-Willed [3 points]
- Stone Hard [3 points]
- Size: Well-built [1 point]
- Resilient [2 points]
- Talented: Firearms [4 points]
- Appearance: Unattractive [1 extra point]
- Eye Damage [2 extra points] **Characteristics**

Arrogant (smug) Suspicious (jealous)

Relationships

Field medic; Influence 9, Neutral relationship Understanding bartender; Influence 9, Favorable relationship Neighbor; Influence 6, Favorable relationship **Suspicious Petty Criminal**

Limitations

- Drug Addict: Sedative drugs [1 point]
- Nightmares [2 points]
- Minority [1 point]
- Fear (overwhelming): Stapo [4 points]

- Debt: Completely indebted [2 points] **Traits**
- Ex-Con [1 point]
- Build: Thin [1 extra point]
- Agile [2 points]
- Standard of Living: 2 [2 extra points]
- Reputation: Infamous (4) in the underworld [2 points]
- Quick-Thinking [2 points]
- Talented: Awareness [4 points]
- Appearance: Handsome/beautiful [2 points] **Characteristics**

Suspicious (paranoid) Greedy (money-hungry)

Relationships

Street hustler; Influence 12, Favorable relationship Drug dealer; Influence 12, Neutral relationship Cop; Influence 9, Hostile relationship **Naive Actor**

Limitations

- Fear (significant): Public humiliation [3 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Opposite sex (influential men/women) [2 points]
- Ailment (minor): Migraine [2 points]
- Drug Addict: Stimulant drugs [1 point]
- Weakness (noticeable): Events (society parties/gala pre-mieres) [2 points] **Traits**
- Easily Influenced [1 extra point]
- Anxious [1 extra point]
- Charming [2 points]
- Talented: Charm [4 points]
- Appearance: Sensational [4 points]
- Standard of Living: 6 [2 points] **Characteristics**

Very arrogant (superficial)

Relationships

Booking agent; Influence 15, Neutral relationship Competitor; Influence 6, Dislike relationship, Attraction Reporter; Influence 9, Neutral relationship **Uneducated Brawler**

Limitations

- Code of Honor (basic): Help and protect your friends [1 point]
- Impaired Hearing: Poor [1 point]
- Fear (significant): Claustrophobia [3 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Children (vulnerable children) [2 points]
- Weakness (significant): Opposite sex (paternal/maternal feelings) [3 points] **Traits**
- Flaw: Charm [1 extra point]
- Flaw: Resist [1 extra point]
- Natural Warrior [3 points]
- Stone Hard [3 points]
- Size: Giant [4 points]
- Battle Ready [2 points]
- Resilient [2 points]
- Slow Learner [3 extra points]
- Fate's Favorite [1 point] **Characteristics**

Aggressive (violent)

Relationships

Boxing manager; Influence 12, Dislike relationship Gangster; Influence 12, Neutral relationship Childhood friend; Influence 6, Favorable relationship **Frightened Refugee**

Limitations

- Family: Two narrator characters [3 points]
- Ailment (minor): Cough [2 points]
- Minority [1 point]
- Fear (overwhelming): Being found by the State [4 points] **Traits**
- Build: Thin [1 extra point]
- Agile [2 points]
- Standard of Living: 1 [3 extra points]
- Sickly [1 extra point]
- Strong-Willed [3 points]

- Resilient [2 points]
- Talented: Awareness [4 points]
- Lucky: Luck 3 [3 points]
- Fate's Favorite [1 point] **Characteristics**

Cautious (unassuming) Loving (their family) Suspicious (insecure)

Relationships

Spouse; Influence 9, Favorable relationship, Attraction/ Passion, Blood Ties Son/daughter; Influence 6, Neutral relationship, Blood Ties People smuggler; Influence 9, Neutral relationship Blackmailer; Influence 6, Hostile relationship Wise elder; Influence 15, Friendly relationship **Shrewd Businessman**

Limitations

- Family: Two narrator characters [3 points]
- Fear (significant): Great heights [3 points]
- Debt: Heavily indebted [1 point]
- Weakness (significant): Sex (new conquests) [3 points] **Traits**
- Build: Fat [2 extra points]
- Standard of Living: 7 [4 points]
- Pain-Sensitive [2 extra points]
- Quick-Thinking [2 points]
- Talented: Worldly [4 points]
- Talented: Persuade [4 points] **Characteristics**

Very greedy (money-hungry) Deceitful (unscrupulous)

Relationships

Spouse; Influence 12, Dislike relationship, Blood Ties Son/daughter; Influence 9, Friendly relationship, Blood Ties Bureaucrat; Influence 15, Neutral relationship Entrepreneur; Influence 12, Neutral relationship Mistress; Influence 6, Dislike relationship

Talkative Fixer

Limitations

- Code of Honor (basic): Never break a made deal [1 point]
- Fear (noticeable): Aggressiveness/violence [2 points]
- Fear (tangible): Dogs [3 points]
- Weakness (tangible): Objects (art) [3 points]

- Impaired vision: Poor [1 point] **Traits**

Gifted [2]

- Standard of Living: 7 [4 points]
- Reputation: Known (7) in the underworld and in the district where he/she is active [4 points]
- Strong-willed [3 points]
- Quick-thinking [2 points]
- Size: Small [1 extra point]
- Anxious [1 extra point]
- Impatient [3 extra points] **Character Traits** Greedy (stingy, money-loving)

Relationships

Fence; Influence 15, Neutral relationship Police; Influence 9, Neutral relationship Skipper; Influence 9, Disliking relationship **Thoughtless Socialite**

Limitations

- Drug addict: Alcohol [1 point]
- Family: Two narrator characters [3 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Objects (sports cars) [2 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Gambling (card games) [2 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Sex (appropriate inclination) [2 points] **Traits**
- Charming [2 points]
- Quirk: Empathy [1 extra point]
- Standard of Living: 8 [6 points]
- Reputation: Known (7) in high society and media world [4 points]
- Slow learner [3 extra points]
- Lucky: Luck 1 [1 point]
- Appearance: Attractive [1 point] **Character Traits** Arrogant (vain) Very lustful (erotic)

Relationships

Father; Influence 15, Hostile relationship, Blood tie Mother; Influence 15, Friendly relationship, Blood tie Party buddy; Influence 9, Neutral relationship Restaurant owner; Influence 9, Disliking relationship Hostess; Influence 9, Disliking relationship, Attraction **Believing Priest**

Limitations

- Depression: Maximum Wellbeing 8 [2 points]
- Code of Honor (basic): Offer help and protection for the needy [1 point]

- Code of Honor (basic): Uphold the name of the One [1 point]
- Nightmares [2 points]
- Fear (noticeable): Servants of the State (Stapo) [2 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Children (vulnerable children) [2 points] **Traits**
- Body type: Thin [1 extra point]
- Quirk: Firearms [1 extra point]
- Standard of Living: 6 [2 points]
- Reputation: Talked about (6) within the Church [2 points]
- Sickly [1 extra point]
- Strong-willed [3 points]
- Size: Well-built [1 point]
- Talented: Leadership [4 points]
- Fortune's favorite [1 point] **Character Traits** Lustful (guilt-ridden) Very convinced (believer)

Relationships

Bishop; Influence 12, Neutral relationship State official; Influence 12, Hostile relationship Lost housewife; Influence 6, Benevolent relationship, Attraction **Tired and Worn Worker**

Limitations

- Depression: Maximum Wellbeing 8 [2 points]
- Family: Three narrator characters, [4 points]
- In debt: Heavily indebted [2 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Alcohol (beer), [2 points] **Traits**
- Iron health [2 points]
- Size: Tall [2 points]
- Resilient [2 points]
- Talented: Construction [4 points] **Character Traits** Cautious (careful) Honest (principled) Loving (his/her family)

Relationships

Spouse; Influence 12, Friendly relationship, Attraction/Passion, Blood tie Son/daughter; Influence 6, Benevolent relationship, Blood tie Son/daughter; Influence 6, Benevolent relationship, Blood tie Coworker;

Influence 6, Neutral relationship Bar owner; Influence 12, Neutral relationship Foreman; Influence 9, Disliking relationship **Daring Adventurer**

Limitations

- Wanted: Minor crimes [1 point]
- Code of Honor (basic): Never betray or leave a friend in danger [1 point]
- Fear (noticeable): Responsibility [2 points]
- Indebtedness: Completely indebted [2 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Gambling (card games) [2 points]
- Weakness (noticeable): Opposite sex (appropriate superficial inclination) [2 points] **Traits**
- Bad drunk [1 extra point]
- Fatalist [3 points]
- Iron health [2 points]
- Quirk: Sense [1 extra point]
- Quick [2 points]
- Easily influenced [1 extra point]
- Damaged hand [2 extra points]
- Lucky: Luck 4 [4 points]
- Appearance: Handsome/beautiful [2 points]
- Fortune's favorite [2 points] **Character Traits** Lustful (easily aroused) Very risk-prone (daring)

Relationships

Debt collector; Influence 12, Hostile relationship Pilot; Influence 12, Neutral relationship Rich lover/mistress; Influence 15, Benevolent relationship, **Attraction Adventure-seeking Dilettante**

Limitations

- Family: Three narrator characters [4 points]
- Code of Honor (basic): Never lose composure among people [1 point]
- Weakness (noticeable): Alcohol (vintage wine) [2 points]
- Weakness (tangible): Masochism (self-torture) [3 points] **Traits**
- Charming [2 points]
- Quirk: Sense [1 extra point]

- Quirk: Worldliness [1 extra point]
- Standard of Living 9 [8 points]
- Reputation: Talked about (6) within high society [2 points]
- Strong-willed [2 points]
- Slow learner [3 extra points]
- Appearance: Attractive [1 point] **Character Traits** Arrogant (snobbish, vain) Lustful (amorous)

Relationships

Grandfather; Influence 15, Neutral relationship, Blood tie Aunt; Influence 9, Hostile relationship, Blood tie Brother/sister; Influence 9, Benevolent relationship, Attraction/ Passion, Blood tie Lover/mistress; Influence 6, Benevolent relationship, **Attraction** Restaurant owner; Influence 9, Hostile relationship Family member; Influence 15, Neutral relationship "I prefer that you not buy me a drink." "Why not?" "I am a married woman." "And that means?" "That I do not seek your company." "Then you would have said you were a happily married woman." — Marlena Illianescu and **Gabriel Jandaran**

What separates those who know from those who think they know is that the former possess practical experience, tricks and insights that amateurs cannot use through improvisation. This deeper understanding of, and insight into, a subject is collectively called expertise, and it gives the user clear advantages in situations where the expertise can be applied. **Areas of Expertise** A person can possess expertise in an ability. This means that the knowledge or skill in the ability is directed toward a specific subject, a specific maneuver or a specific situation, thus a narrower delimited subject within the broad ability. Next to each ability are suggestions for areas of expertise, but nothing prevents a narrator from inventing more.

Expertise often gives a bonus to a roll if its conditions are met. For example, Weapon handling (Automatic pistol) is an area of expertise for the ability Firearms — when a person who possesses the expertise shoots with a pistol he/she gets a bonus, but if the person shoots with a shotgun instead the expertise's effect does not count. Areas of expertise have no value of their own that is increased but either you have them or not.

A person who gets a bonus from several different areas of expertise adds these together. This can mean that certain combinations of expertise can give high bonuses, which is the intention.

Unless otherwise stated, the general rule is that an area of expertise can only be chosen once.

Complexity & Requirements Areas of expertise have two values beyond the effect: complexity and requirements.

Complexity shows how difficult and comprehensive the area of expertise is. A person can at most possess areas of expertise whose total sum in complexity is equal to or lower than the person's ability value in the current ability. Complexity also shows how much experience the expertise costs, see page 222.

Requirements show what minimum ability value is required in the ability for a person to be able to learn the expertise. If the person's ability value does not reach the value under requirements then the person cannot learn the expertise. Other requirements may also be listed, such as that the person must possess expertise in another field, for example.

Expertises

Determination

Alert [3] The person has a natural ability to learn things from their surroundings. Requirements: Determination 7+, Quick learner Rule: Increase the person's Learning by one (+1). "It's just a flesh wound..." [3] The person does not accept that he/she is mortally wounded. Requirements: Determination 7+ Rule: If the person succeeds with a difficulty roll (Determination) with penalty (−5) he/she gets to reroll a failed difficulty roll (Will to live), when he/she has just been mortally wounded. The attempt increases the person's Stupor by the value of the highest die, regardless of whether the roll succeeds or not. Stubborn [2] The person refuses to give up. Requirements: Determination 7+ Rule: If the person succeeds with a difficulty roll (Determination) with penalty (−5) he/she gets to make a new attempt to carry out an action that just failed. The expertise can only be used with a failed difficulty roll, not with resistance rolls, and may only be used once per game session. Stubborn as sin [3] The person really does not accept that he/she is mortally wounded. Requirements: Determination 10+, "It's just a flesh wound..." Rule: If the person succeeds with a difficulty roll (Determination) with penalty (−2) he/she gets to reroll a failed difficulty roll (Will to live), when he/she has just been mortally wounded. The attempt increases the person's Stupor by the sum of the value of all dice, regardless of whether the roll succeeds or not. Focus [2] The person can effectively shut out disturbing elements from the surroundings. Requirements: Determination 4+ Rule: With a successful difficulty roll (Determination) the person gets for as many rounds as the value of the lowest die to ignore penalties from external influence (for example rain, blinding light, disturbing sounds, etcetera.) on the task that is the subject of the focus. Each attempt to focus wears on the person, who receives as much Stupor as the value of the highest die. High-performing [3] The person has a natural ability to learn things from their surroundings. Requirements: Determination 10+, Alert Rule: Increase the person's Learning by one (+1). Quick learner [2] The person has a natural ability to learn things from their surroundings. Requirements: Determination 4+ Rule: Increase the person's Learning by one (+1). Obstinate [4] The person does not know what giving up is. Requirements: Determination 13+, Persistent Rule: If the person succeeds with a difficulty roll (Determination) he/she gets to make a new attempt to carry out an action that just failed. The expertise can only be used with a failed difficulty roll, not with resistance rolls, and may only be used once per scene. Persistent [3] The person really refuses to give up. Requirements: Determination 10+, Stubborn Rule: If the person succeeds with a difficulty roll (Determination) with penalty (−2) he/she gets to make a new attempt to carry out an action that just failed. The expertise can only be used with a failed difficulty roll, not with resistance rolls, and may only be used once per game session. Endure strain [3] The person manages strains through willpower. Requirements: Determination 10+ Rule: Increase the person's Will to live by one (+1). "Inside the courthouse you make sure to keep your mouth shut, don't say a word, don't react, don't let yourself be provoked. If you get a direct question then just answer 'yes' or 'no' and always add 'Your Honor'. If you manage to keep calm you might avoid the Fort. You got yourself into this mess, but you did right in hiring me, because I am the best you can get. Now you do your part and I'll do mine. Hopefully we can shake hands outside the halls of justice after this, rather than you shaking bars." — Franko Millovy **Handling** This section is laid out so that the summary of the expertises is on pages 60–61 and are sorted by requirements, while the reference section is sorted alphabetically for each ability. The idea is to first use the table to see which expertises a protagonist can acquire at all, given the different ability values he or she has.

Then use the reference section to get more detailed information about each expertise.

To directly use the reference section to see the connections and links between different expertises can easily seem unmanageable — then use the table for overview.

Expertise [Complexity] Requirement Page

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Amateur in (sport)	[1]	(Ability) 4+	79
Practitioner in (sport)	[1]	(Ability) 7+, Amateur in (sport)	79
Professional in (sport)	[2]	(Ability) 10+, Practitioner in (sport)	79

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Focus	[2]	Resolve 4+	59
Quick Learner	[2]	Resolve 4+	59
Alert	[3]	Resolve 7+, Quick Learner	59
"It's Just a Flesh Wound..."	[3]	Resolve 7+	59
Stubborn	[2]	Resolve 7+	59
Stubborn as Sin	[3]	Resolve 10+, "It's Just a Flesh Wound..."	59
High Performer	[3]	Resolve 10+, Alert	59
Persistent	[3]	Resolve 10+, Stubborn	59
Endure Hardship	[3]	Resolve 10+	59
Obstinate	[4]	Resolve 13+, Persistent	59

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Charismatic	[2]	Charm 4+	62
Very Charismatic	[2]	Charm 7+, Charismatic (within sphere)	62
Exceptionally Charismatic	[3]	Charm 10+, Very Charismatic (within sphere)	62

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Read Person	[2]	Empathy 4+	62
Animal Friend	[3]	Empathy 4+	62
Understanding	[2]	Empathy 4+	62
Sympathetic	[2]	Empathy 7+, Understanding	62
Comfort & Calm	[2]	Empathy 4+	62
Intuitive	[4]	Empathy 7+	62
Tangible Reading	[2]	Empathy 7+, Read Person	62
Intense Reading	[4]	Empathy 10+, Tangible Reading	62

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Pickpocket	[2]	Manual Dexterity 4+	63
Lockpicking	[2]	Manual Dexterity 4+	63

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Tricks	[1]	Manual Dexterity 4+	63
Experienced Pickpocket	[2]	Manual Dexterity 7+, Pickpocket	62
Improvised Picking	[3]	Manual Dexterity 7+, Locksmith	63
Locksmith	[2]	Manual Dexterity 7+, Lockpicking	63
Conjuror	[2]	Manual Dexterity 7+, Tricks	63
Illusionist	[3]	Manual Dexterity 10+, Conjuror	63
Lock Specialist	[3]	Manual Dexterity 10+, Locksmith	63
Master Pickpocket	[3]	Manual Dexterity 10+, Experienced Pickpocket	63

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Driver	[1]	Vehicles 4+	63
Locomotive Engineer	[1]	Vehicles 4+	63
Airman	[1]	Vehicles 4+	64
Pilot	[2]	Vehicles 4+	64
Skipper	[1]	Vehicles 4+	64
Experienced Driver	[2]	Vehicles 7+, Driver	63
Veteran	[3]	Vehicles 7+, Pilot	64
Master Driver	[3]	Vehicles 10+, Experienced Driver	64
Ace	[3]	Vehicles 10+, Veteran	64

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Academic Specialization	[2]	Humanities 4+	64
Linguist	[2]	Humanities 4+	64
Academic Specialist	[2]	Humanities 7+, Academic Specialization (within field)	64
Academic Authority	[3]	Humanities 10+, Academic Specialist (within field)	64

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Gut Feeling	[2]	Intuition 4+	64
Inspiration	[2]	Intuition 4+	64
Instinct	[2]	Intuition 4+	64
Sense of Direction	[1]	Intuition 4+	64
Eyes in the Back of Your Head	[2]	Intuition 4+	65
"Something's Wrong"	[2]	Intuition 7+, Instinct	65

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
See Through Person	[3]	Intuition 7+, Instinct	65
Self-Preservation Instinct	[3]	Intuition 7+, Instinct	65
Vigilant	[2]	Intuition 7+, Eyes in the Back of Your Head	65
Sixth Sense	[4]	Intuition 10+, Vigilant	65

Expertise [Complexity] Requirement Page

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Throwing Technique	[2]	Throwing Weapons 4+	65
Combat Ready	[2]	Throwing Weapons 4+	66
Avoid	[2]	Throwing Weapons 4+	66
Sidestep	[3]	Throwing Weapons 7+	66
Draw and Throw	[3]	Throwing Weapons 7+, Throwing Specialist	65
"Bullseye"	[3]	Throwing Weapons 7+, Throwing Specialist	65
Throwing Specialist	[2]	Throwing Weapons 7+, Throwing Technique (type of throwing weapon)	65
Precision Throw	[2]	Throwing Weapons 7+, Throwing Technique (type of throwing weapon)	66
Double Throw	[3]	Throwing Weapons 10+, Throwing Specialist	65
Repetition	[2]	Throwing Weapons 10+, Draw and Throw	66
Killing Throw	[4]	Throwing Weapons 13+, "Bullseye"	65
Double Targets	[3]	Throwing Weapons 13+, Double Throw	65
Master Sidestep	[3]	Throwing Weapons 13+, Sidestep	66

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Diving	[2]	Stamina 4+, Swimming	66
Good Shape	[2]	Stamina 4+	66
March	[1]	Stamina 4+	66
Swimming	[1]	Stamina 4+	66
Sprint	[1]	Stamina 4+	66
Very Good Shape	[2]	Stamina 7+, Good Shape	66
Tenacious	[2]	Stamina 7+	66

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Strong Lungs	[2]	Stamina 7+	66
Exceptionally Good Shape	[3]	Stamina 10+, Very Good Shape	66
Very Tenacious	[3]	Stamina 10+, Tenacious	66
Take It Like a Man	[4]	Stamina 10+	66
Extremely Tenacious	[3]	Stamina 13+, Tenacious	66
Fantastically Good Shape	[4]	Stamina 13+, Exceptionally Good Shape	66

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Technical Specialization	[2]	Engineering 4+	67
Technical Specialist	[2]	Engineering 7+, Technical Specialization (within area)	67
Technical Authority	[3]	Engineering 10+, Technical Specialist (within area)	67

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Animal Trainer	[2]	Leadership 4+	67
Presence	[2]	Leadership 4+	68
Rhetoric	[2]	Leadership 4+	68
Teach	[2]	Leadership 4+	68
Gravitas	[2]	Leadership 7+, Rhetoric (grouping)	68
Commanding Respect	[2]	Leadership 7+, Presence	68
Intimidating	[2]	Leadership 7+, Rhetoric	68
Train	[2]	Leadership 7+, Teach	68
Control	[3]	Leadership 10+, Gravitas (grouping)	67
Brilliant Pedagogue	[3]	Leadership 10+, Train	67

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Medical Specialization	[2]	Medicine 4+	68
Medical Specialist	[2]	Medicine 7+, Medical Specialization (within area)	68
Medical Authority	[3]	Medicine 10+, Medical Specialist (within area)	68

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Perceptive	[2]	Resist 4+	68
Very Perceptive	[2]	Resist 7+, Perceptive	68
Exceptionally Perceptive	[3]	Resist 10+, Very Perceptive	68

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Natural Science Specialization	[2]	Natural Science 4+	69
Natural Science Specialist	[2]	Natural Science 7+, Natural Science Specialization (within field)	69
Natural Science Authority	[3]	Natural Science 10+, Natural Science Specialist (within field)	68

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Amateur Boxing	[2]	Melee 4+	69
Martial Arts Trained	[2]	Melee 4+	69
Melee Weapons	[2]	Melee 4+	69
Self-Defense	[2]	Melee 4+	70
Brawl	[2]	Melee 4+	70
Combat Prepared	[2]	Melee 4+	70
Wrestling	[2]	Melee 7+, Brawl	69
Defensive Techniques	[3]	Melee 7+, Martial Arts Trained	70
Counterattack	[3]	Melee 7+	69
Offensive Techniques	[3]	Melee 7+, Martial Arts Trained	69

List of All Expertises

Expertise [Complexity] Requirement Page

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Parry	[2]	Melee 7+, Melee Weapons (type of melee weapon)	69
Professional Boxing	[3]	Melee 7+, Amateur Boxing	70
Slugger	[2]	Melee 7+, Brawl	70
Chokehold	[4]	Melee 7+	70
Two-Weapon Practitioner	[3]	Melee 7+, Weapon Master	70
Weapon Master	[2]	Melee 7+, Melee Weapons (type of melee weapon)	70
Block	[2]	Melee 10+, Defensive Techniques	69
Draw and Attack	[2]	Melee 10+, Weapon Master	69
Knockout Blow	[3]	Melee 10+, Professional Boxing	69
Clean Strikes	[3]	Melee 10+, Weapon Master	70

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Strike Sequences	[2]	Melee 10+, Offensive Techniques	70
Superiority	[2]	Melee 10+, Defensive Techniques	70
Neutralize	[3]	Melee 13+, Defensive Techniques	69
Precision Attacks	[3]	Melee 13+, Strike Sequences	70
Two-Weapon Master	[3]	Melee 13+, Two-Weapon Practitioner	70

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Duck	[2]	Reactions 4+	70
Blast Sense	[2]	Reactions 4+	70
Nimble	[2]	Reactions 4+	71
Quick Reactions	[2]	Reactions 4+	71
Lightning Parry	[2]	Reactions 7+	70
Rapid Movement	[2]	Reactions 7+	71
See Opportunities	[3]	Reactions 7+	71
Spinal Reflex	[2]	Reactions 7+	71
Combat Impulses	[2]	Reactions 7+, Quick Reactions	71
Combat Reflexes	[3]	Reactions 10+, Combat Impulses	71
Exploit the Situation	[3]	Reactions 10+, See Opportunities	71

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Jaded	[2]	Resistance 4+	71
Fearless	[3]	Resistance 4+	71
Very Jaded	[2]	Resistance 7+, Jaded	71
Extremely Jaded	[3]	Resistance 10+, Very Jaded	71
Nerves of Steel	[2]	Resistance 10+	71
Insensitive to Pain	[4]	Resistance 13+	71

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Agile	[1]	Mobility 4+	72
Breakfall Technique	[2]	Mobility 7+	71
Flexible	[2]	Mobility 7+, Agile (within area)	72
Fast	[2]	Mobility 7+	72
Fleet-Footed	[2]	Mobility 10+, Fast	71

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Graceful	[3]	Mobility 10+, Flexible (within area)	71

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Aura of Calm	[2]	Sanity 4+	72
Ice Cold	[3]	Sanity 4+	72
Self-Discipline	[3]	Sanity 4+	73
Inner Reserve	[2]	Sanity 7+, Self-Discipline	72
Strong-Willed	[3]	Sanity 7+	73
Balanced Psyche	[4]	Sanity 10+, Self-Discipline	72
Inner Calm	[3]	Sanity 10+, Strong-Willed	72
Come to One's Senses	[2]	Sanity 10+, Self-Discipline	72
Wellspring	[3]	Sanity 10+, Inner Reserve	73
Play Dead	[4]	Sanity 10+, Self-Discipline	73
Cheat Death	[5]	Sanity 13+, Self-Discipline	73
Self-Healing	[5]	Sanity 13+, Self-Discipline	73

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Creator	[2]	Create 4+	73
Outstanding Creator	[2]	Create 7+, Creator (within area)	73
Virtuoso	[3]	Create 10+, Outstanding Creator (within area)	73

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Much Lead in the Air	[2]	Firearms 4+, Weapon Handling (correct weapon category)	74
Suppressive Fire	[2]	Firearms 4+, Weapon Handling (correct weapon category)	74
Battle Hardened	[2]	Firearms 4+	75
Take Cover	[2]	Firearms 4+	75
Weapon Expert	[1]	Firearms 4+, Weapon Handling (correct weapon category)	75
Weapon Handling	[2]	Firearms 4+	75

Expertise [Complexity] Requirement Page

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Hail of Bullets	[2]	Firearms 7+, Much Lead in the Air	74
Massive Return Fire	[3]	Firearms 7+, Two-Gun Shooting	74

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Return Fire	[3]	Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert	74
Marksmanship	[3]	Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert (a rifle with scope)	74
Shot Placement	[2]	Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert	74
Heavy Weapons Specialist	[4]	Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert (a heavy weapon)	75
"Take Cover!"	[2]	Firearms 7+	75
Two-Gun Shooting	[3]	Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert (some one-handed firearm)	75
Controlled Fire	[3]	Firearms 10+, Weapon Expert	73
Double Reload	[2]	Firearms 10+, Two-Gun Shooting	74
Double Tap	[3]	Firearms 10+, Weapon Expert (some one-handed firearm)	74
Multiple Targets	[3]	Firearms 10+, Two-Gun Shooting	74
"Close Only Counts in Horseshoes!"	[3]	Firearms 10+, "Take Cover!"	74
Quick Draw	[2]	Firearms 10+, Weapon Expert	75
Critical Hits	[2]	Firearms 10+, Shot Placement	74
Escape	[2]	Firearms 10+, "Take Cover!"	75
Gun Play	[2]	Firearms 10+, Weapon Expert	75
Executioner	[4]	Firearms 13+, Weapon Expert	73
Many Targets	[4]	Firearms 13+, Multiple Targets	74
"Two in the Head and One in the Chest"	[4]	Firearms 13+, Weapon Expert	75

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Clear-Minded	[2]	Deduction 4+	75
Smart	[2]	Deduction 7+, Clear-Minded (within area)	75
Genius	[3]	Deduction 10+, Smart (within area)	75

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Lift/Drag	[1]	Strength 4+	77
Well-Trained	[2]	Strength 4+	77
Beefy	[2]	Strength 7+, Well-Trained	77

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Lead Fists	[2]	Strength 7+	77
Menacing	[2]	Strength 7+, Beefy	77
Iron Fists	[2]	Strength 10+, Lead Fists	77
Muscular	[3]	Strength 10+, Beefy	77
Robust	[3]	Strength 10+, Beefy	77
Strike/Break Objects	[3]	Strength 10+, Lead Fists	77
Enormously Strong	[3]	Strength 13+, Muscular	77
Pulverize/Tear Apart Objects	[4]	Strength 13+, Strike/Break Objects	77
Steel Fists	[3]	Strength 13+, Iron Fists	77

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Resilient	[2]	Tolerance 4+	77
Withdrawal Control	[2]	Tolerance 7+	77
Very Resilient	[2]	Tolerance 7+, Resilient	77
Exceptionally Resilient	[3]	Tolerance 10+, Very Resilient	77

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Observant	[2]	Awareness 4+	78
Very Observant	[2]	Awareness 7+, Observant (within area)	78
Extremely Observant	[3]	Awareness 10+, Very Observant (within area)	77

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Polite	[2]	Streetwise 4+	78
Well-Versed	[1]	Streetwise 4+	78
Know the Situation	[2]	Streetwise 4+	78
Local Knowledge	[1]	Streetwise 4+	78
Gambler	[1]	Streetwise 4+	79
Well-Dressed	[2]	Streetwise 4+	79
Fixer	[3]	Streetwise 7+, Know the Situation	78
In-Depth Local Knowledge	[2]	Streetwise 7+, Local Knowledge	78
Very Well-Versed	[2]	Streetwise 7+, Well-Versed (grouping)	78
Skilled Gambler	[2]	Streetwise 7+, Gambler (type of game)	79
Style & Taste	[2]	Streetwise 7+, Well-Dressed	79

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Extremely Well-Versed	[3]	Streetwise 10+, Very Well-Versed (grouping)	78
Very Skilled Gambler	[2]	Streetwise 10+, Skilled Gambler (type of game)	78

Expertise	Complexity	Requirement	Page
Convincing	[2]	Persuade 4+	79
Very Convincing	[2]	Persuade 7+, Convincing (within sphere)	79
Extremely Convincing	[3]	Persuade 10+, Very Convincing (within sphere)	79

List of All Expertises

Requirements: Empathy 10+, Tangible Reading **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Empathy) when using tangible reading. This bonus is added to other bonuses.

Intuitive [4]

The person can put themselves in other people's situations, analyze them from their perspective, and can draw conclusions so real that they appear lifelike in the per-son's mind.

Requirements: Empathy 7+ **Rule:** The person finds it easy to subconsciously sense things about other people and can put themselves in others' situa-tions in an eerily effective way. This understanding is often very intense and fraught with anxiety. By reading criminal records, psychological evaluations, police reports, and inter-view summaries, the person can form a picture of another person's habits, likely behaviors, underlying drives, and motives. When an intuitive person who has studied a case thoroughly visits a crime scene or communicates with a suspect, the person may receive inner fragmentary im-ages of events that have occurred. These images often appear very frightening and tangible.

To receive such images requires the person to succeed with a difficulty roll (Empathy), with a penalty (−5). If the roll succeeds, the person receives a bonus (+2) in all forms of communi-cation with a chosen individual whom the person knows through study. This bonus applies primarily to dice rolls (Empathy) but also to other forms of communication. The person may also use the bonus for dice rolls (Resist) in situa-tions where the chosen individual is present. The bonus is also applied to dice rolls (Deduction) related to a case in which the person is well-versed.

Tangible Reading [2]

The person is very receptive to subconsciously interpreting people and understanding their state of mind.

Requirements: Empathy 7+, Reading **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Empathy) when using reading. This bonus is added to the previous bonus.

Sympathetic [2]

The person is perceived as sympathetic.

Requirements: Empathy 7+, Understanding **Rule:** The person's Impression value increases by one (+1).

Comfort & Calm [2]

The person possesses an ability to calm and comfort sad and upset people.

Requirements: Empathy 4+ **Rule:** The person receives a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Empathy) when attempting to calm or comfort other individuals.

Dexterity

Experienced Pickpocket [2] The person is very skilled at performing a specialized form of pickpocketing.

Requirements: Dexterity 7+, Pickpocket (within the form)

Charm

Exceptionally Charismatic [3] The person is a specialist within their sphere.

Requirements: Charm 10+, Very Charismatic (within the sphere) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Charm) within a sphere where they are very charismatic. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per sphere.

Charismatic [2]

The person is knowledgeable within their sphere.

Requirements: Charm 4+ **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Charm) within a sphere they master. Choose one of the following: Act/Perform, Deceive/Manipulate, Seduce/ Captivate, Mingle/Converse, Sing/Play, Flatter/ Fawn, Entertain/Amuse. Write down which sphere the person masters well. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per sphere.

Very Charismatic [2]

The person is experienced within their sphere.

Requirements: Charm 7+, Charismatic (within the sphere) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Charm) within a sphere where they are charismatic. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per sphere.

Empathy

Reading [2] The person is receptive to subconsciously interpreting peo-ple and understanding their state of mind.

Requirements: Empathy 4+ **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Empathy) when it comes to noticing what state of mind a person is in.

Animal Friend [3]

Animals do not attack the person as they possess a natural aura of calm and respect that animals perceive.

Requirements: Empathy 4+ **Rule:** The person rolls a difficulty roll (Empathy) to keep the animal calm. This roll receives a bonus (+5) and the chosen animal is calm for as many minutes as the lowest die value. If the animal is extremely aggressive or affected by, for example, drugs, the person can only keep it calm for a short while. In that case, the animal stays calm for as many rounds as the lowest die value.

Understanding [2]

The person's understanding manner makes individuals around them feel at ease.

Requirements: Empathy 4+ **Rule:** The person's Impression value increases by one (+1).

Intense Reading [4]

The person is extremely receptive to subconsciously interpreting people and understanding their state of mind.

Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Dex-terity) for a special form of pickpocketing where the person is already a pickpocket. This bonus is added to the previous bon-us. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per form.

Pickpocket [2]

The person is skilled at performing a specialized form of pick-pocketing.

Requirements: Dexterity 4+ **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Dex-terity) for a special form of pickpocketing they master. Choose one of the following: Planting, Stealing rings/ jewelry/watches, Stealing from handbags/pockets. Write down which form the person masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per form.

Illusionist [3]

The person is a very skilled magician.

Requirements: Dexterity 10+, Magician (within the area) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Dex-terity) within an area where they are already a magi-cian. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The exper-tise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area.

Improvised Lockpicking [3]

The person is skilled at using improvised objects to open locks.

Requirements: Dexterity 7+, Locksmith (within the lock type) **Rule:** The person receives no penalties when using improvised objects, such as hairpins, paper clips, or drinking glasses (for combination locks), to pick locks.

Lockpicking [2]

The person can open locks without access to a key or combination.

Requirements: Dexterity 4+ **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Dex-terity) to open a certain type of lock. Choose one of the following lock types: Car Lock, Door Lock, Padlock, Combination Lock, Security Lock. Write down which lock type the person masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per lock type.

Locksmith [2]

The person is skilled at opening locks without access to a key or combination.

Requirements: Dexterity 7+, Lockpicking (within the lock type) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Dex-terity) to open a type of lock they can already pick. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The exper-tise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per lock type.

Lock Specialist [3]

The person is a specialist at opening locks.

Requirements: Dexterity 10+, Locksmith (within the lock type) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Dex-terity) to open a certain type of lock where they are a locksmith. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per lock type.

Masterful Pickpocket [3]

The person is classified as a masterful pickpocket regarding a spe-cial form of pickpocketing.

Requirements: Dexterity 10+, Experienced Pickpocket (within the for-m) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Dex-terity) for a special form of pickpocketing where they are already an experienced pickpocket. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times but only once per form.

Tricks [1]

The person is versed in some magic tricks.

Requirements: Dexterity 4+ **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Dex-terity) within an area they master. Choose one of the following areas: Distraction, Conceal in/produce from hand, Card tricks/Coin tricks, Steady hands. Write down which area the person masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area.

Magician [2]

The person is an experienced conjuror.

Requirements: Dexterity 7+, Tricks (within the area) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Dex-terity) within an area where they master tricks. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area.

Vehicle

Experienced Driver [2] The person is skilled at operating and maneuvering a type of vehicle.

Requirements: Vehicle 7+, Driver (within the vehicle type) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Vehi-cle) for maneuvering a type of vehicle where they are already a driver. This bonus is added to the previous bon-us. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per vehicle type.

Driver [1]

The person can operate and maneuver a type of vehicle.

Requirements: Vehicle 4+ **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Vehi-cle) for maneuvering a certain type of vehicle. Choose one of the following vehicle types: Car, Bicycle, Canoe, Horse, Horse-drawn

wagon, Truck, Motorboat, Motorcycle, Sailboat, Tank. Write down which vehicle type the person masters. The exper-tise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per vehicle type.

Train Engineer [1]

The person can operate and maneuver a locomotive.

Requirements: Vehicle 4+ **Rule:** The person knows how to control and handle a locomotive with accompanying cars. Without this know-ledge, the person can neither start nor operate a locomotive whatsoever.

Additional Expertise Areas

Nothing prevents a player and narrator from creating new expertise areas together. Try to balance them based on the existing expertise areas so they don't become too weak or too powerful.

Airship Pilot [1]

The person can operate and maneuver a zeppelin.

Requirements: Vehicle 4+ **Rule:** The person knows how to control and handle a zeppelin. Without this knowledge, the person can neither start nor maneuver a zeppelin whatsoever.

Master Driver [3]

The person is very skilled at operating and maneuvering a type of vehicle.

Requirements: Vehicle 10+, Experienced Driver (within the vehicle type) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Vehi-cle) for maneuvering a type of vehicle where they are already an experienced driver. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per vehicle type.

Pilot [2]

The person can fly an aircraft type.

Requirements: Vehicle 4+ **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Vehicle) for maneuvering a certain type of aircraft. Choose one of the fol-lowing types: Small aircraft, Medium aircraft, Large air-craft. Write down which type the person masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per aircraft type.

Captain [1]

The person can operate and maneuver a vessel.

Requirements: Vehicle 4+ **Rule:** The person knows how to pilot and operate a vessel. Without this knowledge, the person can neither start nor maneuver a vessel whatsoever.

Veteran [3]

The person is an experienced aviator of a certain aircraft type.

Requirements: Vehicle 7+, Pilot (within the aircraft type) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Vehi-cle) for maneuvering an aircraft type where they are already a pilot. This bonus is added to the previous

bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per aircraft type.

Ace [3]

The person is an expert at flying.

Requirements: Vehicle 10+, Veteran (within the aircraft type) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Vehi-cle) for maneuvering an aircraft type where they are already a veteran. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per aircraft type.

Humanities

Academic Authority [3] The person is a specialist within a field.

Requirements: Humanities 10+, Academic Specialist (within the field) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Humani-ties) within a field where they are an academic specialist. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be cho-sen multiple times, but only once per field.

Academic Focus [2]

The person is knowledgeable within a subject or field.

Requirements: Humanities 4+ **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Humani-ties) within a field they master. Choose one of the fol-lowing: Administration/Organization, Archaeology/Anthropology, Economics/Bookkeeping, Philosophy, Geography/History, Heraldry/Semi-otics, Law/Political Science, Art History/Literary Studies, Criminology/Profiling, Linguistics, Psychology/Sociology, Reli-gion/Occultism. Write down which field the person masters well. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field.

Academic Specialist [2]

The person is experienced within a field.

Requirements: Humanities 7+, Academic Focus (within the field) **Rule:** The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Humani-ties) within a field where they have an academic focus. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field.

Linguist [2]

The person masters a foreign language.

Requirements: Humanities 4+ **Rule:** All people can speak, read, and write their mother tongue without problems. This expertise provides both oral and written knowledge in a foreign language. The languages that exist in the Imperium are described on page 170. The expertise can be cho-sen multiple times as long as a new language is chosen.

Intuition

Touch [2] The person knows how to interact with others so that they feel good.

Requirements: Intuition 4+ **Rule:** The person's Impression value increases by one (+1).

Inspiration [2]

The person's subconscious helps them when danger is afoot.

Requirements: Intuition 4+ **Rule:** Increase the person's Awareness by one (+1).

Instinct [2]

The person listens to their inner voice and gut feeling to receive guidance in life and to make decisions.

Requirements: Intuition 4+ **Rule:** When the person visits a place or finds themselves in a certain situation and succeeds with a difficulty roll (Intuition) with a bonus (+2), they can sense if something is not right. It is just a feeling and provides no concrete information about the place/situation.

Sense of Direction [1]

The person has a good sense of direction.

Requirements: Intuition 4+ **Rule:** The person always knows which direction north is and finds it easy to find their way and orient themselves. They often see a three-dimensional map before their mind's eye, with the places, areas, and streets they want to find.

"Something's wrong" [2] The person is subconsciously vigilant to threats and reacts with lightning speed. Requirement: Intuition 7+, Instinct Rule: If the person is surprised in a combat situation (see page 254), the person automatically gets to make a difficulty roll (Intu-ition). If the roll succeeds, the person is not considered surprised. See through person [3] The person has an easy time detecting whether another person is lying or not. Requirement: Intuition 7+, Instinct Rule: The person makes a resistance roll (Intuition) with a bonus (+2). If the roll succeeds, the person can determine if an indi-vidual is lying or not. The expertise cannot be used to see exactly what the lie consists of, but gives a general feeling that the individual is being dishonest. Self-preservation instinct [3] The person has an instinctive sense of self-preservation. Requirement: Intuition 7+, Instinct Rule: Increase the person's Defense by one (+1). Sixth sense [4] The person has developed a sixth sense that warns when danger is present. Requirement: Intuition 10+, Vigilant Rule: The person gets a bonus (+5) on rolls (Intuition) when it comes to generally detecting danger. This bonus is added to the others from eyes in the back of your head and vigilant. Vigilant [3] The person has developed an uncanny ability to escape danger by trusting their instincts. Requirement: Intuition 7+, Eyes in the back of your head Rule: The person gets a bonus (+3) on rolls (Intuition) when it comes to detecting danger. This bonus is added to the one from eyes in the back of your head. Eyes in the back of your head [2] The person is in the habit of keeping track of their surroundings and not letting themselves be surprised. Requirement: Intuition 4+ Rule: The person is vigilant by nature, and has a sense of whether danger lurks nearby. Often this is a subtle feel-ing that can manifest in the hairs on the neck standing up, the throat becoming dry, or similar. Exactly what constitutes the danger the per-son cannot determine and the sense is not entirely reliable. The per-son gets a bonus (+2) on rolls (Intuition) to notice when someone is following or intends to surprise him/her. **Throwing Weapons** Draw and throw [3] The person can draw and throw a weapon in one and the same motion. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 7+, Throwing Specialist (within weapon type) Rule: If the person has an Initiative of ten or higher and successfully manages to draw a throwing weapon he/she is a throwing specialist with, the person immediately gets to execute the Initiative action Throw object at target, with the same weapon in the same Initiative. This attack gets a penalty (−5) and lowers the person's Initiative by five (−5) after the attack action, in addition to any initiative modifications that come from the Ini-tiative action's outcome. Killing throw [4] The person is deadly with throwing weapons. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 13+, "Direct hit" (Throwing Specialist within weapon type) Rule: If the person succeeds in executing the Initiative action Throw object at target with a weapon he/she is a throwing spe-cialist with, he/she gets to add 1D to the damage in addition

to the extra damage for "direct hit". Double throw [3] The person can throw two throwing weapons in a single motion. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 10+, Throwing Specialist (within weapon type) Rule: The person can use two already drawn throwing weapons simultaneously. When the person uses the Initiative action Throw object at target, he/she gets to add together the throwing weapons' dam-age. The attack gets a penalty (−5). This expertise can only be executed if the person is a throwing specialist with the weapons used. Dual targets [3] The person is expert at throwing at two different targets with one throwing weapon in each hand. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 13+, Double throw (throwing specialist within weapon type) Rule: When the person uses the Initiative action Throw object at target with throwing weapons he/she is a throwing specialist with, he/she can choose to hit two targets. The thrower rolls only once, with a penalty (−5). Both targets get to defend themselves, and if anyone is damaged, the damage value is counted as being the weapon's normal, without any additional modification. "Direct hit" [3] The person knows how to hit to do great damage. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 7+, Throwing Specialist (within weapon type) Rule: If the person succeeds in executing the Initiative action Throw object at target with a weapon he/she is a throwing spe-cialist with, he/she gets to add 1D to the damage. Throwing Specialist [2] The person is expert at handling one type of throwing weapon. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 7+, Throwing Technique (within weapon type) Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) when he/she uses a throwing weapon he/she can already handle. Write down which weapon type the person is expert with. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per weapon type. Throwing Technique [2] The person is skilled at handling one type of throwing weapon. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) when he/she uses a specific type of throwing weapon (for example Throwing Knife or Hand grenade). Write down which weapon type the person handles. The exper-tise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per weapon type. Note that the bonus applies to all combat actions where the weapon is an active part – from drawing that weapon to throwing it.

Rule: If the person becomes mortally wounded, he/she gets five extra rounds before he/she dies. These rounds are added together with those from hard to kill and very hard to kill. Fantastically good shape [4] The person is in fantastically good shape. Requirement: Endurance 13+, Exceptionally good shape Rule: Increase the person's Stamina by one (+1). Good shape [2] The person is in good shape. Requirement: Endurance 4+ Rule: Increase the person's Stamina by one (+1). March [1] The person is well-drilled in marching. Requirement: Endurance 4+ Rule: The person gets a bonus (+2) when he/she uses Endurance to march, see page 243. Very good shape [2] The person is in very good shape. Requirement: Endurance 7+, Good shape Rule: Increase the person's Stamina by one (+1). Very hard to kill [3] The person is very hard to kill. Requirement: Endurance 10+, Hard to kill Rule: If the person becomes mortally wounded, he/she gets three extra rounds before he/she dies. These rounds are added together with those from hard to kill. Hard to kill [2] The person is hard to kill. Requirement: Endurance 7+ Rule: If the person becomes mortally wounded, he/she gets two extra rounds before he/she dies. Swimming [1] All people are assumed to be able to swim, but this person is competent in the water. Requirement: Endurance 4+ Rule: The person gets a bonus (+2) on activities in water. Sprint [1] The person can effectively sprint short distances. Requirement: Endurance 4+ Rule: Increase the person's combat movement by one (+1). Strong lungs [2] The person has good lung capacity. Requirement: Endurance 7+ Rule: The person can hold their breath twice as long as a normal person. Take it like a man [4] The person has a tough physique and can handle hits that would have downed other people. Requirement: Endurance 10+ Rule: Increase the person's Wound Threshold by one (+1). Masterful sidestep [3] The person can effectively defend against ranged attacks. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 13+, Sidestep Rule: Increase the person's Defense against ranged attacks by two (+2). Precision throw [2] The person can throw an object with great accuracy. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 7+, Throwing Technique (within weapon type) Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on the Initiative action Throw object to location when he/she uses a weapon type he/she already has throwing technique in. Sidestep [3] The person can use their knowledge to avoid being hit. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 7+ Rule: Increase the person's Defense

against ranged attacks by one (+1). Combat ready [2] The person is versed in how combat works. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 4+ Rule: Increase the person's Overview by one (+1). Evade [2] The person sacrifices their offensive capacity to avoid attacks. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 4+ Rule: The person can choose to give themselves a bonus to De-fend against a ranged attack. Before he/she rolls their resistance roll, he/she can choose to lower their Initiative by any number of steps, though at lowest to six. Each step the Initiative is lowered gives a bonus (+1) to the resistance roll's result. Repetition [2] The person can after a throw draw a weapon in the same motion. Requirement: Throwing Weapons 10+, Draw and throw Rule: If the person has an Initiative of ten or higher and successfully manages to execute the Initiative action Throw ob-ject at target, the person immediately gets to attempt to draw a new throwing weapon of the same type as the one just thrown. This attempt gets a penalty (−5) and lowers the person's Initiative by five (−5) after the attack action, in addition to any initiative modifica-tions that come from the Initiative action's outcome. **Endurance** Diving [2] The person can without problem stay and act underwater. Requirement: Endurance 4+, Swimming Rule: The person gets a bonus (+2) on activities while diving. Exceptionally good shape [3] The person is in exceptionally good shape. Requirement: Endurance 10+, Very good shape Rule: Increase the person's Stamina by one (+1). Extremely hard to kill [3] The person is extremely hard to kill. Requirement: Endurance 13+, Very hard to kill

Construction

Technical authority [3] The person is a specialist within an area. Requirement: Construction 10+, Technical specialist (area) Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Con-struction) within an area where he/she is already a technical specialist. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area. Technical focus [2] The person is good at building and constructing one type of thing. Requirement: Construction 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Con-struction) within an area he/she masters. Choose one of the following fields: Alarm systems, Bridges, Electrical objects, Vehicles, (Craft), Houses, Throwing weapons, Camp setup, Machines/Motors, Mechanical objects, Melee weapons, Metalwork, Plumbing, Firearms, Carpentry, Explosives. Write down which area the person masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field. Technical specialist [2] The person is technically experienced within an area. Requirement: Construction 7+, Technical focus (area) Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Con-struction) within an area where he/she already has a tech-nical focus. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area. **Leadership** Animal trainer [2] The person can train and handle a certain animal type. Requirement: Leadership 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Leader-ship) to train, control or handle an animal within one of the following types: Dog, Cat, Bear, Horse, Snake, Bird, Mouse/ Rat. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per animal type. Control [3] Through their controlling streak, the person is good at directing people within a group and getting them to obey. Requirement: Leadership 10+, Presence (group) Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Leader-ship) to direct and command, organize and decide within a group where he/she already has presence. This is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per group. Brilliant pedagogue [3] The person can get students to perform better. Requirement: Leadership 10+, Train Rule: If the teacher succeeds with a roll (Leadership), his/her students temporarily get to add five (+5) to their Learning during the current study period. This bonus is added to other bonuses from teach and train.

Presence [2] The person's presence affects those around them. Requirement: Leadership 4+ Rule: The person's Impression value increases by one (+1). Gravitas [2] Through their natural gravitas, the person is skilled at controlling people within a group and getting them to obey. Requirement: Leadership 7+, Rhetoric (group) Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Leadership) for directing and organizing, managing and

commanding within a group where they already have rhetoric. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per group. Commanding Respect [2] The person has an aura of respect around them. Requirement: Leadership 7+, Presence Rule: The person's Impression value increases by one (+1). Rhetoric [2] Through their eloquence, the person is skilled at controlling people within a group and getting them to obey. Requirement: Leadership 4+ Rule: The person gains a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Leadership) for directing and organizing, managing and commanding within one of the following groups: Academic World, General Public, Children, Crime Syndicates, Bureaucrats, Refugees, The Streets, Club Scene, Criminals, The Church, Resistance Groups, Military, Entertainment Industry, Police, Press, Justice System, High Society, Sports World, The State, Clans. Write down which group the person controls within. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per group. Intimidating [2] Through their dominating aura, the person can frighten others. Requirement: Leadership 7+, Rhetoric Rule: The person can roll a dice roll (Leadership) to act threateningly toward people, instead of using Convince. Teach [2] The person can make students perform better. Requirement: Leadership 4+ Rule: If the teacher succeeds with a roll (Leadership), their students temporarily add two (+2) to their Learning during the current study period. Educate [2] The person can make students perform better. Requirement: Leadership 7+, Teach Rule: If the teacher succeeds with a roll (Leadership), their students temporarily add three (+3) to their Learning during the current study period. This bonus is added to the bonus from teach. **Medicine** Medical Authority [3] The person is a specialist within a medical field. Requirement: Medicine 10+, Medical Specialist (field) Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Medicine) within a field where they are already a medical specialist. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field. Medical Focus [2] The person is knowledgeable within a medical field. Requirement: Medicine 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Medicine) within one of the following fields: Anatomy/Surgery/Forensic Medicine, Diagnosis/Healthcare, Pharmaceuticals/Toxicology, First Aid, Psychiatry/Hypnosis, Dentist, Veterinarian. Write down which area the person masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field. Medical Specialist [2] The person is experienced within a medical field. Requirement: Medicine 7+, Medical Focus (field) Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Medicine) within a field where they already have a medical focus. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field. **Resist** Exceptionally Perceptive [3] The person has an exceptionally easy time seeing through social influence. Requirement: Resist 10+, Very Perceptive (type of influence) Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Resist) for seeing through a type of influence where they are already very perceptive. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of influence. Perceptive [2] The person has an easy time seeing through social influence. Requirement: Resist 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Resist) for seeing through any of the following: Seduction, Interrogation Techniques, Threats, Bribery Attempts, Flattery, Persuasion. Write down which type of influence the person easily sees through. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of influence. Very Perceptive [2] The person has a very easy time seeing through social influence. Requirement: Resist 7+, Perceptive (type of influence) Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Resist) for seeing through a type of influence where they are already perceptive. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of influence. **Natural Science** Scientific Authority [3] The person is an authority within a scientific subject. Requirement: Natural Science 10+, Scientific Specialist (subject)

Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Knowledge) within a subject where they are already a Scientific specialist. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per subject. Scientific Focus [2] The person studies/studied within a scientific subject. Requirement: Natural Science 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Knowledge) within a subject they master. Choose one of the following subjects: Acoustics, Architecture, Astronomy, Atomic Physics, Ballistics, Biology,

Botany, Physics, Geology, Chemistry, Mathematics, Material Science, Metallurgy, Meteorology, Optics, Zoology. Write down which subject the person masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per subject. Scientific Specialist [2] The person is a specialist within a scientific subject. Requirement: Natural Science 7+, Scientific Focus (subject) Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Knowledge) within a subject where they already have a scientific focus. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per subject. **Close Combat** Amateur Boxing [2] The person knows the basics of boxing. Requirement: Close Combat 4+ Rule: Increase the person's Defense (for close combat attacks) and Endurance by one (+1) each. Blocking [2] The person is skilled at defending themselves in close combat. Requirement: Close Combat 10+, Defensive Techniques Rule: Increase the person's Defense (for close combat attacks) by two (+2). Wrestling [2] The person possesses knowledge in wrestling and grappling. Requirement: Close Combat 7+, Brawling Rule: Increase the person's Defense (for close combat attacks) by one (+1). The person gains a bonus (+5) when they attempt to grapple or disarm an opponent. Defensive Techniques [3] The person can utilize their martial arts defensively. Requirement: Close Combat 7+, Martial Arts Training Rule: Increase the person's Defense and Defense for close combat attacks by one (+1). Draw and Attack [2] The person can draw and attack in one motion with a close combat weapon. Requirement: Close Combat 10+, Weapon Master Rule: If the person succeeds in drawing a close combat weapon they are a weapon master with, they immediately perform the Initiative action Fight in the same Initiative, with the requirement that the drawn weapon is used. This attack receives a penalty (−5) and lowers the person's Initiative by five (−5) after the attack action, in addition to any initiative modifications that result from the Initiative action's outcome. Martial Arts Training [2] The person is trained to fight in a coordinated and studied manner. Requirement: Close Combat 4+ Rule: The person gains a bonus (+1) on dice rolls (Close Combat) when they fight unarmed. Increase the person's Defense (for close combat attacks) by one (+1). Knockout Blow [3] The person has learned how to strike truly hard blows against opponents. Requirement: Close Combat 10+, Professional Boxing Rule: When damage for an unarmed close combat attack exceeds the victim's Endurance value, the victim of the attack is either knocked down or becomes completely dizzy. This means the victim's Initiative is lowered by as much as the result of the damage. Counterstrike [3] The person is trained in executing surprising counterattacks. Requirement: Close Combat 7+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on the defensive action Strike Back. Neutralize [3] The person is knowledgeable in the art of effectively preventing an enemy from acting offensively. Requirement: Close Combat 13+, Defensive Techniques Rule: Increase the person's Defense (for close combat attacks) by one (+1). The person gains a bonus (+10) when they attempt to grapple or disarm an opponent. Close Combat Weapon [2] The person is skilled at handling a type of close combat weapon. Requirement: Close Combat 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) when they use a specific type of close combat weapon (for example Knives or Clubs). Write down which weapon type the person handles. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per weapon type. Offensive Techniques [3] The person can utilize their martial arts offensively. Requirement: Close Combat 7+, Martial Arts Training Rule: The person gains a bonus (+1) on dice rolls (Close Combat) as well as on damage when they fight unarmed. Parrying [2] The person is skilled at deflecting attacks when they wield a weapon they master. Requirement: Close Combat 7+, Close Combat Weapon (weapon type) Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) on the defensive action Defend in close combat, when they use a close combat weapon they can handle. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per weapon type.

Precision Attacks [3] The person knows how to strike an enemy to inflict maximum damage. Requirement: Close Combat 13+, Strike Series Rule: Increase the person's Defense (for close combat attacks) by one (+1). The person's unarmed attacks no longer count as stunning. Professional Boxing [3] The person is a competent boxer. Requirement: Close Combat 7+, Amateur Boxing Rule: Increase the person's Wound Threshold and Endurance by one (+1) each. Add one (+1) to damage when the person fights unarmed. Clean Strikes [3] The person is an expert at handling a specific weapon type. Requirement: Close Combat 10+, Weapon Master

Rule: The person deals 1D extra in damage with the close combat weapons they are a Weapon Master with. Self-Defense [2] The person sacrifices their offensive capacity to avoid being attacked. Requirement: Close Combat 4+ Rule: The person can choose to give themselves a bonus to Defend against a close combat attack. Before the defender rolls their resistance roll they can choose to lower their Initiative by any number of steps, to a minimum of six. For each step Initiative is lowered, the resistance roll result increases by one (+1). Strike Series [2] The person has knowledge of especially effective techniques for repeated attacks. Requirement: Close Combat 10+, Offensive Techniques Rule: Add the person's damage progression once more to damage when the person fights unarmed. Brawling [2] The person can fight in close combat. Requirement: Close Combat 4+ Rule: The person gains a bonus (+1) on dice rolls (Close Combat) as well as on damage when they fight unarmed. Slugger [2] The person uses their strength and mass to overwhelm an enemy with strikes. Requirement: Close Combat 7+, Brawling Rule: When the person uses unarmed close combat, they add their damage progression once more to the damage value when they attack to damage. The fighter cannot use the defensive action Defend, but must use Chance Defense, Push Back or Strike Back until their turn in the following round. Combat Ready [2] The person is used to fighting. Requirement: Close Combat 4+ Rule: Increase the person's Awareness by one (+1). Chokehold [4] The person knows techniques for effective choking. Requirement: Close Combat 7+ Rule: The person may add 1D to damage during choking. Two Weapon Master [3] The person is masterful at handling two weapons at the same time. Requirement: Close Combat 13+, Two Weapon Practitioner Rule: The person can use two one-handed close combat weapons they are a weapon master with simultaneously. The weapons' damage value is combined on a hit and 1D is added. The attack receives a penalty (−5). Two Weapon Practitioner [3] The person is skilled at handling two weapons at the same time. Requirement: Close Combat 7+, Weapon Master Rule: The person can use two one-handed close combat weapons they are a weapon master with simultaneously. The weapons' damage value is combined on a hit. The attack receives a penalty (−2). Weapon Master [2] The person is an expert at handling a specific weapon type. Requirement: Close Combat 7+, Close Combat Weapon (weapon type) Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) when they use a close combat weapon they can already handle. Write down which type the person is an expert with. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per weapon type. Takeover [2] The person is skilled at disarming the opponent to then use the weapon themselves. Requirement: Close Combat 10+, Defensive Techniques Rule: If the person succeeds in performing a disarm and has at least one hand free, they may choose to catch the weapon instead of making it unusable for the victim. **Reactions** Lightning Deflection [2] The person reacts to danger in close combat in the right way. Requirement: Reactions 7+ Rule: Increase the person's Defense against close combat attacks by one (+1). Duck [2] The person reacts to danger in the right way. Requirement: Reactions 4+ Rule: Increase the person's Defense by one (+1). Explosion Sense [2] The person reacts quickly to explosions. Requirement: Reactions 4+ Rule: The person may roll a difficulty roll (Reactions) when they perceive that an explosion is imminent, for example if they perceive a bomb or a hand grenade. If the roll succeeds, the person has thrown themselves half their

combat movement away from the detonation site, though a maximum of long range. This action doesn't count as an action, though the person is considered prone which lowers their Initiative to 1.

Swift Movement [2] The person moves quickly in combat. Requirements: Reactions 7+ Rule: Increase the person's Combat Movement by one (+1).

Quick-Footed [2] The person moves quickly in combat. Requirements: Reactions 4+ Rule: Increase the person's Combat Movement by one (+1).

Quick to React [2] The person reacts quickly to danger. Requirements: Reactions 4+ Rule: Increase the person's Awareness by one (+1).

Spinal Reflex [2] The person reacts to danger from long range in the right way. Requirements: Reactions 7+ Rule: Increase the person's Defense against ranged attacks by one (+1).

See Opportunities [3] The person can exploit a situation to their advantage. Requirements: Reactions 7+ Rule: If the person succeeds exceptionally at any Initiative action, their Initiative increases by five steps (+5), beyond the normal effect from the action's outcome.

Combat Impulses [2] In combat, the person reacts quickly and correctly. Requirements: Reactions 7+, Quick to React Rule: Increase the person's Awareness by one (+1).

Combat Reflexes [3] The person knows how to act in combat to survive. Requirements: Reactions 10+, Combat Impulses Rule: Increase the person's Awareness by one (+1).

Exploit the Situation [3] The person is skilled at exploiting situations to their advantage. Requirements: Reactions 10+, See Opportunities Rule: If the person succeeds exceptionally at any Initiative action, their Initiative increases by five steps (+5), beyond the normal effect from the action's outcome. This bonus is added to the effect from See Opportunities.

Resistance

Hardened [2] The person is less affected by a certain form of negative influence. Requirements: Resistance 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Resistance) to resist one of the following: Resist fear/horror, Face death/murder others, Endure degradation/abuse, Endure violence/war, Withstand pain/torture. Write down which resistance the person possesses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of influence.

Extremely Hardened [3] The person is not affected at all by a certain form of negative influence. Requirements: Resistance 10+, Very Hardened Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Resistance) to resist something they are already very hardened against. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of influence.

Very Hardened [2] The person is not affected by a certain form of negative influence. Requirements: Resistance 7+, Hardened Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Resistance) to resist something they are already hardened against. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of influence.

Insensitive to Pain [4] The person barely feels pain anymore. Requirements: Resistance 13+ Rule: Increase the person's Stamina by one (+1).

Fearless [3] As long as the person can see a way out of a difficult situation, their self-confidence is at its peak. Requirements: Resistance 4+ Rule: The person gets a bonus (+2) in threatening or risky situations, though not in combat, when they lack freedom of action.

Steel Resolve [2] The person can steel themselves against, and endure, pain better. Requirements: Resistance 10+ Rule: Increase the person's Stamina by one (+1).

Mobility

Fall Technique [2] The person is trained in falling in ways to minimize damage. Requirements: Mobility 7+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on difficulty rolls (Mobility) during falls & collisions, see page 267.

Fleet-Footed [2] The person is incredibly fast. Requirements: Mobility 10+, Fast Rule: Increase the person's Combat Movement by one (+1).

Graceful [3] The person is a specialist in a form of body control. Requirements: Mobility 10+, Agile (area) Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Mobility) within an area where they are already agile. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area.

Mobile [1] The person is skilled in a form of body control. Requirements: Mobility 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Mobility) within one of the following areas: Acrobatics/Balance/Gymnastics, Dance, Jump/Climb, Crawl/Slither, Modeling/Posing, Sneak, Escapology/Contortionist. Write down which area the person masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area.

Agile [2] The person is experienced in a form of body control. Requirements: Mobility 7+, Mobile (area) Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Mobility) within an area where they are already mobile. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area.

Fast [2] The person is fast. Requirements: Mobility 7+ Rule: Increase the person's Combat Movement by one (+1).

Mind

Aura of Calm [2] The person radiates calm. Requirements: Mind 4+ Rule: Increase the person's Impression by one (+1).

Balanced Psyche [4] The person needs minimal sleep. Requirements: Mind 10+, Self-Discipline Rule: The person becomes rested in a short time and only needs to sleep four hours per day.

Inner Peace [3] The person has an inner peace that gives spiritual serenity. Requirements: Mind 10+, Strong-Willed Rule: Increase the person's Will to Live by one (+1).

Inner Reserve [2] The person can mobilize their energies when it really counts. Requirements: Mind 7+, Self-Discipline Rule: The person can once per game session directly restore Disorientation by drawing energy from their inner reserves. If they succeed at a difficulty roll (Mind), they immediately recover as much Disorientation as the value on the highest die.

Ice Cold [3] The person is completely emotionless when killing defenseless people. Requirements: Mind 4+ Rule: The person gets a bonus (+5) when executing defenseless people.

Come to One's Senses [2] The person's consciousness allows them to quickly come to their senses again after being knocked out.

the result of the value on all dice. The person needs about a minute to perform the action. When the person wants to wake up, it takes about a minute and requires a successful roll (Mind). Each attempt gives the person as much Disorientation as the result of all dice in the roll. The person is perceived by non-medically trained people as deceased. A successful medical examination (Medicine) with a penalty (−5) is required to discover that the person is actually alive.

Create

Outstanding Creator [2] The person is experienced in an artistic area. Requirements: Create 7+, Creator (area) Rule: The person has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Create) within an area where they are already a creator. This

bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area.

Creator [2] The person is skilled in an artistic area. Requirements: Create 4+ Rule: The person has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Create) within one of the following creative areas: Photography, Forge artwork/sculptures, Forge documents/papers/licenses, Forge money, Forge jewelry, Disguise/Makeup, Compose music/songs, Cooking, Paint/Draw, Poetry/Poems, Write journalistic texts, Write fiction texts, Sculpt. Write down which area the person masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area.

Virtuoso [3] The person is a specialist in an artistic area. Requirements: Create 10+, Outstanding Creator (area) Rule: The person has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Create) within an area where they are already an outstanding creator. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area.

Firearms

Executioner [4] The person is trained in efficiently murdering people. Requirements: Firearms 13+, Weapon Expert Rule: Every time a target suffers at least one Wound, an additional Wound is inflicted. This expertise can only be performed with firearms the person is a weapon expert with.

Controlled Fire [3] The person fires fewer rounds during repeated fire. Requirements: Firearms 10+, Weapon Expert Rule: If the number of fired rounds is Sum of the result on all dice x2, it is lowered to Sum of the result on all dice, Sum of the result on all dice is lowered to Result on the highest die, and Result on the highest die is lowered to Result on the lowest die. Those with Result on the lowest die lower the number of fired rounds to one round. This expertise can only be performed with firearms on which the person is a weapon expert.

Requirements: Mind 10+, Self-Discipline Rule: The person gets a bonus (+2) on rolls (Stamina) to regain consciousness (see page 263).

Power Source [3] The person can draw help from their inner forces. Requirements: Mind 10+, Inner Reserve Rule: The person can once per game session directly restore Disorientation by drawing power from their inner reserve. If the person succeeds at a difficulty roll (Mind), they immediately recover as much Disorientation as the result of the value on all dice.

Cheat Death [5] The person can rise from the dead. Requirements: Mind 13+, Self-Discipline Rule: When the person dies, they may roll a difficulty roll (Will to Live) with a penalty (−10) once per minute, for as many minutes as the value on the lowest die in the failed difficulty roll (Will to Live). If any of these rolls succeed, the person lives again, but retains all injuries they had at the moment of death — though they are not mortally wounded. Should any of the rolls fail exceptionally, the person is irrevocably dead. This expertise may only be used once per game session.

Self-Discipline [3] The person has mental methods for achieving calm. Requirements: Mind 4+ Rule: The person can improve their Well-Being by one level with a successful difficulty roll (Mind). Using the expertise takes about ten minutes, and during this time the person must be undisturbed and concentrated. The expertise may be used once per game session.

Self-Healing [5] By redirecting the body's resources, the person can heal injuries on themselves. Requirements: Mind 13+, Self-Discipline Rule: The person can recover Wounds once per game session by rolling a difficulty roll (Mind). For the person to roll, they need an hour of seclusion for concentration and energy focusing. The outcome is read below.

Exceptionally successful: The person heals as many Wounds as the value on the lowest die. Successful: The person heals one Wound. Failed: The person heals no Wounds. Exceptionally failed: The person takes one Wound from the exertion and must immediately roll (Will to Live).

Strong-Willed [3] The person has a strong will to live. Requirements: Mind 7+ Rule: Increase the person's Will to Live by one (+1).

Play Dead [4] The person can control all their bodily functions. Requirements: Mind 10+, Self-Discipline Rule: If the person succeeds at a difficulty roll (Mind), they can play dead for up to as many hours as

Suppressive Fire [3] The character is trained in effectively returning fire in difficult situations. Requirements: Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert Rule: When the character uses the defensive action Return Fire with a weapon they are a weapon expert with, the penalty is only Recoil x 2 instead of x 3 (see page 260).

Lead in the Air [2] The character doesn't spare bullets when firing automatic weapons. Requirements: Firearms 4+, Weapon Handling (weapon category) Rule: The character can choose to gain a bonus (+1) to hit and damage when using an automatic weapon they can handle. In return, the number of rounds expended is doubled.

Multiple Targets [4] The character is an expert at shooting at many different targets with a weapon in each hand. Requirements: Firearms 13+, Several Targets Rule: When the character uses one of the Initiative Actions Shoot with Two Weapons or Shoot Automatic Fire with Two Weapons, with a weapon they are a weapon expert with, they can choose to shoot at as many targets as the value of the lowest die. The shooter only rolls once. All targets get to defend themselves, and if anyone is damaged, the weapons' combined damage value is counted, without further modification.

Suppressing Fire [2] The character focuses on trying to pin down enemies by continuously shooting at their general position. Requirements: Firearms 4+, Weapon Handling (weapon category) Rule: The character can choose to take a penalty (−2) to hit and damage when using the initiative action Sweep with Automatic Weapon with an automatic weapon they can handle. The number of rounds expended is doubled. In return, those being shot at reduce their Initiative by five steps (−5).

"Close Doesn't Count!" [3] The character can use all their combat knowledge to best avoid gunfire. Requirements: Firearms 10+, "Take Cover!" Rule: Increase the character's Defense (against ranged attacks) by two (+2).

Marksmanship [3] The character is an expert at handling rifles with scopes. Requirements: Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert (rifle with scope) Rule: The character increases their weapon's damage value by 1D when using the Initiative Action Sniper Shot and shooting with a weapon they are a weapon expert with.

Shot Placement [2] The character is skilled at hitting non-vital parts of the target with firearms. Requirements: Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert Rule: Attacks made with the combat action Shoot Aimed Fire and with a firearm the character is a weapon expert with can, if the shooter wishes, be counted as stunning instead of lethal.

Double Hit [3] The character can shoot at two separate targets with one weapon in a single motion. Requirements: Firearms 10+, Weapon Expert (any one-handed firearm) Rule: When the character uses the Initiative Action Shoot Snap Shot, with a weapon they are a weapon expert with, they can choose to shoot at two targets. The shooter only rolls once. Both targets get to defend themselves, and if anyone is damaged, the weapon's normal damage value is counted, without modification.

Dual Reload [2] The character is an expert at reloading two one-handed weapons simultaneously. Requirements: Firearms 10+, Two-Handed Shooting Rule: When the character uses the Initiative Action Reload, they can attempt to reload two one-handed weapons they are a weapon expert with simultaneously. This gives a penalty (−5) to the dice roll.

Several Targets [3] The character is an expert at shooting at two different targets, with a weapon in each hand. Requirements: Firearms 10+, Two-Handed Shooting Rule: When the character uses one of the Initiative Actions Shoot with Two Weapons or Shoot Automatic Fire with Two Weapons, with a weapon they are a weapon expert with, they can choose to shoot at two targets. The shooter only rolls once. Both targets get to defend themselves, and if anyone is damaged, the weapons' combined damage value is counted, without further modification.

Critical Hits [2] The character is skilled at hitting critical points on the target with firearms. Requirements: Firearms 10+, Shot Placement Rule: The character increases the damage value by two (+2) when using a firearm they are a weapon expert with.

Bullet Storm [2] The character likes to fire a lot of automatic fire. Requirements: Firearms 7+, Lead in the Air Rule: When the character performs an Initiative Action with an automatic weapon that fires multiple rounds, they can choose before the roll to double the ammunition expenditure to give themselves a bonus (+2) to both hit and damage value. The disadvantage is that they may not use the defensive action Defend, but must use Chance Defense, Return Fire, or Strike Back until their turn in the next round. This expertise can only be performed with firearms the character is a weapon expert with.

Massive Counter-Fire [3] The character is trained in giving effective return fire with two weapons in difficult situations. Requirements: Firearms 7+, Two-Handed Shooting Rule: When the character uses the defensive action Return Fire, with two one-handed weapons they are a weapon expert with, the weapon's damage increases by 1D per 2D in damage value (minimum +1D).

Quick Draw [2] The character can draw and shoot in a single motion. Requirements: Firearms 10+, Weapon Expert Rule: If the character succeeds in drawing one or more firearms they are a weapon expert with, they immediately fire the drawn weapon at the same Initiative. This attack takes a penalty (−5) and lowers the character's Initiative by five (−5) after the attack action, beyond any initiative modifications that come from the Initiative Action's outcome.

Heavy Weapons Specialist [4] The character is an expert at handling heavy weapons. Requirements: Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert (heavy weapon) Rule: The weapon's damage value increases by 1D when the character uses a heavy weapon they are a weapon expert with.

Battle-Hardened [2] The character is used to using firearms in combat. Requirements: Firearms 4+ Rule: Increase the character's Awareness by one (+1).

Take Cover [2] The character sacrifices offensive capacity to avoid being hit. Requirements: Firearms 4+ Rule: The character can choose to give themselves a bonus to Defend against a ranged attack. Before the defender rolls their resistance roll, they lower their Initiative by any number of steps, but at least to six. For each step the Initiative is lowered, a (+1) bonus is added to the resistance roll's result.

"Take Cover!" [2] The character can use their combat knowledge to more effectively avoid being hit. Requirements: Firearms 7+ Rule: Increase the character's Defense (against ranged attacks) by one (+1).

Two-Handed Shooting [3] The character is an expert at shooting with a weapon in each hand. Requirements: Firearms 7+, Weapon Expert (one-handed firearm) Rule: The character has a bonus (+2) on the Initiative Actions Shoot with Two Weapons and Shoot Automatic Fire with Two Weapons with weapons they are a weapon expert with.

"Two in the Head and One in the Chest" [4] The character is trained in assassin techniques. Requirements: Firearms 13+, Weapon Expert Rule: The character can use the Initiative Action Shoot Snap Shot in an alternative way against a single target at most three meters away. The shooter must have higher Initiative than the target. If the shooter succeeds, an additional 2D is added to the damage value. Furthermore, exactly three rounds are always crossed off. This expertise can only be performed with firearms the character is a weapon expert with.

Weapon Expert [1] The character is an expert at handling a specific weapon model. Requirements: Firearms 4+, Weapon Handling (weapon category) Rule: The character has a bonus (+3) when using a specific weapon model (for example, Calder M2245 or Rais H100) they can already handle. Write down which weapon model the character is an expert with. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per weapon model. The different models are found on pages 106–117. Note that the bonus applies to all combat actions where the weapon is an active part—from drawing the weapon to shooting and reloading.

Weapon Handling [2] The character is trained in handling a category of firearms. Requirements: Firearms 4+ Rule: The character has a bonus (+2) when using a firearm from one of the following categories: Automatic Pistol, Rifle, Shotgun, Submachine Gun, Machine Gun, Revolver, Heavy Weapons. Write down which category the character can handle. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per weapon category. The different categories correspond to those on pages 106–117. Note that the bonus applies to all combat actions where the weapon is an active part—from drawing the weapon to shooting and reloading.

Gun Play [2] Requirements: Firearms 10+, Weapon Expert Rule: If the character incapacitates an enemy with a firearm they are a weapon expert with, their Initiative increases by two (+2).

Evasion [2] The character is skilled at avoiding damage, regardless of situation. Requirements: Firearms 10+, "Take Cover!" Rule: Increase the character's Defense by one (+1).

Deduction

Genius [3] The character is a specialist at drawing conclusions from clues. Requirements: Deduction 10+, Smart (area) Rule: The character has a bonus (+5) when using Deduction within a field they are already considered smart in. This bonus is added to other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field.

Clear-Minded [2] The character is good at drawing conclusions from clues. Requirements: Deduction 4+ Rule: The character has a bonus (+2) when using Deduction within one of the following fields: Analyze/Laboratory Work, Crime Scene Investigation/Forensics, Cipher/Code Breaking, Dream Interpretation, Experiment/Invent, Puzzles/Brain Teasers, Remember Things/Places/Phenomena, Tactics/Strategy, Investigate/See Connections. Write down which area the character masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field.

Smart [2] The character is experienced in drawing conclusions from clues. Requirements: Deduction 7+, Clear-Minded (area) Rule: The character has a bonus (+3) when using Deduction within a field they are already

considered clear-minded in. This bonus is added to the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field.

For days he had traveled through the Imperium. Looked down upon glittering rivers, endless plains, and forests so deep and dark that their interiors still lay unexplored. Day and night he had sat on the zeppelin's observation deck and gazed at the vast empire that lay below him.

The zeppelin's staff fawned over him partly because of his wealth. The family name and lineage made him feared—he would like to say respected, but it was rather dread that came into people's minds when they heard it. Hrûzda, he took the name in his mouth and let it leave his lips in a whisper. The woman at the table next to him tremblingly set down her teacup, excused herself before her company, and quickly left. To think that a name can mean so much, and all people know they have gotten from myths and legends.

To dispel his thoughts, he took out his sketchbook, let his hand glide over its rough cover, and opened it. There he had tried to sketch mountain formations and the Copper River's winding path to the sea, but constantly he returned to drawing her face—the woman he had loved, the woman he had murdered. Constantly she seemed to haunt his subconscious; not even her death had freed him. He opened a new white page and took out his pen, sharpened it with a penknife, and let the shavings fall into the ashtray. His gaze sought out through the window again, and he saw the black smoke from one of the smaller industrial towns—they had passed several such during the journey. Like black seeds they were buried in the earth of the realms, slowly sucking in nourishment to grow and spread, and around them the lands died.

He fixed his gaze on a clear lake and quickly began sketching it, the trees on its shore and the reflections of clouds—but as usual on the lake's bottom, her face.

A murmur and buzz among the fellow passengers on the observation deck made him look up—there in the distance one could see the smoke from Sandukar—the great whore—or the city of hope as some preferred to call it. This would be the first time he visited this magical place, saw the vast basalt walls and towers rise against the firmament. He closed his sketchbook and enjoyed the rest of the journey toward Sandukar and dusk.

The wind was cool up at the air harbor and tore at his coat. The zeppelin was now a dark shadow in the night darkness above him where it was not lit by searchlights. He grasped his bags in each hand. He had chosen to travel alone, without servants, which was most suitable for his task. The city spread out around him, tall stately buildings, millions of glittering points of light and people everywhere—so unlike his desolate homeland. On a bridge below him, a train passed creaking, and from the opera house next door, music streamed out, partly drowned by the endless noise from the traffic.

He followed the stream of people out into the terminal, took the elevator down to street level, and then went to find a taxi. He took out his notebook, read the address to the driver, and silenced his complaints with a thick bundle of zovrins.

The hotel they pulled up in front of had seen better days. The red carpet in the foyer was worn and the potted plants were all dead. He walked up to the cross-eyed porter who was listening to a boxing match on the radio and asked for the key to room number seven while giving his false name. The porter looked up, then nodded and walked with shuffling steps to the hooks on the wall behind him where countless keys hung attached to their brass plates. When the key finally lay in his hand, he took the creaking stairs to the second floor and unlocked the door.

There on the bedspread it lay; a black envelope, like a hole into nothingness against the white fabric. He dropped his bags and immediately took it in his hands; it smelled of perfume and his false name was written on it with an elegant, white script. As he sat down on the bed, he broke the seal and took out the letter; he didn't bother reading it as it was only a facade. Instead, he took out his lighter and let the heat coax forth the hidden signs written there in ancient Sadovian. He smiled, mentally noted the address, time, and phone number before letting the flame consume the letter and envelope.

Strength

Beefy [2] The character is beefy. Requirement: Strength 7+, Well-trained Rule: The character's Size increases by one (+1). The character's Defense decreases by one (−1). Lead Fists [2] The character has hard fists. Requirement: Strength 7+ Rule: Increase the character's Damage Bonus by one (+1). Enormously Strong [3] The character is enormously strong. Requirement: Strength 13+, Muscular Rule: The character's Size increases by one (+1). The character's Defense decreases by one (−1). Threatening [2] Thanks to their build, the character can instill fear in others. Requirement: Strength 7+, Beefy Rule: The character can make a dice roll (Strength) to act threateningly toward people, instead of using Persuade. Iron Fists [2] The character's fists are rock-hard and large. Requirement: Strength 10+, Lead Fists Rule: Increase the character's Damage Bonus by one (+1). Lift/Drag [1] The character is skilled at lifting/dragging objects/people. Requirement: Strength 4+ Rule: The character gains a bonus (+2) to Strength when lifting/dragging something or someone. Muscular [3] The character is muscular. Requirement: Strength 10+, Beefy Rule: The character's Size increases by one (+1). Pulverize/Tear Apart Objects [4] The character is expert at smashing everything in their vicinity if needed. Requirement: Strength 13+, Smash/Break Objects Rule: The character may add 2D to damage when attempting to smash objects. If it's a difficulty roll, the character gains a bonus (+5), for example when trying to break a pair of handcuffs or tear away prison bars. Note that these modifiers stack with those from Smash/Break Objects. Robust [3] The character can shrug off minor damage with a shrug. Requirement: Strength 10+, Beefy Rule: Attacks that deal stunning damage only inflict half of the Disorientation the attack causes (damage is still the same for calculating Wounds, etc.). Smash/Break Objects [3] The character has a talent for smashing things to splinters. Requirement: Strength 10+, Lead Fists Rule: The character may add 2D to damage when attempting to smash objects. If it's a difficulty roll, the character gains a bonus (+5), for example when trying to break a pair of handcuffs or tear away prison bars. Steel Fists [3] The character's fists are like tempered steel. Requirement: Strength 13+, Iron Fists Rule: Increase the character's Damage Bonus by one (+1). Well-trained [2] The character is well-trained. Requirement: Strength 4+ Rule: The character's Size increases by one (+1). **Tolerance** Withdrawal Control [2] The character is not notably affected by withdrawal. Requirement: Tolerance 7+ Rule: If the character has withdrawal (see page 269), they gain a bonus (+2) on difficulty rolls affected by the withdrawal. Exceptionally Resilient [3] The character is exceptionally resilient. Requirement: Tolerance 10+, Very Resilient (effect) Rule: The character has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Tolerance) to endure something they're already very resilient against. This bonus stacks with other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of effect. Very Resilient [2] The character is very resilient. Requirement: Tolerance 7+, Resilient (effect) Rule: The character has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Tolerance) to endure something they're already resilient against. This bonus stacks with the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of effect. Resilient [2] The character is resilient. Requirement: Tolerance 4+ Rule: The character has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Tolerance) to endure one of the following: Alcohol, Sedative Poisons, Depressant Drugs, Deadly Poisons, Hallucinogens, Cold/ Heat, Truth Serum, Diseases, Stimulant Drugs. Write down which resilience the character possesses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of effect. **Awareness** Extremely Observant [3] The character has extremely easy time making a certain type of observation. Requirement: Awareness 10+, Very Observant (type of observation)

Rule: The character has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Awareness) in a category where they're already very observant. This bonus stacks with other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per category. Very Observant [2] The character has very easy time making a certain type of observation. Requirement: Awareness 7+, Observant (type of observation) Rule: The character has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Awareness) in a category where they're already observant. This bonus stacks with the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per type of category. Observant [2] The character has easy time making a certain type of observation. Requirement: Awareness 4+ Rule: The character has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Awareness) in one of the following categories: Perceive Smells/Identify Tastes, Never Forgets a Face, Notice Deviations/Details, Lip Reading, Notice Hidden Weapons on Person/Search, Spot Person in Crowd, Orient in Darkness, Shadow/Track, Hide, Track in Nature. Write down which area the character masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per category. **Streetwise** Courteous [2] The character can conduct themselves in social settings. Requirement: Streetwise 4+ Rule: The character's Impression increases by one (+1). Well-versed [1] The character is skilled at small talk and blending in with a certain type of group. Requirement: Streetwise 4+ Rule: The character gains a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Streetwise) to ferret out information, blend in, get a feel for the situation, get a name, a location or similar from one of the following groups: Academia, General Public, Children, Crime Syndicates, Bureaucrats, Refugees, The Street, Club Life, Criminals, The Church, Resistance Groups, Military, Entertainment Industry, Police, Press, Legal System, High Society, Sports World, The State, Clans. Write down which group the character is well-versed in. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per group. Extremely Well-versed [3] The character is extremely skilled at cold-calling and blending in with a certain type of group. Requirement: Streetwise 10+, Very Well-versed (group) Rule: The character has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Streetwise) in a group where they're already very well-versed. This bonus stacks with other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per group. Fixer [3] The character knows how to move freely in the underworld and can sniff out who to talk to to get the right information and/or hot items. Requirement: Streetwise 7+, Know the Score Rule: The character gains a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Streetwise) in the underworld to see if they can find a fence, find out who runs which crew and where they hang out, get a handle on who's who, find out who's in conflict with each other and who's allied, etc. In-depth Local Knowledge [2] The character is king of their area. Requirement: Streetwise 7+, Local Knowledge Rule: The character truly knows everything about an area or a district where they already have local knowledge. The character gains a bonus (+3) on using the expertise in the area or district. This bonus stacks with the bonus from local knowledge. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area. Know the Score [2] The character has general know-how about where to go to get things done and who to talk to. Requirement: Streetwise 4+ Rule: The character gains a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Streetwise) to see if they generally know the score. Local Knowledge [1] The character knows what's happening in an area or district. Requirement: Streetwise 4+ Rule: The character has good knowledge of a smaller area or a district. Most likely it's an area near their residence, but it could also be near their workplace, favorite pub, or a place where they do a lot of business. With local knowledge, one knows alleys, shortcuts, backyards, and all sorts of hangouts. The character can gain a bonus (+2) when it comes to finding the right person, information, or a temporary hideout, if the narrator finds it reasonable. This expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per area or district. When the expertise is chosen, a district or area must be determined. Very Well-versed [2] The character is very skilled at cold-calling and blending in with a certain type of group. Requirement: Streetwise 7+, Well-versed (group) Rule: The character has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Streetwise) in a group where they're already well-versed. This bonus stacks with the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per group. Very Skilled Gambler [2] The character is a very skilled gambler. Requirement: Streetwise 10+, Skilled Gambler (game type) Rule: The character has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Streetwise) to

play a game they're already a skilled gambler at. This bonus stacks with other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per game type.

Skilled Gambler [2] The character is an experienced gambler. Requirement: Streetwise 7+, Gambler (game type) Rule: The character has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Streetwise) to play a game they're already a gambler of. This bonus stacks with the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per game type. Gambler [1] The character is versed in some game. Requirement: Streetwise 4+ Rule: The character has a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Streetwise) to play one of, for example, the following games: Baccarat, Backgammon, Blackjack, Board Games, Craps, War Games, Poker, Roulette, Chess. Write down which gambling game the character knows. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per game type. Style & Taste [2] The character has an ability to always choose the right clothing and appearance for prevailing circumstances. Requirement: Streetwise 7+, Well-dressed Rule: The character's Impression increases by one (+1). Well-dressed [2] The character knows how to dress to give the best first impression possible. Requirement: Streetwise 4+ Rule: The character's Impression increases by one (+1). **Persuade** Extremely Persuasive [3] The character is a specialist at influencing others in a certain way. Requirement: Persuade 10+, Very Persuasive (field) Rule: The character has a bonus (+5) on dice rolls (Persuade) in a field where they're already very persuasive. This bonus stacks with other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field. Very Persuasive [2] The character is experienced at influencing others in a certain way. Requirement: Persuade 7+, Persuasive (field) Rule: The character has a bonus (+3) on dice rolls (Persuade) in a field where they're already persuasive. This bonus stacks with the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field. Persuasive [2] The character is good at influencing others in a certain way. Requirement: Persuade 4+ Rule: The character gains a bonus (+2) on dice rolls (Persuade) in one of the following fields: Negotiate/Haggle, Interrogate/Interview, Threaten/Intimidate/Harass, Bribe/Grease Palms, Convince/Plead. Write down which field the character masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per field. **Sports** Since sports are based on different prerequisites, here is a general template for the abilities that govern each sport. **Ability Sport Branches** Stamina Rugby, soccer, basketball, rowing, track and field, long-distance running, etc. Agility Tennis, golf, gymnastics, short-distance running, long jump, high jump, etc. Strength Weightlifting, discus, arm wrestling, shot put, hammer throw, etc. There are other sports that use other abilities, for example racing (Vehicles), boxing (Close Combat), horseback riding (Vehicles), swimming (Stamina), and fencing (Close Combat). See corresponding expertise areas. Amateur (sport) [1] The character is an amateur in a sport or athletic discipline. Requirement: (Ability) 4+ Rule: The character has a bonus of two (+2) when using (Ability) to practice a sport. Write down which sport the character masters. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per sport. Professional (sport) [2] The character is a professional practitioner of a sport or athletic discipline. Requirement: (Ability) 10+, Practitioner (sport) Rule: The character has a bonus of two (+2) when using (Ability) to practice a sport they're a practitioner of. This bonus stacks with other bonuses. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per sport. Practitioner (sport) [1] The character is a practitioner of a sport or athletic discipline. Requirement: (Ability) 7+, Amateur (sport) Rule: The character has a bonus of two (+2) when using (Ability) to practice a sport they're an amateur in. This bonus stacks with the previous bonus. The expertise can be chosen multiple times, but only once per sport. "He's worth over twenty million zovrins." "It doesn't matter, I promised myself to marry for love." "Who doesn't love twenty million?" — Gabriel Jandaran to Talia Navarre

In all people there are weaknesses, some are physical and tangible — others are psychological and difficult to detect. Yet they're there, no person is exempt from them, no person is without flaws. **Description of Limitations** The character has 10 points that must be spent on limitations before character creation can proceed. Activation indicates whether the option is always active or can be activated, either by the prevailing scene or when the narrator triggers a setback, see page 237. Depression (points: 1 to 10) Dark and melancholy

thoughts weigh down the character's mind when they enter the story. The day is a gray haze and the night is filled with suffocating silence and relentless darkness. Few things can lift the character's spirits; they're constantly sunk in gloom. Life seems meaningless and the character may have several suicide attempts behind them. To function normally together with people in their surroundings is often very difficult for the character and the depression can express itself in tears, anger, or apathy. **A depression lowers a character's Maximum** Wellbeing according to table 1:10 **Maximum Maximum Wellbeing Points Wellbeing Points** 9 1 4 6 8 2 3 7 7 3 2 8 6 4 1 9 5 5 0 10 Table 1:10 Activation: Always active. Drug Addict (points: 1) Reality and its gray everyday must be suppressed with something. The character is driven by a hunger for something that numbs the dreariness and shuts out the agonizing world they live in. The character requires drugs to keep their mind clear. Without drugs they become depressed, aggressive, and suffer from painful withdrawal. More about drugs and dependencies can be found on page 268; choose a type of drug the character abuses. Activation: Governed by the drug's withdrawal (see page 268).

Limitations

Wanted (points: 1, 2, or 4) The person is wanted by the police for a crime he/she has committed, or is believed to have committed. Determine whether the person is a repeat offender, on the run from prison, or merely sought for questioning (see table 1:11). The player should speak with the narrator before choosing this limitation—especially if choosing one of the higher levels.

Category Points Wanted Level

Minor crime 1 The police keep their eyes open for the person but aren't actively searching for him/her. Tips leading to the person's capture yield a minor reward. Major crime 2 An active group of police constables are searching for the person. Word has also spread on the street that the police are looking for the person, and one can receive a larger reward for tips about the person's whereabouts. Enemy of the State 4 The person is hunted by the police, State troops, and the commissars. The person's face has been circulated in newspapers and he/she can barely remain anywhere without being recognized. Even bounty hunters keep their eyes open for the person. A deserter falls into this category.

Table 1:11

Activation: The narrator can activate the wanted status so that the person is identified and the long arm of the law comes after the person. A minor crime can be activated once per story, a major crime once per game session, and a person classified as an Enemy of the State can be affected once per scene.

Family (points: 2 to 4) The protagonist has one to three relationships (see page 210) belonging to his/her family, either through blood ties (own children, parents, siblings, close relatives), or partnership (wife/husband, girlfriend/boyfriend).

These relationships consist of narrator characters whom the protagonist cares deeply about and has a strong emotional bond with, usually in the form of love. However, there's nothing that says you like each other just because you share the same blood—on the contrary, hatred, jealousy, and intrigue often occur between members of a family.

The number of family relationships determines the point cost as well as how many level points of Influence and Relationship (see page 29) may be distributed freely among all family relationships. Table 1:12 summarizes this.

Number of family relationships Points Level points

One narrator character 2 4 Two narrator characters 3 8 Three narrator characters 4 12

Table 1:12

Activation: A protagonist's family can be activated by the narrator and then takes an active role either in the scene or in the entire story. The circumstances are up to the narrator to determine, but could for example involve kidnapping, threats, arguments, divorce, or an accident—something that becomes a focus in the protagonist's life. It's rare for one and the same family to be activated more than once per game session.

Code of Honor (points: 1 or 3) The person has a strict code of honor as a guiding principle in life. It could be a self-imposed one, one learned since childhood, or perhaps a professional duty that the person carefully follows, such as the Hippocratic oath.

A basic code of honor means the person can consider breaking it if it would otherwise endanger their own or a loved one's life.

If the person chooses a fanatical code of honor, this symbolizes something the person has built their entire life around and which he/she will defend unto death if required. It doesn't matter what sacrifice must be made—it must not be broken. If extreme factors nevertheless cause the code of honor to be violated, there's a great risk the person will break down from shame, guilt, and feelings of remorse.

When a code of honor is broken, it counts as stress, see page 244, and table 1:13 below.

Impact If broken Points

Basic Considered a shocking experience 1 Fanatical Considered psychological trauma 3

Table 1:13

Selection of codes of honor

• Never give up • Never raise one's voice • Never betray a comrade • Never accept bribes • Always treat the wounded • Always obey a superior's order • Always speak the truth • Always remain calm • Combat crime • Defend defenseless women • Help one's friends • Keep one's word • Not attack the unarmed • Not harm others • Protect the weak • Punish child abusers

Activation: Automatic (scene- or event-specific).

Psychological Trauma

The people of Noir's world suffer from their memories and from the harsh environment around them. Many are those whose mental defenses crack under the burden so that they develop problems with their psyche. Those who refuse to acknowledge their limitations often try to numb the anxiety, nightmares, or depression with drugs, alcohol, degradation, vulnerability, and/or guilt. Others manage to make their way to a sanatorium for rest and care.

Ailment (points: 2 to 4) The person suffers from one or more ailments or afflictions of some kind. When the ailment sets in, the person risks being weakened, see page 243.

When the ailment risks setting in, the person must make a difficulty check (Stamina). This difficulty check receives a penalty equal to the ailment's effect, which is either mild, serious, or very serious. The penalties are

shown in table 1:14.

Effect Penalty Points

Mild −2 2 Serious −5 3 Very serious −10 4

Table 1:14

The outcome of the difficulty check is given on page 243.

Selection of ailments

• Shortness of breath/cough/asthma • Terminal illness under treatment (e.g., cancer) • High blood pressure • Angina/heart condition • Stomach ulcer (possibly bleeding) • Migraine/headache • Stiffness/back problems • Intestinal problems/gas • Burned-out internal organs • Dizziness/fainting due to low blood pressure

Activation: A narrator can activate an ailment at most once per scene. The activation should occur so that it creates drama in the story. Often, but not always, stress, nervousness, or pressure causes the ailment to set in.

Nightmares (points: 2) The dreams are filled with agonizing and surrealistic images and hallucinations—and these live on in the waking world as shadows from the forgotten and the past. The person sleeps poorly, tosses in sleep, screams, and seems to be in constant torment. During the days he/she is often tired and sometimes seems to see visions from their dreams flicker by. The nightmares' origin may have to do with a violent and frightening event in the past but can also be of unknown origin.

Activation: During each rest period, a narrator can activate a protagonist's nightmares by letting his/her night's sleep be filled with particularly agonizing, realistic, and unpleasant dreams. The nightmares result in the person receiving a penalty (−5) on the difficulty check to recover Well-being, see page 243.

Minority (points: 1) The person belongs to a different ethnic group than the one that dominates where the story is set. This usually means the person doesn't belong to the vagyar people, see page 157. In cases where the story is placed somewhere where vagyar aren't ruling and dominant, this group can be considered a minority—discuss the circumstances with the narrator.

Belonging to a minority usually means generally worse treatment, lower respect, and greater contempt from those in power. Racism and prejudice are common elements in the Empire and especially in the cities.

Activation: Once per game session, the narrator can activate a person's minority status, which results in the person having problems in some way. This could involve racist gangs, a shop that refuses to serve the person, or a restaurant that refuses the person entry.

Impaired Hearing (points: 1 to 2) The person's hearing is impaired. Table 1:15 indicates different degrees of impaired hearing as well as what penalties apply in situations where hearing is used—such as distinguishing things said in a crowd, or hearing that a door is cautiously being opened.

If a person with impaired hearing acquires a hearing aid, this counteracts one step of penalty, meaning a person with poor hearing receives a penalty (−1) instead of (−2), and a person with terrible hearing receives a penalty (−4) instead of (−5). Table 1:15 summarizes hearing and its significance.

Hearing Penalty Points

Poor −2 1 Terrible −5 2

Table 1:15

Activation: Always active.

Impaired Vision (points: 1 or 3) The person's vision is impaired. Table 1:16 indicates different degrees of impaired vision as well as what penalties apply in situations where vision is used, for example in combat or to notice things.

If a person with impaired vision acquires glasses, these counteract two steps of penalty, meaning a person with poor vision avoids penalties, and a person with terrible vision receives a penalty (−3) instead of five. Table 1:16 summarizes vision and its significance.

Vision Penalty Points

Poor −2 1 Terrible −5 3

Table 1:16

Activation: Always active.

"It is the One's responsibility to judge and punish the State's henchmen. It is our responsibility to ensure the meeting between them takes place!" — The Fallen

Fear (points: 2 to 4) A fear is a personal terror, phobia, or panic reaction to something. This creates stress in the person, see page 244. The fears addressed here are those that are so intense they can severely affect the person's ability to act effectively upon confrontation.

To resist a fear, one makes a difficulty check (Resistance), with a penalty depending on the fear's intensity, see table 1:17.

Intensity Penalty Points

Noticeable −2 2 Significant −5 3 Overwhelming −10 4

Table 1:17

The outcome of the difficulty check is given on page 244.

Selection of possible sources of terror

• Aggression/hostility • Blood • A certain color (usually a color that has featured in a traumatic experience) • Crowds • Madness • High heights • Corpses • Darkness • Closeness/intimacy • Sex • Specific organization (e.g., a league, the police, or the military) • Specific person (e.g., one's father or a bully) • Specific symbol (usually a symbol that has featured in a traumatic experience) • Specific animal (usually snakes, spiders, or dogs) • Confined spaces (claustrophobia) • The underground • Water

Activation: Automatic (scene- or event-specific).

Debt (points: 1 to 2) The person has large debts to some person or organization—for example, a loan shark, a gangster, or a bank. To choose this limitation, the protagonist must have at least living standard 4. Debt is described on page 248.

Table 1:18 shows the different degrees of debt the person can hold.

Degree of debt Debts Points

Heavily indebted 50% of Creditworthiness 1 Completely indebted 100% of Creditworthiness 2

Table 1:18

Activation: The debt itself is always active. However, the effect of being indebted can be activated by the narrator and then takes an active role in either the scene or the entire story. The circumstances are up to the narrator to determine, but could for example involve threats or reminders that the debt should be paid, or humiliation or assault due to previously missed payments. It's rare for the debt to be activated more than once per game session in this way.

Weakness (points: 2 to 4) A person's weaknesses encompass those experiences, situations, events, persons, or objects he/she has a soft spot for. It's a subconscious passion that makes him/her waver in character and commit emotional, ill-considered, and rash actions, in a situation where logic or rational thinking is shut off. Note that what the person is weak for can have a limiting effect on his/her ability to act effectively as it provokes stress, see page 244.

To resist a weakness, a difficulty check (Sense) is made, with a penalty depending on the weakness's intensity, see table 1:19.

Intensity Penalty Points

Noticeable −2 2 Significant −5 3 Overwhelming −10 4

Table 1:19

The outcome of the difficulty check is given on page 244.

List of weaknesses

Weaknesses are general and can strike at any time—if the person is weak for women, any woman can potentially create distraction. People who have a weakness also always possess a specific inclination within the general weakness. This is a narrower area within which the person's weakness is at its strongest. The person's penalty from the weakness's intensity is doubled when he/she risks falling for such an inclination. Table 1:20 provides suggestions for weaknesses.

Weakness suggestions Example of specific inclination Alcohol Whisky, beer, spirits, champagne... Children Specific person, vulnerable children, orphans, talented children, homeless children... Animals Specific type—e.g., dogs... Drugs (specific drug)... Objects* Specific objects within a category—e.g., sports cars or antique coins... Phenomena** Specific phenomena within the chosen phenomenon. Gambling Roulette, card games, dice games, betting, lottery... Women Specific person, red-haired women, short women, large-breasted women, young women... Masochism Self-torment, self-degradation, submission... Men Specific person, men in uniform, dark men, tall men, "dangerous" men... Sadism Torture, humiliate, threaten, dominate... Sex Specific activity, new conquests, exciting places, trying new things...

Table 1:20

- Determine category of objects, e.g., cars, artworks, rare coins, or weapons. ** Determine which phenomenon, for example setting fire to things, photographing everything and everyone, looking at pornographic images, self-gratification over used nylon stockings, or perhaps watching and collecting newsreels.

Activation: Automatic (scene- or event-specific).

Weaknesses and Fears

All people suffer from their fears and weaknesses which constantly demand attention and can mercilessly drive a sound and rational individual over the brink of ruin—emotionally, physically, and socially—if they're allowed to escape control's grasp.

The narrator should emphasize to the players that weaknesses and fears fit very well into the dark world Noir takes place in, where broken and battered heroes move and act in their attempts to survive or achieve redemption.

A narrator should ensure that the weaknesses and fears chosen have relevance to the person and can reasonably be justified.

Activations of fears and weaknesses should occur to the extent that they become interesting situations in the story, and not so often that they feel like interrupting moments in the flow.

All people possess strengths, abilities and/or physical characteristics that make them unique individuals. Often it is a person's characteristics that those around them notice and remember. **Description of characteristics** The character has 10 points that must be reduced to zero before proceeding with character creation. Some of the choices below may result in the character gaining additional points. A character may at most choose options that grant a total of five extra points. These points must then be used before moving on. We suggest that the player and narrator begin by defining the character's Size, Appearance and Standard of Living. Assets & talents (points: see below) The character possesses some form of special aptitude that gives him/her an advantage over others. When a modification occurs, it is always added after the related attribute value has been calculated. A character generally cannot have multiple instances of the same asset (exception Talented), but they can have several different assets. A character cannot have an asset in an area where he/she suffers from a flaw (see page 85) and vice versa. Gifted (points: 4) The character learns new things quickly and draws lessons from experience effectively. Increase the character's Learning by two (+2). Charming (points: 2) The character easily charms others and is therefore perceived positively. The character's Impression increases by two (+2). Hardboiled (points: 2) The character is tough and doesn't flinch at the slightest thing. The character gets a bonus (+2) to dice rolls (Resistance). Quick (points: 2) The character is fleet of foot when it matters. Increase the character's Combat Movement by two (+2). Iron Health (points: 2) The character has a very well-functioning immune system and strong physical resilience. The character gets a bonus (+2) to dice rolls (Tolerance).

Characteristics

Natural Warrior (points: 3) The character has natural instincts that help him/ her operate in combat. Increase the character's Damage Modifier by one (+1) and Defense by one (+1). Quick-Witted (points: 2) The character is hard to deceive or influence with words and quickly sees through such attempts. The character gets a bonus (+2) to dice rolls (Oppose). Stone-Hard (points: 3) The character is stone-hard and doesn't become seriously injured so easily. Increase the character's Injury Threshold by two (+2). Strong-Willed (points: 3) The character

refuses to leave this earthly life without a real fight. Increase the character's Will to Live by two (+2). Battle Mind (points: 2) The character is ice-cold in combat and manages to act in a calculated and efficient manner. Increase the character's Overview by two (+2) Sturdy (points: 2) The character can take a lot of punishment and abuse without being too bothered by it. Increase the character's Endurance by two (+2). Talented (points: 4) The character has natural talent in a single skill. That skill is always considered experience-checked (see page 221). A character can be talented in several different skills simultaneously, even those under different attributes. Flaws & handicaps (points: see below) The character suffers from some kind of physical deficiency that affects him/her negatively. It can also be a handicap. When a modification occurs, it is always subtracted after the related attribute value has been calculated. A character generally cannot have multiple instances of the same flaw (exception Difficulty), but they can be afflicted with several different flaws. A character cannot have a flaw in an area where he/she has an asset (see page 84) and vice versa. Poor Alcohol Tolerance (points: 1 extra) The character can't handle alcohol. It only takes one or two glasses of beer or wine for him/her to become unruly, nauseous or wasted. This can be a major social trauma depending on which circles the character moves in. When the character must make difficulty rolls (Tolerance) regarding alcohol, he/she gets a penalty (−10). Lame (points: 2 extra) The character has an injured or deformed leg. Decrease the character's Combat Movement by two (−2). Difficulty (points: 1 extra) The character has difficulty learning a skill. It always costs the character double the Experience to increase the skill's skill value and the skill cannot be experience-checked. A character can have difficulty with several different skills simultaneously. Life-Weary (points: 2 extra) The character's soul is weak. Decrease the character's Will to Live by two (−2). Easily Influenced (points: 1 extra) The character tends to credulously take what others say for truth and rarely stands their ground in discussions. The character gets a penalty (−2) to dice rolls (Oppose). Reserved (points: 2 extra) The character has a dismissive and reserved manner. Lower the character's Impression by two (−2). Sickly (points: 1 extra) The character is sickly and frail. He/she gets a penalty (−2) to dice rolls (Tolerance). Injured Hand (points: 2 extra) The character cannot use two-handed weapons or other objects that require two hands in the normal way, see page 103. Additionally, he/she can only use one one-handed weapon at a time. The player may decide if the injury has resulted in the character having some kind of prosthetic – often a glove-clad wooden hand or a metal hook. Pain Sensitive (points: 2 extra) The character has a low pain threshold. Decrease the character's Endurance by two (−2). Weak Grip (points: 3 extra) The character has a weak grip that makes it difficult for him/her to use the strength of their hands. He/she may be rheumatic. The character gets a penalty (−2) on all actions involving hand strength (shooting with weapons, climbing, holding on, etc.). "I am a woman. We don't say what we want, but reserve the right to get angry when we don't get it. That's what makes us so fascinating, and also a bit scary." —Talia Navarre

Slow Learner (points: 3 extra) The character has difficulty taking in new knowledge for some reason – it could be due to learning difficulties, problems with concentration or perhaps dyslexia. Decrease the character's Learning by two (−2). Anxious (points: 1 extra) The character is anxious and fearful and quickly gives in in terrible and stressful situations. The character gets a penalty (−2) to dice rolls (Resistance). Eye Injury (points: 2 extra) The character's eye is damaged in some way – decide yourself how and if it's visible (scars, eye patch, etc.). This means the character has more difficulty getting an overview in combat. Decrease the character's Overview by two (−2) Frail (points: 3 extra) The character is fragile and is easily injured. Decrease the character's Injury Threshold by two (−2). Fatalist (points: 3) The character believes in fate's influence and that life is predetermined to such a mild degree that the prophecy becomes self-fulfilling. The disadvantage is that the character doesn't take skill as seriously. Improving one's Fate through Experience (see page 223) costs half as much for a fatalist. Ex-Convict (points: 1) The character has been in prison for a time for a crime he/she has, or hasn't, committed. During the prison stay, the character was active in communication with other prisoners, learned to get along with them and perhaps acquired prison tattoos. This makes it easier for the character to exist among other criminals and testifies to a certain experience and reliability in the underworld. The

character may get a bonus (+2) in situations where such experiences can help, for example in rolls for Impression, see page 209. The character has a criminal record, which can make it difficult for him/her to get work or licenses. Additionally, the character has credibility problems before the law and is often automatically suspected of various crimes and can be called in for questioning at any time. Body Type (points: see below) The character has a body type/body size that deviates from the norm. This affects the character according to the table below. Characters without this trait have normal body type. Table 1:21 summarizes the rules for body type, and its significance. Weight: What the character's weight is modified by. Size: How much the character's Size is modified, see page 87. Injury Threshold: How the character's Injury Threshold is modified. Movement: A general penalty that includes all actions involving physical mobility, as well as all types of Defense actions, Combat Movement and Overview. Memorable: What bonus other people have to notice and remember the character. **Weight Injury Threshold Memorable Body Type Size Movement points** Thin x0.75 −2 −1 ±0 +1 1 extra Normal x1.0 ±0 ±0 ±0 ±0 0 Overweight x1.3 +1 ±0 −1 +1 1 extra Fat x1.8 +3 +1 −2 +2 2 extra Extremely Fat x2.5 +5 +2 −3 +5 3 extra Table 1:21 Reputation (points: 2 or 4) The character is known for something within a group or sphere of interest. The reputation can be built on respect and admiration, or on fear and oppression, see table 1:22. More on rules for notoriety can be found on page 208. **Notoriety Points** Talked About (6) or Notorious (4) 2 Known (7) or Infamous (3) 4 Table 1:22 Standard of Living (points: see below) One's standard of living refers to one's place in society's hierarchy. It shows one's birth, riches, success and status. The standard of living is a simplified way of seeing what resources, what style and what residence a character normally has. The narrator should be consulted if the player wants to acquire a very high or low standard of living, so that this fits into the story or chronicle the narrator has devised. Unless otherwise stated, a character is considered to have standard of living 4. See table 1:23 for summary. **Standard of Living Points** 0 4 extra 1 3 extra 2 2 extra 3 1 extra 4 0 5 1 6 2 7 4 8 6 9 8 10 10 Table 1:23

Size (points: see below) Size shows how voluminous and massive a character is. It also indicates the character's sturdiness, as high Size means a greater mass that can withstand bodily harm better. A character's Size is a measure used to derive other attribute values. Unless otherwise stated, the character is medium-sized, which means that value 15 is entered as the attribute value for Size on the character sheet. If the player wants the character to have a different Size, simply choose which one and note the change in points. The player chooses the character's height and weight themselves based on the intervals given in table 1:24. Note that the interval refers to normal body weight – this can be modified, see Body Type on page 86. A suggestion is that if a character's Strength is high, this results in a higher weight within the interval, and vice versa, as Strength largely refers to muscle mass. Generally, women fall somewhat lower within the intervals than men. Table 1:24 summarizes the rules regarding size, and its significance. Size: An attribute value that shows a character's mechanical Size. Build: A general term for the character's body volume. Can also be seen as the first physical impression outsiders get when they meet the character. Height: An interval indicating appropriate height, in centimeters, for the chosen size. Weight: An interval giving appropriate weight, in kilograms, for the chosen size. Body weight can be modified, see page 86. Defense: How the build raises or lowers the character's Defense. Build **Size Build Height Weight Defense Points** 9 Slight 140–155 cm 40–50 kg +2 2 extra 12 Small 150–170 cm 45–65 kg +1 1 extra 15 Medium 160–180 cm 50–75 kg ±0 0 18 Well-Built 170–190 cm 55–85 kg −1 1 21 Tall 180–200 cm 65–95 kg −2 2 24 Large 185–210 cm 70–110 kg −3 3 27 Giant 190–220 cm 75–130 kg −4 4 30 Gigantic 195–230 cm 85–150 kg −5 5 Table 1:24 Lucky (points: see below) The character possesses a luck that sets them apart from the crowd. Increase the character's attribute value in Luck according to table 1:25 Luck value Points 1 1 2 2 3 3 4 4 5 5 6 6 7 7 8 8 9 9 10 10 Table 1:25 Appearance (points: see below) "When young Miss Bonn smiles, the world stops. Men can't help thinking dirty thoughts while women can't suppress their envy." Appearance always plays a major role. If a person looks good it's noticed, and the person has a greater chance of achieving success, wealth and stardom. The disadvantage is that people more easily recognize you and that you attract attention generally, which makes it difficult to blend into the crowd. Good

looks help the character in most cases of social interaction, debate and seduction. If the player wants the character to have an appearance other than ordinary, simply choose which one in table 1:26 and note the change in background points. A good or bad appearance can affect by giving bonuses or penalties. This applies in situations where an advantageous appearance can help, or a repulsive appearance can hurt, for example when trying to charm someone, talk your way into a hot nightclub, persuade someone, succeed in getting a film role, physically attract someone, etc. The narrator must decide on a case-by-case basis whether the bonus or penalty is applicable. Often the character's appearance affects their roll for Impression, see page 209, and in most cases where social conflicts arise. The bonus a character gets because of their appearance gives observers the same bonus when it comes to observing, noticing and remembering the character, for example if the police ask for a description. Even people with penalties due to unfavorable appearance give the observer a bonus, as ugly people also stand out from the crowd, just like beautiful people, so there ugliness becomes a double punishment. Table 1:26 summarizes appearance and its significance. Appearance Bonus/penalty Points Repulsive ±4 3 extra Ugly ±2 2 extra Unattractive ±1 1 extra Ordinary ±0 0 Attractive ±1 1 Handsome/Beautiful* ±2 2 Sensational ±3 4 Perfect ±4 6 Table 1:26 * Men are usually handsome while women are beautiful. Fate's Favorite (points: 1 to 3) Fate looks kindly upon the character. Increase the character's starting value in Fate according to table 1:27. **Fate Points** 15 1 20 2 25 3 Table 1:27 "Georgi, darling, run and fetch my strawberries. Don't forget that I'm the biggest in the whole, wide world." — Sayah Bonn

Chapter 3 – Belongings

A new day revealed itself as a mockery to me outside the sunlit blinds. Yesterday was a great battlefield of memory fragments and emotions. The headache told me to keep sleeping, but I was already late for the meeting with Manik — a broker of odd things I'd known for a long time. A good guy with connections. Laboriously I hauled myself out of bed, saw that I'd spilled a bottle of cheap liquor across the wooden floor and cursed my bad luck.

I should clean the revolver after yesterday's incident, but couldn't be bothered. Cartridges and casings lay scattered across the desk while I reloaded my faithful companion with hangover-trembling fingers. The gun oil and cleaning rod would have to wait. I quickly wiped down the knife too with a dirty towel. Noticed lipstick on the table and didn't remember where it had come from.

A half-drunk warm beer became breakfast while I tried to dampen the pile driver inside my skull with a handful of painkillers. The mold stench chased me away from the kitchen. A new shirt at least, for the sake of appearances. The one I'd slept in was both stained and torn. A new one with a starched and spotless collar. The pants would have to do, even though they reeked of sweat and smoke. The shoes were still damp from last night's rain. But first a few splashes of aftershave were needed to drown the stench of sin from my stiff and scarred body.

Once inside the bathroom I saw her. The frozen dead expression in the pale doll face, where she lay on her back in the dirty bathtub, with her head and arm over the edge. The dried blood had painted the soiled tile wall like a burst water pipe. The spatter had even reached the ceiling.

I sighed irritably and realized it was going to be one of those days. Manik would have to wait while I fetched the bag and the tools. And I'd just recently cleaned both the saw and the axe.

—Mordekai Remus, Thursday, 09:12

Possessions

People identify themselves with their belongings. While the upper class indulges in luxury and excess, the simple worker finds satisfaction in the simplest of things, like a new pot or perhaps a kitchen chair.

Property

Possessions include things and objects that a person carries with them or uses daily. This does not include larger investments such as permanent residence, personal vehicles, summer houses or furniture, as such things are included in the person's standard of living.

Generally, possessions are described quite abstractly because that's not where the focus in Noir is meant to lie. People usually automatically have with them reasonable equipment that fits their concept and place in the world without needing to be specified in detail beforehand. Some narrators, however, have higher demands and prefer that protagonists' possessions be written down to the last matchstick. This makes the whole thing more cumbersome but can simultaneously create drama when, for example, a rope is needed but missing.

Starting Equipment

In addition to the property included in the standard of living (see page 246), the protagonist has the following:

• A pack of cigarettes (if a smoker) • Glasses (if vision impaired) • A bag or duffel bag • Wallet or purse • Citizen's passport • Any licenses (weapons, etc.) • Any membership cards (to clubs, etc.) • Business cards (if deemed reasonable)

Cash

The currency in the Empire is called zovrin, after the dynasty of the same name. It is issued in both coins and bills. The coins are worth 1, 2, 5 and 10 zovrins while the bills come in denominations of 20, 50, 100, 500 and 1,000 zovrins.

Credit cards or debit cards do not exist in Noir's world; all transactions are made with cash or via checks or bills of exchange issued by a bank or credit institution. It's not entirely uncommon for larger transactions to be conducted through exchange of gold bars for a good or service. Cash and gold are usually stored either in safe deposit boxes or in private safes or vaults.

A protagonist receives starting capital from their standard of living, see page 248.

Loans

Should a protagonist lack cash, he/she can borrow money. How much can be borrowed is determined by the person's standard of living. The procedure is described on page 248. The entire loan procedure is kept deliberately abstract so as not to take focus away from the story. Therefore the rules do not determine the details regarding whether it's a bank, a credit institution, a gangster boss, a loan shark or perhaps the family lending out the capital.

Carrying Objects

It's not essential to keep track of the weight of objects carried on the body. The narrator and player should make a judgment about the reasonableness of the amount of equipment carried, so that there are at least

enough pockets or other storage spaces for it.

Two terms exist to facilitate interpretation, these are unwieldy and bulky respectively. The guideline is that a person can at most carry a limited number of unwieldy objects (a couple three pieces, perhaps more if the person is large and strong) and/or at most one bulky object.

Unwieldy objects are large, and/or heavy to carry around. A bulky object, on the other hand, is so strenuous to lug around that a person rarely manages to carry it more than brief moments at a time.

Examples of unwieldy objects are a large sword, large tools (like a pickaxe), a kitchen chair, a small child, a full suitcase or a crate of bottles. Bulky objects include a tire with rim, a body rolled in a carpet, a massive leather armchair, a large wooden crate filled with books or a welding unit without a cart.

Storage

A suggestion when it comes to objects carried on the body is to note where they are located. This creates a good overview and one quickly sees where unreasonable situations arise. Write down whether the object is in a pants pocket, in the coat, in the briefcase or perhaps in the glove compartment of the car. Those who are interested in keeping track of equipment also get a lot for free through this solution as one immediately sees what is lost respectively remains when, for example, an overcoat is left behind at a crime scene.

Buying Things

Purchases are made almost exclusively in stores face to face. Mail order is rare and expensive, although exclusive goods can be ordered from far away if one is rich.

Large department stores exist only in Sandukar and they are relatively uncommon in the capital. Instead it's small specialists, craftsmen, shops and retailers that dominate. There is almost always a tailor, a butcher, a baker, a shoemaker, a hardware store, etc., in every other block, so it's never far to go to get help.

Many stores make an effort with personal service and familiar atmosphere to get customers to stay and return. Various forms of discounts, gifts and special offers to regular customers and the affluent are common. Having a sense for service is crucial for one's livelihood as a shopkeeper.

Objects are usually in stock. If they must be ordered, it can, depending on the type of goods, take anywhere from a few days to several months to get them home. It's important that all one's licenses and permits are in order when making an order, otherwise most honest merchants will refuse the purchase, but most can still be persuaded with a bundle of cash.

Purchase

All prices are negotiable. This is symbolized by the rules regarding haggling over price, found on page 207.

Availability

Some of the objects in the equipment lists on page 94 and onward have an availability requirement next to the price. This requirement shows if anything special is needed to be able to obtain the item, such as the right kind of permit. Table 1:28 shows common price increases in cases where the availability requirement is not met.

Code Object's Availability

— Generally available — exists essentially everywhere commerce occurs. This code is not written out by the object but is assumed to be the default case.

§ Special, rationed or rare. The object is available in selected specialty stores, making it difficult to buy if one is outside the shopping districts in the city. Often a valid citizen's passport without criminal record is required to be allowed to purchase the object, otherwise the price is at least double (x2).

§§ Subject to restrictions. Some form of license or permit is required for acquisition of the object, for example weapons license or medical certification. If one doesn't have the papers in order, the price becomes between three to five times (x3 — x5) higher and one must buy the item on the black market. Most expensive if one lacks citizen's passport and is in the criminal registry.

§§§ Prohibited or illegal. The object is only available if one knows where to turn and one must usually have all papers in impeccable order, alternatively have well-established contacts and/or a long-standing and proven relationship with someone who can provide the object, otherwise the price becomes between six to twenty times (x6 — x20) higher.

Table 1:28

Licenses and Permits

There are a number of different phenomena and activities that require licenses or approved permits, including: own firearms, carry concealed firearms, own automatic weapons, be police (the so-called police shield), be firefighter, take flight certificate, be state inspector, be train engineer, be doctor, be priest, be journalist, handle explosives, take skipper's exam, start a family, be a citizen, attend higher education.

Selling used items

An item can always be sold to a junk dealer or pawnshop for approximately 20% of the new price. If you want to get a better price, you'll have to go to a shop or a merchant who has the opportunity to resell the item with their own profit— for example, a full toolbox can be sold to a hardware store with better profit than to a pawnshop. If you find the right buyer, the price is usually around 40% of the new price. The item's condition/quality has not been taken into account, see below.

The final price comes as a result of haggling, see page 207.

Condition & quality

An item's or service's condition and/or quality affects not only its value and price but also its function. There are six levels of condition/quality, which are shown in table 1:29.

The item's condition/quality is written before its name in the character sheet, for example "a poor pair of binoculars". Items with normal condition/quality need not be noted this way since they constitute the standard from which all deviations are judged.

The item's condition/quality gives bonuses or penalties to actions that involve the item or service in a reasonable way. If a carpenter claims that his exceptional screwdriver should give him a bonus to screwing, that shouldn't be approved, though perhaps the screwdriver withstands high stress or abuse. A car of exceptional quality, however, can give the driver a bonus since its quality actually helps the driver handle

demanding situations. Exceptional clothes can give a bonus to Impression or in social situations if it's deemed reasonable in the scene. It's up to the narrator and players to figure this out based on the prevailing situation.

An item's or service's condition/quality provides a multiplier that is calculated on its normal price. An excellent hotel room costs five times more per night than a normal hotel room. But at the same time, the excellent hotel room can give a bonus when, for example, business meetings, recovery from Wounds, or seduction takes place within it.

| Condition/quality | Bonus/penalty | Price | | Exceptional | +2 | x20 | | Excellent | +1 | x5 | | Normal* | ±0 | x1 | | Worn** | −1 | x0.8 | | Poor | −2 | x0.5 | | Wretched | −5 | x0.2 | | Broken | Cannot be used | x0.1 |

Table 1:29 * All shop-new items are considered to have this condition/quality. ** All used items that have not been abused are considered to have this condition/quality.

Breakdown & reliability

All items can break, or at least stop working as they should. This is called suffering a breakdown. When a breakdown occurs, some form of action is required to restore the item to working condition. Certain items generally cannot suffer breakdowns— this applies to solid items that lack mechanics or moving parts, such as a sword or a screwdriver. A narrator can of course choose to introduce breakdowns even for such items if the situation's framework and reasonability supports this—a screwdriver can, for example, break off if it's used incorrectly.

Breakdown

A breakdown occurs if an exceptional failure happens when using an item and the numbers on the dice also show equal to or below the item's breakdown value. In most situations, the breakdown value is (1), which means that breakdown occurs when the user rolls snake eyes and the result counts as an exceptional failure.

Note that if snake eyes are rolled but the roll counts as an exceptional success thanks to skill or bonuses, no breakdown occurs. This symbolizes that a competent and knowledgeable person automatically maintains and handles their items correctly, or the situation is so favorable that a breakdown cannot occur.

The breakdown value can be higher than (1) if the item being used is of inferior quality. This is indicated in table 1:30.

If an item breaks down, it is unusable until it has been repaired.

Stoppage

Stoppage is a lighter form of breakdown that only affects firearms and means that the weapon has jammed in some way—either there is some mechanical fault or the ammunition is defective or has ended up incorrectly in the feeding process.

When a person rolls for a combat action in which they fire a firearm in some way, stoppage occurs if the roll is exceptionally failed and the dice show below or equal to the weapon's breakdown value. One cartridge is struck from the weapon's magazine when stoppage has been determined.

Before a firearm that has suffered stoppage can be used again, a successful Reload action is required. Should the Reload action's difficulty roll also result in an exceptional failure and its numbers be equal to or below the weapon's breakdown value, the weapon has suffered a real breakdown and is unusable.

Item condition and quality

An item's condition/quality is crucial for its breakdown risk. A poorly maintained item runs a significantly higher risk of breakdown than a well-maintained one or one of good quality. Table 1:30 summarizes this.

The breakdown/stoppage column shows which numbers in a roll cause breakdown or stoppage in an exceptional failure when the item is handled.

"In the fight against the enemy, where one's equipment is the same as one's chance of survival, the reliability and durability of items is crucial. To the soldiers' disadvantage, and the bureaucrats' satisfaction, equipment of the best quality is considerably more expensive than a simple soldier's life." **— Vautiren Markov**

About stoppages

A question one might ask is why firearms get an extra chance at risk of breakdown—why don't they break down directly? This is because stoppage provides a dramatic effect that makes the game more exciting and unpredictable, as the player gets to make the choice to try to fix their jammed automatic pistol in the heat of battle, or do something else, rather than being forced to the latter if the weapon automatically breaks down and requires qualified repairs.

Condition/quality	Breakdown/stoppage
Exceptional	1
Excellent	1
Normal	1
Worn	1–2
Poor	1–4
Wretched	1–8
Broken	**Cannot be used**

Table 1:30

Example: Gabriel is at the eastern flank after a bloody storming of the enemy's trenches. He has just escaped a grenade blast but has lost his rifle in the confusion. In the wet mud, he steps on an old rusty army pistol. He wipes the worst filth off against his uniform shirt, blows the sticky mud out of the barrel, and checks that the weapon is loaded. The narrator judges that the pistol is in poor condition, and this means that every action with the weapon that results in an exceptional failure where the dice show snake eyes, double twos, double threes, or double fours means stoppage.

Gabriel is unlucky—he sees an enemy at a distance rushing toward him with a saber and chooses to shoot. The roll shows double twos and becomes exceptionally failed, so the weapon suffers stoppage. Desperate, Gabriel tries to reload in the next action and rolls a difficulty roll. The roll shows double threes and is also exceptionally failed, so the pistol breaks down completely and requires repair to work again. Resolute, Gabriel turns the pistol over to use it as an improvised club in the impending melee.

Repairs

Broken items must be repaired by someone who has tools, time, and competence. When a broken item is to be repaired, a difficulty roll (Construction) is usually required. One roll may be made per hour, and the repair generally counts as a complex action, see page 201.

In certain situations, the narrator may judge that other skills connected to the item can be used for repair, such as Vehicles for car breakdown and Firearms if a rifle stops working. In such cases, the narrator should apply a penalty (−5) to the roll, as it should be considered a makeshift fix rather than a competent repair. Should a roll for makeshift repair fail, the practitioner may not try again.

If any difficulty roll in the repair becomes exceptionally failed, the repairman has destroyed the item in some way, beyond the ordinary damage. The item's quality/condition then drops one level (an item of normal quality thus becomes worn). Should the numbers in the exceptional failure be lower than or equal to the item's breakdown value, the item can never be used again. The same applies if the item's condition reaches broken status.

"*...and nightmares. Miss Navarre also exhibits deep emotional disturbances, detachment, hateful behavior, and a clear authority problem. It is my professional assessment that Miss Navarre should immediately be placed in a rest home or, even better, in a sanatorium, where she receives the care she needs. I...*" **Dr. Amileia Anezka**

Explosives & skullduggery equipment

When diplomatic and/or subtle attempts to solve a problem don't help, more direct methods may be needed. More often than not, these methods involve explosives or other skullduggery equipment.

| Item | Price (availability) | Other | | Box of dynamite | 480z for 24 pieces (§§) | Bulky | | Lock picking set | 300z (§§) | | Forgery equipment | 10,000z (§§§) | Unwieldy | | Disguise materials | 1,500z | | Handcuffs | 120z | | Demolition equipment | 375z (§§) | Unwieldy | | Tripwire | 250z (§§) | Unwieldy | | Phone tapping equipment | 500z (§§§) | | Cable rifle | 1,200z (§) | Unwieldy | | Grappling hook | 165z | Unwieldy |

Academic & investigation equipment

Investigation equipment and academic equipment are a must for police officers and private detectives.

| Item | Price (availability) | Other | | Flash | 1z for two pieces | | Crime scene investigation equipment | 1,600z (§) | Unwieldy | | Pocket camera | 850z | | Film camera | 35,000z (§) | Bulky | | Developing equipment | 300z | Bulky | | Hand film camera | 2,800z (§) | | Chemistry equipment | 1,000z (§) | Bulky | | Laboratory equipment | 10,000z | Bulky | | Camera | 500z | | Reference library (subject) | 5,000z | Bulky |

Services & lodging

Services make Sandukar spin, often greased with money or favors. More expensive alternatives, i.e., higher condition/ quality, usually mean higher service level at the establishment or increased expertise from the person you hire.

| Item | Price (availability) | Other | | Lawyer | 250z per hour | | Courier service, distance | 75z | | Courier service, local | 10z | | Driver | 40z per hour | | Laborer | 20z per hour | | Hotel room | 200z per day | | Bodyguard | 100z per hour | | Postage | 1z per kilogram | | Private detective | 125z per hour | | Prostitute | 75z per hour | | Psychotherapy | 200z per hour | | Radio ad | 3z per 20 words | | Hospital/operation | 1,000z per hour | | Phone call, distance | 1z per minute | | Phone call, local | 1z per five minutes | | Telegram | 1z per ten words | | Newspaper ad | 5,000z per page |

Equipment

Below is a list of various items and services with price, availability, and any other information. The list should be seen as an inspiration and guideline and not as a complete listing of the total range available in Sandukar or in the Empire as a whole.

Miscellaneous

General items of various character.

| Item | Price (availability) | Other | | Notebook | 4z | | Batteries | 15z | | Gasoline | 2z per liter | | Gas can | 20z | Unwieldy, holds 20 liters | | Pencil | 1z | | Fire extinguisher | 300z | Bulky | | Cigarettes | 5z for 20 pieces | | Cigarette lighter | 10z | | Cigars | 2z for five pieces | | Dictaphone/tape recorder | 150z | | Blanket | 7z | | Gas mask | 100z | | Generator, gasoline | 2,500z | Bulky | | Padlock | 30z | | Instrument | 200z | Unwieldy | | Music record | 30z | | Appointment calendar | 25z | | Paper sheets | 4z per 50 pieces | | Pipe | 60z | | Rope, 15 meters | 30z | Unwieldy | | Fountain pen | 10z | | Typewriter | 250z | Bulky | | Literary book | 10z | | Tobacco | 5z for ten doses | | Wire radio | 500z (§) | Bulky | | Matches | 2z per box | | Business cards | 50z per 100 pieces |

Tools

Tools are indispensable if the protagonists want to perform work of various kinds. Tools can be purchased individually or bought in sets. The contents of tool sets are only suggestions, and it's up to the narrator and player to collaborate so that the contents of a set become reasonable.

| Item | Price (availability) | Other | | Blowtorch | 60z | Unwieldy | | Crowbar | 40z | Unwieldy | | Bolt cutters | 150z | Unwieldy | | Pickaxe | 80z | Unwieldy | | Duct tape | 15z per roll | | Shovel | 80z | Unwieldy | | Welding equipment | 700z (§) | Bulky | | Cable | 3z per meter | | Tool set: electrician | 1,500z | Bulky | | Tool set: basic | 200z | Unwieldy | | Tool set: mechanic | 1,000z | Bulky | | Tool set: carpenter | 1,800z | Bulky | | Tool set: excavation | 3,000z | Bulky |

Tickets

If you want extra good service and more luxury when traveling by, for example, train or airship, you must buy a ticket of higher quality, see page 92.

Rental

Renting a vehicle of normal type (passenger car, van, truck) costs approximately 500 zovrins per day. From unknown customers, the lessor usually requires a substantial deposit. To rent a vehicle requires a citizen's passport.

Food & Entertainment For the average citizen, it's the simpler pleasures that make time pass. You spend a large part of your time at work and need something to temporarily loosen monotony's grip on you. Item Price (Availability) Other Cinema ticket 5z Daily newspaper 1z Breakfast 20z Field ration 25z Deck of cards 10z Lunch 30z Dinner 50z Musical ticket 30z Opera ticket 60z Sporting event ticket 20z Spirits, bottle 20z Spirits, glass 8z Theater ticket 40z Dice 6z for two Variety show ticket 10z Wine, bottle 15z Wine, glass 6z Beer, bottle 7z Beer, glass 4z Light & Navigation On expeditions into the wilderness beyond the city, equipment is very important. Item Price (Availability) Other Flashlight 60z Hand lamp 75z Binoculars 350z Communications radio 600z (§) Compass 40z Lantern, gasoline 25z Lantern, electric 120z Flare 25z for five **Medical Equipment** A collection of drugs and medical equipment for both stabilization and healing. Item Price (Availability) Other Drug, sedative 50z per dose (§§§) Drug, hallucinogen 50z per dose (§§§) Drug, truth serum 100z per dose (§§§) Drug, painkiller 15z per dose (§§) Drug, stimulant 50z per dose (§§§) First aid kit 125z Poison, sedative 40z per dose (§§) Poison, lethal 250z per dose (§§§) Surgical equipment 2,000z (§) Bulky Smelling salts 35z Doctor's bag 500z (§) Straitjacket 200z (§) Clothing & Accessories All protagonists receive a wardrobe from their standard of living (see page 246). Any clothes or accessories acquired beyond that are seen as additional supplements to this wardrobe. More about fashion can be found on page 96. Item Price (Availability) Other Work clothes 70z Wristwatch 250z Fine clothes 1,000z Eyeglasses 500z Hat 125z Formal wear 3,000z Cane 175z Umbrella 70z

Footwear 100z Makeup 200z Jewelry 1,500z Sunglasses 175z Toiletries, woman 200z Toiletries, man 100z Uniform 500z (§§) Everyday clothes 300z Pocket watch 200z Outerwear 700z Vehicles & Travel Certain standards of living include vehicles of various kinds. Vehicles acquired independently are not included in assets when moving up or down in standard of living (see pages 248-249). Item Price (Availability) Other Bicycle 400z Bulky Flight ticket 500z per hour Airplane 2,000,000z (§§) Cannot be carried Truck 90,000z (§) Cannot be carried Limousine 60,000z (§) Cannot be carried Luxury car 200,000z (§) Cannot be carried Motorcycle 10,000z (§) Cannot be carried Automobile 40,000z (§) Cannot be carried Van 50,000z (§) Cannot be carried Sports car 300,000z (§) Cannot be carried Taxi ride 1z per minute Cannot be carried Tractor 35,000z Cannot be carried Train ticket 10z per hour Zeppelin ticket 50z per hour Zeppelin 12,000,000z (§§) Cannot be carried "The desire was too strong, she wanted too much. That was her weakness, that was where she went wrong. Photo flashes and gala premieres, furs, jewelry and nightclubs. That's why she's dead now. Why wasn't she born ugly?" — Gabriel Jandaran **Renting Clothes** Among common folk it's usual to rent formal wear rather than buy it. The rental for a complete outfit usually runs around 150 zovrins per day, but that includes washing, ironing and handling.

Clothing & Accessories At galas and premieres, on factory floors and in offices, everywhere fashion is represented. Some people spend enormous sums on having the latest from the most talked-about tailoring houses, all so they can keep their places in society's finest rooms. **Fashion** Fashion is very important in the social game. Clothes show which social level one moves in and allow one to determine at a glance how to treat the person standing before you. Thus they have a control function as they help people know their place. Fashion regarding clothes and accessories varies rapidly with new designers' whims and fashion houses' caprices. Within the upper social classes, and the families in particular, it's important to be updated about what's in. People usually keep current with the help of stylish fashion magazines, visits to fashionable fashion shows and mingling with fashion designers at high society cocktail parties. There are thousands of different clothing brands, some families even have their own fashion designers who manufacture garments only for them. Likewise there are influential tailors whose names make their creations incredibly valuable. **How Clothes Are Bought** Clothes are acquired in two ways, either as ready-to-wear, or as custom-tailored garments. Ready-to-wear clothes are manufactured in textile factories, in mass editions, and sold to citizens via the fashionable department stores in the city, or in smaller shops that often specialize in one or a few types of garments, for example coats, hats, shoes or ladies' wear. Custom tailoring is still common but it's more expensive than buying ready-to-wear. The advantage of custom-tailored garments is that the fit becomes much better and the customer can influence the garment's appearance in a hands-on way. Most customers like the personal relationship built up between tailor and customer and many keep the same tailor for many years. Alongside the tailor, the shoemaker, glovemaker and hatmaker are also respected professionals. The trade in used clothes is extensive. In shops and at market squares used clothes of greatly varying type, style and quality are sold. Among the less well-off it's common for clothes to be used until they literally fall apart. The clothes are patched and mended until the very end.

Women's Fashion

Ladies' fashion is what varies most from year to year. New ideas are tested and new designers take over. The current fashion favors the feminine and highlights the classic feminine curved form, with hips, narrow waist and emphasized bust. **Undergarments** Undergarments are usually made of cotton, silk or satin. Lace is often present, especially among the upper class. Corsets come in many different types, everything from those worn openly, as a daring garment, to those intended for more festive use and which grant a pronounced neckline. Other models provide generally better and more comfortable support but are then used primarily with blouses or jacket tops. Stockings are often made of nylon and reach mid-thigh and come in different styles —

usually held up with the help of garter belts. Blouse & Sweater The blouse is usually solid-colored and made of cotton or silk. The collar has soft and rounded tips and the neck is usually v-necked. The sleeves are wide and flowing and reach past the wrist. Among women in certain professions the blouses are very similar to men's shirts with pronounced collars and pointed tips. Sweaters are used more often by women than by men and don't have the same lower-class stigma when worn by a woman. The sweaters are usually thin and form-fitting to show the feminine figure. Skirt & Trousers The skirt is a very common garment, the length usually reaches to the knees — wearing shorter skirts than that is considered vulgar and cheap. The styles are usually straight, single-slit or pleated. If volume is needed a petticoat is used. Trousers are used primarily by working women or in other situations where the skirt gets in the way of the tasks at hand. The trousers are usually made of durable wool, cotton or linen. **Suit** The suit consists of a skirt or trousers with matching jacket. A woman's suit can be said to correspond to a man's suit. **Dress** There are many variants of dresses, suitable for different situations from everyday to parties. Like the skirt, the dress rarely ends higher than at the knee but long dresses often have slits. The dress usually buttons in front, or has a zipper in back, while certain models have lacing at the side. Jacket & Coat Jackets are form-fitting, discreet and short and end just below the waist. The lapels are pronounced but not as large as those displayed by men's fashion. The coat should cover the skirt and thus reaches approximately mid-calf. Both jackets and coats have discreet shoulder pads and are usually single-breasted. Among high society the fur is common, often made of mink, fox or rabbit. The most exclusive furs are made of wolf fur. At more festive occasions and at premieres a pronounced and elegant cape with high collars is sometimes used. **Hat** The fashion-conscious woman wears a wide-brimmed hat with a fairly angular profile. More active working women often use male hat styles such as the fedora. During mourning or other occasions when it's etiquette to conceal the face, the woman wears a veil. **Shoes** The standard footwear for women is pumps, a closed shoe with a low heel. A second alternative is the button boot. At more festive occasions shoes with higher heels are used, often between four and eight centimeters, but sometimes even higher. Boots are also common, especially in poor weather. The boots reach mid-calf or to the knee. **Women's Accessories** Jewelry and jewels of various kinds are common among wealthier women. Silver, gold and platinum are valuable metals and rubies, emeralds, sapphires and diamonds are popular settings in rings, bracelets, earrings and necklaces. Other ways to express oneself are by wearing colored ribbons in the hair, elaborate hairstyles, ankle and waist jewelry or neck chokers with or without bows. At events long gloves are worn as a complement to the long dress. To this often comes a fluffy boa, a shawl or a scarf. Handbags are also in fashion. They are relatively large, seen more as a means of expression than as a practical storage space and can contain everything from makeup to small firearms. "We used to love each other but now I wonder, are you my friend or my enemy? Before I saw such things in your eyes, now there's nothing there." — Gabriel Jandaran to Talia Navarre

Men's Fashion

Men's fashion has been the same for a long time, with the suit as the classic garment. A number of changes occur as trends shift, particularly regarding color, form and accessories, but the basic appearance is the same. Office workers usually wear shirts and trousers while manual laborers, farmers and miners use trousers of coarse fabric and sweaters. **Undergarments** Men often wear undergarments of cotton or silk. On the upper body the undershirt is not uncommon, especially among the middle class. Socks are almost always made of cotton and usually match the color of the trousers. **Suit** The men of Sandukar usually wear a two- or three-piece suit. The three-piece suit consists of jacket, trousers and vest in matching colors, while the two-piece lacks the vest. The suits are usually solid-colored, and common shades are muted brown, beige, gray, black and charcoal. A popular pattern is the pinstripe, on gray, blue or charcoal-colored backgrounds. **Jacket** The jacket is either single- or double-breasted. The lapels are broad, with pointed tips. Shoulder pads are sewn in to give a more masculine appearance. Two outer pockets and one breast pocket are standard. The materials

that dominate are cotton and wool. Linen and tweed also occur. **Vest** A vest is worn with a suit and is always in a matching color. It's often part of formal or party attire. The vest lacks a collar or lapels and is single-breasted. The back panel is either in the same material as the front panel or in distinguishing silk. On regular suit vests two front pockets are something of a standard. Shirt & Sweater The shirt is almost always made of cotton, even though silk shirts are preferred in certain upper-class circles. Flannel shirts occur among the working class. Solid-colored, white, shirts are most popular. If they are patterned they are vertically striped. The collar is pronounced and the tips are fairly long and pointed. The shirt usually lacks a breast pocket. The cuffs usually have buttons sewn on, but finer shirts should instead be used with detachable cufflinks. The shirt always buttons all the way up, even if a tie is absent. It's considered unkempt to have the top button unbuttoned. Sweaters are uncommon and are considered lower-class garments. It's primarily outdoor manual laborers who wear thick, sturdy, usually gray, wool sweaters. Tie & Bow Tie A tie is almost always worn with the shirt. Manual laborers usually go tieless as the tie gets in the way of their work. The tie should reach just below the trousers' waistband. It's usually solid-colored and almost always darker than the shirt. Discreetly and tastefully patterned ties are acceptable but more vul-

garish expressions are usually viewed with contempt by the conservative upper class – with the exception of the Guiskard family where colorful ties are more the rule than the exception. The tie is held in place with a tie pin in the same metal as the belt buckle, buttons and wristwatch. In the banking and entertainment world, the bow tie often replaces the necktie as neck attire. **Trousers** Trousers are primarily made of cotton, wool or linen. They are of straight design with turned-up cuffs and pressed creases. The colors are matte and if a jacket is worn, the trousers are almost always matched. With trousers, suspenders are worn, but the belt is gaining ground and it's becoming increasingly common for loops to be sewn onto trousers so that a belt can be used. Two front pockets are common. Manual laborers and country folk often have trousers in coarser fabrics. Coat & jacket The overcoat is usually made of wool. It usually comes single-breasted, although double-breasted variants occur among the families and the military. Previously it was forbidden for ordinary citizens to wear double-breasted coats. The coat usually extends to mid-calf. The lapels are wide and the colors often dark. At the front, the trench coat is very common. It is a beige, gray or dark poplin coat that has good resistance to moisture and rain. The leather coat is also not uncommon. Within the Kriger family, black leather coats made of pigskin, with silver buttons, are very common among both men and women. On special occasions or at receptions, the cape is not entirely uncommon, especially among the upper class. **Hat** The hat is a given among the men of the Empire when they are outdoors. All hats are made of durable felt and come in a multitude of different colors and shapes. Usually the hat is in the same shade, or darker, than the suit being worn. At festivities or formal occasions, the tall top hat is sometimes used. The cap is a distinctly working-class headgear and is primarily used by the lower class. **Shoes** The majority of all shoes are made of leather and have leather or wooden soles. The colors vary but brown and black shoes dominate. If a belt is worn, its color should match the shoes. Patent leather shoes are used at parties and holidays and are almost exclusively black, with shiny soles for the best dancing aid. Manual laborers use solid boots in durable leather that must withstand dirt, moisture and hard work. The boot is usually knee-high, in treated leather, with a sturdy sole. Many officers in the army wear boots as part of their uniform. **Men's accessories** Having special buttons, particular tie pins, a handkerchief in the breast pocket, an exclusive pocket watch or perhaps an elegant scarf creates a personal style. The important general rule when it comes to accessories is the rule of matching. If metal accessories are worn, for example cufflinks, belt buckle, pocket watch, wristwatch, tie pin, tie clip and rings, everything should be of the same metal. Mixing gold

with silver is a grave breach of etiquette, not to mention mixing base metals with precious ones. Cufflinks are often custom-ordered to be of a particular material or have a chosen motif such as a family crest, initials or set gemstones. Wearing different types of rings is common. There are countless variants, everything from

wedding or engagement rings to graduation rings, order rings or family rings. The families have their own rings that members wear. Those who work at higher levels within the State often wear so-called state rings. Within the upper class, the walking stick is common. Often it's a black, polished wooden cane with a knob in precious metal, with delicate ornamentation or proper family traditions on it. On the hands, leather gloves are often worn, which should preferably match the overcoat's color. The gloves are usually lined to warm the hands. Party & ceremony When it's a ball, soirée, banquet, cocktail party, wedding, reception, premiere or inauguration, it's important to have the right clothes. Everyone in the upper class and most in the middle class own a tuxedo or an evening gown. If you don't, there are usually good opportunities to rent such items for an occasion. Women wear either an evening gown, or at more formal events, a ball gown. An evening gown is an elegant type of dress that is often strapless and/or low-cut. The evening gown is usually accompanied by a chic jacket, a stately cape or a tasteful shawl as well as long evening gloves, so-called opera gloves. These reach above the elbow and are often made of satin to signal feminine elegance and sensuality. With the evening gown, jewelry of various kinds is worn such as rings, earrings, bracelets and necklaces. The ball gown, sometimes called a tailcoat gown, is a floor-length dress that is mainly used at balls and other similar ceremonies where formal dress is recommended. The woman preferably wears it together with a starched petticoat so that the dress skirt can achieve generous width. The ball gown usually lacks sleeves but can be complemented with long gloves. It often has a bare back and can be strapless and low-cut as far as good taste allows. The male tuxedo consists of several parts: a black tuxedo jacket with velvet or silk lapels, black trousers with braids, a white tuxedo shirt (unstarched) with pleated ruffle, a cummerbund (black at formal occasions, colorful at more boisterous parties) or a vest, a bow tie in the same color as the cummerbund, black suspenders and black patent leather shoes. At more formal events, it's the tailcoat that applies. The tailcoat is a male formal dress, it is black and has long tails at the back and jacket lapels of silk. The trousers have silk braids and lack cuffs. With tailcoats, a white tailcoat shirt and white bow tie are worn as well as a vest. In the jacket's breast pocket there is usually a white handkerchief carefully placed. Outdoors, a black top hat and cane are worn. The hands are enclosed in white gloves of thin fabric. The male formal dress can always be replaced with dress uniform if an officer rank within the armed forces, police or security corps is held.

Cultural differences

There are many cultural differences in fashion and they become particularly noticeable when leaving the capital Sandukar. The different kingdoms that make up the Empire all have their distinctive traits when it comes to clothing style, although in the cities people try to dress so they fit in as well as possible. **Darost** The majority of the population in Darost wears simple, unadorned clothes, but many Celenkers still wear their traditional costumes. Among the latter, white, wide-sleeved shirts and blouses are common, and richly embroidered velvet jackets with slashed sleeves are worn by both men and women. Celenka women often don long, wide skirts. **Iskarian** Since the capital Sandukar constitutes Iskarian's shining center, it is from here fashion flows and here all original clothing styles have been absorbed. **Kovan** The traditional sleeveless wool coat in black or dark blue is still worn by men in Kovan at ceremonies such as weddings and funerals. The coat extends to the knees and under it a shirt with wide sleeves is worn. A cloth belt is tied around the waist to hold the coat together. The traditional dress is floor-length, lacks sleeves and often comes in dark red or dark green. Married women cover their hair with a shawl. **Madrostav** The former high culture of Madrostav doesn't have much left of its clothing tradition but here and there women still wear wide dresses with multitudes of colorful petticoats. Embroidered headscarves and gold jewelry as well as waist sashes decorated with silver coins are worn at festive occasions. Men wear baggy linen trousers, a shirt with a high collar, and a vest that is laced together. **Presvedonia** Among men, uniform-like garments are common, the outer coats are double-breasted and the trousers are tucked into the high, coarse boots or work boots. The shirts and blouses have

lacing in the sleeves and neck and one pulls them over the head to put them on. Embroidery and simpler silver jewelry are common embellishments. **Sadovia** Sadovia seems to have stopped in development when it comes to clothes and fashion. Here it's prim Victorian dresses with tightly laced corsets that apply for women and for men strict suits are custom. **Vadaja** Up in the northern mountains and the isolated villages, not much has changed over the past centuries but here people still wear traditional clothing. Men wear trousers held together with wide belts and long sheepskin vests and fur coats are common during the cold seasons. Thick, knitted cardigans and woven dresses, often naturally dyed, are common among women.

For many citizens, violence is omnipresent. Some choose to shy away and try to avoid problems, but others choose to arm themselves to be able to defend themselves when threatening situations arise – often with fatal consequences. **Acquiring weapons** For an unconvicted citizen with a valid citizenship pass, there are no major problems in obtaining a personal weapon license for an automatic pistol or revolver. The right forms are acquired from the authorities, filled in and stamped at the gun dealer, together with the weapon's serial number. Without a valid license, ammunition may not be purchased. Generally one must obtain a separate permit to be allowed to carry the weapon concealed when present in public places, but if the citizen has a profession that requires this, the State usually doesn't see any problems with it. A current license must always accompany the citizenship pass as long as the weapon is in the person's possession. Automatic weapons and heavier weapons, like machine guns and flamethrowers, may only be possessed by members of the State's forces – the military and police – when these are on duty. Of course, there is extensive black market trade in illegal weapons where serial numbers are filed off and where the weapons have often been involved in criminal contexts previously. Such illegal weapons circulate on the shadow market until they are completely worn out. Being found with an illegal weapon results in confiscation and prosecution in court. **Weapon information** Weapons is a collective term for the different ways and objects a person uses to try to incapacitate another person, whether it be in a boxing match, on the battlefield, in a gang confrontation or in some other context. Since combat and action tend to be commonly occurring in Noir's world, weapon information is fairly thorough. It's not necessary for narrators and players to know everything covered in this chapter, but the information is available for those interested. Below follows an explanation of various terms found mentioned in the weapon lists on pages 104–117. Weapons & combat equipment

Conceal

When a person wants to attempt to detect a concealed weapon on another person, an opposed roll is made (the detector's Perception against the carrier's Dexterity). The carrier receives penalties or bonuses depending on the weapon's Conceal value, as well as depending on how the weapon is carried, see page 119. If the detector frisks instead of observes, he/she receives a bonus (+10) to their roll.

As long as the weapon is not concealed in some way, for example under a jacket or coat, it is naturally automatically visible if someone looks. Objects classified as unwieldy or bulky (see page 91) cannot normally be concealed.

Grip (Melee Weapons) Most melee weapons, or implements used in melee, can be used with either one or two hands. As long as a person is not using one hand for something else, Noir's rules system assumes he/she is holding the weapon with both hands, in cases where this is reasonable (knives and daggers, for example, are generally not used with two hands). The effect of using a weapon with both hands is that the person may add their Damage Bonus to the damage value one additional time.

Grip (Firearms) Certain types of firearms can only be handled properly with two hands. If this requirement is not met, the shooter receives a penalty (−5). Firearms that only require one hand (for example automatic

pistols and revolvers) benefit from the support of two-handed shooting. If the shooter is not using one hand for something else, the rules assume it is used as support, which gives a bonus (+1) on dice rolls (Firearms).

It is possible to use a one-handed firearm in each hand simultaneously. The description of combat actions that involve two one-handed firearms specifies which rules apply.

Malfunction

The weapon's construction can increase the risk of misfires and malfunctions, which is indicated by its malfunction value. See page 92 for more information about malfunctions.

Caliber

The caliber indicates a firearm's ammunition diameter, either in millimeters or in hundredths of an inch. One must have the correct caliber ammunition for it to fit the weapon.

Magazine

The magazine's size and design determines how many cartridges the weapon can be loaded with and how the cartridges are stored.

Precision

Precision indicates how much bonus a shooter receives when he/she takes time to aim by, for example, using the combat action Shoot aimed fire.

Recoil

The recoil is the jerk the weapon gives off when it is fired. How noticeable the recoil becomes depends on two factors, partly on the shooter's inherent nervousness and fear of the recoil, partly on how much the force at firing actually affects the weapon. High recoil is counteracted by high weapon weight, good physique, and handling training.

At the Recoil value, the letters "A" and "E" are also present. They describe the weapon's mechanism – fully automatic mechanism (A), single-shot mechanism (E), or both (AE). For most combat actions involving firearms, it is stated as a requirement that the weapon must have a specific mechanism – if the weapon lacks the correct mechanism, it cannot be used to perform that specific combat action.

Range

All firearms and throwing weapons have three range limits – short, effective, and maximum range. Attacks against targets within the weapon's short range are not modified, attacks against targets within the weapon's effective range receive a penalty (−2), attacks against targets within the weapon's maximum range receive a penalty (−5), and attacks against targets farther away than the weapon's maximum range receive a penalty (−10). See table 1:31 for a summary. Maximum range is always double the effective range.

The narrator should view the ranges listed for weapons as recommendations. Noir is not a detailed tactical game, and if a target is judged to be exactly on a range limit, it is better to let it fall within the shorter distance.

Range Penalty

Within short ±0 Beyond short but within effective −2 Beyond effective but within maximum −5 Beyond maximum −10

Table 1:31

Damage Value

The damage value for different weapons is written, for example, "2D−1". That means the damage effect is rolled with two dice (D stands for die) and one is subtracted from the sum.

Some damage values are designated, for example, "S1D". The code "S" stands for stunning; more information about stunning damage effects can be found on page 263.

Distance and Melee

Two terms are used to determine combat distance. Ranged combat is combat with firearms or throwing weapons against enemies who are usually out of reach. Melee is combat at such short distance that those involved can touch each other without great effort. Melee can be fought either unarmed or armed.

Melee Weapons

The concept of melee includes all forms of man-to-man combat, both armed and unarmed. Melees are fought when attacker and defender are in proximity to each other, often at contact distance.

Melee weapons include all possible different weapons and implements a person can use to effectively render an enemy unfit for combat. It is common for a person to try to specialize in a specific type of weapon that he/she prefers.

For all melee attacks, Damage Bonus is added to the weapon's damage value. See also the section "Grip" on page 103.

Knife

The knife, that is, a sharpened blade with handle, comes in many different designs: double-edged, single-edged, with guard, etc. This also includes the stiletto, whose blade is hidden in the handle, as well as other lighter bladed weapons.

Dagger

This includes, in addition to the common dagger, the commando knife and bayonet, which are substantial double-edged knives intended for the battlefield. The commando knife can be likened to a universal tool for the State's commando soldiers who often carry out sabotage and resistance operations in enemy territory. The bayonet can be used either in hand or on a rifle with bayonet mount. In the latter case, the rifle becomes a spear-like melee weapon.

Melee Weapons Damage Value Conceal Price

Unarmed combat S1D −− Light, improvised implement S2D−1/1D+1* Varies – Heavy, improvised implement S3D−2/2D* Varies – Very heavy, improvised implement S4D−3/3D−1* Varies – Knife 1D +6 75z Dagger*** 1D+2 +1 150z Club** S3D−2 −6 60z Spear** 2D+1 Unwieldy 200z Sword** 2D−1 −8 2,500z Axe** 2D −7 250z

- The narrator determines whether the damage effect is Stunning or Lethal, see page 263 for more information. Generally, all attacks with weapons with a sharp edge or point inflict Lethal damage, while crushing or blunt attacks usually cause Stunning damage. Improvised implements break if the damage effect shows an odd result. ** The weapon can be used with both one-handed and two-handed grip. If used with two-handed grip, damage bonus is added one extra time. *** Bayonets used attached to rifles count as spears with the rifle's Conceal value.

Throwing Weapons Damage Value Range Conceal Price

Light, improvised throwing weapon S2D−1/1D+1* 5–10 m Varies – Heavy, improvised throwing weapon S3D−2/2D* 2–5 m Varies – Throwing knife 1D+2 5–15 m +6 75z Shuriken 1D+1 10–25 m +2 40z Hand grenade** 10–25 m +3 80z Molotov cocktail*** 5–10 m −4 25z

- The narrator determines whether the damage effect is Stunning or Lethal, see page 263 for more information. ** The damage value for damage zones is: S10D (0–1 m), S5D (1–2 m), S2D (2–5 m). See page 266 for more information. *** The damage value is 2D−1 per round of exposure. Spread radius two meters, burns out in five rounds, ignition value +5. See additional information on page 267.

Army saber (sword) Heirloom sword (sword) Stiletto (knife) Wood axe (axe) Fire axe (axe) Folding knife (knife)

Spear

Rapier (sword)

Club

A club made of, for example, wood or steel inflicts substantial crushing damage. The designation includes everything from the police baton to the cudgel.

Spear

The spear is a long stick topped with a double-edged metal blade that is thrust into the enemy.

Sword

Swords come in countless lengths and designs – with single or double edge, straight, curved, wide or narrow blade, one-handed or two-handed grip – it is only the creator's imagination that sets limits. Rapiers and sabers are also included in the designation. A sword can be camouflaged in, for example, a cane – and thus become a so-called swordstick.

Axe

The axe consists of a blade with a handle. Common versions are the meat cleaver, hand axe, and machete. The somewhat larger fire axe is also included in the designation, and in the countryside the handy wood axe is often seen.

Throwing Weapons

Throwing weapons are weapons and objects a person flings away in hopes of hitting a target or position. Nearly all throwing weapons are one-handed weapons. Skilled weapon throwers can perform tricks or inflict great damage with these primitive weapons.

Throwing Knife

The throwing knife is sharpened and well-balanced, and often made entirely of steel. It comes in countless different designs.

Shuriken

The shuriken is a metal construction in the form of a star with sharpened edges. The weapon is of Celenkt origin. It is handy and relatively easy to conceal. With a little training, the shuriken can also be used as a melee weapon.

Hand Grenade

A hand grenade is a small cylindrical metal object with an explosive substance inside. The hand grenade is armed by pulling out a pin and releasing a safety lever – which often occurs when the grenade is thrown. Most hand grenades detonate on impact or within a few seconds from being armed. A hand grenade damages its surroundings through an explosive pressure wave and by the casing breaking up into numerous fragments. In game terms, a hand grenade detonates in direct connection with the throw action.

Molotov Cocktail A molotov cocktail is a glass bottle filled with gasoline or other flammable liquid (for example spirits) and with a rag in the neck. The rag is ignited and the bottle is thrown against the ground where it breaks so that the rag comes in contact with the liquid which then hopefully catches fire. In game terms, the liquid catches fire in direct connection with the throw action.

Other Forms of Melee

Unarmed Combat Mastering unarmed combat means having the ability to utilize body, fists, feet, head, elbows, and knees in the best way to render the enemy unfit for combat. There are numerous different specialization areas (see page 58) that improve a person's melee ability.

Light, improvised implement For example screwdriver, scissors, shoe, book, stool, stiletto heel, hockey puck, telephone, billiard cue, chain, flower vase, bottle, or coffee mug.

Heavy, improvised implement For example crowbar, plank, tool, frying pan, chair, golf club, fire poker, or tire iron.

Very heavy, improvised implement For example a board, shovel, sledgehammer, tire, or bookshelf.

Improvised implements' durability

All melee weapons with the term "improvised" in the name are not made for fighting with. Therefore, it is easy for them to break or become unusable in some way. If the damage effect from such a weapon in an attack becomes odd, the improvised weapon is counted as unusable for the rest of the fight.

Example: Mordekai hits a shady nightclub owner with a billiard cue that counts as a "light, improvised implement". The damage effect lands on eight, which is not odd, so the cue holds. The next attack Mordekai performs also hits but now the damage effect becomes five – an odd result – so the cue shatters into splinters.

Other types of throwing weapons

Light, improvised throwing weapon For example flower vase, bottle, coffee mug, ashtray, plate, automatic pistol, book, stool, hockey puck, attaché case, revolver, tool, a fistful of nuts and bolts, or a substantial stone.

Heavy improvised throwing weapon

For example coffee table, large painting, wheel, submachine gun, sword, rifle, shovel, axe, heavy furniture, crowbar, sledgehammer, or trash can.

Cudgel (club) Police baton (club) Dagger (dagger)

Throwing knife

Shuriken (dagger) Commando knife (dagger) Bayonet (dagger)

Hand grenade

Automatic Pistols

Automatic pistols are small one-handed firearms intended for easy transport and effective defense at short distances. The term automatic pistol refers to the mechanism where the empty casing is ejected and a new cartridge is automatically fed into the barrel each time the weapon is fired. For firing a new shot, a new trigger pull is required – the weapon does not continuously feed in cartridges if the trigger is held down.

Most automatic pistols require slide operation or other manual preparation each time the weapon is reloaded with a new magazine. All automatic pistols are one-handed weapons. Those weapons that are magazine-fed can have an extra cartridge in the chamber, even though this is considered unsafe as it increases the risk of accidental discharge.

Breer z.7 The Breer z.7 is one of Sandukar's most common automatic pistols despite the relatively expensive price tag. The pistol is common on the civilian market and has a good reputation for being durable, safe, and reliable. It is often found with private detectives, spies, and bodyguards. The magazine capacity and the manageable recoil add to its popularity.

Breer z.9 The Breer z.9 is a well-regarded pistol often used as a backup weapon or as a handy and light main weapon. It is powerful in relation to its size and is readily used by those who want to be able to carry a weapon without it being clearly visible, such as criminal police and ministry personnel. The weapon's low mass makes it somewhat harder to control during rapid fire, compared to heavier models.

Automatic Pistols Damage Value Range Precision Recoil Magazine Caliber Conceal Malfunction Price* Breer z.7 2D−1 10–50 m +2 3E 13+1 9mm +4 ±0 2,200z Breer z.9 2D−1 5–20 m +1 3E 7+1 9mm +7 +1 1,900z Calder M2245 2D+1 10–50 m +2 4E 8+1 .45 Auto +3 ±0 1,500z Darov 5/2 2D−1 5–10 m +1 4E 2c 9mm +10 +2 800z Darov 6/6 1D+1 5–10 m +1 2E 9+1 6mm +8 +1 590z Karev Morov** 1D+1 10–50 m +3 2E 15+1 6mm +5 ±0 3,500z Kriger Army Pistol-4 2D 10–50 m +2 3E 7+1 10mm ±0 ±0 2,000z

- Availability for all automatic pistols is §§. ** The weapon is prepared to accept a suppressor.

Firearms

Firearms are handheld mechanical weapons that fire projectiles at the enemy, usually a bullet fired via a cartridge.

The modern battlefield demonstrates the superiority of firearms, as a soldier at long distance can eliminate the enemy with minimal risk to their own life and limb.

Kriger Army Pistol-4 Darov 5/2 Breer z.7

Calder M2245 The Calder-45 is the pistol that rules Sandukar's back streets. It's popular among criminals as it inflicts serious damage, is reliable and accurate. The weapon was formerly a status symbol but is now considered by some to be a bit simple, a bit brutal. Few weapons have endured as long, however, with such an unwavering reputation. The Calder-45's recoil is relatively heavy which requires a firm grip. The pistol comes in countless variants, from blue-anodized and silver-plated to chrome-plated with ivory grips. Darov 5/2 Darov manufactures distinctive self-defense weapons that are very handy and easy to carry. Darov 5-series pistols are technically not autopistols as they lack an external magazine and are loaded with two cartridges straight into the two stacked barrels. The Darov 5/2 is designed for easy transport and is an easily concealed weapon. The caliber is considered sufficient to neutralize an attacker with two shots. Darov 6/6 The Darov 6/6 is a very compact and cheap pistol for self-defense. The caliber is quite weak, but the low recoil makes it easy to use the pistol for repeated fire when needed. The precision is quite acceptable even though the barrel is short. The weapon fits perfectly in a handbag, a garter, a jacket pocket, or as a backup weapon in an ankle holster. **Karev Morov** The Karev Morov is a pure assassin's weapon with a barrel that is factory-prepared to accept a silencer. The precision is solid and the weapon has good quality feel and smooth and pleasant recoil. For a factory-made weapon the pistol has very good accuracy. Persons caught with such weapons are usually viewed with great suspicion, as they are almost exclusively used for assassinations. Kriger Army Pistol–4 House Kriger is the main supplier to the army and their AP–4 is used by officers and staff personnel as a defensive weapon. Stapo also uses the weapon, but then it has a specially decorated grip with Stapo's emblem. The AP-4 is known for its robustness and resistance to dirt, mud and moisture. Few specimens reach beyond State ownership. Darov 6/6 Breer z.9 **Karev Morov** Calder M2245 Magazine type: Magazine The magazine is sometimes called a box magazine. It is a small metal box with an opening at the top where cartridges are fed in by hand, against a spring on the bottom. Two magazine lips hold the cartridges in place at the opening. When the reloading mechanism is activated the empty case is ejected from the weapon and the topmost cartridge in the box magazine is fed by the mechanism into the chamber in the weapon's barrel. All weapons that have box magazines can have a bullet in the chamber and a full magazine. This is shown in the weapon lists by "+1" appearing after the magazine capacity. Since the box magazine is considered the standard magazine, weapons with box magazines have no code in the weapon lists. "I have a bullet with Rulov's name on it. I have ten thousand bullets with his name on them." — Gabriel Jandaran

Revolvers

Revolvers are one-handed firearms that are loaded with cartridges individually into a cylinder. The cylinder rotates with each firing so that the cartridge chamber comes in line with the hammer and barrel. A revolver is considered safer and more reliable than an autopistol. This is because defective ammunition can stop the entire feeding process in an autopistol while it's enough to pull the trigger again if you get a defective cartridge in a revolver, since a new cartridge rotates into firing position. Revolvers therefore don't suffer from the consequence of misfires (they don't need to be reloaded, see page 92), other than that the action counts as failed and the cartridge is seen as expended. However, if the following action with the revolver shows doubles on the dice roll the revolver has suffered a malfunction. Kai/Dekere Conceal The Kai/Dekere Conceal challenges Darov's series of small self-defense weapons. It is small and light and designed for purses, garters, or jacket sleeves. The short barrel and low weight make the pistol unwieldy but its small size makes it popular among card players and women about town. Detectives and criminal police use it as a backup weapon. Kai/Dekere Wake Kai and Dekere, two families within House Guiskard, created a challenger to the Ruuik and

Salimo .38 Police. The reception was lukewarm, since Wake is heavier than Police and doesn't use its standard caliber, which makes it difficult for the individual policeman to get ammunition at a reasonable price. However, this very elegant revolver is popular among private guards, bouncers and gangsters. Revolvers Damage Range Precision Recoil Magazine Caliber Conceal Malfunction* Price** Kai/Dekere Conceal 2D–1 5–10 m +1 3E 4r .38 S +8 ±0 700z Kai/Dekere Wake 2D+2 10–50 m +2 4E 6r .357 M +1 ±0 1,400z Kai/Dekere Wrath 3D–2 5–20 m +1 5E 5r .44 M +6 ±0 1,600z R&S .38 Police 2D–1 10–50 m +2 2E 6r .38 S +2 ±0 750z R&S .38 Sneak 2D–1 5–20 m +1 3E 5r .38 S +7 ±0 650z R&S .44 Grandeaux 3D–2 10–50 m +3 5E 6r .44 M –1 ±0 3,500z R&S .540 Mardeaux 3D+1 10–50 m +3 6E 4r .540 M –2 ±0 8,000z

- Revolvers don't need to be reloaded on misfires, see page 92. ** Availability for all revolvers is §§. Kai/Dekere Wrath R&S .540 Mardeaux R&S .38 Police

Kai/Dekere Wrath Wrath was meant as a solid backup weapon but received a lukewarm reception as the powerful caliber, short barrel and low weight made the weapon quite unwieldy during rapid fire. To keep down the size of the revolver the cylinder holds only five cartridges. Ruuik & Salimo .38 Police The Ruuik & Salimo .38 Police is the standard weapon of Sandukar's police force – at least among the patrolling constables. The revolver is also popular among criminals. It is smooth, effective and very reliable, but completely without refinements for the lowest possible production cost. Many policemen buy better sights themselves, or a more comfortable grip than the rough-hewn wooden one that comes as standard. Ruuik & Salimo .38 Sneak Sneak is a short-barreled version of Police but with the hammer built into the metal body. The size makes the revolver handy and the caliber makes it easy to shoot. It's a popular choice among criminal investigators and detectives who don't like having to lug around extra metal junk. The weapon's rounded form without protruding parts makes it smooth to draw. Ruuik & Salimo .44 Grandeaux Grandeaux is a macho-revolver for criminals and wilderness men. It's a very well-made, large and heavy revolver that has gained some popularity among shadow hunters as its destructive capability is not to be found on the autopistol side. Ruuik & Salimo .540 Mardeaux Mardeaux, this giant monster of a revolver, is mostly a status symbol in certain criminal circles. The force generated by the very potent .540 cartridge makes the weapon directly unpleasant to shoot with unless you possess good strength. The revolver is, however, of very good quality, like most of R&S's weapons. Kai/Dekere Conceal Kai/Dekere Wake R&S .38 Sneak R&S .44 Grandeaux Magazine type: Revolver cylinder (r) The revolver cylinder is a fixed part of the revolver. In the cylinder there are a number of chambers in which cartridges are placed. The number of chambers is usually five or six, more won't fit without stressing the material too much. The cylinder rotates with each firing so that the cartridge chamber comes in line with the hammer and barrel. The cylinder can usually be released from the weapon body by releasing a safety lock and swinging the cylinder out to the left. This exposes all chambers. The empty cases must be ejected before new cartridges can be inserted. Weapons with revolver cylinders are marked in the weapon lists with an "r" in the Magazine column. "Get away from the revolver, or I'll make your citizen's pass a worthless piece of paper!" — Anya Malov

Submachine Guns

Kpist is an abbreviation for kulsprutepistol – that is a handheld firearm that fully automatically fires pistol ammunition. The weapon concept is fairly new but has been well received. It's primarily gangsters and the military who demand this type of weapon. Since the concept of submachine guns is quite newfangled there are quite a few teething problems in the construction methods. This makes the weapon type more sensitive to misfires than many other weapon types. **Breer Kalgari** Breer of House Kriger are known and reliable weapon manufacturers even though their models sometimes lack inventiveness. Their two-handed weapon Kalgari is a purely military instrument of war suited for small reconnaissance squads or for assault groups who use it as light support weapons. The Kalgari is hard to find on the black market which has made it a status symbol

among gangsters. It can be equipped with an extended drum magazine for higher magazine capacity. Submachine Guns Damage Range Precision Recoil Magazine Caliber Conceal Malfunction Price* Breer Kalgari** 2D–1 10–100 m +2 3AE 30+1 9mm –5 +1 6,000z – with drum magazine 2D–1 10–100 m +2 3AE 60+1 9mm –8 +4 – Breer Kalgari a.1** 2D+1 10–100 m +2 4AE 25+1 .45 Auto –5 +1 6,500z – with drum magazine 2D+1 10–100 m +2 4AE 50+1 .45 Auto –8 +4 – Gault Assault Pistol 2D+1 5–20 m +1 5A 35+1 .45 Auto –3 +2 3,500z Karev Riekon*** 2D–1 5–20 m +1 4A 20+1 9mm ±0 +1 4,000z Karev Ulz** 2D–1 10–50 m +2 3A 32+1 9mm –4 ±0 5,500z Kriger Commissariat Pistol–4 2D 10–50 m +3 4AE 18+1 10mm +1 ±0 10,000z

- Availability for all submachine guns is §§§. ** The weapon is a two-handed weapon. *** The weapon is prepared to accept a silencer. Breer Kalgari/Breer Kalgari a.1 **Karev Ulz**

Breer Kalgari a.1 The two-handed weapon Kalgari a.1 resembles the regular Kalgari but has a heavier caliber. **Gault Assault Pistol** Assault Pistol was intended to be a backup weapon for assault soldiers but intrigue within House Kriger has made it difficult for Gault to reach out with the creation. Instead it's very popular on the streets. Its small size, low price and light weight make it easy to carry around, but it also means it kicks something terrible when fired. Assault Pistol is a one-handed weapon. **Karev Riekon** The engineering genius Karev van Dunarmco de Zovrin is behind the specialized, rapid-fire one-handed weapon Karev Riekon. It resembles a large pistol but has the magazine in front of the trigger. The barrel is threaded to accept a silencer. The weapon has found a place among commando soldiers on covert missions, state agents, assault soldiers (who are often seen carrying a Riekon in each hand) and assassins who need to take out multiple targets in rapid succession. **Karev Ulz** Ulz is an older model from Dunarmco's factories. The two-handed weapon has become very popular on the street and is known for being extremely reliable and easy to repair. It's also relatively easy to get hold of. Kriger Commissariat Pistol–4 The Commissariat Pistol is a fully automatic one-handed pistol specially developed for the State Commissariat. The weapon is of utmost quality, finish and precision. Carrying a KP–4 without proper license is subject to harsh penalties and therefore the weapon is very rare in the underworld. "You, I think I'll die another day, this one doesn't feel like the right one." — Jessca Navarre **Gault Assault Pistol Karev Riekon** Kriger Commissariat Pistol–4

Rifles

All rifles are two-handed weapons and fire powerful ammunition. They are used by hunters and are soldiers' standard weapons in the military. It's House Kriger that supplies the State's war machine with rifles and carbines. A carbine is a shorter rifle, while a sniper rifle is of extra high quality, has a heavy precision barrel and is extremely balanced. Soldiers' rifles are either semi-automatic or bolt-action. On a loaded, semi-automatic weapon you just need to squeeze the trigger to fire shots while a bolt-action weapon must be loaded manually with a new cartridge before each firing, using an operating handle that ejects the empty case and feeds a new cartridge into the chamber. This mechanism has the advantage that it increases accuracy for single shots but it makes rapid repeated fire virtually impossible, since each shot must be chambered manually. Kriger Combat Rifle–2 Combat Rifle–2, or KG–2 as it's called among soldiers in the field, is the State's soldiers' standard weapon. The weapon is well-made, effective and durable, the only thing soldiers usually complain about is the weight, the heavy recoil and the long reload time that comes from the magazine being built into the weapon and having to be loaded cartridge by cartridge. The rifle's bolt-action mechanism makes the weapon difficult to use when rapid repeated fire is needed. The weapon lacks mounts for scope sights but its fixed sights are considered very competent. The KG–2 exists in such quantities that many have disappeared from State control and are often found as souvenirs in the city. The weapon has a bayonet mount. Rifles Damage Range Precision Recoil Magazine Caliber Conceal Malfunction Price* Kriger Combat Rifle–2 3D+2 50–400 m +3 5E 8i 8mmR –8 ±0 2,500z Kriger Sniper Rifle–1 5D–2 50–800 m +5** 8E 3i 13mmR –9 ±0 18,500z Kriger Sniper Rifle–2 3D+2 50–600 m +5** 5E 4i 8mmR –9 ±0 12,000z Kriger Assault Carbine–3

3D–1 50–200 m +2 3E 15+1 8mmC –7 +1 4,500z Rais 8mm Bolt-Action 3D+2 50–500 m +3** 5E 5i 8mmR –8 ±0 3,500z

- Availability for all rifles is §§. ** The weapon is prepared to accept a scope sight, see page 118 for more information. Kriger Combat Rifle–2 Kriger Sniper Rifle–1 Kriger Sniper Rifle–2

Kriger Sniper Rifle—1 The Kriger Sniper Rifle—1 is an almost two-meter-long weapon based on the Sniper Rifle—2, but with a higher weight and a much more powerful caliber. The range and destructive power of the heavy 13mm bullet make the weapon feared and respected. Only extraordinary marksmen within the army are given access to this massive weapon.

Kriger Sniper Rifle—2 The Sniper Rifle—2 is a very high-quality construction. It is large, long and heavy, but its precision and range are unmatched. The rifle's wooden details are of the finest quality. The weapon can be disassembled into three parts for easier transport. Since it lacks advanced fixed sights, it is assumed that a military-grade and state-approved scope will be used with the weapon. This masterpiece of a weapon is only found in the State's army, with extraordinary marksmen who have been selected to become snipers. A few examples disappear onto the civilian market where assassins pay dearly to acquire a specimen.

Kriger Assault Carbine—3 The Assault Carbine—3 is a carbine developed to improve soldiers' capacity during trench assaults. The weapon is semi-automatic, magazine-fed for quick reloading and has reduced caliber for good handling and low recoil. The disadvantage is that its penetration is lower and the range significantly shorter than the Battle Rifle—2.

The AC—3 is still in limited supply but the first reports from the front demonstrate that its effectiveness during assaults is higher than the BR—2's. Reports of poor quality have emerged, however. The weapon has a bayonet mount.

Rais 8mm Bolt-Action The Rais 8mm Bolt-Action is a common hunting weapon outside the city's stone facades. Alongside the shotgun, it is used by many farmers to shoot larger game. The weapon is of good quality, and has a polished wooden stock and good fixed sights even though it is intended to be used together with a scope.

Magazine type: Internal magazine (i) The internal magazine is built into the weapon in some way, like a tube where the cartridges are stored, or in a part of the weapon body next to the barrel. When the reloading mechanism is activated, the empty case is ejected and a new cartridge is retrieved from the internal magazine. When reloading, each new cartridge must be inserted individually. There are loading clips that contain five cartridges which speed up the reloading process. Weapons with internal magazines are marked in the weapon lists with an "i" in the Magazine column.

"You can't evade the police forever, wouldn't it be smarter to give up and turn yourself in?" "As smart as cutting your own throat to breathe." — Mordekai Remus and Stelia Lock

Kriger Assault Carbine—3

Rais 8mm Bolt-Action

Rais H100K

Shotguns

Shotguns have several advantages and quite a few disadvantages. The advantages are that they have high damage capacity and accuracy at short distance, and that they are mechanically simple to handle and maintain. The disadvantages include the limited range and that the damage capacity decreases radically with distance to the target. The reason for the latter is that the weapon uses buckshot cartridges which, unlike regular cartridges, do not contain a bullet but between 9 and 23 small round lead pellets. When a buckshot cartridge is fired, these lead pellets are shot through the air. They spread somewhat with distance, and a hit at close range often means that several pellets strike the target, which increases the risk of serious injury.

The problem is that lead pellets quickly lose energy and power, which means that the weapon's damage effect drastically decreases when it comes to distances beyond its short range. Therefore shotguns have two indicated damage values, one for hits within short range and one in parentheses for hits beyond this range. The damage caused is considered stunning since it is relatively superficial and spread over a larger area.

Rais H90 (sawed-off) The Rais H90 is used as a large firearm that causes massive destruction at close range. It is an H90 Shotgun on which the stock and barrel are sawed off to make the weapon manageable. A limitation is obviously the two buckshot cartridges that are loaded directly into the barrels, which requires more time for reloading during extended firefights. The weapon is used mostly by scum at the bottom of society, or by certain types of gangsters.

Shotguns Damage Value* Range Accuracy Recoil Magazine Caliber Conceal Malfunction Price** Rais H90 (sawed-off) S5D—4 (S2D—1) 5—10 m +3 5E 2p Cal 12 —2 ±0 2,000z Rais H90 Shotgun S5D—4 (S2D—1) 10—30 m +5 4E 2p Cal 12 —7 ±0 2,000z Rais H100 Pump Shotgun S5D—4 (S2D—1) 10—30 m +4 4E 5i Cal 12 —7 ±0 3,000z Rais H100K Pump Shotgun S5D—4 (S2D—1) 5—10 m +3 5E 4i Cal 12 —4 ±0 3,200z Rais H100U Pump Shotgun S5D—4 (S2D—1) 10—30 m +4 4E 7i Cal 12 —8 ±0 3,800z

- The damage value in parentheses is used against targets located farther away than short range. Note that shotgun damage values count as stunning, see page 263. ** Availability for all shotguns is §§.

Rais H90 (sawed-off)

Rais H90

Rais H90 Shotgun The Rais H90 Shotgun is very common in the countryside, outside the city's neon lights. Farmers and hunters use it for hunting birds and small game. The two barrels sit parallel to each other and the cartridges are placed directly into each barrel after the weapon is broken open. The shotgun has two triggers in the trigger guard, one for each barrel.

Rais H100 Pump Shotgun The Rais family, of house Mengal, created the H100 Pump Shotgun for trenches and bunker clearing. Its effectiveness and precision have meant that even the police have taken a liking to it and use it when greater firepower is needed. The cartridges are stored in an internal tube magazine that runs along and under the barrel. With each shot, the shooter moves a pump handle located under the barrel back and forth with their left hand to eject the empty cartridge and load a new one from the tube magazine. It is this pumping that gives the weapon its name.

Rais H100K Pump Shotgun The H100K is a short version of the H100, intended for witness protection and rapid clearing. It lacks a stock and has a shortened barrel for increased maneuverability. The weapon is popular among enforcers. There are various ways to smoothly secure the weapon in a holster-like mounting device under the armpit to quickly draw it from inside, for example, a large overcoat.

Rais H100U Pump Shotgun Following requests from bunker clearing teams, Rais developed the H100U, an H100 with extended tube magazine and elongated barrel, to give the clearers more magazine capacity before they were forced to reload.

Magazine type: In the chamber (p) If the weapon is loaded in the chamber, the cartridges are placed by hand directly into the barrel and must after firing be removed to make room for new ones. Weapons that are loaded directly into the chamber are marked in the weapon lists with a "p" in the Magazine column.

"Want a drink?" "No thanks, I still have a bit of a stomachache since you stabbed me." — Ilsa and Gabriel Jandaran

Rais H100

Rais H100U

Machine Guns

Machine guns, or machineguns, are pure military weapons and can be said to be fully automatic heavy rifles created to demoralize the enemy and provide covering fire during assault or retreats. Machine guns are often very heavy and unwieldy since they are intended for longer, continuous fire in fixed installations. They constitute a common armament on various types of vehicles used at the front, not least aircraft. All machineguns directly used by individuals require two hands to operate.

Kriger Machine Gun—1 The Kriger Machine Gun—1 is a heavy machine gun that requires a three-man crew. Assembling the mount takes only one minute, and half that time to disassemble it again. Each team member is responsible for just over fifteen kilograms each, which makes the weapon both hated and loved on the battlefield. Its highly effective ammunition is known for penetrating most protection, which is appreciated. Its rhythmic pounding rattle during automatic fire becomes a morale booster during attacks as it makes the soldiers feel supported.

Kriger Machine Gun—1B The Machine Gun—1B is only found permanently mounted on vehicles, bunkers or aircraft. It is made to withstand uninterrupted fire for long periods without risk of fire interruption, feeding problems or overheating. The magazine is enclosed for better maneuverability and exclusion of dirt.

Kriger Machine Gun—2 The Machine Gun—2 is a water-cooled machine gun intended for a crew of two men — a gunner and a loader/observer. The weapon comes with a tripod that is surprisingly quick to set up — it rarely takes more than ten seconds to get the machine gun ready to fire after a regrouping. The belt feed has received criticism since it has a tendency to jam if dirt or mud gets stuck in it.

Kriger Machine Gun—2B The Machine Gun—2B is a water-cooled, medium-heavy machine gun that is only used permanently mounted on vehicles or in installations. The reinforced barrel and mechanism are enclosed in a cast iron block to maximize reliability during extended fire. A large heavy magazine box holds the cartridges and it is a cumbersome procedure to reload the weapon.

Machine Guns Damage Value Range Accuracy Recoil Magazine Caliber Conceal Malfunction Price* Kriger Machine Gun—1 5D—2 50—500 m +1 4A** 50b 13mmG Bulky +2 25,000z Kriger Machine Gun—1B 5D—2 50—750 m +1 2A 650 13mmG Bulky +1 30,000z Kriger Machine Gun—2 3D+2 50—300 m +1 3A** 100b 8mmG Unwieldy +3 17,500z Kriger Machine Gun—2B 3D+2 50—500 m +1 1A 1250 8mmG Bulky +1 22,500z Kriger Machine Gun—3 3D—1 50—150 m +1 3A 67+1 8mmK Unwieldy +2 14,000z

- Availability for all machine guns is §§§. ** If the weapon is not used together with support or mount, Recoil becomes ten higher (+10) during fire.

Kriger Machine Gun—1

Kriger Machine Gun—3

Kriger Demolition Lance

Kriger Machine Gun—3 The light Kriger Machine Gun—3 is intended as a portable support weapon. The weapon is a late addition to the infantry and is not belt-fed but has a large round drum magazine lying on top of the weapon body. Empty cases are fed downward, through the weapon. Soldiers who have fired the weapon like its maneuverability and destructive capacity, but curse its weight and the fact that it is not uncommon for red-hot empty cases from the weapon to land in their boots.

Heavy Weapons

The term heavy weapons includes specialized weapons primarily used by the military, such as flamethrowers or weapons for building clearing and armored vehicle combat. No heavy weapons can be fired without using the initiative action Fire aimed shot.

Kriger Dragonfire

Dragonfire is a portable, back-mounted flamethrower that requires two-handed grip to operate. The two fuel tanks carried on the back can hold enough liquid for eight substantial bursts.

Kriger Demolition Lance

The Demolition Lance is a cheap and low-quality disposable weapon made for anti-armor and bunker assault. Its high-explosive grenade is created to spread destruction around it through shock wave and shrapnel. The weapon's effectiveness against armored vehicles is limited, but better than nothing. It is not uncommon for a soldier to carry two to three Demolition Lances just in case. When the weapon is fired, its empty tube is discarded.

Kriger Steelfist

Steelfist is a heavy, dedicated, portable anti-armor weapon whose powerful grenade sends a very hot fire jet into the target. The weapon is very unwieldy and requires much time to reload, which means that there are often two people who handle a Steelfist — a gunner and a loader.

Heavy Weapons Damage Value Range Accuracy Recoil Magazine Caliber Conceal Malfunction Price* Kriger Dragonfire High intensity 5—10 m +1 — (8) — Bulky +1 13,000z Kriger Demolition Lance ** 50—100 m +1 — 1p**** 78mmSS Unwieldy +4 8,000z Kriger Steelfist *** 50—200 m +1 — 1p 95mmAV Bulky +2 30,000z

- Availability for all heavy weapons is §§§. ** The damage value for the damage zones is: S10D (0—1 m), S5D (1—5 m), S2D (5—10 m). See page 266 for more information. *** The damage value for the damage zones is: S20D (0—1 m), S10D (1—2 m), S5D (2—3 m). See page 266 for more information. **** The weapon cannot be reloaded.

Magazine type: Belt-fed (b) Belt-fed weapons can have almost endless capacity, since multiple ammunition belts can be linked together. It is only machine guns that use this magazine type, which is required for

continuous support fire on the battlefield. Belt feeding is one of the reasons why machine gunners often operate in pairs of a gunner and a loader. Cartridges are placed in a belt of fabric or metal links which are pulled through the weapon's chamber and barrel by a feed mechanism. Empty cases and link pieces are spat out on the chamber's other side during firing. The state standard length of military ammunition belts for machine guns holds 100 oiled and inspection-stamped cartridges. Belt-fed weapons are marked in the weapon lists with a "b" in the Magazine column.

"I can sleep when I'm dead." — The Sorrowful

Kriger Machine Gun—2

Kriger Steelfist

Ammunition & Weapon Accessories For a weapon to be loaded, ammunition of the correct caliber is required. Various forms of weapon accessories can improve a weapon's area of use. Item Price (availability) Other Ammunition, 6mm 20z per 100 rounds (§§) Ammunition, 8mmG 30z per 20 rounds (§§) Ammunition, 8mmK 30z per 20 rounds (§§) Ammunition, .38 S 50z per 50 rounds (§§) Ammunition, 9mm 50z per 50 rounds (§§) Ammunition, .357 M 60z per 50 rounds (§§) Ammunition, 10mm 70z per 50 rounds (§§) Ammunition, .45 Auto 40z per 50 rounds (§§) Ammunition, .44 M 80z per 50 rounds (§§) Ammunition, .540 M 150z per 50 rounds (§§) Ammunition, 13mmG 30z per 10 rounds (§§§) Ammunition, 12 Gauge 35z per 12 rounds (§§) Grenade, 95mmRV 6,000z per 3 grenades (§§§) Bulky Ammunition harness 180z Unwieldy, holds 10 magazines Scope 1,500z Required for Sharpshooting Suppressor 750z (§§§) Box magazine 20z (§§) Ammo belt 30z Unwieldy, holds 50 rounds Weapon maintenance kit (weapon type) 250z Ammunition harness, 10 magazines The ammunition harness fastens over the shoulders and around the waist. It is equipped with adjustable holders for about ten magazines of any type. **Scope** The effect of using a scope is that the shooter gets to use the Initiative Action Sharpshooting, see page 256. Scopes can be mounted on all rifles that have mounts for them. **Suppressor** The suppressor dampens the sound from a fired bullet. Opponents get a deduction on rolls to detect the shot for every meter of distance (−1/m) between him/her and the shooter. The suppressor increases the weapon's malfunction value by one (+1) and reduces Conceal by two (−2) as long as it is screwed onto the weapon. It can be attached to all auto-matic pistols and submachine guns that have threaded barrels. **Box magazine** A box magazine is an empty magazine for a suitable weapon. Note that all weapon models have their own magazines which cannot be used for other types of weapons. Ammo belt, 50 rounds The ammo belt hangs over one shoulder, diagonally across the body. It is equipped with a holder for 50 rounds of any type, or 20 shotgun shells. Weapon maintenance kit (weapon type) A weapon maintenance kit includes gun grease, cleaning rod, weapon cloth, wood oil, brushes, sandpaper, steel wool and a small screwdriver and file. All packed in a box of wood or metal.

Holsters

The holster is a carrying device for weapons. Pure firearm holsters are almost always made of hardened and molded leather. Common holster types are the shoulder holster, hip holster, and ankle holster. **Holster properties** Each way of carrying a weapon entails requirements and effects, according to table 1:32 Accepts shows which weapon size the holster can handle. The weapon size is defined by the weapon's Conceal value, and is given in the table as a range. If the weapon's Conceal value does not fall within the range, the weapon cannot be holstered in that type of holster. If a specific weapon type is mentioned instead of a value range, the holster only works for that weapon type. Draw indicates if the person gets any deduction or bonus when he/she draws a weapon from the holster (with the Initiative Action Draw weapon). Conceal shows if the wearer gets any bonus or deduction to the weapon's Conceal when someone tries to find a weapon in the holster,

provided that the holster is hidden in some way, for example covered by clothes, otherwise it is automatically visible if anyone looks. Holster type Accepts Draw Conceal* Ankle holster (+6) – (+10) −1 +5 Wrist sheath (+7) – (+10) +10 ±0 Shoulder holster (±0) – (+7) +1 +1 Waistband (−2) – (+10) ±0 −2 Sling (−10) – (−3)* −2 −5 Pocket (+6) – (+10) −2 −2 Hip holster (−2) – (+3) +5 −2 Thigh holster (+5) – (+10) −2 +10 Small of back holster (+3) – (+7) +1 +2 Side holster (+2) – (+7) +2 ±0 Combat harness Hand grenade/bayonet** +2 −5 Sword scabbard Sword ±0 −5 Table 1:32 * Some bulky weapons can also have slings, for example Kriger Sprängsfär. ** The bayonet can be replaced with a combat knife. **Holster descriptions** The holster descriptions are general and creative players and narrators can use them as inspiration and guidelines to create special holster types for their own weapons. Among the holsters below, other ways of carrying weapons are also described for comparison. Additionally there are carrying devices for other types of weapons than just firearms. A holster is made for a specific weapon model so you need to get a new holster if you change weapons. Item Price (availability) Other Ankle holster 125z Wrist sheath 500z Unwieldy Shoulder holster 150z **Waistband As clothing** Sling 40z **Pocket As clothing** Hip holster 225z Thigh holster 140z Small of back holster 125z Side holster 125z Combat harness 300z Sword scabbard 200z Unwieldy **Ankle holster** The ankle holster fastens around one ankle with a quick-release mechanism. Some models have support straps that go up over the calf. To be able to draw, the wearer needs to pull up the pant leg. **Wrist sheath** The wrist sheath is a metal construction that sits along the wearer's forearm and holds the weapon in a spring cradle. When the wearer makes a special flick with the arm, usually slightly forward, downward, the spring is released and the weapon is flung forward and into his/her hand. Small firearms or knives are usually carried this way. It requires some training to handle the holster fully. "When you're lying there, wounded, in a sea of blood and corpses caused by your hand, do you lie there, with closed eyes, short breath, scared as hell and hope to bleed out to avoid continuing? Or do you pull yourself together, stand up for your own, protect them, make sure nothing further bad happens to them?" – Anya Malov

Shoulder holster

The shoulder holster sits under the armpit, and the arms are threaded through it. The holster is often fastened to the belt for increased stability. To compensate for the weight on the side where the firearm is placed, the opposite armpit usually has pockets for one or two extra magazines, in cases where the weapon is an automatic pistol. There are also special shoulder holsters that accept throwing knives on one or both sides. **Waistband** The weapon can be stuck into the waistband, with the stock or handle above. This is a cocky but impractical way to carry the weapon, as it is difficult to draw and easy for the weapon to disappear down into the pants. **Sling** Slings are common aids for those who want to carry hunting rifles, shotguns, or larger melee weapons on their backs or over their shoulders. They are used, for example, by the army if soldiers need to march longer distances or have special duty. **Pocket** Simply carrying the weapon in a pants or jacket pocket is a classic. It is risky, however, as the weapon can easily get caught in the lining. **Hip holster** The hip holster fastens on the outside of the shooter's thigh and the lower part is tied just above the knee. The placement makes the weapon easy to draw, but it also makes the holster very easy to see. Hip holsters are worn by police constables and by field officers in the State's army. **Thigh holster** The thigh holster is usually used by women wearing skirts. It goes around the thigh and has a hidden fastening device that holds the weapon in place. Variants that fasten to nylon stockings with accompanying garters exist. The shooter must pull up the skirt to draw the weapon. **Small of back holster** The small of back holster is placed in the belt or fastened with a metal clip in the waistband at the lower back. The advantage of the holster is that it is difficult to detect if you wear a jacket over it. **Side holster** The side holster is threaded through the belt and placed just above the hip bone on either side. **Combat harness** The combat harness is worn by the State's soldiers. Hand grenades and a large knife can be attached to it. **Sword scabbard** A sword scabbard accepts a sword. It can be placed in a belt or baldric on the hip, or carried on or over the back. **Body Armor** Body armor is very rare on the city's

streets and the technological development in the area is sadly neglected. Of the body armor that exists, most are rather heavy, clumsy, and expensive. **Body armor properties** Body armor makes the wearer able to endure more before he/she becomes seriously injured. However, it helps little against the stunning that comes from the kinetic energy or force of an attack. As long as the armor is used, the wearer has an increased attribute value for Wound Threshold. See table 1:33 for more information. Protection shows how much higher the wearer's attribute value for Wound Threshold is when the armor is used. Restriction shows what deduction the wearer gets on rolls (Awareness, Combat Movement, or Defense) when the armor is used. **Body armor Protection Restriction** Tactical gear +3 −4 Police armor +2 −2 Bulletproof vest +1 −2 Storm armor +4 −5 Table 1:33 **Body armor descriptions** The body armor that exists is used primarily by the State's troops – the police and the military. It is very unusual for civilians to wear body armor. Item Price (availability) Other Tactical gear 7,500z (§§) Bulky Police armor 3,500z (§§) Unwieldy Bulletproof vest 3,800z (§§) Unwieldy Storm armor 9,000z (§§) Bulky **Tactical gear** The tactical police use tactical gear when they make raids or busts on places where resistance is expected to be hard or opponents armed. The armor consists of heavily padded, hardened leather with thick steel plates on the upper side of the arms, front of the legs, torso, back, groin, and neck. The head is covered by a full-coverage steel helmet with visor of impact-resistant glass, extra protection for ears and neck, and a sturdy leather strap under the chin. The body armor is very difficult to move in and also quickly becomes very hot. Criminals usually realize they have a good chance of successfully fleeing from a tactically-clad policeman, who due to his heavy armor has difficulty running after someone fleeing. **Police armor** The police's standard armor, during foot patrol or in patrol car, consists of heavy reinforced leather gloves and metal-reinforced boots. The chest is covered by a woven silk vest that provides some protection against bullets. Over the police armor is often worn a heavy knee-length police coat in black durable leather, with metal insert plates over the torso.

Police armor is a relatively light armor, intended to give the police constable increased ability to function in brawls and similar situations where heavier weapons are not expected to be used. The armor is not used by criminal police but only by uniformed personnel. **Bulletproof vest** The bulletproof vest is a large and extremely clumsy vest in ballistic nylon, steel, and silk, that protects the torso, shoulders, and groin against damage. Since it is relatively quick to take off and on, it is used by criminal police who need protection in threatening situations or during potentially dangerous operations. Aircraft pilots who need protection against machine gun fire also use it since it weighs little enough that it doesn't provide any disadvantages. **Storm armor** The storm trooper wears a padded high-hardened molded steel armor with vambraces, cuirass, which protects the torso and groin, as well as gauntlets. In the gaps sits tough leather. The armor is extremely heavy and clumsy to maneuver in but since its protective ability actually means the wearer can be hit by rifle fire and still survive, it is appreciated by the poor bastards sent out on the trench fields. It is not uncommon for fresh storm troopers to inherit fallen comrades' storm armor. Many consider this to be a great honor and in some units it is common for the wearer to honor the previous user by carving his/her name into the cuirass's hard plate. Others choose not to repair previous damage to the armor as a symbol of luck. It echoed loudly in the stairwell when Anya Malov with determined steps walked toward the cells. Her eyes were cold and her expression set. She had gone down the stairs many times before, but this time took the cake. The phone call a minute earlier had ruined an already lousy day, a day lined with idiocies and idiots. She knew she had done a good job. The arrest was correct down to the last detail. There were no weak points – witness statements, physical evidence, everything was in the report. She snorted irritably as she approached the end of the stairs and saw the metal door into the holding cells. She threw open the door and saw the duty officer standing with a mug of black, oily coffee in his hand and a cigarette in the corner of his mouth. The fat, sweaty man lit up when he saw Anya come in. She did not return his smile. She positioned herself firmly on the concrete floor and scanned out toward the cells. "Well, Parkon, what the hell is going on?" The man took a deep and slow swig from the mug. He swallowed audibly. She saw that he started sweating and avoided her gaze. "Uh,

yes, Anya, you see..." "Police Inspector Malov." "Uh, yes, Police Inspector Malov, suspect number 899–53456 is injured and will be transferred to Kuinn Hospital for care." "Bullshit, what do you mean injured? How can a person in your custody injure himself in here?" Anya fixed her gaze on Parkon, who took another swig of coffee. "Uh, yes, it... seems to be that... that he fell, unfortunately. He must have hit his head on the bunk, or the floor. He looked like spaghetti in the face. It happened when I was... in the bathroom. I called up to the police captain, according to regulations, and informed about the incident, and then got orders to wait until the prisoner is picked up." Anya demonstratively took a step closer to the man, who backed into a desk. "He's mine, no damn hospital staff is coming here and taking him to a hospital where he can escape like a rat. No one!" A throat clearing interrupted her. She turned around and felt the day getting even worse. She looked into a police badge, of a type she hated. She looked at the owner's face, a pale visage, with eyes hidden behind a pair of sunglasses. The black hat and leather coat revealed his identity faster than the police badge. A hoarse voice drawled the words. "Police Inspector Malov, I am Doctor Borzakov, Stapo. Your prisoner is now my responsibility. If you have any questions you can take them up with your command. You may leave now."

Chapter 4 – Imperiet

The roar from the packed foyer was palpable. It was intermission at Beratinalde's production of Fionios' "The Merchant Without Memory," a farcical opera on the edge of what the audience could endure. A major draw, however, was that the production boasted the renowned violinist Darius Pavlov, who was expected to musically illustrate the forgotten son's death scene solo.

The head of House Mengal stood at the bar, gazing out over Sandukar's society over the rim of a vodka. The cold gray eyes searched, registered, and assessed the situation—who was talking to whom, who stood outside, who was there and who was missing. Her bodyguards maintained perfect distance, invisible but ready.

"Madame Archiatros."

The voice was deep, raspy as if it originated in smoky gentlemen's clubs. The older, well-preserved woman responded without turning toward the voice.

"Grand Duke van Gralen-Kriger. I saw you in box three in the hall."

She turned toward the massive, broad-shouldered, gray-haired man whose face seemed carved from granite, scarred by war and battle—the head of House Kriger. His tailored suit fit perfectly and was adorned with the characteristic carnation in his lapel. He bowed stiffly and lightly kissed the archiatros's gloved hand.

"You truly look ravishing this evening, you light up the room, upon my honor."

The man clicked his heels together to reinforce the compliment. She responded with a veiled smile. He lit a cigarette and positioned himself at her side.

"So, Nadya, what do you think of tonight's performance? Surprising that Pavlov is involved, isn't it?"

"No, not at all, if one keeps up with the rumor mills."

She smiled more broadly. He saw in her eyes that it was a genuine smile. One he had seen before, in an entirely different situation.

"Rumors, those are for enlisted men and whores, pardon my language."

He observed the woman's frozen smile. Then she burst into tasteful laughter, laughter that made her sound younger than she was. He took a drag and raised one eyebrow. He saw that his adjutant was vigilant, ready should anything occur, whatever that might be. A brief moment of silence followed.

"I've missed you, Sebastien."

She said it more quietly than necessary. There was no one else around the two of them. No one dared.

"And I you. What say you to a nightcap in my private, and discreet, suite at the Ristoria, say, an hour after the performance concludes?"

"What say you to right now?"

He smiled for the first time that evening and waved over his adjutant.

Sandukar is a vast metropolis containing everything from majestic skyscrapers to workers' quarters with sooty brick buildings as far as the eye can see. The districts' appearance varies depending on origin and who lives there. In this maze of architectural styles, historic buildings, and social classes, the people live under the State's eternally watchful eye.

Sandukar - The Empire's Heart

Sandukar lies on an island at the Copper River's mouth. East of the city are large shipyard constructions and military installations. The island lies closer to the northern shore and three bridges lead from the island to the mainland. One of these is intended only for train traffic. Most of the harbor area lies outside the walls, and here are large garbage dumps and shantytowns where the homeless survive by scavenging through the refuse and eating the remains.

The city's character changes with the year's cycles. The winters are harsh, cold, and severe with massive precipitation and temperatures that creep down toward minus 20°C or colder in the icy winds from the Oil Sea. Many see winter as a time of purification, when the homeless freeze to death and the city's worn facades and garbage are concealed by the gray-white snow. Winter's contrast is the short but very hot summer, when for a few weeks it becomes very hot, with an average temperature over 30°C, which makes the air shimmer in the almost windless city. Between these two poles are the long spring and autumn, both cool and very rainy.

Sandukar resembles no other city in the Empire as it is circular and surrounded by an over twenty-meter-high wall of blackened basaltic stone. Seven gates adapted for cars, trains, and people lead out/in through the wall. Security at these locks is rigorous, with checks of identification papers, freight permits, and passes, and the waiting time to enter or exit the city is often long.

Just inside the wall runs the first canal, called the Moat. It is one hundred meters wide and filled with dark, murky water. Seven bridges span the canal, one to each gate. The Moat is connected to the other canals in the city in a strange geometric pattern that separates the city's areas from each other. The canals are used partly to transport materials within the city on massive barges. Collective transport between districts exists in the form of ferries. The canal system is also where the treatment plants empty wastewater.

The Capital

The canals are 100 meters wide and deep, and the water is regulated with dams and locks in areas where the terrain is too hilly. Standing at the canal's edge, one can face a vertical drop of twenty meters before the

water's surface begins. The water comes from the Copper River and travels through the various city districts before plunging into the depths at the inner city's center.

Sandukar's architecture is varied and in places almost mad in its execution, as it displays many different wills and a long history. One can find buildings hundreds of years old adjacent to skyscrapers and grand factory halls. In alleys and on squares stand architectural wonders whose origins have long been forgotten, and wherever one wanders, one can find places and things to marvel at. The closer to the city's center, the taller the buildings become. Skyscrapers stretch hundreds of meters up toward the dark clouds, and on tall iron bridges and stone viaducts, trains and cars travel in a steady stream.

Despite new construction, most is worn and blackened, with an aura of antiquity about it. It seems as if the city itself causes the copper statues to patinate, the facades to soil, and the metal to rust. The dark facades are lit up, however, by the electric lights erected by the millions of people who are born, live, and die here. The city is a world unto itself, and the people are parts in its eternal machinery.

Administration

Each district functions almost as an autonomous city, and citizens rarely need to leave it, except for job commuting if they work in the Machine Cities or in other districts.

The State has branches of the authorities spread throughout each district to give the population greater service in daily activities. Each district's administration is run by its respective city director and his/her subordinates at the city office. Each district administration is controlled by the ministries and cabinet, in a complicated and illogical web of regulations, rules, norms, practices, and laws.

The police stations, run by the police directors, have local precinct offices to be close to the citizens. In each district is a police headquarters that serves as the main office for all police activity in the district and functions as an administrative coordination unit with the other districts and the State.

The State Hospital serves as a hub for more serious care interventions and for administration, which is led by the health director. Under the state hospital are a number of clinics—health centers that should handle most of the daily care citizens need. Without a citizen license, one receives no care.

The districts' courts try, and judge in, all cases not considered enemies of the state. The courts' soldiers are the district justiciars and their deputies, who are responsible for prosecution and act as prosecutors in court.

The State's subjects must be able to manage their work while fulfilling their obligations to friends and family, otherwise many suffer. Therefore, citizens are encouraged to report exhausted or depressed friends, colleagues, and family members to the State, which then assists with counseling and help so the individual shall find the guiding light again. The Ministry of Truth has special offices for this type of case, where accommodating officials can quickly and discreetly help concerned relatives and handle the practicalities regarding retrieval of, and conversation with, the patient.

The Office of Denunciation is a known, hated, and feared place. Seeing a friend or family member enter the building can make even the most cold-blooded person sweat. The office often lies near the district's police headquarters to facilitate occasions when rapid apprehension of a suspect must occur. The office's promise that denunciations leading to successful apprehension can grant the denouncer citizenship brings many desperate outcasts, ravaged refugees, and unknown informants to betray their brothers and sisters in hope of gaining a place in the State's arms and thus beginning new lives. This type of betrayal, as it is usually

perceived, is seen as the lowest type of action a non-citizen can engage in. Information about the Office's existence is proclaimed with frenzy in the Ministry of Truth's printing presses and loudspeaker vehicles.

The City's Districts

Sandukar has several different areas, all clearly separated by the canals. The areas become cities unto themselves as facilities and conditions exist so that most never need to leave their own district.

The Inner City

In the center of Sandukar lies what is the Empire's soul and heart within the dark and ominous inner canal that ends its journey at the city's absolute center. Here one finds the Imperial Cabinet, the State's ministries, the Houses' stately constructions, the finest hotels and restaurants, and the most important bureaucratic institutions. Massive skyscrapers of steel, stone, and glass stretch up toward the firmament—some seem so ancient they have grown from the bedrock itself. Walkways lead between the skyscrapers, hundreds of meters above ground level. The zeppelins glide between the buildings and cast their elongated shadows down on the winding avenues.

The Seven Towers

Sandukar is a city whose urban geography is unlike any other. Beyond the circular shape, the deep canals, and the high walls, it also distinguishes itself in yet another way. Seven towers, taller than the skyscrapers, rise from the city at various, seemingly, random locations.

The towers are of the same black basaltic stone as the walls and have massive gates at their base, gates that never open. They are seemingly completely abandoned, but if one is in their vicinity, one can sometimes hear the sound of machines from within them. The towers' origin and function are unknown.

Since a conflict in the fallen city, one of the towers is now destroyed and its broken facade stretches jagged up over the ruined landscape.

In other places in the city center lie grand old estates and palaces behind walls and iron fences. Along the well-maintained streets one travels by taxi or with a private chauffeur.

The State's presence is very strong—everywhere one can see armed guards, security police, and uniformed members of the law enforcement. It is not uncommon for these to demand to see one's citizen license and any passes during random inspections. Dignitaries and the State's higher servants are accompanied by plainclothes guards constantly prepared for assassination attempts from the enemy or subversive elements. Family figures rarely travel without a cortege of bodyguards, assistants, and attendants.

In the Inner City's center, commerce and intrigue seethe. At inaugurations, galas, and balls, wealthy families rub shoulders with the nouveau riche, traditions meet upstarts, all behind stiff smiles and ingratiating nods. Money, goods, information, scandals, and evidence change hands, circulate, and incite power plays.

The bureaucratic process is a colossus on clay feet, and the bureaucrats seldom manage to enforce the rules and regulations they themselves have established to protect the State and its subjects. Behind the ornate facades and the grinning sculptures one finds calculating, ruthless individuals who stop at nothing when it comes to achieving power, success, fame, and/or wealth. Polished brokers, wealthy bankers, powerful magnates, and arrogant bigwigs meet strict bureau directors, harsh ministers, venerable family figures, and

charismatic stars from the worlds of film, music, or sports, in a struggle for attention and supremacy. In the Inner City there always reigns an inflammable calm, a storm lying in wait for the next move.

The Free City

The majority of Sandukar's inhabitants have their dwelling outside the inner canal. By the citizens this part of the city is often called The Free City, as the feeling of control and surveillance is secondary among everyday problems. Occasionally visiting one of the city administration's offices is seen as a necessary evil. The people are allowed to live their lives, work for their bread, and start businesses. The misery is noticeable but most cannot be bothered to care. Notice boards and radio programs echo the messages from the Ministry of Truth over and over again.

People must work hard to survive and corruption exists at all levels, in everything from police constables to bureaucrats. The Families indirectly control the most profitable operations, and criminal gangs fight each other in the underworld. The many districts have different backgrounds and cultures, which makes them interact in a jumble of experiences, traditions, and prospects. A melting pot of people from across the realm—some with hope in their eyes, others with a gaze long dead.

The Free City is an area that encompasses many different kinds of districts—everything from wealthy, well-tended villa quarters with beautiful parks to dirty, run-down working-class neighborhoods where desperation bubbles beneath the surface. Class and racial differences are often extremely palpable, and envy and lust for power are born when the poor walk side by side with the rich, refugees alongside those who have always lived in the city. It is a true melting pot where all facets of society meet. When paths cross and contrasts become too great, the spark risks igniting, with violence, assault, or death as a result, all under the eternal city's oversight.

Along the countless streets lie small shops, convenience stores, and craft stalls crammed side by side, at the subway entrances stand the newspaper stands where sellers call out the day's news, and in smoky bars and restaurants exhaustive conversations are held in alcohol's haze. At beer cafés the workers chat over a mug before it's time to head home. The many restaurants can be anything from shabby joints where the food's contents are questionable to luxurious establishments where stern waiters serve appealing meals on gleaming silver trays. In the alleys there are entrances to secret clubs and suspect business premises. At squares and centers the State's services are available alongside magnificent arcades and department stores full of well-dressed merchants who eagerly sell their goods to lustful customers.

Entertainments range from languishing operettas and mighty theatrical plays for the wealthier to crackling cinema films and bloody boxing matches for the poorer. Going to a venue to eat, drink, and dance are appreciated pleasures, and the clubs lure with entertainment in the form of everything from tricks by skilled illusionists and sweet singing by talented songstresses to burlesque cabarets with humorous and erotic performances.

Both in the nouveau riche, curious middle class and in the conservative, bored upper class, interest in the unknown, the titillating foreign, flourishes. Individual séances with mediums, and group rituals behind drawn curtains after exquisite dinners with coffee and cognac are common, if secret, experiences. The exploration of the past, the search for significance and meaning, communication between living and dead, spiritualism, divination, clairvoyance, astrology, theosophy, telepathy, and similar occult—and by the State especially forbidden—phenomena are steadily increasing in popularity in Sandukar in particular and in the Empire in general. When those in power lack answers to the questions the enlightened pose, excellent breeding grounds are created for this type of experimentation. It also gives rise to the problem of frauds and charlatans

who exploit the confused person's need to believe in something, to find the meaning of their existence and their role in the universe.

The same clientele that can be seen engaging in exploration of the occult are often those who start archaeological expeditions to, and excavations in, the most inaccessible of the Empire's wilderness areas. Especially in the country of Madrostav but also in an easterly direction there are plenty of remains from antiquity. Those who find ancient artifacts or the remains of a city or perhaps a temple immediately become famous and invited to the galas and parties in the upper class's ballrooms. A place in a prestigious museum guarantees a place in society. If the finds can be sold to private collectors, the explorer often becomes wealthy in the bargain. Often the expeditions take place in secret and competition is fierce between the different initiators. In the wake of the expeditions follow guards, educated personnel, bearers, and other labor, so they are often very costly and risky enterprises undertaken around the Empire. Should one have the misfortune to find the remains of something the State considers forbidden, one risks being detained or imprisoned.

I was once asked: "What kind of person are you?", by a man I was just about to shoot in the head. He was half-lying against a wall and slurring between swollen lips and knocked-out teeth, his flickering gaze filled with pain and tearful self-pity. His expensive shirt was soiled with blood and dirt, his pomade-gleaming hair had been thrown forward over his forehead, and his entire person presented a pitiful sight.

It's hardly the first time a condemned man has raised an accusing finger at his executioner, it's always the loser who screams about injustice.

"What are you yourself?", I could have asked back, but why would I do that? I knew very well what he was. I know most things about the people in the criminal circles in the stratum I work in. I was well aware what a ruthless fraud the guy was, he had built a fortune at the expense of less fortunately situated people. How many lives hadn't he plunged into ruin to fill his own pockets.

This time, however, he had stepped on the wrong turf. Klarence Gieger has not built his empire by letting himself be outmaneuvered with impunity.

I finished the job without a word.

Not that I haven't asked myself the question many times. Every man with an ounce of self-awareness must sometimes regard his person from an external perspective. I know fairly well who, and what, I am. I cannot pretend to be a soft and friendly person, but I myself think I have a good heart, deep inside the stone facade.

My name is Haner Cerkasz Donercu, but no one knows me as anything other than Donner. For the past fifteen years I have been in Gieger's service and followed him like a shadow. When he says "sit" I sit, when he says "bite" I bite. There has been quite a bit of biting. I have buried more inconvenient elements than I can remember, I have spilled much blood—both with bullets and with fists. It has happened that I handled women, albeit reluctantly, but I have never touched children. Even I have my principles.

The boss never speaks to me except in commands and I seldom even answer with words. He knows by now that his orders are carried out without questions. I don't think he sees me as anything other than a big, dumb, emotionally cold watchdog. The question is whether anyone sees me as anything else. It makes no difference to me. Gieger pays decently for my services. Not enough for me to be able to retire—he's not stupid—but enough for me to afford a certain degree of luxury in my existence. I have a small attic apartment in a middle-class area where I have created a refuge for myself, completely cut off from my everyday life. One day a week I am free to screen myself off from the scum out there, and find peace in my own world. It is a stripped-down environment, a few large, simply furnished rooms with bright walls and dark beams in the ceiling. Soft, still

light filters in through small skylights and is pleasantly reflected in tall, antique mirrors. The sound from the city rarely reaches up here, most of the time the silence is palpable.

Klara sweeps soundlessly past me where I sit in my favorite armchair, with a book under her arm and a cool smile that briefly lights up her melancholy features. She doesn't make much fuss, my woman, and few would probably understand what we see in each other, but she is one of the few people I've met who gives me peace.

...and the music—the music gives me peace. It is my only passion, the only thing that brings my mind into balance, that moves me to tears.

These sounds that rise from the gramophone's throat caress me, comforting, calming, longing, dreaming. Violins that speak of melancholy, life and death, dawn light and changing seasons. Everything it encompasses, everything it expresses, the music.

Composers and virtuosos are the true heroes, those who give my life its golden moments. Kowin, Beratinalde, and Pavlov—ah, Pavlov, the violinist, the virtuoso above them all. Many times my eyes have teared at the tones of his music. I do not value a thousand human lives higher than one of his pieces.

His dance across the strings takes me to another world, a private and secluded place, where my thoughts flow clear as the clearest water, and a strong light radiates heavenly even over a murderer's blood-dripping soul. There are others, but Pavlov is a god.

I put on one of his recordings and lean back with a long breath.

Damn it—the phone rings. I hate being disturbed at times like these, but I know it's about work. No one calls here except Gieger, or possibly his wife, Janella. It's Janella this time.

I kiss Klara and get in the car. It takes less than an hour to drive to Gieger's residence. It's part of the job to be a chauffeur, most of the time is spent escorting one of the couple back and forth between various business meetings and entertainment venues. I always have bad premonitions when it comes to Janella. She is a beautiful woman in her mid-thirties, intelligent, haughty, and accustomed to immediate obedience. Obeying is my job, but this past year I have had concerns, there is no doubt that she has acquired a lover.

Who she's fucking I couldn't care less about, but I have thought a lot about what would happen if Klarence found out that I chauffeured his wife to secret meetings without informing him. Klarence Gieger likes to know things. In fact, he becomes absolutely furious if things are going on behind his back.

It would clearly be damaging to our relationship if he found out that I knew things about his wife that he himself doesn't know.

The problem is that Janella is such a cunning damn witch. She has more than once implied that she can put me in a bad light if I can't keep my mouth shut. I am anxious to maintain my standing with Klarence Gieger. Therefore I keep my mouth shut. For now.

We're heading down to the harbor. Yet another of these obscure meetings. Janella doesn't deal with business so her outings exclusively involve visits to various beauty salons, meetings with some equally well-groomed girlfriend, or excursions to various jewelers and furriers. Not so today then—you don't drive down to the old harbor for anything but shady business. It's afternoon and dusk is already settling over the city. Autumn is approaching with fog, moisture and bleak days. The poor trees that survive among the buildings have begun to shed their leaves and stretch frozen fingers toward the sky. Dark banks of clouds drift in from the sea and

descend with vapors of rotting seaweed. I receive directions to drive down to one of the old piers that lie deserted nowadays. Only the occasional ship moors there for repairs, the old cranes rust away from lack of maintenance, trade and cargo handling have long since moved. We glide silently along the quay toward an old sailing ship, whose rigging emerges from the fog like an ancient skeleton. The city's skyscrapers rise from the haze in the background and if I weren't on duty I would have found the surroundings enjoyable. We stand there by the water for a while, without a word. Janella doesn't address me except to give orders. I long for home, for the music. A pair of lights emerge and a large car of an older model comes driving along the quay. It stops some distance away and a man steps out. Janella opens the door, swings her slender legs out of the car and walks toward the man. I look straight ahead. They meet in an embrace, quite brief, he seems to disengage from her. So this is the lover—one wonders who is foolhardy enough to get involved with Klarence Gieger's wife? He's a man around forty I would guess, with a slender, almost feminine figure. Classic features from what I can see, a somewhat large, curved nose and deep-set eyes. Upper class without doubt, the coat is well-tailored and the shoes are very shiny even in this dim light. I observe them while they converse. They stand fifty meters away and the car doors are closed, so I don't have a chance to catch what they're talking about. It's not in my interest either. I look toward the old full-rigger. Not a bad piece. In its day there was still beauty in the world. I can almost hear the creaking from the blocks when it plowed through distant swells once upon a time. Raised voices make me turn my attention back to Janella and her lover. Something has heated things up, the man takes a couple of steps to the side, turns back and gesticulates as if in frustration. Janella's posture signals disturbed emotions, anger, pleading. Now the situation is different, the professional in me awakens, I prepare to rush to her aid if needed. I check the pistol inside my jacket. Not yet, the man seems to collect himself and places a calming hand on her shoulder. No—she knocks his arm away and pushes him away. I'm alert, place my hand on the door handle. He flares up, hisses something, she slaps him. He takes a couple of steps back, holds his cheek and I don't need to be an expert to read his lips when he turns to leave —"Goodbye, Janella!" It's now that I realize I've taken the situation too lightly. Without a word Janella draws a weapon and puts two shots in the man's back. He stumbles, loses one shoe, collapses. I'm already at them, pistol in hand, and quickly survey the surroundings. Crazy fucking bitch. I can neither see nor hear anyone who could have witnessed what happened. Good—I know who's going to have to clean up if there are problems. "Is Madam alright?" I ask professionally. She's white-faced with rage. "What the fuck do you think?" she hisses and regards the corpse at her feet. "You never saw this, understand?" Her voice is like steel. "Put him in the trunk, this must be dealt with... you surely know what to do." She turns abruptly and walks toward the car, with her gloves pressed against her face in a sudden surge of emotion. Well look at that —there are emotions after all. "Yes, Madam," I say expressionlessly. I've disposed of bodies before, so I certainly know what must be done. The bone meal factory is a half hour's drive from the harbor. I drive straight there, without taking the long detour via the Giegers'. I have access to the facility, don't ask me to explain how. I carry the body in while Janella waits in the car outside. At this hour there's no one here, I can undisturbed walk through the premises with the corpse over my shoulder, over to the large crusher I've used before, in similar situations. I press some buttons and the machine rumbles to life. From the ramp above the chute I unceremoniously throw down the light body, but turn away my eyes when it disappears down. I may be a cold bastard, but I don't enjoy this sort of thing. The sound makes me nauseated. A twist of fate causes the machine to spit up the man's wallet in front of my feet. I pick it up to throw it back down into the grinder when my gaze catches on the front. A symbol, a golden violin, and an inscription in gold—Darius Pavlov —my heart freezes to ice. She swears many oaths and manages to claw a large mark on my cheek before I get her down. I turn off the machine, make sure everything looks as it did before I came, then I turn off the lights in the facility and walk heavily back to the car. On the way home I brood a bit about tomorrow, but the emptiness within me leaves me indifferent. Klara notices that something is wrong, as she always does, but asks

nothing. She brews a cup of tea as usual, stands quietly beside the armchair and lets her soft hands stroke my hair. The music fills the emptiness, comforting, calming...

People are trapped in their own worlds with their own problems and few have the energy to question or see things in a larger perspective. Being part of the State becomes part of life and outside the Inner City the State's direct presence is seldom noticed even though it permeates everything. The illusion of freedom and free will means that many accept their situation even though some take it a step further—the relative freedom breeds creativity and a few even manage to question the State and their worldview. However, there are those who find happiness within the State's framework. Who together with family and friends can suppress reality even in the hardest of times and avoid being stained by the bitterness that spreads in the heart of humanity. **The Fallen City** Once long ago, what now constitutes the Fallen City was the most powerful industrial district in Sandukar, a free part of the Machine Cities. Factories turned raw materials into riches, monuments were built and companies erected stately buildings that rose hundreds of meters above the workers' quarters' sooty brick buildings. Despite being on the outskirts, the district became an important and influential place and those who ruled from there gained great power and respect. Then something happened. Chaos and violence began to spread and the companies' own troops rose up against Sandukar's police and military. The Ministry of Truth proclaimed that the enemy had infected the district and an outright war began on the cobblestones between the brick buildings. A darkness covered the firmament and it was said that the enemy used a new type of weapon that spread madness and destruction. It ended with the central parts of the industrial district being bombed to pieces. The massive tower at its center collapsed and the fire-ravaged buildings lit up Sandukar's night sky with a sickly, red glow for several weeks. Instead of retaking the district and rebuilding it, the State decided it should be abandoned and all state troops were hastily withdrawn from there. The confused inhabitants who remained tried to provide for themselves as best they could and the district quickly became a haven for all manner of shady elements. Why the State allowed, and still allows, this to happen is unknown but the Fallen City is notorious as a dangerous and dark place throughout all of Sandukar. The area is controlled by gangs but in many ways the district is considerably more free than those held in the State's iron grip—however, it requires strength, finesse and contacts to survive in the district. The residents of the area engage in ordinary activities—work in the factories that remain, go to church, buy food in the shops and entertain themselves with what's available. The area suffers, however, from lack of maintenance and roads and buildings are in deplorable condition. Along the streets stand burnt-out and rusted car wrecks side by side with modern vehicles purchased from other parts of the city. The police are conspicuously absent—the gangs handle everything in their own way. Rumors say the gangs have bribed the police to stay away, others claim the police don't have the courage to clean up the mess. Ordinary people don't have much to fear from the gangs as they're not seen as any threat but rather as potential customers for the gangs' services. Despite the bad reputation and danger that hangs over the Fallen City, the district has many curious visitors. Those seeking something can most likely find it here. Many who have been to the city become morbidly dependent on it and go there again and again to let themselves sink deeper into perdition. Private clubs, bizarre performances, shady hotels and blacklisted goods exist for those who search. If you need to escape the State's gaze, the Fallen City is a perfect place to lie low. It constitutes a macabre carnival of experiences and impressions and if you lack something you'll find it here. In smoky brothels every pleasure is satisfied—however cruel and perverted it may be. The gambling dens offer entertainment and risktaking—you can gamble your money, your body or your soul. However, you must keep a cool head. The Fallen City devours incautious visitors whereupon the inhabitants feast on the remains. **The Machine Cities** Along Sandukar's outer circle, vast areas spread with industries, factories, works, warehouses, smelters and countless chimneys whose smoke conceals the sky in a gray-black gloom. Iron and coal become steel in the steelworks' heat, the coal constitutes fuel for the power plants that supply the city with light, the steel gives the city strength to grow large and mighty. Among grinding cogwheels and the eternal thudding of machines, the workers toil to

produce everything from household goods and tools to motor vehicles and war materiel. In the Machine Cities it's never quiet—the factories are relentlessly running around the clock, year-round. In total there are 49 sectors here which cover almost all of Sandukar's outer edge, toward the Moat. In addition there are 49 residential sectors, called the Soot Cities, in which many of the industrial workers live. Most of these workers are owned by the companies and families that run the factories and they're forced to live in the Soot Cities—work for a temporary, limited citizenship. They're not allowed to leave Sandukar but are held as "lifetime employees," as they're usually called. The minority of workers who are free citizens often manage to reach higher positions within the industries and also live in other places, outside the Soot Cities. The work in the factories is hard and dangerous and fatalities occur daily. The enormous factories stretch both high up toward the sky and deep down underground. Raw materials are transported to the area by train and the finished material is then shipped away by train or ship to other districts or out of Sandukar. In the Machine Cities there are also immense greenhouses and large-scale livestock breeding. The animals are fastened in their pens and kept alive through force-feeding. Fires constantly shoot up toward the sky from the massive incinerators that annihilate the by-products from the animals. People live in a constant stench among ash and burnt fat that adorns both facades and streets. **The Soot Cities** The Soot Cities are Sandukar's true slum areas. They're divided into sectors which are separated by high walls with checkpoints toward the rest of the city. The quarters belong to various industrial companies, families and houses and it's here their workers live as slaves under the factories' time clocks.

The area forms an enormous, miserable housing enclave connected to the Machine Cities. Here live the poorest workers in worn brick buildings, soiled by factory fall-out. The standard of living is very low, the homes are drafty, cracked and damp, and diseases, plagues and ail-ments rage constantly. The unemployed, mentally ill, disabled and drug addicts struggle for survival side by side with working family men, struggling shopkeepers and broke beggars. All have their crosses to bear. Many don't even have citizenship. The lively black market trade in items smuggled out from the Machine Cities is extensive and can give a poor worker a few extra zovrins to live on. Corporate leaders view this activity very seriously and workers dis-covered engaging in this occupation are fired and mutilated so they will never be able to work in a factory again. The clinics in the Soot Cities are understaffed and that they remain open at all is often only thanks to passionate souls. The police in the area are brutal and work to protect the State's and the corporations' property. Many police stations completely lack detectives for investigative work. On those occasions when desperate riots occur, the State sends in military troops to cleanse entire blocks with the help of automatic weapons and flamethrowers. The workers who live here are regarded as not much more than animals and usually have no rights whatsoever. **The Harbor** By the island's coast, outside the city walls, an industrial-like landscape with endless rows of harbor warehouses and powerful cranes spreads out. The vast harbor area lies beside the polluted Oil Sea — an ocean that at the Copper River's outlet is filthy, foul-smelling and stagnant. Gigantic piers and quays stretch out over the dark water. At the horizon one can make out rusty oil platforms that erode away in the acid rain and salt water while they stubbornly suck sustenance from the earth's interior. Oil and natural gas are drilled by solitary derricks and experienced skip-pers use the fires from the waste gases to navigate to avoid reefs on the fastest route to their destination. Trade across the sea and along the river means that several import and export companies have their offices squeezed among the enormous cargo warehouses. The air is hard to breathe as diesel locomotives constantly struggle to pull their heavy loads to and from the rusty vessels, and trucks spread arriv-ing goods to different parts of the city for greedy consumption. By the quays one finds modern cargo ships side by side with old wrecks, sailing ships and rusted-through barges that barely float. The latter serve as homes for the destitute and refugees without citizenship. Different gangs try to gain control over these individuals to make them work with loading and unloading of goods and fighting other gangs competing for the lucrative employment as sailors and stevedores. The gangs are often built based on country of origin, which means some of them have thou-sands

of members. **The Icon** The Icon is a large district in the Free City's southwestern parts. The district harbors a rich variety of social class-es and houses many cultures, even though the established upper class chooses to reside in other places than here. The western parts of The Icon are populated mainly by refugees and immigrants. The district borders the Emperor, the Ash and the Golden Orchard but it also borders the Fallen City and is influenced in many ways by its lawless neighbor. **The Icon Quarters** The Icon Quarters form the center of The Icon and it is here the middle class resides. The area contains, in addition to tall residential buildings, chain stores and office buildings, also depart-ment stores and marketplaces. The grand and very straight Sterner Avenue cuts through the district as a landmark. Several of the shops that have headquarters in the Inner City have chosen to establish branches along Sterner Avenue, which is why the entire stretch is called "the people's luxury." The two-lane avenue is cross-ed by a multitude of smaller streets that connect the residential areas all around with the life-giving artery that consists of the wide road. **Argai's taxi** Argai's taxi is a smaller taxi company that mainly operates in The Icon but for the right sum of money also ventures out to other city areas — even to the Fallen City. The company's cars are spacious, matte black and with a glowing taxi sign on the roof. Many of the drivers are former soldiers or thugs. They are all armed in the event that some customer causes trouble or they get rides in dangerous areas. They wear strict but simple uniforms with black double-breasted suits and driver's caps. **The Brothel Night Bird** Night Bird is one of the finer, stricter brothels in The Icon. It has well-maintained premises, healthy women and high prices. It is thus a brothel for those who are a bit better off. Night Bird's leader Madam Sophie has re-cently taken control over the sex trade in almost all of The Icon. The smaller brothels have been forced to close, pimps have disappeared and whores changed owners. Even the women who work the street are indirectly connected to the brothel. There are still gangs fighting to take control over the sex trade but they are clearly at a disadvantage and Night Bird thus has relatively little competition in The Icon. Those who seek cheap prostitutes or have odd lusts usually go over to the Fallen City where carnal pleasures are plentiful and the sickest lusts are satisfied. Madam Sophie is a member of the organization Lust Twilight but runs business her way and doesn't want her girls to be harmed. The serial killer ravaging the city's streets has begun causing major problems for her. The girls no longer dare pick up customers on the street and as long as the Whistler rages she loses money. Despite contacts within both the police and bureaucracy, Madam Sophie has not been able to get the killer captured, which is why she is now considering hiring a group of investigators who can track down the killer and take care of him. **The Underworld** Sandukar is a vast city and there are plenty of underground spaces in the form of sewer systems, subway tunnels, culverts and remains from the ancient temple city. In the depths carved tunnel systems stretch eternally downward. Here one finds underground lakes and torrents where the city's canal water disappears into the abyss. The echo from massive machines can sometimes be heard in these tunnels but who built the machines, what function they serve and who they belong to no one knows. 131kapitel 4 — imperiet

The Golden Salon

The nightclub the Golden Salon, by Strasser Avenue, is a finer establishment where in the large salon with its whitewashed walls, golden decorations and dark purple drapes one can listen to music and song and enjoy a good meal with luxurious wine and spirit varieties. On weekends the club is well-attended and one only gets in if properly dressed and well-behaved. From the salon a spiral staircase leads up to the upper floor and only those who are rich and seeking pleasures wander up its steps, with the owners' permission. Here they enter a smaller salon with sofas and divans, candelabras, incense and a smaller bar where Max, the man of forbidden pleasures, has his operation. Absinthe, opium pipes and various hallu-cinogenic drugs are offered and if one passes through any of the drapes one finds a collection of rooms where bodies and satisfaction of lusts can be purchased. The atmosphere is relax-ed and pleasurable, here the wealthy meet to live out their fantasies and let dreams wander in the intoxication of drugs. Konstantini Hall At Prince Barto's viaduct stands The Icon's

most talked-about building. The gigantic, several hundred year old Kosantini Hall has a ceiling height of 30 meters, and large ornate pillars hold up the enormous roof, which houses one of Sandu-kar's most impressive paintings — The Virgin Spring. Now-adays the building functions as a gigantic commercial center with focus on meat, delicacies and other fresh foods — in common parlance the building is simply called the Market Hall. Korolev Station Like a spider in a web of steel lies the train station in The Icon's center. From here one can travel by subway or with one of the other train networks across all of Sandukar. Trains that travel out of the city and through the Empire's expanses depart from specially guarded platforms. The train station constantly seethes with life during the day but at night its vast halls stand empty with the exception of a few waiting travelers. The building is in neo-Gothic style with tall, arched windows and a facade decorated with statues representing people and monsters. The main hall in the building's center is a common meeting place and here are several cafés and fast food joints. From crackling loudspeakers visitors are informed about arriving and departing trains and in photo booths one can immortalize oneself. Uniformed police move among the crowds and occasionally make routine checks of persons with suspicious appearance or behavior. If one follows the rails away from the stations one comes to the rail yard where endless rows of passenger and freight cars stand along sidings. In the engine sheds diesel locomotives are maintained and here the drivers also have their own rooms to rest in. The train station is a meeting place for people traveling to and from Sandukar and for people in the city. Shady activity takes place on the crowded platforms. It is a place for secret meetings and agreements, a paradise for pickpockets, and a hub where contraband is smuggled in and out of the city. The platforms are many and at night they become scenes for confrontations, and sleeping places for intoxicated homeless. **The Cogwheel** The Cogwheel — so the central police headquarters in The Icon is called by both criminals, common folk and guardians of law and order. The forces of order's center is housed in a mas-sive brick building that once served as a factory and smelting works. It bears clear traces of its heritage — still blackened chimneys tower up toward the firmament and in halls and chambers stand in some places rusty machine parts and cogwheels. The greater part of the building is rebuilt and there is plenty of office and storage space and garages for police vehicles. In one of the wings the morgue is housed and in these antiseptic spaces the corpses are stored in cold storage until the forensic doctors can perform their samplings and draw their conclusions. There-after the corpses are transported to the still functioning incinerator oven to be spread in a cloud of ash over the city. The Cogwheel is almost a world unto itself. The police constables change in locker rooms that were previously worker housing. Every day they hope that none of their friends will perish on the violent streets or once and for all break under the pressure and the violent scenes they time and again experience. After being among the destitute and the worst of criminals they must then write their re-ports on clattering typewriters so that all that happened can be saved in vast basement halls with endless filing cabinets. The police captains have their own offices where they are responsible for various investigations and hand out their orders. The ambitious sit there late into the nights studying crime's effects in the glow from green-shaded brass lamps. The walls are filled with maps, pictures of places and victims and newspaper clippings about investigations and corruption. In this chaos of violence's whispers, whiskey-diluted coffee and cracked ashtrays overflowing with cigarette butts the guardians of law try to prevent the district from falling into total chaos. Their frustration and powerlessness they take out on the criminals sitting in custody in the police station's basement. Abuse of prisoners is part of everyday life and during interrogations often the fists speak. In many ways the designation "cogwheel" seems extremely fitting as everything seems to repeat itself and nothing changes. Criminals come and go, police get tired and give up or die in service and despite the cogwheel being in eternal motion it cannot change the world surrounding it — rather it contributes to its chaos. **Klaus's bar** Set down in a basement not far from the cogwheel lies Klaus's bar. In this smoky environment many police gather after their shift to drink beer, play billiards, talk shop, talk shit about the bosses and discuss cases that seem impossible to solve. The walls are covered with framed newspaper clippings about major criminal cases that were solved and police who were promoted. On one wall there are

pictures of the police academy's graduating classes and the guests have drawn crosses above the head of those who died in service. Klaus is himself a former detective who lost one leg in service. He started the bar as he didn't want a desk job and now it serves as a haunt for the guardians of law. Klaus has heard most things and has a very good handle on what's happening in the police world.

132 kapitel 4 — imperiet

Franko Millovy Defense Attorney

Valeri Ducalls Street 117 Ikonen, Sandukar

September City

In the middle of the district lies an extensive residential area that differs greatly from the surrounding buildings. Its small stone houses lie tightly compressed together while large parts of the area have been left open in favor of parks and artistic monuments.

The area, called September City, is surrounded by high iron fences. Only those with very high income and good contacts can find housing in this area whose residents have tried to cut themselves off from the outside world.

The Zeppelin Harbor

At Petsamer Square in Ikonen lies the zeppelin harbor. Here a massive tower of bare steel beams rises up toward the sky, and at the very top are four platforms where zeppelins can dock. Thick steel cables keep the platforms stable in the harsh wind, and at night powerful searchlights are lit at ground level, illuminating the structure and serving as navigation points for the zeppelins.

Large elevators travel up and down between the platforms and ground level. Down on the ground, rows of taxicabs wait to carry passengers onward on their journey. Here there are also entrances to the subway as well as smaller hotels and restaurants. In the white-tiled waiting hall beneath the tower, one can buy tickets and check baggage that is transported up to the zeppelins via cargo elevators.

From the zeppelin harbor one can travel with smaller airships within Sandukar or board large Imperial zeppelins that travel hundreds of miles—all the way to Sadovia and Vadaja.

The zeppelin harbor is always patrolled by the Imperium's soldiers and by the airship companies' own security forces. It is open around the clock, and the only times when zeppelins do not depart or arrive is when the winds are too strong and howl through the steel tower's beams.

The Workers' Quarters

In the southwest sprawls a mixed residential and industrial area, where factories spew out massive clouds of smoke that create heavy smog on windless days. Several of the factories are run by the company Werner & Quildos, which is said to be connected to the Kriger family.

Many protests and complaints have been heard from nearby residents who want the factories shut down because they so heavily pollute the air and cause soot cough to spread. So far their cries have been ignored, and the Ministry of Truth has posted notices stating that the soot smoke is not harmful to health.

Werner & Quildos Factories

Werner & Quildos is a family company with connections to the Brana family within the Kriger clan. The company has borrowed large sums of money to expand factory operations within the Ikonen area, which has led to large residential areas being forced to be demolished.

The new factories have given rise to great dissatisfaction from private individuals in the factory area's vicinity and factory workers who have received reduced wages and work under very dangerous conditions. The large chimneys spread stinking fallout over the workers' residential areas, making it impossible to have windows open for ventilation, hang out laundry, or even be outdoors without the stinking sulfur vapors settling into clothes and skin.

The workers have begun organizing themselves more and more and openly demonstrate against the injustices and the reduced wages. Karl Erwald is the name of the charismatic leader who has gotten the workers to dare make demands—he is himself a factory worker since his youth and known for having been a promising boxer for a short period. He gives fiery speeches in taverns, on street corners, and on factory floors about the unjust treatment.

Werner & Quildos first tried to silence him with bribes but have now instead moved on to threats against Karl and those who support him.

Beyond threatening with dismissal, the extortionists bring out the brass knuckles, and many workers come to work with battered faces and broken ribs as well as reminders that their families too can come to harm. The extortionists who have jumped on Karl have however been beaten down and publicly humiliated, and many of the workers see Karl as their hero and leader.

A strike in the most dangerous factory hall has begun after yet another fatal accident occurred—the situation is untenable and risks ending in violent riots.

Werner & Quildos's leader, the elderly patriarch Lester Quildos, sees it as his final task to rein in the factory workers once and for all, but it must be done quickly because the money that is to be repaid to the Brana family is not coming in as long as the factory is not producing its full quota. Lester himself lives in Ikonen's finer area and sits constantly connected to IV drips, catheter, and oxygen mask as he is very old and terminally ill with cancer. Around him are a number of high-level executives who are just waiting for his death and who will fight among themselves for power. Lester has decided to hire outside help to clean out the factory workers who are throwing wrenches in the works and who think they have rights. He has also begun hiring child laborers for the more precision mechanical projects, as children need very little pay and don't make any demands.

Nedomstad

In southern Ikonen lies Nedomstad, a residential area for factory workers and other low-wage earners. The residential area consists of several five-story brick buildings that lie next to each other. The apartments above ground are cramped and small but still luxurious if you compare them with the dwellings that lie underground. There are ten basement levels with dim cement corridors and water-damaged walls. Doors lead into small rooms with peeling paint and bare light bulbs. Here stand dirty beds, worn furniture, and attempts at decoration of the stinking holes. The ventilation is poor and leaks sometimes cause the corridors' floors to be covered by a thin layer of water.

The area is overcrowded; here workers sleep between shifts at the factories and dream of a brighter future. There are many violent crimes in Nedomstad as intoxicated workers take out their frustrations on each other.

The police must come here several times a week to investigate robberies, assault, and in some cases murder. The most common cause of death among residents in Nedomstad, however, is suicide—many cannot stand their lives and throw themselves on the railway tracks or hang themselves in the leaking pipes.

Keiter's Clinic

Wedged between two factory premises in the workers' quarters lies a small clinic run by Doctor Keiter, an eccentric, domineering older man, and his wife, also a nurse. **They are said to harbor a burning hatred** against the State and therefore help the sick and injured in Ikonen when needed, for a cheap penny. The availability of advanced equipment and medicine is variable, and the hygiene could be significantly better in the premises, but the good doctor's help is both appreciated and effective.

The Emperor's Quarters

The Emperor's Quarters is a gigantic residential area that runs along the eastern canal's edge. Here live primarily Ikonen's middle and lower classes in row houses and in quarter complexes of stone and concrete. Many areas are pure ghettos that have been marked by local culture and by the indigenous population.

The big band struck up in Janos Kegel's "The Bearer's Song" and I swept down the last of the champagne glass and stepped up to the beautiful red-haired woman. We danced out among the other well-dressed who let themselves be seduced by the atmosphere at the Golden Salon. My hand rested lightly on her hip and she locked my gaze with hers. We whirled around among the well-dressed couples from the upper class and after the dance I invited her to my table where I ordered a new bottle of champagne.

Her red-painted lips left a seductive mark on the glass and when I leaned closer to be able to speak with her over the din and music I smelled the scent of her perfume. The words exchanged were polite but the glances became increasingly indecent during the evening, and when she invited me home to her place I was not slow to accept.

A taxi took us to the house where she lived, an elevator took us up to her door, and once there she clung to me and kissed me on the neck. That night we made love while the windows stood open in the summer heat until the sun rose over the rooftops.

Only much later did I learn that she was Ilsa, an assassin and criminal, but the night we shared was one of pleasure. We had set aside our roles, set aside our loyalties and were only a man and a woman who needed each other.

Building style and design vary wildly between the quarters; in some parts dilapidated stone houses with ornaments on the facades dominate, in other parts one finds wooden houses with cracked paint layers as well as soiled, vandalized brick houses. The further south, the richer the residents; the further north, the poorer.

The First Imperial Bank

When it comes to money, and especially loans, withdrawals, and deposits, it is to the Imperial Bank one turns. This bank chain, which is directly linked to the Zovrin family, exists throughout the Imperium and is known for its good security and discretion in sensitive money transactions.

The office in Ikonen is housed in a stately building with marble columns, statues, and wide stairs. In the bank windows, clerks handle ordinary people's business while the rich and influential are invited to private offices where they can enjoy a cognac while the accountants go through the books.

In the cellar vaults are stored valuable personal belongings, large sums of money, and deepest down in the depths a massive gold reserve that is the Kordar family's personal fortune. The Imperial Bank also handles money transports, and these usually occur with armored vans which are driven by guards armed with automatic weapons.

The massive fortune connected to the bank and its business draws many covetous glances, and recently a number of value transports have been robbed. The Imperial Bank does not trust that the police will find the gang behind the robberies and has therefore appointed a special group of auditors, most of them former soldiers, who torture their way through the underworld in search of the perpetrators.

The Rulov Gang

One of Sandukar's worst gangs, the Rulov gang, has its headquarters in Ikonen. At the fashionable Hotel Kristatos, in the southern parts of the Emperor's Quarters, the inner circle, including the boss Sergy Rulov, resides. The top floor is completely closed off and is inhabited exclusively by Sergy's henchmen. Sergy has his own suite on the floor but is known for rarely being in the same place for any longer periods as he knows he is a sought-after and hated man.

Sergy Rulov came together with his brother Dashim from Darost to the city of hope to seek their fortune. The two brothers got into trouble early on, but Sergy proved to have an enormous asset—a ruthlessness that meant he dared to go further and take greater risks than most others. His total lack of respect for everything meant that he surprised the traditional criminals in the city, among whom honor and respect are prioritized.

Sergy Rulov has been married to Iryana for many years. Together they have three children, two sons and a daughter. The daughter, Aria, is the one who gives Sergy the most headaches of the three as she is rebellious and unruly. She lives a diligent nightlife at several of Ikonen's worse taverns and goes through even more temporary boyfriends—many of whom suffer visits on her father's behalf.

The Rulov gang is large and is controlled through fear and rewards for well-executed work. Informing is encouraged, and wrongdoers who break the rules are killed immediately, often by Sergy Rulov himself. Sergy is considered the highest in the gang, with brother Dashim as a good second—it is Dashim who is the administrator of the two, while Sergy gladly goes out in the field with a baseball bat and a revolver ready. Both brothers are constantly guarded by a horde of bodyguards.

The gang's primary occupation is gambling, protection, and smuggling—primarily of drugs and liquor which is distributed via connected gambling clubs and speakeasies. The gang has been spared from more serious controversies with the law and with Stapo, much thanks to a certain tact for whom one can quarrel with and whom one does not take on—the State's guardians often choose to look the other way when conflicts occur within the underworld. Sergy Rulov is also careful about clashing with the local police. He restrains his vindictiveness for a higher purpose—to slowly but surely take over the entire city.

Final Rest

Final Rest is one of the larger nursing homes in Ikonen, an institution that has become increasingly popular as one no longer has time to take care of one's father and mother when they have become too old to manage on their own. The Abhrovich family, which runs the nursing home, earns large sums of money, among other things through subsidies, on their humanitarian efforts.

The nursing home is housed in an old hospital building and promises in its brochures a dignified final time for the elderly in calm and stimulating environments. This is far from the truth; large parts of the building are in deplorable condition with water damage and poor ventilation. Here the old are forced to lie in urine-stinking beds and are fed the cheapest food that can be obtained. The staff number is kept to a minimum to save money, and the heating has been shut off in many parts of the building, also for cost reasons. The caregivers are almost all non-citizens, they receive terrible pay, live in the building, and dare not report the poor conditions as it would lead to their non-citizenship becoming known.

Families who want to meet their old relatives must contact them in advance; the old people are then dressed up, washed, placed in wheelchairs, and brought to heated, cozy rooms. No other parts of the building may be viewed by outsiders, for confidentiality reasons.

Most who put their elderly relatives in the nursing home have enough of their own problems and do not investigate the conditions more closely; the majority do not care at all and only dutifully meet their relatives on birthdays and holidays. Milo Erdesser, however, is not such a man; since his mother died of malnutrition at the nursing home, he has written several letters to the editor to the newspapers and tried to draw attention to what is happening there. He has even tried to get into the building to photograph. The Abhrovich family has, as a countermeasure, invested money to make him disappear, and Milo is now trying to find people who have relatives at Final Rest to get them to help him expose the shameless abuses.

The Starmaker

Ikonen's starmaker is a man named Marx Begel. He is a talent scout and agent who recruits young talents for film and music production. Some call him the "Evil Eye" as one of his eyes is damaged.

The office where auditions and screen tests are conducted is located in the well-maintained Ustinov Palace, a former summer home for bored nobles converted to provide facilities for record production, simple filmmaking, and other forms of entertainment.

Begel channels the most skilled talents onward to the big studios in Glitterdalen, Sandukar's entertainment hub, in exchange for a share of the future stars' wages. Marx is known for knowing everyone, knowing what's happening, and staying on good terms with those who matter for continued success.

The Celenk Quarters

The Celenk Quarters is a poor district populated mainly by refugees and immigrants, especially the western sections. The buildings consist of low brick tenements, and over the area hangs a constant vapor from the characteristic Celenka food culture, where fatty oils and butter form the base.

The district's many squares are cluttered with market stalls where street vendors compete for customers, with everything from trinkets to fruit, meat and vegetables, to clothing and crafts. The squares are also crowded with street musicians, entertainers, and con artists trying to cheat the unwary out of their zovrins through rigged card tricks and wagers.

Jostin's Café

A ways down Vätter Alley lies Jostin's Café, a basement establishment and gathering place for local leaders among the ethnic groups and gangs that plague Ikonen. The café is a powder keg, but the owners—the gigantic Malabar triplets Tarik, Marek, and Ibhim—manage to keep order among their unruly clientele through a good mix of diplomacy and strength.

Gideon's Pawnshop

Gideon is an obese, sweaty man with less conscience than hair on his head. He owns a pawnshop on the corner of Branka and Maslow, where everything from watches, dolls, and instruments is crammed together with stolen goods, jewels, and illegal weapons.

Gideon has a short fuse and hates haggling over prices, but since he has very good knowledge of what's happening in the area, the criminals let him be.

Rumors say that Gideon has hidden away evidence against known figures in Ikonen, evidence that will be made public if he should disappear or meet with some accident.

The Cauldron

In an extensive underground area consisting of several linked basements beneath high-rises and office buildings lies what's called the Cauldron—a tangle of small traders, peddlers, and brokers in all manner of things. In the midst of the commerce are beer cafés housed in the cellar vaults, and the entire area is shrouded in the heavy, fatty vapors from the typical Celenka food culture.

Everyone is welcome in the Cauldron, though non-Celenks are rarely offered the best prices or the largest selection of special goods. Through the Cauldron, one can travel long distances underground if needed—for example, if the police should be chasing you.

The Old Quarter

The Old Quarter is a sprawling and dirty residential area where mainly the middle and lower classes reside. It's dilapidated and worn, with many smaller slum areas where vagrants and gangs occupy empty, ramshackle buildings and condemned structures.

The various addresses are separated by neglected and overgrown park and green areas with sporadic lighting and plenty of hiding places. Crime is, however, under control in the area's other parts, even though much protection racket activity occurs.

Millovy's Law Firm

"*Those who say crime doesn't pay understand nothing! Of course crime pays—the reason so few engage in it is that it's wrong!*" —Franko Millovy, newspaper interview

Franko Millovy is a renowned defense attorney who has helped many in Ikonen escape the State's punishments—both ordinary people and more shadowy elements are in his clientele.

Millovy is a rather short and slight person with a childish face and piercing gaze. Some whisper that he was thrown out of one of the Houses—probably Arkady—others maintain that he's a passionate defender of the weak. What's true and what isn't is hard to say, but the fact remains that Millovy is known for his quick statements and that he gladly sees himself on the morning paper's front page.

Sister Hilda's Shelter

The homeless and destitute seek out Sister Hilda's shelter during the coldest winter days to sleep in warmth and eat watery soup. They can also pick up discarded clothing that's been donated, and Sister Hilda and her volunteer workers sometimes have medicines to give to the sickest.

Sister Hilda, now an old woman, has fought against the world's injustices her entire life and has run the shelter for more than thirty years. She's seen as a saint by many of the homeless since she gives them security in the world.

Sister Hilda has recently become old and sick, and the lease for the shelter expires within a few months. There's no money to renew it, and the residents of the area would prefer the homeless to disappear.

Berekia Forest

In some of the green areas, women and men gather at night hoping to succeed in selling their bodies to speculators. Most famous of these areas is Berekia Forest—a hilly park area where young girls and boys, sexual deviants and perverts offer themselves to the curious and desperate. The overgrown groves provide shelter and are said to awaken nature's lust in those who venture in for sexual pleasure and release.

Aramis Contact Brokerage

At the intersection of Dion's Road and Eriana Avenue lies one of Sandukar's most renowned contact agencies, "Aramis Contact Brokerage." Melchior Aramis, a man of unknown origin, leads a firm shrouded in the highest discretion that ensures interested parties meet and do business with each other.

The house is a two-story office with a cellar vault for archives. The office contains specialized bulletin boards and private meeting rooms for personal counseling and brokerage. The establishment is open around the clock and is rarely without vigilant consultants, nervous clients, or stern problem-solvers.

Pane Square

Pane Square, located above the underground central station, is a large square whose center is occupied by a large statue of a veiled man with a spire in his hand raised toward the heavens. The statue has remained since ancient times, and who the man represents is unknown. However, cults have arisen around him, and some call him Sandukar since he's believed to be the city's founder.

The Syrovska Cathedral

The One's faith has several missions in Ikonen. In the middle of Pane Square stands a mighty building in the One's name—the Syrovska Cathedral. No one remembers exactly when it began being built, but work crews are still laying the final stones in the work.

The cathedral is built of matte black basalt and is of Gothic proportions, with massive arched vaults. Over the centuries, however, the architectural ideas have mixed, and the oldest sections have been allowed to decay.

The cathedral's great hall, where mass is held, is vast. So vast that the only thing visible when it's filled is a sea of people. Beneath the cathedral are overwhelming crypts from the time when bodies weren't sent to the meat factories. The names of those who lie here are unknown, however, and they seem to have left no marks on history, even though their tomb monuments testify to greatness.

Western Park

Opposite the Syrovska Cathedral lies a large, lush park with several larger forested areas. Western Park is a known hangout for junkies and dealers and is not considered a safe place to be in the evening—unless your business is to score a high. Rumors say there are entrances to a tunnel system beneath the park, which in addition to housing the homeless and destitute also leads further downward to something else.

Reerdon's Hotel

Reerdon's Hotel has seen better days—it's a worn-down and decrepit place, with a clientele that usually consists of wanted criminals, lowlifes and their customers, and people who just need to lay low for a while. The manager, Mr. Viktor Vandort, is a discreet man who doesn't ask unnecessary questions, as long as he gets paid in advance.

The building is a large stone and concrete block of eight stories. The inside bears traces of the prosperous days of yore, with velvet, brass lamps, and wood panels—but now everything is decayed and dirty.

The Borderlands

The Borderlands is what the western area facing the canal and the Fallen City is called. It's a slum area that has no exact boundary but merges into the workers' quarter and the beggars' quarter. Here are many large warehouse buildings, storehouses, smaller bars, and suspect individuals. Two marvels of steel bridges rest over the canal, and those who travel between their rusty iron beams by car or take the broken-down and stinking train arrive at the Fallen City.

The Hangars

Near Kader Bridge and the steep shaft leading down to the stinking canal stand several abandoned zeppelin hangars and old industries with rusty gates and cracked windows like a monument from a bygone era. From this desolate place, one can see the lights from the Fallen City and the lanterns from the vehicles that like fireflies search their way across the rusty bridge.

Despite the area being in the middle of the city, the place breathes menacing isolation. Many of the buildings have begun to collapse and are harshly attacked by the cold wind that howls through them with a wailing sound. Walls and barbed wire fences keep out the curious, but those familiar with the area know several ways to get in. Most avoid doing so, however, since those who end up here rarely make it back.

To this place, the police usually take people they think should disappear, or who must be interrogated in special ways that aren't even suitable in the police station. The street dwellers who move in the quarter can tell of chilling screams and the sound of gunfire and relentless machinery. Bodies are carried out in sacks that are then thrown into the canal or ground up in one of the functioning meat grinders in the former slaughterhouse. Those who wander near the slaughterhouse smell the stench of putrefaction, and those who dare venture in experience a macabre world with pulverized bodies, blood-stained tile, and remnants of personal belongings.

The hangar area has become a center for the more shadowy operations within the police force. In addition to space for interrogations and executions, it also functions as a meeting place, warehouse, and training ground.

The Smuggling Transports

Certain evenings, large trucks make their way from the Fallen City to various meeting places in Ikonen, loaded with smuggled liquor and cigarettes. This illegal trade occurs between the Hexagon and the Rulov gang and brings in large sums for both camps. The organizations are suspicious of each other, but as long as both profit from the cooperation, a temporary peace prevails.

The Whistler

A serial killer is prowling Ikonen's streets, who over nine months has killed seventeen young women and men, most of them destitute or prostitutes. The news has only recently made headlines in the newspaper Voice of Hope since one of the victims was found to be a middle-class man—from a family with a certain measure of influence.

The police are stumped; it's only during recent months that all the murders have been connected, and they're still not sure they've found all the victims. Most of the victims are fished up from the canal and bear signs of having been kept alive in captivity for an extended time; a handful of victims, however, have been found in their own homes, tied up in their beds, cut to pieces, and with missing organs.

The serial killer has been named the Whistler by the media after a witness claims to have seen the murderer whistling as they left a victim's residence. There are many theories about who the killer might be, but no evidence. Most believe it's someone from the hraghian people taking revenge, or that it's an escaped mental patient.

Reporter Mikos Razciak devotes all his time to finding the killer and hopes for a big scoop that will make him famous. In many ways he has greater insight into the killer's methods than the police and has become obsessed with the deeds. He has published a handful of articles and found evidence that he connects to the murders, including that one of the victims had traces of an expensive oil paint on their body, a paint only used for paintings. He has also found a person he believes is a witness to one of the murders or possibly a victim who got away. The young woman is not in full possession of her faculties and now sits in a mental hospital, but under hypnosis Mikos has gotten accounts and descriptions of the killer's deeds from her. Whether this is merely a way for Razciak to create greater interest around the murders and sell more copies is unclear.

Groups in the Icon

In the Icon there are a number of elements all fighting to gain as much power as possible in the district. Besides business leaders, greedy family members and new entrepreneurs, there are those who bend rules and laws to achieve their goals and thus become part of the underworld.

The Police Force

Even though the police are meant to protect the weak and catch the suspects, it's not uncommon for individual constables to walk other paths than the distinguished ones. The police have great power in the Icon area and are divided into several subgroups that struggle among themselves.

The Punishers

There is a group of police officers who have grown tired of criminals they lack evidence against but who they still know are guilty — and criminals they know will commit crimes again once their sentences are served. There are also those who want to cleanse unwanted elements from society or who just want to feel the rush of having power over life and death.

The Revenge Patrol is a group of police officers who have many sympathizers within the force. Members take to the streets to establish order and justice according to their own laws. They capture, interrogate, torture and execute people to extract the information they desire. They avenge fallen colleagues and ensure that criminal elements fear them and the police force.

The advantage of their actions is that they can smash criminal organizations without evidence and trial costs. The disadvantage is that many innocents perish and that people in the lower rungs of society fear and despise

the police force and refuse to seek help from it.

What was once a strong ideology focused on doing right has for many members of the revenge patrol turned into pure lust — to purge the individuals they don't like. Besides criminals, the homeless, prostitutes, street children, homosexuals and people of other ethnic origins have become targets. Likewise, there is an economic gain in looting the bodies of those they've killed and some see the act as a pure source of income on the side.

The Bought

The salary for a police officer is rarely particularly large considering the dangers one exposes oneself to, and it's more of a rule than an exception that one takes bribes to supplement the income. There are even those who take it a step further and completely sell themselves to a criminal organization. It may be for strictly economic or ideological reasons or because the organization has leverage over them. Whatever the case, they are the organization's eyes and ears in the police world and see to acting in the organization's interests.

The Hexagon and the Cartel are the two organizations that have the greatest influence in the police force in the Free City, and as a bought policeman one must play one's cards right because if one's colleagues find out about one's new loyalties, one will surely suffer an "accident" or be sentenced to a long prison term.

Those who serve the Hexagon often do so for a generous sum of money or various services granted to them — usually an exploitation of twisted lusts and weak points, but many have an almost religious view of the Hexagon's operations and serve the ideology because they consider it right.

The Corrupted

There are those police officers who have realized what an advantageous position they are in and what power they have over people in the underworld. These individuals use their resources to run their own criminal operations alongside their police work, usually pimping operations or drug dealing. Thus they have become part of the corrupting effect they swore to fight.

The Liger Family

The Liger family owns and runs the Golden Salon and tries to keep it outside the major organizations. The ambition is to let the nightclub remain a neutral meeting place, even though it's becoming increasingly difficult. The family has good leverage over the police, however, and is never subjected to raids or the like.

At the top of the building is an attic floor that can be reached via a rickety fire escape on the back or through a rarely used staircase hidden behind draperies on the upper floor. The space functions as a hiding place for friends and allies of the family who must stay away from the law or enemies in the underworld.

Those who have money or information to offer can find an important ally in the Liger family as the family members have contacts within the police and knowledge of most of what happens in the shady parts of town.

"You are one second later than the solution to everything." — The Engineer

The Fallen City

The Fallen City is a world unto itself. It is ruled by gangs and warlords who replace state oppression but in many ways the people have more freedom. Here one does not find state propaganda and bureaucratic difficulties.

The Water Moat

On the outskirts of the Fallen City, toward the outer wall, the water from the canal has risen, while the ground level has been undermined and sunk. The oily water completely drowns the lowest buildings while the others stand half in dirty, blackened water. In the buildings that still stretch up out of the water live poor workers and the lawless. Empty factories are marked by their water-filled chimneys that stand above the water surface. On the bottom are corroded car wrecks and trucks that bear witness to the time before the flood.

Despite the grim surroundings, the whitish-gray fog and the icy dampness, the people have adapted — small boats with lanterns at the bow find their way between the buildings that have gotten new entrances level with the water surface. Makeshift bridges of rusty metal, creaking cable constructions and piers of scrap make it possible in places to move between nearby houses via a network of narrow and dangerous walkways. Few of the houses in the sunken district have electricity and refuse is dumped out through the windows, down into the sluggish water. Some residents have built houseboats that function as dwellings and make it possible to move quickly if unrest can be sensed.

The largest buildings have become societies in themselves and are ruled by various gangs and crews. All bow before the Hexagon, however, which is the largest of the criminal organizations in the district and which houses itself in a massive skyscraper in the center of the area (see page 147). Certain routes have been completely blocked off with debris, or mined, to give the organization control over who or what moves in the district. Armed groups patrol the area to keep track of the figures moving in the organization's domains.

Attempts to restore the water level have been made but failed. It's as if the water has decided to bury what is buried, or the State has decided to drown the city by opening the locks.

Den of Sin

Those who make their way to the Fallen City from other parts of Sandukar head first and foremost to the district that goes by the name Den of Sin. Here pleasures and indulgence are offered. It is a lively place with a perverted market where drugs, flesh and lusts are offered up.

Den of Sin revolves around the massive Vaslav Square which at night is a marketplace with burning fires, trading stalls, makeshift dwellings in broken buses and cars, and a throng of people. In the middle of the square are the remains of a fountain, the statues are weathered and shattered and between their twisted bodies tents and tarps have been stretched up. In the sea of people are pickpockets, guides, merchants and fortune-seekers — if one is not careful, one may find oneself robbed, assaulted, kidnapped or enslaved.

Around the square stand a number of monumental buildings such as state institutions, railway stations and museums, which bear witness to a bygone era of greatness. Many of the buildings now house casinos, hotels and gambling halls of various kinds, with worn red carpets and fake gold decorations. Those who have plenty of money and power can get real luxury even if it is worn by the district's destructiveness. It is to this place that most from the Free City make their way and the owners of these establishments ensure that visitors are not disturbed.

The activities spread out in a web from Vaslav Square and among the residential buildings lie cellar pubs and beer cafés. A pleasant conversation can quickly degenerate into brawls if one doesn't play one's cards right. There are always those who wish to trick outsiders out of everything they own and have.

The Circus

At one end of Vaslav Square lies an old amusement park that long stood abandoned and boarded up until a circus company drove out the homeless from there and made it their dwelling. This is now a strange place that is open during the evenings and where for a cheap penny one gets a ticket to peculiar pleasures and long-forgotten forms of entertainment.

In the Ferris wheel with its colorful lamps one comes high up over the Fallen City, the funhouse offers moaning sounds from tinny speakers and erotic paintings, the mirror halls are long and winding and everywhere are

Doctor Grehorian smiled a stinking smile behind his drip-adorned mirrored sunglasses as he cranked down the side window. The waxed mustache was stained red, as was the light suit jacket. The rain pattered unrelenting against the roof.

He took out his fat wallet, pulled out a stack of unused bills and gave them together with the citizen's passport to the waiting constable Ivanov. "Here you go, one of the city's hardest working, see this as a bonus, and we'll forget tonight's incident, okay?" He raised his eyebrow suggestively, turned his head and glanced toward the alley, toward the beaten woman lying in the rain. She moaned weakly as the water carried her life down into the storm drain's black darkness.

Ivanov looked at the bills, at Grehorian, and gave them back with a throat-clearing. "Herr Doctor, this is an exceedingly vile assault and it will be reported, registered and archived, entirely according to protocol. You are under arrest."

it an aura of madness. From vendors one can buy col-ored cotton candy, record players perform music from bygone days, and older women claim to foretell the future.

The circus staff perform spectacular acts on the grand stage while the corpulent circus director Bruno in top hat, polished boots and blood-red coat proclaims what incredible danger the performers expose themselves to during tightrope walks without nets and juggling acts with sharp objects. Among other things, one can witness the tattooed woman, the sword-swallower from Sadovia, the world's strongest man—the giant Tamos who can tear apart chains and bend iron pipes, the mirror man, the knife throwers from Myta, the four snake women with their untamed lusts, the deformed wolf boy, the shadow dancer, the disfigured equestrian king from the Darost plains, the singer from Vadaja, the blood tamer and his ensemble of flagellants, the Siamese twins, the eye collector, and many more. Even though many of the performers' appearances and abilities are exaggerated with the help of makeup and Bruno's colorful descriptions, there are several among them who possess unique abilities and mystical powers.

Bruno takes care of his staff and pays tribute to the Hexagon for protection. People who still come to the circus to cause trouble are dealt with efficiently. The knife throwers have shown themselves skilled at hitting vital areas on several occasions, and the mighty Tamos can easily knock down a dozen grown men single-handedly. Violence is, however, bad for business and the circus folk try to resolve most things through conversation. They know, namely, that people need entertainment, they need to amuse themselves. At the circus one can laugh, cry, and marvel, and see mimes and cunning jesters mock the State and the bureaucrats. It is because of this that the circus stays afloat. People pay for happiness and for entertainment that is something other than mind-numbing, as long as such alternatives exist.

The Underground Market

Adjacent to the square one can find a building whose upper floors are burnt out. It previously housed a brewery and is still used to some extent as such by the Zhavrans, who have a large part of their liquor production and sales here. However, it is not this that makes the building so special but what lies beneath it. Under the vaults and the winding passages and storage halls, an underground market is held. Here the most bizarre and fantastic things are offered on filthy blankets by fawning vendors. The dim space is poorly illuminated by oil lanterns and bare light bulbs—sounds are distorted in the echoing passages and the air is usually filled with incense and mustiness.

Many who visit this market become obsessed with it and return time and again. There always seems to be new finds to acquire and things to trade in. Greed and desire never seem to end but drive people to inhuman acts or to the brink of ruin.

Doctor Kansal

The bodies of people who have been killed usually turn up sooner or later. Either the homeless drag their rat-eaten corpses up from the sewers in hope of reward, or the bloated bodies are fished up from the canal. If one wants a body to disappear and never be found again, it can be a good idea to visit Doctor Kansal, who operates in an old warehouse building in the Fallen City.

Kansal is a chemist and runs a small chemical factory with a dozen employees. However, he conducts a business on the side to earn some extra money. For 2,000 zovrins he takes care of unwanted bodies and lowers them, together with any belongings, into an acid bath where they dissolve over a few days into an unrecognizable sludge that is then emptied into the sewers along with the rest of the industrial waste. If one has many bodies, one can get a bulk discount, but if one wants to lower living people into the acid, Kansal usually doubles the prices.

The Bazaar

The Bazaar is the part of the Fallen City that can most be likened to a normally functioning district. In the south lies a power plant that supplies the district, and even neighboring districts, with electricity. Several factory areas are open and production of basic equipment continues around the clock. Some of the factories are run entirely by the workers who work there—something that is completely unknown in other parts of the city.

The inhabitants have formed robust and well-armed citizen guards who ensure that criminals and violent offenders are repelled—often in a very palpable way. Diplomatic contacts with the larger gangs exist, agreements that have been reached to satisfy both sides. The times gangsters have violated these agreements, blood has flowed, and so far the population of the Bazaar has not lost such a showdown.

The district's name comes from the large markets that are held every weekend at various locations in the area. Finds from the Ruins, crafts and tailoring, junk and trinkets are haggled between buyers and sellers. Old antique books, ornaments, and documents that survived the firestorms in the Ruins fetch high sums from wealthy outsiders.

The Sisterhood

A large group within the citizen guard in the Bazaar is the Sisterhood. The group is led by Jea Karev, a good rhetorician and charismatic leader who is always seen wearing a black veil over her face. The Sisterhood consists largely of female prostitutes. It was formed after a group of prostitutes had killed their pimps and

started their own business in Sin's Nest. Soon they gained more and more women on their side, but as the business grew, the more attention it attracted. The women were forced eastward, into the Bazaar, and were eventually forced to defend themselves with violence.

Despite lesser firepower, the Sisterhood had other advantages, including means of extortion, skilled assassins, and seductive talents. The Hexagon, which was the greatest opponent, finally gave them the Bazaar to conduct their business in, for a smaller share in their earnings.

Recently, several conflicts have arisen within the Sisterhood as many in the organization compete for power. The company Lustskymning has also begun to challenge the Sisterhood's power and tries to take control over members within the organization, something that has caused Karev to begin motivating members to strike back.

The Ruins

In a several-square-kilometer area in the Fallen City, there is nothing but ruins. Crumbling and burnt-out buildings line desolate avenues, and the urban landscape is covered with debris, fallen mortar, and twisted metal parts. The walls are covered with bullet holes, and in poorly covered mass graves rest the bone remains of thousands of people who died from gas attacks and fragmentation bombs.

The district is almost always covered by an eerie fog, and rumors from treasure hunters say that at night one sees strange creatures rummaging through the ruins, and moans and cries of anguish are heard distantly wherever one turns. Some even claim to have seen fragments of their own inner struggles.

In the middle of the ruins lies the remainder of the tower that once stretched up toward the firmament and obscured the district with its ominous shadow. It is also said to be this place that caused the district's violent fall. It was here the fiercest battles took place. In places, the ruins are nothing but impassable wasteland with fallen brick, granite blocks, and twisted metal frames—but in many places the burnt-out buildings have been restored and house life again.

The people who live here have a very harsh existence but live in relative freedom. Likewise, one can still make valuable finds in the ruins as the area was once very wealthy. Searching for treasure is lucrative, and if one manages to find a great discovery, one can move away from this forgotten place.

A destructive and dark disease haunts the area. Madness, nightmares, and violent outbursts strike the inhabitants of the ruins—but at the same time there is a dark allure, and people with black souls seek the secrets that are embedded in the ground and in the buildings' foundations.

The Varlekus family (see page 149) and its servants are the ruling power in the ruined city, but there are plenty of odd religious sects, gangs, and leaders with visions and prophecies.

The Fallen Tower

The fallen tower's base still rises toward the sky, but the tower is broken and its shadow no longer haunts the surrounding district. The black basalt facade has cracked and the shards are scattered across the area. Blocks were crushed when the tower broke off and fell with a roar that was heard far beyond Sandukar's walls. Many strange things have happened in the tower's vicinity, and it is still avoided as those who seek it out seldom return with their sanity intact—if they return at all.

At night the tower is surrounded by a freezing, pale gray fog, and sometimes one can hear echoes, screams, and machine sounds from within it. It is said that the tower's master still rests in the ruins, and many myths circulate about what has happened to people who have sought the tower's innermost reaches and been slain by its master. What the truth about the tower is, no one knows, but most keep a safe distance despite the riches and artifacts one might find in its interior.

Tavol

Sandukar has a maze of tunnels, culverts, and passages that wind down into the depths. In the Fallen City, many of them are flooded and collapsed and are said to be home to horrible things.

If one can navigate through the tunnels, one has the advantage of being able to bypass walls, guards, and districts and enter otherwise well-guarded areas. Few know of this tunnel network, but one of those who has mapped it is Tavol, a middle-aged man who lives underground and only ventures up to the surface to conduct barter trade with the finds he has collected.

Tavol has long, stringy, gray hair and a weathered, wrinkled face. He usually goes dressed in a worn, dark green suit, raincoat, rubber boots, and headlamp. For defense he has a sawed-off shotgun, and for company he has a large bloodhound. Usually he travels in the water-filled tunnels in a small boat with a brightly glowing lantern at the bow. Tavol has been to most places under the Fallen City; the only place he avoids is the area near the fallen tower where the water is black as tar and moves pulsating to the echo of dull heartbeats. Here he has seen horrors that have scared him senseless, and no matter how much money he is offered, he will not go there again. Otherwise, Tavol offers his services for the right amount of money and can lead people through the old sewer passages to the places they desire.

Malgrav

At the foot of Kostor Bridge it is close to a square that is enclosed between massive buildings, which means it always lies in shadow. The square is called Malgrav Square and has come to be a hub for the entire area called Malgrav in common parlance. During the days there is a large marketplace here where one can find everything from fruit and old books to smuggled firearms and guides to the city's lower parts.

At night, entertainers, artists, and performers gather here who try to become known or earn money from their works— everything from portrait painting to bizarre variety shows occurs. Deformed, monstrosities, and disturbed people see their chance in this jumble of impressions. This is also the hragers' strongest area, and they have their own enclave here.

The Hraghic Enclave

What was previously a walled hraghic ghetto has now become a fortress for the hraghic people in the Fallen City. The people have united and shown great cooperation in the work of restoring the dilapidated houses and fortifying the walls. One is only admitted inside the walls if one belongs to the hraghic people or if one is invited.

The Bathhouse Santor

By the canal lies a large bathhouse with Gothic architecture and separate sections for men and women. Here one is washed and massaged for a small sum of zovrins and can also request private bathing facilities. There

are plenty of different pools, everything from cold baths to steaming hot water with exotic herbs. The bathhouse is seen as something of a spa for those with joint pain of various kinds.

The bathhouse has, however, a darker side. Madam Santor, who runs the bathhouse, conducts slave trade with kidnapped people who are caught when they arrive confused at Sandukar by train. Gullible people fall into the hands of Madam Santor's emissary deceivers, who drug them and

for them to the bathhouse. Once a month, auctions are held where the slaves are herded down into the drained pools and masked bidders haggle over them.

Beneath the bathhouse, a network of tunnels leads to the abandoned and half-flooded subway, and it is through these tunnels the slaves are transported. Here there are also underground dungeons where the slaves are kept imprisoned while awaiting sale. People from the organization Lustskymning often make purchases at Madam Santor's bathhouse and always attend the auctions.

The Destroyers

A group known as the Destroyers has its base in an abandoned hotel in the southern part of Malgrav. The group consists of a number of the enlightened whose sole purpose is to fight the shadows. No real clarity on what this entails has emerged, but the confirmed members who have been encountered all seem coldly focused and carry long, ornate swords beneath their coats.

Seburah's Cinema

On a back alley near Malgrav Square lies the notorious cinema owned by Seburah, a member of the organization Lustskymning. According to the yellowed posters, the cinema is showing The Battle at the Front, but it's entirely different films that are on its repertoire. Here come those with odd pleasures, those who revel in the violent and bizarre, once a month and pay 400 zovriner to take a seat in the decrepit salon. Here they get to see shaky silent films where people are stalked and kidnapped. When the film ends, the kidnapped person is brought onto the stage and subjected there to cruel acts by a duo dressed in black and white respectively. These two gentlemen are called Mr. Black and Mr. White and wear theater masks over their faces —it is also they who film and kidnap the victims.

The deeds committed vary from month to month, and so do the victims. It can range from torture, rape and humiliation to outright execution. Sometimes the audience is invited to participate in various ways. All victims are killed at the end of the performance, usually to the sparse audience's cheers.

Those who witness the deeds often become spellbound and addicted to the performances and seek them out time and again. They are often disgusted, certainly, but cannot resist the perversions that unfold.

The Free Haven

A large area in the northeastern quadrant of the Fallen City is simply called the Free Haven. When the tower in the ruined city collapsed, a firestorm swept across the sky, over what is now the Free Haven where most houses and buildings were constructed of wood. A persistent rain extinguished the flames after a few days, but afterward only the burned skeletons of the houses remained. Nowadays it is mostly the poor, the sick, the mentally disturbed, refugees, escapees and addicts who roam among the ramshackle huts, shelters and dilapidated buildings. Electricity, water and food are scarce commodities.

Rumors of cannibalism occur and bodies tend to disappear only to later be found with considerably less meat on their bones.

A unifying force in the area is the church, which has several well-attended premises. Whether it's the message being preached, the roof over their heads or the warm soup from the soup kitchen that attracts makes no difference—there are few other churches in Sandukar that have so many visitors at sermon and evening prayer.

The Zoo

Adjacent to the Ruins lies Hauer's Zoological Park, a long-overgrown zoo and home to various mad animals. The zoo was damaged by the firestorms and in an attempt to save the animals, they were set free. Many were confused by the fires and fled deeper into the devastated city. The stronger ate the weaker, the zoo was abandoned and the wild animals fed on the burned corpses they came across.

The Black Park

The Black Park is a desolate forest area that spreads out in the borderland toward the Ruins. The trees are all damaged by the fire from the firestorms, and shake their naked branches toward the sky. The ground is black and there are plenty of oily puddles and sunken vehicles. A makeshift dump for bulky waste exists in the center of Black Park. Here garbage is dumped from zeppelins that travel over the area. Desperate scavengers rummage around in the area searching for finds and underground caches.

The Plague Yard

The Plague Yard is one of the few areas where the State has influence within the Fallen City. It is a smaller district, surrounded by high walls with barbed wire at the top. Guards in fortified towers with searchlights ensure that no one enters or leaves.

Something happened in the district that required this intervention. Those who lived there were struck by an insidious, contagious disease that drove them mad, and one can still hear inhuman screams from the center of the district. The State has long waited out those imprisoned in the hope that the entire district will die off on its own—but it doesn't seem to be happening. Moreover, reports come that unmarked trucks arrive now and then and that desperate people are forced into the area by gas-masked soldiers.

At one of the "Gates of Power," as the three passages in and out are called, lies an enormous facility with an associated crematorium. State patrols in protective suits are said to occasionally reconnoiter inside the Plague Yard and bring bodies out for sampling. The bodies are then burned along with the equipment brought in.

The Mauser Fields

An interesting area deep within the district is the Mauser Fields, a magnificent and now nearly overgrown burial ground with tens of thousands of graves, crypts, statues, parks and memorial groves—all in deplorable condition. Apparently the burial ground is several hundred years old, or even older, and dates from the time when Sandukar was built. Beneath the area, ancient catacombs miles long are said to stretch, filled with legendary personalities, hidden writings and ancient artifacts.

Groups in the Fallen City

The Fallen City is ruled by criminal gangs that fight for power. There are constant conflicts between them and people who live in the district are more often than not connected to, or under the "protection" of, at least one of them. These organizations not infrequently have branches extending to the rest of Sandukar.

The Hexagon

The Engineer looked out through the tall windows from his chamber at the top of the Hexagon's skyscraper. The buildings below him were mere dark shadows in the white fog and here and there he could see the light from the boats' lanterns as they made their way through the place that had once had streets and stately monuments. Everything was now submerged. He raised his own hand and looked at it. Rotten, decayed, putrid—far too similar to the building he now resided in. It seemed as if they were bound to each other, he and the building, and shared each other's decay. He turned around and stared at the blackened Hexagon inlaid in the study's marble floor and wondered if he would ever get an answer to the six-pointed star's riddle.

In the center of the Water Moat rises a skyscraper with a worn and algae-covered stone facade. Behind the cracked windows one can see the flickering light of lanterns and figures moving around them like shadows. The building lacks electricity and its lower parts lie completely underwater. The interior is old, worn and moldy with threadbare carpets, moth-eaten drapes and peeling paint. Through the corridors draft cold winds and everything is damp. At the same time, the building is magnificent with its hexagonal facade, the tall leaded windows, the Gothic vaulted arches and the massive halls that bear witness to former wealth and splendor. This is the Hexagon's seat—a feared organization that controls the majority of criminal activity in the district and its surroundings, and which receives large sums of money through the so-called tax it extracts from the people in its territory.

The Hexagon was originally an industrial company and its symbol, a six-pointed star, can be found on stained brass plaques at several factories and buildings in the district. Whether the criminal organization has any connection whatsoever to the former industrial company is unknown, but the members claim the right to control all of the Hexagon's former premises and occupy its seat.

Members of the organization have a six-pointed star tattooed in each palm, which they conceal with gloves when they want to move anonymously. For living in the Fallen City, the members are well-dressed in proper suits and dresses of older cut. Likewise, they usually have an aristocratic and noble manner on the surface, they generally socialize only with each other and avoid the places where "lower standing" individuals frequent.

The organization has thousands of members and branches everywhere in Sandukar. Their influence is deliberately low in the Inner City, as it would otherwise attract bad attention from the truly powerful.

The Hexagon has acquired something of a state-like apparatus in the Fallen City and this is where people come to ask for help, buy information or swear their allegiance. At

"Can you give me another drink? So, you want to know about her? She's at the Fallen City, keeping an eye on the riffraff from the shadows. You'll never see her before she knows who you are, what you're doing there and where you live. Well, her face is badly burned, as if by acid or fire or chemicals. Without the damage, the Sorrowful One would be Sandukar's most beautiful creature."

this damned place, the people see the Hexagon as the only sign of order, albeit a draconian one, and many therefore support the organization's control. It's no secret either that the Hexagon has contacts with the police force in the Free City and that it greases several high-ranking officials to be left alone.

In its immediate area, however, the organization doesn't hesitate to display its power in the most brutal ways—usually by slitting troublemakers open from crotch to throat and leaving them to die in their own blood. Right now this is happening primarily to people believed to have dealings with the new organization the Apostles of Annihilation, which has begun to challenge the Hexagon's power.

The Hexagon is ruled by the patriarch Hugo Gavilan, though few know his name. He is better known as the Engineer and is a mythical figure whom few have met. According to rumor, he never ventures out into the city but resides high up in the Hexagon building. His right hand Raclia, also known as the Sorrowful One, is the one who relays his orders. This woman would have been beautiful if not for half her face being burned away.

Stradh and Ilsa

When the Hexagon needs to have some dirty or dangerous job carried out, they usually send out Stradh and Ilsa—a deadly pair. Ilsa uses charm, cold-bloodedness and manipulation to get where she wants and extract information while Stradh uses violence, torture and threats. Together they perform cruel deeds for the Hexagon's master.

Stradh dresses entirely in white and is a tall man with fine features, his hair is slicked back and he has two automatic pistols under his jacket. His hands are usually covered by leather gloves and outdoors he wears a coat under which he can have several concealed weapons. His indifferent, light gray eyes are widely known in the underworld.

Ilsa is a very beautiful, dark red-haired woman with black clothing, usually corsets and elegant dresses. Around her neck she always has a choker. She wears tall, black velvet gloves and carries in her handbag an automatic pistol as well as several poisons and drugs hidden in perfume bottles and powder compacts. In her hair there are always several hairpins which she skillfully uses as weapons in close combat when needed.

Both have black, six-pointed stars tattooed in their palms as a sign of their loyalty to the Hexagon. Their signature is a playing card whose symbol is a six-pointed star and they leave such cards as threats or warnings for what can happen if one defies the Hexagon.

The Apostles of Annihilation

When rumors began spreading on the streets about a new organization in the Fallen City, not many eyebrows were raised. Various criminal associations come and go, only a few manage to hold together for any length of time. But the Apostles of Annihilation persisted, and even though the organization at first didn't make much fuss, it gathered more and more members. The followers were drawn from the poor and outcast, those who had neither power nor hope, people no one cared about. The members' fanaticism, their ability to hold the group together and organize themselves quickly made the organization a power to be reckoned with.

The organization's leader, the Supplicant, is a mythical figure who together with his most faithful companions wanders through the Fallen City and binds more people to his flock. It's said that the Supplicant was once a priest, it's also said that he fought in the army against the enemy in the north and that in this bloody chaos he came to an insight. He received a vision of purgatory, the abomination and eternal torment and it is from this that the Supplicant has promised to free his followers. How much truth lies in these tales cannot be known, myths about the Supplicant spread through hundreds of mouths and are distorted before they reach the listeners' ears.

Many of the organization's followers are of the Hraghic people and they have found new hope in their master's words. The followers, who openly show themselves to belong to the Apostles of Annihilation, wear long, black, priest-like robes. They are long-haired and the men usually have beards according to Hraghic tradition. If you enter the apostles' territory you will encounter their guards. You can also expect a visit from them if you cross the apostles in any way.

Nowadays the apostles control a considerable part of the Fallen City and many smaller gangs obey them out of fear. Those who don't follow them are seen as enemies and the apostles have quickly gained a reputation as merciless murderers who perform human sacrifices to their master. Their deeds are unusually brutal and they find great honor in killing their opponents in close combat. Thus they are often armed with heavy, curved knives, axes and garrotes. Their access to weapons is for unknown reasons very good, particularly access to military materiel.

The apostles' agenda often seems confused and random as they make attacks and commit acts against seemingly random people and organizations. The Supplicant proclaims a blasphemous darkness that exists in certain individuals—a darkness that must be eradicated. Weapons and resources are gathered and through sermons and cruel deeds the apostles try to open people's eyes to the Supplicant's power. Recently the apostles have defied the agreement with the police force and made raids into the Free City. Their deeds have many times been completely open and they have left masses of corpses in their wake.

On the home front, a war is about to erupt between the Hexagon and the apostles, a war that will claim victims in droves on both sides—and innocents will likely suffer as well.

The Supplicant

Despite the countless stories that exist about the Supplicant, his life history is known only to a few. He is of the Hraghic people but grew up in Sandukar and spent his childhood on the streets under miserable conditions. With forged papers he managed to get permission to join the army at a young age and served there for several years in the northern trenches. His tactical mind and manipulative ability made him an advisor to one of the officers and he learned most things about tactics and strategy. During an unusually bloody offensive where his comrades were killed he received a vision of the world's darkness and of the cruelty that rests in the swirling and destructive abyss.

The Supplicant realized the truth about the enemy in the north and escaped from the war zone to an abandoned monastery up in the mountains. There he spent several years living off nature while writing his own bible based on his dreams and visions. After that he returned to Sandukar. When he left the city he was just a child, when he returned he was an aged man. The city was the same though and he sought out his old quarters where the Hraghic people now lived under oppression. There he began to proclaim his commandments. He wants to awaken people's minds by claiming that the world has been cast into hell and that the life they live is part of purgatory.

To remedy the situation he claims that one must find the people who have darkness in their hearts and kill them. His bible has now begun to be printed and is spreading in secret—in it are said to be answers to who is tainted by the darkness and how they shall be killed. The Supplicant takes no heed of innocents who fall victim to his following. His struggle is for mankind and without him he considers it doomed.

The Supplicant often wanders disguised in the alleys of the Fallen City but when he shows himself to his followers he does so clad in a dark red priest's robe and with his long, steel gray hair loose. He always has

several weapons on him even though his gaze can be just as imposing and threatening. It's rumored that he has several doppelgangers as his life is constantly in danger.

The Varlekus Family

Among the ruins, in the fallen tower's shadow, the Varlekus family has its lair. Behind high walls the family has established its seat in what was once a botanical garden and a museum. The buildings have been restored and from the massive greenhouses the artificial light once again illuminates the night. Over the parapet rise slender chimneys and a stench of chemicals and rotted meat hangs over the area. Exactly what goes on in the former halls and under the charred trees no one knows but from here come many of the drugs that spread through the city. The walls are constantly guarded by men with automatic weapons and flamethrowers and the surroundings are patrolled by dogs.

The ruined buildings that lie around the Varlekus seat are all condemned and only one passable road leads up to the wall's massive steel gate. Every week trucks arrive with deliveries and every week precious cargo departs. Who rules the Varlekus family no one knows but it's said to be someone subordinate to the Mengal lineage—perhaps even a family member themselves. That would explain Varlekus's vast resources and the fact that the authorities do nothing about the family's operations.

Servants of the family can be found throughout the Fallen City, they often function as drug dealers, slave traders and doctors. The doctors in particular are often respected as they know what they're doing and are known for not asking any questions but charging handsomely in zovrins or favors. Among other things they can perform abortions, plastic surgery and lobotomies. Varlekus doctors often pay a sum of money to anyone who comes with fresh organs to them—exactly how the organs came into the person's possession they never ask. This has led to bodies in the Fallen City often being primitively butchered by desperate individuals to produce a few zovrins for drugs. There are even those who donate parts of themselves, such as eyes, arms or legs, to satisfy their addiction.

Besides drug and organ trafficking, the Varlekus family engages in human trafficking. Young, healthy individuals are bought and taken to the family's seat to never be seen again.

The members of the Varlekus family have managed to stay out of most conflicts as their power is such that one doesn't want to cross them, while they seem content with the power they already have.

The Zhavrans

The Zhavrans are a collection of Celenkae who keep to and around the Nest of Sin. They have their own business in liquor and drug trafficking. The liquor they usually brew themselves in legal and well-guarded breweries in the area—the drugs are either imported from outside or bought from the Varlekus family.

The Zhavrans have business in the Free City as well but keep to the Celenk quarters as the Hexagon handles smuggling to the rest of the Free City. They have plenty of contacts in both districts and if you need a guide or to arrange something, it's to the Zhavrans you should go. Most members are Celenkae but still blend well into the environment they move in and one can rarely tell if a typical Celenk belongs to the Zhavrans or not.

Lustshadow

If you're looking for forbidden pleasures, macabre pornography or unusual games to satisfy your lusts, then it's to Lustshadow you should go. The company owns several brothels and porn theaters in the district and also has secret meeting places where customers can have all their wishes fulfilled.

Even among the higher social classes, Lustshadow is popular. Many decadent lineage members order self-produced films or prostitutes who participate in the most bizarre acts. It's even said that members of the Guiskard lineage have connections to the company.

Lustshadow's employees are always well-dressed and skilled at moving socially and understanding their customers' desires. The company's business card is in black and silver and is handed out to the rich and important... and to those with special needs.

The Couriers

The Couriers are a loose association of pure muscle— most members are former military or prisoners led by a man simply called the Captain. The Couriers are large-built and don't back down from a fight. The Hexagon often uses the gang as a strike force and it also handles the organization's business in the Free City.

Recently the Couriers have begun to grab a larger share of the business for themselves in hope that the Hexagon will be too focused on the Apostles of Annihilation to dare risk yet another conflict.

"In a nightmare, every decision you make is wrong." —Jessca Navarre

The Empire is everything—the State, the provinces, the peoples, the lineages, war, peace, countryside and cities, the great and the small, in a blessed mixture. Few know anything other than what the Empire boasts of, what the Empire protects and what the Empire stands for.

Society

Look at the artists on the silver screen, at the magnates who build companies and at those who make careers within the bureaucracy. It's written about them every day in the newspaper. They get a better and easier life. If they can, so can I, if I just fight a little harder and strain myself a little more, there's always time to rest later. —Jako Kovalch, foreman, Krauss Mechanical

Much in the world of Noir is described in grim terms, with words like isolation, desperation, frustration and hopelessness. One might ask how anyone has the energy to do anything at all in the Empire if everything is so thoroughly rotten and damnable?

The thing is that most people don't experience their situation as particularly miserable, as they don't have much to compare with. Sure it's heavy and wearing but one lives and doesn't have to be afraid as the State provides for one's needs and protects one from the enemy.

The vast majority who come to the cities in general or Sandukar in particular from a life in the countryside get things better. The land rains away in acid rain and nature bows under industrialization's yoke. Crops rot and livestock sicken. Untouched nature is rare, other than in inaccessible areas.

In the cities there is security, you're not alone, there is a governing order that protects you from the enemy, from anarchy. You can get a job, a home, a family if you fight. The opportunity to perform great deeds and fulfill your goals exists there, even if you don't get it tomorrow, or in a month, or even in a year.

Fear of the enemy, of seeing the system waver, of chaos, makes citizens remain passive and accept, albeit reluctantly in some cases, the current situation as the best possible.

The State may be cumbersome and impersonal but the police, Stapo and the realm's soldiers protect the individual from crime, collapse and doom. Citizens need the State as a counterforce to the enemy and its

sadistic rule in the north and east, which is just waiting to destroy and enslave everyone. All this is fact that the Ministry of Truth gladly enlightens downcast or doubting citizens about.

The State & the Empire

Should life become too heavy, there is always the church to comfort and warm. Even though the church is said to be poison for the soul, there is someone there who listens and understands. Others seek comfort in humanity. They search hope-fully to find the warmth that comes from love, the security that comes from a warm embrace under the covers while rain hammers against the windows. To find someone to confide in, to share one's innermost thoughts, feelings and fears with, is a powerful force that drives many people in an otherwise cold and frightening world. Love can become the light. Even when the world outside seems large and impersonal, it is there, and through it one can start a family. In love, one's own life becomes valuable and the family, with spouse and perhaps children, is a man-ageable and comprehensible concept for most, something to cherish and protect. Even here the Ministry of Truth can help— with information brochures about family planning. **The State** The slumbering beast that through ordinances, laws, reg-ulations and registrations rules over the citizens of the Empire is best known as the State in common parlance. The State is like its own entity, difficult to meet, harder to understand and hardest to satisfy. Many citizens are reluctant to have any-thing at all to do with the beast, as its attention falls upon the individual if provoked—and no one wants obli-gatory meetings with tax inspectors, visits from truth controllers or visits to Stapo's local office for talks. If one stays out of sight, one avoids having the light on oneself and can operate in relative safety under one's own control. **State Control** The State operates through different channels, from paragraph-riding bureaucrats to surly police officers, via local offices, depart-ments, departments, directorates, ministries and further into a very tangled jungle of connections, links and areas of responsibility. Everything done in the Empire in general and in the capital Sandukar in particular, is noted, registered and archived for future needs. In large office environments sit thousands of people occu-pied with rattling down reports on their heavy type-writers and between the offices documents are distributed via pneumatic tubes or internal couriers on scooters. All decrees must be conveyed out to every local office, both in the city and to the provinces. The Post Ministry and the telegraphs work hard to convey the authority's will to the chosen champions in the State's forces. Through the Ministry of Truth's auspices, messages are conveyed to citi-zens via loudspeaker cars, public notices, distributed leaflets, via radio and in newspapers. In Sandukar there are fixed loudspeakers positioned at important gathering points such as certain squares, public transport hubs and main streets, from which quick announcements can be conveyed when needed. **The Informers** Within all parts of the State there are informers and spies for the same. No one knows if "the new person in the department" is placed as an intelligence agent or snitch for one's own administration, for Stapo, or even worse, for the Ministry of Truth. At factories and larger private workplaces there are watch-ers and reporters planted to ensure that messages and rules are followed, both by employees and those responsible. Should subversive activities or treasonous thoughts and utter-ances be found, the guilty party quickly receives a visit from Stapo for collection and talks. Sometimes entire families or all staff at a company can be collected during nocturnal raids when a dozen or more dark Stapo vehicles stand ready for transport to bare cells and desolate interrogation rooms. **The State's Ministries** The State governs through ministries which have the task of running the Empire. These institutions are from the outside incom-prehensible with their labyrinthine bureaucracy and their tens of thousands of employees. Here follows a selection. **Ministry of Archives** One of the seven primary ministries. The guarantor that all documents, permits, deeds, receipts, contracts, pass-ports, citizen passes, agreements and licenses are produced, regis-tered, saved, copied and stored in a safe and permanent way. **Ministry of Administration** Responsible for the State's properties, real estate and resour-ces being managed in the best way and also handles other admin-istrative matters. Manages the maintenance of drinking water supply and sewage systems. **Ministry of Health** Provides free public healthcare and access to medicines, and ensures that

hospitals and clinics function as they should. **Ministry of Industry** Responsible for simplifying enterprise and ensuring the labor market functions. Registers all production in the Empire so that there is current information should it become relevant with forced recruitment or rationing.

Ministry of Justice

One of the seven primary ministries. Manages the courts at all levels and appoints suitable persons as judges. Oversees prosecutors and defense attorneys so they do not abuse the power and responsibility given them by the State. Enacts new laws and ordinances. **Ministry of War** One of the seven primary ministries. Ensures through strategies and resource allocation that the war against the enemy functions as efficiently as possible and ensures that the wars are fought in accordance with the State's set goals. Secures Sandukar's military defense and is responsible for military research and development. **Ministry of Culture** Ensures that citizens' spiritual lives are stimulated in a good way in accordance with the State's recommendations. Responsible for theaters, operas and the like, as well as for paintings, musi-cal compositions and books. The film medium, however, lies under the Ministry of Truth's domain. **Ministry of Logistics** One of the seven primary ministries. Responsible for road networks, airports, railways and boat traffic functioning satisfac-torily and for transports occurring as efficiently as possible. Also telegraph and telephone networks are their responsibility. **Ministry of Order** One of the seven primary ministries. Responsible through the order police, criminal police and tactical police for order being maintained in Sandukar and the Empire in general and for crimes being combated, investigated and solved. **Ministry of Post** Responsible for letters and packages reaching the right destination, and for maintenance of mailboxes and post offices throughout the Empire. **Ministry of Resources** Guarantees that the right goods are moved to the right places in the Empire so that resources for industry reach the factories and food for citizens reaches the markets. Responsible for the State's mines, agriculture, livestock management, forests and land. **Ministry of Coordination** The organ for coordination and coordination between the minis-tries and/or the Empire's provinces. Ensures that informa-tion is channeled correctly and reaches the right instance or person. Produces standards and templates to simplify work and admin-istration. **Ministry of Truth** One of the seven primary ministries. Keeps track of all of the Empire's citizens and ensures they are upda-ted with current ordinances and facts regarding the Empire's current situation. Provides citizens with information and announcements and ensures that printed media, radio and film contain correct information. Handles talks with citi-zens who are lost regarding their place in society and their atti-tude toward the State. Is also home to the Commissariat. **Ministry of Tax** Manages the State's finances and oversees tax payments from citizens and businesspeople. Controls the financial world, stock exchanges and banking system so that nothing is done that can harm the State in any way. **Ministry of Security** One of the seven primary ministries. Responsible for the state po-lice Stapo, the protection of important persons in society and surveillance of state buildings and institutions. Also responsible for telephone and telegraph interception and for sus-pected subversive letters that must be checked. Also has responsibility for prisoners, prisons, labor camps and such admin-istration. **Ministry of Education** Responsible for the five-year elementary school, preparatory education and higher education. Guarantees that the teaching is performed in a suitable and competent way, so that citizens learn the right things and have access to app-roved textbooks. **Ministry of Science** Responsible for cataloging research and new inventions being performed and used in accordance with the State's set goals and rules. **Ministry of the Archive** Responsible for all other ministries continuously rep-orting what is ongoing and functioning without interruption. These reports are later channeled further up in the State's upper layers. The Ministry of the Archive stands just below the cabinet, constantly ready to convey information and directives upward and downward in the hierarchy. Their Ari, or "Department for revision and internal investigations" is rightly feared as it through different methods ensures that efficiency in the State's various organs is maintained and that troublesome elements are eliminated. **The Empire** The Empire stretches over a thousand miles from east to west. Untamed and barren wilderness is here

and there broken up by mas-sive industrial cities that day and night spread their ash across the firmament. The cities are connected by a modern and constantly expanding railway network and poorly main-tained roads. Many of the transports otherwise occur via the Copper River which like a life-giving artery runs through the realm. The river is in some places so wide that one can only with binoculars spot the opposite side, and the water which in the east is drinkable and crystal clear has blackened, foul-smelling and disease-causing when it runs past Sandukar to poison the Oil Sea. Outside the modern indust-rial cities by the river there are smaller communities and traces of another era before cogwheels and state control dominated. On this vast expanse there once existed seven great kingdoms but now they are united into one mighty state where dissent is not tolerated. From the capital Sandu-kar the entire vast realm is controlled through complicated ordinances, strict laws and a labyrinthine bureaucracy. The cities located along the Copper River are in the State's firm

grip but the farther out from the flood zone one goes, the weaker the State's control becomes. To maintain order in the outer regions, the clans and their servants are granted authority to administer the areas and the people who live there. Here rule influential industrial magnates, decadent clan families and religious leaders. It is another world, consid-erably more antiquated and primi-tive, where humanity's struggle against nature is a harsh reality. Here mysticism, superstition and belief in the supernatural still hold sway. If the people are the machinery that drives the State forward, the vast natural resources are what feeds it — and the resources are devoured greedily without any thought what-soever. The brutal exploitation strikes back, however, as the waste from industrialization contaminates nature, makes the water in water-ways undrinkable and causes acid rain to devastate entire regions. Rural folk find it hard to survive in the wake of crop failures and seek the safety of the cities where they hope for a new and better life. Instead they become trapped in the state system where they must sub-mit to state decrees and partake in the intense enlightenment that the Ministry of Truth engages in. **The War** No one remembers what it was like before the State took power. Accord-ing to the State's official historio-graphy, which can be found in the vaults of the Ministry of Archives, centuries upon centuries of brutal-ity and conflict between the seven kingdoms followed, and the State was the instrument needed to bring peace, order and an opportunity for the kingdoms to stand united against the terrible enemy in the north. The enemy in the north swept in like a storm over the lands and brought destruction and death. Their armored cruisers bombarded the coastal cities and the soldiers raped, plundered and killed wherever they advanced. Times were dark for the kingdoms before seven powerful clans, one from each kingdom, united and together fought the threat. Finally they managed to drive away the enemy and established the city of Sandukar at the mouth of the Copper River. The enemy threatened reinforcements beyond the Arkady Mountains, but the State's forces made their way through the mountain passes and attacked the enemy on its own ground while defending their own borders. The war has been ongoing north of the mountains for centuries, and there are gigantic forts, minefields and trench complexes which today constitute the Empire's northernmost and most important defensive line. Certain outspoken researchers have questioned the state historiography, but it is known that the State has banned all other types of historiography and that sources found out in the provinces have been rewritten or banned by state bureaucrats. This is to make the peoples and lands more uniform and preserve peace by consigning old conflicts to oblivion. **Tensions The state purge and** rewriting has not been able to completely change the kingdoms' culture and history, which means they differ from each other in many ways. One thing that is the same for all provinces, how-ever, is the rural population's mis-trust of big cities in general and of Sandukar in particular. Narrow-mindedness and prejudice dominate and outsiders and foreign-ers are regarded with great suspi-cion. This underlying fear of the unknown remains when rural folk move to the cities, as they prefer to build enclaves and quarters around their own people rather than mix with others. National pride applies to the homeland rather than the Empire as an entity. This poorly concealed racism cre-ates breeding ground for frustration and conflict, with arguments like "the others" are stealing "our" jobs, "our" women, etcetera. Riots and fights based on culture,

race and origin are unfortunately not uncom-mon, and little is done by the State to curb it. The prejudices also take hold among employers, who prefer to hire someone "from their own country", and among the police, who on more than one occasion have looked away from crimes com-mitted by countrymen. **The Peoples of the Empire** There are plenty of ethnic groups and minorities in the Empire. Some live relatively isolated in desolate rural areas with their own cultures and skepticism toward the outside world. The majority of the population, however, is assimilated by the State to fit into the society the State provides. There is a Stradh checked his pistols, felt the reassurance of their weight and closed his eyes for a few seconds. The footsteps of two, maybe three, intruders echoed in the damp cellar corridor. He could smell the scent of cheap aftershave, liquor and cigarettes. There were defi-nitely three, one had wheezing breath-ing, the other two were more controlled. Typical cops, he thought, always med-dling when they should stay away — this time they had to disappear. He quietly put his hand into his coat pocket, fumbled around among the con-tents, felt the cool lighter, some pieces of paper, a condom, and there... a coin. He flipped the coin away so that it hit the cement wall a few meters to the left of his position, an old trick, but one that almost always worked. The reactions were not long in coming, a beam of light turned on, directed at the wall, and weapons were unsecured. A wheezing voice ordered him to come forward and Stradh smiled to himself. He couldn't deny that he liked what was about to come, the bangs that would echo in the confined space, the smell of gun-smoke and the quiet clanking of empty shells hitting the cement floor. He was an artist in death and now he would get to create one of his works. In one motion he threw himself up and fired the first shot in a symphony that would last around three seconds — after this brief time all listeners would lie dead.

widespread racism toward certain ethnic groups and prejudice is common. Especially against those who hold on to their cul-tures and don't blend in the way that is desired. In Sandukar one can find representatives from all pos-sible peoples. They may be refugees from war-torn areas, desperate rural folk in search of work, fortune seekers hunt-ing for wealth or individuals keeping away from justice among the anonymous masses. The eternal city has room for them all in its embrace. Often they seek out people of the same kind and certain ethnic groups have taken over entire quarters or districts. **Vagyar** Vagyar are not really counted as an ethnic group since they are the peo-ple who dominate the Empire by number and are considered to be "the original people" or "the main people". Vagyar is also not a term that is used except by academics; instead vagyar are called "the peo-ple". **The Vagyar ethnic group** origi-nates from the former kingdoms in the Empire but has over the cen-turies been brought together eth-nically and socially and united under the propaganda. The part of the people who originate from the northern Arkady Mountains tend to have light hair and blue, gray or green eyes. The majority, those who originate from the vast plains and forests, are somewhat darker in complexion and usually have black or dark brown hair and dark eyes. Centuries of kinship and marriage have meant that the features of the two ethnic groups are now mixed — but blond and red hair are seen as unusual and exotic. Unless other-wise stated, all main characters are assumed to belong to this ethnic group. As a vagyar one easily blends into society and into the rest of the population. **Celenk** The Celenk ethnic group is the rem-nants of an ancient horse people from the western wilderness. The Celenk still retain their ancestors' nomadic spirit and a large part of those who live in the countryside usually use horse and wagon as means of transport and travel between villages and towns to con-duct trade and take temporary employment. The Celenk who have permanently migrated to the cities usually make their living in the lower strata of society with various odd jobs and sometimes even criminal activity. Celenk often stick together even in the cities and survive by help-ing each other with loans, services and favors. The Celenk people have olive-colored skin and often jet-black, curly hair. Their slightly almond-shaped eyes are often dark but some-times people are born with green or blue eyes. Celenk are somewhat shorter, and often stronger, than the average vagyar. **Hragher** The Hragher are an oppressed people who live under great suspicion from the State since the province in the east, the Hragher's homeland, turned against the State and the Empire. A bloody war now rages on their land and the Hragher who live in other places in the Empire find themselves persecuted by both state and citizens.

Many crimes and accidents are blamed on them and the law does not do much to follow up on harassment, assaults and murders of Hragher. **The Hragher seek safety with** each other and live close to each other to protect themselves from the world's hatred. In some cities the State has established ghettos where the Hragher are placed. In the breakaway province in the east, the Hragher are the dominant people and those who have all power and all bene-fits. The Hragher people are in many ways like the Vagyar ethnic group but with coarser features, more abundant hair growth, fuller lips and a somewhat grayish skin tone. Long hair indicates status and is therefore common among both men and women — at work or in battle the hair is usually gathered in a braid, which is sometimes taken as a tro-phy by triumphant soldiers from the Empire. **Arkarer** In the eastern mountains and the vast forests that spread out beneath them, the Arkara people have their origin. The Arkarer have managed to preserve a large part of their cul-ture largely thanks to an isolated location and skillful political maneu-vering. In the cities the Arkarer are well regarded although there is some suspicion toward them as they stand out from the crowd. They are notori-ous for engaging in all kinds of mys-tical things and it is whispered that they have natural insight into the occult. Many are also well-read and knowledgeable in academic subjects. The Arkarer are somewhat taller than the Vagyar people but also generally slimmer. They have well-defined cheekbones and sharp features. They are pale in complexion and have straight, fine hair but otherwise very little body hair. Ilsa had with a glance gotten the man's attention, through a gesture awakened his desire and with a few words won his trust. She had let his hands caress the clothes off her, his fingers play on her stomach, continue down her thighs and press up into her. Warm and sweet she gave herself to him, felt his pulsat-ing nearness, the heat of his breath against her neck and his lips, so soft for a man's. **She let him take control and** lured out his deepest lusts, she clawed him pas-sionately and bit his shoulder. When she whispered asking to tie him to the bed-post he smiled and nodded. She tore the bedclothes into strips, tied them into knots and rode him slowly while ensur-ing that he was firmly secured. The cli-ent had asked her to make an example that would serve as a warning to the man's gang, so the death had to be spec-tacular. In a slow motion she loosened her hair and let it fall in a black cascade over her naked shoulders. The hairpin glit-tered in her grip as she thrust it into his throat just deep enough that only the ability to speak was lost. A work of art takes time to create after all, and this act of blood would be performed to the sound of rattling and faint moans of suffering.

Mechanical Differences Between Peoples

Just as Noir's rule system does not account for any differences between genders, no modifications are included based on ethnic origin. However, a protagonist can belong to a minority, which is described on page 82.

Naming Conventions

In general, the Empire's naming traditions are such that names resemble those of our world's Russian, Eastern European (such as Romanian, Czech, and Slovak) and German names. Latin-based (French, Italian, and Latin) names also work well, but English names and pronunciation essentially do not occur. Note that this applies only to pronunciation and melody—not that the names necessarily exist in the aforementioned places in reality.

Darost

With its vast and fertile plains, Darost is the Empire's breadbasket. The farms are enormous, and on the somewhat barren heaths graze the livestock herds. Everything is about exploitation and production in order to survive. Farmers and wage laborers work themselves to death in the fields, and in the cramped labor camps all

manner of diseases rage. Ironically, many workers die of malnutrition and starvation despite Darost being the province richest in food.

Ever-larger portions of the work are industrialized and mechanized; human workers are seen as nothing more than machines and are discarded when they are no longer of any use. Even the livestock is treated without dignity as it is led to the mechanical slaughterhouses or loaded onto overcrowded ships and train cars and transported to the cities to feed the people.

The new oil discoveries have caused large land areas to become poisoned, and machines pump day and night to extract the black gold from the earth's interior.

History

Darost previously consisted of several small kingdoms that existed in relative harmony with one another. Large parts of the plains were home to the Celenka horse people, who were increasingly displaced until a war finally erupted between the Celenkas and the local population. The Celenka culture was eradicated after centuries of conflict, and those Celenkas who did not flee were enslaved.

When the kingdom of Sadovia in the east began its raids, Darost's kingdoms united to meet the threat. The enemy in the east came to affect daily life for the people of Darost; the inhabitants could no longer feel safe as they could be attacked at any moment. Sadovia's troops were infamous for their cruelty, raping, plundering, and enslaving the people in the conquered areas.

Old chronicles tell that when Dargher of House Orlok came to power, he promised that the people would be kept safe and expelled all the Church's men from the land, as it was well known that many of them supported Sadovia. Thereafter he gathered forces that drove back the invaders, and along the western bank of the Ravike River he had fortifications and defensive works erected, armed with heavy cannons—weapons that Sadovia did not yet possess.

Dargher had himself crowned regent over the new plains kingdom and named it after his son, Darost. Just a few years later, Dargher and his family fell victim to a calculated and macabre assassination; the murderers were suspected to be of Sadovian origin. The kingdom lived on, however, under House Orlok's rule. When the enemy in the north launched its attack, Darost was one of the kingdoms hardest hit. The enemy fleet sailed into the Mirror Sea and bombarded the important coastal cities and landed its troops.

Before reinforcements from the eastern border could be summoned, large parts of the kingdom were destroyed or conquered. When the kingdoms allied under one state, it took a long time before Darost joined them, as their arch-enemy Sadovia was one of the founders of the idea. When the war was over and the Empire formed, Darost slowly came to be transformed into the important natural resource the kingdom is today. Nowadays, much of what is produced is sent to the fronts in the north and east, and oil in particular has become increasingly important for operating the machines of war.

Natural Resources

Besides cultivation, livestock, and oil, Darost contains large deposits of brown coal which power the power plants. Brown coal is an important export commodity, and long trains fully loaded with coal travel daily toward Sandukar and the other major cities of the Empire. The toxic smoke from the coal power plants and the destruction of the land when the coal is excavated ruin things for the farmers and livestock keepers and have led to a conflict between two important industries.

House Orlok has great control over Darost, but there is still land to stake out on the plains, and fortunes can still be made. There are a number of newly emerged industrial magnates who challenge the Houses' power through bold ventures and innovative thinking. So far, however, the Houses show who is in charge, and it happens that industrial magnates who have made too many enemies are found brutally murdered. Of course, the Houses always have an explanation for who carried out the deeds; usually it is people from the Church or the enemy's agents who are mentioned. Another approach is to force the upstarts into marriages with the Orlok line.

The Church has always been viewed poorly in Darost, and the few churches that have reopened are sparsely attended. Mischief and unrest are often blamed on the Church's men or on members of the Celenka people.

Despite the fertile location, there are plenty of diseases among Darost's people. Some claim it is a remnant from the chemical weapons that Sadovia or the enemy in the north are said to have used against the province—others maintain that House Orlok is culling the weakest workers to reduce the burden on the province. Whatever the case, a large portion of the working population dies before the age of 40. Many try to leave the hard work by either enlisting in the army or fleeing from their employers and seeking their fortune in Sandukar.

Devastok

Cranes, excavators, digging machines, and thousands of workers are constantly in motion in Devastok, a city expanding along the shores of the Mirror Sea. Harbor areas are built to receive all types of ships, and the railways transport goods that are reloaded to then be transported further into the kingdom.

There was previously another city called Devastok on the Mirror Sea coast, but it and its neighboring cities were all annihilated during a November night when a meteorite struck the frozen Mirror Sea and sent a tremendous tidal wave that brought about the cities' destruction. It took time, but new cities began to be established on the new coast, and the primary one inherited the name Devastok. Few think about the area's past, but on the bottom of the sea there are still remains of the cities and rusty ship hulls. Since the meteorite impact, fishing has also changed—many of the animals have become distorted and unpalatable and can no longer be eaten.

Liberinsko

Liberinsko is a larger city located inland. Certain parts of the city are abandoned, as a terrible plague broke out there a few years ago and the majority of the city's population perished in terrible pain. New workers are recruited daily, who get to fill the now-sanitized worker housing.

Liberinsko is seen as one of the freer cities where workers have good housing and live under relatively bearable conditions. The State does not have as much control over the city, but House Orlok keeps a close watch on what happens. The House operates the enormous coal power plants east of the city, which supply large parts of the country with electricity.

The Dome Battlefield

On the rolling Dome Battlefield, the important final battle against the northern enemy's armies took place. Here the united armies of Vadaja, Sadovia, and Darost met the hostile hordes. It became a hard fight that lasted for months as the enemy was slowly but surely driven down toward the Mirror Sea. The area is still filled with overgrown ruined cities, bunkers, and trenches.

Northern Plainlands

The gray, slightly rolling plainlands seemingly extend endlessly before they meet the kingdom of Vadaja. The acid rain has killed almost all life, and the animals that remain are mad and savage. There are no roads in this wilderness. The Wasteland Railway's lonely steel tracks run through the landscape, but what lies beyond the hills is unknown to most. However, there are places where not all hope has died. Where the grass grows strong and lush and where the trees bear leaves and needles.

The Coal Fields

In the Coal Fields, valuable brown coal is found just below the muddy ground. Enormous digging machines crawl like insects across the muddy landscape and tear up the coal to the surface with scoops. Everywhere you find the traces of caterpillar tracks, and the coal is transported by smoking trucks or rumbling trains to their destinations.

From the power plants near the Coal Fields rises toxic yellow-green smoke and sweeps the landscape into a fog. The workers here have very short lifespans and are secretly drugged to endure their tasks. They are also equipped with face filters to survive the day at all. Many of the criminals in Darost are sent to labor camps here, under the rule of House Kostash, until their sentences are completed or until they are buried in the muddy ground.

Iskarian

The Copper River divides Iskarian into a southern and northern part before its poisoned waters spread in the Oil Sea like a plague cloud. The Empire's center, the capital Sandukar, is located on a nameless island at the river's mouth and is a node for humanity's poisoning. On either side of the river mouth are massive forts with enormous steel cannons pointing out to sea, ready to bombard enemy fleets.

The southern parts of Iskarian are virtually uninhabited. They consist of a vast swampland like the neighboring kingdom of Kovan. The northern part is infested with several smaller industrial cities and a network of railways that transport raw materials to Sandukar, the eternally hungry whore. In the few places where fallout has not acidified nature, wealthy industrial magnates have established their estates, usually near one of the many lakes whose muddy bottoms and murky waters can no longer sustain any life.

History

Once upon a time, Iskarian was a fertile kingdom. The fields were verdant, the lakes and rivers contained abundant fish, and in the forests there was plenty of game. It seemed to be a paradise of nature's abundance. Sea winds brought cool summer rains to the harvests, and in the mountains one could mine precious metals and iron ore. In the coastal cities and the cities along the Copper River, rich trade took place with other kingdoms, and the people were known for their song, their music, and their fiery dances.

Iskarian's soldiers were brave and defended the kingdom against those who tried to plunder its riches—they often managed to stay out of other conflicts. They had close cooperation with Madrostav and borrowed liberally from the high culture in the north, but the kingdoms beyond the river were also explored by Iskarian's traveling merchants. When the ships from the northern enemy appeared on the horizon, the rulers believed that diplomacy could resolve the conflict, but their white flag was met with cannon fire from the armored cruisers.

In desperation, Iskarian's fleet and soldiers tried to hold the river mouth to the Copper River, but their defense was mercilessly ground down and the cannons obliterated the proud coastal cities. The enemy continued up the Copper River and annihilated and plundered wherever they passed. They landed their soldiers who committed cruel deeds.

When the proposal for an alliance between the Houses and the lands south of the mountains came up, Iskarian's leaders were among the first to accept—partly to get rid of the enemy and partly because they saw the power and advantages of unity.

In battle after battle, the enemy's forces were driven from the kingdoms, but they clung tenaciously to Iskarian, and when they finally retreated, the cities were burned-out ruins and the muddy lands covered with corpses. Nothing remained of the proud kingdom except a landmass soaked with blood and destructiveness and the memories of what had once been. These memories came to be reforged into a vision of what would become.

The Empire

Together, the Empire, now under the State's rule, began to rebuild Iskarian, and it was decided that the capital, Sandukar, would be located on the island at the Copper River's mouth. On the island before the war lay a massive temple city with tall buildings and underground sanctuaries, but the enemy's cannons had transformed it into rubble and ash. On either side of the Copper River's mouth, gigantic forts were built that with their cannons could annihilate the enemy should it ever return. Sandukar was also

The Fate Cross

In northern Iskarian, near the sea, rises the massive Fate Cross, a construction of rusty steel beams, machine parts and chains. The cross is more than a hundred meters tall and disappears up into the gray-white fog. The workers in the area worship and make offerings to the cross. Even the authorities show it respect. Those who die in labor are usually laid at the cross's feet or hung up in one of the chains.

The cross is said to be able to influence fate and if one believes enough and offers diligently one's prayers may be heard. Likewise the cross is said to be able to proclaim visions for those who seek. This occurs through violent nightmares from which not all awaken.

People from across the realm can sometimes see the cross in their dreams and pilgrimages to its macabre form occur daily.

The Montroy Quarries

When the black basalt was quarried for Sandukar's walls, towers and foundations, it was from the Montroy quarries the majority of all stone was taken. Nowadays it is desolate wasteland with several large open-pit mines and ponds that make up the landscape. There are plenty of caves and hollows and the quarries have become a place for outlaws and criminals who avoid the State. Now and then state forces are sent in to clear out those who live there but it is nearly impossible to cover all ravines, crevices and hollows. State commissars are said to conduct part of their training in the desolate area.

Kovan

Kovan is an undulating landscape filled with mist-shrouded marshes, tangled forest patches and cliffs. Several smaller rivers from the Valek mountains run through the ravines to then reach out to the Copper River. The

marshlands in the northern parts spread out more and more as a result of rivers being dammed up, and many of the older settlements now lie under water.

The cities have grown up at the rivers' outlets and many are protected by high levees to keep the water away.

In the rocky ravines are countless mines rich in precious metals and on the ravines' slopes rest modern forts that watch over the riches. The land is covered by a gray-white haze that seems to rise from the countless, stinking marshes and virtually all people from the inland have sought out the safe and rapidly growing cities. There are almost no remaining roads and if one must travel one does so by boat, on foot or on horseback.

In the east the marshlands transition into undulating forest terrain and border the breakaway realm Presvedonia and the eastern front. Here are several army camps and in the cities things go downright wild when the soldiers have time off from the battles at the front. Here one can find fortune seekers, prostitutes, battle-weary soldiers and the enemy's agents.

History

Kovan was once upon a time a rich land whose people conducted trade along the rivers and were known for their skill as seamen and craftsmen. In the undulating inland there was plenty of livestock and the waterways were filled with riches, both gold and noble fish. The people were however moderate and took only what they needed and managed to stay outside most conflicts with the help of diplomatic skill.

The Church came to gain hold of the realm via merchants from Sadovia. Soon it gained through manipulation and foul play total power. It took control over the peoples' industries and gave heavenly grace to those who paid much tax. Massive riches were sent by river boats to Sadovia and gigantic cathedrals were built in the midst of the moderate people's cities.

Soon however doubts began to come, was really the one god's teaching the right one and how could god's greed be allowed to plague the people so? In religion's name thousands died in the mines, greed gained hold of their hearts and soon discontent began to spread. With force of arms Kovan's people annihilated the church, the priests were executed publicly, some had molten gold poured down their throats, others were nailed up on crosses. The churches were burned and their ruins allowed to remain as warnings and reminders.

When religion was driven out the people decided to themselves watch over their riches. The seeds of envy and greed were however already sown and in the following centuries many internal conflicts broke out. The clan that emerged victorious from the bloodbath bore the name Zovrin.

When then the enemy from the north attacked with its massive fleet along the Copper River, Kovan's coastal cities were blown apart by the warships' cannons. The people fled inland and took shelter in ravines and settlements. The enemy never managed to gain foothold in the realm but proceeded further eastward along the river. When the State was formed, the Zovrin clan came to gain great power and also gave name to the currency that is still minted in the realm. Industrialization became increasingly evident and large parts of the countryside were abandoned.

The Riches

Kovan is a large trading realm, ships run back and forth along the Copper River and the Mirror Sea has several harbors. In the east coal is mined from the porous mountains and the coal then supplies the realm with energy and heat. Along the rivers are masses of mines in the ravines' walls. They are very rich in precious metals, primarily gold and silver but one can also find lead, copper and zinc.

The rivers have plenty of fish, which to some extent constitutes the basic diet, even though it is beginning to become increasingly scarce much thanks to the large overfishing as well as discharges from the mines.

Industry is for the most part focused on steelworks and chemical factories. Here and there one can find abandoned villages and cities where the people were forced to a "better" life in the cities.

Almost all rulers have left the realm and taken themselves to Sandukar. As the wealth leaves the realm the marshlands spread out and the people no longer remember their moderation, their benevolence and culture's origin that lies resting deep beneath stagnant marsh water. People's minds are now bound to machinery and cogwheels and by plundering nature, not living in harmony with it, the people continue their parasitic existence.

Myta

The stately city Myta lies on a peninsula where the river Khastyr meets the Copper River. It is a place for trade and transshipment. In the massive harbor area warehouse buildings rest beside each other and out on the piers stand rusty cranes. In the city's center is the mint where parts of the state currency are minted. Here the guard is very strict and one must have special certificates and passes to enter the city's inner parts that rise on a mountain ridge and tower up over surrounding districts.

In the harbor area state control is weak and there are plenty of criminal elements, seamen, beggars, fortune seekers, shady bars and prostitutes. The nights in Myta's harbor quarter are widely notorious for their violence and debauchery.

The Southwestern Marshlands

The southwestern marshlands are an extensive area covered by treacherous swamps, pools and mangrove marshes and border the realm Iskarian. A sickly yellowish-pale fog rests over the region and the stagnant smell causes nausea and sometimes even diseases in throat and eyes. To travel here without a gas mask is dangerous as people have died from the area's poisonous fog banks.

Buildings, machines, vehicles and cadavers of both animals and people stick up from the wetland and create gloomy silhouettes in the fog. From deep below the ground one can sometimes hear the rumble of machines and in the murky water rusty cogwheels still move in unknown tasks. At night one can behold a green-violet phosphorescent glow on the firmament above the marshlands.

The marble floor was cold, rough and inviting, almost soporific. His tremors made the beard hairs sweep rhythmically over the microscopic stone landscape, laboriously built up by a hundred years of madness. He slowly heaved himself up, snorting and drooling. The straitjacket still hung limply around his waist and clumsily hindered his movements. The pen he had written down the so important words with on the back of the Envelope now lay before him—it must have fallen from his grasp when he stumbled. Awkwardly he grasped the pen and stuffed it inside his shirt.

With an effort he tore apart the remains of the straitjacket and began to stagger forward. Stopped briefly, loudly smacking. Ah, a tooth. Spit! No, no traces. No traces! They must not find us! He swallowed, felt the tooth root scrape against his throat, tried not to cough.

Out there she was. He knew it. He had seen the Envelope. He had seen how they began to push it into the gap under the door with their coarse, dry fingers. He had sat as if petrified with fingers spread and his whole body crouched like a lurking insect. But they pulled it out again.

Could they know? Their slimy, slack eyes had surely already swept over the Envelope's contents, but had they understood? They would not be able to understand, impossible, completely impossible. Had they understood they would be sitting in the same cell as him. They do it only out of pure malice, they do not realize what sentence they pronounce over him and her, what they tear from his and her future! How can they? The tears immediately pressed forth. He had already crawled forth to the gap on all fours, snorting from the thin layer of flaked skin and dust that swirled up in his nose. But he could sense it—the scent. The proof that it really was the Envelope. And then he saw, through the gap. Beside the two pairs of coarse, white-painted boots that the Soul Mourners always wore together with their dirty gray coats he saw them: brown, gleaming, charged with wealth, reeking of Andorov bootblack and Belusian leather, reinforced heels that now echoed away. He had himself worn shoes like these. He saw the order badges. The Order is here!

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had a fortification-like character, hundreds of thousands of workers and heavy machines worked to raise the massive basalt walls and dig out the canals according to a carefully thought-out design. The work sucked out all the province's riches and the city became the only place of significance.

Many times the work with the city seemed doomed, diseases and madness spread among the workers and when the Copper River's water was led into the city's canals the end seemed near. Massive storms seemed to sweep in from all points of the compass and gather in one and the same place above the city's center. The lightning swept down from sulfur-reeking thunderclouds and a third of the city's population perished in this plague. Many who survived were forever mad and spoke of winged beings and terrible beasts.

It took a long time for the city to be populated but nowadays few have heard of the dark things that happened during its past and it constitutes the Imperium's shining center. Iskarian is hardly seen as a realm anymore, but as the wasteland that surrounds the city. The new era never restored the old realm—the hope that once budded together with joy and openness was obscured into decadent suspicion. Sandukar, the eternal city, the great whore, is however hungrier than ever and devours souls greedily and ruthlessly.

Resources

There are few natural deposits left in Iskarian but Sandukar demands much of both people and resources to be kept alive. Brown coal is transported to massive power plants and in the dammed tributaries turbines generate electricity. The southern part of the realm is rich in natural gas—rusty towers and pipelines lead the gas to Sandukar to give the city life and light. The pilot flames on these facilities burn with dirty flames and light up the marshlands with a sickly glow.

The mines no longer yield any return, the forests are felled or dead and the fields increasingly fall into crop failure. The cold rainstorms that drive in from the seas seem only to imprint the contagion into the earth and during the winters the snow that falls is often gray-black from all factory smoke. In the north are the large quarries where the black basalt for Sandukar's walls was quarried long ago. Its echoing black abysses are filled with stagnant water and in its cliff walls outcasts and criminals have taken their refuge. Some of the shafts are however avoided as it is said that dark horrors rest in their depths. It is a dark and sorrowful place outside Sandukar's walls and the people in the realm leave the rusty railyards and decaying industrial cities if they only can.

The Forts

On either side of the Copper River's outlet rise two massive forts whose task is to defend the river's inlet from invading fleets. Each fort is equipped with two massive cannons that can fire several miles out to sea. In

addition to main armament there are several bunkers with machine gun positions that shall protect against invaders from land and from the air. The northern fort is located on, and to large parts embedded in, a high mountain slope and at its foot is the harbor for the military fleet. The southern fort is embedded in the high cliff wall that rises up from the sea and is very difficult to detect and attack.

The Blood Combat

Since time immemorial, blood combat has been popular entertainment for the rich and powerful in Sadovia. It is a macabre event where slaves fight each other with bladed weapons, either to the first drop of spilled blood or to the death. Noble families often have their own personal slaves who fight for their honor and spend all their time training in the art of the sword.

Originally, this tradition was common only among the families within House Arkady and was used to resolve conflicts between members, but nowadays it is seen more as entertainment. In the Empire, the activity is officially forbidden but is still performed for pleasure at various events where spectators sit in high-backed chairs and nobly applaud the victor. The winner catches their opponent's blood in a chalice and then offers their owner to drink to capture the defeated one's soul.

Near the middle of the swamplands, massive basalt cliffs rise tens of meters into the air like enormous pillars. Between these, a sanctuary, Arovia, has been established, and in this lawless place one can find many types of dissidents and people with twisted beliefs. So far, the State has ignored this gathering of rebels and defiers.

The Vaslov River

The cities along the Vaslov River are all abandoned and the vegetation is dead. A stench of chemicals hangs between the ravine walls, and without a gas mask one quickly becomes teary-eyed and nauseous. Some claim the enemy used one of their weapons here, others that the stench comes from a discharge from one of the mines upstream.

There are also those who claim the One punished the people for their greed. Hundreds of thousands died when the poisonous vapors rose from the water, and it is still dangerous to stay here. The ship crews that travel up and down the river always make sure to wear their gas masks when passing this cursed place.

The Southern Railway

The Southern Railway is one of the few railways in Kovan, whose main purpose is to transport coal from the east to the mining cities in the west. It is also used to transport soldiers and materiel to the eastern front. The Southern Railway is winding and crosses deep ravines and bridges through swamplands and mountain ranges. Large parts of the railway are under guard, especially the vulnerable wooden bridges that can be easily sabotaged, as this route is so important in the realm.

Madrostav

In the west by the Raben Mountains, the ancient realm of Madrostav spreads out. The majority of the Gothic cities lie on slopes, plateaus, or in narrow valleys between the jagged mountains. The roads there are all well-guarded by cannon-fortified forts in the narrow mountain passes.

Low clouds from the sea cover the mountains in a gray fog and dreary rain both summer and winter. The rainwater travels in thundering torrents to irrigate the valley farmlands and gives the people a chance to survive. In some places there are cable cars and railways, but much of the travel occurs by zeppelin. Farthest

west, where the mountains give way to windswept flatlands that slope down toward the sea, lies Madrostav's cradle.

Countless coastal cities once made the realm one of the most successful seafaring nations—but these have long been in ruins. Massive ship hulls slowly rusting away lie aground in sandbanks, craters, grenade fragments, and blown-up bunkers testify to great battles in ancient times.

East of the mountains, several new cities have been established, modern industrial towns where the lifetime-employed workers live. The lands are acidified after emissions from the northern neighboring realm Vadaja, but in the southern parts and near the mountains cultivation is possible, and here the railway network is extensively developed. Everywhere one can find traces of cities, monuments, burned-out churches, defense towers, and shrines—all overgrown with coarse grass and eroded by wind and rain.

History

Madrostav was once a high culture that outshone its neighbors when it came to science, art, architecture, and knowledge. The people were rich and used the sea as a transport and trade route, and the coastal cities were said to be magnificent. In the mountains, the monastery cities were built, for the people were all sworn to the doctrine of the One God, and they claimed he originated from this realm.

Envious eyes from surrounding realms regarded Madrostav's riches, but the only ones who dared enter into conflict with the great power were the warlords from Vadaja and the Celenka horse people. Their attacks struck the cities on the eastern side of the mountains, and Madrostav erected a defense of walls and watchtowers.

Diplomacy and negotiations, however, meant that most conflicts could be resolved peacefully. Madrostav's position was to remain neutral in all conflicts, and by doing this, the realm managed to avoid many bloody intrigues and outright wars.

But when the enemy from the north swept over the realms, it was Madrostav that was struck first and hardest. The enemy's entire war fleet sailed up along the coast and bombarded the cities until nothing remained but ruins. The enemy landed their troops and began a massacre without equal—people were impaled on bayonets, shot with rifles, and slaughtered with swords.

Madrostav would never recover; the high culture had fallen. Even though some of the people managed to seek shelter in the mountain cities and the mountain passes could be defended, everything that symbolized the realm's greatness was lost.

In the conflicts that followed the invasion, the eastern cities were plundered by the enemy from the north or by greedy warlords from Vadaja who now finally saw the chance to obtain the riches.

Madrostav's royal family established a new seat in the mountain cities and received neither refugees nor allies. They isolated themselves to survive. When word came of an alliance between the seven realms to resist the enemy and avenge the deed, Madrostav was the last realm to join the union.

Revenge was what drove them, and the realm's knowledge that was previously used for art and beauty was twisted into the creation of weapons and tyranny. When the State was formed, royal power diminished, and when protests about this made themselves heard, all members of the royal family were captured and publicly executed. It is said, however, that the king's daughter managed to escape this bloody deed and that the royal line thus still lives in the province. The State claims this is merely propaganda from the enemy, but documents

have recently surfaced showing that state searches for the last remnants of the ancient royal line have been conducted.

House Mengal took control of the province in place of the royal power and has ruled it with an iron fist ever since, despite countless attempts by the other houses to gain influence.

Madrostav is rapidly growing in power; the lobotomized workers extract great resources that are used in the most efficient way possible with the help of ancient knowledge preserved by Mengal's brilliant physicians.

When the footsteps disappeared around the corner, he knew it was his last chance. He let the force seek through the crack, push out like a tidal wave. The familiar vein began to throb in his temple as the splinters began to tear from the wooden door and the iron bindings complained. He turned his face away just before the door buckled and sent a shower of sharp splinters toward him, some of which pierced his shirt. It was time. Like the mechanical clockwork he had drilled himself to become over the years, he set to work. Turned his arms over his head, tensed all the muscles he had carefully trained until the seams began to give way. Even before his arms were free, his legs had begun to engage, like the pistons in a locomotive heading toward the fatal Northern Graves. The same cold, violent fate would meet him.

Resources

The mountains in Madrostav are relatively poor in resources unlike the northern Arkady Mountains, but the resources that exist are extracted with great efficiency. One can find iron ore and copper in some places, but many of the older mines are now depleted and abandoned.

The realm has instead specialized in importing resources and then, in massive factories, transforming them into mechanical constructions and architectural wonders. In Madrostav, the majority of the flying machines and airships used in the Empire are manufactured. At the shipyards by the Lazlo River, vessels intended for transport and war are constructed.

He had flung himself over the Soul Feeders. The man with the shoes, merely one of the Order's simpler henchmen, had drawn his revolver in vain. It served no purpose—now he was a machine, well-oiled and designed for this moment. The envelope fluttered through the air, accompanied by the howling from the cells when the poor animals realized what was about to happen. He grabbed the envelope with his bloody right hand before it landed. He hid it immediately, then began to run. He had to find his way out of this labyrinth; he needed to buy himself time. The Order would not wait; they would not hesitate now that he had taken the first step.

His hand sought down inside his waistband.

He knew the Envelope was still there, for it scraped his groin. It was in safe keeping. Forward, forward. Somewhere there must be an opening, for he heard the city's sounds, the whistles that shrieked and the machinery that thumped. Before him in the darkness, the wall fan whipped up a constant storm of dust frantically.

"Georgi," he heard then behind him. "Your life is over and you know it. You can spare yourself all this trouble if you just give us the envelope and tell us where she is." The sharp voice and mint breath were unmistakable. The vein began to pulse again, but he knew it was futile this time.

He did not answer. He thought of her. She was of his blood, and she held the truth and would bring down the Order in the same way her mother once tried to do. As furiously loyal as he had then beaten that poor woman

to pieces, so defiantly rebellious did he now shoot his arm like a projectile into the fan drum. The envelope was convulsively extended between his thumb and index finger. Almost childishly delighted, he saw in the man's gaze that this was unexpected. Unplanned. The Order had not thought of everything, he thought over and over as the fan began to eat into his arm and a black sludge began to fill his vision. The envelope fluttered calmly away on the other side, lifted by the warm vapors from the sewers before it settled on a rusty water cistern.

On the newly established rail yards at the foot of the mountains, locomotives are assembled while the railway network spreads out. Cable cars, mechanical elevators, and airship harbors are used for travel between the mountain cities, as some of the cities can no longer be reached via the regular roads. Despite the realm being symbolized by industrialization, it is also known for its culture, particularly for the magnificent theaters that have at least as many visitors as the cinemas.

There are also numerous hot springs in the mountain regions, whose mineral-rich waters are said to have a beneficial effect on health. This has led to a large number of spa resorts being found here. Everything from luxurious clinics for the very wealthiest to more affordable establishments for the middle class. Many from Sandukar and the other cities in the Empire dream of someday seeing the massive mountain cities that tower above precipices and waterfalls, often covered in white, pristine snow. Few ever see the misery that exists in the labor camps and the suffering required to keep the realm alive.

Piklos

In the barren, gray Rabenberg mountains, the city of Piklos has been erected. The innermost parts of the city have plenty of churches, winding streets, and ancient buildings, but the further from the center one goes, the more modern the properties become. Piklos was originally built on a plateau but has now spread to slopes and ravines. Despite this, the city lies largely underground. Since it is located high in the mountains, the gray-white clouds often drift in and sink the entire city into a rain-gray haze.

A great deal of mining takes place in the area—primarily iron ore, as Piklos is one of the few cities in Madrostav that still has deposits in the depths. Beneath the city lies an elongated underground lake where water was previously fetched. However, the chemicals used in mining operations have contaminated the water to such a degree that it is undrinkable. Instead, water is fetched from one of the high-altitude rivers in the area.

The underground lake is now used as a transport route and garbage station. Many criminal elements operate in the darkness—on artificial islands covered with garbage and debris. A number of conflicts have arisen between different mining companies, and some outer parts of the city have been affected by cave-ins due to reckless blasting.

Karduna

The city of Karduna lies on both sides of the Valtava river's steep slopes. Its industrial districts spew black sooty smoke over the region, and the place is called "The Black Land" in common parlance. The smoke obscures the sunlight and sinks the city into eternal darkness. Few have ever seen the stars or the moon.

From the open pit mines north of the city, ore is transported to massive refineries where it is cast into ingots. Refineries and chemical factories make up large parts of the cityscape.

Almost everyone who lives here in Karduna is a worker or bureaucrat. The workers are often owned by the factories, and many are lobotomized or drugged. On either side of the river stand massive military buildings that guard the city and the vessels traveling on the river. Ten years ago, "the week of blood" occurred—a workers' uprising took shape and the military entered the city and slaughtered everyone in the entire northern district. The blood is said to have run down the steep streets and colored the river's murky water red. Corpses floated in the water as far down as Sandukar.

The Fallen Church

A massive church of dirty red brick stands overgrown in one of the valleys; its water-filled crypt is said to hide many secrets. Those who have ventured down into the swamp water have become ill and died within hours. Several state commissioners have investigated the areas around the church and questioned people who lived nearby. Apparently, someone, or something, has made the church its dwelling. The State claims that enemy spies operate there, but there are others who have more macabre and horrifying theories.

The Vorgul Mines

The Vorgul mines are an extensive mining area that is now largely abandoned. Here there are plenty of remnants from the mines' golden age: rusty railway tracks, ghost towns, and dammed rivers. Large parts of the mountain area are marked with risk of collapse, and in some places entire mountainsides have collapsed.

The mines go deep underground and merge with natural caves, underground rivers, and bottomless shafts.

Eviza's Factories

On the plains rises an anonymous factory building surrounded by a high brick wall and guarded by many soldiers. At the train station next to the building, only military transports stop, from which researchers and scientists are escorted to their workplaces. Here, weapons of mass destruction are produced for a coming war. Various types of poison gases and biological weapons are tested on test subjects and livestock, and there have also been reports of research into a new type of weapon that will bring fire, disease, and mass destruction in a single violent explosion.

Presvedonia

In the east lies the vast realm of Presvedonia with its deep coniferous forests, high mountains, and rocky terrain. This is the origin of the Hraghic people; from here stems their culture and history, and despite the State's attempts to eradicate it, it has always lived on in the shadows. Now that the realm has rebelled against the State and begun fighting for its survival, the culture has experienced a renaissance and the people are beginning to seek their old identity again.

History

Presvedonia was originally a clan society where the most powerful clans schemed and fought against each other. The peoples kept to the forests and mountain slopes, and few surrounding realms gave them any thought except when they stormed out from the wilderness to plunder neighboring realms.

However, the rulers of the neighboring realm of Sadovia realized the value of the resources that could be found in the untamed wilderness. They made contact with one of the weaker clans and offered it their support. They used the church as a tool and got the people within the clan to swear themselves to the One God.

Soon the clan had grown strong, and with House Arkady as advisors, it conquered larger and larger areas.

Protectors

In Vadaja there is a group of officers directly subordinate to House Kriger, whose task is to maintain order in the difficult-to-control parts of the realm, which for the most part means the wilderness and the smaller mining towns. The Protectors, as they are called, have the right to apprehend, interrogate, and execute people without any trial whatsoever, as long as these people are of the working class or lower. This is to speed up the otherwise costly and time-consuming legal processes and to remove undesirable elements for whom there is no evidence.

The Protectors' uniforms are entirely black, with long, double-breasted coats with brass buttons.

The Hraghers became obsessed with the One God's commandments and erected black cathedrals in his honor where the priesthood could spread their words to the people.

After less than a hundred years of conflicts, all of Presvedonia was united under the church and became an effective vassal realm to the neighboring country of Sadovia and House Arkady. The people were made to function as workers and soldiers; they were manipulated into attacking Sadovia's enemies and sold their realm's resources for pittances.

This oppression would continue for centuries as the Hraghers were first a vassal people for Sadovia and thereafter the lowest of servants under the State.

The Fallen One

House Todescu, which represented the Hraghic people, was exploited and used to carry out the lowest of tasks, and the envy and hatred toward the State grew with each day and humiliation. Then one day, the Fallen One appeared.

He first came to a mining village up in the snow-covered mountains and walked into the church in the middle of the service. He proclaimed who he was: an outcast and rejected one who had been cast from heaven to wander the earth, and the words set fire to the ember that existed in the people's hearts. The Fallen One promised to lead them, to restore their honor and free them from the scourge. The rumor of him spread and he appeared in smaller towns and villages in the realm's outskirts. The State's forces searched desperately for him, but after his sermon, he seemed to be swallowed by the night. More and more came to call the Fallen One the One's sign. Some went so far as to call him the Messiah.

The War

The members of House Todescu had carefully planned an uprising, and during the darkest and coldest of winter months, they struck. Their troops succeeded with sabotage and well-planned attacks to take out almost all the military forces loyal to the State in less than a week. Com-

PI A.

Malov (#I-40955): And then you saw the suspect?

(Confidential information): Yeah, then I saw the fucking asshole knock 'er down with an iron pipe. Just went clonk!

PI A.

Malov (#I-40955): And by "the fucking asshole" you mean the suspect, Argan Jakovlev?

(Confidential information): Yep, sure as amen in church.

PI A.

Malov (#I-40955): Right. How did you recognize the suspect?

(Confidential information): Dead easy. He was lit up by a passing car. The whole mug was white on 'im. Well, except for the blood splatter.

PI A.

Malov (#I-40955): Okay, thank you for your cooperation. Is there anything you'd like to add?

(Confidential information): Just that I've never been questioned by a pudding before. Say, when do you get off?

PI A.

Malov (#I-40955): Never. The interrogation is concluded. The time is 03:57.

End of interrogation with witness SA-Ik-933 4443 5577 332

munications were sabotaged, railway bridges were blown to pieces, and before the State realized what was happening it was too late. Brutal executions followed—in the town squares blood stained the snow and frozen bodies were stacked upon each other as those deemed loyal to the State were purged. The Fallen One filled the people with rapture and fanaticism, and Presvedonia's population has been given something to believe in while the war against the State rages on.

Resources

Presvedonia has abundant natural resources and the waste has not yet completely poisoned the rivers or killed the forests. In the mountains iron ore and copper are extracted, vast oil reserves exist in the southern forests, and timber is used for heating. The country is far from as industrialized as the other realms in the State, as there are only a few large industrial cities, and in many places people still live in smaller communities in the countryside. The roads are poor and were it not for the railway network it would take a long time to travel through the realm. Horses are common outside the cities as they are seen as safer and more reliable means of transport in the hilly terrain.

Presvedonia is a realm at war. The State has decided to retake its lost territory and its armies have slowly begun moving into Presvedonian land. However, the people of Presvedonia have prepared themselves, and since many of the inhabitants served as soldiers at the northern front, there is experience in warfare. Likewise, they have the conviction that they are led by a divine power. Many, both men and women, join the army to get the chance to defend their realm and avenge their ancestors' slavery with blood. The cities near the front are not much more than ruins but they are well fortified with machine gun nests, trenches, and artillery.

Rasov

Rasov is a hilly city built on several hills with large granite blocks jutting up here and there from the ground. The houses are seldom higher than two or three stories and the city is spread out over a large area. Along the banks of the Hadia River lie factory buildings and shipyards in rows, and massive water dams upstream supply the city with electricity.

In the city center, by the oldest parts, several taller buildings rise up beside which a cathedral is being built. Its main tower shall be higher than any other building in this region, but since the stone must be of black basalt it requires several miles of travel to transport it there and the work therefore progresses slowly. However, it is the Fallen One who shall have the tower as his dwelling, so workers gather voluntarily in the hundreds to help.

In military camps outside the city men and women are trained in the art of war, and in the forested area surrounding the city there is plenty of anti-aircraft defense and hidden defensive positions. Rasov has good railway connections and nearby there are several smaller industrial and factory towns that all have their role to fill in the war's production.

Derimrad

Near the front lie the ruins of the massive city of Derimrad. There are few inhabitants left in the city except soldiers on both sides. The State presses on with its troops but Presvedonia's forces have fortified themselves well and the city refuses to fall. That Derimrad has plenty of culverts and underground spaces that Presvedonia's troops have well mapped makes it no easier to clear them out.

There are still buildings that are reasonably intact but artillery from both sides slowly demolishes everything into a mass of shattered brick and twisted steel. How many hundreds of thousands have died in the city's ruins cannot be said, but everywhere lie bodies in various stages of decomposition. The rats are now the city's rulers and the only ones who feast and thrive in the brutal environment, and for them there is food in abundance. Some soldiers claim to have encountered rats as large as dogs, but this is laughed off as hallucinations caused by stress or lack of food and sleep.

The Stone of Doom

There is an ancient tradition of rune carving in Presvedonia, usually erected on the high granite cliffs that rise up from the coniferous forests. The most famous of these cliffs is the Stone of Doom—a massive, pointed cliff whose one side is sloping and clad with moss and conifers while the other side is smooth and drops straight down and has an extended prophecy carved into it. Those who can interpret the ancient script can discern that it concerns the end of the world and contains many references to events that shall occur in the final times.

The Stone of Doom is seen as a religious place and during summers many pilgrimages are made there. It is said that the stone was destroyed by the State when it gained power in the realm but that it is now whole again. It is also said that it was the Fallen One who one summer night joined together the shattered stone fragments to avail himself of the stone's forbidden knowledge.

The Burned Lands

Between the Preos Mountains and the Hadia River the Burned Lands, a vast area of scorched, inaccessible wilderness, spread out. No plants live here, the trees are nothing more than charred, macabrely twisted, skeletal remains, the earth is blackened and the few watercourses are sulfur-stinking and poisonous. What has caused this blackened desert with ochre-colored earth is unknown. Some interpreters of the holy scripture

believe it is a sign that the end is near, others say the State has created a new type of weapon that was used here.

Sadovia

Sadovia is a myth-shrouded realm whose power-mad rulers have previously plagued their neighboring countries with devastation and conquest. It is a dark place with deep forests, forgotten valleys, and winding mountain roads that lead to old castles and fortresses.

History shows centuries of constant conflict within the realm as decadent noble families fought for power. Even to this day many of the inner parts function like feudal states where the people are in practice owned by the rulers, but slavery has always been a cornerstone of Sadovia's society.

Slaves were used to quarry stone for massive bridges and fortresses, slaves were used to construct roads along mountain slopes, and slaves were used to entertain the rulers in brutal fights to the death. For something Sadovia's rulers have always been good at is subjugating people and forcing them to accept tyrannical rule. Sadovia's indigenous population, the Arkars, see themselves as a chosen race, more suited to rule than the others, and many of the noble families guard their bloodlines well to ensure that persons of the wrong folk and rank do not enter the family and can poison the future offspring.

History

The Arkars were formerly a warlike people who believed that power and honor could only be found through conquest. They fought each other for a long time but when the Valka family came to power and Malach van Valka de Arkady declared himself emperor the realm was kept relatively united. Instead attention was directed toward the surrounding realms. The plains in the west and the realm of Darost in particular, became victims of violent attacks and plundering.

Eyes were also turned toward Presvedonia but here manipulation was used more than military force. By supporting the weaker of the clans, introducing the church and thereafter crushing all resistance, they made Presvedonia function as an obedient vassal state with a puppet on the throne.

When the enemy in the north invaded Sadovia's leaders were among the first to discuss the unification of the realms and came to occupy many decision-making positions when the State was formed.

Present Day

Nowadays Sadovia is a more peaceful realm that no longer attacks its neighbors, even though many noble family members contentedly recount the time when their ancestors drank enemies' blood on the battlefield and conquered wealth and honor. One can also find traces of this if one looks around, in everything from inaccessible castles on barren mountaintops to more modern bunkers and overgrown trenches. If one digs in the country's black soil one soon finds traces of countless mass graves.

Since Presvedonia broke away from the State the war has come closer again and Sadovia's rulers intend to force the former vassal realm to its knees and punish the people for their rebellious minds. The hragher in the realm who are not believed to be loyal or are closely connected to any of the noble families have all been executed or enslaved.

A large part of the resources produced in the realm now go to the army which hits the poorer part of the population hard. The declining standard of living and the harsh climate have caused child mortality to

increase. As a response to this, families in the realm are given a subsidy for each child they have so they can buy clothes and medicines. The realm needs these future workers and soldiers.

Even though the cities nearest the Copper River are heavily industrialized, much of the old times remain and the deeper into the realm one goes the further back in time one seems to travel. Horse and carriage are in many places the most common means of transport and there are plenty of small villages where people have not even seen factories or motor vehicles. Here many old customs are also kept alive, including burying their dead instead of cremating them.

The signs of modernization are becoming increasingly clear however—railways are being built through the forested realm and in the mountain areas trains make their way along precipices, cascading waterfalls and rusty, ancient bridges. Noble families often have private trains that take them to their family castles and the traditional carriages are almost completely abandoned. There are also those who travel between family castles by airship.

The important River Ravike is a vital trade route, in the Arkady Mountains extensive mining takes place and in the areas around the mountains logging is ongoing. The plains are fertile and one finds cattle breeding and cultivation almost everywhere. The realm is not as plagued by the industries' pollution but in many places nature is violent and dangerous. There are plenty of wild animals that do not hesitate to attack humans who enter their domains.

Orava

On islands in the Ravike River, connected by bridges and canals, rests the city of Orava. The old fortress city retains its medieval walls while new constructions spread out on the eastern, sloping, riverbank. The old houses are built of thick, dark, stone blocks and richly decorated with gargoyles and statues. Even the new buildings bear traces of this old style even though they are largely built of brick.

Some buildings stand out in the cityscape and the most striking of them is the Maur Cathedral—a majestic building whose seven bell towers stretch up among the clouds. Even though the cathedral has few visitors it is lit day and night from the towers and it is said there are many secret entrances and crypts that lead into the cathedral. The Markal family of the Arkady lineage has many members who live in the cathedral and it also functions as the family's unofficial seat.

In Orava one also finds Jakov's Square, a slave market that during holidays is overcrowded with sellers, buyers, and "lifetime employees."

My dearest sister

I send this letter with my friend Mikael and hope that he despite his injuries shall be able to deliver it to you before your birthday. The regular mail has an ability to censor that which is not "appropriate" for the public to know and there are words that must be allowed to be free.

I have been stationed at the southeastern trenches, firing line Pavel, the most feared and notorious of them all. In this hellscape of mud, barbed wire, grenade fragments and empty shells so many brave men have died that wherever one sets down one's feet one treads on a body or parts of bodies. I have ended up here due to refusal to obey orders as I refused to participate in the execution by firing squad of a deserting soldier.

My dearest sister, I could not shoot him for wanting to flee from this purgatory and it is only cowardice that has prevented me from trying to follow his example. I do not expect to survive long so this is a letter of

farewell. My thoughts are always with you sister and I long back to the times when we were young and the world was simple—when we walked by the canals, built dream castles and told dark stories to each other in old man Esser's attic.

Now I can write no more for the medical transport that Mikael shall travel with departs shortly.

Farewell

Your brother Oliver

Tarant

Tarant is an industrial city located in a valley with steep mountain slopes on either side. The city has expanded in recent years as more and more factories are built for the production of weapons and ammunition for the soldiers fighting at the eastern front. Two smelting plants are situated up on the mountain slopes and their smoke settles over the valley and the city, making the air difficult to breathe and reducing visibility to a hundred meters on the most windless days. The buildings in the city are black with soot and the windows must be cleaned monthly to avoid becoming completely sooted over.

The greatest plague, however, are the cockroaches and insects that swarm over the city, fill the sewers and torment the inhabitants. They originate from a ravine not far from the city where thousands of hragher were shot dead and thrown down after the kingdom of Presvedonia's uprising. The faithful in the city believe that the insects are a punishment from the One. They refer to a passage in the book of revelations and see it as a sign of the final day. State troops have tried to clear out the ravine using fire and chemical insecticides but the plague constantly returns.

Eastern Arkady Mountains

The rocky terrain toward the high peaks in the Arkady Mountains is often shrouded in a cold, gray fog. During autumn, however, tremendous storms blow up between the cliff crevices and thunderclaps roll across the landscape, lit up by gray-blue lightning. Among twisted trunks, moss-covered stones and boggy hollows one finds massive wooden crucifixes, worn by age and in many places overgrown.

There are plenty of ruins of old fortresses, abandoned villages and large gaping mine shafts on the gloomy mountainsides. Narrow, winding roads run alongside bottomless depths where cold green rivers slowly flow down toward the dark forests. There is talk of horrors that haunt the mountains, black beings that glide between the trunks, constantly hunting for careless wanderers.

Ghalder's Monastery

In a valley rests the old monastery building of Ghalder's Monastery, now owned by the Zabran family. It is no longer a place for prayer and contemplation but a place for oppression and manipulation. At Ghalder's Monastery, children are raised to become slaves, their wills are broken and they are trained in the knowledge and skills they should master. When they are finally sold as dancers, courtesans and servants at 15-16 years of age, they always command high sums.

The monastery is surrounded by high walls covered with climbing vines and in the forested valley there are plenty of wild wolf packs. The only way out of the valley is also guarded by soldiers and all of this has led to very few ever succeeding in escaping from the monastery.

Castle Dubravka

In the inaccessible mountains, high up among plateaus and jagged mountain ridges rests the dark and gloomy Castle Dubravka. The bridge that previously ran across the massive ravine separating the plateau where the castle is located from the outside world has collapsed - or, as some claim, been destroyed. The only way to reach and leave the plateau is

via airship and these are under strict control of the HrÅ«zda family who are also the lords of Castle Dubravka. There are several villages on the plateau and their inhabitants live in fear of their dark lords and are trapped without any possibility of reaching the outside world.

Vadaja

At the northern Arkady Mountains, the harsh province of Vadaja spreads out. Cold winds sweep down from the snow-clad peaks and during the winter half of the year the province is exposed to violent snowstorms that isolate entire cities from the outside world. The massive forest belt of Walaru that spreads out below the Arkady Mountains is poisoned by chemicals from the mining towns. Likewise, the timber and paper industry has its share in the devastation and releases its waste products directly into the forest's waterways. This has killed the plants and affected the wildlife and the entire ecosystem is on the verge of collapse. The herbivorous animals are nearly extinct, birds are rarely heard or seen and hungry wolf packs seek closer and closer to humans to obtain food - often human.

Vadaja is the province that borders the northern front and the proximity of war is palpable. Justice is draconian and one sees plenty of soldiers and officers from the Kriger bloodline in the cities. The factories manufacture weapons, ammunition and vehicles intended for war and criminals are dispatched almost immediately to the trenches north of the mountains or to massive labor camps.

History

Vadaja was long a divided realm ruled by warlords who fought against each other and against the kingdoms in the south. They were barbaric and savage but when sporadic trade with Darost was established, the culture slowly changed. The people became more united and when Ritzka Brana, daughter of the great warlord Karlov, married Morav Rötz, the rebel leader, Vadaja was officially proclaimed a kingdom.

Throughout history, not much has been noticed of Vadaja except when the realm made sporadic attacks against its neighboring countries, primarily Madrostav. Internal conflicts have taken up all the time and the leaders have often been assassinated, deposed or unrecognized.

When the enemy from the north attacked with its fleet, warlords from Vadaja seized the opportunity to attack and plunder several of Madrostav's cities. However, diplomats from Darost caused the attacks to cease and instead large numbers of soldiers from Vadaja were hired to participate in the battle at the Mirror Sea where the enemy had conquered large areas. The then warlord of Vadaja, Kriger the Black, personally led the battle and personally performed several great deeds on the battlefields. He was also the one who agreed that Vadaja should unite together with the other kingdoms into a massive state in order to crush the enemy.

The unification of Vadaja went more easily than expected, the realm's rulers embraced the bureaucratic system with goodwill as its strict rules gave the realm stability and kept the people in order. A massive rearmament began as they knew the enemy was north of the Arkady Mountains. Hundreds of labor camps and mining towns were formed together with weapons factories and training grounds for the new army.

When the time came, the soldiers were led through the winding mountain passes of the Arkady Mountains and to the northern plains where the enemy held position. The clashes became brutal and millions died during the war's first years. Soon they found that the offensive was too costly and that the enemy's forces were numerous, their morale was strong and their courage admirable.

A drawn-out trench war began which continues to this day. Previously, livestock keeping and agriculture during the short summers were what sustained Vadaja but nowadays all food is imported from the south while the self-sufficient farmers are nearly gone. Hundreds of thousands of inhabitants in the province have died of starvation or been forced to the cities where there is at least a chance of survival. Most are forced into substandard work at the factories, become homeless or are recruited into the army. The houses in the poorer quarters are overcrowded and people are forced to live like animals. The population has in recent decades declined drastically and the crematorium furnaces are always running and stain the cities' snow-covered rooftops with black ash.

Resources

The mountains in the north have plenty of precious metals and also iron ore, nickel, lead, uranium, zinc and copper. The province has well-developed railway tracks used for transporting the extracted riches. Communications are otherwise poor, the roads are impassable unless one has terrain-adapted vehicles, and the telephone lines between cities are often knocked out.

The province is characterized by war, it is the Imperium's last outpost to the enemy in the north and the military presence is very strong. There are plenty of fortresses embedded in the mountains, secret airfields and Stapo agents looking for traitors. Desperate deserters often try to hide in the mountain regions but sheltering them is considered high treason and is punishable by death. The people are held under the State's boot, public executions and cruel punishments are part of daily life. There are plenty of forbidden military testing areas where the army tests everything from bombs to new types of field weapons and nerve gases.

The Church has begun to gain increasingly greater influence despite being opposed by the State. The people need something to console themselves with and many secretly attend services and masses, especially the poor and sick. The people have a history of rebellion behind them and this worries the State. It is said that church leaders are threatened or disappear and that state commissars are in charge of all investigations concerning the church.

Mikalburg

On the southern side of the northern Arkady Mountains, by the crystal-clear Moon Lake, lies the stately military city of Mikalburg. With its massive monuments over war heroes, its state supremacy, its magnificent buildings and its broad parade streets, it gives a mighty impression. This is Vadaja's center, more modern and beautiful than any of the realm's other cities. Here is the military command that conducts the war against the enemy in the north and all bloodlines are represented in their own, stately palaces.

Near the city's center lies the Kriger mausoleum with its silvered dome, where the body of the warlord Kriger the Black lies. The military marches around the city and displays its greatness and strength on holidays and in the sky one sees flight squadrons in formation. At the same time, it is a cold and gray city where chilly winds sweep down between the granite buildings and military control is total. People who don't fit into the societal picture, the poor, sick or people of the wrong sort are kept away from the streets and live in the city's outer parts.

In the mountains north of the city there are several forts embedded in the slopes and behind barriers are military airfields and garrisons. Trains from the south arrive daily to the city and an important zeppelin line makes journeys to Sandukar relatively quick. This makes Mikalburg seen as a central place despite its geographically remote location.

Salen

Salen is one of the most notorious mining towns in Vadaja, known for its isolated location and the enormous amounts of iron ore and copper mined in the surrounding mountains. It is a frozen place where snow falls from the low clouds and soot from smelting plants and machines stains the mountainsides. The city is relatively small with low houses that spread out on both sides of the Bader River where cargo barges depart and arrive several times daily. The workers are divided into different city districts depending on which company they work for and far from all workers get along with their competitors.

The wages are good but many are injured or even die in the heavy work. During free time, workers usually seek out one of the bars, gambling dens or brothels. The work crews that achieve the best yields are offered free liquor or female entertainment by their employers. Several different mining companies compete for resources and workers, conflicts that sometimes lead to direct violence. The current power struggle concerns the mining company Junger, which is laying a railway through the wilderness toward Salen. If this railway line is completed, Junger can transport significantly more ore more safely and quickly to the southern parts of the realm than any of the other mining companies.

Northern Arkady Mountains

The Northern Arkady Mountains are a massive gray mountain range, largely impassable and uninhabited. The highest peaks are covered in eternal frost-death and even the valleys are barren and almost completely devoid of life. Storm winds echo between the cliff faces which are drenched by acid rain. During winter, many of the mountain passes are covered with snow and the rumble from the thundering avalanches can be heard far out on the plains.

Below the mountains, dying coniferous forests spread out as a result of emissions from the countless mining towns. The trees are usually just husks, homes for masses of pest insects that exterminate all living things in the area.

The Kesenik Pass

In the northern Arkady Mountains lies the crooked Kesenik Pass which is surrounded by vertical granite walls. In the middle of the pass runs a cold river and along the rocky sides roads have been carved out. The Kesenik Pass is constantly guarded. Here several important battles have taken place, the enemy has time and again tried to push through the pass and has several times been close to succeeding. Hundreds of thousands of soldiers on both sides have fought and died between these cold cliff walls and everywhere one can find grenade fragments, bullet holes, rusty cartridge casings, blown-up vehicle wrecks and fragile skulls.

The Arvald Camp

In the middle of the plains, by one of the smaller side tracks, lies several barracks behind barbed wire fencing and watchtowers. Prisoners are sent out by train from the camp to different areas along the line; in winter to shovel snow so that trains can get through, in summer to dig up brown coal near the surface.

The Arvald Camp is known for its sadistic prison guards and for the diseases that ravage among the inmates. Many freeze to death during the winters or die during disciplinary punishments. The prison camp is divided into a male and a female section but it has come to light several times that male guards have entered the female part of the camp and assaulted the prisoners.

The Arvald Camp is feared by criminals and most soldiers dread having to serve there - although some cruel souls see the camp as an excellent place to give outlet to their personal lusts.

Languages in the Imperium

Several languages are spoken within the gigantic Imperium's borders.

Iskara

Iskara is the common language in the Imperium, which almost everyone speaks. All state papers are issued in this language and if one cannot communicate in Iskara it is virtually impossible to get by in society.

Ketish

Ketish has its origin in Madrostav and is still used within the church throughout the Imperium.

Malish

Malish is an extinct language that scholars have not yet succeeded in piecing together.

Orish

Orish is the celenka ethnic group's own language, which few outsiders understand.

Presish Runic Script

In Presvedonia there are remnants of the Presish runic script which is said to have an ancient religious significance.

Presveda

In eastern Presvedonia, the Presveda language has experienced an upswing since the province broke free from the Imperium.

Vadask

Vadask is spoken in a few isolated places in the northern parts of the Imperium, primarily near the northern Arkady Mountains.

Old Sadovish

Old Sadovish is an ancient language originating in Sadovia. Some literature is still written in this language but it is directed at the Sadovian upper class in general and the Arkady bloodline in particular.

I had just put my feet up on the desk, poured a glass of whiskey into an almost clean glass and lit an imported cigar when there was a light knock on the frosted glass of the door. My grip on the automatic pistol behind the desk tightened as I called out loudly "Come in."

I realized immediately when I saw her that this would mean trouble. She was upper class. Tailored, dark clothes, handmade heeled shoes. Sunglasses, despite the rain pouring down outside. The black coat was hung up with an elegant movement and quickly she seemed to survey my office with her gaze. The glasses and hat she placed on a bureau. She had long deep red hair, not for a second did I believe it could be her own. Expensive, discreet jewelry adorned her smooth skin.

She walked steadily to the visitor's chair, quickly brushed off the cushion with her gloved hand and sat down, with crossed legs. The skirt's slit slid apart and revealed a pair of very expensive, thigh-high, black nylon stockings with matching garter belt, also black, caressing her well-formed thighs. She noted that I was staring, she smiled and I smiled contemptuously back. Her smile suddenly stiffened and became serious. Hard, almost clenched.

"You are Mr. Jandaran, are you not?" "The same." "If your reputation is true, then I am in need of a man like you." "Which reputation? I am a jack-of-all-trades—private eye, hired muscle, scout, lover, the choice is yours."

Her makeup was perfect. The bruise by the eye was invisible to anyone not looking for it. She opened her handbag and expertly produced a cigarette from a silver case. Smoothly I took out matches from my pocket and she nodded, pleasantly surprised.

When she leaned forward to meet the warm flame it played across her face. I had been right. The surgical scar had not quite healed. She was probably at least ten or fifteen years older than she looked, so she was over fifty. But she was beautiful and fresh. Had the offer come at another time I would not have refused her company, with room service and champagne.

"It's a story about money, violence and sex." "It probably doesn't surprise you, but I have heard that story many times before." "Perhaps so. In any case, I have encountered a, how shall we say, a problem." "How fortunate, as I solve problems." "Excellent. It is a person, a stranger, who has hurt me." "You shouldn't trust strangers." "Everyone is a stranger when we meet them for the first time."

The words hung in the air while she scrutinized me. The way she did it both burned and gave ice-cold shivers along my spine. She seemed satisfied, relaxed somewhat and blew out a smoke ring that dispersed on its journey toward the ceiling.

"I have heard that you like money?" "Of course. I only work for money." "Only?" "Yes, carnal love and cheap liquor don't pay the rent."

She leaned forward slightly. The expensive earrings rattled somewhat. Her voice lowered to a whisper. "I have a lot of money." "I'm happy for you."

She smiled a dazzling white smile and laughed with relief. From her bag she took out a stack of bills and placed it in the middle of the desk. I studied the thick stack quietly while I continued sipping the cheap liquor. Her gaze was focused on me. Waiting.

She means trouble. But it's worth it. After all, my job is to fix problems.

The heart, brain and blood of the State. The Beast's will, desires and cravings. As one unit, a crawling mass, the clans' tentacles exist in the Empire's foundations. Its blocked possibilities and inability to show compassion stem from the administrative hell that is its defense and survival.

The Clans

The seven clans are powerful and influential factions within the Empire. Once upon a time they are believed to have been rulers over their own kingdoms but since the State took control they now function as an integrated part of its machinery. Still they have connections to the provinces where they once reigned, though not as tangible as power has been focused to the city of Sandukar.

In the state machinery each clan has been given its own area of influence over which they have special responsibility. The clans are however so large and influential that they all have some control in all of society's areas. This is also a deliberate plan to prevent one clan from gaining unrestricted power at the expense of the others.

The clans are built up of countless families, connected to each other through marriage, blood ties or oaths. Individuals can also be adopted into a family as needed and thus become part of the clan. It is the clan families that jointly put forth the clan's will and perform the majority of the work and administration.

The clan families have influence over several parts of society. They run companies, hold administrative positions at various ministries, control trade and production and in some cases engage in illegal activity in the underworld. Much of their work happens in the shadows and many times ordinary citizens work for the clans without knowing it themselves.

To be employed by a clan, or a company controlled by a clan, is very common. Sometimes it doesn't show at all but often the person in question must swear themselves to the clan during their employment and is expected to show the clan loyalty and obedience. The higher up one is as an employee the more secure one can feel. This naturally does not apply to the lifers who do the rough jobs but rather their foremen and overseers.

A search in the archives shows that with the State's formation, several approaches and procedures were standardized between the clans, as well as state titles and their meanings. Previously each province had its own methods for deciding, judging and executing various actions and appointments.

The seven clans

In state law it is written that each clan has a head who shall be voted forth within the clan. When the time comes to choose a new head (usually after the old head has died) this brings with it diplomatic actions, intrigues, assassinations and power games. To be able to reach the position as head one must have plenty of money, powerful contacts and political acumen. The different clans have their own titles for the head.

The clans' power is easy to see in the Empire. A high member of a clan can usually commit the gravest crimes and still get away as long as the crimes don't harm the State or are directed at other clans. The clans resolve conflicts between each other through diplomacy or in special higher court instances where power and influence determine the verdict's outcome.

What can be very damaging for persons and clans who commit crimes is the social backlash criminal actions can cause— with shame and ostracism as a result. Not infrequently the person's property and assets are also confiscated.

It should be added that the clans are very skilled at silencing scandals—through either bribes, threats or assassinations.

Even though ordinary society's problems rarely affect members of the clans, the relationships between the clans can be everything from good to outright hostile. No open conflicts between the clans are tolerated by

the State and the rulers but in the hidden conspiracies and intrigue-making occur to gain as much power as possible. Not even within one's own clan can one be safe as there are internal conflicts even within the families. Thus there is always a degree of suspicion between all members of the clans. Caution is a virtue and the higher up one comes in the organization the greater intrigues one becomes drawn into.

Arkady

Under the gothic vaulted arches walks the woman of clan Arkady. She is guardian of ancient knowledge and bringer of laws and ordinances. Few have as good insight as she into bureaucracy's winding web but then she is also the spider sitting in its center. To rule in the hidden, to let shadows and ignorance be one's allies makes it possible to achieve great deeds. Even the other clans fear her and her clan. Arkady's breath follows the State's will and her whispers slay those who stand in her way. The others may feast among the living, she herself has found knowledge in suffering souls and occult secrets. Pleasure and happiness are for the weak-minded.

Arkady is the most powerful clan but its power does not rest in wealth or troops—it is its insight into bureaucracy's nature and shortcuts as well as learning in the occult and forbidden knowledge that makes them influential. The clan constitutes the very backbone of the State and in the highest political positions one can find its members. The clan controls the justice system and has according to some underground periodicals close ties to the Commissariat.

Arkady's presence can be found in all major cities and the clan also resides in the eastern Arkady mountains, in its original province Sadovia.

The membership number is significantly lower than with the other clans. Arkady does not take as many servants and the families that stand close to the clan are small.

The clan's high seat consists of a cathedral-like building in Sandukar's center, in the district The Book. The building is constantly guarded and houses several forbidden libraries and storage vaults. The clan's head is duchess Erzse-beate van Straker de Arkady, also maliciously called the "cat-witch", who has ruled for nearly 40 years. Few have ever seen her as she rarely leaves the high seat.

Member of a clan

There is no actual support in Noir's core rulebook for playing a member of a clan. Of course the narrator can allow this but then all protagonists should be offered this privilege.

As a member of a clan one has many benefits but also obligations that the narrator must take into account. If a protagonist wants connections to one of the clans the narrator can instead let him/her be employed by it. In either case the protagonist's relationships and other traits should be tied to his/her clan affiliation.

It is worth remembering that it can give at least as much trouble as benefit to be sworn to a clan. Persons tied to other clans will be extremely cautious when dealing with the protagonist but at the same time they may refrain from harming him/her as they may fear reprisals from the clan.

Anya Malov brushed the jet-black hair away from the man's face. He was still breathing, but painfully and rattling. She had during the fierce hand-to-hand combat kicked him out through the window on the third floor but a slanted roof had cushioned his fall. Now she stood over him in the alley with a pistol to his temple—this was him, the murderer, she was certain of it.

Glass shards lay like ice crystals in his hair and over his badly battered suit. Everything indicated that he was well-off—too well-off to be in this decrepit district. She felt with practiced hands through his clothing and found in addition to a silver-plated revolver also a slender knife in a hidden sheath on his arm. She took them from him, the knife would surely prove to be the same weapon that killed the prostitutes.

In the jacket's inner pocket she found his citizen's passport, in a wallet that was swimming with zovrins. She involuntarily recoiled when she realized that the man who lay at her feet was of clan Arkady.

She knew instantly what she had to do, no judges would ever convict him. A muscle movement and the bullet from her Breer would create justice. The seconds passed, she backed away, the fall injuries might already be killing him. She was not his executioner but he would have to manage on his own and the chance was good that he would not survive the chilly night. She walked toward the car as the snow began to fall.

Gabriel Jandaran knocked cautiously on the decrepit apartment door. Paint flakes came loose and fell onto the worn wooden floor in the corridor. He heard children screaming from the floor below. The bouquet in his hand smelled fresh. The door opened and he looked into Anya's beautiful eyes. She wore a simple, freshly washed blouse and a pair of well-fitting pants. Light makeup, but she was a natural beauty. Her lithe, well-trained body made her posture almost militarily correct. She smiled at him. His mouth went dry. She raised one eyebrow questioningly. A bit too eagerly, he held out the flowers and smiled.

"Happy birthday Anya, you look fantastic. How does it feel to no longer be a teenager?"

She smiled at his silly compliment and accepted the flowers.

"Thanks Gabriel, I see you dressed up, I said it was informal. But come in, the sisters are already here. Mordekai should arrive any moment."

He stepped inside, looked into the spartanly furnished living room. In an old sofa sat one of the Navarre sisters, the older of the two, Jessca. She sat cross-legged and looked up at Gabriel, met his gaze. The sorrowful eyes had something hard in them, but he at least got a brief smile back before she looked away. Jessca was difficult. Gabriel didn't know much about her except that she was often serious, melancholic and taciturn. She was slender in build and didn't take up much space. But she had another side too, one of boldness and aggression. He had seen it once and it was a complete transformation. Moreover, she was hell with a knife; fast, reflexive, deadly—both close up and at a distance. But she didn't let many into her life, that was certain. He had never seen her with any man. She was comfortable having plenty of space between herself and the people around her. Gabriel had met the sisters at a private party at a wealthy industrialist's a few years ago during a case like any other. But something made them seek each other out now and then.

Gabriel moved to the hostess's sparse selection of alcohol, and chose a glass of whiskey with ice. In the kitchen Anya was working on something in the oven. The scent of grilled meat spread through the apartment and Gabriel noticed how hungry he was.

Behind the door to Anya's bedroom the sound of a receiver being placed on a telephone could be heard and shortly thereafter Talia Navarre swept out. She truly was an apparition. Gabriel stood as if frozen by her direct eye contact and the perfectly measured, veiled smile she gave him. The black, slender dress accentuated every detail of her shapely body. She smiled again when she noticed the effect she had on him and winked one eye.

"I see the party is getting better and better."

She approached Gabriel, brushed past him and poured herself a stiff drink. Her perfume made him dizzy and involuntarily he felt desire for her. Discreetly she moved her hand across his thigh and giggled delightedly while looking at him over the rim of the glass. He noticed how Anya looked at him with a dubious expression and suddenly he felt uneasy.

Talia was dangerous. More dangerous than any of the gangsters he had worked for. She was, like her sister, difficult, but on a completely different level. It was impossible to gain control over a situation where she was involved, she was always at least two steps ahead and seemed to know with playful ease exactly how she should act to make men become like mice in her cat-like presence. She had something vulnerable in her personality, something disarming, something that made one expose oneself and risk being destroyed. Gabriel took a step away from her when there was a hard knock on the door. Anya put down a steaming pot on the counter.

"That must be Mordekai."

She opened the door and let in the evening's last guest. It was a broad-shouldered, coarse and powerful man, with a shaved head and an almost devious look. He took off a worn coat and revealed a chalk-white, starched shirt and a pair of suit pants. With a brief grunt he handed over a brown paper bag to Anya, who thanked him and accepted the clinking present.

Mordekai and Gabriel had known each other for almost a decade. They often moved in the same circles, far down among society's dregs. The muscular brute could take care of himself, he fought readily and often and took on seemingly hopeless tasks and solved them. His surly and somewhat grumpy attitude made many dismiss him as a dimwit, something he gladly let them believe. Gabriel knew that in that large body were hidden many dark secrets and sides that Mordekai didn't talk to anyone about. But toward Gabriel, who was the one who had introduced him and Anya to each other, he had always been decent and Gabriel trusted him more than most others he knew. He nodded welcomingly to Mordekai and observed the large man while he gave the women in the room each a bear hug and then sat down as first man at the table, eager to eat of the fragrant roast.

Later they sat, the five of them, around the table. They ate and drank, talked and laughed, entertained themselves and enjoyed the experience. Their innermost thoughts, dark demons and dreary experiences were for this evening pushed aside by the fellowship they felt with each other. The five came from completely different places and had taken their own paths in life, made tough decisions and regretted many times. But they would all remember this evening, in a run-down apartment in Ikonen's poorer parts, as an evening of joy and companionship.

The majority of families within the clan are of the Arkara people and they have preserved much of their culture. This makes them stand out in society with their odd customs and practices. They usually go dressed in black, strict clothing. When they move outside their halls and chambers they usually wear a black bone mask over the face to conceal their appearance.

Using the correct title of honor in conversation is crucial to being able to hold a conversation with anyone from clan Arkady. To ignore this is a breach of etiquette without equal. One seldom finds representatives from clan Arkady at social gatherings as members are withdrawn and vigilant.

Hrůzda

In the deepest and darkest parts of eastern Sadovia, high up among the Arkady mountains, the Hrůzda family has its seat. Hrůzda rules over the domains the lineage has administered for centuries and rumors in the countryside whisper that family members are involved in diabolical rites, occultism and black magic. Moreover, they are said to be guardians of forbidden knowledge.

The members of the Hrůzda family are respected and feared within their own clan. The people in the area have an almost panicked fear of them and see them as punishing demons. In recent times family members have sought out Sandukar to explore the modern world, many of them devoting themselves to art and authorship.

Markal

Markal was previously a family that owned very great power as it in practice controlled the Maurist branch of the church that dominated Sadovia and a number of surrounding countries. The family had great influence and plenty of money and devoted much time and resources to the struggle against the Janost branch. When the State was formed and Maurism was banned, the family's power was split. Even though the members themselves do not acknowledge it, they still have great influence over the church's affairs and many priests secretly follow the Maurist doctrine.

Sapal

Sapal has earned a great fortune from trade along the Copper River and owns several ships that transport timber and iron ore to Sandukar. In the cargo it is said that one can also find illegal goods, spies and weapons but Sapal has through its contacts managed to wriggle out of all problems with justice.

Sapal is the most social of the families within clan Arkady and can sometimes be seen in public. Family members have also entered the clothing industry and are known for their tailored suits which are also common on women.

Straker

Straker is a smaller family that only exists in Sandukar and that only corresponds with Sadovia via intermediaries. According to an ancient agreement, family members are not allowed to return to their homeland after a bloody conflict with the other families in the clan.

Straker's ancestors were those who planned the construction and architectural design of the seven towers and canals in Sandukar. The family still controls the main city planning and eyewitnesses in the city's poorer parts claim that expeditions from the family have been seen wandering down into the sewer systems, carrying a lot of bulky equipment.

Valka

The Valka family has a bloody history of conquest, war and cruel deeds, something its members are very proud of. The family's fortune is great thanks to centuries of plundering neighboring realms. But fortune from the past does not strengthen the family name and many family members now fight at the eastern front with their soldiers to relive old times of glory and slaughter on the battlefield. Members of the Valka family always carry edged weapons, often swords or daggers.

Valka earns large sums of money from the timber industry and slowly but surely fells stately, ancient forests to manufacture furniture and paper.

Vrazdi

The Vrazdi family has its seat in Sandukar and controls large parts of the justice system regarding the judicial order and the establishment of laws. Most family members keep isolated and move almost exclusively with persons of their own clan. It is said to be Vrazdi who control the state Commissariat but there is of course no evidence for this claim.

Zabran

The Zabran family's wealth previously rested on slave trading but in recent times, especially after Presvedonia's revolt, the family has chosen a different direction. Its slaves are placed in labor camps and factories and the family now drives industrialization in Sadovia. Weapons are manufactured for the war at the fronts and the family has started up its own zeppelin fleet that travels between Sadovia and Sandukar.

Guiskard

The masquerade was in full swing despite the midnight hour having long since passed. Still whirling dressed-up women and men in each other's arms to the dance's suggestive music. In alcoves and secluded rooms at the hotel the ball's visitors sought further in more intimate dances, some two by two, others in groups. Bureaucrats, film stars, police chiefs and gangsters were all invited to participate as long as they were rich and powerful and let themselves be carried away by lust and passion. The woman from clan Guiskard pulled her strings and spread poisonous rumors. She flirted with the film producer who promised her a role in the upcoming major film and simultaneously blackmailed his partner for dark purposes. Many pacts had been made in this night of decadence and desire.

Guiskard is the most social of all the clans. It has a multitude of subfamilies with great influence among the rich and powerful in the Empire. Guiskard controls the media and the information that is spread and the clan's imprint is clearly felt within the Ministry of Truth. Guiskard owns a majority of all newspapers, publishing houses, film studios, fashion houses and entertainment establishments in the Empire.

The clan is spread across all provinces but mainly keeps to the cities and seldom moves at the lower social levels unless special pleasures beckon. Guiskard has

a predilection for controlling the underworld where they attempt to control prostitution, drug trade, slave trade and the arrangement of forbidden pleasures. The clan's headquarters is an enormous palace, called Dream-land, located in the Center. The palace, which consists of a doz-en ornate buildings, has multiple ballrooms, an opera house, hotel, well-maintained parks as well as numerous secret spaces and places of pleasure. The clan's head, Prince Malkom Harakat, has multiple luxurious residences in and outside the city but can often be found at various events at the clan's seat. The clan is regarded by most other clans as deca-dent, perverse and manipulative — but it performs its duties well even if it sometimes lets passion override the laws. Guiskard is also the clan with the most intrigue within it — things like slander, blackmail and assassination attempts are not uncommon if one has angered the wrong people. The clan's members are very concerned about their appearance and spend considerable time on choosing the right clothes and hairstyles. It is Guiskard that controls fashion and it is them the people and the other clans try to emulate. Many people within the clan are also well-known from media, several of them have appeared in films and/or featured on tabloid front pages. **Cateur** The Cateur family owns some of the largest film companies in the Empire and produces high-quality films with moral messages and state educational activities on behalf of the Ministry of Truth. It is said that one cannot become a true star until one has been discovered by someone within the Cateur family. Many of the family's members are known by the common man, some are film stars while others

are notorious producers and directors. It is Cateur that creates most of the documentary newsreels shown at the cinemas. Cateur is also a brand synonymous with luxury items such as ladies' underwear, perfume and chocolate. **Darcy** The Darcy family is known for its influence in fashion houses and clothing factories — its members are seen as pioneers when it comes to style, taste and trends and always go dressed in the very latest. Besides the Darcy clothing brand there are several other exclusive clothing brands bearing the names of influential people within the family. The members of the Darcy family are often seen in public and are known for arranging large parties and fashion shows. The family has very well-renowned butler and servant schools, whose students become known for their skill and discretion. **Dekere** Within the Dekere family almost all members engage in politics on one level or another. They are involved in the State and active in the cabinet and various enterprises, but also spend much time at social events where they make connections and display their wealth and extravagance. The family has several times been embroiled in scandal due to crude statements and obvious oppressive tendencies, which has resulted in conflicts with other families, other clans and even within the family. The conflicts have often ended in mudslinging, betrayal and assassination. Dekere has recently earned large sums from the vehicle industry as the car brand bearing the family name has become a popular car among the upper middle class. **Fauss** The Fauss family owns many of the most exclusive restaurants and food stores in Sandukar. Fauss imports delicacies from all corners of the empire and several exclusive vineyards and liquor brands bear the family's name. Family members are often out at social events and are known as decadent gluttons when it comes to alcohol, food, tobacco and sex. **Kuinn** Many of the major newspapers and news agencies in the Empire are under the influence of the Kuinn family. The family uses the written word to conceal scandals, spread lies and manipulate its opponents. The family also has a large fortune from the time when they had a monopoly on textile trade from the east. Today information is the family's commodity, as is the spreading of disinformation. Kuinn is also a well-known cigar brand. **Palisar** Palisar is one of the smaller families that earns a large portion of its money from pornography, erotic literature and clothing. Above all men at the front read the Palisar family's richly illustrated books and at seedy porn theaters in the cities one perversity after another is shown in the family's name. The members of the family are known for decadence and erotic escapades and both the men and women are known for being skilled in the art of seduction. Palisar is also a well-known fashion name and besides tailored overcoats and suits they have a large selection of underwear of an erotic nature. **Revenir** Outwardly the Revenir family engages in real estate business and trade but it is an open secret that large sums of money come in from illegal business in the underworld. The family controls large parts of Sandukar's drug trade and has influence over prostitution on the streets. The Revenir family is somewhat ill-regarded within its own clan. The only real allies the family has is Palisar. Few dare to cross Revenir who thanks to contacts, information and influence can strike hard and brutally against its opponents. **Kriger** The machinery of war is driven by human blood, will and fury. Sacrifices must be made in the struggle to preserve the Empire. Soldiers must suffer and die to maintain the balance. The General from clan Kriger regards the map that lies before him. His gaze sweeps over the northern front — trenches, ruined cities, bunkers and fortifications. A hell of mud and rusty barbed wire. He looks up and puts his monocle in the uniform's breast pocket. The adjutants and advisors stand at strict attention along the walls. The General feels their fear and despises it. With a cold voice he gives orders to advance on all battle lines. The orders are noted down and then telegraphed out to the hungry and tired men in the trenches. The General then orders his car to be brought forth. He wants to be present himself to observe the slaughter. Clan Kriger has primary responsibility for the Empire's armies. It is an important part of the State and stands close to clan Arkady, but more as subordinate than as equal. The clan is relatively large and many of the members sit in high positions in the army and at the Ministry of War. There are also plenty of engineers, inventors and technological innovators within the clan who construct machines of destruction and weapons. The clan has influence in the cities but one finds many of the members at the fronts and at forts out in the wastelands. They are disciplined and tyrannical and within the clan a draconian and swift justice system is applied. When

discipline falters the members often fall prey to senseless rage and an unquenchable bloodthirst. Not infrequently the younger officers within the clan personally lead the soldiers across the battlefield. The clan's administrative headquarters consists of a black concrete skyscraper in the center of Sandukar, decorated with symbols and statues of influential clan members. To the skyscraper, called the Horn, all information is sent and here are also the most skilled tacticians as well as the clan's head Archduke Sebastien van Gralen-Kriger. The clan has little control in society except in the military domain. The members do however have some social status as they are seen as brave heroes fighting for the Empire's preservation. The clan has very few internal conflicts but is somewhat rigid as members seldom do anything that doesn't follow all laws and regulations to the letter. Few want to antagonize them even though quite a bit of intrigue happens behind their backs. Kriger's members usually wear strict suits, dresses or uniforms in everyday life, their straight posture, well-trained bodies and somewhat stiff manner usually reveal which clan they belong to. Decorations and medals are displayed with pride. They often carry concealed weapons to whatever event it may be. **Brana** In the northern Arkady mountains lies the Brana family's golden calf. The family owns several large mining companies and earns ample sums of money from the valuable metals they mine. In the cities the family has begun competing with clan Zovrin and challenging the banking system. Its riches are used to erect monuments and raise statues in memory of great battles and significant ancestors. Unlike most families within clan Kriger where women have a hidden role, the Brana family has several high-ranking women in its ranks who all hold significant positions in society.

Gault

The notorious Gault family earns large sums of money from its labor camps where undesirable people toil without either pay or rights. The family also has several mining enterprises and is known for terrible deals and miserable conditions. The family has great influence in Vadaja but relatively little presence in Sandukar. People within the Gault family are known for being sadistic, racist and in many ways totally emotionally cold toward the suffering of others. **Gralen** The backbone of the Empire's army is in many ways made up of the Gralen family and its military leaders. The family has great influence over the military and most training camps where soldiers receive their basic training are under its control. The family has also managed to earn money from the wars and the equipment they require. Gralen owns factories where seamstresses sit in rows sewing uniforms, manufacturing canteens, tents, tarpaulins and other things needed in the field. The Gralen family has become a beast that feeds itself. The members of the family are very proud of their history and have great knowledge of their ancestors' exploits. **Hauser** The Empire's largest weapons manufacturer is the Hauser family, which manufactures everything from automatic pistols to fragmentation bombs, artillery units and mines. Family members have an almost loving attitude toward their firearms and it is said that hell closes the day one encounters a member of the Hauser family who willingly goes unarmed. Hauser owns several factories around the Empire but has the greatest influence in Vadaja and Sandukar. Recently the family has entered the film industry and produced several violent action films where their weapons are extensively used and where the state flag is held high. **Kaldberg** The Kaldberg family has a long and bloody history as warlords and ravagers. They still have cavalry units under their control and rely on old methods with lightning strikes, guerrilla warfare and sabotage to achieve their goals. The family is unreliable and has several times betrayed agreements and regulations to instead grab riches and avenge old wrongs. It has gained increased influence in the army recently and handles much of the logistics along the northern railways. **Rötz** The Rötz family is often called the steel kings of the north. Even though the family doesn't have such great influence over the mining itself, it is the one that smelts the metal and transports it across the empire. Rötz has several large factories that produce everything from nuts to entire ships. Recently the family's engineers have begun working to develop tanks for the army that will change the static trench wars. For being of clan Kriger, Rötz is a relatively social family whose members can often be seen in various contexts in Sandukar.

Beloved Max, I have painful news. As you suspected I have earlier in my life, before we met and you opened my eyes, done things I am not proud of, things that I knew would come back later. Now it has happened. I feel close to you now, now that I open myself to you. A vile man who ensnared me, beat me and humiliated me, a man I fled from, has found me. He will kill me as he is not a man who takes lightly the fact that I escaped his wrath. But we have a chance! I managed to lure him to the other end of the city so we have the chance to flee together. We can take your car and the cash you said you had at home in the safe? We can build a future together, somewhere else, just the two of us. Come to the harbor, to our place. I long for you and need you, more than ever! Yours forever —Talia

Turga

The dreaded Turga family has its fingers in many affairs. Unlike most other families within the Kriger line, they own no large mining operations or factories. Instead, they have focused on administration and state information management. Turga is clearly the family within the line that has the greatest insight into the state bureaucracy, and its members hold positions as bureaucrats and politicians, high-ranking military officers and police. They maintain discipline among soldiers and search for dissidents. They often keep to the cities, where they have power over police and private security firms, or to the fronts where they research psychological warfare and conduct interrogations of prisoners. The family is known for having close contact with the Arkady line, and it is said that many state commissars have their origin among the members, something representatives from the Ministry of Truth nervously laugh at. **Mengal** The woman on the steel gurney screams as the narrow drill penetrates her temple. The scream turns into a gurgle and the woman's gaze becomes empty. Instruments are inserted. The operation proceeds quickly. Part of the brain is cut apart. A syringe injects chemicals. Then the skin flaps are sewn together. The man from the Mengal line smiles contentedly. The lobotomies are becoming ever more effective. The lifers owned by the line can now be programmed to become obedient workers, pleasure slaves, and loyal soldiers who lack fear. The man walks with his escort away from the tiled laboratory and its antiseptic air. He stops by the tall windows and gazes out over the factory city—his domains. Against the vault of heaven stretch hundreds of chimneys spewing out their sooty smoke. Soot flakes drift down over the workers' quarters like black snow. Never has he seen anything so beautiful. Factories and labor camps are the Mengal line's domains. Under the line members' supervision, the wilderness's raw materials are transformed into architectural wonders and all manner of utilitarian objects. On vast rail yards, locomotives and train cars are built, in air hangars zeppelins are constructed, and on assembly lines motor vehicles are manufactured. The line members themselves sit leaning back and decide what shall be built. The line has several subfamilies, but most of the workers are lifers who wear themselves out without either wages or rights. Within the line there are plenty of doctors and psychologists who have studied the human body and the human psyche and developed several methods for lobotomy and mind control that make the workers become will-less and harmless. The line is spread across all cities but has its headquarters in Sandukar, in the first sector of the Machine Cities. Here they have a seat of concrete, steel, and cogwheels where administration is conducted. The seat houses tens of thousands of workplaces and is ironically called Paradise in common parlance. Mengal's head, Archiatrist Nadya van Arghezi, oversees all the line's undertakings and is a feared woman in the Empire, as her opponents have a tendency to disappear so without a trace that not even the overarchivists can find documentation. Recently the line has begun using the workers to create will-less soldiers, which is viewed with great concern primarily by the Kriger line, as one cannot know how capable the soldiers are and what the line might think to use them for. Members of the Mengal line encountered at social events have a tendency to be pale and thin. They wear fashionable clothes but often lack the social charm and elegance that most other lines possess. **Alexos** The Alexos family has a connection to the Janoistic part of the church, even though many members have openly renounced religion. Instead, the family has tried to focus on administration and education—its members hold

high positions at most major universities, medical schools, and libraries. The family rests on very old knowledge, even such as is officially forbidden, and uses this knowledge to bargain politically with other families and lines. **Arghezi** The family within the Mengal line that has the most contact with members of other lines is without question the Arghezi family. The members often operate in public and function as diplomats and advisors and own several large industries. The Arghezi family devotes much time to trade and buys raw materials to then sell finished products. Part of the family manages a large portion of Sandukar's meat production and owns a large number of livestock farms and slaughterhouses. **Eviza** The Eviza family has achieved great success in research in medicine and pharmaceuticals. The members study human organs and how to best strengthen and destroy them, for as much as they are researchers in life, they are pioneers in death. Members of the Eviza family have great knowledge of how to use chemical gases as weapons, and at the fronts they conduct their hideous experiments. They also research how to alter humans through mutation and breeding to create a super race. Eviza's institutions in Sandukar are always well-guarded. **Harlos** Insular, wealthy, and utterly fearless are designations that fit well the members of the Harlos family. They have carried out several bold projects and are now leading in the development of flying machines for the army and for private use. They invest large sums in constructing more efficient flying machines and more precise weaponry and hope that air dominance will one day become as important as the infantry strength corps' conquests. The family has also earned some money from the car and motorcycle industry, particularly when it comes to the robust products sold to the army. **Luri** The well-off Luri family is known for its architectural creations and vast mechanical constructions. When it comes to dams, coal power plants, mining equipment, and the science of durability and construction, the family is world-leading.

Luri owns large amounts of real estate, and many of the members are architects and engineers. Recently they have bought up several radio channels and newspapers, which has given them an influence over media that has in turn driven them into conflict with the Guiskard line. **Mugrona** The dreaded Mugrona family has for a long time concentrated on the human psyche and the best way to keep it enslaved. The members control several companies that in turn have control over factories and labor camps where the lifer workers get to function as experimental subjects. Many within the family are skilled in medicine and psychology and use lobotomy, chemicals, and hypnosis to create efficient and will-less servants. Recently great progress has been made in directing the servants toward different tasks in order to thus create capable workers, passionate pleasure slaves, and will-less soldiers. **Verdos** The Verdos family is known throughout the Empire for its vast zeppelins. The family was the first to take to the skies with its airships and has maintained dominance over air traffic since then. In secret, the members work against the Harlos family while simultaneously researching in secret their own types of flying machines and more modern zeppelins that shall be able to travel faster and more safely over great distances. The Verdos family has control over a large number of fortresses and research institutes located on hard-to-reach mountaintops and isolated on islands. **Orlok** The forests, mountains, fields, and lakes are all resources that are felled, blasted, and consumed in the hunt for raw materials. Modern mechanical machines break brown coal out of the ground while drills and explosives tear holes in the mountains' roots. Timber from devastated forest areas drives blast furnaces and vast refineries spew out chemicals and waste products into the rivers. Nature is mutilated, reshaped, and plundered of its resources. Along the railways the raw material is sent to the cities where it is processed into food, machines, and weapons. The man from the Orlok line and his kind are the wilderness's pioneers. They find new resources and assets to feed the hungry beast that the State has created. Unlike the other lines, Orlok has its power in the wilderness. Here they erect their industries to secure nature's raw materials. They have multitudes of subfamilies that all struggle to surpass each other. These in turn have multitudes of workers beneath them, who are paid pittances for dangerous work. Members of the Orlok line despise the other lines' sedentary life in the cities, as true freedom exists in the wilderness. The line members erect provisional labor camps where resources can be found, and there workers extract around the clock nature's assets. Additionally, they are

landowners and have the task of overseeing agriculture and livestock management. Since the Todescu line broke free, Orlok has also taken over a large part of control over the railways and logistics within the realm, but as yet everything is far from running smoothly. The line's political seat is a stately self-sufficient estate, nicknamed the Farm, with a magnificent inner courtyard near Sandukar's center in the Spiran district. Here lives the line's head, the aged Grand Duke Karel d'Petkovich. He carefully studies the reports he receives from his subordinates and plans new expeditions to places where refineries shall be built. Members of the Orlok line are known for not being particularly meticulous or patient, which often causes them trouble and leads to many workers' deaths. Outside the cities, line members wear practical clothes, but in social situations they usually change into lavishly decorated uniforms. The men then often wear traditional swords at their sides. **Jasonek** Explorers and pioneers are plentiful within the Jasonek family, and through history they have had several famous explorers in their ranks. The family devotes much time to finding new assets and natural resources, information that they then sell to other families within the line—or even to other lines. The Jasonek family is active in many areas but has no total dominance anywhere. Its largest income comes from the timber industry. Family members are those who without question have the greatest insight into the Empire's geography, and it is also said that they rest on secret knowledge of hidden and mysterious places. **Kostash** Black is the color that members of the Kostash family have on their suits, dresses, and coats—black is the smoke that billows out from their coal power plants, and blackened is the ground in the areas they control. Kostash has great riches for being such a small family and owns several railway companies and manages railway maintenance. Family members are known for being sickly and weak but possessing great intellect. They are disliked and feared as they often indulge in assassinations—preferably of all through poisoning. Even within the family, premature deaths are many. **Lachek** Lachek—the largest family within the Orlok line is spread across the entire Empire and controls large parts of food production. Everything from cultivation of beets and fruit to the meat market lies under its control. Recently the family has gotten increasingly more competition in the market and uses dishonest methods to maintain its dominance. Despite the Lachek family being large and relatively wealthy, it is ill-regarded and the members are seen as easily influenced and somewhat stupid. There are clear signs of inbreeding in the family, and hereditary diseases and madness are very common. "Anger from lies is eternal. Anger from truth is transient." — Legate Felix van Kordar de Zovrin

Navod

The members of the Navod family usually keep to the cities where they manage administration and negotiate trade agreements with other clans and families. They own factories and refineries and strive to gain greater influence in the state bureaucracy.

Despite their important diplomatic position, many of the family members are boorish and clumsy in social contexts and known for their gluttony in food and drink, which has caused many of them to suffer from severe obesity. They also have an ability to treat most others as their subjects, which is hardly appreciated.

Petkovich

Day and night, the Petkovich family's oil pumps drain the earth's interior of black gold. Entire fields can be filled with oil pumps and from tall steel towers equipped with searchlights, the treasure is guarded greedily.

The family has many competitors and has been forced to devote large resources to soldiers who protect its properties—sabotage occurs daily, however, and in some places the oil wells are on fire.

The family members are known to be very spoiled and arrogant and have openly expressed their contempt for the other clans. Always wearing a golden flower on their person is important to them.

Yakutsk

Along the rivers of the Empire travel massive diesel-powered steel ships bearing the Yakutsk family symbol. If the other families in the Orlok clan handle the extraction of raw materials, Yakutsk transports them to their destinations.

The family is known for being able to keep quiet about most business deals if the payment is good enough—they can also move things through inspections and customs without great risk. Rumor has it that family members engage in plunder and sometimes have competitors' ships attacked and sunk, but no evidence of this can be found.

Zakov

The Zakov family has large work camps throughout the Empire and has focused on extracting ore deposits. Members of the family are known to be honest and understanding but have shown several times that they don't hesitate to crush those who deceive or go against them.

Recently, the family has been working to establish grand forts and defensive works blasted into the mountains for the army and for their own use.

Todescu

Their seat is destroyed. Their name is tainted. The State has turned its will against them and fights to annihilate them. But now they are free and now they have the opportunity to influence their future. No longer shall they be bullied by the other clans—no more envy, no more humiliation. Now they are feared and have taken up the fight to raise their own honor. The fire of faith burns within them all and the fire of hatred burns their enemies to ash. They are no longer alone, the fallen angel stands at their side—like them he was bullied and persecuted and condemned to wander the earth for eternity. These thoughts swirl through the mind of the man of clan Todescu after he finished his prayer in the trench. He grips his rifle with dirty fingers and raises it with a roar toward the blood-red vault of heaven—the time of vengeance has come.

Todescu is no longer part of the State and the Empire. The clan, which has always been one of the least influential, was previously responsible for the logistics and construction of the great railways outside the realm. Its members were always regarded with suspicion because most were of the Hraghic people and were strictly religious. The clan therefore had weak power in Sandukar and the majority of members lived in the eastern province of Presvedonia.

The oppression against Todescu and its new, influential leaders who burned for the religious faith caused members to rebel against the State. Everything happened in the shadows at first. The steel mills in the eastern province began secretly manufacturing weapons and war materiel and the people were filled with religious ecstasy and conviction. The war has now raged for some time and the clan is condemned—only in the breakaway province can it act openly.

Todescu's formerly magnificent seat in Sandukar is now a burnt-out ruin left as a warning of what happens to traitors. The clan still has spies and sympathizers in the Empire, however, who secretly help them—these individuals live a very dangerous life.

The clan's members usually wear their hair long according to Hraghic culture. A number of them are now within the army and church where they have important roles as leaders and warriors.

Ferescu

Driving the machinery of war is very costly in terms of natural resources and the Ferescu family does its best to produce what is needed for the soldiers to continue fighting against the State's lurking troops.

Ferescu has several important mining areas under its control and has also begun extracting oil on an increasingly large scale. The family is relatively bullied by the other families and constantly pressed from all sides to produce more materiel.

Invida

The Invida family was previously responsible for work on the railways in the Empire and now handles communications in Presvedonia. Under the family's supervision, railway tracks are laid through forests and over mountain ridges in the realm and family members ensure there are transports for troops and materiel.

Invida is the family that has the most contacts and spies outside Presvedonia.

Mâcelar

Mâcelar has a history of war behind it. The family has led its people in countless battles against the enemy in the north and now uses this knowledge to liberate its realm. Many of the family members have experience from the horrors of battlefields and participate in the fighting themselves. They focus primarily on the State's forces in the west and let the Rasbotny family and its troops fight against the northern front in Sadovia.

The family members are filled with religious hysteria and hubris which makes them somewhat reckless. In battle they gladly use axes during assaults.

Nălucă

Previously Nălucă was a vassal family to clan Arkady and is still suspected of serving it in one way or another. Many family members have been imprisoned because of this but no evidence could be presented and since the family has participated in the freedom struggle with at least as much intensity as other clan families, they have begun to be more accepted.

The family has several large assets when it comes to arable land and livestock and is now working hard to expand its production.

Rasbotny

The Rasbotny family has a past as warriors and now commands many parts of the fighting units together with the Mâcelar family. Members have focused on the fighting in the north and against Sadovia and in the shipyards they oversee the construction of a fleet that will be able to challenge the State's destroyers.

Within the family it is very common to move with the help of horses and the family has introduced many mounted units that can quickly move through forests and rugged terrain where state motor vehicles cannot reach.

Sânge

Those who stand closest to the Fallen One and interpret his commands are the Sânge family. The family functions as the Fallen One's black priesthood and its servants search for infidels and rebels in the realm.

Sânge has become an inquisition that captures, interrogates and tortures those who oppose the new regime. It is perceived that the women within the family are much crueler than the men, especially when it comes to torturing, or extracting information from, the State's supporters.

Vrajba

Vrajba is one of the smaller families that was previously excluded from clan Todescu but has now returned with renewed power. Madness seems to characterize the members in one way or another and they are also filled with a hatred toward their former oppressors in Sadovia and the entire state structure.

Vrajba has gained great control over the cities and has founded a new bureaucracy where the people shall have the right to choose.

Members of the family handle information dissemination in a very active way, they spread leaflets with demoralizing truths about the Empire over the State's trenches, among other things.

Zovrin

From the office window one can see out over the eternal city. A myriad of lights from millions of inhabitants trying to keep the night and cold away. In the alleys, street urchins warm themselves by small fires, in the apartments families gather around radios, in the manors the rich eat silent dinners.

All are enslaved, all realize the power of money and cannot resist its temptation. Money can pervert the strongest mind, turn brother against brother and force people into submission. The very aura of wealth can strike people with speechlessness and awaken admiration and envy. This insight caresses the mind of the woman from clan Zovrin as she sits at her desk at night and seals the fate of yet another citizen with a simple signature.

The members of clan Zovrin are administrators and bureaucrats whose main purpose is to watch over Sandukar's economy, banking and trade. The clan has even given its name to the Empire's currency. Within clan Zovrin most members are very rich and thus powerful.

The members are not particularly numerous, Zovrin is the second smallest clan after Arkady, but with money one can buy both followers and loyal servants. Thus the clan is one of the most powerful in the Empire. It has, however, only important contacts in the upper parts of society; dealing with the poor other than by granting them loans with outrageous interest rates is rarely economically defensible.

The clan's head, legate Felix van Kordar de Zovrin, is a stately, middle-aged man with a calculating mind. He lives at the very top of the clan's stately round skyscraper—a mighty construction of pillars, bridges, black steel, stone and glass called the Midas Tower, located in the central parts of the Mint. The tower houses endless filing cabinets, filled vaults and financial reports. Only trusted ones may tread the skyscraper's polished marble floors.

Clan Zovrin leads the persecution of the Hraghic people. This largely as revenge for the enormous sums of money the clan lost when Todescu broke free from the realm without repaying its debts.

Members of clan Zovrin are usually conservatively well-dressed in discreet creations and indulge in expensive pleasures. Most have blond hair in strict hairstyles. Money is their passion and many of them indulge in gambling and games of chance.

Dunarmco

The Dunarmco family consists of arrogant gamblers and libertines who spend much time on riches and pleasures. Their wealth comes largely from the mines in the former homeland of Kovan but almost all members of the family live in Sandukar and let the mines be managed by various companies.

There is an exclusive watch brand that bears the family name but the watches are only sold within clan Zovrin.

Egato

The Egato family deals largely with foodstuffs of various kinds but also owns many business chains—particularly exclusive interior design firms and furniture stores.

The family has several of its own liquor brands and recently managed to negotiate an agreement with the State to subsidize cigarettes to soldiers at the fronts. This has brought Egato into conflict with the Umoriti family but Egato is a family with big plans and does not enter fights it doesn't think it can win.

Kordar

Kordar is the family that has control over the banking system and currency. The members own stately buildings, wear beautiful clothes, drive luxury cars and can be said to form the foundation for all of clan Zovrin.

Kordar is, however, a family with problems, there is plenty of discord within it and the greed among members never wants to end, they betray their closest for the highest possible return. Arrogance and contempt have begun to result in violence and the other families within the clan look hungrily at how the eternal power struggle means that Kordar loses more and more power and initiative.

Masteri

The Masteri family runs gaming halls and entertainment establishments, everything from stately casinos to betting firms, bars and theaters. Masteri focuses on delivering pleasures and playing on obsession and exploits people's weaknesses and dreams of a happy future.

Members of the Masteri family manipulate games and matches, bribe judges and athletes and also have contacts far down among the criminal gangs. They themselves are almost obsessed with games and gambling and often challenge each other.

Morganti

The members of the cunning Morganti family have been merchants for centuries. They buy and sell everything—their transports go along rivers and railways and with their well-sharpened tongues they get the best prices and the rarest equipment.

After a newspaper scandal that accused the family of having redirected food that was on its way to soldiers at the eastern front so that it instead ended up in one of the family's work camps, they have become more cautious but behind the scenes they have begun to challenge clan Guiskard more and more, by among other things leading the mudslinging against it.

Paninaro

The Paninaro family owns large amounts of real estate and controls construction firms and architectural offices. It is usually Paninaro who is responsible for the new constructions that take place in Sandukar.

Paninaro has come into conflict with the Straker family of clan Arkady, founder of the city's original architecture, and this conflict has led to state commissioners increasingly beginning to interfere in Paninaro's affairs. The family members are, however, known for their courage and do not hesitate to challenge state statutes.

Umoriti

Humanity's greatest vice during the last hundred years is almost entirely under Umoriti's control since the family has almost complete power over the tobacco industry. Umoriti owns several tobacco plantations and factories, invests massive sums in marketing and launches brands aimed at personal style and taste.

Many of the family's employees receive part of their wages paid in cigarettes which they can sell on or use as barter goods. The Egato family, within their own clan, has come to challenge Umoriti's power and it is only a matter of when Umoriti will strike back.

"Some stories are better off not being told." — Mercurian Corso

The day had started badly and looked set to end worse. The only good thing the massive rain brought was keeping down the city's stench, rinsing away the refuse that its inhabitants mindlessly scattered about. Mordekai turned around, raised his hand to his brow and squinted through the rain. The alley behind the bar was poorly lit and a single bare bulb struggled to bring hope against the rain's relentless assault. He recognized the voice, knew immediately who it was standing behind him. The silhouette was illuminated when a car's headlights out by the street swept past and the contours revealed a slender, tall woman clad in a tight wet coat. For a brief second he saw her within himself, how the sil-houette came to life, features and expression. The memories washed over him like a kick in the gut. He remembered how the two had spent days on end at Reerdon's hotel down by Västerparken, how they had loved, slept, drunk and loved, over and over again. How he had been calm during this brief time, how the light within him had penetrated the dark shimmer that surrounded his rigid heart. She had left him. Who could blame her for that, he was who he was. His heart was black as night. But still the meeting, this meeting in a dark, cold and rainy alley, made him feel excitement and a certain anticipation. His dark heart pounded faster in his chest. A raindrop ran down over his cheek and into the corner of his mouth where his smile took form. "Stelia?" He noticed that his voice trembled slightly. The silhouette took a couple of steps forward. The stiletto-heeled high boots broke the puddles and the woman's face was reached by the bulb's cold white light. Her skin was still pale as the finest imported porcelain, her dark green eyes appeared black in the gloom under the wet hat's brim. The eyes he had lost himself in dreams of, which had given him a calm like a mother comforting a sad child. These now dark and cold eyes. "Mordekai." The name was said low and her perfectly red-colored lips moved faintly. Her voice, the husky voice that had whispered endearments in his ear long ago. She lifted her head slightly and brushed a wet blonde lock from her face with a gloved hand. "I knew you were here. You're so predictable." It sounded almost mocking, but Mordekai couldn't quite distinguish if it was meant that way through the rain's drum-ming against the overflowing garbage cans and tin roofs. She seemed to be waiting. It made him suddenly feel uncertain. "Stelia, what the hell do you want? We haven't seen each other in over a year." And what a year of longing it had been. "You disappeared when I was out getting cigar-ettes. Without a sound, gone, poof!" He raised his voice to cut through the patter-ing rain. He slowly took a couple of steps forward. "Mordekai, darling. Don't think it was your fault. I'm not right for you. I'm not right for anyone. You gave me an embrace to fall asleep in, a moment when I could forget myself and become someone else. You gave me memories I

still carry with me." Her mouth was still hard and stern. Her eyes hidden by the gloom. Her voice sounded sorrowful. The rain pounded violent-ly down around the two people in the alley. "But darling, you know as well as I do that this city brings out the worst in people. I hadn't planned for us to meet again. The memories would have sufficed." Mordekai suddenly felt uneasy. It went head to head with his awakened desire for her, her body, her scent, her warmth. Slightly confused, he blinked the rain from his eyes. "What are you talking about? Why are you here?" He took a step backward, to increase the distance. The red lips suddenly showed a faint smile. "This isn't personal, I really hope you understand that. This is business and this is what I do. Regardless of target." From the rain-wet coat the silhouette drew a large chrome automatic pistol with a matte black suppressor and aimed it straight at him. Mordekai stared. He saw in detail how a rain-drop hit the muzzle of the suppressor, and how it slowly ran off the oiled surface. His right hand instinctively drew back to reach the revolver at his back below the heavy coat. He already knew he would never make it in time. The woman's hand tensed barely noticeably and the pistol jerked. The powerful heat from the powder cloud that pressed the lead bullet through the suppressor scorched him. He noted knife-sharp how the empty casing that was ejected rotated through the air and gleamed in the bulb's light.

He had been right. The day ended worse. The bullet bored in just below his right nipple. He gasped, reflexively took two steps backward. His vision became blurred. His right arm stopped functioning just when he had felt the revolver grip in his palm. The pain took over all other impressions as he slowly fell down onto the cold street. His breathing was heavy and a hissing sound came from his chest. Blood and water colored the asphalt beneath him. He lay on his back, perceived only the cold rain dancing over his face. In the distance he heard footsteps of high heels. She came up to him. Her face, half hidden, clenched tight. The bulb flickered irregularly in the rain. The pistol in her hand seemed too heavy for her. A faint wisp of smoke rose from the suppressor. He had forgotten how beautiful she was. She raised the pistol toward his head. "Mordekai, darling. I've always liked your face. So you can keep that." She smiled an almost tender smile. Mordekai fought against the pain numbing him. He felt how the darkness within him worked to get him going. Wake him. The woman lowered the pistol toward his chest. It was beautiful in its binary deadliness. It decided; life or death. Neither arms nor legs obeyed him. "Sleep now, darling, let me help you rest again." Wake him. He blinked frantically, he felt how the black rage bubbled. His heart beat unnaturally fast and loud. The sky was dark and the rain grew in strength. She hesitated a second, bit her lip. Wake him. Wake him! He suddenly managed to clench his fist. She closed her eyes, drew her head back and sighed quietly out into nowhere. The darkness pumped in his veins, the pain ran out of him. He opened wide his dark eyes. He was close! She opened her eyes, lowered her gaze and met his. He awakened. She knew. A brief bow and she squeezed the trigger. Three times. The rain drummed against roofs and street. The only thing that could be heard was the casings' metallic dance against the wet asphalt. Behind her the bulb finally gave up its struggle and went out with a hiss. Stelia bent down and gave the motionless man a light kiss on his wet forehead and gently closed his blank eyes with her palm. She rose, picked up the empty casings, and left the alley, and the memories, behind her.

The law wears black uniform and hard baton and strikes merci-lessly and without quarter down like a sledgehammer on those who dare abuse the freedom the State provides. **Justice** The laws in the Empire are enacted by the bureaucrats at the Ministry of Justice in Sandukar. They are written to first and foremost serve the State's interests, secondly to give the police support to carry out their work with the greatest effective-ness and lastly to protect the citizens. The regulations around the laws and their interpretations are mas-sive and require a great work effort to comprehend. **The Police** The police's duties are to protect the State, appre-hend the State's enemies and investigate and combat common criminal activity among the citizens. Generally the public has a rather low confidence in the police force as corruption and scandals taint the organization, even though individual individuals within it act with integrity and compassion. To maintain control over the

police, the State has several different types of organizations with different duties. The uniformed police force, commonly called the order police, is seen patrolling out on the streets. The order police are often first on scene at alarms, cordon off crime scenes, handle barricades and clear up minor crimes. As a counterpart to the order police there is the criminal police which consists of plainclothes criminal investigators, interrogation leaders and crime scene investigators. Many are trained in psychology and various criminal-techno-logical subjects. The criminal police get, besides inves-tigating more complex crimes, to engage in important surveil-lance assignments and work undercover inside the criminal organizations. Subordinate to the criminal police is the tactical unit which is used when heavier firepower is needed, such as during break-ins at armed suspects' locations or for protection of the detectives when they need to venture into unsafe parts of the city. The tactical unit is also used during riots and for clearing out among the destitute and criminals. Part of the tactical unit acts as escort for dignitaries and during trans-port of dangerous persons and theft-attractive goods. In case of crime suspicion where the State is the plaintiff, the State Police, popularly called Stapo, is always brought in. Often Stapo comes in even before the criminal police have had time to notify them, which fuels the rumor that Stapo has moles and **The Justice System**

informants everywhere within the police force. Stapo's methods are very effective and the resources enviable. When it comes to curbing activity that threatens the State, no means are shunned to achieve success. Stapo operates directly under the Ministry of Security and has the right to take over cases from the criminal police if the State's interests are considered threatened. This often creates a harsh atmosphere between the detectives and Stapo, as wounded egos and bul-lying methods create resentment. Within the Ministry of Truth there is the Commissariat, a mysterious section shrouded in darkness. For those who search in the archives for information about the Commissariat, very little is to be found. The commissaries constitute a small, very power-ful police force believed to be directly subordinate to the State's elite. The commissaries have the right to take over any cases whatsoever from both detectives and Stapo, can requisition personnel without objections and may pronounce sentences for crimes on the spot. The myths about the commissaries are many, ranging from them possessing strange powers to them being the State's own murder-ers. It is considered a truth that if a commissary takes a citizen to the Ministry of Truth for interrogation, that person will not return to society. Before a commissary no one is safe—neither family personalities, high police chiefs nor industrial moguls. **Ranks within the police** The different service ranks that exist within the police force are in ascending order: **Within the order police** • Police aspirant • Police constable • Patrol chief • Police group chief • Police captain **Within the criminal police** • Criminal assistant • Criminal inspector • Criminal chief inspector • Police captain • Police director **Within Stapo** • Stapo lieutenant • Stapo captain • Stapo major • Stapo colonel • Stapo marshal **Criminal Technology** In a former museum near Sandukar's core is the police force's central criminal laboratory, or Crimlab as it is called within the police. It houses several thousand researchers, technicians and forensic pathologists working in different depart-ments, on different cases and projects. Criminal police also come here for training as it is here the methods used to solve crimes and find clues and evidence are developed, with technical knowledge and profiling. The new era's criminal technology is viewed with skepticism by the old guard as they prefer using proven methods such as harsh interrogations or one-on-one conversations with suspects—who not infrequently "happen to fall" during the conversations. This difference in the view of police work not infrequently breeds frus-tration and friction between younger and older colleagues. The detectives who embrace the new technology in their crime-fighting gladly resort to the methods and techniques that Crimlab's prominent criminal psychologists develop when it comes to motive-searching and profiling of suspects. Sometimes, however, specialists from Crimlab or someone from Stapo are called in to help with the investigation. Stapo has a large number of well-educated people who trust the modern technology. Stapo is the police instance within which the use of modern criminal technology has gone the furthest. Often Stapo operates very effectively and thoroughly with regard to profiling, motive-searching and qualified surveillance work. Great focus is placed on crime scene analysis and securing of traces

and potential evidence for future comparisons. On the well-guarded laboratory building's many base-ment levels, detailed personal information, registration of activities and technical evidence are stored in long rows of archive cabinets. They also have cells where they keep the most interest-ing criminals, like the mentally ill serial killers, the cold criminal geniuses and similar deviants. These indi-viduals are studied and subjected to various experiments in the hunt for the human psyche's darkest depths. It is gener-ally known that the Mengal family has great influence over Crimlab and it is usually their researchers who handle the most bizarre and macabre cases. The evidence crime investigators find in service is usually taken to Crimlab if it cannot be utilized directly at the local police station. It is routine at crime scenes to search for and document fingerprints and to photograph the actual crime scene from different angles so that one can see what it looked like even at later times. Clothing fibers, cartridge casings, strands of hair and similar items are collected to be examined under microscope, analyzed and registered. Through visual comparisons by sharp-eyed employees, technical evid-ence can help in binding a person to a location. **Stapo's departments** Stapo consists of several distinct departments that are responsible for protection of different parts of the State's operations and for crushing society-subverting tendencies. Department 1 — Personal protection and protection of state property Department 2 — Infiltration and control over internal subversive groups & persons Department 3 — Infiltration and control over external subversive groups and persons* Department 4 — Surveillance of the church and secret societies Department 5 — Administration, auditing and logistics Department 6 — Counterespionage Department 7 — (secret) Department 8 — Border control and identification Department 9 — Special operations, assassinations and abductions

- This includes the enemy.

A skilled forensic pathologist can determine the time of death of a victim through a quick examination of the body. If the victim is examined within a day of death, accuracy is within an hour thanks to liver temperature. If the body is examined within a week, a probable date of death can be determined.

In cases where there are injuries to the body caused by, for example, knives, or if severe violence is evident, such as strangulation, the forensic pathologist can with high probability determine whether the killer is right- or left-handed. If the victim has been subjected to sexual violence, this can be established through examination of genitals and body orifices. A completed autopsy provides answers as to whether the cause of death was blood loss, oxygen deprivation, poisoning, brain damage, natural causes, etcetera.

Bullets can be matched to caliber and type of weapon through ballistics examination and rifling inspection under microscope. This requires bullets in good condition to compare with. Gunshot wounds can indicate the approximate distance between victim and shooter and from which angle the shot must have hit.

Court & Legal Process

When sufficient evidence has been gathered against a suspect, the criminal police contact the Justice Ministry's local prosecutor division to submit their report. The selected prosecutor takes on the case and prepares the trial. The suspect meanwhile sits in detention in the police district's central jail until the trial and is given the opportunity to speak with a defense attorney. In rare cases, the defense attorney and prosecutor can agree that the suspect should be released until the trial occurs, but then against a substantial bail sum. Worth noting is that truly powerful family personalities, State ministers and successful industrial leaders have legal immunity, which means they cannot be prosecuted, regardless of crime, as long as it does not concern High Treason.

A trial usually occurs within one to a couple of weeks, depending on the case and perpetrator. Simpler cases end up in the lower court where sentences are pronounced assembly-line style — it's rare that a case takes

more than five minutes from description to verdict. In the higher court, more complicated crimes are taken up. Here the trial can take days or even weeks depending on the circumstances.

In the lower court there is a single judge who pronounces the verdict. In the higher court there are instead three judges, one of whom is a magistrate. Common to both courts is the black, hooded garment and that the judge's face is always covered by a mask that prevents recognition.

In the higher court there is always a professional jury with prominent people from different parts of society selected by the State — businesspeople, military officers, bureaucrats and doctors. The jury is only advisory and after a case is concluded but before the verdict falls, the jury gives the trio of judges their analysis and recommendation, which the judges have every right to ignore.

When the verdict falls, the accused is either acquitted or convicted. In an acquittal, the person is immediately released, without any claims on the legal apparatus — he/she should be grateful that justice prevailed, other compensation is superfluous. If the person is convicted, the punishment is announced in conjunction with the conviction.

It's not uncommon for trials where famous people figure, either as accused, witnesses or victims, to attract reporters in droves, which turns the entire legal process into a media circus with radio segments, reports and investigative journalism that gets column meter after column meter in the newspapers. Nothing attracts readers like juicy scandals in the chambers of high society.

Punishment

When a person is convicted of a crime, regardless of severity, the person enters the state criminal register and receives a new citizen's passport where the conviction is clearly noted. This usually causes problems when purchasing restricted goods, financial transactions and employment options.

Common punishments are penal labor or prison, often in conjunction with fines that partially go to the State and partially to the crime victim. There are several prisons in the Empire, but the most notorious is Kasterov Fort on the island of Kasterov a couple miles outside Sandukar's harbors. Kasterov Fort houses a large number of hardened criminals and it's rare that a day passes there without some prisoner dying. Attempting to escape is more or less doomed, but that doesn't stop escape attempts from being carried out, either across the sea or through the special underground railway that runs between the island and Sandukar.

An alternative that men are often given when determining punishment is to be sent to the front during the sentence period and fight for the nation's honor and success with courage and blood. Many desperate souls see this as a better alternative than longingly staring out through a damp slot for the coming years. Women instead get the alternative to serve as bondservants during the sentence period, at one of the state institutions for companionship.

The death penalty occurs but is relatively rare — it's primarily for criminal activity against the State that it's pronounced. Common citizens are sentenced to execution by burning in one of the state incinerators. More prominent people can themselves choose whether they wish to be executed by bullet, rope, poison or electricity.

Laws

The Empire's law books are thick and filled with clauses and bureaucratic incomprehensibilities. Many of the laws are clear, such as that one shall not kill, steal or assault, but in addition to them there is a multitude of

ordinances that affect everyday life for the Empire's population.

That a law is enacted doesn't mean it's followed, but breaking it always entails a risk and if the police want to get someone, they take every opportunity that comes their way. Social status, class, ethnicity and gender play a role in criminal investigations. Crimes against disliked minorities in society often remain unsolved.

To speak negatively or seditiously toward the State in the form of speech, image, writing, music, theater or similar is punishable, often with prison, penal labor or death penalty as consequence. This law is overseen by the Ministry of Truth which monitors that no public information contains non-state propaganda. However, there are underground magazines and radio programs that broadcast from secret locations.

Not reporting slander or sedition toward the State is a serious crime. Persons who have made themselves guilty of such offenses shall immediately be reported by any witnesses.

Crimes between family members can be resolved through dueling, if both parties so wish. These so-called honor duels are always to the death and the winner is completely acquitted of any suspicions.

Homosexuality and other sexual deviations from the norm on an emotional level are seen as diseases that can be cured with various forms of therapy and experimental treatments. Prominent doctors from the Mengal family gladly demonstrate electricity therapy as a very good remedy.

To practice deviant physical intercourse, such as sodomy or oral sex, is criminal and can lead to fines or prison. This law is naturally very difficult to enforce as people usually engage in that type of activity privately and covertly.

A woman in a marriage is not considered able to be raped by her husband, as she cannot deny her husband intercourse. Possibly the man can in very rare cases be convicted of assault. Generally, rape is a crime that is seldom followed up on at all.

The law gives no extra protection to minors under twelve years, but children are often sentenced as if they were adults. In the same way, there are no special laws concerning intercourse with young individuals.

Abortions are illegal. This doesn't prevent them from occurring, however; many black clinics deal exclusively with abortions but prices are high if one wants to ensure not getting complications from the procedures. At higher levels in society, private doctors can usually take care of these procedures without asking any questions.

Prostitution is only legal at special state brothels. The majority of prostitutes in the Empire, however, don't belong to any of these brothels. This means they are vulnerable, both to violent customers and to the law's guardians who often exploit them for their own lusts' sake.

Children who are placed in orphanages and not adopted before they turn twelve can be confiscated by the State and placed in labor camps.

"*Crime is not for amateurs. There are fifty ways to screw it up. If you can think of half of them, you're a genius. And you're no genius.*" — Franko Millovy

Religion has left large marks in history but since the State was formed, the church has been humiliated and forced to its knees.

The Church's Role

In Sandukar it's no longer considered normal to seek a higher power together with others. The church is opposed partly through bureaucracy, partly through eager enlightenment campaigns from the Ministry of Truth.

As a religious practitioner one is regarded as something of a desperate fanatic who doesn't quite fit into society. That the enemy in the east has taken religion to its heart and fights in the name of the One doesn't make things easier for the faithful, and many now choose to keep their faith secret from outsiders, to avoid persecution.

But still there exists a need for spiritual guidance and the brave are not scared by society's opinion but seek out the churches at services. Others content themselves with taking out the holy scripture and reading it when no one is watching to find comfort and security.

History

The church's origin is shrouded in darkness; it seems to have existed in one way or another in all seven provinces, imprinted since ancient times. In ancient writings deep down in old church archives it can be found that the great western branch of religion, Janoism, has its origin in Madrostav. The teaching of the One god spread thanks to a preacher named Janos, who brought several traveling cults with him.

The cults crossed the country's borders but it was first when Madrostav's regent Karlof VII Alexos converted to the One god's teaching that Janoism truly spread.

The religion was well received in most surrounding kingdoms, especially by rulers, as the teaching advocated that the church should keep away from worldly power and instead concentrate on the spiritual. The people toiled to build churches that sanctified the faith and paid what they themselves felt they could spare to the church.

Around the same time another teaching began to spread in the eastern kingdoms, with its seat in Sadovia. It also built on an interpretation of the One god's commandments and was given the name Maurism. Maurism held that the church should be the ruling part in society as the priesthood were those who interpreted the One god's commandments. The church taxed the people

The Church of the One

and had black cathedrals erected where priests frightened the people into obedience with the horrors that awaited them if they violated the foundations of faith.

Those who openly questioned the Maurist priests were subjected to persecution and those who protested loudest disappeared.

The Conflict

When the two doctrines met, the conflict became violent. What began in heated discussions soon led to war and conquests on both sides. The religious power struggle stretched from the smallest hovel to the greatest palace and dragged countries and peoples into massacres and destruction of sanctuaries. A cold war then came to prevail as Maurism maintained its iron grip on the eastern parts while Janoism's doctrine was generally accepted in most of the remaining areas.

Darost had the priesthood banished as many of the inhabitants were secretly Maurists, and in Kovan an uprising occurred among the people, supported by the Zovrin clan, which led to the Maurist priests being

slain and the cathedrals burned. After this, Kovan never let any religious doctrine in again.

The State & the Enemy When the war against the enemy in the north descended like darkness over the realms, all countries were affected. The alliance between the seven clans had to have the church on its side in forming a strong state that could withstand and repel the enemy. This required Janoism and Maurism to make peace, and even though neither faith was happy about the idea, they supported it and the State's emergence in exchange for being allowed to continue spreading and proclaiming their doctrines.

Once the State had been formed and the united realms beaten back the enemy, there was hope for a brighter time. Centuries of war and conflicts between the countries were over, the church was united and priests from both doctrines blessed the soldiers on the battlefields. Those who saw beyond the facade, however, noticed how the rulers acquired more and more power, and when the war was finally said to be over, they had the realms in an iron grip—as well as the church. They forced religion to give up its power and assets, Janoism became the fundamental doctrine and Maurism was more or less completely banned. Slowly the State began working to rule over the Empire alone.

The Split

When it looked as though religion was completely dead and powerless and the State stood as the obvious victor, something happened that no one could have foreseen: the realm of Presvedonia, which had always maintained a strong religious faith, got a new spiritual leader who called himself the Fallen One. According to documents from that time, the new leader managed to seduce both the people of Presvedonia and the Todescu clan into rebelling against the State. Inciting, powerful speeches and condemning threats caused the masses to rise and show what strength and hatred can be ignited by a strong faith.

The soldiers bore crosses and chanted the One God's commandments, the priesthood was among the trenches and the mighty cathedrals were overcrowded. A variant of Maurism had been created, and it took the name Siferism after the Fallen One's heavenly name, Siferos. The faith proclaimed that the Hraghian people were chosen and that they should fight for their freedom after millennia of oppression.

Many of the openly faithful in the Empire lost their jobs, were subjected to extensive state interrogations and some were imprisoned or executed. The Ministry of Truth worked at high pressure to educate the people about the falsehoods in the spiritual poison that religion was.

But within the church they have realized that religion still has power, the State does not dare crush the church completely for fear that the fires of revolt will spread. Despite this, the church has gone out and condemned the Siferists and their actions even though many are secretly impressed by their strength and courage to fight for the One God, in a time when few dare confess their need for spiritual guidance.

The church is studying what is happening and even though its members are oppressed, it knows it has support among large parts of the people. More and more Maurists are beginning to appear in its ranks, they whisper in secret about retaking power and reforming the State into a religious one. Others only want religious freedom but for now the State is too powerful and the church allows itself to be cowed while waiting for change and for an opportunity to achieve restoration.

The Religious Branches

There are three branches within what is called the church: Janoism, Maurism and Siferism.

Janoism

The religious faction Janoism, originating in Madrostav, is based on interpretations by Janos, a simple man who after a tragedy that cost him his entire family restored religion by frenziedly reinterpreting and translating the ancient scriptures. He proclaimed that the church and the people were one and that faith fundamentally lay with the individual—together, however, one could accomplish great deeds. The most important thing was not that one performed all the ceremonies, the most important thing was that one prayed and acknowledged the One God and his son, the savior, who sacrificed himself for humanity's sins.

Playing the Faithful

There are many who pray to the One God as in human nature there is a longing to understand and be part of something greater. However, only a few are openly faithful, visit the churches and participate in masses. They are regarded with suspicion and must be prepared to be extra scrutinized when the State searches for traitors and insurrectionists. Fundamentally, however, there is not much difference between a believer and a non-believer. The state laws resemble in many ways the heavenly ones so the greatest difference lies in the individual's view of the world and of their role in the grand scheme. Playing a member of the priesthood requires choosing one's religious orientation and how much one is willing to risk to advance one's commandments. Is one willing to go as far as dying for one's faith? As part of the church one is included in a world of mysticism and forgotten knowledge. A believer is in many ways a seeker and the more one seeks and scrutinizes the world, the more cracks one can find in the State's facade. Even within the church, however, there are plenty of secret societies and orders that act for their own purposes. Some of them have, somewhat contradictorily, connections high up in the clans.

Janoism advocates hard work and abstinence and that one lives in harmony with nature, follows the ten commandments and guards against the seven sins. However, it is not a condemning doctrine but even the darkest of souls can find forgiveness. Likewise, Janos believed that church and state should be kept separate as the church should concentrate on the spiritual and the heavenly world while worldly governance should be left to the rulers. Janoism is now the only doctrine accepted by the State.

Maurism

Maurism has its basis in the Maurean gospel, a gospel that is not recognized by the Janoists as it is said to have been written much later. The Maurean gospel is filled with mysticism, difficult-to-interpret prophecies and divine laws for how peoples shall be governed under the One God's commandments.

According to the gospel, the people shall submit to the One God. Forgiveness and grace cannot be counted on if one breaks his ordinances, but rather a sojourn filled with eternal torment in the afterlife. On the other hand, one will receive wealth and power and a chance to rise in society if one serves him well. Those who have served the One God devotedly and carried out his commandments can also become saints and be worshipped and depicted on icons and statues.

Maurism's followers have erected mighty cathedrals to demonstrate the One God's power. Stately statues of angels and demons show the heavenly and the infernal, and mighty painted glass windows illustrate events from the holy scriptures.

In addition to the holy scripture and the Maurean gospel, there are several saints' gospels where the saints' commandments are proclaimed. The use of rituals and ceremonies is great within Maurism, and many of the devout engage in various forms of flagellant rites to strengthen their faith.

Maurism is forbidden as a doctrine by the State and all documents mentioning the branch are copied and archived by the Archival Ministry. The orientation still exists relatively openly in the east and there are many within the church, even in Sandukar, who are secretly Maurists and hope for a religious order where the church rules.

Siferism

Siferism is a variant of Maurism but has some different viewpoints, among other things the Hraghian people are considered chosen and urged to fight to free themselves from slavery. Siferism's leader, the myth-shrouded Siferos, is said to have been cast down from heaven and divinity to help humanity find god and simultaneously find their own atonement. By many he is regarded as the new Messiah.

In one of his most famous and well-documented speeches, Siferos asserts that Sandukar is the place on earth where Evil resides and that to achieve final purification Sandukar must be burned to dust for 77 days. All copies and transcriptions of this speech, commonly called the Liberation Speech, that are found by the State's troops are immediately burned and individuals found with the speech are immediately taken in for interrogation by the Commissariat. The Liberation Speech is seen by many followers as the sign of Siferos's divinity and is therefore often carried close to the heart.

The church pews stand empty. Flickering wax candles force back the shadows from the altar passage but otherwise the building is immersed in darkness. Outside the sooty snow falls and frost has spread along the painted glass windows. The church breathes peace and stillness but its halls are no longer visited, people are too afraid or have lost faith. Sebastian Okra looks out over the One's house and remembers the time when the pews were overcrowded, when the church was a symbol of warmth, peace and light. How has it gone so far?

The congregation's fall began with the expansion of Werner & Quildo's factories. A new hope for the future it was called. A new bright time for the area where no one would need to go unemployed or hungry. It sounded fine on paper and in the slogans but the truth became quite different. Those who owned the factories only thought about profit, through bureaucratic trickery they dissolved the workers' contracts and offered them new ones and when the alternative stood between a worse agreement and unemployment, most were forced to accept.

The workers lost large parts of their wages, their rights and their security. The sooty fallout made them sick and many injured themselves in the machine presses and cisterns.

Sebastian noticed the difference in the congregation and heard during confessions how the people in his flock became increasingly desperate. The money was no longer enough, those who tried to organize against management were harassed or dismissed, the children were sick practically all the time and the work was harder than ever. Sebastian's flock was however still loyal to him. Every Sunday they came to service and many times they sought him out during the evenings to ask for advice. Sebastian himself visited many of the sick who could not come to church and when he saw the suffering they were in he himself made contact with the leader of Werner & Quildo.

The meeting did not go well, the aged Lester Quildo openly mocked both the workers, Sebastian and the church. In an angry monologue he proclaimed himself an enemy of the church, he even threatened Sebastian and ordered him to leave the congregation. Sebastian refused and thereafter the sabotage and harassment began.

It started relatively quietly, the workers were advised not to visit the church henceforth. Worker meetings were scheduled at the same time as the services and when Sebastian changed the church's times, the time for the worker meetings was changed shortly thereafter. The congregation shrank, but the most faithful remained. Each time they came they seemed more emaciated, the clothes hung like rags on their thin bodies. Their pale faces and pleading eyes were directed at Sebastian when he preached about how the truly faithful will get to experience true peace in the kingdom of heaven. He spoke of the One's goodness and began increasingly often to see the doubt in their gazes, but they so wanted to believe.

Sebastian chose to fight back, he began during his services to openly speak against the oppression that the workers felt. He supported Karl Erwald, a factory worker who took the matter in hand and began organizing a resistance against the factory management. He met members from his congregation in secret as they did not want to be harassed and services were held at home in his apartment. But for money everything can be bought, informants soon revealed what was going on and the punishment came in the form of anonymous threatening letters and assault of the congregation's members.

The electricity and heating were shut off in the church due to an "unknown technical error" and during the cold months the church transforms into an ice palace that was impossible to stay in for long periods. The church leadership's pressure was ineffective and finally it seemed as if Lester Quildo had won and the church lost.

Nowadays almost no one dares come here. Sebastian Okra walks alone through the dark building and prays to the One for guidance and help. He has spoken with his superiors and in secret they have decided what must be done. A man within the church has been hired, a man with special abilities. This man shall ensure that Lester Quildo disappears. The church's piety only extends so far. A priest must look after his flock and if the flock is oppressed and harmed the guilty must be punished. Manufacturer Lester Quildo will soon feel the One's wrath.

Chapter 5 – Influence

It was one of those evenings, a hot, windless evening that breeds only three things; booze, lust and sweat. I snuffed out my third cigarette for the evening and looked out over the aimless flock of sheep all searching for a body to drunkenly crawl next to at closing time. He stood alone at the inner bar. Abandoned. Awkward. He wasn't in con-trol at a place like this. I took one last look in the pocket mirror and saw with satisfaction that the blonde wig sat perfectly. The man was about twice my age. Handsome with graying, thin hair. Faint age lines on his face. Slim and well-preserved body. Manicured and sensitive hands. Round glasses with metal frames. Sharp and expensive suit. Wedding ring in gold. A fat wallet. He was perfect. Meek, lonely and longing. I walked toward him in my carefully chosen outfit for the evening. I positioned myself close to him, so he would detect my perfume. He turned his face toward me. I moistened my lips and pulled out a cigarette. While he fumbled for a lighter I leaned close to his ear. "You seem like you need a friend." He nodded, surprised. He was caught. I moved closer. In profile so the curve of my breasts was accentuated, crouched slightly so he could look down into the neckline. A discreet sigh came from him. It was almost too easy. He looked bewildered. Slightly sweaty on the forehead. I blew out the smoke, away from him, and turned back toward him. He cleared his throat and finally spoke, with a slightly cracked voice. "So, I'm..." He got no further before I pressed my gloved finger over his lips. I slowly shook my head. "No names, friend. That's not what we're here for." He seemed feverishly searching for something to say but before he got that far I locked his gaze. Camouflaged behind an innocent smile I whispered sweetly. "What do you say, friend, a classic you and me, somewhere else?" His hazy gaze flared up and his breathing answered for him. I stroked him gently across

the cheek and didn't look away. He's hooked, and once again I'm going to be rich. — Talia Navarre, Club Karisma, a Saturday in November

Influence

Influence covers the fundamental rules and frame-work for playing Noir. Everything from action resolu-tion and how dice should be rolled to drama-creating mechanisms like fate and drives are covered. Additionally, how a protagonist is constructed and the parts included in their profile are described in detail. Feel free to use the table of contents to quickly find the rules being sought. **System** The system in Noir helps narrator and players consistently and reasonably determine whether actions succeed. It exists primarily to create randomness which in turn creates drama. In a novel, for example, an action's outcome is given by the author's desire, while action in role-playing is based on what participants wish to attempt to perform in the game world and in the current scene. The system provides conditions for desired actions to be executed in a successful way. **Vision** Noir's rules system is created according to a vision that builds on the system being: • Simple • Flexible & consistent • Inspiring • Reasonable **Simple** That the system should be simple means that few steps should be included in it. Both players and narrator should quickly understand how the system works and how it should be interpreted. Flexible & consistent By flexibility and consistency is meant that the same com-pact rules core should recur in all parts of the rules system. There should be no exceptions or special solutions for different cases, but the system should be usable in all situations. **Inspiring** It may sound strange to say that a system should be inspiring — a system is fundamentally just rules, mathematics and probabilities. By inspiration is meant in this case that participants should be able to use the system based on their own characters to create dynamics

in the story. It's about allowing will over ability which means that built into the system are elements that make it possible to produce the utmost, the desperate power in hopeless situations and use it in dramatic ways. A competent but willless person performs a given task worse than a determined amateur. By incorporating personal gain, conviction and independent influence in the story's scenes, the engagement and immersion of the participants will increase, and make the entire experience stronger. **Reasonable** One of the fundamental pillars Noir rests on is that the experience and story take their departure in a reasonable world. To stop a train by grabbing hold of it is unreasonable, while stopping a cyclist in the same way is reasonable. However, it should be pointed out that Noir's world is not the same as our own and that protagonists can perform feats and/or heroic deeds that can be seen as unreasonable in our world, often through sacrifices or thanks to strong conviction. This is something that both narrator and players quickly learn — to set the level right for the experience they desire. Some prefer a greater measure of unreasonableness than others — the important thing is that actions feel reasonable in the story that's underway. **Dice** Dice are used to produce random numbers which in turn are used to for example answer whether a person succeeds with their action or how much damage an attack does. In Noir, ten-sided dice are used. On certain types of ten-sided dice the number "0" appears. It should always be interpreted as "ten" which means that the outcome on a die varies from one to ten. To determine whether a person succeeds or fails with an action, two ten-sided dice are always used. The result of the roll is obtained by adding together the numbers on the rolled dice. Generally it applies to roll as high as possible to increase one's chances of succeeding with the action. Dice notations are sometimes abbreviated as 2D, where D means "dice" and the number indicates the number of dice in the roll, in this case two. Maxed & blocked dice Dice showing ones or tens in the roll have a special meaning. For each ten one rolls, one gets to roll another die. This is called the die being maxed. The number on this new die is added to the result. If one has the luck to roll new tens these are also maxed which means one can get very high results in the end. There is no limit to how many maxed dice one can get. For each one rolled, one prevents a maxing. This is called a block. **Breakdown** When two ones are rolled in a situation where objects or equipment are

used, and the roll is simultaneously an exceptional failure, the objects/equipment risk suffering breakdown. More information about breakdown can be found on page 92. Lowest & highest die In certain cases the individual dice numbers can affect a situation. The terms used for this are lowest, highest and all respectively. Lowest means that it is the lowest number in the roll that is important, highest means that the highest number in **Glossary** In Noir, terms and concepts appear that at first glance may seem difficult to handle or extensive. In this section are explanations of such concepts. ALL: The sum of the rolled value on all dice in a difficulty or resistance roll. ATTRIBUTE: Secondary informa-tion about a person. Determined often with the help of attribute values. ATTRIBUTE VALUE: Defines an attribute of a person. Attribute values are often based on Skills. PENALTY: The opposite of bonus. If an action is difficult to perform the result of the dice roll for the action can be worsened through penalty. NARRATOR: The game's director, presenter and rules arbiter. He/she prepares a larger or smaller situation with the help of a relationship map and a number of bombs, to together with the players create a story. The narrator portrays, describes and interprets what happens in the interaction between players and the game world. In rules disputes the narrator has the final word. NARRATOR CHARACTERS: Supporting roles, helpers and opponents to the protagonists in a story. They are run by the narrator and live and act in the game world. All persons in a story, except the players' protagonists, are narrator characters. STORY: The exciting, dramatic tale the narrator and players create together. A story consists of a number of scenes which contain places, events, narrator characters, clues and background information that frame the adventures and missions the protagonists encounter. BONUS: The opposite of penalty. If an action is easy to perform the result of the dice roll for the action can be improved through bonus. The lowest die's result is 5. The highest die's result is 8. All dice in the roll together give the result 13. A roll with maxed dice. The result is 30 (7 + 10 + 10 + 3). Each 10 means that another die is rolled and added to the final result. The dice roll is exceptional because both dice show the same number. The result is 12 (6 + 6). The roll is considered successful if the total sum (the dice roll's result + Skill or Attribute Value) reaches equal to or over 20 (in a difficulty roll) or is higher than the opponent's (in a resistance roll), otherwise it is failed. A block with the result 11 (1 + 10). Each 1 in a dice roll blocks a 10, that is, prevents it from being maxed.

PARTICIPANTS: Players and storyteller, that is, those who participate in the roleplaying. BOMB: An open choice situation where players through their main characters determine how the story and main characters will develop. Bombs should be formulated so that doing nothing also constitutes taking a stance. Some bombs are prepared in advance by the storyteller, others arise naturally during the course of play. DEAD: The person is deceased and is no longer an active part of the story. A player whose main character dies usually creates a new one who is given space in the story at an appropriate time. MORTALLY WOUNDED: The person is so severely injured that they will die within one or a couple of minutes. A mortally wounded person can be stabilized by someone with medical knowledge. ATTRIBUTE: A person's basic aptitude to become skilled in an area. ATTRIBUTE VALUE: Indicates a person's maturity/ development for an attribute. EXPERIENCE: A point value that is given to the main character and which is based on how much they have learned during the course of the journey. Used to improve attribute values and skill values, acquire expertises, and increase Fate. EXCEPTIONALLY SUCCESSFUL ROLL: A successful roll in which the dice also show identical numbers. Grants extra advantages to the action performed. EXCEPTIONALLY FAILED ROLL: A failed roll where the dice also show identical numbers. Causes disadvantages to the action performed. EXPERTISE: Special competence in, or specialization within, a skill. SKILLS: Everything a person has learned and trained up. SKILL VALUE: Indicates how much knowledge and/or proficiency the person has in a skill. DEFENSE SKILLS: **The collective name for the skills** Tolerance, Resist and Resilience which are used to withstand physical, social and mental attacks. DEFENSE ACTION: Collective name for the actions a person can perform when they are attacked. roll is important, and all means that the sum of the result on all dice in the roll is important. All possible maxed dice are also counted when reading lowest, highest and all. Individual results can among other things affect when it comes to determining a certain time, for example "Lasts for the lowest die's result number of minutes", or to

get a sum, for example "Strike as many cartridges from the magazine as the value on the highest die". **Dice Rolls** When you want to determine whether a desired action succeeds or fails, a dice roll is made. There are two types of dice rolls: difficulty rolls and resistance rolls. A good general rule for all forms of dice rolls is to always let the rolled dice lie openly on the table so that the result can be read. This is because not only the total value but also the individual dice's numerical values shall be readable and used for various purposes. Sometimes the storyteller may also have hidden bonuses and penalties that are applied to the roll. When should you use dice rolls? It's easy to think that you must roll dice in all possible and impossible situations to see if you succeed with what you have set out to do — this can include everything from opening a door to driving a car. This is not the case. **Dice rolls should be made in the following situations** • When it is interesting for the scene or story whether the person succeeds or fails • If the randomness of the roll contributes to creating drama or tension. • If some form of conflict or challenge exists. • If a person's health and/or survival is at stake. Rolls should usually not be made in the following situations • If the situation is routine, boring or trivial for the person. • If the randomness would destroy mood and drama. • If an action's outcome has already been established in the scene, new rolls should not be made for the same thing; if for example a person has succeeded in sneaking past a guard, then they have succeeded and the stealth skill should no longer be questioned in the scene. **Difficulty Rolls** Difficulty rolls are made when a person must overcome a fixed difficulty, without direct involvement of any other person. Driving a car, pushing open a door, climbing over a wall or finding certain information in a book are typical situations where difficulty rolls are made. Difficulty rolls are always made with two dice (2D) and to this is added a skill's proficiency value or an attribute value. The result is always compared against a fixed difficulty level of 20. If the result equals or exceeds 20, the outcome is counted as successful, if it is below 20 the roll is considered failed. Which proficiency or attribute value should be used for the roll is stated in parentheses. "Make a difficulty roll (Manual Dexterity)" means that the person shall roll 2D and add the proficiency value in the skill Manual Dexterity. If this sum equals or exceeds 20, the action succeeds. It can happen that a person is so skilled that they reach 20 automatically even before the dice are rolled. This is logical since a very skilled individual does not fail at routine tasks. Rolls can still be made if it is deemed important to check if the outcome becomes exceptional (see below). **Resistance Rolls** Resistance rolls are made when two or more people try to win over each other through different forms of influence and conflict. On almost all occasions when a personal skill is directly pitted against another person's skill, resistance rolls are used. Common examples of when resistance rolls are used are during persuasion attempts, gambling, arm wrestling and attacks in combat. Resistance rolls are always made with two dice (2D) and to this is added a skill's proficiency value or an attribute value. The person who gets the highest result on their roll succeeds in successfully carrying out their intended action. The one who got the lower result therefore fails. Which proficiency or attribute value should be used for the roll is stated in parentheses. "Make a resistance roll (Strength)" means that each of those involved shall roll 2D and add the proficiency value in the skill Strength. The one who gets the highest sum is considered to have succeeded with the roll and the current action. In cases where two or more parties reach the same sum, the one with the highest proficiency or attribute value wins. If the value is the same, the one who has the highest value on any of the dice wins. If even this is equal, each party rolls 1D and whoever rolls highest wins over the other — if equal, the die is rerolled until the result differs. **Exceptional Rolls** An exceptional roll results in something special occurring, something extraordinary that affects the person's future in some way. Exceptional rolls can influence either positively or negatively and can occur with both difficulty rolls and resistance rolls. A roll counts as exceptional if the first two dice in the roll show the same number — any maxed dice don't count. If a roll counts as successful and is also exceptional, it is called an exceptionally successful roll and something positive occurs beyond the action succeeding. If a roll counts as failed and is also exceptional, it is called an exceptionally failed roll and something negative occurs beyond the action failing. Exactly what happens during an exceptional roll depends on what the roll concerns; generally it is up

to the storyteller and player to dramatically and engagingly describe an event that is reasonable in the scene. In combat it is defined that it is the person's initiative that is affected, which is described for each combat action. Example: Anya Malov is on her way home through the rain when she hears the sound of an engine behind her. She turns around and sees how the headlight beam from a sports car approaches at high speed. Her

only choice is to throw herself aside. A difficulty roll (Reactions) is made and the dice show 9 + 9, which together with Anya's skill gives a result far over 20 — an exceptionally successful roll. With a normally successful roll, Anya would simply have suc-ceeded in avoiding being run over, but since the roll is exceptionally successful she doesn't just jump aside but performs an elegant somersault, comes up on her feet with perfect balance and gets a chance to read the license plate on the fleeing car. Example: Jessca Navarre hangs in a rope outside a skyscraper in the central parts of Sandukar. She has just cut open a window and is about to enter the building when fate strikes and her flashlight gives out. Since she finds herself in a chal-lenging situation, her player must make a difficulty roll (Dexter-ity) for her to have a chance to replace the batteries. The roll shows 2 + 2 which together with the skill value in Dexterity doesn't reach over 20 — the roll becomes exceptionally un-successful. Rather than simply failing to get the new bat-teries in, Jessca drops both flashlight and batteries, which silently fall toward the wet pavement far below. **Complex Actions** When an action is so extensive and/or time-con-suming that more than a simple difficulty roll is required to determine success or failure, the action is considered complex. This could for example involve picking a door or a safe, searching through an archive for informa-tion or studying academic research material. **Performing a Complex Action** The narrator determines how much time each attempt to perform the complex action shall take and then specifies the chal-lenge level. The sum from each successful difficulty roll is added together and when you reach the challenge level you have completed the action. Determine a time for each difficulty roll, for example "one roll per minute". Examples of times are given in table 1:34. Each roll represents an attempt during which a certain time pas-ses — a roll might be made every minute or half hour. A failed roll doesn't mean the entire action fails but rather that it takes longer to perform it, since the failed attempt has taken time. **Time Example** Very fast (one roll per round) Pick a lock, hotwire a car Fast (one roll per minute) Disarm a bomb, repair a simple machine Short (one roll per ten minutes) Build a timed bomb, set up a camp in the wilderness Long (one roll per hour) Search for information in an archive/library, crack a cipher Very long (one roll per day) Repair a car wreck, compose a piece of music Extremely long (one roll per week) Translate a book, build a bridge Table 1:34 Once the time is set, the complex action's challenge level is determined, that is, the sum one must at least reach for the complex action to be considered successfully completed. The challenge level is determined by the complex action's difficulty, according to table 1:35. **Difficulty Challenge Level Example** Simple 50 Pick a padlock Ordinary 100 Pick a door lock Troublesome 150 Pick a security lock Significant 200 Pick a safe Table 1:35 **Outcome** The outcome of difficulty rolls is calculated differently depending on the roll's suc-cess when it comes to complex actions. Exceptionally successful: The roll's sum counts double. Successful: The roll's sum counts. Unsuccessful: The roll's sum doesn't count. Exceptionally unsuccessful: The person gives up the com-plex action entirely. Example: Gabriel is going to pick the rusty lock on a worn back door. He has skill 10 in Dexterity and an expertise in lockpicking that gives him a bonus (+2). Picking the door is considered a complex action. The time is set to Very fast (one difficulty roll per round) and the difficulty to Simple (challenge level 50). In the first round, the dice in the difficulty roll show 4 + 4, which gives the sum 20 (10 + 2 + 4 + 4) — an exceptionally successful result. The total sum increases by 40 (20 + 20) so Gab-riel is close to getting the lock open at once. In the next round, a new difficulty roll is made, the dice show 2 + 3, sum 17 — a failure. The total sum is still 40 and the round's six seconds are wasted. The narrator informs that Gabriel hears footsteps further away in the dark alley and that he should expect company in about two rounds so he better hurry! The following round's difficulty roll is made and the dice show 4 + 7, which gives sum 23, a successful result. The total sum reaches 63 (40 + 23), which is higher than

the challenge level of 50 so the picking is successfully completed. Quick as lightning, Gabriel gets the door open, sneaks in and closes it behind him while he hears the footsteps pass by outside. **Hidden Rolls** Generally, there are no problems letting the players make the rolls that concern their protagonists openly. In certain situations it may be that the narrator wants to make rolls for the protago-nists hidden. This could involve events when the players shouldn't get the forewarning that a dice roll implies, for exam-ple if some unknown narrator character is spying on the protag-onists or discovering a cigarette butt with lipstick on it under a bed. **The Narrator's Rolls** In most cases the narrator can choose whether his/her rolls should be hidden or open. Many narrators prefer to make all their rolls hidden and focus on the drama and describe the outcome directly rather than let all participants share in the dice roll. At especially dramatic climaxes in a scene where for example a protagonist's life hangs in the balance with a dice roll, it can however become very exciting to make the roll openly. DEFENSELESS: A person who is not able to defend themselves and who can be subjected to two specific ac-tions — knocked out or executed. MALFUNCTION: Means that an object stops working. Often occurs if an action fails exceptionally and the dice show low numbers. PROTAGONIST: The heroes in a story are called protagonists and each protagonist is controlled by a player. The protagonist is created according to the game's rules and receives different values and characteristics which determine his/her competence and skill in the game world. Once the game session has begun, the protagonist develops in different ways through the choices the player makes. HIGHEST VALUE: The number on the die in a difficulty or resis-tance roll that shows the highest value. INITIATIVE: Indicates how composed, coolly and effectively a person acts in combat. The higher the value, the more effective. Also determines the person's turn order in combat. INITIATIVE ACTION: Collec-tive term for the actions a person can actively perform in combat. CATATONIC: The term for the lowest level of Wellbeing. COMPLEX ACTION: A series of difficulty rolls made at regular intervals. When the total sum of the difficulty rolls reaches a determined challenge level, the action is considered successfully completed. CHRONICLE: A series of stories that are connected, but which usually have concluded parts. Often appear-ing in previously experienced sto-ries are established narrator characters, incidents or other connections in the different parts, but in completely different situations. An example of how the stories can be connected is through the protagonists being given the task of locating three missing persons — when each individual person is found, it's seen as a concluded story, but the chronicle isn't finished until all three persons have been found. COME TO: A dazed person must come to in order to again act and perform actions. LIFE EXPERIENCE: The accu-mulated amount of experience a person has gathered in their life, over the course of different stories.

SUCCESSFUL ROLL: When the result of a roll is sufficient to overcome an obstacle or succeed at a challenge, the roll is considered successful.

LOWEST VALUE: The number on the die in a difficulty or opposed roll that shows the lowest value.

MAXED DICE: Each die showing a ten allows an additional die to be rolled and added to the final total. See also locks.

UNCONSCIOUS: An unconscious per-son may not take an active part in the story until he/she has come to.

FAILED ROLL: If the result of a roll is insufficient to over-come the obstacle or succeed at the challenge, the roll is considered failed.

OPPOSED ROLL: Used in situa-tions where two or more people are trying to best each other in some way. Participants roll two dice (2D) each and add their skill or some other appropriate value. The one with the highest result wins and the roll is considered successful. The opponent's roll is considered failed.

STUNNED: The person has taken so much of a beating that he/she is so knocked out, confused, or in so much pain that he/she can no longer act independently. A stunned person must come to before he/she may perform any further action.

RELATIONSHIP MAP: Helps the narrator keep track of their narrator characters and how they react to the protagonists' actions. Both narrator characters and protagonists appear on the relationship map, with the various relationships that bind them together.

SCENE: A building block in a sto-ry. Usually contains a clear element, for example the meeting with an important person, the flight from villains, the bank robbery, et-cetera. Lasts anywhere from a few minutes to days or weeks in game time.

SKILL: The sum of an attribute value and an ability value. Indicates a person's total knowledge in an ability. It is the skill value in an ability that is added when dice rolls are made.

ROLL: A dice throw — ei-ther a difficulty roll or an opposed roll. Can also refer to the outcome of a dice throw.

Bonuses & Penalties

A roll can be affected in two ways. One is through bonuses, the other through penalties. Bonuses are added to a result while penalties are subtracted from it. A roll can be affected by both bonuses and penalties at the same time. A bonus is written in text with a plus sign and a number in parentheses, for exam-ple (+5). A penalty is written in text with a minus sign and a number in parentheses, for example (−2).

A general list of appropriate bonuses and penalties base-d on the action's difficulty is given in table 1:36. The table should be seen as an aid — nothing prevents narrators from using values other than those suggested.

When an action or task is deemed routine, it is automatically considered successful. Examples of this could be that an experienced taxi driver doesn't need to strain themselves to find the city's best hotel and a well-trained athlete automatically manages to do thirty push-ups.

Bonus/ Penalty Complexity Example +10 Very easy Passing a car on a deserted country road +5 Easy With a sports car, passing a truck with oncoming traffic +2 Fairly easy Driving through a busy intersection ±0 Challenging Driving fast through busy streets in pouring rain −2 Fairly difficult Making repeated overtakes at high speed in rush hour traffic −5 Difficult At high speed avoiding a motorcycle that suddenly drives out in front of your car −10 Very difficult At high speed on an icy road turning ninety degrees with the car into a narrow alley −20 Unreasonable With a motorcycle running a truck off the road −30 Hopeless While maintaining control at high speed skidding 180 degrees in a truck with trailer and punctures on all wheels, and then driving on

Table 1:36

Collaboration

Multiple people can collaborate when a roll is to be made, if the task is such that more participants improve the chance of success. Examples of actions where it is advantageous to have multiple people are when trying to break down a door, pull a person up on a rope, disarm a complicated explosive charge or search for information in books. A typical situation where it doesn't help to have multiple people is when driving.

Each person who helps with an action, and who is considered qualified within the action's area, gives the person who will make the roll (usually the person who has the highest skill in the relevant ability) a bonus (+2).

The narrator must determine how many people can reasonably help at the same time — even if there are twenty people available, not all can break down the blocked door simultaneously.

Actions

The term action is used in all cases where a person wants to attempt to do something. An action can be more or less challenging, but some form of reasonable risk of failure must exist. Actions' outcomes are determined via the result of either an opposed roll or one or more difficulty rolls.

Each protagonist has 9 attributes and 27 abilities. It is usually with the help of skill in an ability that a roll is made. In some cases rolls are made with the help of attribute values. In most cases it is obvious which skill or att-ribute value is most appropriate. If it is unclear, the narra-tor and player discuss their way to what applies.

Noir's system is not built for interaction between abilities and/or attributes. All rolls are made with the help of one value — either a skill value or an attribute value. In spe-cial cases multiple rolls with the help of different skill and/ or attribute values may be needed in sequence to determine a result.

The players and/or narrator may also determine that personal influence can help or hinder an action — character traits, motivations and other things can influence the action's result positively or negatively.

Defense Abilities

The abilities Resist, Resilience and Tolerance constitute a person's defense against social, mental and physical attacks respectively. When opposed rolls to withstand influence are made, the victim must add the value in the appropriate defense ability to the result.

Resist is used as defense in social conflicts, for example seduction, interrogation or persuasion attempts. Resil-ience is used as defense against horror experiences, stress or violations. Tolerance is used as defense against adverse climate, drug influence or poisoning.

Perception Abilities

The abilities Awareness, Intuition and Empathy are typical perception abilities — how well a person perceives things in their surroundings. Awareness is the five common senses — sight, hearing, touch, taste and smell. Intuition is the sixth sense, a subconscious sense that interprets information intuitively and can provide clues or premonitions about what is to come. Empathy opens a person's emotional channel so that he/she can sense and read other people's general mood — for example sadness or anger.

Often the narrator makes rolls with the protagonists' percep-tion abilities secretly, to avoid unnecessarily giving players insight that they might be missing something.

Luck

The attribute Luck shows a person's unconscious flow in existence and general luckiness in situations where skill is sub-ordinate. Luck can be used in all situations where chance determines an outcome, without direct influence from a person. For exam-ple, Luck is used in combat in the defensive action Chance De-fense. In a situation where a group of protagonists risk being hit by a falling flowerpot, it is the one who gets the lowest result on their opposed roll (Luck) who gets the pot on the head. Generally Luck is used when the person is not aware of the situation and cannot influence its outcome. Otherwise it is usually more appropriate to use an ability.

Breaking free from rope/straitjacket Mobility **Communicating with animals Empathy** Sensing that something is wrong Intuition **Landing favorably when falling Mobility** Leading/influencing a group of people Leadership **Local knowledge Worldliness** Calming down/comforting a person Empathy **Deceiving a person Charm** Lifting/dragging Strength **Applying first aid Medicine Noticing things Awareness Marching Endurance Mathematics Natural Science Remembering something Deduction Modifying objects Construction Bribing a person Convince** Painting/drawing Create **Noticing hidden objects on a person Awareness Performing an autopsy Medicine Posing Mobility Haggling over price Convince** Psychiatry/psychotherapy Medicine **Psychology Humanities Religion Humanities Repairing objects Construction Riding a horse Vehicles Swimming Endurance Shooting with firearms Firearms Setting up a base camp Construction** Hitting/breaking objects Strength **Fighting Melee Sneaking Awareness Blending into surroundings Worldliness** Quickly reacting physically to sudden events Reactions **Running a marathon Endurance Tracking Awareness Stabilizing injuries Medicine Pickpocketing Sleight of Hand Resisting physical influence Tolerance Resisting mental influence Resilience Resisting social influence Resist Resisting fatigue Determination Disabling objects Construction** Assembling/rigging a bomb Construction Searching area/location Awareness Tactics/strategy Deduction **Hot-wiring vehicle Construction Harassing a person Convince Comforting a person Empathy** Enduring/controlling chaotic situations Composure **Teaching a person Leadership** Perceiving that someone has been at the location Awareness Acting/entertaining Charm **Detecting danger Intuition** Investigating incident/situation/case Deduction Appearing anonymous/inconspicuous Worldliness Verifying facts/authenticity Deduction **Searching a person Awareness Zoology Natural Science Persuading a person Convince**

Table 1:37 Actions & appropriate abilities for performing them

In table 1:37 follows a series of actions along with recommen-dations for which ability can be used together with each action. See it as a guide when deciding which ability fits best in different situations.

Action/knowledge Ability **Administration Humanities** Acting relaxed within a social grouping Worldliness **Analyzing Deduction Architecture Natural Science Attracting a person Charm Executing a person Determination** Balancing on unstable/narrow surface Mobility **Maintaining calm Composure Driving Vehicles Biology Natural Science Crime scene investigation Deduction Building something Construction Dancing Mobility Deciphering Deduction Disarming a bomb Construction Drawing a throwing weapon Throwing Weapons Drawing a melee weapon Melee Drawing a firearm Firearms Drug knowledge Medicine Picking a lock Sleight of Hand Economics Humanities Stubbornness Determination Finding the right person in the city Worldliness Flying an aircraft Vehicles Photography Create Physics Natural Science Forging Create Writing texts Create** Tailing a person/vehicle Awareness **Seducing a person Charm Negotiating Convince Interrogating a person Convince Disguising oneself Create** Faking/imitating voice/mannerisms Charm **Defending against physical attacks Defense Seeing through lies Resist Hiding Awareness** Hiding/planting objects on a person Sleight of Hand Hiding/planting objects at a location Awareness **Keeping track of the situation Worldliness** Handling/identifying firearms Firearms **Gambling Worldliness History Humanities Jumping Mobility** Threatening a person Strength, Convince or Leadership **Interviewing a person Convince Law Humanities** Throwing objects/throwing weapons Throwing Weapons **Diving for cover Reactions Chemistry Natural Science Handling chaotic situations Composure** Handling disgusting/repulsive experiences Resilience **Climbing Mobility**

SOCIAL CONFLICT: When a protagonist and a narrator charac-ter want to achieve different goals through a conversation or discussion. Social conflicts often have an active and passive party and can escalate if a participant so desires, often at some cost.

PLAYER: Participates in the game via their own protagonist who is their connection to the game world and the story.

GAME SESSION: The term for a game meeting, that is, the real time that passes between game start and game stop. During a game ses-sion one or more scenes unfold and sometimes even multiple stories, depending on the game session's length.

GAME TIME: The time that passes in the story. It can pass at different paces and has no connection to the time that passes in real-ity during the game session.

GAME WORLD: The world where sto-ries in Noir take place, usually in the dark city of Sandukar, but also in other places in the Imperium.

LOCK: Each die showing a one prevents a ten from being rolled again, see maxed dice.

STABILIZE: A medically skilled person can stabilize a mortally wounded person so that they survive.

COMBAT ACTION: Action per-formed during combat; either an initia-tive action or a defense action.

DIFFICULTY ROLL: Used when a person tries to overcome a passive difficulty for example climbing up a steep slope or picking a lock. Two dice (2D) are rolled and the person adds their skill or some other appropriate value. If the sum is equal to or over 20, the roll is successful. If it is under 20, the roll is failed.

D: Same as die.

TURN ORDER: The order in which people act in combat.

DIE: A ten-sided die with values 1–10 (if the value 0 is represented on the die it should be interpreted as 10). Two dice are used when dice rolls are made.

DICE ROLL: Can be either difficulty or opposed roll.

CHALLENGE LEVEL: The total sum that difficulty rolls must reach for a complex action to be considered successfully performed.

Social Interaction, Reputation & Relationships To survive in a cold and harsh world, it's important to have contacts and friends you can turn to for help. Otherwise, you often learn the hard way that alone is weak.

Social Interaction

The interaction between player characters and narrator characters is a vital part of any roleplaying story. Many scenes consist of various forms of dialogue, whether it be persuasion, threats, or perhaps seduction. These are collectively called social conflicts as they involve two wills struggling to achieve their respective goals.

This section describes the procedures used in social conflicts between player characters, and between player characters and narrator characters. The rules are designed to create drama and to give player characters who are skilled at the social game the advantages they deserve.

Conducting Social Situations

There are essentially three different ways to act out social interaction, and none is really more right or wrong - different gaming groups prefer different methods.

The first method involves no dice being used at all; all dialogue takes place between the players and/or the narrator - in other words, what a participant says becomes what their player character or narrator character says in the story. This method takes very little notice of the character's numerical values, and the role is replaced, so to speak, by the person behind the character and their social and verbal competence.

The second method is to roll dice for appropriate skills - whoever wins succeeds at what they set out to do and the scene is over. This is how most actions in Noir work, from combat and driving to picking locks or fixing a broken engine, so why shouldn't Persuade and Charm work the same way? However, this method is far from ideal. Social interaction is important in roleplaying - the form of roleplaying is made for conversation and for the entertainment, joy, and drama it brings when participants together build atmospheres, crystallize characters, and move the story forward.

What remains then is the third method: combining methods one and two. This is the approach Noir advocates and that the rules best support. In this case, the social conflict begins with

the players delivering the arguments their player characters would have presented in the story, and the narrator does the same with their narrator characters. When it feels appropriate, resistance rolls are made to determine who gains the upper hand in the conflict.

If one or more parties have succeeded in providing good, exciting, sharp arguments during the opening, this should be rewarded with a bonus to the roll. Factors such as character traits and/or motivations can also have an effect, and naturally any relationship between the parties should also be factored into the whole.

The Social Conflict

The purpose of social conflicts is that they are indeed conflicts to be overcome. A conflict can vary in scope from small to large, from personal to universal. Almost all social situations in Noir can be seen as social conflicts.

Parties

In every social conflict there is an active and a passive party. The active party uses some appropriate skill - usually Charm or Persuade - to achieve their goal, see table 1:38. The passive party, that is, the one being targeted, usually uses the skill Resist. In situations where violence, or the threat of violence, is involved, the passive party can use the skill Resilience instead.

If there is any doubt about who is active and who is passive in a social conflict, the rule of thumb is that whoever has the highest attribute value in Impression is the active party.

In the rare situations where there is no passive party - this occurs primarily in pure debate situations - both parties roll with skills as if active.

Selection of

Social Actions | Skill Act/perform | Charm Dupe/manipulate | Charm Seduce/captivate | Charm **Negotiate | Persuade Interrogate | Persuade** Threaten/intimidate/harass | Persuade* **Interview | Persuade Haggle over price | Persuade** Mingle/converse | Charm **Bribe | Persuade Sing | Charm** Flatter/fawn | Charm Entertain/amuse | Charm Convince/plead | Persuade

Table 1:38 * With the right expertise, Strength or Leadership can also be used.

The Stakes

In certain social conflicts it seems natural that the active party must choose what the goal of the conflict is. Or rather, what happens if the goal is achieved. This is called the stakes. In the same way, the passive party should propose what the effect will be if the active party fails to gain the upper hand and win the conflict. Both stakes should be roughly equally serious - so that an attempt to win big means that a failure also becomes significant.

For example, a failed negotiation at a critical stage might mean the active party is ostracized or dismissed, successful mingling grants an audience with the countess while a failure means dishonor upon the character and their family, and attempting to sing high C can mean anything from fantastic to catastrophic reviews in the culture sections the next day.

Example: Gabriel and Mercurian are both in love with a mysterious femme fatale named Yvonette. Gabriel wants to get Mercurian to back off and not interfere with his continued courtship of Yvonette. The stakes for Gabriel are proposed to be "get Mercurian to stop loving Yvonette." In the discussion between players, however, the stakes are judged to be skewed - it's not something a social conflict can decide, but something deeper. Instead, the stakes are redefined to the clearer "get Mercurian to stay away from Yvonette for now."

The effect if Gabriel loses becomes "Gabriel becomes uncertain of himself regarding his chances with Yvonette compared to Mercurian's." Exactly what that would mean can be judged in future scenes featuring the three involved - perhaps Gabriel gets a penalty on the courtship, or maybe Mercurian can play out the discussion they had to make Gabriel angry, broken, or sad.

Social Conflicts Between Player Characters

Player characters can also be active and passive in a social conflict. This means that one player character can influence another according to the rules above. A player has no general veto, but if an influence goes strongly against a character's personality, the resistance roll should be modified with bonuses or penalties to symbolize this.

"You don't seem too smart. I like that quality in a man." "What do you like more? Laziness? Ugliness? Horniness? I possess them all." "I don't think you seem lazy." — Stelia Lock and Mordekai Remus

When Rolls Should Be Made

It should be emphasized that rolls should only be made if there is a conflict where opposing wills are struggling for the upper hand. Does Androv succeed in convincing **Raceu to abandon the idea of revenge? Does Teresia succeed in charming Markeriu into revealing the code to the safe? Does Captain Merkel succeed in getting the broken soldier on his feet through his morale-raising speech about patriotism and comradeship?**

If all parties in a scene are in agreement, no resistance rolls need to be made at all - if Dorian wants to have sex with Julianique, then Julianique doesn't need to exert herself to succeed in seducing him.

Resolution

Whoever gets the highest result on the resistance roll stands as the victor in the conflict. If the one who didn't want to be persuaded (the passive party) wins in an argument about whether Sayah Bonn is the world's most beautiful woman, it means the arguments didn't bite and the active party must accept that they were wrong. If

the one who initiated the conflict (the active party) wins, this means the opponent accepts and agrees that Bonn is indeed the world's most beautiful woman.

Note that a victory doesn't necessarily mean the loser changes their attitude about what the conflict concerned, but only that the winner's arguments trumped the loser's.

A win in a social conflict is lasting for at least the current scene and at most until further notice, depending on the situation and the stakes - people are by nature changeable and can change their minds at the most inopportune times.

A social conflict can escalate, see below, if the losing party doesn't accept the outcome.

If a party during a social conflict gets an exceptional result on the resistance roll, the character gets either a bonus (+5) or a penalty (-5) on all further rolls in the same social conflict - this is important during escalation.

Escalation

The losing party in a social conflict has two alternatives. The first, and perhaps most common, is to accept the defeat and act according to the winner's goal, based on any stakes. The second is to escalate the situation in hopes of a changed outcome.

Every social conflict has four levels of severity: Conversation, Quarrel/squabble, Brawl/fistfight, and Deadly violence.

Conversation: The parties discuss in normal tones and present their positions, wishes, or wills with respectful and logical arguments.

Quarrel/squabble: The situation is harsher in tone. Loud exchanges of opinion, crude insults, hurtful personal attacks, verbal blows below the belt, shoves, slaps, or blustering gestures close to the opponent's person are included.

Brawl/fistfight: The situation degenerates and the discussion turns into non-lethal violence - such as wild fistfight, sneaky cheap shots, throws and holds, chaotic wrestling match, or storming close combat with all manner of improvised weapons. However, the intent is rather to defeat the opponent than to kill them.

Deadly violence: A raging fight to the death breaks out. The parties don't hesitate to attack each other with merciless violence, with everything from melee weapons to firearms, with the intent to kill. Uninhibited combat is a fact.

Whoever is active in a social conflict determines which escalation level the whole thing starts at - either Conversation or Quarrel/squabble. When the loser decides not to accept but to escalate the conflict, they can go to whichever escalation level is desired, as long as it's more serious than the current one. Then the winner can choose to follow to the new level or abstain and hand over the victory to the loser.

To my admirer Adrian Niemans, thank you for your support and for the beautiful flowers. You know how to make a film star happy.

If the victor follows to the new level, a new opposed roll between the parties shall be made and the loser gets to decide whether to either accept or escalate the conflict further, as far as is possible. Which abilities are used for the roll are judged case by case depending on circumstances and situation.

At the levels Brawl/fight and Lethal violence, a party can at any time choose to give victory to their opponent by giving up and accepting defeat.

The point of the escalation rules is to give the player good opportunities to participate in the conflict and steer it forward if desired. Most often escalation means that some form of cost arises in the form of enmity, lost face, missed opportunity, visit to jail, or in the worst case, that someone dies. Sometimes it can be considered worth paying that cost to win a conflict.

Example: Mordekai has picked up the scent of one of those responsible for his beloved's death. The person is at the opera when the rain-soaked Mordekai throws open the door to the foyer. At the door is a snooty opera guard who informs Mordekai that he must wait until intermission as no admittance is allowed after the performance has begun.

This is a typical social conflict, where Mordekai as the active party tries to persuade the guard to let him in. Mordekai sets the level to "Conversation" as he doesn't want to brawl openly and draw attention from the other opera employees. The opposed rolls are made with Convince versus Resist and the guard gets a higher result than Mordekai.

Mordekai can now choose to accept not being let in, or he can escalate the conflict — which he does! He pulls it straight up to "Brawl/fight" and simply decides he wants to knock down the opera guard, who chooses to follow along in the escalation. This means the social conflict becomes a fight where Mordekai fairly quickly gains the upper hand and wins. The guard, as loser, chooses to accept without escalating to the final level: "Lethal violence".

The cost in the given situation is that other staff have contacted the police to remove Mordekai from the opera.

Special social situations

Certain forms of social conflicts require a more detailed explanation. See below.

Interrogate

To interrogate someone means that through psychological attrition, frightening threats, fair promises or with brutal violence one attempts to force information out of someone. The one conducting the interrogation is always active and the one being interrogated is passive. Each opposed roll is calculated to take approximately one hour to complete.

If the active party fails, their Wellbeing decreases (−1) due to frustration. If the active party succeeds, the passive party suffers stress corresponding to a shocking experience, or, if much violence, threats and torture have occurred, a psychological trauma. When the passive party's Wellbeing reaches Tormented (2) or lower, the passive party's defenses break and the active party learns all reasonable information they requested.

The active party can affect their roll. By using torture they get a bonus (+5). If the active party possesses information that affects the passive party on a personal level — for example real threats against family/relatives, threats of revealing something the interrogated doesn't want to come out, or similar — they get a bonus (+5). Each doubling of interrogation time gives a bonus (+2), up to a maximum of (+10).

Haggle over price

When a buyer tries to haggle down the price of goods, an opposed roll is made as usual for a social conflict — the buyer is always active and the seller always passive.

If the buyer succeeds, the price is lowered by five percentage points times the number on the lowest die in the roll. If the buyer fails, the price is not adjusted. When haggling, usually no direct stake is made, as it is considered a universal phenomenon in Sandukar and the Empire. Those who don't try to haggle are viewed with skepticism. This also means the seller usually sets a higher price on their goods than what they expect to actually get.

Threaten

By acting threateningly, a person can frighten another person into doing things they don't really want to. The one making the threat is always active while the target is passive. If the opposed roll succeeds, the passive party is exposed to stress, corresponding to a shocking experience, which is described on page 244.

The relationship automatically worsens one step when threats are used, regardless of whether the conflict is escalated or not.

Inspirational speech

A leader can make a mentally worn subordinate, soldier or henchman feel better through an inspirational speech. The one speaking is always active while the target is passive. If the opposed roll succeeds, the passive party's Wellbeing improves one level, if it fails it worsens one level. The passive party's Wellbeing may at best be Gloomy (6) for the speech to have any effect.

At most one attempt may be made per game session and person.

Bribe

By bribing a person with money, objects or advantages, a person can reach set goals more easily or escape tragic situations. The one bribing is always active and the recipient of the bribe is passive. If the opposed roll succeeds, the passive party is bribed and performs what the active party requests. The relationship automatically worsens one step when bribes are used, as respect is eroded. If the same person is bribed multiple times, the relationship is not lowered again however.

Generally a bribe should correspond to at least half a monthly salary (for the passive party) for minor activities, and one or more monthly salaries for more serious ones. Situation and circumstances — such as the consequences the passive party perceives they could suffer if the activity is discovered or how great the risk is of being caught — must determine how large the bribe should be. If too low sums are offered, the active party gets a penalty, while higher amounts provide a bonus. In the Empire everyone is corruptible if the sum is right.

The importance of game flow

Defining the stakes — what happens both with a successful and with a failed result — before the dice are actually rolled can be double-edged. At best it leads to everyone participating in the conflict knowing what's at stake, accepting it and moving forward with what they intended to do.

On the other hand, this defining can initiate a long discussion about what is reasonable and what is not, which in turn leads to players wanting to revise the outcome at for example a success in order to thereby change the

result of a possible failure. Such discussions can become very drawn out and destroy the flow of the game and the total experience for everyone involved.

To avoid unnecessary game interruptions, the narrator can introduce penalties to the opposed roll for each time a player changes their mind. This can be explained in the story by the protagonist seeming nervous or otherwise uncertain about their case and their arguments. Another tool for the game master to maintain game flow is to only let the players define what they want to happen with a successful outcome and only when the dice are rolled explain what happens with a possible failure.

Seduce

"If you want someone to love you, open your heart. If you want someone to become obsessed with you, close it." — Talia Navarre

Seduction is the art of enchanting someone to do something for you. Generally the relationship worsens one step if the opposed roll fails for the active party.

One of the most common stakes is that the active party simply tries to get the passive party in bed, to have sex or for some other reason.

Another common stake is to create an attraction. This means the active party tries to get the victim interested, lured, focused and tempted, through promises, hints and flirtation. This is done through an opposed roll (Charm). If the active party succeeds, they get until further notice a general bonus (+2) on all rolls in such social interactions with the victim where it is judged that the attraction can facilitate. Note that it can be completely non-sexual interactions — once the attraction is awakened, it is.

The active party can try to strengthen an attraction through another successful opposed roll so it becomes a passion. If this succeeds, the bonus becomes (+5) instead.

Both attraction and passion are noted in the character sheet, next to the relationship.

Note that the seduction doesn't need to be of a sexual nature at all — a leader who captivates underlings or an artist who succeeds in charming an admirer follow the same rules.

An attraction or passion needs to be maintained to persist — if the active party ignores or humiliates the victim too much, a passion can drop to become an attraction and an attraction can cease entirely. Often this results in hurt feelings and bitterness on the victim's part.

As usual, if a victim is willing, no rolls need to be made at all. The same applies if the victim lacks capacity to be seduced, for example if a man tries to pick up a homosexual woman, if a woman wants to have sex with an impotent man, etcetera. However, it is entirely possible for attraction or passion to arise even if an anything but benign relationship exists between two individuals — even enemies can be attracted to each other.

Notoriety

Notoriety shows a person's fame and celebrity status. The normal state is for a person to be Unknown (Notoriety level five). If Notoriety increases to a level above five, it means the person has been noticed for events or statements that by common people are perceived as exemplary, praiseworthy and good. If Notoriety instead decreases to a level below five, then the public's perception is rather that the person is villainous, threatening and evil.

All notoriety levels except Unknown (5) have a modification attached to them, see table 1:39. This modification can be used by the narrator as a bonus or penalty in situations where the person's reputation is judged to be able to affect an action's outcome. When for example people with good reputation speak warmly for a cause, they influence those who listen, and when a person with bad reputation threatens someone it has greater effect as the reputation has preceded the person.

The opposite also applies – a person with a good reputation who acts threateningly might not be taken as seriously, and then the modification might instead give a penalty in the situation.

Reputation Bonus/penalty Spheres of influence Lauded (10) ±10 5 Honored (9) ±5 4 Respected (8) ±3 3 Known (7) ±2 2 Mentioned (6) ±1 1 Unknown (5) ±0 – Notorious (4) ±1 1 Infamous (3) ±2 2 Scum (2) ±3 3 Monster (1) ±5 4 Abhorred (0) ±10 5 Table 1:39

Spheres of influence

Each time a person reaches greater Reputation it must be specified to a sphere of influence or a grouping. The sphere of influence shows where the person is known and where their Reputation can affect and be used. Examples of spheres of influence are The academic world, The general public, Children, Crime syndicates, Bureaucrats, Refugees, The street, Club life, Criminals, The church, Resistance groups, The military, The entertainment industry, The police, The press, The justice system, High society, The sports world, The state, Houses, etcetera.

If a person's reputation decreases this means that a previously established sphere of influence disappears – cross out the one that makes most sense.

Example: Sayah Bonn is a famous film star. Her reputation is Respected (8). The three spheres of influence she has are: The general public, The entertainment industry and The press. This means that she has a bonus or a penalty (±3) within these spheres in situations where her reputation could be thought to improve or worsen her situation.

Recognition

People with Reputation other than Unknown (5) must be recognized before their modification can be used. To be recognized the observer must succeed at a difficulty roll (Worldliness), with the target's modification from their Reputation as a bonus. A person is automatically recognized within their spheres of influence.

How reputation changes

There are no concrete rules for how a person's Reputation changes. The guidelines are that a person who does not actively work to increase or maintain their reputation tends to lose it after a time. In the same way sudden upheavals can result in large jumps in Reputation – if for example the respected philanthropist is exposed in the press as a sadistic pedophile their Reputation will plummet, and their spheres of influence will change.

Relationships & Contacts A protagonist has a defined relationship with all narrator characters he/she knows. Each such narrator character also has an influence that shows his/her power within the field he/she operates in.

When a protagonist is created relationships are established, see page 29. During the course of a story the player can create new relationships themselves by expending Fate to gain contacts (see page 240). Even

narrator characters who appear in a story can be entered as relationships if the situation encourages this.

Usually relationships have no other values than Influence/field and Relationship which are described in this section. Should a relationship/contact need to be filled out this is done according to the rules that exist for narrator characters on page 330.

Impression

Impression shows how a person is perceived and received by others at first meeting. Each time a protagonist enters a social conflict with a new narrator character a difficulty roll (Impression) must be made to see how the protagonist is perceived by the narrator character. The result gives the relationship the protagonist has with the narrator character during the social conflict and until further notice.

Note that even if several protagonists are part of a group it is the one who primarily acts in the social conflict who creates the relationship – the other protagonists do not get a relationship with the narrator character.

Exceptionally successful roll: The relationship is set to Benevolent. Successful roll: The relationship is set to Neutral. Failed roll: The relationship is set to Disliking. Exceptionally failed roll: The relationship is set to Hostile.

The difficulty roll can be modified depending on whether the narrator character has any preconceived opinions that could affect it. A person who for example hates police and who is interrogated by a constable gives a penalty to the constable's difficulty roll. Other things to consider here could be factors such as racism, rivalry, possible threats, prejudices, previous experiences, or general behavior by the person before the difficulty roll (Impression) is made.

A narrator character never makes an Impression roll to create a relationship with a protagonist – the protagonist's player decides for themselves how he/she perceives the narrator character based on the narrator's portrayal.

Thoughts on seduction

The reason there are special rules for seduction and attraction is that the classic noir ingredient of temptation/desire for the unattainable should be emphasized. A man who seeks to win the cool woman who has enchanted him with her icy charm and intensity, the woman who can manipulate and tempt him to anything, cannot resist his lust despite the risks it brings.

"I once knew a woman who looked like you." "Really?" "She's dead now." "How sad, what happened?" "I killed her." "Why?" "Otherwise she would have killed me." "You seem to have bad luck with women." – Mordekai Remus and Stelia Lock

Relationship

A person is rarely alone in the darkness of the city. Turning to others and sharing joy, experiences and companionship is a way to resist the heavy and inhumane environment the city represents. In the same way previous meetings may have resulted in conflicts, quarrels and hatred. This is shown through the relationship a narrator character has with a protagonist.

The five levels of relationships are: Friendship, Benevolent, Neutral, Disliking and Hostile.

A relationship's nature generally controls the protagonist's ability to influence the narrator character in social conflicts. It gives bonuses or penalties to the protagonist's rolls (regardless of whether he/she is active or passive) according to table 1:40.

Relationship Bonus/penalty Friendship +5 Benevolent +2 Neutral ±0 Disliking –2 Hostile –5 Table 1:40

Friendship

In Noir's world unconditional friendship is something rare. It means that the narrator character has a deep emotional bond with the protagonist and supports almost everything he/she needs help with, even if it is risky or dangerous. This level of relationship usually means that the narrator character loves or is deeply in love with the protagonist, or that they are very close friends since long ago.

Benevolent

The narrator character is benevolently disposed toward the protagonist and can consider helping out with time, information or material help without major demands for compensation. To get the narrator character to help with something that entails danger to his/her life or that constitutes a great risk however requires very good reasons or proper encouragement.

Neutral

The narrator character sees the protagonist as an acquaintance, someone he/she knows but has no special relationship with. The narrator character can politely help with simpler tasks or questions, but more advanced or dangerous proposals will probably result in the narrator character either breaking off the conversation or demanding good compensation. The narrator character may very well sell out the protagonist if such a situation should present itself, as there is no loyalty between the two.

Disliking

The narrator character probably sees the protagonist as an opponent. If this is the case the narrator character does not hesitate to put down, harass or humiliate the protagonist. It can even go so far that the narrator character actively tries to sabotage for the protagonist, not to inflict physical harm but rather to mess with him/her.

At lower influence levels it involves a lone individual or a smaller group of enemies, for example a small street gang or perhaps a couple of corrupt constables. Influential enemies are significantly more well-organized and have good equipment. At very high degrees of influence the opponent has very great power, he/she can for example be gang boss, member of a House, or similar.

Hostile

The narrator character is hostilely disposed toward the protagonist and does not hesitate to harm, maim or kill him/her if the situation should become serious. The protagonist should see the narrator character as a real threat if their paths should cross.

Sometimes the narrator character may seek out the protagonist themselves to set him/her up in various ways. It is a matter of pure and simple hatred, disgust, emotional bitterness or perhaps cold vindictiveness due to a real or fabricated wrong. An enemy does not hesitate to go after their victim's family, friends and acquaintances so everyone is in danger when the enemy is near.

At lower degrees of influence it involves a lone individual who has no direct significance but who can still be life-threatening. An influential enemy has a collection of henchmen, great resources or is very skilled at what he/she does. At very high influence levels it involves a very influential, rich, or powerful person, who spends time finding their victim and killing him/her.

Summary of relationships

How a narrator character generally behaves in relation to the protagonist, based on relationship, is described in table 1:41.

Relationship Means Possible actions

Friendship Takes risks to help Intimate conversation, sacrifices, protect, support, help, defend Benevolent Wishes well-being Talk relaxed, give advice, offer limited help, advocate Neutral Doesn't much care Talk superficially, ignore Disliking Wishes adversity Talk coolly, mislead/deceive, spread rumors, avoid, observe/monitor, threaten, insult, sabotage for Hostile Takes risks to thwart Attack, harm, kill, degrade/demean, slander, flee from, set up, destroy for Table 1:41

Changing an established relationship

An established relationship may very well change. Most common is that such things occur naturally in a story. The narrator must judge whether it is reasonable for the relationship to change based on the experiences the protagonist and narrator character share. If the protagonist for example sets up or makes life harder for the narrator character the relationship can deteriorate.

The relationship can change as many steps as necessary – a scorned lover may very well plummet from "Friendship" to "Hostile" if the protagonist has betrayed and deeply hurt him/her. In the same way a person who initially disliked the protagonist can after a time discover that the first impression was wrong and become "Benevolently" disposed.

A relationship does not change more than once per scene unless special reasons exist.

Family and kin

When it concerns relationships that are founded in blood or marriage the type of relationship, for example "brother" or "spouse", should be noted on the character sheet as such things can have impact. Blood is thicker than water and one's beloved may forgive more than a fleeting friend would have done.

Contact

A contact is a narrator character that the protagonist knows. **Contacts are acquired with the help of** Fate. The cost varies depending on the contact's influence. When the narrator character's influence is determined the relationship is decided through a difficulty roll (Impression).

A taxi took him part of the way but he chose to walk the last few blocks. He passed by a smoky bar where he had to stop and ask for directions. The grim, beer-reeking workers glared at him, they noticed he didn't fit in. The bartender explained the way though, and even drew a map on a napkin. He left the bartender a few zovrins and then continued on between the brick facades.

When he stood before the warehouse building he looked carefully around to make sure he wasn't being followed before slipping into the alley and approaching the back door. He knocked and almost immediately a bolt was drawn aside and the door opened. There stood a veiled woman with a candelabra in her hand, gesturing for him to enter. He stepped into the dimness and caught the scent of incense, paint, and turpentine. There was yet another smell making itself known, however, a stench of death, and it came from the woman beside him. The question he asked about whether it was her he sought went unanswered, instead she pointed with a stiff gesture toward a drape where a strip of light was visible. He asked again but the woman before him was locked in the same stiff gesture, with no tendency to move. The veil hiding her face was torture, what if she was the one he was looking for—admittedly impossible but what if... He slowly raised his hand and took hold of the veil's hem and the woman made no attempt to move, in fact not even a breath seemed to come from her body. Slowly he began to lift the veil but interrupted the motion when he heard footsteps behind the drape and a woman's voice asking him to come.

The drape was drawn aside for him and he entered a large studio with tall windows facing the night sky and the canal. In wine bottles and candlesticks, candles lit up the room and its countless easels, sculptures, and tapestries. He turned toward the woman who had called to him, his aunt and newly found mentor. He thanked her for receiving him and she nodded while taking a deep drag from her cigarillo and examining him from top to bottom. His own gaze caught on her long, yellowed nails and on the white hair hanging in stringy strands over her back. She was old, but her face was surprisingly young and free from wrinkles.

In the corner of his eye he saw the veiled woman enter through the drape and position herself in a corner. The aunt bared her yellowed teeth in a bestial grin and said that he was not yet ready to see the veiled one's face but that it was a step in his education. He was told to sit down while she sketched him with charcoal and told him about his coming time as an apprentice, the tasks he would perform and the paths he would walk. She too was of the Hrůzda family and her art drew power from dark and ancient forces—forces he would learn to master. For even though power exists in both wealth and servants, there is also power in images and words and by depicting the perfect image one can gain control not only over oneself but also over life, death, and time. The image of the murdered woman with the haunting face will forever exist as a ghost in his mind, but by drawing it he can also give it life.

The man from the Hrůzda family sat until morning listening to his aunt and when sunlight shone on the portrait of him he fell to his knees in gratitude for this was a gift greater than any other. He now understood the meaning of the name Hrůzda and would in the boundless terror find the truth.

Influence

Influence shows how much influence the narrator character (the relation) has within their field. There are five degrees of influence: Very great influence, Significant influence, Influential, Moderate influence, and Minor influence.

At each degree of influence there is a value called Power that symbolizes the relation's general power, resources, and forcefulness with a game-mechanical value. When needed, rolls (Power) can be made to determine whether the narrator character succeeds with the task he/she has set out to do—for example getting hold of the secret document, persuading the prosecutor to drop the case, fixing the sniper rifle without paperwork, or perhaps gaining access to the film star Sayah Bonn. Naturally this roll can be affected by penalties or bonuses depending on what is to be accomplished.

A narrator character's Influence and Power are summarized in table 1:42.

Degree of Influence Power

Very great influence 18 Significant influence 15 Influential 12 Moderate influence 9 Minor influence 6 Table 1:42

Field

To give the narrator character some form of framing, he/she gets a sphere of influence. This is called the narrator character's field.

Common fields are • The academic world • The general public • Children • Crime syndicate • Bureaucrats • Refugees • The street • Club life • Criminals • The church • Resistance groups • The military • The entertainment industry • The police • The press • The justice system • High society • The sports world • The state • Houses

The protagonist's anatomy

A protagonist is described using a number of attributes and abilities whose values show how accomplished the person is in various fields. Together they provide the person's skills from which a number of attributes are derived.

Attributes

There are a total of nine different attributes. An attribute is a person's basic prerequisite. There are three categories of attributes: physical, mental, and spiritual, and there are three attributes in each category.

The physical attributes

• Coordination • Build • Motoric

The mental attributes

• Education • Creativity • Will

The spiritual attributes

• Insight • Perception • Charisma

Every attribute has an attribute value that shows how well developed it is. An attribute can at lowest have attribute value one (1). There is no upper limit for how high an attribute value can reach. Table 1:43 summarizes an attribute's capacity.

Value Capacity

1–2 Poor. The person's capacity within the attribute is either untrained, unutilized, or undeveloped. 3–4 Average. The attribute is used and trained to a normal extent. 5–6 Good. Either the person possesses a natural talent within the attribute or it is regularly trained and used. 7–8 Excellent. The attribute is very well developed and utilized. It is likely one of the person's gifts. 9+ Fantastic. The attribute is developed as far as human capacity allows, thanks to thorough and continuous training, refinement, and/or due to extremely favorable personal prerequisites. Table 1:43

Abilities

A person's abilities indicate his/her learned and trained competence, knowledge, and talent within a given field. There are a total of 27 abilities, each of which is linked to a governing attribute. Every attribute governs three abilities. Every ability has an ability value that shows how skilled the person is within the ability's area.

Physical abilities (with respective governing attribute) • Close combat • Reactions • Mobility • Endurance • Strength • Tolerance • Dexterity • Throwing weapons • Firearms

Mental abilities (with respective governing attribute) • Humanities • Medicine • Natural science • Construction • Create • Deduction • Determination • Resistance • Sense

Spiritual abilities (with respective governing attribute) • Empathy • Withstand • Worldliness • Vehicles • Intuition • Awareness • Charm • Leadership • Persuade

Every ability has a value that shows how developed it is. A person who is completely inexperienced within an ability starts with ability value zero (0). There is no upper limit for how high an ability value can reach. Table 1:44 summarizes an ability's level of competence.

Value Level of competence

0 Nonexistent. The person lacks knowledge or methods for using the ability. Attempting to use the ability results in a greatly increased risk of failure. 1–3 Amateur. The person has basic, unpolished, and untrained knowledge or approaches for performing the ability. This also includes a certain form of general knowledge within the ability's area. 4–6 Competent. The person has proven and reliable knowledge, qualifications, or methods for performing the ability. 7–9 Professional. The person has broad, detailed, and comprehensive knowledge or methods for performing the ability. 10–12 Expert. The person has very great, significant, and deep knowledge or methods for performing the ability. 13–15 Master. The person is among the most skilled within their area and possesses enormously outstanding and recognized knowledge or methods for performing the ability. 16+ Unsurpassed. The person is among the best, most skilled, and respected in the world at performing and understanding the ability. Table 1:44

Nonexistent competence

A person who has ability value zero (0) in an ability lacks the basic knowledge he/she needs to be able to use the ability in a competent way. Naturally good capacity in the ability's attribute can facilitate usage but without concrete competence in the ability it becomes difficult anyway. As long as the ability value is zero (0) the person receives a general penalty (–5) on all dice rolls regarding the ability.

Skill

The sum of an attribute value and an ability value is called skill and is always obtained from an attribute and its underlying ability. Attribute values are never added to an ability's value unless the attribute governs the ability.

It is always the skill that is added to difficulty rolls and resistance rolls, never an individual attribute or ability value. (Formula for skill: attribute value + ability value).

Skill = attribute value + ability value

Example: Jessica has attribute value 8 in Motoric and ability value 15 in Throwing weapons. This gives her a skill of 23 in the use of throwing knives.

} Coordination } Build } Motoric } Education } Creativity } Will } Insight } Perception } Charisma

Description of the Attributes

Here follows overview descriptions of the attributes. Education (mental attribute) Education shows the brain's memory capacity and ability to collect, store and categorize learned theoretical information. It gives a picture of the person's understanding of the stored information and provides subconscious methods for quickly and efficiently remembering facts and app-lying them in arising situations. Education is important for, for example, students, researchers, teachers, doctors, scientists, profilers, lawyers, bureaucrats, librarians, society people, leaders, con artists and planners. Insight (spiritual attribute) Insight is a person's common sense, understanding of events around him/her, ability to interpret and exploit situations, handle quick turns and surprises without being caught off guard as well as to resist temptations, lures and attractions. The attribute also includes being able to understand and empathize with other people's emotional states. Insight is important for, for example, scouts, spies, fences, fixers, leaders, soldiers, gamblers, con artists, lawyers, criminals and socialites. Coordination (physical attribute) Coordination is the person's bodily balance, ability to move harmoniously and in a controlled manner, to react based on sensory impressions and maneuver their body. The attribute also shows the person's reaction ability and physical speed. Coordination is important for, for example, boxers, brawlers, martial artists and troublemakers, but also athletes, dancers, mountain climbers, burglars, acrobats, gymnasts, magicians and wall climbers. Creativity (mental attribute) Creativity shows a person's imagination, creative power and basic curiosity. It also indicates aptitude for putting together disparate parts into wholes and drawing concrete conclusions, as well as showing ingenuity and inventiveness. Creativity is important for, for example, artists, authors, actors, reporters, profilers, detectives, engineers, mechanics, designers and inventors. Physique (physical attribute) Physique shows a person's physical well-being, health status and muscle strength. It indicates in what condition the body is, how strong and how resilient it is as well as how well-toned, defined and aesthetically pleasing the muscle mass is. The attribute does not show the person's physical size – that is instead described on page 87. Physique is important for, for example, athletes, boxers, laborers, sailors, brawlers, weightlifters, runners, models, bodybuilders, police, soldiers, hit men and bouncers. Dexterity (physical attribute) Dexterity shows a person's manual dexterity, and finesse as well as aptitude for precision work. It gives steady hands and fingertip sensitivity. Dexterity is important for, for example, shooters, locksmiths, magicians, card players, athletes, criminals, police, soldiers and snipers. Perception (spiritual attribute) Perception is a person's ability to observe things or phenomena using sight, hearing, taste, touch and smell, and to be able to draw conclusions from the impressions. It constitutes the aptitude to understand and filter impressions and prioritize what is currently most important. It also indicates the person's sensitivity to the usually imperceptible, such as body language, mannerisms, nuances in speech, nervousness and lies. Even what is usually called instinct is included. Perception is important for, for example, interrogators, hunters, soldiers, psychologists, therapists, profilers, police, forensic technicians, con artists, drivers, pilots, lawyers and detectives. Presence (spiritual attribute) Presence is a person's charisma, charm and aura. It indicates the person's power of attraction, ability to influence others and convey messages. The attribute affects how the surroundings react and receive what the person says and thinks. The attribute does not include the person's physical appearance – that is described on page 87 – but a person with strong presence can be anything from fantastically beautiful to repulsively ugly. Presence is more about the ability to influence and convince others through social aggression or shamelessness. Presence is important for, for example, actors, leaders, con artists, salespeople, interrogators, models, military officers and cult leaders. Will (mental attribute) Will is a person's willpower, mental resilience, determination and ability to

take action. It gives strength to steel oneself in demanding and stressful situations, to manage to carry out activities under pressure and to summon inner strength to achieve results when everything is against you. The attribute gives personal calm, dignity and self-respect together with the power to resist influence and provocations without reacting emotionally or rashly. Will is important for, for example, athletes, leaders, celebrities, entrepreneurs, soldiers, police, businesspeople, rescue personnel, doctors, negotiators, scientists and artists. "In my experience there are three ways to get rid of a blackmailer. Either you pay, and pay, and pay, until you're ruined. Or you call the cops and your secret becomes front-page news. Or you kill him." — Gabriel Jandaran

Description of the Skills

Here follows overview descriptions of the skills. Determination (Will) Determination shows a person's stubbornness and ability to achieve results, regardless of setbacks and obstacles. The skill helps the person maintain focus and concentrate on the task to be performed and prevents the person from being affected by disturbing elements. It indicates the person's ability to absorb new knowledge, apply old knowledge in new ways, and absorb and store information under pressure. Determination is an important skill for leaders, elite soldiers, detectives, coaches, athletes, detectives, planners, students, lawyers, researchers, scientists and journalists. Charm (Presence) Charm is used to influence, beguile, mislead, manipulate, deflect suspicions as well as lie quickly, effectively and convincingly. The skill also covers flirtation, courtship and seduction. It also includes entertaining other people through performance, acting, drama and role-playing. The skill is useful when it comes to imitating other people. Charm is an important skill for con artists, swindlers, femme fatales, hustlers, actors, entertainers, singers, spies, lawyers, salespeople and scouts. Empathy (Insight) Empathy indicates a person's compassion, ability to empathize and sensitivity to other people's feelings and moods. The skill facilitates communication by providing the person with subconscious information and ability to interpret this information in a correct way. A person with Empathy notices if someone else is nervous, worried, upset, sad, depressed, or affected by some other strong emotion. Empathy also gives the ability to understand others' drives and motives, even if one doesn't share them oneself. Empathy is an important skill for interrogators, parents, doctors, priests, psychologists, counselors, negotiators, forensic technicians, detectives, entertainers, lawyers and advisors. Manual Dexterity (Dexterity) Manual Dexterity controls fine motor skills in precision work with the hands. The skill is used for example in card tricks, magic tricks and other forms of entertainment. Pickpockets need it to steal things from pockets and the like, and it is indispensable in lockpicking. Manual Dexterity is an important skill for magicians, locksmiths, burglars, pickpockets and car thieves. Vehicles (Perception) Vehicles gives knowledge of how to operate different vehicles, which laws and rules apply when operating vehicles and how to perform rudimentary vehicle maintenance. The skill is mainly used when something extraordinary occurs during travel, for example during chases, vehicle failures or sabotage against vehicles. Vehicles is an important skill for chauffeurs, taxi drivers, aircraft pilots, motorsport drivers, getaway drivers, sea captains, transporters and stuntmen. Humanities (Education) Humanities consists of knowledge acquired through studies and learning in various social science and humanistic subjects. The skill gives basic general education in a number of different subjects such as for example economics, history, linguistics, literary and art appreciation, law, political science, sociology, philosophy, psychology as well as religious studies. Note that this concerns a very broad overview – for deeper and more practical applicability the person needs to acquire expertise in the desired subjects. Humanities is an important skill for students, bureaucrats, researchers, academics, historians, socialites and teachers. Intuition (Perception) Intuition is the person's instincts, reflexive actions and sensitivity to their surroundings. It makes the person subconsciously vigilant and attentive to suspicious behavior or strange situations as well as gives the ability to instinctively protect oneself from such things. Intuition helps when it comes to seeing through lies and detecting signs of stress. Intuition is an important skill for police, detectives, soldiers, psychologists, interrogators, spies, burglars,

lawyers, forensic technicians and con artists. Throwing Weapons (Dexterity) Throwing Weapons indicates proficiency in throwing objects with precision and hitting what one aims at. The skill also includes things like weapon maintenance and knowledge of what range of throwing weapons is available on the market. The skill applies to all types of thrown objects, from stones and snowballs to throwing knives and hand grenades. Throwing Weapons also gives some understanding of combat and behavior in life-threatening situations. Throwing Weapons is an important skill for circus performers, knife throwers, soldiers as well as dodgeball and basketball players. Stamina (Physique) Stamina shows a person's physical endurance, energy and health status. It gives the person strength to push themselves to the limit and to continue fighting even when every muscle in the body screams for mercy. The skill shows what physical shape a person is in. Stamina also indicates how patiently a person withstands bodily injuries and their effects. Stamina is an important skill for athletes, bodyguards, soldiers, hunters, survival experts, weightlifters and brawlers. Construction (Creativity) Construction is the talent to assemble, understand and repair technically advanced constructed objects or to set up camps, build houses or erect bridges. All forms of basic knowledge in mechanics, electronics, engine knowledge and repair are included, but deeper knowledge in each field is acquired through expertise. Construction is an important skill for mechanics, installers, electricians, welders, foremen, craftsmen, plumbers, engineers, bomb makers and repairmen. **Basic knowledge** A person who has skill value one (1) or more in Humanities can read and write their native language and has basic mathematics knowledge. For deeper knowledge in mathematics the skill Natural Science is required. All persons are considered able to swim adequately even though there is expertise within Stamina that improves one's performance in water.

Leadership (Charisma) Leadership is the ability to get people to listen and absorb the message you want to convey. It can involve directing a group of people in a certain direction, getting them to perform a task, or cease a certain activity. Different social strata have different methods for achieving results, but eloquence, rhetoric, charisma, and presence are essential parts of successful leadership. Leadership is also used to appear strong and indomitable in a threatening or stressful discussion. The ability can be used to add weight behind threats and intimidation. Leadership is important for commanders, interrogators, lawyers, police officers, teachers, managers, con artists, negotiators, and cult leaders.

Medicine (Education) Medicine is studied and learned knowledge about the human body, everything that can afflict it, and ways to remedy such afflictions. The ability's scope includes elementary competence in making diagnoses, performing surgical procedures and practicing emergency medicine, as well as knowledge of anatomy, psychiatry, toxicology, forensic medicine, and drugs. Even basic knowledge of diseases and poisons is included. For deeper specialist knowledge, expertise is required. Medicine is an important ability for doctors, therapists, coroners, surgeons, ambulance personnel, military personnel, police officers, and society poisoners.

Resist (Insight) Resist helps a person withstand external social influence and provocations without reacting rashly or emotionally. It gives the person the capacity to see through what is being said, how it's being said, and why it's being said, and thereby the ability to defend themselves against arguments or attempts at influence. Resist is used to withstand persuasion attempts, handle temptations, enticements, attractions and seductions, as well as interviews and interrogations. Resist is an important ability for unfaithful husbands, spies, couriers, con artists, interrogators, police officers, bureaucrats, waitresses, strippers, prostitutes, and merchants.

Natural Science (Education) Natural Science consists of learned and studied knowledge in various technical areas such as mathematics, logic, and physics, and basic familiarity with chemistry, metallurgy, and biology. Additionally, a person with Natural Science possesses superficial knowledge in zoology, astronomy, geology, and botany. To deepen knowledge, further expertise in different fields is required. Natural Science is an

important ability for students, bureaucrats, researchers, academics, architects, engineers, technicians, scientists, and teachers.

Close Combat (Coordination) Close Combat is a person's aptitude for attacking and harming enemies in close combat, with or without implements. It provides understanding of how close combat psychology works and how feints, tricks, and deceptions are executed correctly. A person with good close combat ability lacks or can overcome the barriers that exist in most people when it comes to going after an enemy with everything they have. There are numerous expertises that deepen the ability. Close Combat is an important ability for gang members, bouncers, small-time thugs, brawlers, bartenders, police officers, soldiers, boxers, fighters, gangsters, hitmen, and thugs.

Reactions (Coordination) Reactions is a person's reflex speed and reaction ability. The ability provides advantages in combat situations where instinctive action, quick reflexes, and the ability to quickly assess and react are decisive. Reactions is an important ability for boxers, soldiers, police officers, gangsters, martial artists, and athletes.

Resilience (Will) Resilience is a person's mental toughness and psychological defense as well as the ability to maintain focus and distance despite strong mental stress. It helps the person handle severely degrading and traumatic experiences, such as various forms of threats, stress, torture, violence, humiliation, and abuse. In directly frightening or disturbing situations, it is resilience that shows whether the person breaks down or not. The ability helps a person see through situations and endure the horrible and twisted, as well as function somewhat normally after trauma. Resilience is an important ability for commando soldiers, spies, smugglers, waitresses, soldiers, prostitutes, police officers, investigators, and informants.

Mobility (Coordination) Mobility describes a person's trained movement ability, grace, sense of rhythm, and bodily flexibility, agility, suppleness, and springiness. The concept also includes a certain form of balanced strength required for utilizing the body's sway and power in, for example, long jumps or free climbing. The ability is also used for bodily maneuvers such as acrobatic feats or advanced body contortions. Mobility also provides talent for more shady activities such as moving quietly or sneaking past others without being noticed. Mobility is an important ability for burglars, gymnasts, athletes, climbers, acrobats, detectives, scouts, commando soldiers, spies, dancers, strippers, and performers.

Composure (Will) Composure describes a person's self-discipline, dignity, and calm. A composed person is often methodical, controlled, balanced, and unaffected. Often the person possesses good self-confidence and is fundamentally secure. In stressed or surprising situations, those with good aptitude in the ability enjoy good opportunities to act relaxed, rationally, and calculatedly. The person can still crack and break down if the mental stress becomes too great, even if they might still manage to hide it from the world by maintaining an external calm and dignity. Composure is an important ability for martial artists, stressed careerists, wise hermits, lifestyle personalities, soldiers, shadow hunters, cult leaders, slick criminals, and con artists.

Create (Creativity) Create indicates a person's aesthetic development and talent. The ability is used when a person wants to write, compose music, paint, sculpt, photograph, or design and sew clothes. Create can also be used for more shady activities such as forging licenses, papers, and documents. Within the ability there is also knowledge of makeup, cosmetics, wigs, and disguise. Create is an important ability for artists, journalists, writers, actors, makeup artists, poets, musicians, photographers, entertainers, and designers.

Firearms (Motor Skills) Firearms is a person's ability to correctly handle, control, and fire firearms of various kinds, from light handguns to heavy sniper rifles and machine guns, but for deepening knowledge there are numerous different expertises. This includes familiarity with how to load, unsecure, perform bolt action, etc.

Knowledge of weapon models, basic weapon mechanism theory, ammunition knowledge, and weapon care is also included in the ability. Firearms provides certain insight into how to act in combat situations. Firearms is an important ability for soldiers, police officers, snipers, assassins, hitmen, gangsters, gang members, detectives, bodyguards, security personnel, and guards.

Deduction (Creativity) Deduction is the brain's ability to see connections and patterns and figure out seemingly nonexistent links through inference, reasoning, and logical thinking. It also indicates a person's ability to formulate and develop thoughts and ideas. The ability is used to draw conclusions, solve puzzles, crack ciphers and codes, interpret dreams and texts, or to progress in various experiments. Deduction is very common in the police force, especially among forensic technicians in evidence analysis at crime scenes. Deduction is an important ability for forensic technicians, criminal investigators, detectives, scientists, researchers, seers, criminals, doctors, and tacticians.

Strength (Build) Strength is a person's muscle mass and physical development, and a measure of both raw strength and strength technique. The higher value a person has in this ability, the more well-built and muscular they are. The ability is important for breaking down barriers, lifting heavy things, dragging objects, or smashing something or someone. Strength is an important ability for boxers, weightlifters, models, bodybuilders, bouncers, soldiers, fighters, hitmen, and laborers.

Tolerance (Build) Tolerance is the body's ability to resist foreign organisms, poisons, and drugs, as well as influence from cold and heat. Tolerance includes immune defense, metabolism, and general resistance—and of course tolerance to alcohol. Tolerance is an important ability for athletes, survival experts, soldiers, alcoholics, and vagrants.

Awareness (Perception) Awareness is a person's observational ability and vigilance and is used both actively and passively. It gives the person an aptitude for discovering and noting things by using and interpreting sensory impressions in the best way in every situation. The ability primarily concerns sight and hearing, but also touch, taste, and smell. It can also be used when searching persons, as well as to stay hidden and hide oneself. Awareness is an important ability for scouts, spies, bouncers, bodyguards, soldiers, police officers, snipers, detectives, forensic technicians, burglars, guards, and hunters.

Streetwise (Insight) Streetwise indicates the ability to function in social contexts. It constitutes a person's social agility and understanding of how the norms and culture that prevail should be exploited for best results. A person with Streetwise doesn't feel lost or out of place in social situations, regardless of circumstances or social class, but finds ways to fit in. The ability provides a sense of how to interact with people of various kinds, how to adapt language use, jargon, gestures, and conversation topics so as not to offend or show lack of respect for the person you're speaking with. The ability also includes various specialized areas within social contexts, for example gambling. Streetwise is also used to pick up and exploit information "on the street," knowing who to talk to about a certain question, or which bar is the hangout for a certain gang, etc. Streetwise is an important ability for gossip journalists, socialites, celebrities, spies, luxury prostitutes, intelligence agents, fixers, fences, undercover cops, con artists, gamblers, and models.

Persuade (Charisma) Persuade is the ability to verbally convey a message or desire to another person and try to get that person to follow your will. The ability covers social competence and allows the person to overcome inhibiting factors such as shyness or awkwardness. There are countless ways to achieve results, and the ability includes diplomacy, rhetoric, and negotiation technique as well as pure persuasive ability. The ability also covers interview and interrogation technique. Persuade is an important ability for businessmen, reporters,

leaders, mediators, negotiators, interrogators, prostitutes, salespeople, hitmen, spies, businessmen, detectives, and informants.

"The greatest of all conspiracies is that there isn't one! No one is after you. No one cares about you. It doesn't matter if you live or die. So, does that feel better now?" — Franko Millovy

Will to Live

Will to Live is a person's ability to withstand serious injuries without dying. More information can be found on page 264. The attribute value for Will to Live is obtained by adding together the skill in Determination, Fitness and Sense and dividing the sum by three (/3), rounded down, and then adding five to the sum. **Notoriety** Notoriety indicates how well-known a person is and how they are perceived by others. The reputation can be good or bad. Most people have Notoriety Unknown (5) — that is, they are completely unknown. A person's notoriety can be changed during the creation of traits, see page 86. **Damage Modifier** Damage Modifier is a person's ability to inflict extra damage on the enemy in close combat. The attribute value is added to all close combat attacks' damage value. The attribute value for Damage Modifier is obtained by adding together the person's skill in Strength with their Size and dividing the sum by ten (/10), rounded down. **Size** Size measures a person's physical bulk, presence, height and weight. The attribute value in Size affects a person's capacity to withstand damage. It is extremely rare that rolls are made directly for Size, instead the value is primarily used in calculations of other values. Once size is determined, it is very rare for it to change — certain expertises can, however, affect it over time. The attribute value for Size is normally 15, when the person is considered to be medium-sized. The value can be changed during the creation of the person's traits, see page 87. **Combat Movement** Combat Movement indicates the person's aptitude for maneuvering their body in a pressing situation such as combat. The concept includes things like not hesitating, moving in a zigzag, keeping the head low and running in a crouched position. In cases where distance measurement is needed in combat, the attribute value in Combat Movement counts as the number of meters the person reaches. This occurs primarily in connection with the Initiative actions Move, Fight and Fury Attack (see page 255). The attribute value for Combat Movement is obtained by adding together the skill in Determination, Fitness and Agility and dividing the sum by three (/3), rounded down. **Wound Threshold** Wound Threshold indicates how resilient a person is and their capacity to take damage without receiving Wounds. If an attack's damage effect exceeds the victim's Wound Threshold they receive a Wound, see page 262 for more information. No rolls are made against the attribute value for Wound Threshold, it is only used as a comparison value. The attribute value for Wound Threshold is obtained by adding together the skill in Fitness and Strength with the person's Size and dividing the sum by three (/3), rounded down. **Description of Attributes** A person has a number of attributes and attribute values. Attributes are a kind of secondary information about the person. Some of the attributes are used for rolls while others are used as references for other circumstances. The 16 attributes are • Defense • Learning • Impression • Standard of Living • Will to Live • Notoriety • Damage Modifier • Size • Combat Movement • Wound Threshold • Luck • Endurance • Appearance • Wellbeing • Fate • Awareness **Defense** Defense is a person's survival instinct and ability to keep themselves out of danger in combat. Defense is considered the basic instinctive disposition while trained thugs, police or soldiers have other trained methods to escape harm in various forms of combat. The attribute value for Defense is entered in the box marked "Defense" as well as in the two boxes marked "Ranged" and "Close Combat" respectively in the character sheet. For rolls (Defense), always use the attribute value that best fits the situation — either Ranged or Close Combat. The attribute value for Defense is obtained by adding together the skill in Intuition, Reactions and Vigilance and dividing the sum by three (/3), rounded down. **Learning** Learning shows a person's general aptitude, learning ability and wisdom. It shows how the person primarily learns things — the hard and physical way, by reasoning logically and rationally, or perhaps by having an innate cunning and a certain

measure of guile. Learning is used in the calculation of Experience, see page 220. The attribute value for Learning is obtained by adding together the skill in Determination, Reasoning and Worldliness and dividing the sum by three (/3), rounded down. **Impression** Impression shows how a person is perceived and treated by others when they meet for the first time. At meetings with significant narrator characters, a difficulty roll (Impression) is made. More information about impression can be found on page 209. The attribute value is obtained by adding together the skill in Charm or Leadership with the skill in Sense and Worldliness and dividing the sum by three (/3), rounded down. Charm/Leadership shows what impression the person gives — one of style and allure or one of respect and authority. **Standard of Living** A person's standard of living refers to their place in society's hierarchy. It shows birth, wealth, success and status. It is a simplified way of indicating what resources, what style and what housing a person normally has. A protagonist's standard of living is normally 4 but can be changed during the creation of traits, see page 86.

Luck

Luck shows the degree of good fortune in life and the person's general luckiness in situations where skill is worth nothing. Being lucky is granted to very few in the world of Noir. The attribute value for Luck is normally 0. The value can be changed during the creation of traits, see page 87. **Endurance** Endurance indicates how much beating, pain and stunning a person can withstand before they risk being knocked out, fainting or becoming unconscious. See page 263 for more information. The attribute value for Endurance is obtained by adding together the skill in Strength and Resistance with the person's Size and dividing the sum by three (/3), rounded down, and then adding five to the sum. **Appearance** Appearance is a person's physical exterior, features, bearing and beauty — or lack thereof. A good appearance helps the person in most cases of social interaction, debate and seduction. A frightening exterior and appearance defects can, on the other hand, make social interaction more difficult as others instinctively distance themselves from a person with such characteristics. Rolls are never made for Appearance but the attribute can give bonuses or penalties to social actions. The attribute value for Appearance is normally 0, which corresponds to an ordinary appearance. Appearance can be changed during the creation of traits, see page 87. **Wellbeing** Wellbeing shows a person's general health, energy level, freshness, mental soundness and general capacity for action and initiative. Various phenomena, such as hard work, taxing stress, shocking events and traumatic experiences lower a person's Wellbeing while sleep, food, shelter and security increase it. Love, drugs and therapy can also have an effect. More about Wellbeing can be found on page 242. If nothing special has emerged during the creation of limitations or traits, all persons start with Wellbeing Relaxed (10). **Fate** Fate shows the person's relationship to destiny and its whims. The person can manipulate the odds in life and sometimes succeed in performing things that seem unlikely or escape misfortune with a few scratches and mere fright. All protagonists begin with 10 points in Fate, unless something else emerged during the creation of traits. More about Fate can be found on page 236. **Awareness** Awareness is the person's talent for acting in a controlled manner in combat, their combat experience, quick thinking and ability to quickly assess the situation. Awareness is used to determine a person's Initiative, and gives the person the aptitude to act in an efficient, planned and decisive way in combat. For more information, see page 254. The attribute value for Awareness is obtained by adding together the skill in Reactions, Sense and Vigilance and dividing the sum by three (/3), rounded down. "I promise, I saw it, he was lying here. Three shots he took while lying down. First she fired one shot so he fell like a pine tree. Unprovoked, they talked a bit then she just shot. So fucking sick, she seemed to kiss him after he died. When she had left I ran out of hiding and called you, as soon as I could, on my word of honor. When I came back he was gone! Poof gone. As if the Reaper had taken him! I may be drunk but it's completely true, I promise!"

Protagonists learn from experiences, maturity, adventures and events. This is called gaining Experience. Experience is used to improve a protagonist's qualities. Experience & Life Experience After each story that is concluded, each protagonist who has participated receives a sum of Experience. This sum is added to any previously recorded Experience in the character sheet. The same sum is also added to Life Experience. **The total sum of Life Experience shows** how much Experience the protagonist has accumulated in total during all their adventures, and can be seen as a general indication of wisdom and knowledge, see table 1:45. It is a good sum for the narrator to use if the protagonists are at very different development levels and a narrator wants a newly arrived protagonist to catch up, then the narrator can award the inexperienced protagonist a certain sum of Experience directly after the protagonist's creation process has been completed. Experience shows how many available "points" a protagonist has to improve themselves. When a protagonist improves, the sum in Experience is reduced by the cost of the improvement. Life Experience does not decrease when Experience is used, nor can one use Life Experience to improve oneself. **Life Experience Maturity Level** 0–100 Untested 100–400 Tested 400–1,000 Practiced 1,000–2,000 Experienced 2,000–3,500 Hardened 3,500–6,000 Veteran 6,000–9,000 Authority 9,000–15,000 Excellent 15,000–25,000 Peerless 25,000+ Legendary Table 1:45 Example: Convarian has 120 points in Experience and 425 points in Life Experience. He is awarded 360 points in Experience, which increases Experience to 480 points and Life Experience to 785 points. Convarian spends 295 points of Experience on improving various abilities. In the character sheet it is noted that he has 65 points remaining in Experience, while Life Experience remains at 785 points. **Experience**

Learning

When a protagonist uses an ability and gets an exceptional result (whether successful or failed), they may place a learning mark next to the ability on the character sheet. This is also called marking the ability. A learning mark makes it easier for a protagonist to increase the ability's ability value by one level using Experience, see page 222. Only exceptional rolls for abilities grant learning marks. Exceptional rolls for attributes grant no marks. Learning marks remain with the ability until the ability value is raised, regardless of how long this takes. An ability can only have one learning mark at a time.

How a protagonist gains experience

After a completed story, the narrator should distribute Experience to the participants. This is preferably done when the protagonists have an opportunity to take it easy and reflect on what has occurred in their lives and what they have learned. Experience is distributed based on the story's Challenge. If the story has been challenging, difficult, and given the protagonists opportunity to grow and become an active part of the environment, this gives more Experience than if it had been simple, routine, and isolated. The points for Challenge are then multiplied by the protagonist's attribute value in Learning. Beyond this sum, extra experience can be awarded based on Ego – if a player has portrayed their protagonist in accordance with their personality, character traits, and motivations, and if they have actively supported and created exciting and dramatic situations during the story's course, they can be rewarded with extra points. The sum of all this becomes the number of Experience Points distributed to the protagonist. (Formula for Experience: (Learning x Challenge) + Ego).

Experience from motivations

A protagonist can receive Experience upon fulfilling motivations. The Experience is then distributed directly when the motivation is fulfilled and used in the same way as other Experience. For more information about Experience from motivations, see page 233.

Experience pacing

If Experience is distributed rarely, the protagonists should receive extra much when it does happen. However, it's recommended to distribute Experience fairly often since the protagonists' development then becomes more consistent and not so jerky. Additionally, this provides room to improve Fate continuously, something that can be crucial for the protagonists' lives and health.

When may experience be used?

Experience may be used when a protagonist is rested, is in an undisturbed place and doesn't feel stressed, for example after having slept through an uneventful night. The protagonist should feel calm and reflective and have opportunity to gather their thoughts. This can occur multiple times during one and the same story. Every time Experience is distributed, it can also be used immediately. However, Experience may not be used for things like in the middle of a scene in the story increasing an ability the player just discovered they needed, or improving Fate just when the need presents itself. Note that there are no limitations on how much unused Experience a protagonist may have. The player decides themselves when they want to use the protagonist's Experience for improvements.

Learning

The attribute Learning shows a person's general aptitude, learning ability, and wisdom. It shows how the person primarily learns things – the hard and physical way, by reasoning logically and rationally, or by having an innate cunning and a good deal of guile. More about Learning can be found on page 218.

Challenge

The Challenge is the story's difficulty level set in relation to the protagonists' knowledge, resources, and opportunities. Table 1:46 shows how many points a challenge should give depending on its difficulty level.

Rating | The Challenge was... 10 | Child's play – the protagonists danced through the story's problems without any difficulties whatsoever. 15 | Uncomplicated – sure, some resistance appeared, but on the whole the protagonists had no major difficulties solving the problems. 20 | Troublesome – the resistance was there and the protagonists had to exert themselves to overcome it with the right combination of cunning, luck, and skill. 25 | Tough – the resistance was tangible and purposeful, the protagonists had to fight hard to reach the goal and it was close a few times that someone bought it or nearly fumbled away. 30 | Enormous – virtually no protagonist has Fate left, their lives hung by a fragile thread on multiple occasions, the opponents' resources were enormous and the protagonists were truly exposed, outmaneuvered, and manipulated.

Table 1:46

Ego

Ego encompasses the player's roleplaying – how the player's protagonist expresses themselves in the world. What affects the rating in this category is how well the player lives out the character traits and background the protagonist possesses, how consistent they are in the role, in what way they use the bonds and contacts the protagonist has in the world and how they let their protagonist develop from experiences and knowledge. That the player is concentrated and doesn't clown around and disturb the atmosphere is also to be considered. Table 1:47 shows how many experience points from Ego that should be distributed depending on the player's participation.

Rating | **Participation was...** 10 | Ordinary – the player participated but didn't exert themselves notably and didn't contribute much to building up atmospheres or conveying the protagonist's personality. 40 | Active and engaged – the player succeeded well in conveying the protagonist's character, personality, and goals as well as being active in the story in a positive way. 100 | An exceptional performance – the player immersed themselves in the protagonist to a very high degree, was strong in the portrayal and independently created exciting, dramatic, and interesting events through the protagonist's actions, limitations, and choices.

Table 1:47

Example: Convarian has Learning 9. The just completed story was incredibly difficult, with tricky traps, cunning enemies, and several setbacks which gives him 25 points in Challenge. Multiplied by Learning this becomes 9 x 25 = 225 points Experience. During the story's course, Convarian's player was very involved in the story and roleplayed his character in a very convincing and consistent manner. Therefore the narrator gives him the highest possible points for Ego, that is 100 points. This means that Convarian is awarded a total sum of 325 (225 + 100) points Experience, which is noted in the character sheet under both Experience and Life Experience.

Challenge

Learning | **10** | **15** | **20** | **25** | **30** 1 | 10 | 15 | 20 | 25 | 30 2 | 20 | 30 | 40 | 50 | 60 3 | 30 | 45 | 60 | 75 | 90 4 | 40 | 60 | 80 | 100 | 120 5 | 50 | 75 | 100 | 125 | 150 6 | 60 | 90 | 120 | 150 | 180 7 | 70 | 105 | 140 | 175 | 210 8 | 80 | 120 | 160 | 200 | 240 9 | 90 | 135 | 180 | 225 | 270 10 | 100 | 150 | 200 | 250 | 300 11 | 110 | 165 | 220 | 275 | 330 12 | 120 | 180 | 240 | 300 | 360 13 | 130 | 195 | 260 | 325 | 390 14 | 140 | 210 | 280 | 350 | 420 15 | 150 | 225 | 300 | 375 | 450 16 | 160 | 240 | 320 | 400 | 480 17 | 170 | 255 | 340 | 425 | 510 18 | 180 | 270 | 360 | 450 | 540 19 | 190 | 285 | 380 | 475 | 570 20 | 200 | 300 | 400 | 500 | 600

Table 1:48

Improving a protagonist

Improving values costs Experience. A protagonist can be improved in four areas: increase attribute values, increase ability values, acquire expertise areas for an ability, or improve their odds with Fate.

With Experience the following activities can be performed

• Increase attribute value • Increase ability value • Acquire expertise area • Improve Fate

Increase attribute value

Increasing an attribute value costs 50 x the new level in the attribute value points Experience. Note that one must increase a value one step at a time.

Example: Convarian has attribute value 4 in Build. Increasing the value to 6 costs 550 points Experience (first 50 x 5 = 250, thereafter 50 x 6 = 300, sum 550).

Increase ability value

Increasing an ability value costs 10 x the new level in the ability value points Experience. Note that one may only increase a value one step at a time. If one wants to increase an ability value to over double the level in the governing attribute value, the Experience cost is doubled. This symbolizes that it requires enormous

training to reach ultimate success in a field one lacks basic aptitude for. If a protagonist has a learning mark next to an ability that is about to be improved, the cost to reach the next level is halved. Note that this only applies to increasing one level.

Example: Convarian wants to increase his ability value in Strength, which falls under the attribute Build where he now has attribute value 6. Currently Convarian has ability value 8 in Strength, but he wants to increase this as much as he can without getting the double cost. The highest ability value he can then reach is 12 (double the controlling attribute value, in this case 6). Increasing to ability value 12 costs 420 points Experience (first 10 x 9, then 10 x 10, followed by 10 x 11 and finally 10 x 12: sum 420). Convarian discovers he has Experience left so he decides to after all increase Strength one more step. Ability value 13 is over his double controlling attribute value, which means the cost is doubled, so it costs him 10 x 13 x 2, or 260 points. Thereafter Convarian wants to increase Awareness. He has ability value 3, but also has an improvement mark noted after an exceptional failure that occurred during the story's course. He wants to increase Awareness to level 5. This costs him 70 points Experience (10 x 4 x 0.5, followed by 10 x 5, sum 70).

Acquire expertise area

Acquiring a new expertise area for an ability costs 10 x Complexity points Experience. Note that an expertise area's Requirements must be fulfilled for a protagonist to be allowed to acquire it. The protagonist may also not have a higher total sum in

Quick reference for Experience

In table 1:48 experience based on Learning and Challenge is calculated in advance. Learning is shown on the vertical axis and the different challenge levels on the horizontal axis.

Complexity than ability value in all of an ability's expertise areas, see page 58. A protagonist can erase learned expertise areas, but does not get back the Experience points that the exper-tise areas cost to acquire. Naturally, the erased expertise areas' values do not count toward Complexity, since they no longer exist or can be used. Removing expertise areas can be interesting if a protagonist wants to completely change direction within an ability, for example perhaps a rifleman who has lost his arm wants to "forget" his expert knowledge in rifle handling and instead concentrate on becoming a skilled revolver shooter. Example: Convarian wants to become a specialist in shooting with his revolver, an R&S .38 Stealth. He has ability value 4 in Firearms so he can at most have expertise with a total complexity value of exactly four. He already has the expertise "Take cover" which has Complexity 2. Acquiring "Weapon han-dling: Revolvers" and "Weapon expert: R&S .38 Stealth" costs a total of 3 (2 + 1) in Complexity, which is one too many. Conva-rian can choose to increase the ability value in Firearms one step but he will then not have enough Experience to acquire the two expertises he wants. The solution is that he forgets "Take cover" and acquires the two new expertises for a total of 30 Experience points ((2

- 1. x 10). "Take cover" is erased from the character sheet and "Weapon handling: Revolvers" and "Weapon expert: R&S .38 Stealth" are added. Convarian is satisfied as he now gets a bonus of a full five (+5) when he uses his revolver. **Improving Fate** A protagonist can improve their standing with Fate through Experience. For a cost of 2 Experience points the protagonist gets to increase Fate one step. A protagonist can have a maximum of 25 in Fate.

Example: Convarian wants to improve Fate by seven steps. This costs 14 points (2 x 7) Experience. **Extreme values** A protagonist who reaches extreme attribute or abil-ity values finds it much harder to improve fur-ther. This means that it is usually much more econom-ical to become reasonably skilled in several fields than

to become hyperskilled in a single one. There is no upper limit for how high a protagonist's values can reach. When an attribute value is increased to 10 or higher, each new level costs five times more Experience than usual. Similarly, the cost increases five times when an ability value is increased to level 20 or above. This is summarized in table 1:49. Example: Increasing attribute value 9 to 10 costs 2,500 (10 x 50 x 5) Experience points. Similarly, it costs a full 1,200 (24 x 10 x 5) Experience points to increase ability value 23 to 24. **Attribute value Ability value Increase multiple** 10 or higher 20 or higher x 5 Table 1:49 **Skills that affect attributes** When a person's skill increases, this can affect the per-son's attribute values. This effect is listed below. **Ability Attribute** Determination Learning, Willpower, Combat Movement **Charm Impression Intuition Defense** Endurance Willpower, Combat Movement, Injury Threshold **Leadership Impression** Reactions Defense, Overview **Resistance Stamina Mobility Combat Movement** Sense Impression, Willpower, Overview **Deduction Learning** Strength Damage Bonus, Injury Threshold, Stamina Awareness Defense, Overview Worldliness Learning, Impression Training & studies A protagonist can engage in studies to learn things and acquire knowledge. However, this method is nowhere near as instructive as gaining experience through real experiences and insights. **Study ability** The protagonist can choose to study an ability. After 40 hours of study in a suitable place and with appropriate study material, the player rolls a difficulty check (Learning) to see what result the studies produced. Attributes cannot be trained in this way. Exceptionally successful roll: The protagonist receives as much Experience as the sum of the results on all dice. In addition, the studied ability counts as learning-checked until it is improved. Successful roll: The protagonist receives as much Experi-ence as the sum of the results on all dice. Failure: The protagonist receives as much Experi-ence as the result on the lowest die. Exceptional failure: The protagonist learns nothing during the period. **Teaching** A teacher who helps and guides a student can increase the student's understanding of the study material. The teacher rolls after 40 hours of teaching a difficulty check (Leadership), before the student rolls their check. The result gives the modification the student gets on their difficulty check (Learning) for studying an ability. Exceptionally successful roll: The student gets a bonus (+5) on the difficulty check. Successful roll: The student gets a bonus (+2) on the difficulty check. Failure: The student gets a penalty (–2) on the difficulty check. Exceptional failure: The student gets a penalty (–5) on the difficulty check. **Daily grind** A protagonist who is not active in a story or who is not actively studying still learns things just by being in the world. After each month in the game world, the protagonist rolls a difficulty check as if they had studied an ability. The player and narrator should agree on which ability is most appropriate to check if an exceptional success occurs.

All people are different, some remain cold and cal-culating while others are ruled by their emo-tions. Character traits show passions and distinctive traits in an individual's personality. **Character traits** Character traits show how a person is. It is the per-son's inner disposition and fundamental behavior in the world they operate in. Character traits affect the choices a person makes. Possessing a character trait does not automatically entail an advantage or disadvantage, as the same character trait can work both positively and negatively, depending on the situation. The 13 character traits included in Noir are • Aggressive • Arrogant • Cautious • Greedy • Honorable • Vengeful • Loving • Indifferent • Lustful • Suspicious • Deceitful • Risk-taking • Convinced **Aggressive** Aggression can manifest in many ways – from every-thing from senseless rage to more restrained sadistic satisfaction. An aggressive person is often tempera-mental, irritable, violent, sadistic, brutal, combat-ive, hot-tempered and angry. Aggressive people easily become angry at provocation and do not shy away from violence. They also often lack the moral barriers that most people have. Aggressiveness is a common character trait among box-ers, police officers, brawlers, hitmen, debt collectors, gangsters, gang members, drunks, party animals and soldiers. **Arrogant** A person who is arrogant usually considers them-selves superior to everyone else and likes to point out their own importance and competence. The person is often cocky, superior, smug, ambitious, nonchalant and contemptuous. Not infrequently, the person is vain, egotistical, attention-seeking, conceited, snob- **Character traits**

back. The revenge can happen immediately through violent actions or through careful planning and protracted action that bit by bit destroys another person's life. The vengeful person usually magnifies the extent and signifi-cance of any insults. Vengefulness is a common character trait among crime victims, gangsters, betrayed wives, fired people, cor-porate leaders and dynastic personalities. **Loving** Love is a powerful force in human life and even though it can be twisted into both jealousy and pure lust, it main-tains hope. There are those who have an open and peaceful attitude toward their fellow humans and these lov-ing people are often compassionate, sensitive, humble, friendly, understanding, sympathetic, forgiving, helpful and kind-hearted. A loving person listens to their feel-ings and rarely resorts to violence unless it is to defend friends, family or an ideal. The loving person usually lets offenses go quickly and feels no need to dwell on old events or keep old grudges alive. They believe it is better to move on and seize life and seek new experiences instead. Lovingness is a common character trait among priests, good parents, spouses, teenagers, teachers, aid workers, philan-thropists and doctors. **Lustful** Lust and passion are powerful emotions that exist within all people. In some they are so strong that they constantly dominate the mind and sometimes become twisted into perversions and bizarre acts. A lustful person is often easily aroused, horny, single-minded, sexual, erotic, amorous, pleasure-seeking and/or passionate. It is not uncommon for the lust-ful to have odd inclinations, perversions or obsessions due to eager curiosity or past traumas. The lust that drives the person, however it manifests, often becomes the dominant part of the person's life even if it is not always evident on the surface. Lustfulness is a common character trait among addicts, broken souls, prostitutes, war veterans, crime vic-tims, party animals, socialites, gangster bosses, jaded people, seducers, femme fatales and casanovas. **Indifferent** The chaos and suffering surrounding a person can make them become jaded and indifferent to what happens. An indifferent person is often world-weary, unengaged, uninter-ested, cynical, scornful, ironic, sarcastic, lazy, slack and blasé. The person rarely feels any joy in experiencing new bish, thoughtless, narcissistic and shallow. Many arrogant peo-ple easily tire of people around them and have great difficulty cooperating with others. Arrogance is a common character trait among bosses, movie stars, gangster bosses, ruthless scientists, domi-nant people, socialites, models and bureaucrats. **Cautious** Caution can be due to insecurity, mild paranoia or excessive planning. A cautious person is often discreet, modest, shy, unassuming, simple and forward-thinking. It is not uncommon for the person to be insecure in themselves. Cautious people often avoid getting into combat or dangerous situations – some would call them cowardly or timid but often it is the cautious who survive longest in Noir's harsh world. Caution is a common character trait among hermits, cowed people, academics, priests, scientists, par-ents, servants and submissive people. **Greedy** The fire of greed burns in many hearts. Without money and power one is defenseless and the pursuit of influence, status and wealth often makes the greedy ignore morality and laws. Even though greed can ultimately pay off, many greedy bastards lose their friends along the way and instead gain hordes of enemies. Greed often leads to spiritual loneliness. Greed is a common character trait among gangster boss-es, executives, bankers, financiers, socialites and gamblers. **Honorable** Honor is a virtue that is all too rare in the harsh and cruel world Noir takes place in. The honorable often become exploited and over time bitter and withdrawn but there are those who hold ideals high throughout life. An honorable person is often righteous, loyal, just, faith-ful, noble, upright, reliable, honest, steadfast, dependable, selfless, solidary and/or comradely. Only in emergencies or for a higher purpose does the honorable break a promise or abandon a friend. Honor is a common character trait among auditors, forensic scientists, police officers, prosecutors and key witnesses. **Vengeful** The thirst for revenge exists within all people but some trans-form their dark thoughts into reality. A vengeful person is often resentful, bitter, unforgiving, touchy, relent-less and quick to take offense and believes that wrongs must be paid

things. The condescending and joyless attitude that often accompanies such a person is quite enervating for outsiders. Or the person is simply lazy and listless and chooses to waste their life by loafing around and doing nothing at all during the day. Indifference is a common trait among war vete-rans, seasoned police officers,

jaded doctors, ambulance per-sonnel, divorced people, and spoiled teenagers. **Suspicious** In a world of shadows, violence, and desire, a certain degree of suspicion is required to survive. However, there are those who are completely ruled by this trait. A suspicious person is insecure, distrustful, critical, doubting, question-ing, and skeptical. Even envy and jealousy belong here. In more extreme cases, suspicion takes the form of paranoia. The person is suspicious of strangers, and tries to keep to themselves when out among people. Suspicion is a common trait among street dwellers, criminals, police officers, bureaucrats, lonely people, and betrayed individuals. **Deceitful** Deceit is a dark and destructive force that is deeply rooted in every person. If it takes complete hold of a person, they often become selfish, ruthless, lying, false, unreliable, cunning, treacherous, sly, smug, unscru-pulous, hardened, and cold. Deceitful people are everywhere in the dark world of Noir. People who first and foremost look out for their own gain and who wouldn't blink at selling their children as slaves if the price were right. Deceitful-ness usually stems from selfishness — granted, the deceitful themselves may see it as the only way to survive, but it also ensures they remain alone, as deceitfulness almost unfail-ingly crushes every relationship with other people. Deceitfulness is a common trait among con artists, swindlers, gamblers, gangsters, unfaithful swine, spies, femme fatales, traitors, war criminals, smugglers, human traffickers, and criminals. **Risk-Prone** There are those who don't shy away from danger but rather seek it out. A risk-prone person is often brave, bold, wild, daring, fearless, crazy, proud, self-confident, and often has a great deal of integrity and courage. Virtually nothing scares the risk-prone, and they dare perform insane heroic deeds to achieve results, without much thought for their own safety. No odds are too impossible and no challenge too difficult. The risk-prone aren't afraid to argu-e for their case, even if their opinions will create conflicts and friction with others. Of course, the risk is great that the person gets in over their head and ends up in greater difficulties than they can handle. Risk-proneness is a common trait among pilots, heroes, firefighters, police officers, adventurers, desperate crimi-nals, businessmen, lawyers, and managers. **Convicted** Nothing strengthens the soul and will as much as personal con-viction. A convicted person is certain, assured, believing, determined, rigid, and inflexible when it comes to the conviction's nature. Not infrequently, the person is hard to persuade, rather fana-tical, and relentless when it comes to argumentation or attacks against what the conviction concerns. Being convicted means having a deep belief in something, a mantra, a path in life, or a view of how the world works and looks. It could be a police officer who sees the law as the only right thing, a priest who has seen the One's glory, a soldier who has the fatherland's well-being in their heart, or an agitator who hates the State's oppression. It can also involve superstition — there is much unknown in the dark alleys, the sewers' damp tunnels, and the vast wastelands that spread out beyond the cities. The conviction helps the person move forward in life, it constitutes a fixed point in the chaos and a clear goal to strive for. Attacks on the conviction usually fall flat or are dismissed as idiotic or uninformed statements. Conviction is a common trait among reporters, police officers, soldiers, pilots, lone wolves, homeless people, athletes, self-proclaimed prophets, and rural folk. **Using Traits** In situations where a trait could influence a person's choices and reasoning, the narrator can let the trait provide a bonus or penalty to relevant dice rolls. Of course, players can also suggest when traits should be used in this way. If a person finds themselves in a situation where the player thinks the person's trait should be able to influence — positively or negatively — the narrator must judge whether this is the case. It is always the narrator who ultimately decides whether a trait can be used or not. If the trait is used, the affected rolls receive a penalty or bonus of one (±1). In cases where multiple traits affect the same situation, the total bonus or penalty can at most be five (±5). This also applies to Stronger influence, see page 229. Using traits during the story should be encouraged, and a player who portrays their character based on their traits should be rewarded when experience is distributed. The difference between traits and drives It can be difficult to see the difference between traits and drives. The difference is that traits show how a person is, while a drive shows what a person wants. "So, what do you want to drink?" "I told you I have a husband." "He can have a drink

too." "He's not here, he's away on business." "Perfect. We can toast to his honor?" "He's only home on weekends." "You know, I like him better and better." — Gabriel Jandaran and Marlena Illianescu

Trait Negative Influence

Aggressive Can make a bad first impression, may have difficulty charming someone and creating personal or business contacts, people become anxious and insecure in the person's presence and don't trust them. Arrogant Gives the impression of being condescending and snide, may have difficulty charming someone and initiating personal or business contacts. Cautious Is afraid of combat or of being hurt, avoids conflicts Greedy Can be perceived as unreliable and/or disloyal, can easily be bribed or lured with riches Honorable Cannot consider bending moral and ethical rules, meets disapproval in interaction with dishonorable people Vengeful Can make a bad first impression, can be perceived as emotion-ally cold, is easily misled when a chance for revenge presents itself Loving Stands up for themselves, has limited freedom of action when loved ones are threatened, has a strong desire to care for the vulnerable Indifferent Perceived as apathetic and cynical, often seen as unpleas-ant and emotionally cold and may have difficulty functioning normally in social situations Lust-driven Easily tempted with sex, can be persuaded and manipulated by a sexual or passionate individual Suspicious Can make a bad first impression, has difficulty building relationships, has difficulty perceiving things beyond what occupies their attention Deceitful Has difficulty maintaining contacts and friends, easily tempted to switch sides or sell information Risk-Prone Doesn't hesitate before dangerous situations, has difficulty resisting bets or challenges, can easily drag others into danger Convicted Is strong in thought and conviction Table 1:51 **Suggested Influences** Traits can influence positively or negatively, tables 1:50 and 1:51 provide suggestions. **Trait Positive Influence** Aggressive Is threatening, good at fighting and hurting others, doesn't back down in threatening situations Arrogant Creates insecurity and inspires respect/fear in others, refuses to admit when hope is lost Cautious Inspires confidence in some, has patience in stressful situations, is thoughtful when planning Greedy Often sees opportunity for profit in all situations, doesn't hesitate to bend rules and regulations to reach their goals Honorable Makes a positive impression, inspires confidence, is easy to trust Vengeful Is determined, has a good sense of planning, can find extra willpower and inspiration when a revenge opportunity presents itself. Loving Makes a good first impression, has an easy time creating and maintaining relationships, finds it easy to get people to open up, is a safe embrace to cry in Indifferent Resists surprises, is not affected by shocking events, doesn't feel ill when loved ones are harmed Lust-driven Dares to hit on "impossible" targets, has an easy time creating new contacts, makes a good impression on certain partners Suspicious Sees through lies and bullshit, assumes traps and ambushes are the rule rather than the exception, is prepared for dangers Deceitful Has no qualms of conscience, takes all chances, turns their coat with the wind. Risk-Prone Doesn't give up in seemingly impossible situations, dares to perform crazy maneuvers, stays cool in danger Convicted Is strong in thought and conviction Table 1:50 **Changing Traits** It can happen that a player doesn't roleplay their main character based on their traits. The narrator should then make the player aware of traits that no longer feel relevant so they can be changed. In the same way, new traits can be established. This is motivated by the main character having developed in a new direction and gained new values or behaviors — something that isn't at all unusual in Noir's tangible world. The most important thing is still that the main character's traits feel right for the player so they can be portrayed in a good and constructive way.

Adding New Traits

The traits included in the book should be seen as a selection from the infinite number of traits that exist. The traits have been chosen because they fit the mood the game wishes to convey — a harsh, dark world where desire, lies, sex, violence, obsession, betrayal, and revenge rule. Players and narrators are free to add more

traits themselves. However, one should try to create traits that are grounded in the world and are easy to use. One suggestion is to start from the following five requirements when creating a new trait: • The trait should be value-neutral, that is, it should not in itself be positive or negative but should be able to influence a person's actions in both directions. • The trait should be clear to the player, who should understand at a glance what the trait means. • The trait should have a mechanical impact on the rules that is understandable and easy to use. • The trait should be part of the story. The narrator should be able to create stories in which the main characters' traits can take place and be used as a starting point for new stories or substories. • The trait should fit the game and its mood.

Character Traits in Combat

Personal conviction can move mountains. A strong conviction, a burning love, or a seething hatred can drive people to perform actions that would otherwise be seen as impossible. A father can run through a burning house to save his daughter, a woman can drag her injured husband for miles to reach a hospital, and a friend can throw themselves into icy water to pull up their comrade who just fell in. Both protagonists and prominent narrator characters have character traits that help define their personalities, motivations and life goals, but also their weaknesses and desires. In combat, these character traits can help or hinder the execution of a plan. If a player's protagonist has, for example, the character trait Loving with expression toward his beloved, he can in a situation where his fiancée is directly threatened choose to add his value in the character trait as a bonus to a dice roll that results in the threat becoming less.

A narrator must decide how much the character traits factor into combat. Ideally, bonuses from character traits should only be used when something truly matters in a person's life that they care about. It should not be used in every other combat situation, but saved for more climactic events so that the result becomes incredibly spectacular — like when the antagonist lets their hatred pour out over the hero, when the protagonist saves their beloved from a hail of bullets with the help of their strong faith in their love, or when a companion's loyalty is so strong that it affects the outcome of a firefight.

Suggestions for use in general combat situations It's not unthinkable that a player wants to use a person's character trait in just about every combat — especially if the protagonist is Aggressive, Risk-prone or Cautious. A simple approach is to let the character trait be "active" throughout the entire combat. If, for example, Aggressive or Risk-prone is used, bonuses are given on all Initiative actions and penalties on all Defense actions, while Cautious works the opposite way.

Expression

The character traits' expressions provide increased depth and an extra dimension to the person. They specify how and in which situations the character traits primarily manifest, as well as how they affect the person, and thereby make it easier for the player to immerse themselves in and portray their protagonist.

All chosen character traits shall have at least one expression but they can have several, usually between one and three. Character traits can of course also affect situations to which they lack specified expressions, if it is deemed reasonable and in the person's nature.

Suggested Expressions

To facilitate the choice of expressions, here follows a selection. Note that the following are only suggestions and that an enterprising player or narrator can surely come up with more expressions. In cases where one must choose a specific alternative, it refers to something very limited that often stems from a distinct event or

experience in the person's life. If the person has the trait "Suspicious (of the Police)" then they have most likely had bad experiences from previous contacts with the police, and this has given rise to the expression.

The specific expressions that are appropriate (of course depending on situation and character trait) are: • Specific activity • Specific object • Specific company • Specific phenomenon • Specific group • Specific individual • Specific circle • Specific organization

Examples of Expressions

Examples of what expressions character traits can take and how they can be interpreted follow here: • Vengeful (loathes wife-beaters, painful punishments) — The person loathes people who prove to be wife-beaters, and when opportunity for revenge presents itself, it will likely be brutal, harsh and painful. • Very aggressive (murderer, brutal) — The person enjoys killing and has no problem injuring or killing others in excessive and bestial ways. Often little provocation is needed for deadly situations to arise. • Very loving (their wife, their children) — The person is passionate about their family and does everything in their power to make things easier for and support them. • Extremely convinced (immovable, the State's excellence) — The person refuses to accept criticism of the State and attacks with strong frenzy those who attack their conviction. • Extremely risk-prone (death-defying, likes to fly, prefers bad odds) — The person enters without hesitation into violent situations where they risk being maimed or killed. The person is moreover strongly attracted to piloting aircraft and thrives like a fish in water when the odds speak against them. The person is probably happiest when they alone face six enemy aircraft just as they have low fuel and nearly empty machine guns.

Aggressive

• Bloodthirsty • Brutal • Eccentric • Cruel • Hot-tempered • Threatening • Angry • Irritable • Insecure • Disturbed • Sadistic • Self-destructive • Combative • Mouthy • Violent

Arrogant

• Smug • Selfish • Vain • Contemptuous • Insulting • Conceited • Cold-hearted • Narcissistic • Condescending • Nonchalant • Impersonal • Insecure • Self-righteous • Snobbish • Snooty • Proud • Tactless • Thoughtless • Superficial • Honor-hungry • Superior

Cautious

• Unassuming • Shy • Discreet • Thoughtful • Simple • Cowardly • Peaceful • Foresighted • Introverted • Calm • Meticulous • Unmoved • Insecure • Self-assured • Submissive

Greedy

• Extravagances • Gluttony • Materialistic • Lust • Power-hungry • Money-loving • Sneaky • Stingy • Status-conscious

Honorable

• Integrity • Comradely • Loyal • Immovable • Selfless • Reliable • Principled • Upright • Honest • Just • Solidary • Trustworthy • Faithful • Noble • Truthful

Vengeful

• Obsessed • Stern • Bitter • Persistent • Contemptuous • Prejudiced • Grudge-bearing • Easily offended • Unforgiving • Passionate • Guilt-ridden • Quick-tempered

Loving

• Generous • Refined • Forgiving • Understanding • Liberal • Kind-hearted • Hospitable • Helpful • Interested • Compassionate • Sympathetic • Passionate • Tasteful • Magnanimous • Accommodating • Friendly • Lovely • Humble

Lust-driven

• Amorous • Obsessed • Dominant • Single-minded • Erotic • Extroverted • Horny • Easily aroused • Masochistic • Pleasure-seeking • Optimistic • Passionate • Perverted • Sadistic • Sensual • Self-degrading • Shameless • Guilt-ridden • Compulsive thoughts • Submissive • Violent

Indifferent

• Apathetic • Blasé • Cynical • Death-longing • Scornful • Ruthless • Introverted • Ironic • Lazy • Nonchalant • Unengaged • Fearless • Uninterested • Pessimistic • Sarcastic • Slack • Resigned • World-weary

Suspicious

• Jealous • Questioning • Critical • Distrustful • Insecure • Paranoid • Skeptical • Envious • Doubting

Deceitful

• Deceptive • False • Hardened • Treacherous • Ruthless • Cold • Temptation • Cunning • Lying • Devious • Uncomprehending • Unreliable • Self-satisfied • Selfish • Unscrupulous

Risk-prone

• Clueless • Irresponsible • Childish • Bold • Death-defying • Mad • Gullible • Integrity • Courage • Reckless • Brave • Curious • Fearless • Straightforward • Self-assured • Nosy • Proud • Inventive • Wild • Daring • Careless

Convinced

• Obsessed • Determined • Stubborn • Assured • Inflexible • Immovable • Rigid • Certain • Believing

Stronger Impact

The character traits can be made more pronounced and take up even greater space in the person's life and personality. By giving a character trait the prefix very or extremely, one raises its degree of impact. For example, a person instead of Honorable and Aggressive can be Very honorable and Extremely aggressive.

A person should not have more than two character traits with the prefix very or one with the prefix extremely, unless exceptionally good reasons exist.

A character trait that has the prefix very gives a penalty or bonus of two (±2). In the same way, a character trait that has the prefix extreme gives a penalty or bonus of four (±4).

Keep in mind that character traits that are extreme have a very large impact on how the person acts, so they should be used sparingly and with consideration. People with several extreme character traits tend to be difficult to play and exaggerated, and this can easily destroy the story. The narrator must approve all character traits that have prefixes.

Example: Mordekai is "Very lust-driven (prefers very young women)". When a challenging girl comes up to him at the smoky bar counter inside the nightclub Needle's Eye, where he's watching a suspected child murderer, he quickly becomes aware that the woman is trying to seduce him in a rather forceful way.

The narrator judges that Mordekai must make a resistance roll (Resist) to resist the tempting seductress, but because the woman is pushy, young and obvious, the narrator decides that Mordekai's roll gets a penalty of two (−2). This is because the prefix "very" before Mordekai's character trait Lust-driven gives value two and the narrator considers that the trait very clearly works against Mordekai in the situation — it is after all a young woman who's hitting on him.

The woman wins the resistance roll thanks to this and Mordekai, wildly entwined by a young woman in a dark booth far back in the venue, misses that the suspect leaves the nightclub with a rattling medical bag in hand.

Everyone is driven by something, an inner desire that must be satisfied, personal goals that must be met, or a personal agenda that must be followed. The path toward fulfillment is often selfish and full of danger and violence as different people's drives clash with each other — often with fatal outcome.

Drives

A person can possess one or several drives — goals the person wants to fulfill in their life. The drives must be fulfilled for the person to become satisfied and be able to move on. The purpose of drives is to give the characters their own goals to strive toward so that they become a more active part in the world they act in. When a drive is fulfilled, this grants Experience.

Measurable Drives

It's important to remember that there are tons of drives a person can be thought to have, but what's crucial from a rules perspective is that the drives are measurable. More generally held drives like for example making friends or becoming popular are difficult to measure. Therefore they are not included in the listing below. Narrators and players can of course jointly work around this by trying to set up measurable goals within hard-to-measure drives and bring them among the choices.

Secret Drives

Many times players will want to keep their protagonists' drives secret from other players and their protagonists. Such drives should be discussed with the narrator in private and possibly not recorded in the character sheet. It could be about schemes and intrigues that are directed at people within one's own group, or that the player simply doesn't want their protagonist's innermost thoughts exposed. Many times it can be exciting to try to figure out what drives the people in one's surroundings, and as a player knowing what one's protagonist doesn't know can kill most of the mystique.

Drive in a Group

Many of the presented drives can be seen as individualistic. But nothing prevents the entire group from having a shared drive — it's just for each person to note the same drive in their character sheet. Everyone

then gets to share in the fulfillment and effects when such occur.

Drives

Gain Forgiveness/Attain Redemption "It wasn't supposed to happen, by the End, no, it can't have happened, can't, no, NO!" The person suffers from guilt over an event or action and seeks atonement. He/she has difficulty living with what happened and therefore tries to gain forgiveness from someone affected or perhaps from themselves. Others wish to attain redemption through the higher power's grace.

Find Love/Feel Security "Do you, Mattius Rein, take this Fransceska Segeda, to be your wife until you die, regardless of circum-stances or experiences, in the End's name?" The person wants to find someone to grow old with or find security, romance, and companionship in another way. It can also involve achieving harmony in life and no longer having any enemies.

Destroy/Kill "Doctor Bavory has hereby forfeited his right to live and I am his judge, jury, and executioner." Someone or something has wronged the person so badly that blood must be spilled for the person to gain satisfaction. It can involve an individual or a group of people, but it can also be an organization or a company that symbolizes the person's hate and violation.

Attain Position/Prove/Achieve Goal "And with these words I confirm your promotion. Congratulations, Police Captain Tristarian!" The person needs to prove to someone or to themselves that he/ she is capable of reaching a goal in life. It can be attaining a posi-tion within one's profession, showing that one can handle life as a soldier, or achieving a scientific breakthrough with research one has been mocked for. It can be becoming a famous artist, making the front page, or perhaps recording an album. It can also involve things like having sex with a new partner every day or helping the poor by working in soup kitchens.

Self-Actualization

"If you keep training your strength at this pace you'll soon be unrecognizable." The person wishes to reach perfection within some area or field. This is symbolized by him/her reaching the level of out-standing in a chosen attribute or master in an ability.

Suggested Drives

Here various drives a person can possess are described. Feel free to use them as inspiration to come up with more drives that can fit into the story.

Expose/Combat/Oppose "If it's the last thing I do, I will expose to the world what you are!" For some reason, such as personal conviction or pathos, the person wants to reveal what someone or something is or stands for, with clear evidence supporting the exposure. It can involve a person, a group, a company, a phenomenon, criminality, poor working conditions, or something completely different. A public exposure usually occurs as a scoop in newspapers or radio or via a public trial, while a private exposure occurs before a person or group.

Defeat/Gain Vindication "And therefore, Mr. Konstantin, I am right and you are, and have always been, wrong, are you not?" An injustice has been committed and the person has sworn to repay it. The person wants at any cost to defeat an enemy and thereby gain vindication and clear their own or someone else's name, reputation, and honor. The enemy can be an individual, a group, or an organization. The factors surrounding it all vary but it can involve something as simple as getting an apology from the one who insulted, or larger conditions can be involved, where debts from several generations must be paid. Without victory, life is not worth living.

Protect/Help/Save "I can't leave her, not now, not like this." The person has decided to defend someone or something for one reason or another. It can be as a bodyguard for someone, rescuing someone who has been kidnapped, generally protecting women from rapists, or children from slavery, or perhaps pro-tecting an illegal operation from the police with all available means.

Bring/Return/Deliver "A statuette to the Ministry of Truth, Chief Inspector Kamarov. Okay, understood, I'll be done by Thursday, have the money ready." The person is driven by returning or delivering an object, a person, or knowledge to a client or to its rightful family, owner, or place. Until it is done, no peace can be found.

Vision and Abuse of the Rules

The idea with drives is to let the players' characters have their own, clear goals in the stories. The drives exist to give rise to increased drama and pres-ence in the game. There are certainly ways to abuse the rules and the narrator must be prepared to put their foot down and stop such attempts. Drives are not something one should fulfill as many of as possible just to get rewards.

The narrator must keep watch so that group drives become reasonable and support the story and that the players don't try to trick with the rules to maximize the benefit. Be prepared to deny a person a drive if it doesn't feel right from the story's perspective that the person has it.

Harm/Disfigure "He gave Emilia irreparable scars on her soul through his vile actions. It is a mild justice that I give him scars all over his body. Can you pass me the jug of acid?" For some reason the victim wishes to harm and/or disfigure the target of the drive. It can be according to the classic maxim "An eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth," or it can involve some other form of justice, such as cutting off the genitals of a rapist.

Search/Seek/Find "Have you seen the woman in the photo? No? Sure? Look again, please, look again!" The person is searching for someone or something. A lost love from the past, a brother presumed missing at the front, or a colleague who has vanished without a trace. Perhaps it's a coveted object that eludes the person – a special wine, a film reel, a stamp, a peregrine falcon, or perhaps the last component in an experiment. It can also involve a missing heirloom, such as grandmother's pearl brooch. Special knowledge can also be included, such as obtaining an address, the solution to a puzzle, or perhaps one's own adoption papers. Until the object, person, or knowledge is found, the person is unsatisfied.

Experience "Is this your first time flying in an airplane, Professor?" The person craves something special, it can be romance with a certain person or a number of people for a certain time. Perhaps it involves rising in the hierarchy within the crime family one belongs to. It can involve a special experience, such as climbing the highest peak of the Arkady massif, doing a loop with an airplane, firing an artillery piece, meeting a clan head, making a pilgrimage to Georgior's monastery, visiting the northern trenches, being present at the New Year's ball at Marchalk Square, or perhaps seeing the innermost vaults of the ministry archives.

Dishonor/Humiliate "When I'm done your wife will have left you, your children will hate you, and your par-ents will regret the day they conceived you." For justice to be served, the target of the injustice must be humiliated, either before themselves, the avenger, or a third party – usually someone the original violation was about, for example a lover in a love triangle. Or the violated one wants to humiliate their victim before his/her friends, acquaintances, or associates.

Repay/Pay Back "Here are thirty of the fifty I owe, you'll get the rest in five days, I promise. This time it can't go wrong." The person owes someone or something a favor, a promise, money, or their life, and wants nothing more than to repay this debt.

A Drive's Birth

During a story's course, situations arise that give birth to drives. When such a situation reveals itself, a person may choose to take up the drive as their own, provided that he/she has room for it – see Impact. If not, the person can attempt to abandon an existing drive. This is described under Abandon Drive.

When a drive is born, this should be roleplayed by the player, so that the drive becomes part of the story and something worth striving for. Everyone should understand why a drive comes into being and understand the person's motivation for the drive.

All new drives are written down in the character sheet and should also be explained. Generally, a maximum of one drive is born per scene, but variations can occur in special cases.

When a person is created, he/she gets one drive, see page 31.

Example: Mordekai Remus has two drives, namely "Find Stelia Lock" and "Destroy everyone who was involved in the mur-der of Janya." As the drives are written, their goals are clear – when Miss Lock is found, the first drive is fulfilled, and when everyone who was part of the conspiracy that led to Mordekai's youthful love Janya's death is dead, the second drive is fulfilled.

Scope

A drive's scope can be either limited or continuous. Most are limited, which means they disappear when they are fulfilled. Continuous drives remain even after they are fulfilled; this mainly applies to drives whose goal is long-term or can be affected over a long time, for example protecting a person.

Example: Mordekai Remus has two drives, according to the exam-ple above. The drives are both considered limited since there is no reason to keep them once they have been fulfilled. If the second drive were such that the goal itself was each individual's death, then it would have been a continuous drive, but now the wording is such that it is at the point when all involved are dead that the goal is fulfilled and thus the drive is limited.

Impact

A drive can have one of three degrees of impact. These are, from mildest to most pronounced: subdued, burning, and manic. A person has room to at most possess drives that total five points.

• A subdued drive takes up one point • A burning drive takes up two points • A manic drive takes up three points

Strengthen Impact

When a drive is born, the person must set its impact to either subdued, burning, or manic. The impact must be chosen directly and cannot be changed later. The only exception is if the person already has a drive and during a story ends up in a situation, or gains access to new knowledge, that directly affects the drive – then its impact can be increased if there is room for it (in terms of points).

If the drive is continuous, it remains in the character sheet. For example, Walian Kardoni's drive to kill all shadow walkers is a typical continuous drive, as there is really no end to it but each time a shadow walker dies by Kardoni's hands it counts as fulfilled. A continuous drive can be fulfilled at most once per scene.

Long and tough road to fulfillment

A narrator who believes that the path a main character has walked to finally reach fulfillment was both long, perilous and character-defining can without hesitation give up to five times the amount of points at the moment of fulfillment. A burning limited drive would then give 75 points instead of 15 points.

Multiple fulfillments

Even if several different drives would be fulfilled at one and the same time, the person can only receive fulfillment from one of them simultaneously. A person can for example have the drives "Seek out Anannia's jewels" and "Bring the one who stole Anannia's jewels to justice". It is not impossible for these two drives to be fulfilled simultaneously, but then the person only receives points from the one that gives the most.

Fulfillment through roleplaying

The narrator may encounter players who play their main characters as if they had drives but who for some reason don't spend any time specifying these. Perhaps they feel it would take them out of their role to do so, they may have difficulty choosing a limited number of drives, they may have forgotten to do it or they may simply be uninterested in the system for how to use drives. The game master can then choose to give these players points for portrayed fulfilled drives even if it is not specified when the drives are fulfilled.

Abandon drive

A defined drive can only disappear in two ways. Either through fate willing it – "it was not written in the stars that it should happen" (this can happen at most once per game session and to get rid of the drive the person then consumes as much Experience as the fulfillment of the drive could have given). Or through the drive's goal suddenly becoming impossible to reach (if the drive for example is to return Irvan Lesarov's famous painting Moonseye to Felix van Kordar and the painting in question burns up) or if the drive is deemed unreasonable or unnecessary (if for example one has as a drive to protect someone from a person and that person is killed or imprisoned).

When a drive disappears without the person wanting it to, the person suffers stress equivalent to a psychological trauma, see page 244.

Example: Walian Kardoni received the drive "Kill all shadow walkers you encounter" when his family was mutilated by a group of shadow walkers. The drive was then subdued. Later in life, after Kardoni had succeeded in killing several shadow walkers, he found love again, but the happiness was short-lived. A shadow walker violated his new love and ate her up. When Kardoni discovered this, his drive grew to manic.

Degree of influence

A subdued drive lies simmering in the back of the person's mind and unconsciously or consciously guides his/her choices and decisions. There are no problems temporarily breaking the thoughts or focusing on something else, but sooner or later the thoughts will return to the drive.

A burning drive is often present with the person and influences his/her everyday life in a tangible way. The person is still free to disconnect its influence, but has difficulty concentrating on other things for longer periods without falling under its influence.

A manic drive takes over the person's ego and steers him/her toward the goal day after day, night after night, hour after hour. Few things can disturb the thought of fulfilling the drive, of getting an outlet for it, of

reaching the end and feeling the victory. Other phenomena are seen as secondary or insignificant in the context, especially when the end can be sensed.

Example: Mordekai Remus has two drives, as shown above. It is determined that it is clearly more important for Mordekai to find the murderers than to locate the assassin Lock. The drives are noted as follows: "Find Stelia Lock (subdued)" and "Destroy everyone who was involved in the murder of Janya (burning)".

Fulfillment

When a person receives a drive, its goal shall be clearly stated. Therefore the formulation is important. When the goal is fulfilled, the drive has given the person a revelation, a satisfaction and a calm.

This is symbolized by the person receiving points that can be used to increase Experience or Well-being, according to table 1:52. Each point can either be translated into one point of Experience or for ten points, Well-being can be improved one level (this means that for subdued or burning continuous drives, Well-being cannot be improved, as the points are not sufficient – this comes naturally as continuous drives are usually not emotionally sound).

Limited Continuous

Subdued 5 points 3 points Burning 15 points 6 points Manic 50 points 20 points Table 1:52

When a limited drive is fulfilled it disappears and can be struck from the character sheet. If the fulfilled drive is continuous, the situation and the narrator decide whether it is still active or if it is definitively fulfilled and can thus be struck. When a limited drive is fulfilled, an identical drive cannot be born again in the person, unless very special reasons exist.

"What are you going to do?" "I will kill them all. Everyone who was involved in it. Everyone who profited from it. Everyone who tries to stop me. Everyone who talks back." "My god. You're going to kill everyone..." – Sandrine Makovy and Mordekai Remus

Conviction & frustration In situations that have a direct connection to a drive, the narrator can let the person receive a penalty or bonus on dramatic or reasonable activities in the scene that promote or threaten the drive's fulfillment. The modification is linked to the drive's influence, so a subdued drive gives penalty/bonus (–1/+1), a burning (–2/+2) and a manic (–4/+4).

The modification applies to direct connections to fulfillment, preferably in such a way that the person can really imagine that the goal is within reach. This symbolizes the person's inner strength and will to complete something that has long been driving in his/her life.

Such a connection can also create frustration and a feeling of powerlessness in the scene if a person feels that the drive is close to being fulfilled but that something is hindering or disturbing. An example could be wanting to kill a person but when reaching him/her there are 300 witnesses nearby which makes it a physical or at least social suicide to fulfill the drive in a reasonable and credible way.

Example: Gabriel has the continuous drive "Protect Anya Malov (subdued)". In situations where he actually protects her from various misfortunes he receives a bonus (+1). In the same way he receives a penalty (–1) in situations where he experiences that he should protect Anya but cannot do so.

Find strength

A dazed or mortally wounded person, or one suffering from low Well-being, can in a scene where a drive is close to being fulfilled use this motivation to accomplish dramatic feats. It means that the person finds new strength in desperation, rises above the pain and anxiety and continues to fight to reach the goal of the drive.

The person can choose between rising and doing what he/she must do and for a short time focus on a single final task, or resignedly giving up under the injuries, bleeding, pain, exhaustion, poisoning, drug influence, hopelessness, despair or terror and just withdrawing, collapsing, admitting defeat and wasting away.

If the person chooses to pull themselves together to manage the final task, he/she temporarily counts their Well-being as Relaxed (10). Additionally, the person gets to act even if he/she would be dazed or mortally wounded. All other rules still apply as usual: the person dies from an additional Wound if he/she is already mortally wounded, the person dies when the rounds before death arrives have passed, and the total penalty the person has from their injuries applies.

Note that Find strength can only be activated for actions performed in direct purpose of fulfilling the drive. Should the person deviate from the goal the slightest bit, the effect disappears and the person can no longer act. When the person mentally releases the drive's focus, he/she can no longer resist the pain and fatigue or manage to push their body to extreme levels for any less noble purpose than the fulfillment of the drive. If the person in any way tries to leave the scene or perform any action that doesn't directly work for the fulfillment of the drive, the effects cease immediately.

Usually it only works to find strength from drives that were born before the current scene arose. This is to prevent someone from birthing a new drive as a response to an action that just occurred.

Example: The reporter Tremaro has the drive "Expose Franko Davidov", a shady businessman that Tremaro has written tons of articles about. Tremaro is now close to the big scoop. In Davidov's fancy office there is a dossier with detailed information about how Davidov records illegal films with drugged refugees who are subjected to various forms of humiliation and abuse.

Tremaro is in the process of photographing the contents of the dossier when the door behind him opens. There stands Davidov with a revolver in hand, which immediately blinds the reporter with a flash of light and a dull bang is heard as he is hurled across the desk and tears down most of what stood there onto the floor, including a telephone. The bullet hits badly in the middle of his chest and Tremaro, who is not a physically strong person, becomes mortally wounded by the attack and thus cannot act at all, except to lie whimpering on the floor.

The large-built Davidov steps in, turns on the lamp and grins triumphantly. Tremaro lies still and feels that he will soon die. Davidov starts talking to him and tells with a smug grin about all the dirty businesses he is behind – since Tremaro won't get any use from the knowledge anyway. Davidov continues talking while he goes to the bar counter on the other side of the room to pour liquor. Tremaro now wants to pull himself together and find strength – he hates Davidov and wants to expose him to everyone in the whole world.

The narrator wonders what Tremaro has in mind and the plan is that while Davidov has his back to him, he wants to call his editor-in-chief, who he knows records all calls, to let the receiver lie off while Davidov reveals everything about everything. The narrator thinks it's dramatic, fateful and a really good idea so Tremaro finds strength in the scene.

A weak hand grabs the telephone receiver and bloody fingers dial a phone number without being discovered by Davidov. Tremaro collapses, coughing, and the receiver falls silently onto the thick carpet. The editor-in-chief is met with a surprise when one of Sandukar's most notorious businessmen reveals both this and that, all

while a stiffly smiling Tremaro is slowly received by death's cold darkness, with the knowledge that he got his nemesis in the end.

The drama in finding strength

Find strength allows main characters (and also central narrator characters, if the narrator so wishes) to act even when the odds are against them. The mortally wounded policeman who has as a drive to protect a witness can pull himself together and shoot the murderer with his last strength. The psychologically broken mother who has seen her husband rape their daughter can get the opportunity to avenge the crime if this is her drive.

Since the effect is activated when the person is already knocked out and dying (mortally wounded or dazed persons normally do not get to act) or if the person is broken for some reason (low Well-being), he/she has nothing to lose anyway when the situation arises. Instead it becomes a memorable and personal ending – regardless of whether it succeeds or fails.

Abuse around Find strength

The rules around Find strength are made to allow drama at special and fateful occasions. They are not made to be a lifeline away from danger and if the narrator notices a player trying to exploit the rules in this way, it's just to directly let the found strength disappear and let the person lie crawling, unable to act.

The headlights from a passing car illuminated the alley where Anya Malov kept hidden. She pressed herself closer to the damp brick wall and kept her gaze fixed on Hotel Black Lantern, one of Hexagon's infamous opium dens.

Something told her that the man she was looking for, Fredrick Hesser, would be here. He had slipped through her fingers time and again but opium's iron grip he could not escape. Anya waited until the car had passed before she silently ran out of the alley and across the street to the hotel's fire escape. The thick fog that had rolled in from the sea helped conceal her and the night sky's clouds hung low and threatening.

She grabbed hold of the rusty ladder and began climbing upward. The bolts holding it fastened to the brick wall creaked. The windows beside the ladder were all boarded up but through the cracks she could see into filthy rooms where pale men and women inhaled opium through long pipes. Most of them slept, others moved in stupor, they all wanted to get away, they all wanted to forget.

Anya climbed further to the hotel's top floor which housed the private rooms and the brothel.

She opened a small window at the top of the ladder with the help of her pocket knife. She crawled into the dark room and the stench of urine and stale sewage immediately hit her. She had ended up in a small bathroom with a filthy toilet and a cracked bathtub, the cockroaches moved like black spots on the dirty tiles. Silently she made her way out into the corridor.

The hotel's top floor was poorly lit, most of the light bulbs were broken, the others flickered, the walls were covered with damp stains and torn wallpaper. The doors to the various rooms were peeling and cracked — from some rooms came cries of delirium and from others moans and creaking beds. Anya peeked around the corner where the corridor split. She realized immediately that her intuition had led her right. Outside one of the doors sat Fredrick Hesser's short, stocky body-guard on a wooden chair reading a dog-eared porno mag. His underbite, bull neck and shaved head made him resemble a bulldog. A handful of empty beer bottles stood at his feet and he was just downing the last of a lukewarm Redov.

Anya kept still and waited, going after him in the middle of the corridor would have been too risky — gunfire would attract Hexagon's people. She didn't need to wait long, though, soon the bodyguard put down the porno mag and stood up. Anya retreated to the toilet and picked up a rusty fire extinguisher from the corridor.

When the bodyguard had entered the stinking space and reached out his hand to turn on the light, Anya struck him in the back of the head with the fire extinguisher — a metallic clang echoed in the room and the bodyguard fell to his knees. He didn't pass out though but let out a muffled scream and began drawing a revolver from his shoulder holster. The second blow hit him in the neck, the force made him knock out his teeth against the toilet rim and he collapsed unconscious. She locked his hands behind his back with handcuffs and picked up his revolver. Quickly she moved out into the corridor and to the door the bodyguard had been watching. She opened it carefully and slipped in.

The room was dim, only lit by a few thick candles, and the sweet opium smoke hung so thick that one could cut through it with a knife. On a divan among blood-red cushions and thick tapestries lay Fredrick Hesser's sickly figure. She approached him and looked down at his gaunt face, the half-open mouth and the closed eyes. He was covered in sweat and breathed raspingly and as if he sensed her presence in his opium dreams he began to stir. Anya took a step back and raised the revolver toward him but Fredrick's eyes were still closed.

The ash-gray hand with its yellowed nails fumbled for the opium pipe on the table by his side and Anya let the barrel of the bodyguard's revolver take its place. As if in a trance, Hesser brought the oily revolver barrel to his mouth and closed his cracked lips around the muzzle to draw smoke into his lungs — even in this sleeping state opium held him in its grip.

The click when Anya cocked the hammer made him open his eyes and the hazy gaze transformed into surprise when she coldly informed him that he was under arrest.

The goddess of fate may choose to smile or turn away from those she fleetingly rules over. Her will is that little extra that can make the scales tip over. That which makes the coin land on edge, that one manages to catch with fingertips on the roof gutter when falling from a roof or that one takes the stairs and it later turns out that the elevator was sabotaged.

Fate

In Noir, Fate plays a major role as the protagonists are in various ways chosen in the story. Not infrequently, Fate's whims play a decisive role in critical situations. Fate guides and influences more or less discreetly the protagonists and the story's significant narrator characters. Ordinary people in the world are rarely affected by her notions.

Fate can be seen as a kind of currency that players have available to actively influence and interact in a story. It gives them opportunities to handle fantastic challenges, perform spectacular maneuvers or simply have incredible luck in critical situations.

Fate should be seen as a tool for building drama and tension in the story in a way that has mechanical connections, to increase fairness and balance between narrator and players.

Use

All situations where Fate is involved must be motivated in the story in some dramatic way. Additionally it must occur with reasonableness and within the story's framework. If these criteria are not met, the narrator can decide that Fate may not be used.

Generally, Fate may never be used to directly counteract or circumvent an event or situation that is created with the help of Fate. This is described further on page 239.

The protagonists' fate

Each protagonist can at most possess 25 points of Fate. More than that, events cannot be influenced. All protagonists start with 10 points of Fate when they are created, see page 87. A protagonist's Fate is personal and cannot be used to influence other protagonists' situations, unless this is explicitly mentioned — see Rescue on page 241.

One's Fate can be improved by using Experience, this is described on page 223. There are also other

Fate

situations where a protagonist's Fate improves, primarily when the narrator activates the protagonist's limitations or lures them into ruin.

The phenomena a protagonist can use Fate for are:

• Protect • Grit • Change situation • Inspiration • Knows a contact • Play the odds • Rescue • Survive

The narrator's fate pool

The narrator has access to a pool of Fate, called the Fate pool. All narrator-initiated Fate influence comes from the Fate pool. Narrator characters have no personal points of Fate but use the shared Fate pool's points.

Common narrator characters often lack the ability to influence their Fate and therefore rarely expend points from the Fate pool.

The fate pool's size

At each story's start, the narrator has a Fate pool consisting of the same number of points as the protagonist who has the most in Fate, added with the number of protagonists.

Each time any of the protagonists improve their Fate by one or more points, the narrator gets equally many new points to add to the Fate pool.

The Fate pool can never consist of more than 25 points.

Example: At a story start, three protagonists participate. Kallous is the one who has the most Fate, 24 points. This means that the narrator gets 27 points of Fate (24 + 3 for the number of protagonists), but since the maximum Fate pool is 25, the sum is adjusted to 25.

After a number of scenes in the story, the narrator has 12 Fate points left in the Fate pool. Kallous improves his Fate through Experience and gets five Fate points — the narrator then gets equally many and increases the Fate pool to 17.

The phenomena the narrator's Fate pool can be used for are

• Setback • Protect • Grit • Change situation • Knows a contact* • Play the odds • Survive

- Special use, see "Force a contact on a protagonist" on page 241.

How the narrator can use Fate

The narrator advantageously uses the Fate pool's points to guide a story in the desired direction, through divine interventions. Often it is an advantage to begin such situations with words like "Fate plays you a trick..." for then the players realize that the narrator has used their Fate pool to ensure that a situation that may seem a bit strange or contrived occurs, and this creates better understanding than when the narrator arbitrarily takes over a scene.

Example: The narrator has a Fate pool of 25 points available. Jessca is chasing an assassin through a ministry archive. The assassin runs into an office and knocks down a bookshelf that blocks the door. This means that the narrator uses Fate points for "Change situation, minor influence" (as the bookshelf was excellently placed on the narrator's map), see page 239.

The narrator lowers their Fate pool by three, to 22. The reason the narrator uses Fate points is that the story becomes more dramatic if Jessca doesn't catch the assassin at this stage.

The narrator says to Jessca: "When you reach it you hear a crash and dust swirls up between the door and the threshold. The door, which opens inward, is blocked and can at most be opened a few centimeters. From inside comes sounds of furniture moving. You realize it will take time to push aside what's blocking the door. You feel how fate grins mockingly at the back of your neck."

What Fate does

It is possible to influence a variety of situations by playing Fate's game and hoping that she smiles upon you. Here various things that Fate can be used for are described, as well as the amount of Fate that is expended upon use.

Setback (3 points of Fate)

A protagonist suffers a setback when the narrator activates one of the protagonist's limitations. A protagonist can at most suffer one setback per scene, regardless of where it comes from. As usual, the setback should fit into the scene and story and be reasonable. Each time a setback strikes a protagonist, regardless of whether it's activated or not, their Fate improves by one point. This point does not, however, give any points to the Fate pool.

Example: Jon Hargartian has an ailment — a bad heart. In a scene he chases his nemesis, the child murderer Rarkov, through a warehouse. Suddenly Jon sees how Rarkov is about to escape in a car. Jon raises his revolver and just then he suffers a setback. The narrator crosses out three points and Jon must roll to see if the ailment kicks in, according to the rules on page 243. Additionally Jon gets to improve his Fate by one point.

The whole thing is reasonable and dramatic — Jon has been running after his nemesis in the scene and now, when he has the chance to take him, fate laughs in his face...

Fate rewards

If a protagonist behaves or acts in an exciting, dramatic or simply fitting way in a scene, the narrator can immediately reward them by improving their Fate by one point.

The clock was a few minutes before midnight and the time for the meeting was close at hand. On the closed bridge between the Icon and the Fallen City waited Sergy Rulov and his entourage. The cars' headlights illuminated the rusty steel construction and the chilly north wind made cables and beams creak and groan. The wind carried with it a smell of sulfur from the Machine Cities and against the dark cloud masses the silhouette of a zeppelin on its way out towards the wastelands stood out. Rulov drew his Karev Riekon and checked the magazine before returning it to the shoulder holster. His men were on edge and they were all armed to the teeth in case something should go wrong—or if an opportunity should present itself. Finally several car headlights became visible, slowly approaching from the other side of the bridge, the cars slowed down and stopped a few dozen meters away. Rulov nodded briefly to his bodyguards, opened the car doors and stepped out into the biting wind. The crew in the other cars followed his example and positioned themselves in a semicircle with submachine guns and shotguns hidden under their heavy coats. Rulov told his men to stay alert. He let his gaze sweep over his closest bodyguards. Petrov whose light gray coat fluttered in the wind, Rudel who kept a firm grip on his Calder under the brown jacket and the suit-clad Milo who openly held the pump-action shotgun. They were good men and they were ready to follow his orders to the last. Then finally movement appeared at the vehicles on the opposite side, the Hexagon's people stepped out, archaically dressed men and women in suits, high shirt collars and long dresses—all dressed in black and all with gloves on their hands. They carried silver lanterns whose flames were protected by lead-set glass and the light cast surreal shadows on their faces. They stood there and waited. A white-clad man stepped confidently out of one of the cars, the Hexagon's foremost assassin, he carried a submachine gun in his hands and let his vigilant gaze sweep over the Rulov gang. Sergy suddenly became impatient and called out that he was there to meet the Hexagon's leader and not his henchmen. Silence met him—the black-clad individuals on the other side stood motionless—not even the wind seemed to tug at their clothes. Sergy looked nervously at the clock, three minutes to twelve. If the leader didn't show up he would assume it was a trap and he certainly didn't intend to negotiate with simple lackeys. Admittedly the Hexagon's people were as numerous as they were but Sergy didn't doubt that his crew was better armed and had better combat experience. The Hexagon's members would pay in blood if they had lured him to a meeting with their mythical leader, the Engineer, and he didn't deign to show up. Then he heard it, the sound of horse hooves clattering against the asphalt, a sound he hadn't heard since childhood in Darost. The cold wind subsided and the night fell into an uncomfortable stillness. The shadows seemed to grow and deepen while the car headlights' artificial glow became ever weaker. Sergy's men looked around uneasily and some irresolutely drew their weapons. The lights slowly faded only to then go out completely and the only glow came from the silver lanterns that the black-clad figures from the Hexagon carried. Everything was shrouded in darkness. The clattering came closer and behind the Hexagon's vehicles appeared a dark carriage drawn by a team of four pitch-black horses. The carriage swung up in front of the vehicles and stopped. A hunched person sat on the driver's box with a mask over their face. Sergy swallowed, without having thought it through he had drawn the submachine gun and now held it in a firm grip in front of him. His men looked tensely at him and he curtly told them to stay calm. He returned the weapon to the holster and stepped forward a few steps, flanked by his three bodyguards. The door to the carriage opened and out stepped a platinum blonde woman in an old-fashioned dress with a corset. When she turned her gaze toward Sergy he saw that half her face was youthful and beautiful while the other half was scarred and grotesque. After her stepped out an older man whom Sergy realized must be the Engineer. The man was tall and thin, his bony hand rested on a cane whose knob was shaped like a silver skull and his face had almost the same appearance. The worst part, however, were the lifeless eyes that firmly met Sergy Rulov's gaze. Somewhere far away a church bell could be heard tolling for midnight.

Protect (3 Fate points) A person can take on an attack or a harmful situation that another person suffers. This is done after the situation has been established but before damage has been determined. It costs the protector three Fate points to receive the damage. The original target escapes completely without harm. Note that in the narrative it must be reasonable that the protection is carried out, for example the person should be in proximity (within Combat Movement) of the one to be protected, and be aware of what is about to happen. Protecting someone in this way is a noble act and should be described in the narrative in a dramatic and inspiring way. If the protecting person should die as a direct consequence of the situation, a protagonist created in his/her place automatically receives 25 Fate points from the start as a gift from the smiling goddess. Example: Gabriel and Anya are investigating a warehouse in the harbor. When they open the door to the office they hear a metallic sound. Gabriel is the only one who succeeds with a difficulty roll (Awareness) and thus the only one to perceive an unsecured hand grenade in the doorway. He reacts lightning fast by firmly and forcefully shoving Anya away over a couple of crates when the explosion sweeps the area in fire, heat and shockwave. Gabriel crosses off three Fate points for the protection and takes damage from the detonating grenade twice—once because he himself stood in its blast radius and once more because he took the hit that Anya would have received. Anya rises unharmed thanks to Gabriel's protection and finds him shortly thereafter severely burned, with his smoldering overcoat smeared against a container wall, and barely alive. She smiles warmly at him, kisses his cracked lips, lifts him up and supports him out of the premises in search of a taxi. Grit Your Teeth (1 Fate point) The person can use one Fate point to be able to act in a round even though he/she is mortally wounded or dazed. All penalties for Wounds and Dazed apply as usual. The person can continue to expend Fate to act in more rounds while mortally wounded, as long as he/she has Fate to use. Fate cannot be used in the same round that a mortally wounded person dies. Nor can it be used in the same round that the person becomes stabilized. When the person grits their teeth it should be evident from the portrayal how agonizing it is and how battered the person is. The person is after all still mortally wounded and near death or alternatively near unconsciousness. Example: Makasty was stabbed by his lover Keya when he refused to pay for her abortion. The stab went badly and made Makasty mortally wounded and he will die in twelve rounds. His Initiative is automatically set to one. During the second round he grits his teeth, crosses off one Fate point and tries to assess the situation. His Initiative increases to 8 and he sees how Keya is throwing her belongings into a bag, while she curses at him. In round three Makasty continues to grit his teeth and painfully draws his revolver from the back holster. In round four he shoots the very surprised Keya in the head with clenched teeth so that she tumbles into a closet, stone dead. When round five begins Makasty has no Fate points left but collapses and heavily drops the short-barreled revolver on the thick bloody carpet. He looks unfocused up at the window and feels how death slowly arrives, all the while the rain relentlessly lashes against the panes. Alter Situation (3 or 12 Fate points) The person can noticeably change or affect a situation in a scene through Fate's providence. The situation should be such that it is obvious that it is Fate that determines that the situation changes. The narrator should ensure to keep the balance in the narrative at the right level. An altered situation consumes three Fate points. A general rule is that a person cannot use Fate to counteract or combat an effect that has already been created with the help of Fate. Example: Since Karim Darkov has used Fate to barricade the door with a crossbar, Darkov's enemy may not use Fate to knock away the crossbar or affect the door in a way that would negate the reasonable effect of the crossbar. However, of course the door may be attacked in the usual way with gunfire, kicks or axe blows, but then without Fate's involvement. Furthermore, Fate cannot change situations or events that have already occurred or that have been established, thus those that are already clearly established in the narrative. If it is established that a safe deposit box is empty, then Fate cannot be used to make it full of money. However, Fate can be used to let someone find money in a safe deposit box that is not yet established in the narrative—if it is deemed reasonable in the scene. Fate very rarely causes direct damage to, or attacks on, a person so such proposals should be assessed carefully, and their effect should fit very well into the scene and narrative for them to be

allowed to be created. Influence that leads to direct damage to a narrator character costs twelve Fate points to activate instead of the three required for non-damaging influence. A narrator can always veto when a player wishes to use Fate to change a situation if the influence is deemed unreasonable or falls outside the scene's framework. The Fate points are then not expended. **Examples of alterations** As always, the alteration must be reasonable and fall within the narrative's framework. Players and narrator are encouraged to come up with situations and types of influence themselves, but some suggestions follow here. Introduce an unimportant narrator character: • When the protagonists desperately watch for an individual by a house in the slums that the individual has a vague connection to, the individual actually comes out through the gate. • When the protagonists are threatened by the villain's gorillas inside an office, a night watchman just happens to pass by to see it all. • When the protagonists are chased by enemies one early morning they are saved by a newspaper delivery person who suddenly comes around the corner and happens to trip up the enemy. **Reasonableness** All situations where Fate is mixed in must be motivated in the narrative in some dramatic way. Furthermore it must occur with reasonableness and within the scene's and narrative's framework. If this is not fulfilled the narrator can without hesitation decide that Fate may not be used.

• When the villains are searching for the protagonists in a warehouse, police sirens suddenly sound outside the window — it's a patrol car that received an alert from some unknown person who observed suspicious activity. Introduce object/location: • The person discovers a secret passage between two already known locations in a fortress. • The person finds a spare key to a suspect's apartment in the wall lamp by the front door. • A car happens to pass in the night rain and blinds an individual who is watching toward the person's hiding place. • A person stranded in the wilderness after a plane crash remembers that his/her captain from the army actually has a cabin nearby. Manipulate an object's function: • The person manages to position a shotgun as a bar for a door so the enemy is prevented from getting through. • The person manages to shake the flashlight to life when it goes out due to dead batteries. • An enemy's magazine happens to fall out of the weapon when he/she aims at the person. • The person gets a broken telephone to work tolerably for a brief desperate call. Escape indirect harm or death: • The person finds a branch to try to grab hold of when he/she is thrown over a cliff. • The person manages to find a piece of furniture to use as cover when the bomb detonates. • The person lands in a swimming pool after a jump from the seventh floor of a hotel. • A person who has been hanged by the enemy manages to smash a nearby window and with the help of a glass shard between the feet cut through the ropes. Example: Anya comes home after a shift, takes off her clothes and steps into the shower. She hears the front door creak. The scene is already defined such that Anya has removed her clothes, and with them her weapons. She now sacrifices three Fate points so that her shoulder holster hangs by the sink next to the shower so she can easily get hold of her automatic pistol. The narrator has no problem with this as it doesn't take focus from the scene. Had Anya not sacrificed any points, the narrator would have thought that all clothes, including the shoulder holster, would lie on her bed, which is where they reasonably ought to be. But Fate apparently wanted it otherwise. Example: Gabriel is being chased by the enemy up in the Arkady massif. He has no ammunition left and is becoming desperate. He finds an old hunting cabin and breaks in through a window. Gabriel sacrifices three Fate points to find an old hunting rifle in the cabin. The narrator judges it as reasonable and within the framework of the story and has no objections. Example: Talia Navarre is driving home in her car when she is pursued by a motorcyclist. She tries to escape but no matter what she does the pursuer stays on her tail. Since she must meet a contact at a certain time she doesn't have time for more cat-and-mouse games but wants to use Fate for help along the way. She asks the narrator if it's okay that the motorcyclist suddenly drives into a curb and gets a flat tire on the front wheel? The narrator judges that it's not impossible, but fairly unlikely, but approves it anyway as it makes the scene dramatic. Since the reasonable effect is that the pursuer will injure himself, at risk of death, from the change in the scene, Talia must strike off twelve Fate points. She then vividly describes how the motorcyclist tries to shoot her back in a rain-soaked intersection but misjudges the situation, rips the tire off the wheel, slides

down on the side and with full force crashes into a bakery on the other side of the street. Inspiration (1 Fate point per person in the group) Situations may arise in a story when the protagonists have gotten stuck. They may have missed an essential clue, forgotten a detail from a conversation, or not achieved the success expected. Then inspiration can be the solution to move forward. If the protagonist group sacrifices as many Fate points as the number of people in the group, the narrator can give a relatively clear clue, preferably in the form of an inspiring and dramatic aha-moment that describes how the case is cracked, how the solution reveals itself, or how the puzzle piece suddenly falls into place. Note that each group member doesn't have to pay one point each, but that the group as a whole must sacrifice a certain sum — this means someone can sacrifice two points while someone else doesn't need to sacrifice any points. Example: The three investigators Kallous, Irvan and Jesimea have completely gotten stuck in their criminal investigation. They ask for inspiration and the narrator says it requires three Fate points. Irvan sacrifices two and Jesimea sacrifices one for the group to reach the three points. The narrator says that the perfume-soaked handkerchief with sewn-on monogram that was found at the murder scene might be identified by someone whose profession is to manufacture or sell perfumes. Jesimea immediately starts looking in the phone directory to follow up the lead. Knows a contact (5, 10 or 15 Fate points) The protagonists know a narrator character who is considered significant to the scene and the story. Once per scene a protagonist can establish a narrator character as a contact — it could be an old friend, a companion from before, an army buddy, an ex, a relative, a business contact, an acquaintance, a rival, an enemy, or similar. The most important thing is that the contact, when established, must not feel unreasonable or misplaced in the story. That a criminal detective knows the police director isn't strange, but if a homeless vagrant claims he is best friends with a clan patriarch this should be questioned by the narrator. A good explanation can of course make the contact real. A protagonist may at most establish one contact per scene. When the contact is established, this must occur in a way that fits the story and must be motivated by the player, preferably in the form of a monologue or a flashback. This introduction of the contact should include name, location, function/occupation, and how he/she knows the protagonist. It should preferably create a new dramatic situation in the ongoing story.

Rescue (2-10 Fate points) Situations can arise in which a person stands without Fate's blessing when it really matters. Another person can then sacrifice their own Fate to assist the unfortunate one. For every other Fate point sacrificed in this way, the unfortunate one immediately gets to use one Fate point. The one who rescues the unfortunate one may at most sacrifice ten points in this way. The one who is rescued must not have their own Fate remaining. Note that in the story it must be reasonable that rescue can occur. For example, the person should be nearby and notice the unfortunate one's predicament. The rescue should occur in a dramatic and reasonable way in the story, perhaps through an exchange of weary glances, an understanding nod, a thumbs up, or something else that shows that a rescue actually occurs. Example: Nevei stands on a rooftop in the rain and observes the mortally wounded Gabriel, who slowly feels his will to live draining from him. Before Nevei stands Anya on her knees with Nevei's sword blade against the side of her neck. Gabriel has no Fate left after the wild battle that has unfolded and cannot act. Anya meets Gabriel's dim gaze tearfully and forms a soundless "I love you" with trembling lips. This is the signal for Anya to rescue Gabriel (and hopefully herself) by expending two Fate points so Gabriel can immediately use one. He uses it to grit his teeth and manages to raise the automatic pistol toward Nevei, who is just lifting the blade. In the rain, with the pain piercing his head and with a trembling hand, he presses the trigger and the pistol's thunder cuts through the rain's drumming as Nevei jerks and drops the sword when the bullet strikes its blade. Survive (3-15 Fate points) A person who knows he/she will probably be injured can lower the number of Wounds the situation inflicts by one per three Fate points (–1 Wound/3 Fate points). A maximum of 15 points can be expended in this way. The number of points must be determined before the damage effect is confirmed, and even if the number of Fate points would lower the number of Wounds to zero or less, the victim always receives at least one Wound. If the situation results in no Wounds being caused, the expended Fate is wasted. How this occurs

in the story must be described dramatically. Survive can be used during executions (see page 271). Example: Anya takes off with one of the witnesses to a bestial murder with connections to one of the clans. The rain pours down over the two and when they come around a corner they are met by an assassin who fires a shot at Anya. The shot hits and Anya, who feels she must survive, sacrifices 9 Fate points and is lucky — the shot turns out to inflict exactly three Wounds on her, which is reduced to zero. But since she must suffer at least one Wound if Wounds arise, she still receives one Wound. In the story this is described as the bullet taking her right in the chest but her police badge she has hanging around her neck manages to stop it enough that its destructive effect becomes clearly less than one would have thought. She manages to kick the weapon from the assassin's hand and flees headlong down an alley with the witness in a firm grip. The amount of Fate expended determines the contact's Influence. Five points gives Minor influence, ten points give Moderate influence, and 15 points show that the contact is Influential. A difficulty roll (Impression) is then rolled to determine the person's relationship to the contact. This involves a certain risk-taking as the relationship doesn't become known until the contact has been established — an old friend may very well turn out to be hostile. For more information on this, see page 209. The player can choose whether the contact has blood ties with the protagonist or if he/she is a family member. The contact is now written into the character sheet. Once a contact has been established, it is maintained, together with relationship and influence, and can be used in other stories or scenes without problem, by both player and narrator. Example: Mordekai is in trouble and needs to hide. He suddenly remembers an old flame he had when young, Klarysa Hagi — a theater girl who hung around the loft above the nightclub "The High Hat". She and Mordekai had a fiery affair for a couple of months many years ago. This is sufficient to establish Klarysa as a contact in the story. Mordekai strikes off five Fate points and gives Klarysa Minor influence which feels reasonable given the backstory. Then the difficulty roll (Impression) is made. The result becomes a failure whereby Klarysa stands Disapproving toward Mordekai. Mordekai shrugs and mumbles something about "not everyone can love you", while he figures out arguments to convince her to let him hide at her place for a couple of days. Play the odds (1-5 points, alt. 4 Fate points) A person may expend Fate to increase their chances of succeeding at difficulty and resistance rolls. This is usually called "betting the odds". For each Fate point used, the person gets to roll an extra die in the roll. A maximum of five points may be used in a single roll. The player then chooses which two dice results to use, other dice are ignored. A player can also choose to spend four Fate points to roll an extra die after a roll has been made. This die can then be used to replace one of the dice in the result, if desired. Example: Mordekai fires snapshots at an axe-wielding onrushing maniac. He must hit on the first shot as he must make it to a meeting place to get information about Janya's killer. A maximum of five Fate points are sacrificed. Seven dice are rolled and the results are 1, 3, 4, 6, 7, 7, 10. There are two sensible choices to make in this situation. Either Mordekai chooses the two sevens and hopes that it's enough to hit, in which case it becomes an exceptionally successful roll (exceptionally failed if the result isn't sufficient). Or he chooses one of the sevens and the ten which are maxed so another die gets to be rolled. The five dice that aren't chosen are ignored and removed from the roll. Example: Jessca makes a difficulty roll (Stamina) to manage to keep running. The dice show 1 and 1 — an exceptional failure! This cannot happen as it's critical that she reaches the goal in time. She sacrifices four Fate points and rolls one more die, which shows 7. She removes one of the ones and replaces it with the seven which means she succeeds with the roll. **Forcing a contact on a protagonist** Troublesome situations can arise where the narrator wants a protagonist to know a narrator character, even though the protagonist hadn't intended this. If a narrator establishes a relationship in this forceful way, the customary amount of Fate is struck from the Fate pool and functions thereafter as if the protagonist Knows a contact. The protagonist's Fate also improves by one point due to the intervention.

A human body can become sick, injured or killed and likewise the human psyche can be broken down and destroyed. Many cannot handle existence's strains but sink into depression and destructiveness where suicide seems to be the easiest way out. **Wellbeing** A person's well-being, degree of relaxation, general condition

and state of mind are collectively called Wellbeing. Wellbeing can vary between eleven different levels, from Relaxed to Catatonic. Stressful experiences, physically exhausting work or other influence worsens Wellbeing while calm and quiet, security and sleep improve it. When Wellbeing worsens, this can give penalties to all possible, reasonable actions. The penalty symbolizes stress, nervousness, exhaustion, fatigue, confusion, sleep deprivation or similar. See table 1:53. **Wellbeing Penalty** Relaxed (10) — Composed (9) — Troubled (8) — Tense (7) — Uneasy (6) — Stressed (5) –1* Strained (4) –2* Weary (3) –3* Tormented (2) –4* Desperate (1) –5* Catatonic (0) –10* Table 1:53 * The person only suffers the penalty that applies at the current level of Wellbeing — the penalties are not cumulative. **Maximum Wellbeing** Certain events can lower a person's Maximum Wellbeing. A person's Wellbeing can never be higher than Maximum Wellbeing. Usually a person has both Wellbeing and Maximum Wellbeing at Relaxed (10). For a person's Maximum Wellbeing to fall often requires extreme experiences and the afflicted person is then not seldom depressed, traumatized, disturbed or otherwise broken. Wellbeing zero (Catatonic) A person who feels so bad that he/she has Wellbeing level zero must once per day, usually right after any recovery of Wellbeing has been checked, **Wellbeing**

rats, make an unmodified difficulty check (Willpower). If the check fails, the person dies due to the condition, for exam-ple from starvation, from the psyche or body giving up, or from the person simply taking their own life. **Wellbeing Recovery** Wellbeing can at best be at the same level as Maxi-mum Wellbeing, and at lowest at the Catatonic level (0). If Maximum Wellbeing is lower than Relaxed (10), a difficulty check (Sanity) must be made once per day, usually directly after a longer sleep or rest period. This check is modified by the penalty for current Wellbeing as well as depending on how the rest period looked, according to table 1:54. The result from the difficulty check indicates how much Well-being is affected. Exceptionally successful: The person's Wellbeing improves by as many levels as the value on the lowest die, to at most the person's Maximum Wellbeing. If the person's Maximum Wellbeing is under ten, it improves one level. Successful: The person's Wellbeing improves one level. Failed: The person's Wellbeing does not change. Exceptionally failed: The person's Wellbeing dete-riorates one level. **Penalty Circumstances** ±0 Rested for approximately eight hours in a calm and safe environment −2 Rested for approximately six hours, or in a disturbing environment −5 Rested for approximately four hours, or in an unsafe environment −10 Rested for less than four hours, or in a chaotic environment Table 1:54 **Therapy** A person can get help raising their wellbeing through therapy with a therapist. At least one hour of conversation is required. The therapist makes a difficulty check (Medicine) to see if the person's Wellbeing is affected. Exceptionally successful check: The patient gets a bonus (+10) on the next difficulty check for Wellbeing recovery. Successful check: The patient gets a bonus (+5) on the next difficulty check for Wellbeing recovery. Failed check: The patient is not helped by the session. Exceptionally failed check: The patient gets a penalty (−5) on the next difficulty check for Wellbeing recovery. **Love** A person who is happily in love or beloved gets a bonus (+5) on difficulty checks for Wellbeing recovery. Unhappy or unrequited love gives a penalty (−2). **Physical Exhaustion** A person who struggles with heavy physical labor, marches at high pace, suffers from limiting illnesses or handi-caps or is exposed to inhospitable climate, weather and wind, risks being struck by exhaustion. Physical exhaustion is rarely as dangerous to health in the long term as stress is, but can cause temporary obstacles in action. Note that physical exhaustion primarily applies to rela-tively prolonged activity — even if it's tough to run a kilometer, it doesn't cause any mechanical exhaustion. A guideline is that an activity should be ongoing for at least four hours for the rules to apply. **Exhaustion Procedure** When a person is struck by exhaustion, a difficulty check must be made. At most, the check is made once per four hours. Depending on the situation or event, different abilities are best suited for the check. Stamina is appropriate for fatigue, exertion and bodily endurance. Tolerance is appropriate for illness, poisoning and exposure to the elements. When the appropriate ability has been determined, the check is made, pos-sibly modified depending on how serious or extensive the exhausting situation is judged to have been. The per-son's Wellbeing also plays a role. The result of the difficulty check can cause the person to be struck by an impairment for a certain time. More about different types of

impairment and their effects can be found on page 244. Exceptionally successful check: The person withstands the exhaus-tion and does not need to roll again for similar exhaustion for the rest of the game session. Successful check: The person withstands the exhaustion. Failed check: The person is struck by a minor impair-ment. Exceptionally failed check: The person is struck by a serious impairment. **Impairment** There are two different levels of impairment — minor and serious. Minor impairment usually passes with time. Serious impairment can cause long-lasting consequences with long recovery periods. Often it also causes the person's Maximum Wellbeing to deteriorate. There are different categories of exhaustion, depending on source — freezing in a snowstorm is different from being forced to march in harsh terrain for a full day. The narrator and player must judge which category seems reasonable in each individual situation, based on the information given in table 1:55. Sex & pleasure Just like love, sex can also improve a person's Wellbeing. By feeding a drive that is fulfilled through intercourse or similar sexual activities, the person is given the opportunity to improve their Wellbeing. More about drives can be found on page 230.

Category Minor Serious Example

Physically drained Worn Out Exhausted Marching, long-distance running, swimming, hard riding, mountain climbing, heavy physical labor (for example building houses or digging ditches), carrying/dragging heavy loads. Exposure to elements Troubled Beset Heavy rain, snow or sunshine, extreme humidity, cold or heat. Personal ailment Hindering Life-threatening When an ailment is activated. Table 1:55 **Effects of Impairment** The person is struck by damage through a damage value. This can represent overexertion, fainting, disorienta-tion, confusion, hyperventilation, muscle or joint injuries or perhaps sprains. The person's Wellbeing deteriorates as balance and calm are disrupted. In serious impairment, the person's Maxi-mum Wellbeing can also drop — it symbolizes the more long-term effects of the exhaustion. When it is mentioned in the impairment that Wellbeing deteriorates by values from a die, this refers to the difficulty check that was made to check if the person was affected by the exhaustion. All types of impair-ment can lower Wellbeing to Catatonic (0) and the person risks dying, see page 242. **Different Types of Impairment** Description of impairments. **Beset** The person's Maximum Wellbeing deteriorates (−1). The physical strain represents damage value B1T. **Troubled** The person's Wellbeing deteriorates (−1). **Hindering** An ailment is activated and the person is struck by the ailment's penalty (see page 82) in all reasonable activities for the rest of the scene. **Life-threatening** An ailment is activated and the person is struck by the ailment's penalty (see page 82) in all reasonable activities for the rest of the scene. Additionally, the person receives a Wound. **Worn Out** The person's Wellbeing deteriorates (−1). The physical strain represents damage value B1T. **Exhausted** The person's Maximum Wellbeing deteriorates by as much as the value on the lowest die in the check. The physical strain represents damage value B2T. **Psychological Exhaustion** "I if anyone have seen into evil people and felt their destructive power. I am a victim and a victor, for without the insight I would still have been small and lost." — Jessica Navarre, after a heated dispute with Mordekai Remus A person who is exposed to pressing situations, terror-filled experiences, nasty surprises, horrific abus-es, brutal violence or deep violations risks being struck by negative and limiting psychological effects from this. Such events or situations are collectively called stress. **Stress Procedure** When a person is struck by stress, a difficulty check must be made. Depending on the situation or event, different abilities are best suited for the check. Resistance is appropriate for withstanding mental strain, such as experiencing violence, terror or abuse. Sanity is appropriate for withstanding prolonged stress and panic situations as well as for managing to keep one's head cool under pressure. When the appropriate ability has been determined, the check is made, pos-sibly modified depending on how serious or extensive the stressful situation is judged to be. The person's Wellbeing also plays a role. The result of the difficulty check can cause the person to be struck by a stress condition for a certain time. More about different stress conditions and their effects can be found on page 245. Exceptionally successful check: The person withstands the stress and does not need to roll for similar

stress again for the rest of the game session. Successful check: The person withstands the stress. Failed check: The person is struck by a minor stress condition. Exceptionally failed check: The person is struck by a serious stress condition. **Stress Conditions** There are two different levels of stress conditions — minor and serious. Minor stress conditions usually pass with time when the stress-inducing event has disappeared. Se-rious stress conditions can cause long-lasting effects that require outside help to overcome. Often they also cause the person's Maximum Wellbeing to deteriorate. There are different categories of stress, depending on the type of impact — being tortured long-term by the enemy gives different types of harm than being forced to face one's severe fear of heights. The narrator and player must judge which category feels reasonable in each individual situation, based on the infor-mation given in table 1:56. It may be important to note that the narrator must be subjective in the assessment. If for example two main charac-ters, a war veteran and an accountant, together kill a person, the accountant will most likely be struck by significantly more stress than the desensitized war veteran. Base the assessment on reasonableness from the person's background, previous experiences and psycho-logical profile.

"I have no problem with a reasonable amount of trouble." — Mordekai Remus

Category Minor Severe Example

Psychological trauma Shocked Collapse Being violated, subjected to assault/violence/rape, tortured, humiliated, suffering abuse/ degradation Shocking experience Shaken Terrified Violent shocking event, social shock experience, subjected to threats/harassment, being involved in combat/violence/death/mutilation, injuring/killing/murdering someone, seeing visions/apparitions, sudden awakenings from deep sleep/trance/hypnosis. Prolonged stress Depression Melancholy Involuntary isolation, being in a war, close friend/relative ill, bullying/ostracism, debt, living in a destructive relationship, being awake for a long time Personal fear Frightened Panic When a fear is activated Personal weakness Distraction Obsession When a weakness is activated Table 1:56 **Effects of being afflicted by stress conditions** A person's Wellbeing deteriorates when balance, calm and inner harmony are disturbed. In severe stress conditions, the person's Maximum Wellbeing can also decrease — this symbolizes the more long-term effects of the trauma. When it is mentioned in a stress condition that Wellbeing deteriorates by values from a die, this refers to the difficulty roll made to check whether the person was affected by the stress. All types of stress conditions can lower Wellbeing to Catatonic (0). If this occurs, the person risks dying, see page 242. The person risks dying or breaking down completely from the experience. This can involve extreme constraint, cerebral infarction, respiratory arrest, stroke/cerebral hemorrhage, palpitations/cardiac arrest/heart attack, coma or permanent apathy. Ongoing effects, for example daily control rolls to avoid further harm from the experience. **Different types of stress conditions** Description of stress conditions. **Obsession** See Distraction for general information. The difference is that if the weakness is not satisfied in the scene, the person's Wellbeing is lowered by as much as the value on the lowest die in the difficulty roll. Additionally, Wellbeing will deteriorate (−1) each day that the obsession is not satisfied, until Wellbeing reaches zero. **Shocked** The person's Wellbeing deteriorates by as much as the value on the highest die in the roll. **Depression** The person's Maximum Wellbeing deteriorates (−1). Each day the person must make a difficulty roll (Sense) with a bonus (+5) and if it fails, Wellbeing deteriorates (−1). On an exceptional failure, both Wellbeing and Maximum Wellbeing deteriorate (−1). The stress condition releases when Maximum Wellbeing reaches Relaxed (10). **Distraction** The person stops in thought and action to meet, indulge in, converse with, admire, or otherwise give the target of the weakness their attention. This is a subconscious impulse and the prevailing situation plays no role (except in mortal danger). During the scene where the distraction occurs, the person suffers a penalty equal to the weakness's intensity on all actions that do not directly involve the weakness's target. When the distraction can be judged to be satisfied, this penalty releases. Should the person completely fail to

achieve satisfaction in the situation, his/her Wellbeing deteriorates (−1). **Collapse** The person's Wellbeing and Maximum Wellbeing deteriorate by as much as the combined value on all dice in the roll. The person is exhausted and must make a difficulty roll (Will to Live) with a penalty from Wellbeing to avoid dying or becoming incurably insane. **Melancholy** The person's Maximum Wellbeing deteriorates by as much as the value on the lowest die in the roll. Each day the person must make a difficulty roll (Sense) and if it fails, Wellbeing deteriorates (−1). On an exceptional failure, both Wellbeing and Maximum Wellbeing deteriorate (−1). The stress condition releases when Maximum Wellbeing reaches Relaxed (10). **Panic** The person's Wellbeing and Maximum Wellbeing deteriorate each by as much as the sum of the value on all dice in the roll. The person must make a difficulty roll (Will to Live) with a penalty from Wellbeing to avoid dying or becoming incurably insane. If the person is not exhausted, one of the usual defense reactions may appear, for example hysteria, flight, paralysis or outward aggression. **Shaken** The person's Wellbeing deteriorates by as much as the value on the lowest die in the roll. **Frightened** The person's Wellbeing and Maximum Wellbeing deteriorate by as much as the value on the lowest die in the roll. **Terrified** The person's Wellbeing deteriorates by as many steps as the value on the highest die in the roll. The person is exhausted and must make a difficulty roll (Will to Live) with a penalty from Wellbeing to avoid dying or becoming incurably insane. **Dying from an ailment** Situations may arise that at first glance may seem strange when it comes to ailments, as an exceptionally failed roll means a risk that a person dies from their ailment. If it is narratively defined that the ailment is not of such nature that it is deadly to the person, such as back problems, a troublesome knee, rheumatism, migraine, etc., it may seem odd that the person receives a Wound from it. See it then as circumstances outside the ailment's effect itself in the scene giving rise to the Wound. The knee may give way on stairs or cause the person to stumble out in front of a car. A migraine attack may cause the person's vision to blacken so that he/she falls and hits their head on a table edge. In other words, see it as a life-threatening effect arising from the ailment. In this way, all ailments are dangerous, and not just heart problems or a bad liver are potentially deadly.

While the affluent warm themselves by fires in marble halls, the homeless huddle under filthy blankets to survive the winter nights. A person's standard of living is often the same as his/her social level and the respect he/she receives from society. **Standard of Living** A person's standard of living refers to his/her place in society's hierarchy. It indicates birth, wealth, prestige and status. Standard of living is a simplified and deliberately abstract way of indicating a person's lifestyle, everyday life and economic possibilities. If major upheavals occur during the story's course, the narrator can adjust a person's standard of living based on the information given below. Examples of such events are inheritance, catastrophes, fires, bankruptcies, scandals and prison sentences. Standard of living is described with a value between zero and ten, where a higher value refers to better status. All new persons created are considered to have standard of living four unless otherwise modified in their background. Both the players and the narrator are encouraged to use standard of living as a basis when bringing their characters to life and creating places for them in society. Standard of Living 0 The person is a washed-up street bum without a fixed address. He/she seeks shelter in sewers, under bridges and in tunnels and runs a great risk of being assaulted, mocked and scorned. A few good souls donate a coin when the person begs for survival while the State cares little about the person and the police beat him/her up for fun. Many of those who have standard of living 0 are mentally ill, insane, handicapped, addicts and/or criminals. Residence: The street, the sewers. Assets: One set of tattered, torn clothes in miserable condition. Cash: 50 zovrins. Creditworthiness: Cannot borrow cash from anyone. Advancement: One cannot be moved up to standard of living 0. Standard of Living 1 The person lacks permanent housing and lives most of their life on the street but has certain connections that mean he/she can sometimes lodge with some better **Standard of Living**

off unfortunate or at a shelter run by volunteers or the church. Sometimes the person manages to get some miserable odd job that makes everyday life a bit more bearable. Residence: The street, lodging, shelter. Assets: One set of worn, shabby clothes in poor condition. Cash: 250 zovrins. Creditworthiness: 2,500 zovrins. Advancement: 5,000 zovrins in cash. Standard of Living 2 The person is probably temporarily unemployed and still has a roof over their head. Everyday life is tough and grueling and the person often goes hungry but can, thanks to helpful friends and relatives, keep their housing. He/she gets by on shady odd jobs or grueling part-time work. Residence: Rents a room or a small, miserable apartment in a bad area. Assets: Two sets of clothes of older style in poor condition. Furniture in miserable condition. Cash: 1,000 zovrins. Creditworthiness: 10,000 zovrins. Advancement: 20,000 zovrins in cash. Standard of Living 3 The person is probably one of the countless anonymous, unqualified workers struggling with heavy and dirty work in the factories, or perhaps one of the lifetime employees working for slave wages until death relieves them. Perhaps he/she works part-time in a shop or at a small company, as a taxi driver or as a bartender at a slum bar. Residence: Dingy rental apartment in poor condition. Assets: A personal car in miserable condition. A wardrobe consisting of half a dozen garments and shoes in poor condition. Furniture in poor condition. Cash: 2,500 zovrins. Creditworthiness: 25,000 zovrins. Advancement: 50,000 zovrins in cash. Standard of Living 4 The person is counted as low-income but has a reasonably steady job where he/she is considered to have basic qualifications, for example factory work with higher demands or a government job such as police officer. The Empire's soldiers also fit here as compensation for field battles is not high, but lodging and food are included at least. Within this standard of living there are loads of opportunities regarding odd jobs, temporary work, criminal activities and other things where one has shown to be trustworthy and good at what one does. In their free time, the person often hangs out at shady bars to wind down. Residence: Worn rental apartment in a half-decent area. Assets: A personal car in poor condition. A wardrobe consisting of half a dozen garments and shoes in worn condition. Furniture in worn condition. Cash: 5,000 zovrins. Creditworthiness: 50,000 zovrins. Advancement: 100,000 zovrins in cash. Standard of Living 5 The person is a normal income earner living a bearable life without the immediate struggle to survive or the stress of not being able to pay their bills. Perhaps he/she is self-employed or an office worker within companies or the State. Even experienced police officers can fall into this category. The person amuses themselves at dance clubs, pubs and bars. Residence: A normal rental apartment in a decent area. Assets: A personal car in worn condition. A wardrobe consisting of half a dozen garments, shoes and accessories of normal quality. Furniture of normal quality. Cash: 10,000 zovrins. Creditworthiness: 100,000 zovrins. Advancement: 200,000 zovrins in cash. Standard of Living 6 The person has a stable economy and a secure work situation with room for some luxury in the daily grind, such as restaurant visits and theater tickets. The work, which is full-time, is demanding and includes some responsibility, for example over a group of individuals or for an activity. Residence: One's own normal apartment. Assets: A personal car of normal quality. A wardrobe consisting of half a dozen garments, shoes and accessories of normal quality. Furniture of normal quality. Cash: 25,000 zovrins. Creditworthiness: 250,000 zovrins. Advancement: 500,000 zovrins in cash. Standard of Living 7 The person is well-paid and possesses a good position at their work such as doctor, lawyer, higher officer or successful small business owner. The person is almost counted among the upper class but not quite yet. Residence: One's own, large, normal apartment in a good area. Assets: A personal car of excellent quality. A wardrobe consisting of a dozen garments, shoes and accessories of excellent quality. Furniture of normal quality. Cash: 50,000 zovrins. Creditworthiness: 500,000 zovrins. Advancement: 1,000,000 zovrins in cash.

Living Standard 8 The person belongs to the upper class where money and luxury are commonplace. Here you'll find directors, managers and higher officials within the State, together with lesser-known family members. Very successful entrepreneurs and freelancers also fit into this company. Residence: A very large, excellent apartment in a respectable and quiet area. Assets: A luxury car of excellent quality. A ward-robe consisting of dozens of garments, shoes and accessories of excellent quality. Furniture and art of excellent

quality. Cash: 100,000 zovrins. Credit rating: 1,000,000 zovrins. Advancement: 2,000,000 zovrins in cash. Living Standard 9 The person belongs to, or mingles among, family personalities, senior executives and state ministry directors. He/she might be a successful film personality or musician who rubs shoulders with the wealthy at elegant parties, receptions and inaugurations. Here you'll also find the elite of high finance in the form of brokers, financiers and bankers. Residence: An excellent villa or estate, alternatively a luxury apartment in one of the finest areas. Assets: Two cars (a luxury car and a sports car) of excep-tional quality. A wardrobe consisting of dozens of tailor-made clothes, shoes and accessories of exceptional quali-ty. Furniture and art of excellent quality. Cash: 250,000 zovrins. Credit rating: 2,500,000 zovrins. Advancement: 5,000,000 zovrins in cash. Living Standard 10 The person belongs to the social elite consisting of promi-nent individuals from the families, the State's highest directors, top diplomats and foremost investigators. They are seen together with business magnates, wealthy heirs and the most prominent bankers, in a constant struggle to achieve ultimate success. One single mistake and the person can only fall downward. Residence: An exceptional villa, a penthouse in the city, or an estate or castle outside Sandukar. Three excellent overnight apartments in different locations in Sandukar or in some other city. Alternatively a luxury yacht or private island. Naturally the person owns at least one excellent summer house in the country. Assets: Three cars (a luxury car, a sports car, a limousine) of exceptional quality. A wardrobe consisting of two dozen tailor-made garments, shoes and accessories of exceptional quality. Furniture and art of exceptional quality. Cash: 1,000,000 zovrins. Credit rating: 10,000,000 zovrins. Advancement: 20,000,000 zovrins in cash. **The Concepts** What the various terms in the living standard template mean. **Residence** Indicates where/how the person lives. **Assets** Tells what assets are included in the person's household. Upon advancement to a new standard, the person automatically receives the assets specified in the new standard — they are considered included in the advancement cost. The previous assets disappear as they are considered disposed of. Upon a downgrade, all old assets are considered sold or scrapped. A wardrobe is always included in every living standard. It is up to the player to define this in greater detail based on the main character's background and occupation. **Cash** Shows how much ready money the person has available in the form of cash or quickly liquidated securities. All personal belongings in chapter 3 are acquired with cash. **Credit rating** Shows how much the person can borrow without risking losing a living standard. The loans come from family, relatives, friends, banks, credit institutions, pawnbrokers, usurers and/or criminal loan sharks. A person who has borrowed has debts. **Advancement** The advancement value indicates how much cash must be invested to move up to the level from the underlying level. It takes the value in the new living standard in number of weeks to reach a new standard level. Upon advancement, the person discards their old assets and their old residence and records the new residence, the new assets that come with it and the new credit rat-ing in the character sheet instead. However, the person does not receive the cash specified in the new living standard but retains the cash he/she had previously, after the cash invested in the standard is deducted. Debts, if any exist, are also retained. A person may only move their living standard one level at a time and may not skip any level. Loans & debts A person can go into debt by borrowing money. When a person borrows cash, his/her amount of avail-able cash increases by as much as his/her debt. A person may never go into debt beyond their credit rating — however, interest can drive the debt beyond the credit rating limit. Interest & repayment The interest on the debt amount is typically 20% per month (game time), which is added to the debt. Inter-est can bring the debt amount above the person's credit rating limit, which is very risky — see Down-grade. "If you want to be certain of keeping your position of power, then make sure your citizens and servants are dependent on you every second of their lives." — Prince Malkom Harakat to Vincent Cateur

A person can at any time convert cash to reduce their debt but must then pay a surcharge of 10% on the transferred amount. Interest rates other than those stated may apply but this is in that case something that must be determined during the game. Example: Talia incurs a debt of 20,000 zovrins. After one month it has increased to 24,000 zovrins (20,000 x 1.2) and another month later it is up to 28,800 zovrins (24,000 x 1.2).

Talia now wants to reduce the debt by 10,000 zovrins which costs her 11,000 zovrins (10,000 x 1.1) in cash. The remaining debt amount totals 18,800 zovrins and increases the following month to 22,560 zovrins (18,800 x 1.2). Now Talia wants to pay back her entire debt which costs her a total of 24,816 zovrins (22,560 x 1.1). **Downgrade** If a person's debt exceeds his/her cre-dit rating limit, the person must, very quickly, usually within a couple of days, reduce their debt to the right side of the limit. Otherwise the person's assets are liquidated. **Liquidation** If a person is forced, or chooses to, liquidate their as-sets, his/her living standard is lowered one level. The resi-dence and all assets from the abandoned standard level are struck and considered sold, and the person receives ten times (10x) the cash sum specified at the abandoned living standard in proceeds. The new living standard's assets, residence and cre-dit rating should immediately be recorded in the character sheet. The as-sets are considered to have been acquired in the liquidation process. If the liquidation occurred due to the person's debt exceeding the credit rating limit, the per-son must convert enough cash to reduce the debt so it falls below the new limit for credit rating. Additionally, the person should review their finan-cial situation and sort out their personal finances. Example: Mordekai Remus has a debt of 120,000 zovrins after having gambled quite a bit in the city's seedier gambling dens and the interest has just hit. The debt is over his cre-dit rating and he only has 20 zovrins in cash which makes him realize that he must liquidate his assets to escape the devil's grip of debt. Mordekai lowers his living standard from 5 to 4. He receives cash equivalent to ten times the cash value at living standard 5, the level he is leaving. This gives him 100,000 zovrins (10,000 x 10). The credit rating at liv-ing standard 4 is 50,000 so his debt already lies 70,000 above the limit. With his new cash, Mordekai wants to reduce the debt by 90,000 zovrins. This costs him 99,000 zov-rins (90,000 x 1.1). After the transaction he has 1,020 zovrins in cash and a debt of 30,000 zovrins. Additionally he has a worse car, worse residence and worse assets than before the liquidation. If he wants to again reach living standard 5 he must gather 200,000 zovrins in cash and invest them in an advancement. In the game The rules for living standard, advancement, downgrade, loans and debt are kept deliberately abstract as it is not intended that Noir's rules in detail should simulate personal finance and play accountant. However, the rules presented here can certainly be expanded to become interesting scenes in a story — difficult conversations with shady loan sharks or stern bank clerks who lack understanding when the family home must be foreclosed. In all major events concerning a main character's financial situation there is naturally loads of bureaucracy — in the form of licenses, contracts, broker fees, lawyers, tax returns, etc. This is however filtered out in the simple game mechanic that handles financial events.

Chapter 6 – Combat

The rapid footsteps echoed among the dark alleys. "Halt, stop, I'll shoot!" Criminal Inspector Anya Malov pursued single-mindedly after the two men from Rulov's orga-nization. This time they wouldn't get away. She had witnessed the deed with her own eyes. Her partner was shot down when the men tried to escape. She had wounded one of them and in grim triumph she saw the blood trail between the puddles in the alley. She saw how her target turned off between two tall tenements. Otherwise the alleys lay deserted. The moonlight gave the area an almost black and white appearance. She quickly turned into the alley and ducked behind a dumpster when an echoing shot struck the metal. She drew a deep breath and smoothly rose with an automatic pistol in each hand. The larger of them was her partner's, he had asked her to take it. She hoped he would make it, she had left him in the apartment with a gunshot wound to the stomach. She had to catch the criminals. She had sworn that it would happen. Now. Tonight. "Stop, it's the police, put down your weap..." She was interrupted by a long burst from an automatic weapon and dove behind the container again. The bullets echoed and bounced against the groaning metal. She heard mutedly how someone shouted a command further ahead. She didn't hesitate when she rolled forward and up on her knees, in the middle of the alley. She saw two men, the wounded one was laboriously trying to get over a fence while the other, a young slim youth, had a submachine gun in his hand. He saw her and raised the weapon but she was faster — both pistols

echoed surely a dozen times and the man tumbled lifeless into the fence. The other man looked at her in horror and slowly swung around with a revolver in his hand. Anya rose with the weapons aimed at him. "Don't even try, Kristo, you don't have a chance, you're coming with me to the Cogwheel and then to the Fort." Kristo gave her a hazy, contemptuous look. He was bleeding heavily from a wound in his side, the coat was dripping black in the dim light. He seemed to assess his chances. The revolver was still in his hand. "I've got you in my sights, don't be as stupid as your buddy, drop the weapon and come down." Anya had her sights on his chest with one pistol while she holstered the other, took out hand-cuffs and tossed them on the ground beneath him. Kristo sighed deeply and dropped the revolver which landed heavily in a puddle. "Put them on, and do it now, you scum!" The man jumped down with a groan and obeyed the command, and the two figures made their way back out toward the main street where ambulance and reinforcements had arrived.

Bullets & hand-to-hand T he world is hard and cold. Both external and internal darkness are confronted daily. It is an environment where violence lies close at hand and another corpse in an alley just becomes forgotten statistics. Firefights, brawls, assault and rape are part of everyday life when the darkness of night conceals the desperate perpetrators. These criminals are on a blind hunt to find an outlet for their pent-up aggressions and their spiritual anguish. Outlets that often bring innocent people suffering, pain and death. A person who lacks the ability to effectively defend themselves should consider staying indoors after nightfall. **To fight** Since Noir is an action-oriented game, the rules that deal with combat between persons follow the same idea. The rules are made to be fast and support dramatic confrontations between the main charac-ters and their enemies. The goal is to give very great room for players and narrator to describe what the fights look like and paint the scenes based on what they want to experience together. Therefore the rules are made to be general and open. The most important thing is that fights feel like excit-ing and dramatic elements in the storytelling and that they move the story forward. One soon sees that the rules for combat follow certain simple and recurring moments precisely so they will be easy to learn and see the consequence of. The amount of rules for combat is greater than for other moments in Noir. This is because combat is more defini-tive than many other situations and can bring a person to death — which is often a very strong experience narratively and emotionally. Even though the scope of combat rules can be seen as large, the actual rule core is very compact and smooth. This is so it will be simple to learn. Shootouts & throwing knives Firefights are common as firearms are easy to come by in Sandukar's alleys. The objec-tive is to make firefights feel tempo-filled and adrenaline-soaked experiences where much lead flies through the air, where devastation is great, where gunsmoke hangs heavy and where persons perform daring maneuvers of spectacular proportions. Details like how the automatic fire's shell casings feed through the air like a string of pearls in the moonlight, how a blood-red

muzzle flash brutally chases away the shadows in the dark-ened corridor, or how the casing from the fatal shot metallically clinks against the polished marble floor, can all become memorable moments that those involved remember. Details like sounds and scents can make situations even more vivid — such as muffled bangs or gunpowder smell.

Don't be afraid to bring to life scenes where people shoot at each other — describing misses can be at least as dramatic as describing hits. How the bullets slam into the damp bricks next to a person so that stone dust swirls, how the café's window shatters in a cascade of glass shards that whirl through the air, or how the shotgun blasts tear up large holes in the plaster walls while the target desperately throws themselves aside — such experiences and actions make combat become something more than just dice rolls and recording ammunition expenditure.

How a person moves during combat is also part of the event. Feel free to let the players describe how their main characters crawl around behind the worn leather sofa, how they hurl themselves through the terrace

door to execute a som-ersault and land on their feet, or perhaps how they leap up on the bar counter and slide forward while their two heavy submachine guns pump lead toward the enemy.

The protagonists have special talents they can use, even as they struggle against their inner darkness. They are the heroes, or at least the antiheroes, in the story they are an important part of.

Brawls & knife fights When the ammunition runs out, fists take over. Close combat of various kinds is a common feature in the city's dark embrace. Gen-erally there are two types of close combat — with or without weapons. Fistfights are common even though it's rarely just fists being used. Most things can be used as weapons, so even if you don't carry a knife or a club with you, a garbage can lid, a drainpipe, a frying pan or why not a telephone can be used to put opponents out of fighting condition.

The rules describing close combat are very open to allow room for improvisation and portrayal. If a wild melee takes place in a dingy hotel room, each attack can be executed in numerous ways — a directed jaw punch might be followed up by the protagonist grabbing a chair that the play-er says is in the room and smashing it against the enemy so that splinters fly around. After this the protagonist can grab the enemy and drive them through a vanity mirror. Then the enemy is thrown over the bed and into the plaster wall on the other side so that dust swirls, followed by them being shoved into the bathroom where their head is slammed repeatedly against the filthy toilet bowl. Mechanically, this is just repeated Brawl actions, but the descriptions and improvisations make it much more interesting and exciting than just saying "I attack". Therefore encourage the players to describe what and how their protag-onists do while they fight in close combat.

One thing to remember is that close combat according to the rules doesn't bind people to each other, and even those who have fought in close combat can do other things in their turn order, such as shooting with weapons. Since it's in their turn order, they have initiative at that moment and thus get to try to do what they wish.

Brawl is a versatile action as it can be used for many things related to close combat. It's princi-pally only the player's or narrator's imagination that sets the limit. The Brawl action encompasses everything from holds, strangleholds, throwing sand in someone's eyes, tackles, pushing aside people trying to block a doorway, tripping, sticking the stiletto into someone's side, smash-ing an enemy's skull with a flower vase, etc. Creative action should be rewarded and encouraged.

Success in combat

In most cases when one person wants to attack another person, both parties involved will make opposed rolls to determine what happens. The general principle is that who-ever succeeds in rolling highest with their roll wins and succeeds in carry-ing out their chosen action, while the opponent fails.

The terms ranged combat and close combat are sometimes mentioned. Ranged combat means combat executed with the abilities Firearms and Thrown Weapons, while close combat is executed with the ability Close Combat.

The term Defense Roll refers to an opposed roll where the attri-bute value from Defense (Ranged) or Defense (Close Combat) is used.

Combat structure

To bring some order to the chaos that combat is, two terms are used: round and combat action. A round is a time period during which everyone involved in a combat gets the opportunity to act. A round is

approximately six seconds long, but the exact time isn't particularly important. What's important is that everyone has time to try to do what they wish.

Combat actions are what a combatant can perform. There are two types of combat actions: initiative actions and defense actions. When it's your turn to act, you perform an initiative action. If a person subjects you to an initiative action intended to harm you, you get to perform a defense action in response to this. The de-fense action's purpose is to try to make the initiative action fail.

Flow and precise fairness

The rules presented here are intended to be fast and action-packed and shouldn't require floor plans and miniatures. **Therefore, as narrator, don't be** strict about all distances and movements — if it seems like half a meter is missing when a person wants to attack, let the person reach anyway. It's much better to maintain flow and pace than to start bickering about whether you were actually standing one or two meters from the desired position.

Dramatic combat

A player who creatively and dramatically aids the narrative through vivid descriptions can be given increased damage output, if the narrator so wishes. This is something the narrator should be restrictive with since otherwise players will expect it after routine activities.

General bonuses and penalties in combat

Special circumstances provide penalties or bonuses in different combat situations. It's up to the narrator to determine the conditions for this through the standard system for bonuses & penalties on page 202. Shooting when it's dim or foggy might be quite difficult while a heavy downpour in pitch darkness might actually make it very difficult.

Initiative

Initiative is the term that shows a person's ability to act in a controlled, conscious and decisive manner during combat. Initiative determines each involved person's turn order.

People in combat act in descending turn order — the one with the highest Initiative begins by choosing and performing their initiative action. When the initiative action is completed, the next person in turn order performs their initiative action, and so on until everyone involved has acted. Then the round ends and the next round begins, whereupon the one with the highest Initiative acts first again, etc.

When a person performs combat actions, their Ini-tiative can decrease. This symbolizes that the person's decisiveness, situational control and combat awareness are reduc-ed, while stress, confusion, nervousness and exhaustion take over. Especially being forced to perform defense actions reduces one's own ability to control the combat. Injuries can also lower a person's Initiative.

Initial Initiative

At the start of combat, each combatant's Initiative is determined. This is done by all participants automatically making a difficulty roll (Awareness) simultaneously, and reading the result below.

Exceptional success: The person's Initiative is set to double the sum of the total dice result.

Success: The person's Initiative is set to the sum of the total dice result.

Failure: The person's Initiative is set to the highest die's result.

Exceptional failure: The person's Initiative is set to one (1).

The person retains this Initiative for the time being during combat but it can change due to special situa-tions, such as action outcomes, or injuries. A person's Initiative can never drop below 1. Initiative can be as high as anything. Either each person keeps track of their own Initiative or you can advantageously download an Initiative board from Noir's website.

If several participants end up at the same value in Initiative, the one with the highest attribute value in Awareness acts, followed by Alertness, Reactions and finally Luck.

Surprise

If a person is judged to be surprised when combat starts, for example during an ambush, they receive a penalty (–10) on the difficulty roll (Awareness).

Low Initiative

If a person's Initiative is five or lower when the person is to perform a combat action, the person receives a penalty (–2) on it. At Initiative one, the person suffers a penalty (–5) on all combat actions, see table 1:57 for a summary. This symbolizes among other things that the person doesn't feel they have control or overview of the chaos, and becomes extremely stressed and/or confused by this.

If Initiative is... the person receives... 6 or higher No penalty 2 to 5 –2 1 –5 Table 1:57

The Initiative board

The Initiative board is an administrative tool for keeping track of all participants' Initiative. Get as many markers as parties and place the markers at each party's Initiative. When a party's Initiative changes, the marker is moved to the new Initiative.

The narrator can advantageously use the same Initiative board as the players, and can let one of the players be responsible for it as relief since the narrator has many other tasks during combat.

The Initiative board is available for download on Noir's website: www.noir.nu.

When are you surprised? It's up to the narrator to determine whether a person is surprised by an event or not. There are expertises that make it easier for people to detect potential ambushes and other situations that might seem surprising.

Combat Actions

Combat actions are what a person can perform during combat. There are two types of combat actions: initiative actions and defensive actions.

What actions mean & what they include As players and narrator, you're meant to portray combat actions and bring them to life. Combat actions are described in the rules in fairly general terms. The intent is that the participant controlling the person who successfully performs a combat action describes what happens within the framework of the scene, story, and action.

Since combat actions often affect people other than oneself, it's also fair game to, within reasonable limits, affect other people during your own action. If a player's character shoots a narrator character, the narrator shouldn't prevent the player's description of what happens to the narrator character, even if it means they're moved or knocked down.

The fact that you can "take over" other people this way without problems works because they always come back on their Initiative in the turn order. The impact is purely dramatic and doesn't affect the mechanical scope for action in combat.

A combat action shouldn't be seen as a single individual maneuver but rather as an attitude toward what you want to accomplish and how. Many performed actions using firearms involve multiple rounds fired—this doesn't mean you go through how each individual bullet hits or misses but means the person has chosen to solve the task in a certain way, for example through lots of lead in the air.

Movement during combat

Most actions automatically include movement up to the person's Combat Movement, measured in meters, even if this isn't written out. This movement doesn't allow any advanced movement maneuvers. For those, use the initiative action Move.

A person may move around within their immediate area during their action to create atmosphere—for example, perhaps a person choosing to Fight runs around and around a conference table while chasing their target who's trying to escape (Defend). The total running distance becomes quite long, but the person doesn't move particularly far from their own starting point.

Procedure

Each time a combat action is performed, it follows a certain procedure, described here step by step.

1. The person with Initiative chooses an Initiative action.
2. If it's a difficulty roll to be made, do so. If it's an opposed roll to be made, the initiator determines who the target is. The target then chooses a defensive action in response. Both parties make rolls to determine who wins the opposed roll.
3. Initiative is modified based on the combat action's outcome and all other mechanics are noted immediately (such as ammunition expenditure or damage effects).
4. The person who succeeded with the combat action describes in a few sentences for the other participants what happens in the scene, within what's reasonable for the combat action.

Initiative Actions

Initiative actions are the combat actions a person whose turn it is can choose to perform. A person may only perform one initiative action per round. The available initiative actions are summarized in table 1:58.

Initiative Action | Summary | Initiative Change Aimed fire | Firearms (S). Ammo: Lowest | +5 | - | - | −10 Snap shots | Firearms (S). Ammo: Highest | +5 | - | - | −10 | Penalty: Recoil | Damage Effect: +1D per 2D Targeted fire | Firearms (S). Ammo 1 | +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 | Bonus: Precision | Minimum Initiative: 10 Marksmanship | Firearms (S). Ammo 1 | +5 | −10 | −10 | −20 | Bonus: Precision x 2 | Minimum Initiative: 10 Fire with two weapons | Firearms (S). Ammo: All | +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 | Penalty: Recoil + Recoil | Damage Effect: Damage Value + Damage Value Concentrated automatic fire | Firearms (A). Ammo: All | +5 | - | - | −10 | Penalty: Recoil | Damage Effect: +1D per 2D Spray with automatic fire | Firearms (A). Ammo: All x 2 | +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 |

Penalty: Recoil | All targets within 90 degrees make defense rolls Automatic fire with | Firearms (A). Ammo: All x 2 | +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 two weapons | Penalty: Recoil + Recoil | Damage Effect: +1D per 2D (total) Fire blind | Firearms. Ammo: All x 2 | +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 | Penalty: −10. Bonus: Luck | (Defender: Bonus: Luck) Throw object at target | Throwing | +5 | - | - | −10 Throw object to location | Throwing. Minimum Initiative 10 | +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 Fight | Melee. Damage, Hold, | +5 | - | - | −10 | Disarm (Penalty: −10), | Break hold, Shove away Berserk attack | Melee. Bonus: +5 | +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 | Damage. Damage Effect +1 | Minimum Initiative: 10 Move | Combat Movement | +5 | - | - | −10 | Move Combat Movement x 2 meters | Bonus/Penalty: +10 to −10 | depending on complexity. | Each repeated attempt grants Bonus: +10 Draw weapon | Throwing or Firearms | +5 | - | - | −10 | If two weapons drawn simultaneously: | Penalty: −2. Each successive | repeated attempt grants Bonus: +10 Reload | Firearms. Each successive | +5 | - | - | −10 | repeated attempt grants Bonus: +10 | Box magazine: Full reload | Belt-fed: Complex action | Other types: Minimum number of rounds Survey the situation | Overview. Maximum Initiative: 20 | +All x 2 | +All | +Highest | +1 Wait | No initiative action performed | - | - | - | - Other action | See page 259 | =1 | =1 | =1 | =1 Await target | See page 259 | +5 | - | - | −10

Table 1:58

The Combat Action

All combat actions follow a given template:

(Its name) ((type of roll)) **Brief description of the combat action.**

Requirement: The requirements or conditions that must be met to perform the combat action.

Rule: The rules encompassed by the combat action and how they should be handled.

Initiative: How the combat action's outcome affects the person's Initiative, in order from left to right, for: Exceptionally successful, Successful, Failed, Exceptionally failed.

For example, the code: +5 | - | - | −10

...means that the person's Initiative increases by five (+5) if they succeed exceptionally with the combat action, remains unchanged if the person succeeds or fails, and that Initiative decreases by ten (−10) on an exceptional failure.

General about movement

During combat, where there are people who want to harm you, you never stand still like a statue, unless there are special reasons. The people involved in combat all have some form of self-preservation instinct that makes them try to stay out of harm's way by instinctively protecting themselves, staying low, trying to use available cover, etcetera. But this is something the rules automatically assume.

The defensive action Defend includes many variants of ways to avoid harm, see page 260.

Aimed Fire

The person wants to fire roughly aimed limited fire with a firearm at a selected target.

Requirement: The person has a loaded and ready-to-fire firearm that can fire single shots.

Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made. The target makes a defense roll. Strike as many rounds from the weapon's magazine as the value on the lowest die. If the value is higher than the number of remaining rounds, the magazine is empty. If the shooter wins, the target has been hit. Roll the weapon's damage effect.

Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10

Snap Shots

The person wants to fire repeated single shots in rapid succession with a firearm at a selected target.

Requirement: The person has a loaded and ready-to-fire firearm that can fire single shots. The weapon has at least two rounds in the magazine.

Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made. The shooter receives a penalty equal to the weapon's Recoil. The target makes a defense roll. Strike as many rounds from the weapon's magazine as the value on the highest die in the opposed roll. If the sum is higher than the number of remaining rounds, the magazine is empty. If the shooter wins, the target has been hit. The weapon's damage effect increases by 1D per 2D in the weapon's damage value (minimum +1D).

Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10

Targeted Fire

The person wants to take time and fire a carefully aimed shot with a firearm at a selected target.

Requirement: The person has a loaded and ready-to-fire firearm that can fire single shots. The person has Initiative 10 or higher.

Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made and the shooter receives a bonus equal to the weapon's Precision. The target makes a defense roll. Strike one round from the weapon's magazine. If the shooter wins, the bullet has hit and then roll the weapon's damage effect.

Initiative: +5 | −5 | −5 | −10

Marksmanship

The person wants to fire a very well-aimed shot with a firearm equipped with a scope at a selected target.

Requirement: The person has a loaded and ready-to-fire firearm that can fire single shots. The weapon has a scope that the person is using. The person has Initiative 10 or higher. The target is at least 20 meters away.

Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made and the shooter receives a bonus equal to the weapon's double Precision. The target makes a defense roll. Strike one round from the weapon's magazine. If the shooter wins, the bullet has hit and then roll the weapon's damage effect.

Initiative: +5 | −10 | −10 | −20

Fire with Two Weapons

The person wants to fire multiple shots in rapid succession with two firearms simultaneously at a selected target.

Requirement: The person has two loaded and ready-to-fire firearms that can fire single shots. The weapons have at least two rounds each in the magazines.

Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made. The shooter receives a penalty equal to both weapons' total Recoil. The target makes a defense roll. Strike as many rounds from both weapons' magazines as the sum of the value on all dice (this includes any maxed dice as well) in the opposed roll. If the sum is higher than the number of remaining rounds, the magazine is empty. If the shooter wins, the target has been hit. The two weapons' damage values are added together to determine damage effect.

Initiative: +5 | −5 | −5 | −10

Concentrated Automatic Fire

The person wants to fire a burst of automatic fire with a firearm at a selected target.

Requirement: The person has a loaded and ready-to-fire firearm that can fire automatic fire. The weapon has at least two rounds in the magazine.

Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made. The shooter receives a penalty equal to the weapon's Recoil. The target makes a defense roll. Strike as many rounds from the weapon's magazine as the sum of the value on all dice (this includes any maxed dice as well) in the opposed roll. If the sum is higher than the number of remaining rounds, the magazine is empty. If the shooter wins, the target has been hit. The weapon's damage effect increases by 1D per 2D in the weapon's damage value (minimum +1D).

Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10

Spray with Automatic Fire

The person wants to fire a long burst of automatic fire with a firearm over an area, hoping to hit multiple targets.

Requirement: The person has a loaded and ready-to-fire firearm that can fire automatic fire. The weapon has at least four rounds in the magazine.

Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made. The shooter receives a penalty equal to the weapon's Recoil. Strike as many rounds from the weapon's magazine as the sum of the value on all dice times two (x 2) in the opposed roll (this includes any maxed dice as well). If the sum is higher than the number of remaining rounds, the magazine is empty. All people, friends and foes, judged to be within a cone of approximately 90 degrees in front of the target each make a defense roll. Those the shooter wins against are hit. The roll counts as successful if at least one person is hit. The weapon's damage effect is rolled separately per target hit.

Initiative: +5 | −5 | −5 | −10

Automatic Fire with Two Weapons

The person wants to fire automatic fire with two firearms simultaneously at a selected target.

Requirement: The person has two loaded and ready-to-fire firearms that can fire automatic fire. The weapons have at least four rounds each in the magazines.

Ammunition Expenditure

Note that regardless of a combat action's outcome regarding firearms, the indicated amount of rounds is always consumed from the weapon's magazine.

It may seem like a lot of rounds are consumed during a firefight. That's correctly perceived, and entirely intentional. Most actions with firearms involve a greater or lesser amount of discharges. They're not intended to symbolize a systematic firing ("bang-bang-bang-bang-bang") but rather a stressed firing ("bangbangbang-bang-bangbang-bang-bang") because the actions themselves are so open to interpretation. For example, perhaps the combat action Snap Shots consumes nine shots in one action—this just means the situation for the shooter that round has involved multiple opportunities to fire. Most of the shots have probably missed the target. An automatic burst of perhaps 15 rounds can mean a longer burst in sequence or several shorter bursts—the shooter, scene, and situation determine this.

This is where the beauty of the open actions comes in—they're created to generate drama and action in a way that suits the story and scene. Both players and narrator are encouraged to take the opportunity to paint intense combat situations.

"Nothing says goodbye better than a bullet." — Mordekai Remus

Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made. The shooter takes a penalty equal to both weapons' total Recoil. The target makes a defense roll. Cross off as many rounds from both weapons' magazines as the sum of all dice values times two (x 2) in the opposed roll (this includes any maxed dice as well). If the sum is higher than the number of remaining rounds in either magazine, that magazine is empty. If the shooter wins, the target has been hit. The weapon's damage increases by 1D per 2D in the weapons' total damage value (the weapons' damage values are thus added together and not counted separately). Initiative: +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 **Blind Fire** The person wants to shoot and attempt to hit a concealed target, for example someone behind a table, a bar, a wall, in complete darkness, or if the shooter is blinded, through a combination of many bullets, skill, intuition, and a large helping of luck. Requirement: The person has a loaded and ready-to-fire firearm. The weapon has at least four rounds in the magazine. The target area is somewhat limited. Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made. The shooter takes a penalty (−10), but may add their attribute value in Luck as a bonus. The target makes a defense roll and adds their attribute value in Luck as an additional bonus. Cross off as many rounds from the magazine as the value of all dice times two (x 2) in the opposed roll (this includes any maxed dice as well). If the sum is higher than the number of remaining rounds, the magazine is empty. If the shooter wins, the target has been hit. Roll damage. Initiative: +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 **Throw Object at Target** The person wants to throw an object to hit a chosen target. Requirement: The person has a throwing weapon or a throwable object ready. Rule: An opposed roll (Throwing Weapons) is made. The target makes a defense roll. If the thrower wins, the target has been hit. Roll damage. Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10 **Throw Object to Location** The person wants to throw an object in a chosen direction or to a location, for example through a window or to a spot on the ground. Grenades and similar are always thrown with this initiative action. Requirement: The person has a throwable object ready and sees the position (it's possible to throw blind, for example over a wall, but then it's harder to hit the right spot). The person has Initiative 10 or higher. Rule: A difficulty roll (Throwing Weapons) is made, modified depending on circumstances. If the thrower succeeds, the location has been hit. If the throw fails, the object lands somewhere it does no good, or the thrower simply fails to throw the object. If the thrower doesn't see the impact location (if this matters, the narrator decides), they receive a penalty (−5). Initiative: +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 **Fight** The person wants to attack a target in close combat, either unarmed or with the help of a weapon or makeshift weapon of some kind. Requirement: The person can perform the action. Rule: The attacker must choose whether they want to damage the target (the default option), hold the target, disarm the target, break a hold, or push/tackle away the target. To hold the target,

the attacker must have at least one hand free. Attempting to disarm the target results in the attacker receiving a penalty (−10) on their opposed roll. Once the choice is made, an opposed roll (Close Combat) is made. The target makes a defense roll. If the attacker wins, they have succeeded in carrying out the chosen attack. If the intent was to damage the target, roll damage. Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10

Disarming

One variant is to attempt to disarm an opponent, that is, attempt to strike or wrench away, or twist loose, an object that the target has in their hands. If the attacker wants to attempt to disarm, they receive a penalty (−10) on their opposed roll. The effect of a successful disarming is that the object is counted as unavailable to the opponent during the current and following round. This should be portrayed in the narrative in a creative way, for example by the attacker kicking away the revolver and the opponent not seeing where it lies, or not being able to reach it because the attacker is blocking it. The attacker may, however, pick up the object if desired and if the narrative supports it. Should the disarming occur in such a place that the object disappears from the immediate vicinity, for example during a wild brawl on a narrow bridge or on a rushing train roof, the narrator may judge that the object cannot be picked up until a proper search is conducted. **Berserk Attack** The person truly wants with heart and soul to attack a target in close combat, either unarmed or with the help of a weapon or makeshift weapon of some kind, without thought to what consequences it might have later in the fight. Requirement: The person can perform the action. The person has Initiative 10 or higher. Rule: An opposed roll (Close Combat) is made with a bonus of five (+5). The target makes a defense roll. If the attacker wins, they have succeeded in carrying out the attack. The attacker then damages the target and adds one (+1) to the damage. Initiative: +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 On being grasped or held One of the selectable outcomes in a successful Fight action is to hold the target. It is up to the narrator to judge the reasonableness and consequence of various grappling activities. Certain defined grips may also give bonuses or penalties to other activities — a narrator might judge that a person with a low value in Size has more difficulty maintaining a grip on a target with a high value in Size. But these are situations the narrator must decide on a case-by-case basis. A person who is held cannot perform certain actions, such as Move. Which actions are impossible depends on how the grappler defined what they did when the Fight action was carried out. If the attacker said the purpose was to hold the arm and hand in which the defender had a revolver, then the defender cannot perform actions involving the revolver. The narrator must be flexible and try to interpret the grip's nature and intent so that it becomes reasonable in the scene. Other types of holds are partly the so-called police grip, with one arm behind the back pulled up toward the shoulder blade, and partly restraint by firmly holding or lying over the held person so they cannot move. Breaking free from a grip is a Fight action, where both the initiative holder and the opponent may choose between using Close Combat or Strength in the opposed roll. A successful roll for the held person means the grip is broken, otherwise they are still held.

Move

The person wants to move in some way that requires a greater effort. The action can be used to flee from someone or to get to cover or to an object a good distance away. It is the narrator who determines whether the person must use this action or if the purpose can be achieved as a sub-element in another action. Requirement: The person can move. A person can at most move the equivalent of their double Combat Movement meters per round. Rule: A difficulty roll (Combat Movement) is made. For more difficult or easier maneuvers, the narrator may give bonuses or penalties on the roll, see table 1:59. If the difficulty roll fails, the person does not succeed in achieving the goal of the action — perhaps because the person is frozen in fear, the situation feels too risky, the person is too injured to succeed with the maneuver, or it may simply be too difficult to perform the maneuver. Regardless of reason, the person is in the same place and in the same

situation as before the roll was made, or something else has occurred during the action, the narrator decides. A person who fails the action and who chooses Move again as their next initiative action without choosing another initiative action in between receives a bonus (+10) on the subsequent attempt. This applies incrementally, given the above conditions. Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10 Bonus/penalty Type of movement +10 The person wants to run straight ahead through an alley toward an enemy, flee away, or similar. +5 The person wants to run at full speed in furnished rooms or among cars on a busy road, etcetera. +2 The person wants to jump up to a fire escape, grab hold of a hatch in the ceiling and haul themselves up, run in cramped spaces with much debris, cross a heavily trafficked highway, etcetera. −2 The person wants to quickly move by swinging down through a hatch, jump out from the second floor and maintain speed, quickly get out of a trench, etcetera. −5 The person wants to jump between balconies or rooftops, jump from the third floor without being hindered, maneuver in rooms with extremely limited visibility or where stressful circumstances such as heavy fire, grenade detonations, etcetera prevail. −10 The person wants to throw themselves from the fifth floor, roll around and get on their feet with control of the situation, chase a car on foot, run through completely dark or smoke-filled spaces, etcetera. Table 1:59 **Draw Weapon** The person wants to draw a weapon from their person, from a holster, a sheath, a pocket, or similar. Requirement: The weapon is available and can be drawn. Rule: A difficulty roll (Firearms, Close Combat Weapons, or Throwing Weapons depending on which weapon is drawn) is made. Depending on how the weapon is carried, the person receives penalties or bonuses, see table on page 119. If the difficulty roll fails, the person does not succeed in drawing the weapon for some reason. If the person wants to draw two one-handed weapons simultaneously, a penalty (−2) is given. A person who holds a weapon with their hand while it is holstered, for example in a pocket or as standard procedure when a police officer is in a potentially dangerous situation, is given a bonus (+5). A person who fails the action and who chooses Draw Weapon again as their next initiative action without choosing another initiative action in between receives a bonus (+10) on the subsequent attempt. This applies incrementally, given the above conditions. Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10 **Reload** The person reloads a firearm. Requirement: The person has a loadable firearm and extra ammunition available. Rule: A difficulty roll (Firearms) is made. If the narrator judges that the ammunition is difficult to access, this may give a penalty on the roll; if it's very easily accessible, it may give a bonus. If the difficulty roll fails, the person does not succeed in reloading the weapon. A person who fails the action and who chooses Reload again without choosing another initiative action in between receives a bonus (+10) on the subsequent attempt. This applies incrementally, given the above conditions. How many rounds are loaded per successful action depends on the weapon type. • Weapons with box magazines are reloaded fully. • Weapons with revolver cylinders, with internal magazines, or where the rounds are loaded directly into the chamber are reloaded with as many rounds as the lowest die's value, up to the weapon's maximum magazine capacity. • Reloading a belt-fed weapon is an uncomplicated complex action (Challenge Level 50). One attempt may be made per round and person. Most reloadable heavy weapons also function according to this rule. Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10 Why rolls are made for movement, reloading, and weapon drawing Difficulty rolls are made for movement, reloading, and weapon drawing to increase the drama in the scene and create uncertainty in the chaos combat is meant to be. For most uninjured participants, these rolls don't matter much, and should they fail, they will most likely succeed in the next Initiative action, thanks to the high bonus that is granted. However, injured persons will have greater problems with action due to the penalties wounds give. This is in line with the philosophy — injuries and suffering hurt and make one's combat capacity severely suffer. Attacking someone at a distance in close combat If the situation is such that an intended target is a good distance away from the attacker who wants to attack in close combat, then the attacker must advance toward the target before the attack occurs. The target must be within the attacker's Combat Movement, otherwise the Fight or Berserk Attack action may not be used, but then Move should instead be used to symbolize that the attacker doesn't have time to reach

before the target has time to get into action. "What are you after Anya? My life story? Okay, here it comes. Four words: grand ideas, small results." — Gabriel Jandaran

Draw improvised weapons

The initiative action Draw weapon is only used for drawing weapons carried on your person. No Draw weapon action is required to use improvised weapons in melee or to throw one—if the narrator judges that the chosen improvised weapon is available and can be used, you just use it. See page 105 for more information on improvised weapons.

The same applies to firearms in the vicinity that are not holstered but are, for example, lying on a nightstand or on a shelf. They are drawn automatically unless the narrator judges otherwise.

Survey the situation

The person attempts to regain Initiative and get control of, and an overview of, the situation so that he/she can act on his/her own terms.

Requirement: This is the only initiative action this round. Current Initiative is 20 or lower.

Rule: A difficulty roll (Overview) is made. The roll's outcome determines how much the person's Initiative increases (the result is added to the Initiative the person had before the action's outcome).

Initiative: Exceptionally successful: +(Sum from all dice x 2) Successful: +(Sum from all dice) Failed: +(Value of the highest die) Exceptionally failed: +1

Wait

The person chooses not to perform any initiative actions this round.

Requirement: The person is conscious.

Rule: The person chooses not to perform any initiative action during the round. No roll is made, and the person retains their Initiative.

Initiative: - | - | - | -

Other action

The person wants to perform some form of activity during combat that has nothing to do with combat or direct dice rolls, for example using an ability like Medicine.

Requirement: The person can perform the action. The narrator must judge on a case-by-case basis.

Rule: As soon as a person chooses this initiative action, the person's Initiative is immediately set to one (1) because the person is no longer trying to maintain overview or control in combat but wants to dedicate themselves to something else. The narrator must be prepared to judge each individual situation. If the ability is not directly combat-related, the roll is not affected by the general penalty for low Initiative (see page 254).

Initiative: =1 | =1 | =1 | =1

Wait for target

The person wants to wait for a specific target to appear at a specific location and react to this.

Requirement: The person has overview of the target area.

Rule: A person waiting for a target cannot perform any other combat actions (except Chance defense) without breaking the wait. A waiting person can, each time it's their turn order, choose to break Wait for target by performing another initiative action.

If a waiting person chooses to perform a defense action other than Chance defense, the wait is also immediately broken.

Each time the waiter chooses to wait, the person may slowly move up to half their Combat movement. One can, for example, cautiously advance toward a door where one suspects an enemy might be—which is, incidentally, a very common police tactic during operations.

It is only when a target appears that both the waiter and the target must make an opposed roll (Overview). See table 1:60 for bonuses and penalties for this opposed roll. It is also this roll that provides any Initiative impact (this impact applies first in the following round, as those involved in a wait act on the same turn order in the current round, see the paragraph below).

If the waiter wins, he/she gets to perform an initiative action just before the target performs their planned initiative action. If the target wins, he/she gets to perform their initiative action and the waiter gets to perform their initiative action just after (on the same turn order) the target performed theirs.

Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10

Bonus/penalty for the waiter Condition +5 Waiting for target that might appear within a small, defined area, for example in a doorway, in a window, behind a car, and so on. −5 Waiting for target that might appear somewhere within a larger, wider area, for example outdoors in uneven terrain, in a large warehouse, hidden somewhere in a furnished room, among cars in a parking garage, and so on. +2 Has higher Initiative than the target.

Bonus/penalty for the target being waited for Condition +5 The target knows he/she is being observed and knows fairly well (within an area equivalent to a window, a door, behind a car, and so on) where the waiter is located. −5 The target suspects he/she is being observed but doesn't know from where. −10 The target is surprised/doesn't know he/she is being observed. +2 Has higher Initiative than the waiter.

Table 1:60

Increased damage effect

Certain initiative actions cause an attack's damage effect to increase. Usually this happens according to "The weapon's damage effect increases by 1D per 2D in the weapon's damage value (minimum +1D)." Table 1:61 summarizes this.

Increased

Damage Value Damage Value 1D 2D 2D 3D 3D 4D 4D 6D 5D 7D 6D 9D etc. etc.

Table 1:61

Combat example

Examples of how combat actions are used begin on page 272.

Shoot back

The person wants to meet an attack by rather uncontrollably shooting return fire in desperate hope of hitting first.

Requirement: The person is being shot at or subjected to a thrown weapon attack, and is aware of the attack and sees the attacker. The person has a loaded and ready-to-fire firearm ready. The weapon has at least two rounds in the magazine. The person has Initiative 10 or higher.

Rule: An opposed roll (Firearms) is made, with a penalty equal to the weapon's triple (x 3) Recoil. Strike off as many rounds from the weapon's magazine as the value of all dice (this includes all any maxed dice) in the opposed roll. If the sum is higher than the number of remaining rounds, the magazine is empty. If the defender wins, the attack failed and the defender succeeded in hitting the attacker instead. Roll for the weapon's damage effect.

Initiative: +5 | −10 | −10 | −20

Strike back

The person wants to perform desperate counterattacks in hope of successfully outmaneuvering and damaging the opponent, despite their disadvantage in the situation.

Requirement: The person is attacked in melee (or shot at from close range) and is aware of the attack. The person has Initiative 10 or higher.

Rule: An opposed roll (Melee) is made, with a penalty (−10). If the defender wins, the attack failed and the defender succeeded in hitting the attacker instead. The defender then gets to choose whether he/she wants to damage, hold, or push away the attacker. To hold the attacker, the defender must have at least one hand free.

Initiative: +5 | −10 | −10 | −20

Being in cover

If a target is in cover, this grants him/her a bonus to Defend yourself and Chance defense when he/she is subjected to a ranged attack.

There are several levels of cover, and these symbolize both concealing cover or cover that creates difficult circumstances for being hit. Choose the level of cover that feels appropriate for a given situation.

Bonus Degree of cover

+1 Barely protected. The target stands behind a telephone pole, hides behind an armchair, sits in a bush, etcetera. The target is considered covered by the protection to approximately 25 percent. +2 Lightly protected. The target shoots around a corner, stands behind an overturned dining table, lies over a hood, peers out from behind a substantial tree, etcetera. The target is considered covered by the protection to approximately 50 percent. +5 Substantially protected. The target is visible but is in cover of sandbags, ducks behind a car, stands in cover of a door, kneels behind an overturned table, etcetera. The target is considered covered by the protection to approximately 75 percent. +10 Maximally protected. The target is barely visible

and lies cowering in a foxhole, ducks behind a stone wall, peeks out from behind a wall, etcetera. The target is considered covered by the protection to at least 90 percent.

Defense actions

Defense actions are what attacked persons get to perform as a reaction or response to the attack. The standard defense action is Defend yourself unless otherwise stated. What a successful or failed defense looks like in the narrative is determined by the protagonist's player and/or the narrator.

Most defense actions lower the person's Initiative. Note that if Initiative reaches low values, the person's actions suffer penalties, see page 254.

The available defense actions are summarized in table 1:62.

Defense action Initiative Comment

Defend yourself +5 | −5 | −5 | −10 Defense: Ranged or Defense: Melee. **Opposed roll** Chance defense +5 | | | −10 Luck. Opposed roll. Shoot back +5 | −10 | −10 | −20 Firearms. Ammo: A. Penalty: Recoil x 3. Minimum Initiative: 10. Strike back +5 | −10 | −10 | −20 Melee. Penalty: −10. Damage, Hold, Push away. Minimum Initiative: 10.

Table 1:62

Defend yourself

The person wants to defend themselves against attacks in various ways, with different methods and all available means depending on the attack's nature and the circumstances surrounding it. This includes everything from staying in cover, blocking, parrying and avoiding to rolling away, throwing themselves to the ground, moving behind cover, or ducking away from attacks.

Defend yourself is the standard defense action, used when nothing else is said when a person is attacked.

Requirement: The person is being attacked in some way and is aware of it.

Rule: An opposed roll (Defense: Ranged or Defense: Melee) is made, based on the attack's type. If the defender wins, the attack has been deflected and is then counted as a failure.

Initiative: +5 | −5 | −5 | −10

Chance defense

The person instinctively performs a passive defense, if he/she is, for example, unaware of or surprised by the attack, or chooses not to actively defend. The person walks straight toward the attacker, doesn't bother to block, or is nonchalant in general. This usually means the person is hit, unless providence favors him/her very well.

Requirement: The person is attacked and is surprised or overwhelmed by the attack, or the person voluntarily chooses not to actively defend themselves.

Rule: An opposed roll (Luck) is made. If the defender wins, the attack has been deflected and is then counted as a failure.

Initiative: +5 | - | - | −10

"Sleep is death's brother." — Talia Navarre

What Does "Defend" Actually Mean? Here are a number of interpretations of how it might look in the story when the defensive action Defend is used. • An assassin fires burst shots from a machine pistol at Anya as she leaves police headquarters. She chooses to Defend, and wins against the attacker with her resistance roll. **Anya's player describes how Anya instinctively** senses the shooter coming up the stairs. As shots thunder in rapid succession, Anya rolls behind one of the large stone gargoyles standing at the top of the stairs. The statue is damaged and stone fragments break loose in the hail of bullets while Anya seeks cover. • Gabriel creeps across a skyscraper rooftop with a pistol in hand. Through the rain he sees a figure approaching. It's Nevei, a Destroyer, who has been hunting Gabriel for several days. The confrontation is inevitable and Nevei attacks with a large ornate two-handed sword. Gabriel defends against the woman's thrust and manages to win the resistance roll. It's portrayed in the story as Nevei coming rushing forward screaming and Gabriel turning around in surprise. With rain lashing his face, Gabriel ducks just under the sword swing, rolls around, and comes up in a kneeling position with the pistol aimed at Nevei. Since Gabriel is next in turn order, it's dramatic that he gets the pistol up this way, and in his turn fires repeatedly at Nevei... • Anya wakes with a start to someone kicking down her hotel door. In the hazy morning sunlight she sees hired scum that someone in the Gault family has sent to ensure her secret dies with her. Unabashed, the naked woman gets out of bed and meets the thug in close combat. She fights but the thug manages to defend. This is depicted by the narrator and player as her savagely delivering a kick but the thug getting his hand up, stopping the foot and twisting so that Anya is flung over and lands on a coffee table that breaks apart. • Film star Sayah Bonn steps out of a taxi for the premiere of her new film. A crazed Creator in the crowd pulls out a shotgun. Sayah has time to perceive what's happening and defends. She manages to roll better than the shooter. In the story nothing more happens than Sayah having time to twist enough that the shotgun blast only tears apart her wide red ball gown and cape with a boom. • Mordekai is assaulted by a junkie who turns out to be one of the Afflicted. The junkie strikes with a cobra's speed and begins pummeling Mordekai, who defends and succeeds. The situation is portrayed in the story as Mordekai perceiving what's happening just in time, ducking under the punch, circling around, avoiding a kick by jumping over some old crates and parrying a flurry of strikes (remember that the initiative action fight doesn't show a single blow, but only that the person is fighting in close combat to defeat their opponent) before the event is over. • Three Rulov gangsters are enjoying their dinner at restaurant Dorsia. A vengeful Gabriel enters, sees them and draws his Kalgari submachine gun from his coat. He opens fire on all three, and only one manages to defend. In the story this is described as when Gabriel begins sweeping with his chattering SMG, the first gangster takes a bullet right in the back and falls onto the table, the second has time to stand but is hit in the chest and falls backward into a decorative aquarium that shatters so water gushes out onto the floor, and the third miraculously manages to throw himself backward over his chair, stumble behind the bar and disappear from sight. • Jessca encounters a patrolling guard when she breaks into a factory building where slaver Kastor maintains his trucks. Jessca stylishly throws a throwing knife at the guard but he rolls better on his resistance and manages to defend. In the story it's determined that the guard perceives what's happening and just barely gets a trash can lid up as a shield against the knife, which is deflected and lands some distance away.

None of the situations above are described in the rules, beyond what can be found under the defensive action Defend. It's the players and/or narrator who together determine how combat situations manifest in the world. The intention is to create dynamics and tension in the scene. That participants around the gaming table use their imagination collectively and partake in the rich gaming experience Noir is meant to be.

Gladly let tough, bold and spectacular events occur, let there be tension in the story and don't worry if someone else determines something that affects your protagonist or narrator character — after all, Initiative determines when a person gets to act and there are essentially no situations where this is prevented. Thus almost anything can happen in the world — even if it's breakneck or life-threatening things.

Physical Injuries & Death It's more or less inevitable that a person suffers violence in Sandukar's dark alleys and abandoned basement spaces. The injuries caused vary from minor scrapes, scratches and bruises, to serious physical injuries that in the worst case are fatal but give the soul a peace that cannot be found in the world of the living.

Physical Injuries

When a person is injured in Noir, they become either lightly or seriously injured.

Light injuries result in the victim receiving Disorientation but are not life-threatening and one recovers from them fairly quickly. However, Disorientation is debilitating and can cause the person to become temporarily knocked out or unconscious.

Serious injuries give the victim both Disorientation and Wounds. Wounds can kill the victim and it takes a long time to recover from them. Moreover, Wounds are severely debilitating.

Damage & Wound Threshold All dangerous situations that risk injuring a person cause damage, based on the situation's, or weapon's, damage value.

Damage is obtained by rolling the number of dice specified as the attack's damage value. The result of the roll is added to the victim's Disorientation, which shows the immediate disorientation, pain experience, stress and shock that the injury gives rise to.

If damage is also higher than the victim's attribute value in Wound Threshold, the victim receives a Wound — the damage was so serious that the victim risks dying from it.

If damage is higher than the victim's double attribute value in Wound Threshold, the victim instead receives as many Wounds as the number the lowest die in the damage roll shows. If damage is higher than the victim's quadruple attribute value in Wound Threshold, the victim instead receives as many Wounds as the value the highest die in the damage roll shows. Table 1:63 summarizes this.

If damage is higher than the person's... then the person receives... ...attribute value in Wound Threshold ...one Wound. ...double attribute value in Wound Threshold ...as many Wounds as the value on the lowest die. ...quadruple attribute value in Wound Threshold ...as many Wounds as the value on the highest die. Table 1:63

Note that the number of Wounds does not in any way show how many individual injuries a person has suffered. A single instance of damage can result in the victim receiving loads of Wounds. Rather, see the number of Wounds as an indicator of how seriously injured the victim is.

Subduing Damage

There are certain attacks or situations that inflict so-called subduing damage. The difference between subduing and regular, lethal, damage is that the former has a harder time inflicting Wounds on the victim — the victim temporarily doubles their value in Wound Threshold at the moment of injury.

What causes subduing damage is primarily brawls, blunt force, shockwaves, attacks with weapons lacking a cutting edge or penetrating point, as well as fall and collision damage.

Weapons or attacks that deal subduing damage are marked by a "B" in front of the damage value, for example "B1D+1".

Total Penalty

Injuries have negative effects on a person's ability to effectively perform actions in and out of combat.

Every ten steps of Disorientation gives a penalty (−1) on all actions. Each inflicted Wound immediately lowers the victim's Initiative by five (−5) and gives a penalty (−2) on all actions. The sum of these penalties is recorded on the character sheet in the section marked Total Penalty. How Disorientation and Wounds affect is summarized in table 1:64.

Physical Injury Effect

Disorientation Every ten steps of Disorientation gives a penalty (−1) on all activities. Wound Each inflicted Wound immediately lowers the victim's Initiative by five (−5) and gives a penalty (−2) on all activities. Table 1:64

Endurance & Disorientation A victim who receives increased Disorientation must make a difficulty roll (Endurance). The roll is only affected by the penalties from the total amount of Disorientation the victim has.

Exceptionally successful: The victim can continue to act, despite their injuries. Successful: The victim can continue to act, despite their injuries. Failed: The victim is disoriented and may attempt to recover in their turn each round. Initiative is set to one (1). Exceptionally failed: The victim is unconscious for as many minutes as the total amount of Disorientation they have.

Disoriented

If the victim becomes disoriented, this means in the scene that the victim is temporarily knocked out, stunned, or severely confused.

While the victim is disoriented, they may not perform any actions whatsoever, not even scream or attempt to call attention.

A disoriented person automatically receives Initiative one (1) and is counted as defenseless, see page 271. A disoriented person who receives additional Disorientation automatically becomes unconscious.

Recover

A disoriented person may make a difficulty roll (Endurance) on their turn each round to recover. Penalties come only from any Disorientation.

Exceptionally successful: The victim recovers and immediately gets to raise their Initiative as many steps as the value from all dice. In the next round they may act as normal. Successful: The victim recovers. In the next round they may act as normal. Failed: The victim is still disoriented and may attempt to recover again next round. Exceptionally failed: The victim becomes unconscious for as many minutes as the total amount of Disorientation they have.

Unconscious

An unconscious victim may not perform any actions whatsoever. The victim wakes on their own after as many minutes as the value in Disorientation was at the moment unconsciousness took effect.

An unconscious person is always counted as defenseless, see page 271.

Wake the Unconscious A medically trained person can attempt to wake an unconscious person. If the medically trained person succeeds at a difficulty roll (Medicine), the unconscious person is instead counted as disoriented. Each such attempt takes one round. Appropriate methods include slaps, cold water or chemical smelling salts.

Summary of Being Injured

1. Determine damage from the attack (from weapon, attack type or event) by rolling the dice indicated at the weapon's damage value. Let the dice remain visible on the table.
2. Increase the victim's amount of **Disorientation by as much as** the damage dice show.
3. If damage is higher than the victim's Wound Threshold, the victim receives one Wound. If damage is higher than the victim's double Wound Threshold, the victim receives as many wounds as the lowest die in the damage roll shows. If damage is higher than the victim's quadruple Wound Threshold, the victim receives as many wounds as the highest die in the damage roll shows.
4. The victim makes a difficulty roll (Endurance). If the roll fails, the victim is disoriented and must recover to be able to act again. A disoriented victim's Initiative is set to 1.
5. If the victim received one or more Wounds, they must make a difficulty roll (Will to Live). If the roll fails, the victim is counted as mortally wounded and dies after as many rounds as the sum of the difficulty roll's result, and initiative is set to 1. **If the difficulty roll failed** exceptionally, the victim dies immediately. A mortally wounded victim must be stabilized to survive.

"The bullet holes glittered like rubies in her chest, the blood gleamed against the perfect white skin. She was so beautiful. I was satisfied with the work of art." — Stelia Lock

Why damage is so random One might question how victims of weapon attacks suffer such random damage? It's important to remember that targets in combat don't stand still and take perfect hits. Even if a defender fails their defense, they still try to avoid harm in every way, by moving, instinctively ducking that centimeter required to transform a lethal hit into a scratch—the bullet missed the lung by a hair's breadth. See also the rule for hits on defenseless persons, described on page 271. There, guidelines are given for how to act in situations where a person has total control of a situation and violence is to be used. **Painkillers** One way to mitigate the effects of being injured is to pop painkiller pills or inject syringes. This is described on page 270. Willpower & Wounds If a victim is dealt one or more Wounds, they must make a difficulty roll (Willpower). The roll is only affected by the penalties from the total number of Wounds the victim has. Exceptional success: The victim can continue to act, despite their injuries. Success: The victim can continue to act, despite their injuries. Failure: The victim is mortally wounded, and dies after as many rounds as the combined total of all the dice shows. The victim gets Initiative 1. Exceptional failure: The victim dies immediately from the injuries. **Mortally wounded** A person is considered mortally wounded when they fail a difficulty roll (Willpower). When this happens, the vic-tim dies after as many rounds as the combined total on all dice in the difficulty roll. The victim's Initiative is set to 1. In the character sheet, note that the victim is mortally wounded. While the victim is mortally wounded, they may not perform any actions, other than possibly crawling, groaning, rattling, coughing, whispering final words, or similar. The victim may not scream or call attention from others than

those who have already noticed their status. A mortally wounded victim is not automatically unconscious (this is controlled by Confusion). A person who is mortally wounded is considered defenseless (see page 271), and dies immediately if they are inflicted with additional Wounds while they are defenseless. The only possibilities a mortally wounded person has to act are if they are either in a scene where a drive can be fulfilled (see page 233) or if they use Fate and grit their teeth (see page 239). A mortally wounded person who has been stabilized (see below) is no longer considered mortally wounded, so the marking in the character sheet is erased. **Stabilization of the mortally wounded** A medically skilled person can attempt to stabilize a mortally wounded person in hopes of saving their life. Stabiliza-tion is counted per Wound and the person may make a difficulty roll (Medicine) each round to hopefully stabilize a Wound. Each successful stabilization is noted in the character sheet at the Wound. Note that the Wound still remains—sta-bilization doesn't heal any Wounds. The outcome of the difficulty roll (Medicine) is read here: Exceptional success: As many Wounds as the result on the lowest die are considered stabilized. Success: One Wound is considered stabilized. Failure: No effect. Exceptional failure: A previously stabilized Wound is no longer considered stabilized. If there is no stabilized Wound, nothing further happens. When all Wounds are stabilized, the victim is no longer considered mortally wounded, has Initiative 1 and can act as normal. With this, all noted successful stabiliza-tions are erased from the character sheet. Note that each time a person becomes mortally wounded, all their Wounds must be stabilized, even those that have been stabilized previously. This shows that the body is a whole and that too much violence against it causes blood pressure drop, shock, and respiratory distress. Therefore, it's often a good idea to try to break off or avoid combat if one has suffered multiple Wounds. 9 17 28 Here you fill in the total amount of Confusion the per-son has. In this example, the person has accumulated Confusion 28. **Here you mark the person's** Confusion to determine which penalty applies at the current level; in the exam-ple, Confusion 28 gives a penalty of (–2). Should the amount of Confusion be 130 or higher, you must calculate the penalty manually, by taking and striking the last digit in the total amount of Confusion. 3 11 10 9 Here the number of Wounds a person has is noted; in the example, 3 Wounds. Here you see the penalty the person gets from the Wounds they have; in the example, the 3 Wounds give a penalty of (–6). The circle is marked if the person is mortally wounded, which is the case in the example. Here is noted how many rounds a mortally wounded person has left before they die from the injuries. In the example, the person has 9 rounds left. The crosses are used when stabilizing Wounds, to note which Wounds have been tended to. Here you can see that two of the 3 Wounds are stabilized. **Here it shows that the person's** Initiative is lowered by five steps for each Wound they've received. In the example, the person's Initiative has been lowered by 15 steps. The sum of the penalties from these two columns is the person's Total penalty and shows how much the injuries impair their continued actions. In the example, the Total penalty is (–8)

Recovery

A person's bodily injuries heal with time. Confusion decreases gradually while Wounds take longer to heal. **Reduction of Confusion** Confusion automatically decreases by the person's attri-bute value in Endurance per hour in the story. **Healing Wounds** After each longer rest period, usually at dawn, and at most once per day, the wounded must make a difficulty roll (Willpower) to see if they succeed in healing Wounds. The roll suf-fers a penalty if the person has not been in a hospital the day before. The degree of the penalty is determined according to table 1:65. The outcome of the roll is read below. Exceptional success: The person heals as many Wounds as the lowest die shows. Success: The person heals one Wound. Failure: No Wound is healed. Exceptional failure: No Wound is healed and the person suffers an additional Wound due to unforeseen conse-quences of the injury, such as an infection or internal bleeding. **Penalty Circumstances** ±0 Perfect—the person is in a hospital and receives competent care and rest –2 Good—the person rests in a protected environment, for example a room at home, is undisturbed and eats regularly, has warmth and peace and quiet, wounds are bandaged and treated –5 Poor—the person does not rest, engages in physical and/or

strenuous activity such as traveling around or fighting, wounds are poorly treated –10 Terrible—exposed situation, the person is in a trench with dirt and mud, where diseases and infections rage, in moisture and cold, unprotected from weather and wind, with wounds completely un-treated Table 1:65 **Operations** One way to heal Wounds faster is to be patched up and oper-ated on—a skilled surgeon can work wonders. The surgeon may make a difficulty roll (Medicine) for each Wound the patient has. The outcome is read here: Exceptional success: The Wound is restored but the patient's Confusion increases by the result on the lowest die. Success: The Wound is restored but the patient's Confusion increases by the result on the highest die. Failure: The Wound remains and cannot be restored through operation. The patient's Confusion increases by the sum of all dice results. Exceptional failure: The Wound remains and cannot be restored through operation. The patient's Confusion increases by the lowest die's result ×10. Complications arise and the patient receives an additional Wound with all that entails, and thus risks dying on the operating table. Each attempt to restore a Wound takes as many hours to complete as the lowest die's value. A patient's last Wound cannot be restored through surgery. **Realistic injuries** Noir is built to create drama, tension in the world that is presented, based on that world's grounding in reality and natural laws. Relentless realism has had to yield to atmosphere, flow, and entertainment. Parts of Noir, both in world and in rules, lie fairly close to realistic thinking, others lie far from it. However, Noir has deliberately been made credible, that is, rules and world should feel reasonable and well anchored within their internal logic. The damage system in Noir is therefore also deliberately kept abstract to avoid getting bogged down in details that most resemble an autopsy report. In our reality, almost all types of injuries cause a person to immediately cease the activity they were engaged in, thanks to pain and shock. But since the protagonists in the game are indeed protagonists in the ongoing story, they can take more punishment than real people. They still suffer the negative effects of injuries and risk being killed at each instance of damage, but in most cases they manage to continue their endeavor, even if they have bruises, flesh wounds, and pain. For those who want some form of connection to reality, the bodily injuries can be seen as follows: Light injuries include flesh wounds, scratches, small wounds, scrapes, abrasions, bruises, bumps, sprains, light bleeding, swelling, but are also pain, confusion, agony, stress, and disorientation. Serious injuries encompass everything from deep wound channels from bullets, severe cuts, extensive crush injuries, internal injuries, organ damage, broken bones, torn muscles, damaged tendons/joints to severe external and internal bleeding.

Other ways to be injured

There are other situations that can arise during a story where injuries result, which are described here. **Strangulation** Strangulation occurs when a person with their hands or with an implement prevents oxygen supply to the brain of their victim, or damages the throat so severely that continued breathing becomes impossible. The damage value is based on the strangulation method; see table 1:66. Once the victim is knocked out due to high Confu-sion, it's easy to execute them through continued strangulation for another round (see "Defenseless victims" and "Execution" on page 271). A person subjected to strangulation may not use the defense action Defend oneself, but must use Luck defense, Push back, or Strike back. The narrator can judge that the strangler has the upper hand if the strangler, for example, stands in a position so that it becomes difficult for the victim to defend themselves. The strangler then gets a bonus (+5) on all continued strangulations of the victim made in succession. It can also be judged that the strangulation causes problems for the strangled person's freedom of action, and the narrator can then assign penalties to the strangled person. **Method Damage Value** Strangulation without implement B3D–3 Strangulation with implement* B4D–4 Table 1:66 * For example garrote, piano wire, cord, or rope. **Explosions** Explosions cause damage through pressure waves and with shrapnel if such is created. There are three distances when it comes to explo-sions: contact, close, and far. Contact means that one more or less physically touch-es the explosion, or is very close to it (within about 1 meter). Close means that one is within a few meters from the detonation, while far means

that one stands outside the primary damage sphere but is affected by secon-dary effects—usually lighter pressure and burn injuries. The dam-age value is given per distance; see table 1:67. If the damage effect a person suffers from an explosion exceeds their Endurance value, the person is knocked down by the pressure wave. Initiative is then set to 1. If a detonation occurs in an enclosed space, for example in a room or a car interior, the distances for close and far are doubled. **Explosion Contact Close Far** Artillery shell B10D (0–1m) B5D (1–10m) B2D (10–25m) Gasoline barrel B5D (0–1m) B3D (1–2m) B1D (2–5m) Fuel tank B10D (0–1m) B5D (1–5m) B2D (5–10m) Dynamite, stick B5D (0–1m) B3D (1–2m) B1D (2–5m) Dynamite, charge B10D (0–1m) B5D (1–5m) B2D (5–10m) Dynamite, full crate B20D (0–1m) B10D (1–10m) B5D (10–25m) Dynamite, truck bed B30D (0–1m) B15D (1–20m) B5D (20–50m) Aerial bomb, small B20D (0–1m) B10D (1–10m) B5D (10–25m) Aerial bomb, large B30D (0–1m) B15D (1–20m) B5D (20–50m) Gas tank B5D (0–1m) B3D (1–2m) B1D (2–5m) Mortar shell B10D (0–1m) B5D (1–2m) B2D (2–5m) Hand grenade B10D (0–1m) B5D (1–2m) B2D (2–5m) Explosive fence B20D (0–1m) B10D (1–5m) B5D (5–10m) Table 1:67 The blood-stained hands still trembled as he convulsively held the bundle of newspaper against his chest. He had been lucky; no one had seen him drag away the unconscious woman, and he got to perform his task undisturbed on the basement floor. A flask of liquor he had needed to do it, less than last time; that was good—less money for liquor, more money for a fix. He looked around several times before half-running across the street toward the steel door. That there was a clinic behind it one couldn't guess—a friend of his had tipped him off about it. The warmth from the bundle spread across his chest; the soiled shirt was now soaked with blood that had leaked through the newspapers. He pounded with a bloody fist on the door. The fresher the organs were and the younger and healthier the donor was, the more zovrins one got—and the woman had been very young—almost not a woman. The discomfort began to well up over him, and the lump in his throat made it hard to breathe, but he put his thoughts on the fix he could get for the money. The door opened and he looked into the gray-clad guard's gun muzzle. He could barely stammer that he had things to sell; the guard nodded and let him into the room with the antiseptic air and the tile-clad walls. He was shown to the doctor—the bald, sickly thin man whose eyes were always hidden by black glass. The doctor pointed to a bench of stainless steel and he laid down the bundle there. While the doc-tor unfolded the newspaper, the man took the opportunity to look around. On shelves of stainless steel stood quantities of glass jars with organs preserved in medical alcohol; by the floor drain the cockroaches crawled, and on the wall hung a yellowed anatomical poster of the human body. The doctor smacked and licked his lips; he studied the red heart, the kidneys and liver; some of the more mangled intestines he poked aside. The man watched with disgust as the doctor bent down, put his nose right next to the organs and breathed in the smell. Then he turned around and wiped the blood from his fingers. He smiled and walked up to a metal cabinet from which he took a handful of zovrins and placed them in the man's hand. After that, the guard showed him the door, and the man ran out into the night toward the nearest dealer who could give him what he needed to feel good and to get rid of his guilt. The fix, the wonderful high that would remove the image of the girl's butchered body on the basement floor, the rats that had started eating her while he was still working. What won't one do to survive, he thought as he slowly died inside.

Where attacks hit

It doesn't matter where an attack hits an enemy. The player may improvise this based on damage dealt and effect. High damage and/or many Wounds can symbolize very serious hits to the chest or head, while minor damage can be scratches across the forehead, shot-off earlobes, or flesh wounds in arms or legs, but the opposite hit location relationships can also apply. A minor wound can hit the head or torso while damage from high damage can hit vital parts in a leg, for example the kneecap or femoral artery. It is up to the attacker to, within the bounds of reason, describe the sequence and thereby also the hit location. The important thing to remember however is that mechanically there are only two types of damage that count —

Stunning and Wounds. Other descriptions of wounds should be seen as flavor to build atmosphere in the scene.

Falls & collisions

Falls from great heights and being hit at high speed cause similar massive crush injuries to the body. Generally, the victim suffers damage equal to B2T per five meters of fall height or per 20 km/h in speed. This is summarized in table 1:68. The victim must make a difficulty roll (Mobility) during the col-lision or fall to see if they manage to parry or mitigate the accident somehow. Exceptionally successful: Damage is reduced by B2T. Successful: Damage is reduced by B1T. Failed: Damage increases by B1T. Exceptionally failed: Damage increases by B2T. If the impact point is considered hard or angular (for example landing on a marble floor or stone stairs), add B1T to the damage. Similarly, subtract B1T from the damage if the impact point is considered soft (such as landing in water or a pile of hay). If the impact point is judged to be very sharp (such as landing on a fence with spikes along the top or in a container full of large glass shards), the narrator can treat the damage as lethal rather than stunning (see page 263). Should the damage ever drop to zero dice, it means the victim completely avoids damage from the fall or collision.

Fall height Collision speed Damage

0-5 m 1-20 km/h B2T 5-10 m 20-40 km/h B4T 10-15 m 40-60 km/h B6T 15-20 m 60-80 km/h B8T 20-25 m 80-100 km/h B10T 25-30 m 100-120 km/h B12T 30-35 m 120-140 km/h B14T 35-40 m 140-160 km/h B16T 40-45 m 160-180 km/h B18T 45-50 m 180-200 km/h B20T per 5 m per 20 km/h +B2T

Table 1:68

Rolling

If you roll at high speed, for example if you've jumped from a train or vehicle at high speed, damage is read from the collision speed. However, the damage halves each round, starting already from the first round. Halving is rounded down as usual. When the damage reaches B1T, no further damage is dealt the following round and the rolling is considered to have stopped.

Oxygen deprivation

A person can suffer oxygen deprivation, most often from drowning or suffocation (for example during hanging or if a pillow is placed over the face). Note that properly executed strangulation is covered on page 266 and does not fall under these rules. A person who is prepared for drowning/suffocation can hold their breath for Endurance number of rounds. If the person is unprepared or distracted or subjected to violence, the time is halved. When the time has passed, the person suffers B5T in damage per round until the oxygen deprivation is lifted. If the victim becomes defenseless, each subsequent round counts as an automatic successful execution (see page 271).

Fire/acid

If a person is exposed to fire or acid, the person suffers damage depending on the intensity of the fire or acid and its damage value. A narrator may judge that a burn or acid-damaged person has their appearance value lowered due to the injuries that occur. However, this should be fairly rare unless the situation specifically indicates otherwise.

Ignition & extinguishing

A person exposed to an open flame can catch fire. This occurs when the fire makes a difficulty roll, with the intensity's Ignition as a bonus and the victim's Luck as a penalty. One difficulty roll per round of exposure is made. An ignited person doesn't become more ignited unless the fire's intensity increases. Table 1:69 summarizes this. If the fire catches hold, the person burns and suffers damage until the fire is extinguished. This damage is always dealt last each round. **Other factors can also affect the difficulty roll** — if the victim is wearing wet or flame-retardant clothing, the fire gets a penalty (−5). A burning person is extinguished by rolling on the ground, by wrapping in blankets, or drowning in water. To succeed at this requires a successful difficulty roll (Mobility), where the fire's Ignition value becomes a penalty. Each consecutive round used for extinguishing gives an increasing bonus (+5).

*Intensity Damage Ignition** Example** Small B1T +0 Cigarette, match, lighter, drop of acid Contained 2T-1 +5 Torch, campfire, flaming splinters, acid splash High 3T-2 +10 Conflagration, flamethrower flame, welding torch, acid bath

Table 1:69 * Per round of exposure. ** Applies only to fire.

Electricity

A person who comes into contact with electric current risks injury. Damage is dealt each round, see table 1:70. An electrical injury that causes a Wound means the person is stuck to the power source and must pass a difficulty roll (Strength) to break free and not suffer the damage again the following round.

Source Damage* Wall socket 1T Short-circuited fuse box 2T Power cord 2T Electric fence B4T High-voltage cable 5T Stun baton** B3T

Table 1:70 * Per round of contact. ** Weapon used by riot police which knocks out victims effectively.

"I beat him until he loved me. Then I strangled him because I don't deserve to be loved." —T.

Drugs, poisoning

& defenseless victims To cope with many of life's hardships, citizens visit bars and taverns in their quest for alcohol to numb themselves. Others make their way to the safe haze of opium dens. A third uses substances for crimes and assassinations. Drugs are everywhere beneath Sandukar's surface.

Use of drugs

It's not unlikely that the protagonists will come into contact with various forms of drugs and poisons during the course of the story. Here follow general rules and guidelines for this.

Dependency & withdrawal

If a person is dependent on a drug, they need a steady intake of the drug to avoid suffering withdrawal. Withdrawal creates a craving for the drug and makes the person unfocused, irritable, and generally in a bad mood. Physical and motor activity is also negatively affected.

Dependency

A dependency on a drug causes the body's tolerance to increase so the drug has a harder time taking effect. This means the person gets a bonus on rolls (Tolerance) for that specific drug. A person can be dependent on several drugs simultaneously. Table 1:71 shows what effect the different drugs have when the person is dependent. Challenge level shows the target value for the com-plex action (see page 201) required to break the dependency, provided total abstinence is maintained. A difficulty roll (Determination) is made per day. Should the drug be used during the time the person is trying to break the dependency, the total is reset to zero. Tolerance indicates the bonus added to rolls (Tolerance) when the drug is used — with a dependency, it becomes harder to achieve the drug's effect. Withdrawal shows how long it takes before withdrawal sets in, and how severe the withdrawal is.

Drug Challenge level Tolerance Withdrawal

Alcohol 150 +5 8 hours (Mild) Depressants 200 +10 12 hours (Severe) Hallucinogens 200 +10 12 hours (Severe) Painkillers 100 +5 12 hours (Mild) Stimulants 200 +10 12 hours (Severe)

Table 1:71

Withdrawal

Withdrawal is the collective term for the effects that afflict a person when their body and/or psyche craves a drug but doesn't get it. There are two levels of withdrawal: mild and severe. Mild withdrawal means the person suffers a general penalty (−2) on all actions, including difficulty rolls (Determination) to break dependencies. Severe withdrawal means the person suffers a general penalty (−5) on all actions, including difficulty rolls (Determination) to break dependencies.

Overdose

An overdose is considered lethal poisoning and affects the victim immediately. A person who has received the intended effect (that is, who didn't roll exceptionally successfully) from taking stimulants, depressants, or hallucinogenic drugs, and who takes another dose during the duration automatically suffers an overdose.

Drugs & poisons

All forms of foreign substances that in various ways affect a person fall under this heading. They are described here in general terms to be quickly usable in the story, and the narrator is encouraged to fill in details about the course of events, drug names, and visual effects.

Alcohol

Alcohol affects a person's judgment, mental barriers, body precision, and perception. The amount of alcohol in one dose is approximately one strong beer, a glass of wine, or one drink. Make a difficulty roll (Tolerance) per dose the person consumes. Exceptionally successful: The person doesn't feel the alcohol. Successful: The person increases Stunning by as much as the value on the highest die. Make a difficulty roll (Endurance). Failed: The person increases Stunning by as much as the value on all dice. Make a difficulty roll (Endurance). Exceptionally failed: The person increases Stunning by as much as double the value on all dice. Make a difficulty roll (Endurance). If the person fails exceptionally twice within a day, they become dependent on alcohol. If the person has ever been dependent on alcohol and drinks again after breaking the dependency, one exceptional failure is enough for them to become dependent again. If the person becomes dependent, their Maximum Well-being decreases one level (−1).

Detecting hidden poisoning

A person who is poisoned in a hidden way, for example through food, may make a difficulty roll (Awareness), with a bonus equal to the number of doses the poison consists of. Some poisons can be made virtually undetectable, but they are rare and expensive. The narrator decides whether a potential poisoning victim can also notice the poison through a successful difficulty roll (Intuition).

Sedative poison

The term sedative poison includes everything from chloroform, sleeping pills and knockout drops to sedative gases and tear gas, as well as paralyzing poisons. When a person is poisoned, they must make as many difficulty rolls (Tolerance) as the number of doses of poison they were exposed to. Different poisons take different amounts of time to work; a few seconds, minutes, or perhaps even hours — sleeping pills usually take effect in about half an hour. The difficulty rolls for a multi-dose poisoning can advantageously be made at intervals within the time it takes for the poison to work. Make a difficulty roll (Tolerance) per dose. Exceptionally successful: The person resists the poison and can act normally. The person gets a bonus (+1) on resisting the poison for the next day. Successful: The person increases Stunning by as much as the value on the highest die, and must make a difficulty roll (Endurance) immediately. Failed: The person increases Stunning by as much as the value on the lowest die × 10, and must make a difficulty roll (Endurance) immediately. Exceptionally failed: The person increases Stunning by as much as the value on all dice × 10, and must make a difficulty roll (Endurance) immediately.

Depressants

Illegal narcotics. Can be administered in countless different ways, for example smoked, chewed, or injected. Sometimes called downers. Makes the person calm, relaxed, and dopey. Make a difficulty roll (Tolerance) per dose taken. Exceptionally successful: The person doesn't feel the drug. Successful: The person gets a bonus (+2) on rolls involving Endurance, Resistance, and Sanity. The person gets a penalty (−5) on rolls involving Resist, Deduction, Persuade, Leadership, and Awareness. The victim ignores 1 point of Total Penalty from Stunning and Wounds. The effect lasts for two hours. Failed: The person gets a bonus (+2) on rolls involving Endurance, Resistance, and Sanity. The person gets a penalty (−5) on rolls involving Resist, Deduction, Persuade, Leadership, and Awareness. The victim ignores 1 point of Total Penalty from Stunning and Wounds. The effect lasts for four hours. Exceptionally failed: The person gets a bonus (+2) on rolls involving Endurance, Resistance, and Sanity. The person gets a penalty (−5) on rolls involving Resist, Deduction, Persuade, Leadership, and Awareness. The victim ignores 1 point of Total Penalty from Stunning and Wounds. The effect lasts for four hours. The person becomes dependent on the drug. The person's Maximum Wellbeing decreases one level (−1).

"Here, have a drink and you'll feel better" Once per game session, a person can restore a small amount of Stunning caused by injuries in the current or immediately preceding scene by taking a good drink. If the person downs at least a double whisky (or equivalent), immediately recover 2T steps of Stunning due to increased wellbeing, relaxation, and sedation. This is a special rule included to create drama and because it fits the noir style and therefore doesn't follow the rules for alcohol.

Roll a difficulty check (Tolerance) per dose. Exceptionally successful: The person resists the drug's effects. Successful: The person receives a penalty (−2) on checks (Resist) when they try to lie or avoid questions. The victim's Daze increases by an amount equal to the value of the lowest die. Failed: The person receives a penalty (−5) on checks (Resist) when they try to lie or avoid questions. The victim's Daze increases by an

amount equal to the value of the highest die. Exceptionally failed: The person receives a penalty (−10) on checks (Resist) when they try to lie or avoid questions. The victim's Daze increases by an amount equal to the value of all dice.

Painkillers

Painkillers come in tablet or pill form, or as injections. They are usually bought at small pharmacies. Painkillers are used to suppress pain and numb aches — everything from headaches, toothaches, or fleshy gunshot wounds. A normal container of tablets holds about twelve doses.

Each dose of painkillers numbs a specific amount of pain, allowing the victim to ignore a certain portion of the Total Penalty (see page 263) that Daze and Wounds impose on dice rolls.

Roll a difficulty check (Tolerance) per dose. Exceptionally successful: The person is unaffected by the drug. Successful: For four hours, the person ignores 1 point from Total Penalty. Failed: For four hours, the person ignores 2 points from Total Penalty. Exceptionally failed: For four hours, the person ignores 3 points from Total Penalty. The person becomes addicted to the drug. The person's Maximum Wellbeing deteriorates one level (−1).

Stimulants

Illegal narcotics. Can be administered in countless ways, for example smoked, snorted, or injected. Sometimes called upperjack. Makes the person hyperactive, energized, aggressive, and fearless.

Roll a difficulty check (Tolerance) per dose taken. Exceptionally successful: The person doesn't feel the drug. Successful: The person receives a bonus (+2) on checks involving Persuade, Endurance, Resist, Willpower, Stamina, and Overview. The person receives a penalty (−5) on checks involving Sanity, Impression, Deduction, Vehicles, Firearms, and Awareness. The effect lasts for two hours. Failed: The person receives a bonus (+2) on checks involving Persuade, Endurance, Resist, Willpower, Stamina, and Overview. The person receives a penalty (−5) on checks involving Sanity, Impression, Deduction, Vehicles, Firearms, and Awareness. The effect lasts for four hours. Exceptionally failed: The person receives a bonus (+2) on checks involving Persuade, Endurance, Resist, Willpower, Stamina, and Overview. The person receives a penalty (−5) on checks involving Sanity, Impression, Deduction, Vehicles, Firearms, and Awareness. The effect lasts for four hours. The person becomes addicted to the drug. The person's Maximum Wellbeing deteriorates one level (−1).

Lethal Poison

There are countless lethal toxins, both natural and chemically produced. Various animal venoms from snakes or spiders are popular. Generally, they tend to shut down the victim's nervous system, paralyze respiratory organs, or destroy internal organs. The forms of poisons vary — from pills or powder to liquid or gas. Poison gas in particular is common on the battlefield.

When a person is poisoned, they must roll as many difficulty checks (Tolerance) as the number of poison doses they have been exposed to. The most common is for the poison to take effect within a few minutes, although there are poisons that take considerably longer before they activate. The difficulty checks for a multi-dose poisoning can advantageously be rolled at regular intervals within the time it takes for the poison to take effect, rather than in a clump.

Roll a difficulty check (Tolerance) per dose. Exceptionally successful: The person resists the poison and can act normally. The person receives a bonus (+1) to resist the poison within the next day. Successful: The victim

receives one Wound and must immediately roll a difficulty check (Willpower). Failed: The victim receives as many Wounds as the value of the lowest die, and must immediately roll a difficulty check (Willpower). Exceptionally failed: The victim receives as many Wounds as the value of all dice, and must immediately roll a difficulty check (Willpower).

Hallucinogens

Illegal narcotics. Can be administered in countless ways, for example smoked, chewed, snorted, or rubbed against skin. Gives the person hallucinations, heightened impressions of their surroundings, and skewed perception of reality.

Roll a difficulty check (Tolerance) per dose taken. Exceptionally successful: The person doesn't feel the drug. Successful: The person receives a bonus (+2) on checks involving Create, Deduction, Intuition, Awareness, and Resist. The person receives a penalty (−5) on checks involving Impression, Melee, Firearms, Thrown Weapons, and Vehicles. The effect lasts for two hours. Failed: The person receives a bonus (+2) on checks involving Create, Deduction, Intuition, Awareness, and Resist. The person receives a penalty (−5) on checks involving Impression, Melee, Firearms, Thrown Weapons, and Vehicles. The effect lasts for four hours. Exceptionally failed: The person receives a bonus (+2) on checks involving Create, Deduction, Intuition, Awareness, and Resist. The person receives a penalty (−5) on checks involving Impression, Melee, Firearms, Thrown Weapons, and Vehicles. The effect lasts for four hours. The person becomes addicted to the drug. The person's Maximum Wellbeing deteriorates one level (−1).

Truth Serum

Truth serum is a liquid usually administered with the help of a syringe. The effect lasts a short time, usually about ten minutes. An increased dose at one and the same time doesn't affect further, but rather multiple doses increase the time the person is affected. Each dose can be fought with the help of Tolerance.

Defenseless Victims

A person considered defenseless is very vulnerable. To be considered defenseless requires that the person is unaware that danger is imminent, such as during an unexpected ambush, a sniper attack with a rifle from long range, or a punch in the face they're not at all prepared for. It can also involve situations where the person is unable to protect themselves, for example they might be tied up, pinned down, sleeping, unconscious, or subjected to gunpoint.

People who are dazed due to failed checks (Stamina) are also considered defenseless, see page 263, as are mortally wounded persons.

A person who reasonably is prepared that an attack might come, for example if gunfire has been noticed or threats have occurred, and who can act without hindrance almost never counts as defenseless (however, the person can be considered surprised, see page 254).

There are two actions an attacker can perform against a defenseless victim — Knock Out and Execute.

Knock Out

A person can attempt to knock out a defenseless person so they become unconscious or incapacitated. This requires a difficulty check (Melee), (Agility), or (Strength) for this — the situation determines which skill fits best. If the attempt is performed with some form of implement (for example a pistol butt, blackjack, wooden

club, etc.) a bonus (+5) is given to the roll. Note that only the outcome from this roll inflicts damage on the target — the damage value is ignored.

Exceptionally successful: The victim's Daze increases by ten times the sum from all dice (all dice x 10) and they automatically become unconscious for as many minutes as the total amount of Daze they have. Successful: The victim's Daze increases by ten times the sum from all dice (all dice x 10) and must roll a difficulty check (Stamina), see page 263. Failed: The victim's Daze increases by ten times the value of the highest die (highest die x 10) and must roll a difficulty check (Stamina), see page 263. Exceptionally failed: The victim's Daze increases by the value of the lowest die and must roll a difficulty check (Stamina), see page 263. The attacker's Wellbeing deteriorates (−1), see page 242.

Example: Anya has gotten hold of a snitch who knows about Rulov's illegal trade in war slaves. She has gotten him to lead her to the place where the slaves are being prepared to serve their new masters, and when the snitch turns his back, she pulls out her revolver and strikes the butt against the back of his neck.

The narrator judges that since the attack was unexpected and comes from behind, the snitch doesn't get to attempt to defend himself at all but counts as defenseless. The difficulty check (Strength) (which was the skill that felt most reasonable in the situation) succeeds and the dice show 5 and 10. Another die is rolled since the 10 was maxed — it shows 6, sum 5 + 10 + 6 = 21 x 10 = 210. The snitch receives 210 in Daze and rolls his check (Stamina), with a penalty (−21). The roll fails. The snitch collapses dazed onto the rain-wet asphalt.

Execute

The narrator must determine whether a person has the capacity to execute another, based on personality and circumstances, as an execution is an exceptionally cold-blooded and mentally taxing act. Additionally, requirements for some form of suitable implement may exist, although a skilled brawler can execute a defenseless person with their bare hands, through for example strangulation, suffocation, neck-breaking, or simply massive violence.

For a sniper assassination, the right kind of weapon for the purpose is required, and the shooter must succeed in hitting despite the distance (the victim then gets to benefit from a chance defense, see page 260).

Attempting to execute a defenseless person requires a difficulty check (Resolve). If the attempt is performed with some form of ranged weapon (for example a revolver) a bonus (+5) is given, as this is not as personal. Note that the outcome from the roll inflicts the only damage on the target — the damage value is ignored.

Exceptionally successful: The executioner is ice-cold and the victim is inflicted with as many Wounds as the value of the highest die in the roll. The victim must roll a difficulty check (Willpower), see page 264. Successful: The executioner carries out their task efficiently and the victim is inflicted with as many Wounds as the value of the lowest die in the roll. The victim must roll a difficulty check (Willpower), see page 264. Failed: The executioner performs the action with great hesitation and nervousness, and risks being affected by stress equivalent to a shocking experience, see page 244. The victim suffers one Wound. The victim must roll a difficulty check (Willpower), see page 264. Exceptionally failed: The person fails catastrophically with the execution and risks being affected by stress equivalent to psychological trauma, see page 244.

Example: Mordekai has found Kasilan Darvo, one of those who raped and beat to death his childhood love Janya. The scum is sitting tied to a chair in a grimy basement in a condemned building in the slums, and has confessed that the lust murder was just a detail in a much larger event — something that doesn't put Mordekai in a better mood.

After Mordekai has worked over Darvo for a few hours with pliers, gasoline, and a slender gold lighter, the tortured murderer finally tells who hired him to carry out the deed. Mordekai realizes he can't risk the bloody and burned man getting away and being able to warn his employer that the hour of vengeance has come.

The choice is simple — Mordekai shoots Darvo in the forehead with his own matte black Calder .45. Darvo is considered defenseless and a difficulty check (Resolve) is rolled. Mordekai is tough and succeeds when the dice show 7 and 9. This gives the victim seven wounds. Darvo fails exceptionally with his check (Willpower) and the narrator describes how the meat chunks stick to the damp concrete wall behind them, while the lone shot echoes between the basement vaults.

"If you're damn lucky you'll have a stroke before I'm done with you." — Sergy Rulov

Defenseless Victims in Combat

Situations where a defenseless victim ends up in regular combat can very well arise, for example if a person presses a revolver muzzle against the victim's temple or holds a stiletto against their throat. If the defenseless person wants to start a fight and thus try to take control of the situation, difficulty checks (Overview) are rolled just as in normal cases when a fight starts. However, the defenseless victim receives a penalty (−5) on their roll since they find themselves at a disadvantage.

The defenseless person counts as defenseless until they have chosen their first Initiative action. This means that if they get a lower initiative than their opponent, the opponent can still choose to execute or knock out the defenseless person instead of performing a normal Initiative action. Thus, it is very risky to start fighting as defenseless, but sometimes it might be one's only chance.

Examples regarding combat & damage Violent combat situations, serious injuries, and deadly encounters befall many people in Noir's dark world. Many perish, others fall into silence, but there are those who have bestial stories to tell about their macabre experiences.

Examples

To make things easier for the narrator, below follows several examples tied to the rules in chapter six. The reason the examples are separated from the rules section is that they take up considerable space and it should be quick and smooth to browse between the rules so one gets a good overview of them. These collected examples show how the rules can be used in play, and in each example there is a reference to the page where one can find the rule the example concerns.

The examples are divided into the different sections where they occur: combat, initiative actions, and so on. Under these headings follow all examples in alphabetical order.

Combat

Disarming (p. 257) Anya finds herself in melee combat with one of the Afflicted inside a burned-out church ruin in western Sandukar. The sun is just rising over the horizon where the two women fight for their lives. Anya's opponent, Tarinna, is just drawing her sword and preparing for a lunge.

At her Initiative, Anya attempts to disarm Tarinna. This is a Fight action with a penalty (−10) but Anya nevertheless succeeds in winning over Tarinna who is disarmed and cannot reach the sword during the current or next round. In the scene it is portrayed as if the sword is kicked from Tarinna's grip and lands among the pew rows behind Anya where it is inaccessible to Tarinna.

Dramatic Combat (p. 253) Anya is engaged in combat with a knife murderer in the library of a manor house. Her player vividly describes how Anya grabs a crystal decanter of liquor and throws it at the rushing knife man. The attack succeeds and Anya describes how the bottle smashes against the murderer's forehead and drenches the murderer in liquor, how the glass shatters and crunches under the murderer's heavy boots while he advances screaming. The narrator likes how the player immerses themselves in the scene and builds atmosphere during the combat and therefore gives the throwing attack +1 to damage effect.

Draw improvised weapons (p. 259) Mordekai is inside a workshop. Before him he sees a shotgun on a table and further away a deserter with a bayonet comes charging at him. Instead of wasting time drawing his revolver from its holster, he resolutely takes two steps forward and grabs the shotgun and shoots the bayonet-wielder. All of this can be done with a single "Shoot" action. Mordekai discovers, however, that the shotgun is unloaded so his Shoot action fails automatically. But in the next round he has a shotgun that can be used as an improvised club. Opening Initiative (p. 254) Mordekai needs to get into a gambling den run by Sergy Rulov's henchman Karlos. He knows he can't talk his way in and decides to break in the hard way. Mordekai knocks on the discreet door in the filthy alley. The rain beats against his hat brim when a small hatch opens in the door and a pair of shifty eyes peer out. They widen when Mordekai without a word presses his revolver into the opening and pulls the trigger. Since combat is initiated, all involved make a difficulty roll (Overview). Mordekai rolls 9 and 8, which together with his Overview counts as successful. Thus his Initiative becomes 17 (9 + 8). The guard gets a penalty (−10) as he is considered to be surprised. He rolls 3 and 7, the result is a failure and the guard's Initiative becomes 7 (the value of the highest die). Mordekai comes first in turn order and neutralizes the guard with a bullet in the forehead before the guard can execute his first initiative action. What Mordekai doesn't know is that there are two more thugs behind the door, who react to what's happening. In round two they get to act and roll for Initiative. Both have Overview 9. The first, a man with a crooked nose, rolls and gets 3 and 4, sum 16 — a failure, while the other, who has stubble, rolls 1 and 10 (the 1 prevents the 10 from being maxed), which gives sum 20, a successful result. Crooked nose's Initiative becomes 4 and stubble's becomes 11. Mordekai still has Initiative 17 and acts first by shooting crooked nose in the chest so he dies. With turn order 11 the stubble man acts by attempting to draw his automatic pistol, which succeeds. Round two ends. Round three starts with Mordekai, who still has the highest Initiative, shooting again and succeeds in dropping stubble. Mordekai takes a couple of steps over the bodies, ejects the shell casings from his revolver and with a practiced hand inserts new ones while he scans the dim corridor beyond.

About being grabbed or held (p. 257) Mordekai holds his revolver in his hand as he makes his way through Sandukar's sewers. Suddenly the target of his hunt appears, but in an unpleasant way. The man jumps down from the ceiling and has higher Initiative than the surprised Mordekai. In his turn order the attacker wants to grab Mordekai's arm and hand to prevent the revolver from being used. The attacker succeeds with the resistance roll so Mordekai cannot use the revolver until the grip is broken somehow. In his turn order Mordekai attempts to break the grip through a Brawl action which proves to be successful. Mordekai decides that he simply exploits his strength and size and hurls the attacker into the ceiling repeatedly until he releases his grip and falls down into the foul water. After that, the round ends. **Initiative actions** Other action (p. 259) Gabriel is mortally wounded after a gang brutally beat him with baseball bats. Mordekai and Jessca find him and while Mordekai engages the gang with violence, Jessca attempts to bandage Gabriel's Wounds. This automatically lowers her Initiative to 1, but since the bandaging has nothing to do with the combat itself she gets no penalty on the difficulty roll (Medicine). Talia just got out of the bath and meets a burglar naked who gets other ideas when he sees the woman. Just then Gabriel enters and perceives the situation. A gunfight breaks out between the two men and in Talia's turn order she chooses to hastily put on an overcoat to slip away from the scene in the next round. Putting on the coat, with buttoning and all, counts as a non-combat-

related action and lowers her Initiative to 1. Wait (p. 259) Gabriel has after emptying his weapons run from his pursuers and hidden behind a door. He peers out through the door crack and sees two of Gavilan's enforcers searching for him in the dim corridor. In his turn order Gabriel chooses to wait in hopes that the two will split up during the search. Waiting requires no roll and Gabriel's Initiative is unchanged. Draw weapon (p. 258) Gabriel stands weaponless before the corrupt police constable he has been hunting. The constable forces him down on his knees and mocks him. In his turn order Gabriel wants to draw his backup revolver from his ankle holster. He makes a difficulty roll and reaches a sum of 19 — a failure. In the scene this is portrayed with Gabriel not getting a good grip on the pant leg. In the next round Gabriel tries again, he now gets a bonus (+10) and succeeds in drawing the weapon. In the next round he plans to use it against the ranting uniformed idiot before him. Move (p. 258) In the cold moonlight Mordekai examines the top floor of a parking garage. Suddenly he hears the sound of several motorcycles and sees how three submachine gun-armed thugs approach at high speed from the ramp. Mordekai realizes he is as good as hopeless and decides to flee. This is a typical "Move" action. Mordekai's player wants Mordekai to sprint at full speed toward the side of the building, grab the edge and swing down one floor. Mordekai's Combat Movement is 13, which means he can at most run 26 meters — which is more than enough for him to reach his designated goal. The narrator perceives this maneuver as more difficult than usual since there are obstructing vehicles in the way and gives Mordekai a penalty (−2). The difficulty roll is made and it turns out that Mordekai succeeds. He finds himself one floor below the thugs, who quickly turn their motorcycles toward the ramp. Gabriel finds himself in a desolate rail yard. The abandoned rusty metal skeletons of train cars are everywhere and create almost a labyrinth. Unexpectedly he stands eye to eye with two substantial guard dogs that raise their hackles. In his turn order Gabriel's player declares that he wants Gabriel to "Move" to seek shelter in one of the cars about 15 meters away. The difficulty roll shows, despite a bonus (+2), that he fails so the narrator describes how Gabriel grabs a rusty handle while climbing up, but the handle breaks so Gabriel falls backwards down onto the muddy ground, with the excited barking echoing in his ears. Await target (p. 259) Gabriel is alone in a grimy stairwell in a slum tenement. He needs to get into an apartment where a stolen pass is located. The tension hangs in the air and Gabriel advances slowly forward along the corridor toward the closed apartment door, prepared for someone to come out at any moment. This is judged to be a typical example of Await target — Gabriel goes in his turn order prepared for combat cautiously forward with the pistol ready in a firm two-handed grip aimed at the door. As if fate read his thoughts, the door suddenly opens and a figure with a double-barreled shotgun appears. It is the figure's turn order but since Gabriel waited, a resistance roll is made. Gabriel gets a bonus (+7) for having a higher Initiative than the figure (+2) and for awaiting against a specifically defined target (the door, +5). The figure saw Gabriel through a peephole and knew where he was so the figure gets a bonus (+5).

The result from the resistance roll with Awareness speaks in Gabriel's favor (22 versus 18) so Gabriel gets to perform an initiative action directly in the figure's turn order, before them. Gabriel chooses to Shoot aimed fire but the figure succeeds in defending themselves and throwing themselves behind the doorframe while the bullets whine past further into the apartment. In the distance, the sound of a mirror shattering is heard.

Now the figure gets to act with their initiative action and lunges forward with the rifle and shoots at Gabriel who successfully manages to defend himself by diving into a side corridor while the shotgun pellets echo and tear up wallpaper, plaster and brick wall into a dust inferno behind him. The round is over.

Throw object at target (p. 257) Jessca is at a fancy party. When she's on her way to the powder room, one of the host's bodyguards approaches, pushes her into a darkened office and starts groping her. Jessca does not tolerate this and in her turn order takes three steps back toward the desk, grabs a letter opener and throws it at the creep.

Jessca succeeds and the letter opener embeds itself in the bodyguard's chest who, screaming, staggers backward. Jessca quickly leaves the room and the party.

Throw object to location (p. 257) Gabriel is crouched behind a low wall and is being hunted by a gang of slavers. He wants to try to divert their attention with a brick. He throws the brick over the wall but the roll turns out unsuccessful, since he can't see the landing spot the deduction of five (−5) means Gabriel only achieves a result of 18.

In the scene this is portrayed as the brick flying far too short and that Gabriel rather draws attention than the opposite. Additionally his Initiative is lowered by five (−5).

Reload (p. 258) Gabriel is protecting the accountant Janner from organized crime. A firefight breaks out between gangsters and Gabriel in the lobby of the hotel where the accountant is hiding. Gabriel empties his pistol and dives down behind a luggage cart to reload. In his next turn order he makes a difficulty roll (Firearms) and gets a sum of 31 – far above the threshold of 20 for a successful roll, so he smoothly retrieves a spare magazine, pushes it into the pistol and racks the slide, so that he's ready to shoot again with his fully loaded weapon at his Initiative in the next round.

Sweep with automatic fire (p. 256) Semuel Mesarat is being chased by four constables who have discovered his attempt to peddle stolen machine guns on the black market. After Mesarat throws himself around a corner in the warehouse he gets hold of a submachine gun and readies himself. The four constables come around the corner and are met by wild automatic fire. The roll shows 7 and 9, and only one of the constables manages to get a higher sum with their defense roll, so three constables are hit and receive damage of 2D−1 each. A full 32 ((7 + 9) × 2) rounds are struck from the magazine, which is more than the 28 that were in it so the weapon is emptied after the attack.

In the scene this is described as Mesarat desperately just squeezing the trigger to the bottom and dragging the chattering weapon back and forth in an arc until it falls silent and how three of the policemen appear to have been hit by the hail of bullets.

Berserk rage (p. 257) Mordekai catches a pickpocket who stole a photo of Mordekai's dead love, Janya Makovy. This makes the big man see red and he starts pummeling the scrawny boy for all he's worth. Mordekai gets a bonus (+5) for the Berserk rage and he succeeds better than what the pickpocket does with his defense, so he strikes the thief with damage that increases by one (+1). Mordekai's Initiative is lowered by five (−5).

Sniper shot (p. 256) The pigeons scatter in panic as the shot echoes between the streets. Stelia sits in an apartment and gazes out over the square in front of the War Ministry. She coolly observes war minister baron Kaspar van Ducall-Kriger through the precision-adjusted scope, where he crawls away along the wet cobblestones. His guard tries to take control of the panicked situation, with little success. The guard captain in charge lies still in a pool of blood. Stelia smiles and her gloved hand squeezes the trigger again when the minister's head is right in the crosshairs.

Stelia has Initiative 21 so she can without problem use the initiative action Sniper shot. She gets a bonus (Precision +5 × 2) thanks to her sniper rifle. Stelia wins the resistance roll and the war minister's body jerks and falls forward in a fine, red mist.

Stelia's Initiative is lowered by ten (−10), to eleven, and one round is struck from the weapon's magazine.

Shoot automatic fire with two weapons (p. 256) Gabriel is hunting a corrupt businessman who has sold secrets to the enemy. He finds himself on a train out in the wilderness on his way away from Sandukar's safe environments. Gabriel knows that in a compartment further ahead is the businessman and his bodyguard. He hears the rhythmic thudding while the train inexorably thunders onward in the dark night, and when he has assured himself that he is alone in the corridor he draws two silenced Riekon submachine guns (Damage Value 2D−1, Recoil 4, Magazine 20) and advances toward the compartment.

With a smooth movement he quickly picks the lock to the compartment, breathes in, quickly slides the door aside and steps in. The two men in the compartment look up at him in surprise and the larger of the two fumbles for something under his jacket. Gabriel gets the highest Initiative and fires a burst at the fumbling bodyguard. The roll shows 4 + 4 and despite a deduction of 8 (4 × 2) it turns out to be higher than the bodyguard's defense roll so Gabriel succeeds exceptionally. Damage becomes 6D−2 (2D−1 + 2D−1 = 4D−2 + 2D = 6D−2). 16 rounds are struck from each magazine. Thanks to the exceptional result Gabriel's Initiative is raised by five steps.

The compartment is smoke-filled and the empty shells are heard clattering against the polished wooden floor while the bodyguard essentially explodes in a cloud of blood. Gabriel turns his head toward the businessman and smiles a bloody smile while closing the door behind him.

Shoot blind (p. 257) Mordekai comes home and suddenly feels he's not alone in the room. A wardrobe door stands ajar. Mordekai reacts immediately and shoots at the wardrobe with his revolver.

His roll is modified with a deduction of eight (−10 + 2). The target, an assassin standing inside the wardrobe, makes the defense roll and adds their Luck value as a bonus, for a final sum of 19.

Mordekai rolls 6 and 10, 10 again and then 4, for a sum of 30 just on the dice, and manages to hit the assassin. Mordekai's Initiative is lowered by five (−5), the assassin receives normal damage and since 30 rounds should be struck from Mordekai's revolver the five rounds that were in the magazine are struck.

The assassin falls moaning out of the wardrobe with blood pumping from their stomach while Mordekai secures the rest of the apartment.

Shoot concentrated automatic fire (p. 256) Tactical constable Roarc enters a decrepit apartment in the Soot District as the first person. His group quickly secures the apartment but when Roarc himself reaches the bathroom he sees a young and confused woman with a revolver in her hand. Instinctively he fires a burst at her. The roll shows 5 and 9, which together with his skill in Firearms is higher than the woman's defense roll, so the burst hits. The weapon's damage is 2D−1, but it's raised to 3D−1 and 14 (5 + 9) rounds are struck from the magazine.

In the scene it's described how Roarc fires three shorter bursts at the woman, first at leg height, then low in the body and finally over the arm and shoulder, before she collapses with a meaty sound.

274 chapter 6 – combat

Shoot with two weapons (p. 256) Gabriel has a Calder M2245 automatic pistol (Damage Value 2D+1, recoil 4, magazine 8) in each hand and shoots at his Initiative at an attacking thug in an alley.

Gabriel gets a deduction of 8 (4 × 2) on the roll which shows 5 + 7 which still gives a higher result than what the thug gets on their defense roll, so Gabriel succeeds. Twelve shots should be struck from each magazine

but since a magazine only holds eight rounds these are struck and the weapons are considered emptied after the action's execution. Damage is rolled with 4D+2 (2D+1 + 2D+1).

In the scene it's described how Gabriel screaming fires off bullets at the thug and how the alley behind becomes fine stone dust from all the bullets that miss. But several reach their target and the thug jerks in death's dance while their body is torn apart.

Shoot aimed fire (p. 256) Anya has her automatic pistol ready when an assassin comes toward her. She shoots the assassin during her Initiative and rolls 3 and 8, which together with her Firearms value is higher than the assassin's sum with the defense roll so she hits. Three rounds are struck from the magazine and Anya's Initiative remains unchanged.

Shoot sighted fire (p. 256) Semuel Mesarat is a soldier in Sandukar's army. He has Initiative 14 and a skill of 12 in Firearms. The rifle he's using has Precision +3. Mesarat aims at an enemy appearing in the fog. He rolls 2 + 3 on the dice, and gets a sum of 20 (12 + 3 + 2 + 3), which turns out to be higher than the enemy's defense roll so the action is considered successful. Mesarat's Initiative is lowered by five steps, to nine, and one round is struck from the weapon's magazine.

Shoot snap shot (p. 256) Mordekai is involved in a drawn-out fight in a seedy bar. He perceives an enemy trying to sneak up on him and when it's his Initiative he shoots with his revolver, a Kai/Dekere Vrede (Damage Value 3D−2, Recoil 5, five shots in the magazine).

He shoots snap shots and gets a deduction (−5) from the weapon's recoil. The dice show 4 and 9. Four shots are struck from the magazine. Mordekai still gets a higher sum than the villain's defense roll and in the scene Mordekai's player decides that he hits with all shots in the enemy's chest. Damage is rolled with 4D−2 (3D−2 + 1D).

Brawl (p. 257) Mordekai is in combat with The Sorrowful. She meets Mordekai in a stairwell inside a gambling den and Mordekai quickly realizes that the ice-cold platinum blonde woman dressed in black means him harm. Combat is inevitable.

The Initiative rolls show that Mordekai gets 29 and The Sorrowful 17. Mordekai, who is first in turn order, begins by Brawling – he rushes up the stairs and tackles her hard. The initiative action succeeds and The Sorrowful receives a minor amount of Daze. The Sorrowful brawls in her turn order by delivering several kicks and blows at Mordekai, which he manages to defend against by parrying with forearms and hands. After that the round is over.

Mordekai Brawls again – now he chooses to grab the dusty fire extinguisher attached to the wall, and slam with it. The Sorrowful succeeds with her defense roll and decides she ducks under the fire extinguisher which flies down the stairs. The Sorrowful continues brawling by trying to headbutt Mordekai so he falls down the stairs. She succeeds, so the big man falls heavily down the creaking wooden staircase. After that the round is over.

Survey the situation (p. 259) Anya has, after a lengthy shootout aboard a cargo ship, Initiative 5. She doesn't like being in such a disadvantage, especially not when all her enemies have higher Initiative. When it's her turn in turn order she tries to gain an overview and take control.

The player explains that Anya quickly gets up on a container, positions herself in a crouched stance and scans to see where the enemies are located more precisely. The difficulty roll shows two eights (8+8) which, despite

a deduction of two (−2), together with Anya's Awareness constitutes an exceptionally successful roll, since the sum comes far above the difficulty threshold of 20.

This means Anya gets a new Initiative of 37 ((8 + 8) × 2 + 5) – she's more than ready to end the combat, on her terms.

Defense actions

Luck defense (p. 260) Mordekai advances toward an enemy he hates deeply. The enemy raises their black pistol and shoots. Mordekai chooses to continue approaching without reacting to the threat so his defense becomes a clear luck defense. The enemy shoots and gets a result of 17. Mordekai has Luck 2 and rolls 3 and 3, sum 8 and an exceptional failure. His Initiative is lowered by ten steps and he's hit right in the head. But he's so tough that he stands up after the attack, smiling a grim and bloody grin.

Defend (p. 260) Anya hears how the coat-wearing man she meets in the stairwell stops right behind her, how the coat is pulled open and how the characteristic pumping sound from a shotgun follows. She chooses to defend herself. The result of the resistance roll is higher than what the man rolls for his attack, so the man's shotgun pellets miss her as she jumps to the side, grabs the stair railing and jumps down one floor.

Shoot back (p. 260) Gabriel is pinned down by massive gunfire in a warehouse. Half a dozen smugglers with automatic weapons are peppering the container he's hiding behind. Suddenly a smuggler appears around the corner of the container with a revolver ready. Gabriel reacts and wants to try to shoot first as defense.

The smuggler acts in their turn order and has Initiative 19. Gabriel, who carries a Calder pistol (recoil 4), gets a deduction of twelve (4 × 3) and rolls 9 + 8 which totally gives a higher sum on the resistance roll than what the smuggler got. The smuggler's snap shot rattles against the container while Gabriel reflexively throws himself backward and simultaneously in desperation empties the pistol at them. Empty shells whine through the air and the smuggler is seen being hit by several bullets and tumbles behind the corner again while Gabriel heavily lands on the concrete floor. Damage on the smuggler becomes normal and Gabriel's Initiative is lowered ten steps.

Strike back (p. 260) A robber attacks Talia with a steel pipe when she's leaving a secret séance. Talia chooses to Strike back by trying to duck to the side and kick the guy in the stomach. The robber gets a sum of 16 on their Brawl roll while Talia, with a deduction of ten (−10) manages to reach 17 so her counterattack connects. The robber misjudges Talia, fails their attack, loses balance and is furiously kicked down by the lovely woman so one of her heels breaks. Talia's Initiative is lowered by ten for the successful defense action.

275 chapter 6 – combat

Physical Injuries & Drugs

Stunning Damage (p. 263) Gabriel is in combat with a pickpocket. The latter throws a porcelain vase at Gabriel. The damage value is considered to be B3T-2 and the attack inflicts 18 stunning damage on him. This is normally above Gabriel's Wound Threshold of 12, but since the vase deals stunning damage, the Wound Threshold counts as being twice as high, in this case 24, so no Wound is inflicted. However, as usual, Gabriel's Daze increases by 18.

Electricity (p. 267)

Stelia has rigged a trap by connecting a door handle to a power cord. When the victim comes home and grabs the handle, he takes 6 + 7 = 13 in damage. This results in a Wound and 13 in Daze. The victim succeeds at rolls with Endurance and Will to Live. A difficulty roll (Strength) is made. The penalty is three (-3) for the damage. The roll fails and the victim takes damage in the next round as well - this time 7 and 10 + 3, or 20. This is above the victim's double Wound Threshold so he receives three more Wounds, fails the difficulty roll (Will to Live) and dies shortly thereafter.

Stelia witnesses it all from her car below the apartment and sees how the light irregularly swings back and forth before finally stabilizing. Satisfied, she drives away.

Fire/Acid (p. 267)

A barrel of gasoline explodes near Mordekai and he gets burning liquid on him. It's judged to be a "limited" amount and Mordekai suffers 2 + 6 - 1 = 7 in damage and Daze.

The liquid is judged to hit his left arm and leg and burns the skin. A difficulty roll is made with a bonus (+5) for the intensity value for ignition, and penalty (-2) for Mordekai's attribute value in Luck. The roll shows 8 + 9, giving a sum of 20 (8 + 9 + 5 - 2), a success, so Mordekai catches fire.

Next round Mordekai throws himself on the ground and rolls around to try to extinguish the fire. He rolls 5 + 2 which with his Mobility, minus five from Ignition, is a failure. At the end of the round he takes an additional 4 + 5 - 1 = 8 in damage, giving a sum of 15 in Daze.

The following round he continues rolling, now with a bonus (+5). The dice show 8 + 7, minus five (-5) for Ignition and minus one (-1) for the Daze of 15. The difficulty roll counts as successful, so Mordekai is extinguished but wears smoldering clothes and a very pissed-off expression.

Explosions (p. 266)

The Ostarsk lobs a grenade into a trench. Avolano and Remeriko are there at four and twelve meters respectively from the detonation. Avolano, who sits within "Close" range, suffers B10, or (1 + 1 + 3 + 6 + 6 + 7 + 9 + 9 + 10 + 10) = 62 in stunning damage (note that both maxed tens are blocked by the two ones) - which is enough to kill him as he receives ten Wounds (he has Wound Threshold 7).

Remeriko suffers B5T. The dice show a sum of 20 in stunning damage which doesn't exceed his double Wound Threshold of 10 (since it's stunning damage) so he receives no Wound from the attack, but he notes a Daze of 20 on his character sheet. His difficulty roll (Endurance) succeeds so he grabs his rifle slightly dizzied and runs screaming after the Ostarsk.

Falls & Collisions (p. 267)

Gabriel fights against two gangsters up on a balustrade. He's tackled backwards and falls fumbling over the railing into the marble floor seven meters below. A difficulty roll using Mobility is made and proves successful. The final damage value thus becomes B4T (B4T - B1T (success) + B1T (hard surface)), giving a stunning damage of 22 (1 + 5 + 8 + 8).

Coming To (p. 263)

Jessca has 18 in Daze after getting a vase to the skull. A difficulty roll (Endurance) fails so she counts as dazed and gets Initiative 1. Next time it's Jessca's turn her player makes a new difficulty roll (Endurance), but this

time with a penalty (-1) due to the Daze. The roll succeeds so Jessca comes to and in the next round gets to act as usual at her turn.

Will to Live & Wounds (p. 264)

Garvarian was inflicted six Wounds when Mordekai shot him (see "Damage & Wound Threshold" below). Garvarian's difficulty roll (Will to Live) gets a penalty of (-12) (2 x number of Wounds). Garvarian has Will to Live 9, so maxed dice are required for a successful roll. The dice show 2 and 10 + 4 which together with Will to Live gives a result of 25. After the penalty the sum becomes 13, a failure. Garvarian is mortally wounded and will die after 16 rounds (the total sum from the dice), during which he manages to lie rattling on the bedroom floor, while his life force slowly colors the genuine carpets red.

Tumbling (p. 267)

Mercurian Corso is thrown off a train when it's discovered he's carrying secret documents he shouldn't be carrying. The train is traveling at 130 km/h and the surface counts as neither soft nor hard. The roll for Mobility fails, the damage value increases by B1T, to B15T, but is halved to B7T since it's more of a tumble than an actual fall or collision.

First round Corso receives damage value B7T (the roll gives a stunning damage of a low 21), round two the damage value becomes B3T (the roll gives a stunning damage of 13), and round three the damage value is reduced to B1T (gives stunning damage of 2). Finally, in round four, Corso stops, beaten (with a Daze of 36) and dusty but alive.

Damage & Wound Threshold (p. 262)

Anya gets into a firefight with Favian in a basement corridor. Anya is fastest, she fires a shot at Favian and hits. Anya's automatic pistol has damage value 2T-1. The dice show 3 and 8, result 11 - 1 = 10. Favian increases his Daze by ten points. Since the damage is higher than Favian's Wound Threshold of 8, he's seriously injured and also receives a Wound from the bullet. Anya's player describes how she hits Favian in one shoulder so he spins around and staggers backwards.

A roar sounds and the naked Mordekai gets hold of his revolver. He fires it at the screaming legitimate husband Garvarian who rushes at him in wild rage. Garvarian's wife tries futilely to conceal her earlier intimate relations with Mordekai with her silk sheets.

The bullet hits its target and with a damage value of 3T-2 the damage becomes 6, 7, 10 + 6, result 29 - 2 = 27. The legitimate husband's Daze increases to 27, and since the sum is above his double Wound Threshold he's inflicted with as many Wounds as the value the lowest die in the damage roll shows, in this case six. In the scene it's determined that the bullet hit badly, right in the chest, on Garvarian.

Painkillers (p. 270)

Mordekai has been beaten up by Rulov's thugs. He has two Wounds (penalty -4) and a Daze of 35 (penalty -3). This gives a Total penalty (-7) on all actions.

Mordekai staggers up and gets his pill bottle and gulps down the equivalent of three doses of Painkillers. Three difficulty rolls with Tolerance are made of which two fail and one succeeds. This means that Mordekai can ignore 5 of the 7 points from Total penalty, so effectively he has a Total penalty of (-2) for the next four hours.

Stabilizing the Mortally Wounded (p. 264)

Garvarian has six Wounds and lies dying on the carpet. His wife, a nurse, reacts instinctively, she rushes up from the bed and tears out her first aid kit. This takes two rounds so Garvarian has 14 rounds left before he falls asleep for the last time. While Mordekai puts on pants and coat and leaves the room, the nurse begins a frantic effort to stabilize the dying man's condition, each round she gets to make a difficulty roll (Medicine):

• Round 1: The difficulty roll succeeds, one Wound is stabilized, five remain. • Round 2: The difficulty roll fails, five Wounds remain. • Round 3: The difficulty roll fails, five Wounds remain. Garvarian rattles. • Round 4: The difficulty roll fails, five Wounds remain. • Round 5: The difficulty roll succeeds, one Wound is stabilized, four remain. The wife tears up a sheet to bandage the wound. • Round 6: The difficulty roll succeeds, one Wound is stabilized, three remain. The worst bleeding seems to be stopped. • Round 7: The difficulty roll succeeds, two Wounds remain. • Round 8: The difficulty roll succeeds, one Wound is stabilized, one Wound remains. A faint smile can be glimpsed at the corner of Garvarian's mouth. • Round 9: The difficulty roll fails exceptionally, two Wounds remain. Garvarian starts coughing blood. • Round 10: The difficulty roll succeeds, one Wound is stabilized, one Wound remains. The wife places a bloody hand on the man's forehead to calm him. • Round 11: The difficulty roll fails, one Wound remains. • Round 12: The difficulty roll fails, one Wound remains. The man doesn't see how his wife slowly cries while trying to stabilize the damage. • Round 13: The difficulty roll fails, one Wound remains. Garvarian dimly meets his wife's desperate gaze. • Round 14: The difficulty roll fails, one Wound remains. Garvarian's eyes roll back in his skull and he dies soundlessly.

Mordekai, who just left the building, hears a woman's scream full of anguish and fury, shakes his head, raises his hand to shield the flame from the rain, lights the cigarette and draws the smoke into his lungs as he trudges on, away from the evening's events.

Strangulation (p. 266)

Stelia has hidden in the bathroom at the home of a witness to a family-related murder. When the victim steps in to shave, Stelia silently emerges from her hiding place behind the shower curtain, places a piano wire around the victim's neck and pulls. The victim tries to scream but it becomes only strangled croaking and the police constable outside the apartment door hears nothing.

Stelia has the Initiative and succeeds at "Brawl" (hold - strangle) as the victim's Chance Defense fails. The damage becomes 23 stunning, but the victim passes his difficulty roll (Endurance). The victim's attempt to Strike Stelia fails. In the next round Stelia inflicts another 27 in stunning damage and the victim's Endurance roll fails, he becomes dazed and defenseless. In round three Stelia "executes" the victim. She succeeds exceptionally so he's inflicted 8 Wounds (8 + 8) and dies. Stelia quickly climbs out through the window, takes the fire escape down and disappears into the fog.

Oxygen Deprivation (p. 267)

Serial killer Lagonda is executed by hanging outside the Justice Palace. When the floor disappears and the noose strangles shut, Lagonda, who has Endurance 9, gets by without damage for four rounds (9 / 2 = 4.5 = 4) since he's subjected to violence). In round five he receives B5T in damage value, as in each additional round until he becomes "dazed" and thus defenseless. Then he receives as many Wounds as the value on the highest die of two rolled each round until he dies, all the while the audience roars.

Endurance & Daze (p. 263)

Favian has a total Daze of 10 after being shot by Anya. This means his difficulty roll gets a penalty (-1). He makes the difficulty roll and gets 1 and 1 on the dice. Together with an Endurance of 7 that gives the result 9. After the penalty for Daze the sum becomes 8 - an exceptional failure.

In the story it's illustrated by Favian staggering and falling over a crate and hitting a cabinet where he collapses unconscious for the next ten minutes (10 = the value in Daze).

Recovery (p. 265)

Jessca walks home after getting thoroughly beaten by gangster Gavilian's henchmen. Admittedly she broke free and slit both their throats, but before that they went at her with clubs and brass knuckles. In total Jessca has 98 in Daze and one Wound. She unlocks the door to her apartment, collapses into bed and falls asleep immediately.

Four hours later she wakes with a start from the sound of sirens and screeching tires from outside. The pillow is completely bloodied, but she feels much better. Jessca's attribute value in Endurance is 15, so the Daze has decreased by 60 (15 points of recovery per hour, total 4 times during rest) points, to 38. When she has rested for a longer period it's checked whether the Wound heals.

Quickly she gets hold of her knives and heads for the fire escape, with a mask of dried blood over her mouth and on her clothes.

Story:

Name: Concept: Character Traits: Drives:

Size: [ ] _____ **Impression:** [ ] _____ **Luck:** [ ] **Notoriety:** [ ] _____ **Appearance:** [ ] _____ **Coordination** ( ) **Skill** Close Combat ( ) [ ] Reactions ( ) [ ] Mobility ( ) [ ] **Physique** ( ) **Skill** Condition ( ) [ ] Strength ( ) [ ] Tolerance ( ) [ ] **Motor Skills** ( ) **Skill** Dexterity ( ) [ ] Thrown Weapons ( ) [ ] Firearms ( ) [ ] **Education** ( ) **Skill** Humanities ( ) [ ] Medicine ( ) [ ] Natural Science ( ) [ ] **Creativity** ( ) **Skill** Construction ( ) [ ] Create ( ) [ ] Deduction ( ) [ ] **Will** ( ) **Skill** Determination ( ) [ ] Resistance ( ) [ ] Sense ( ) [ ] **Insight** ( ) **Skill** Empathy ( ) [ ] Resist ( ) [ ] Worldliness ( ) [ ] **Perception** ( ) **Skill** Intuition ( ) [ ] Vehicles ( ) [ ] Awareness ( ) [ ] **Charisma** ( ) **Skill** Charm ( ) [ ] Leadership ( ) [ ] Persuade ( ) [ ] **Profile Limitations & Characteristics****Expertises**

Weapons

Weapon Draw Hit Damage Range Precision Recoil Conceal Malfunction Magazine Unarmed _____ ____ _____

Standard of Living: [ ] Equipment & Belongings Ranged: [ ] _____ Melee:[ ] _____ Overview:[ ] Combat Movement:[ ] Damage Escalation:[ ] Damage/ Stun Stun: [ ] **Penalty** 10–19 » −1 20–29 » −2 30–39 » −3 40–49 » −4 50–59 » −5 60–69 » −6 70–79 » −7 80–89 » −8 90–99 » −9 100–109 » −10 110–119 » −11 120 –129 » −12 Damage/Wounds Wounds: [ ] Mortally wounded: [ ] **Penalty Initiative** 1 » −2 −5 2 » −4 −5 3 » −6 −5 4 » −8 −5 5 » −10 −5 6 » −12 −5 7 » −14 −5 8 » −16 −5 9 » −18 −5 10 » −20 −5 11 » −22 −5 12 » −24 −5 **Well-Being** Max. Well-Being: [ ] Relaxed (10) Composed (9) Troubled (8) Tense (7) Uneasy (6)

Penalty Stressed (5) » −1 Strained (4) » −2 Exhausted (3) » −3 Tormented (2) » −4 Desperate (1) » −5 Catatonic (0) » −10 Total Penalty: _____ **Fate**

Experience

Learning: [ ] _____ Life Experience : _____

Name/Concept Influence Relationship Attraction Hostile Dislike Neutral Benevolent Friendly Blood bond/family [ ] Attraction (+2) _____ Industry: _____ Passion (+3) Hostile Dislike Neutral Benevolent Friendly Blood bond/family [ ] Attraction (+2) _____ Industry: _____ Passion (+3) Hostile Dislike Neutral Benevolent Friendly Blood bond/family [ ] Attraction (+2) _____ Industry: _____ Passion (+3) Hostile Dislike Neutral Benevolent Friendly Blood bond/family [ ] Attraction (+2) _____ Industry: _____ Passion (+3) Hostile Dislike Neutral Benevolent Friendly Blood bond/family [ ] Attraction (+2) _____ Industry: _____ Passion (+3) Hostile Dislike Neutral Benevolent Friendly Blood bond/family [ ] Attraction (+2) _____ Industry: _____ Passion (+3) Hostile Dislike Neutral Benevolent Friendly Blood bond/family [ ] Attraction (+2) _____ Industry: _____ Passion (+3) Relationships/Contacts Defense: [ ]

Defense » Wound Threshold:[ ][ ][ ] _____ Endurance : [ ] _____ Will to Live:[ ] _____

ISBN 91-976556-0-0 9 789197 655606 Article number: 10-1001 ISBN: 91-976556-0-0 It is a time of worldly decay, mysteries, violence and dark eroticism. The stage is the metropolis of Sandukar, the heart of the colossal Imperiet. It is a place for hard-boiled men, dangerous women and fallen champions — individuals who create their own rules and who through their actions show what is right or wrong. It is a journey into an existence where strong and destructive emotions such as desire, aggression and vengefulness reign over the dark back alleys. Selfishness, greed and vanity overshadow forgotten virtues like love, justice and generosity. In the State's ministries, the faceless bureaucrats rule through contradictory forms and regulations. In the penthouses, the highborn plan new conspiracies and intrigues for increased power and increased prosperity. On the street, the common citizen struggles against brutal gangsters, corrupt cops and sadistic employers, in a fight to see another day. It is a time for reluctant heroes.

Noir is a dystopian roleplaying game written by two veterans of Swedish RPG development, Marco Behrmann and Petter Nallo. Between them they have nearly 30 years of experience in roleplaying and are behind titles like Eon, Neotech and Viking. Noir explores humanity's darkest sides and is not recommended for sensitive individuals or for children under 15 years.